i’ve never felt so at home (when you and i are alone)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34172422.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Multi

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Part 1 of a love that comes once in a lifetime

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by PointlesslyPoetic

Summary

The covert love saga between a princess and her pirate.

(Or, the boatload of issues and emotions Sea Hawk and Mermista were working through behind the scenes of the series.)

Notes

This will be a series focused on Mermista and Sea Hawk because, for some reason, my brain saw them and went “oh yeah. That’s the good stuff”.

Smut will be alluded to and written vaguely as it applies to the plot, but will not be written explicitly. At least not in this fic.

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

Sea Hawk had traveled the world a dozen times over by the time he was 18. He'd seen the opalescent and transcendental wonder of Bright Moon, the earthy and honest beauty of Plumeria in all its' spring time glory. He'd traveled the Crimson Waste using only his compass and the dried footprints of his then-captain. He had even skirted the edges of the Fright Zone, dancing with death like he did with the bar-maids of Sea Worthy.

Yes, Sea Hawk was a worldly and travelled lad- well, not really much of a lad anymore. At 20, he was broader in the shoulders than his father had ever been, taller than the rest of his crew mates, strong enough to man the wheel in a storm, and his mustache was coming along quite nicely if he did say so himself.

Sea Hawk was a worldly, eloquent, and travelled *man*, thank you very much.

And yet, he'd never seen a sight as beautiful as the Salinean palace at night.

He stood outside with the rest of the waiting guests, and watched as a pearlescent, blue glow seemed to spill from the windows and parapets of the building, like waterfalls of pure, oceanic light. The spires of the twisted and sculpted towers shone from within, while reflecting the night moons' glow. Music winked at his ears from what he could only assume was ballroom. The beat was heady, but refined, and the winding strings and horns made his heart feel like it was dancing up stair after stair to the heavens.

This was going to be one hell of a party.

As if on cue, the doors were flung open to the crowd, and they began to move forward as one. Sea Hawk found himself being politely jostled by nobility and gentry alike, which was really, he thought, unbecoming of their titles. He bit back a sailor’s swear as one brutish young man almost knocked the mask off his nose.

Masquerades. Where the elite had the chance to be assholes in comfortable anonymity, and seized it with relish.

“Boy,” a gruff voice in his ear made him jump. “Remember what the cap’n said.”

Sea Hawk sighed, reaffixing the strings of his mask. “No liquor, no ladies, no licking.”

“Aye,” A meaty clap to his shoulder, freshly tattooed and now singing with pain. “See that you stick to it, Hawk.”

He rolled his eyes beneath his mask as his comrade, First Mate Billiam Nob’dy, or just Bill, pushed past him. From the corner of his eye, he saw his third mate, Scurvy, and two deckhands whose names he didn’t yet know (as they’d only just picked them up in Sea Worthy two days ago), split up.

Sea Hawk fingered the perfectly-forged invitation in the lapels of his too-rich, too-new coat jacket. He’d never been one for formal wear, especially the newest cut of Etheria Suit, but tonight none of this was up to him.

His captain, a well-known man by the name of N’davi, had received a letter when they last docked at the Bright Moon port, from a figure in a cloak who was waiting for them when they stepped ashore. There had been a terse exchanging of words, many rude and heated gestures, and then money changed hands, an envelope was procured, and they had their next pay day.

Such was the life of a pirate, eh?

Sea Hawk had never really meant to fall into piracy, but once he had, the thrill of it seized him like nothing else. The stakes were high, the escapes narrow, and the money was better than anything he’d ever made working on a schooner, or a fishing boat, or even a royal passenger ship.

And so, he put on the monkey suit, tied the stupid pointy mask on, and swore to not have any fun at all for the evening.

Well, maybe some fun. After all, the cap’n only said no ladies, right?

All thoughts of extra curricular activities fled his mind when he entered the ballroom. The floor was made of shell and sea glass, reflecting the warm glow of the blown-glass chandeliers in the shape of fish scales. Sea Hawk didn’t remember descending any stairs, but he must have, because the walls of the room were reinforced glass with a full panoramic view of the ocean. Fish, bioluminescent and sparkling, swam in schools outside the room. Dolphins bobbed and weaved along with the dancing and mingling guests. Occasionally, a larger shadow would pass along the floor as a shark or whale came by to check out the scene.

Indeed, he’d never seen a kingdom as beautiful as Salineas. Not even the auroras of his homeland could compare.

Sea Hawk was meant to aid with distraction while his captain and quartermaster did whatever it was they had to do, while staying alert and aware of any changes in the room. So, he swept onto the dance floor, snagging a partner along the way, so he could oscillate and observe as he nursed his pathetically weak drink.

Despite the masked nature of the party, the king was easily spotted. The royal safa, turquoise with gold woven in, adorned with a feather that was held in place by a cerulean jewel, was not easily missed. Sea Hawk couldn’t help but stumble and stare a bit. He’d never been in the same room as royalty. He’d seen the Queen of Bright Moon fly overhead, but she was so far off she may as well have been a bird. The Princess Regent of Plumeria had been off on a gathering journey when they were there.

It was a bit awe-inspiring. The king carried himself with little emotion. His brow was stern, his facial hair graying slightly. His watery blue eyes were cold, Sea Hawk noted, despite being surrounded by lively music, joyous people, and the most beautiful ocean on the planet. He surveyed the crowd as if bored.

Sea Hawk didn’t like the man very much at all, he thought.

But he moved on, taking note of the royal guard, the door men, the butlers and caterers, chefs running to and from the ballroom. Sea Hawk couldn’t see them all- the room was the width of at least eight ship decks, and length of three sat stern to bow. Massive, truly.

When one dance partner tired, he grabbed another and carried on. When his feet began to ache, he sat at a bar top and mingled idly. He made people laugh, even some of the royal staff that were nearby, being sure to imprint enough of himself to their memory to cover if things went south, but not enough that they’d be able to spot him in a crowd.

What felt like hours later, he bumped into someone- a young woman- at the kelp spread. He had no idea what a kelp spread was, but it looked delicious and he was growing slightly tired of fish.

“Um,” she drawled. “Like, manners much?”

Ah, shit. An upper class lass. “My apologies, m’lady,” he skirted a hasty bow. “I didn’t see you there, though that’s no excuse for my lack of awareness.”

“Geez, okay, sorry will do just fine, dude.” She snorted. Sea Hawk grinned- it was refreshingly unladylike.

“Well, then, sorry,” he chuckled. “Again.”

She nodded, staring at him softly, but with a piercing focus. Her eyes were striking, he noted absently. Amber, or gold, maybe. No, amber imbued with gold. Like the honey they’d been given from Plumeria. For the first time that night, Sea Hawk found himself floundering for words.

“Um, do you-that is- I-,” he raked a hand through his finn hair, mussing it terribly, probably. “I don’t know what a kelp bar is, and I’m starving. Could you…?”

Her lips pursed lightly, as if she were trying very hard not to smile at him. “Sure, whatever.” She led him to the other end of the long banquet table, and he took the chance to run his gaze over her.

Her hair was deep navy, teal highlights shining through where the lamp light caught. She wore a midnight blue mask with delicate gold detailing. It matched the spun metal hair clips she wore in her hair, both sparkling. Her dress was two pieces, embroidered on top with a full skirt on the bottom, shades of blue and sea green mingling together, with more gold accenting. Her skin was deeply tan, rich and beautiful. Her hands, he noticed belatedly, had henna detailing up to her forearms.

She was certainly a noblewoman, and one of very high status at that.

He gulped, and focused on not noticing how her full hips swayed with an innate rhythm as she walked, drawing his eye like a magician’s pendulum.

She stopped him at the beginning of the bar, and grabbed a plate for him. She didn’t speak much, instead pointing at her favorites on the table. When he had a full plate, he followed her to a small table just off the dance floor.

He ate quickly, and between bites he stared at her in what he imagined was a very subtle way. Her ears were cuffed in gold as well, and her nails were painted black. From what he could see when she leaned back in her seat, her belly button was pierced with ornate and priceless jewels as well.

She was absolutely resplendent.

“Um, can I help you?”

He tore his gaze from her bare midriff to her eyes. They were not super pleased, one eyebrow arched high and accusing, the rest of her face carefully neutral.

Fuck.

Sea Hawk, ever the silver-tongued poet, opened his mouth to save his ass.

“You are the most beautiful woman I’ve ever seen.”

Hm. Or that.

She narrowed her eyes at him, disbelieving and possibly somewhat angry. “Uh huuuuh…,” she drawled. “And that means you can stare at my stomach?”

He flushed, and threw his gaze to the table. “No, of course not. I’m...I’m terribly sorry,” he swallowed. “That was inappropriate, and uncouth of me.”

Silence. He sighed. Well, he was nothing if not a perma-fuck up. There goes that, he mused, as he pushed his chair from the table.

“I’m sorry, m’lady. I will leave you to your party. Excuse me-“

Before he could stand and beat a hasty retreat, a hand came to rest on top of his own, stopping him. He snapped his head up.

Her eyes were wide, but not angry. Not happy, sure, or flattered or pleased. More...confused than anything.

“I didn’t say you could leave.”

She spoke with a subtle but commanding authority that thrilled his core.

“I… sorry?”

“Sit.”

He did so immediately. She smirked. “Geez, what are you, a military brat? You follow commands like the guards here.”

He smiled, tentative. “Something like that, yes.”

She still wasn’t quite smiling. But she wasn’t annoyed anymore. Back to what seemed to be her usual neutral. Her hand was still on top of his. When a few seconds had passed, and she made no effort to move her hand or look away, he decided to push his luck.

He flipped his hand over, and grabbed her fingers softly in his. He felt her tense, and he knew she was watching him again.

Sea Hawk smiled, and found it wasn’t his showman’s grin. “Would you like to dance?”

She scanned him, analytical. If he didn’t know better he would say she was staring right through him with some sort of magic, reading his soul, his mind, and intentions.

He found he didn’t much care.

At length, she nodded, and her lips were pursed again in that pinchy, ‘I refuse to smile’ way. He found he was becoming very, very fond of that expression.

Sure, he’d only seen it twice, but that just made his night more fun. He’d never backed down from a challenge, after all.

He swept her onto the dance floor when there was a lull. Bodies pressed around him, laughing and smiling and gasping for breath. This was no Snow’s Waltz. Hell, it wasn’t even a foot-stomping reel from Sea Worthy. The music here was passionate, unpredictable, but marked in perfect time as well. Like the ocean’s tides.

They moved into position, and he hesitated before he leaned in to speak in her ear; it was already getting loud in anticipation of the next song.

“May I, m’lady?”

She stared at him, fathomless and a bit perplexed again, but with something warmer starting to blossom. She nodded, and he moved one hand to her bare waist, and waited for her. She wrapped an arm around his shoulders, and he noticed that this close, they were nearly the same height. He also noticed the deep blue, almost black lipstick she wore, and how it didn’t shine, but absorbed the light around her, drawing his eyes right to her mouth. Her gorgeous, full mouth.

Stars, he was in trouble.

He grabbed her free hand with his, and slotted one slightly bent knee between hers. They froze, as if they’d been stopped mid step, and waited. Sea Hawk tried desperately not to count the inches between their faces (less than two, by his estimate).

With no warning, the music began, bringing the room to life with a melodious crash. He smiled at her, and they were off.

The first few dances were exhilarating and feverish. He was just barely keeping up with her; she was clearly a Salinean native, the way she knew exactly where to place her feet, how to pivot to avoid another couple. Neither was leading, neither was following. They moved in sync, baiting and teasing and chasing one another to the beat. She spun, full skirt flaring, and he caught her before lifting her up with ease. She dipped him with fluid nonchalance, and his eyes widened as the motion flexed well-defined biceps. Sea Hawk was fairly sure this lass could bench him, and then some.

Through it all, he noticed an almost tangible tension growing between them. Her amber gaze bored into his, and when they grabbed at one another, there was no more polite deference to hide behind. If he had magic, he was certain sparks would be flying, whizzing in different directions. Every time they spun apart, they crashed back together with a growing, fervid urgency.

He wanted her like he'd wanted nothing and no one else in his life.

They tore through at least six numbers before the band took a brief break, promising to come back with something slower and sensual. Sea Hawk took little notice; the last song had ended with her flush against him, one leg off the ground hooked around his calf. He was supporting her entirely as she leaned against him, a hand around her waist and crushing her chest to his.

Her very full and heaving chest, beneath a plunging neckline.

Hoooo boy.

Neither made a move to shift, and they weren't alone. Several couples were pressed together, some obscenely so, others shyly. One couple was wrapped around each other passionately, just chaste enough to still be seen in public; the two women were glowing, and their matching, inverted chokers made him smile.

Alright, so he was a hopelessly romantic pirate. Life was too short to pick one or the other.

“Hey,” warm breath puffed against his open mouth. Right, there was an incredibly sexy woman pressed against him. “I never got your name.”

He almost answered without thinking. Thank the stars something, probably the tattered remnants of any common sense, froze his tongue. He smirked at her, crowing internally when he watched blush.

“I never got yours, either, m’lady.”

She narrowed her eyes. “Hm, shame.”

“It is, isn’t it?”

Before they could continue, the musicians began tuning. One picked up a guitar, and began plucking it with deep, forlorn emotion. The melody was lusty, yearning, desperate in the way love so often is during a war.

Wordlessly, they began.

Her arms wound back around his neck, this time fisting gently in his hair and bringing his forehead to hers. He gulped. He took one hand off her waist, placing it on his own hip like he'd seen the others doing. And then she started *moving* .

Her legs didn't move much, but her hips, by the angels, her hips. Like waves on the open ocean, they rolled against him. No, rolling implies predictable rhythm, a back and forth. She was gyrating, winding her hips in figure eights, up and down, side to side. Sea Hawk's world narrowed to every point of contact he had with the woman in his arms, while the rest of it faded away. His eyes were shut, in concentration or passion, he didn't care.

His hands, never still, always moving, even in this, ran from her hair, to her neck, to her waist and up her back. But not lower. He may have been hopelessly turned on, floating on air, and in the best dream of his life, but he wasn't a scoundrel.

The music pushed and pulled them, like the tides, and he found himself helpless to resist. He wasn't sure how to do what she did, but he knew he had to do something. So the next time she wound herself up, he waited for the down count, before yanking her to him by the waist, and letting his hips follow hers on their path.

Her eyes flew open, and he smirked again. They moved in sync, flowing together, grinding against, pulling away. Their bodies undulated hypnotically, and Sea Hawk found himself continually entranced by this enigma of a woman. He dipped her low at one point, her back falling over his forearm while he swooped and dragged her low before pulling her up.

Back to front, front to front, dipping, swaying, whatever, their faces were rarely more than an inch from each other's. He found his eyes focused on her lips, over and over again, watching them open for air, waiting for the seconds where her tongue would dart out to wet them. He caught her doing the same to him, and grinned.

The music was winding down, and he knew it deep in him, like he knew when there was rain rolling in, or when a storm was more than a storm, that he had seconds before the moment broke.

It was now or never.

He slowed his hips, and brought his hand back up to her hair. He cupped the back of her head, gently but with purpose. He leaned in to murmur in her ear, to be heard over the music, sure, but also to feel those lips brushing his neck when he did.

"May I?"

She pulled back, eyes flicking over his face. An hour ago, he would've thought she was bored from the look she gave him. Now, he was pretty sure that the aloofness was just her natural default, for better or worse.

She nodded, and brought a hand up to his jaw.

Like a dam giving way, he surged forward, crushing her mouth to his. In spite of her cool demeanor, she returned his kiss with just as much, if not more passion. He groaned into her mouth, and she nipped at his lips with sharp teeth. Her tongue, just as soft as it looked, ran along his lower lip, teasing him into opening for her. His stomach swooped when she ran the point of her tongue along the pad of his in the same rhythm as the fading music.

He twisted his hand deeper into her hair, careful to avoid the pins, and seized her around the waist.

Eventually, they had to pull back, or risk more than just the amused but understanding stares of their nearby fellow dancers. Sea Hawk couldn’t afford the captain seeing him-

Wait.

There by the door was Bill. He was staring right at him, amused if not slightly exasperated. He held his right hand out, all three fingers extended, and sliced it through the air twice.

The signal. The captain was out, he had what he’d came for.

Another signal, motions like a wave, then a fist.

They were casting off at sunrise.

Shaking side to side.

Rest of the night off.

Bill winked, and then he was gone.

Sea Hawk glanced back down at the young woman in his arms.

“I do hope I’m not being too forward, but-“

She cut him off. “There’s a guest room near here. It locks. We won’t be disturbed.”

He beamed. She pinched her lips again. “Lead the way, dearest.”

“Ugh, do *not* call me that.”

There was definitely a little bit of a smile in that one.

Hours later, Sea Hawk was exhausted in every way known to man. Especially to a man named him. At some point in the night, his mask had fallen away with the rest of his clothes. Probably when his partner was straddling his face, thighs that could absolutely reduce his head to ether framing him.

Hers had come off when she riding him, rough, hard, and fast, daring him to try to keep up, and Sea Hawk had grinned, sitting up with sudden fervor, gripping her hips in a bruising hold, and all but lifted her off her knees while he got to his, suspending her from his grasp. It had slipped off, and he had found himself face to face with truly the most beautiful person he had ever seen, let alone been lucky enough to bed.

Her amber eyes were even more gorgeous when he could see her thick, full lashes, and the bridge of her proud nose. Her skin was the most radiant burnished bronze, and the sea light danced over her in a way that looked ethereal, yet so, so right. Like the ocean was inside her, a part of her, and she it. One and the same; quiet and contemplative one moment, fervent and harsh the next. The potential to become a tempest, parallel to the quiet moments after they'd finished, and he rested his head on her full chest, and felt like he was resting in a shallow cove.

When the first flickers of sun came to dance in the sea, he knew he had to go. They hadn't slept, really, only dozed here and there. They stole kisses, touches, snatches of conversation. The two of them were suspended in time in this bed, under these sheets, removed from everything else they had to do, or be.

At least, that was how he felt.

He sighed, and her hand fell away from where it was tracing faded scars, and the ink on his chest. She lifted her head minutely, and he kissed the top of it as he slid out of bed. He gathered his clothes, leaving behind the suit jacket and waistcoat, only throwing on the buttoned shirt and the dress pants. As he was sitting on the bed and lacing his boots, a weight draped itself-herself- across his back and murmured in his ears.

“You still didn’t tell me your name, you know.” She spoke in a monotonous drawl when she wasn’t moaning, sighing, crying out beneath him (or over, next to, in front of...you get the picture). He found it to be just as melodious as any music, and found joy in following the slight valleys and dips of her sentences. Just as he was learning that she wasn’t emotionless, just reserved.

He smiled. “Eye for an eye, my lady.”

She stilled, paused, and considered. “Fine.”

“You can call me Sea Hawk,” he turned to face her, and found her face inches from his. He reached up and tucked a strand of hair behind her ear, only smiling more when she batted his tender touch away.

She snorted. “That’s not a real name.”

“Says who?” he challenged.

“Uh, says me,” she smirked. “C’mon, really, tell me your name.”

He chuckled. “I’m not joking. My crew and all my friends call me Sea Hawk.”

She stared at him, fathomless eyes carving him out from within. “And what can I call you?”

He quirked a brow. “Does Sea Hawk not suit my lady?”

“Uh, not your lady,” she rolled her eyes. “And I have no problem with Sea Hawk, other than you’re obviously hiding something?”

“Mhm,” he stroked his mustache. “And what if I told you that was all I’d like to be called?”

She considered him. “Then I’d call you that.”

He ducked his head. For a flippant, mercurial girl, she was frighteningly honest, blunt like the blow of a cannon. He raised his head with a put-upon sigh.

“Sebastian.”

For a few moments, she just stared at him, neutral, mulling it over. She did that a lot. She wasn’t impulsive like he was. She took the time she needed to come to her own conclusions. Words were currency with her, hard earned and not handed out lightly.

At length, she nodded. “Sea Hawk, then, as you prefer.”

He smiled at her, and scooped her hand up to press a kiss to her knuckles. “If Sebastian should please my lady from time to time, then she may use it.”

“She-” the hand was yanked back, not that it phased him, “-is not your lady. And if you keep it up, she will only ever call you Sebastian.”

“Ah!” he cried out, flopping onto his back dramatically. “I am wounded, mortally and deeply, by the cutting words of my- er, the lady.”

“You’re such a goober.”

“I’ve been called far worse.”

“Like Sebastian?”

“Just so,” he nodded before dragging himself upright. “And, may I know your name?”

Apprehension flooded her gaze, and she brought a hand up to wring the messy braid she’d thrown her hair into somewhere near round four.

“Um, yeah, uh, there’s a slight, uh, issue with that,” she mumbled. “I’m, um, not really supposed to uh- that is, it might not be great if-“

“Word got out that a noblewoman jumped a sailor in the guest chamber of the royal palace?”

“Yeah, that.”

He sighed, shrugging helplessly. “I understand. Nobility is hard, and I wouldn’t want to damage your standing with the royal family.”

“Um,” she sounded more confused than ever before. “I know it’s dark in here, and we had masks on but...don’t you, like...recognize me?”

“Oh, no, not at all!” He smiled. “I was born in Snows, and I’ve been a sailor all my life, so I don’t really do the uppity political thing. No time for it, sorry.”

“Huh,” she stopped wringing her braid. “Well, then, alright.”

“Alright?”

“Yeah,” she shrugged. “My name’s Mermista.”

“Mermista,” he tried the word in his mouth, and found himself helpless to stop the grin overtaking his face. “Mermista of Salineas. That has, well, the most lovely ring to it.”

“Ughhh,” she groaned, and buried her flushing face in her hands. “Stop looking at me like that, you’re so weird.”

“Again, been called much worse, Mermista.”

“Stop saying my name.”

“Hm, I don’t think I can, Mermista. It’s stuck on my tongue.”

“Okay, get out. Goodbye. There’s the door.”

“But, Mermistaaaa-“

“No.”

“Misty?”

“I’ll kill you.”

“Merm?”

“Do you want to die? Is that where you see your day going? Because it’s going there.”

“Mista?”

“I’ll scream for the guards, Sebastian, I swear-“

He cut her off with a kiss, deep and chaste. He pulled back quickly, time was running out, and he had to know-

“Please, the next time I’m in Salineas, may I see you again?”

“Ughhhhhh, I guessssss,” she groaned, but there was no heat to it. “If you don’t have anything, like, better to do.”

“No,” he smirked, his eyes flicking down her still naked body. “I really don’t think I will.”

She flushed deeply, and pushed him off of her with shocking strength. His ass hit the floor hard, but he was laughing too much to really feel it.

“Goodbye, get out, so long.” She buried her head in her pillow with another groan.

He picked himself up and dusted himself off. He was just about at the door, when something struck him and rooted him to the spot. He had to tell her. He didn’t know why but he had to. She had to know, and he had to be honest. Not that he had time to deal with the consequences. That would have to be the next visit’s problem.

Next visit!

Focus, Sea Hawk.

Right.

“Oh, and uh, Mermista?” He called, and waited for her to lift her head from the pillow. He scratched his neck nervously. “It didn’t come up last night, but I thought you ought to know, just so, y’know, you can keep an eye out for my ship-“

“Sea Hawk.”

“Right, yes. I’m a pirate. Okay? Okay. Excellent-“

“What-!”

“See you next time, dearest! Stay well-“

“Sea Hawk- Sebastian!”

“Exit stage left, pursued by bear!”

The door shut, and before she had time to gather herself and chase him down for answers, he sprinted from the halls, up the gentle sloping ramp (ah, it was a ramp, not stairs, that makes sense), through the main doors, and out of the courtyard. It was only when he was on his ship, dodging noogies and back claps and wolf whistles at his walk- well, sprint- of shame, that he overheard the captain and quartermaster talking.

“It was a double blind. King Mercia hired someone to hire us to test the safety of his castle. They say he’s become paranoid ever since the Horde took the Queen, may her soul rest easy.”

Sea Hawk leaned against the railing, listening idly as he kept his gaze on the balconies of the castle, growing smaller with each passing moment.

“So our success was a bad thing?”

“Peh, only to that dour old blowhard. We got paid either way. We’ll be back in two months time to try the defenses again.”

Sea Hawk perked up. “We will?”

“Aye, lad,” N’davi snorted. “Except next time will be much harder.”

“Oh?”

“Next time, there won’t be no fancy shindig to keep his daughter occupied. And Princess Mermista doesn’t pull her punches.”

Ah. That explained just about everything. Sea Hawk swallowed, heavy, though the anticipation was already thrumming through him like an electric current. “No, she certainly does not.”

Closer, closer

Chapter Summary

> Mermista and Sea Hawk reunite under weird circumstances, and take it from there.

The next time they touched down in Salineas, it was in the dead of night, as per the king's orders. Their mission was a resounding success this time, in that it was an abject failure. One rear flank was taken out by the guard, the other by an incredibly toned butler with a trident. They rounded the corner to the King’s chambers; N’davi, Bill, and Sea Hawk sprinting for the goal, when suddenly he was no longer on his feet. He wasn’t on his ass, though, either.

Sea Hawk tried to yell or move, but found himself unable to. He opened his eyes, and to his complete shock, he was suspended in a ball of water about ten feet off the ground.

And he was running out of air, quickly.

The lights of the grand hall flickered on, bathing the corridor in a warm glow. From behind a coral and cerulean column, Mermista stepped into the light, and his heart stuttered in a way that had nothing to do with the lack of oxygen to his brain.

Her arm was extended toward them, and her countenance screamed ‘I’m so bored, this is so boring and stupid, let me go back to bed.’

On cue, King Mercia strode from his chambers. His crown was gone, and his thick brown hair was queued in a hasty, long braid. He was just as imposing and cold without the crown, Sea Hawk noted.

“Mermista.” His deep voice was warped through the water. “That’s enough. We don’t drown our guests-”

The bubble burst, and Sea Hawk hit the ground hard, with a wet slap and audible heaving.

“-even if they are pirates,” the King sneered, condescension dripping from his every word. Sea Hawk wiped the water from his eyes, tearing off the cloth masks they’d been using as he did. His teeth clenched, his fists balled, and he burned with the desire to voice his protest. They were there on his dollar, doing him a favor, and he had the nerve to-

A hand on his shoulder shook him from his anger, and he turned to see Bill. The older man was drenched as well, but his gaze was stern. Not here, not now. Not with him. Sea Hawk sighed, and helped Bill to his feet.

“Well, then,” the King drawled, “that’s that. In through the side entrance, by the kitchens, picked off along the way, and stopped before you ever reached me. I’d say Salineas is better defended than-”

“We came in through the northern cellar, actually,” Sea Hawk mumbled, wringing water from his jacket. It was new, and he really wanted it to last. It took him a moment to note that silence had fallen.

Uh oh.

“Excuse me, boy?” The King sneered at him like he was a bilge rat found in the grain store.

Sea Hawk straightened up, and bowed at the waist. “Forgive my interruption, your majesty. But we didn’t enter through the kitchen.”

He narrowed his pale eyes. “And why not? If I recall correctly, and I do, those were your orders.”

Sea Hawk’s eyes flickered to Mermista, who had done a wonderful job of ignoring him thus far. But now she was staring at him with something akin to desperate pleading in her eyes. They were imperceptibly wider than normal, her lips were slightly pursed, and she was shaking her head side to side in micrometers.

Sorry, Princess, but it was too late now.

“It was too heavily guarded, sir.”

The King stared at him incredulously. “I understand that a formal education isn’t readily available on the open sea, but I hadn’t expected a pirate of any rank to be plain stupid.”

Sea Hawk squared his jaw, the creak of bone in his ears. Bill’s hand was on his shoulder. He ignored it.

“That was the point of the exercise, boy,” the King spoke patronizingly slow. He was mocking him. “If you could have been stopped at the first checkpoint, then, really, I shouldn’t even have to pay you in full.”

There was a minor uproar from his assorted crewmates, but all Sea Hawk could see was red. His mother’s voice in his ear, warning him to keep his head, was ignored the same as Bill’s grasp.

“Why should it have stopped us when it wouldn’t have stopped the Horde?”

He was too loud, too forward, to be addressing a king. All eyes turned to him incredulously. Mermista’s had never left him.

“Excuse me...” The King stared him down. “...pirate?”

“The Horde won’t give a damn about your checkpoints,” he seethed. “They’ll find another way in, they always do. Your real mistake was heavily fortifying the entrance you directly told us to enter. Horde spies spread out, test every entrance. They have contingency plans, and they do not fail! This exercise, as you call it, was a pointless game. You gave us a map and told us to follow it, and we immediately proved it fallible by using a single iota of critical thought. If this had been real, you would all be dead.”

His voice echoed in the corridor, drawing gasps. His chest heaved with anger, and something pointy. Something very pointy.

Ah.

There was a trident pointed at his sternum.

The King moved closer, and the spears dug in through his shirt. “Was that a threat, boy?”

Sea Hawk wasn’t a nobleman. He had no status, no family name (anymore), no money, nothing really. But he had his integrity, and his pride. He refused to break eye contact.

“Merely an observation, your majesty.”

The King sneered at him, but raised his voice to address the captain. "N'davi. I would speak with you and your crew about the successes and failures of this exercise."

"Yes, your majesty."

Mercia smiled at him, but it was cold. "You will be paid in full, on the contingency that this loud-mouthed, irreverent wretch..." In one fluid movement, he flipped the trident around, and slammed the blunt (but not blunt enough) end into his stomach. Sea Hawk doubled over, as the king had intended, because it made it easier for him to whip the metal base into his temple like a wrought iron switch. He didn't feel the blow, or the floor as he made contact with, but in a second he was sprawled on his side, blood in his mouth and a dull ringing in his ears, "...shows himself out."

N'davi's voice was clipped. "Aye. Sir."

Sea Hawk heard footsteps walking away vaguely, and terse words in a language he didn't understand. After a moment, his vision refocused, and the pounding in his head subsided enough to let him rise. Without a glance back, he stumbled through the heavy double doors, and made his way out of the castle.

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Mermista hadn't expected the night to go well. But she hadn't expected it to go this poorly either.

Her father had told her of the plans a day ago, almost as an afterthought, despite the fact that he wanted her on the frontlines of his guard. She had bit her tongue over breakfast, the usual accusations of being a pawn in his twisted game of chess against the Horde turning to bitter ash in her mouth.

Why bother with accusations when he no longer made an effort to deny the obvious. Ever since she'd inherited the Pearl's full power, he had started talking to her again. Not as a father, though, but as a commander. As a king and nothing more. She had become a valuable, malleable player overnight five years ago, when the Pearl's glow had winked out in front of her very eyes.

And now, she was here, holding a gaggle of pirates suspended in water above the floor of her father's bedchamber corridor.

They were going to drip all over, and she would have to clean it up. Who needs a mop when you've got the water princess, right?

Her father barked a command at her, and she dropped them with a flick of her wrist. They were mostly older men, but a few young adults were brought forward by the guard's the king had stationed throughout their path in the castle. Except for-

Her heart lurched, and dropped into her stomach.

Sea Hawk ripped off his cloth eye mask, shaking water from his vision and hair. Her father made a snide comment to them, and she saw his eyes start to smolder with anger.

That was bad for everyone involved, but it was also not entirely unattractive.

He helped the older man to his left get to his feet, and the man clapped him appreciatively on the back. His father? No, they were too different in appearance. Sea Hawk quite obviously hailed from Snows, or at least one of his parent's did and he favored them greatly. His finn hair was deep and rich like all of Snow's natives were- sleek, thick, and naturally shiny. His skin was tan, though that was most likely from a life spent at sea, under the sun.

Her father was talking again. Ugh. She tuned him out, opting instead to let her eyes wander over Sea Hawk's frame. It hadn't been long, a month at most maybe, so he looked the same, but his clothes were that of a true pirate now. A deeply cut and billowing cotton shirt, work pants reinforced with leather, gently heeled beast hide boots trimmed with gold, a neckerchief and a hair band (that seemed excessive, but he was making it work). His coat was newer it seemed, a deep royal blue trimmed in gold, with shoulder pads that looked heavily reinforced.

A lightblade cutlass hung from the scabbard that was hastily lashed to a belt loop.

Damn it, he was actually hot. She hadn't been dazed and confused by the ambiance of the party.

It wouldn’t be so annoying if he didn’t make it look so effortless. His hair was tousled, wet, and choppy in a way that spoke to hasty and self-done haircuts only when necessary on the sea. It fell into his eyes when he was speaking animatedly, which he was doing now. Oh, oops. In the two seconds it took her to start thinking about his stupidly sexy vibe, he had gotten into an argument with her dad.

The king was berating him for his status, his job, and his intellect, while Sea Hawk’s jaw was working silently.

He caught her eye. She tried to tell him to knock it the fuck off while making minimal movement.

He didn’t listen.

She was getting the feeling he didn’t do that a lot.

He argued back, practically yelling at her father. Privately, Mermista was impressed, and more than pleased at this. Her dad was a narcissistic egomaniac, and he deserved to be taken down, like, all the pegs.

But Sea Hawk wasn’t going to win this.

She had fully expected her dad to throw him in the dungeon, and banish the pirates from their kingdom forever. He did not do that.

Mermista watched in horror as her father levelled his trident at Sea Hawk, before flipping it and-

Alright, well, now she was seething with rage, and that wasn't the most productive situation to be in at that moment.

Sea Hawk was sprawled on his side, blood on his temple and near his mouth. His eyes were sealed shut, and he moved only to curl around his bruising stomach. The other pirates whirled on her father, and for a moment Mermista feared a small coup. But the captain raised his hand, and they held their places. Even the kind looking older man who was shaking with rage.

Her father snorted, and Mermista tasted blood in her own mouth as she bit her tongue. These pirates- these people- had been nothing but helpful to them. Sea Hawk was- had been-

He was different.

The thought swirled around in her head as her father and the pirates strode off. She called after him in Salinean, and he dismissed her brusquely. She held her tongue again, but bitter resentment coursed through her. God forbid she learn any political skill before taking the throne when she could sit and be a pretty little war dog.

Fucking asshole.

She turned back to where Sea Hawk should have been sprawled. Key words- should have been.

He was nowhere to be found, but the minute drips of blood on the floor she followed led her to the front doors. Her personal guard, Ku’ele, gestured lightly with his chin toward the shore by the docks. She nodded her thanks and took off through the courtyard and down the steps.

She found him easily, stumbling down the shoreline very quickly for a concussed, bloodied man. In the night moons’ glow, reflecting off the sea, his already handsome features softened even further.

“Sea Hawk, wait!”

He didn’t turn, didn’t even pause. It was like he hadn’t heard her at all.

She grit her teeth. “Sebastian! I said wait!”

That worked. He stopped, but he didn’t turn to her. In fact, as she caught up to him, he worked very hard to keep his face turned away from her.

“Hey, dude, c’mon, let me see-“

He swatted her hands away. “I’m fine, Princess. You should go back inside.”

“Um, fat chance.” She rolled her eyes. What was with the broody chivalry thing? He hadn’t been like this when they were-

Oh.

When they were strangers.

Again, like so many times in her life, Mermista felt the loneliness of title washing over her, defining her, ruining another relationship- friendship- whatever- before it had even had a chance to start.

That thought flew from her mind when he faltered, doubling over on his knees with a groan. She knelt beside him, reaching out for his bloodied head without another thought.

He hissed when her fingers touched his temple, yanking away. “Ow- fuck-“

“Well if you would hold still-“

“Please!” He held her hands from his wounds. “There is no need to dirty your hands with the likes of me.”

“Ugh, are you serious right now?” Mermista rolled her eyes, silently cursing her father. Again. “Sea Hawk, literally, I don’t care that you’re bleeding, I’ve dealt with worse than a head wound-“

“I meant-” He held her wrist away from him, suspended in the air with a deceptively strong grip. Something in her swooped low at the thought. “-with a pirate.”

“Oh, are you fucking- is that what you’re on about?” She groaned. “Sea Hawk, I don’t give a single shit that you’re a pirate. Why should I, anyway?”

He flushed, and stammered for an answer fruitlessly. She raised a cool brow.

“Is it because we fucked?”

“Princess!”

“Oh, whatever!” She flapped the hand he still held between. “We’re consenting adults, it was fun, now my dad’s contracting you for a vanity project. The fact that you’re a pirate is like, the literal least of our worries now.”

His eyes flickered over her face. She held his gaze, bored with this whole drama.

“If you’re certain, m’lady-“

“Hmmm, not your lady.” She yanked her wrist away from him, hoping it would distract him from her blush. “And you’re still bleeding, like, profusely. So shut up and let me help you out.”

He relaxed, finally, jaw unclenching and those deep brown eyes softening. “If her majesty insists.”

“Her majesty insists you shut up,” she grumbled. She pushed him lightly, and he shifted from sitting on his knees to his butt. Mermista scooted closer, until she was only an inch or so from his gross and bloody face.

It was much nastier in the clear moonlight. The entire left side of his face looked like it had been dipped in crimson paint, and it was starting to cake his hairband-sash-thing to his skin. She sighed, and reached out to the sea.

He watched her with awe as the water answered her as it always had, flowing up and out of the basin, ribboning over to them like a festival kite. The water flowed up her arm and bubbled around her hand.

“Amazing,” Sea Hawk breathed, eyes on the water as she drew it closer to his face. “How…?”

Mermista shrugged. “Magic, y’know?”

He shook his head, still transfixed by her. It was doing odd things to her stomach, the open admiration he displayed at her abilities.

No one had ever looked at her, or her magic, like that.

She sighed, and spoke to him as she worked the water over his skin, under his headband, cleaning him gently. “My magic comes from my family’s runestone, the Pearl. I connected to it when I was young, younger than most, but since it’s not like, crazy dangerous teleportation magic like the moon stone, my mother didn’t see a problem with it.” She avoided his gaze as she scrubbed absently at the headband. “She was the princess before me.”

Sea Hawk frowned. “I thought she was queen?”

“Yeah, she was,” she drawled. When she saw him looking even more puzzled, she heaved her usual put-upon sigh. “Princess is kind of a double meaning in kingdoms and provinces with runestones. Any being who can connect to, and wield the power of their runestone, is a princess. Male, female, neither, both, the runestones see no difference. But in other kingdoms, those without innate magic, like Dryl, princess is also used to refer to a ruler who has yet to inherit full power. So in Salineas, you can be Princess, as well as prince, king, queen, whatever. The same goes for the other Rune Kingdoms.”

Sea Hawk nodded along, his brow furrowed in concentration as he absorbed her words. He wasn’t just hearing her, he was listening. And she got the feeling he wasn’t just listening to her because she was royalty. He wanted to listen to her. At least, she hoped he did.

Mermista flushed, and dropped the now pink water a few feet away on the sand before pulling more forth. He watched her with even more awe this time, if such a thing were possible.

“So, you’re connected to the Pearl? And the Pearl makes you move water?”

“Kinda, sorta,” she hummed, now focused on his jaw and the bruising there. The bleeding had stopped, but she wanted to make sure he didn’t have cracked teeth. “The pearl grants me, like, the ability to control water in any liquid form. So, most liquids fall under the umbrella, as nearly every liquid on this planet is majority water.”

“Coffee?”

“Yup.”

“Wine?”

“Sure.”

“Ice?”

“Nope.” Mermista popped the P, enjoying his confusion. She shrugged. “No one can explain it. But I can’t control ice, and the Princess of the Fractal Flake can’t control water.”

“Huh…” Sea Hawk’s gaze was unfocused, but present. Like he was mulling over what she’d said deeply. “That seems terribly oxymoronic, but alright.”

She bit back a giggle. She refused to giggle at his jokes, like, on principle. Even when the smile on his face told her he already knew she wanted to.

Whatever.

They lapsed back into silence, until the last of the blood was cleared from his face and clothes. Mermista ghosted a hand over his abdomen, apologetic.

“Sea Hawk, I…”

He sighed. “It’s okay, Princess. I understand. I spoke out of line and-“

“Stop.” There was steel woven into her voice, her mask of boredom dropping. “Don’t you dare apologize. You did nothing wrong, Sebastian. He...” Her voice warbled, and she looked away, out to the sea, “He is an egotistical, jealous, narcissistic fool, who can’t admit when he’s wrong, and can’t be bothered to care about anything more than what he looks like to everyone else.”

Fingers brushed against hers, hesitant.

She whipped her head back to him. “He’s the king, and he’s my father, but he is a terrible, cruel man,” she whispered, speaking aloud thoughts she had never been able to. “Don’t you dare think for a second that this, any of this” -she gestured to his body- “was justified.”

Sea Hawk nodded, and she dropped her gaze. Why was she saying any of this? She was… this wasn’t her thing. Feelings and sympathy and comfort. Sharing. Shame flooded her, shame at her emotional weakness, shame at her father, threatening to choke her. She pushed on, regardless of her apathetic instincts begging her to shut the hell up.

“Rules are supposed to protect their people, to listen and lead, and show them the way. The trust their subjects have in them should never be taken lightly.”

A hand on her chin, pushing, made her look up and lock eyes with Sea Hawk. She flushed, realizing how much she’d just said. But before she could throw her walls back up, and retreat behind her mask of eternal indifference, his eyes stopped her. The annoying, worshipful awe was back, but just behind it there were flickers of something deeper: true respect.

“I think, Princess...” He leaned in, eyes on hers, waiting to be stopped, “...that one day, Salineas will have the finest Queen in all of Etheria at her helm.”

She leaned in as well, letting her eyes slide shut as her lips met his. It was nothing like their last kiss; this was softer, but no more chaste than the ones they’d shared in bed, or on the dance floor. Just...different.

Different like him.

Mermista was surprised by a small stab of annoyance. Who did this pirate think he was? Waltzing into her life, treating her with kindness and respect, showing reverent awe at her beloved magic. He didn’t push her boundaries, but he challenged her. Over and over again, he challenged her.

He was weird, and Mermista had the feeling she had only just scraped the surface of that weirdness.

And before she could dig deeper, someone was calling his name.

“Hawk! Sea Hawk, lad, where are ye?”

He pulled back from her as if her lips were made of fire, and a spell was broken. Mermista scowled, and hastily shook off the vulnerability she’d been showing. She had just met this dude, showing weakness could be a huge mistake. She pulled her apathy around her like a threadbare blanket, familiar and comforting in a way that few understood.

“Sea Hawk!” Another voice, deeper and younger, joined the first.

He brought his fingers to his mouth, and whistled shrilly in a bird-like staccato. Like a- well, like a sea hawk. He waited a beat, until it was repeated, and then turned back to her.

“I have to go…”

Mermista ignored the weird twisting in her chest. “Yeah, kinda got that.”

“Princess, may I- that is, could we-“ He stumbled over his words, and she refused to think it was endearing.

“I’m not getting younger over here, dude.”

He drew himself up. “I would like to see you again, your majesty. As a friend. Or as not a friend. Or more than a friend. However you’ll have me,” he stammered. “I just, really, *really* would like to see you again.”

His eyes bored into hers, burning like a wood fire.

“Yeah, alright.” She shrugged. He beamed at her, ecstatic, and she rolled her eyes. “Ugh, like, seriously don’t make a big deal out of it. When are you in Salineas next?”

“I’ll be here in two months, with the market fair for the autumn equinox.”

“Cool.” She shrugged again, even as her stomach was doing funny backflips. “See you then, I guess.”

His smile was brighter than the Pearl at high tide. His injuries, and very likely concussion, might as well have never happened. The quiet little world they'd existed in not two minutes ago was gone. Once again, she was the frigid princess, and he was an overexcited pirate with a ship to catch.

So why did she feel so...warm?

Before she could shove her walls up any further, he darted into her personal space, and kissed her cheek softly. Like she was something precious that deserved to be handled with care.

"Until then, my princess."

She opened her mouth to correct him, again, but he winked at her in a roguish way that should not have been as hot as it was, and took off down the beach. He really shouldn't have been running like that with bruised organs and a concussion. But hey, that wasn't really her problem. He wasn't really her problem.

And that's what she told herself as she walked back to the castle and up to her room, repeating it every time she stopped at window along the way to watch his ship carry him further and further out to sea.

Things Fall Apart

Chapter Summary

> Nothing gold can stay, but damn if they didn't try.

Chapter Notes

> I just realized I haven't been including chapter notes, which is so weird for me. So hey there! Thank you all much for the views, kudos, and comments. They make my day, and I promise I'll be responding to this comments soon. I hope you all enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Sea Hawk returned three months later, and took her around the stalls of the Equinox Festival one night. They talked, and ate, and drank, and danced. They laughed. Mermista laughed more that night than she had in the past eight years combined. He left the following week, with promises to return in a few weeks' time.

And so it continued.

He would blow in from his adventures, rife with stories and tall tales and beautiful gifts that he never fully told her the origins of; jewelry, bolts of fine fabric, gorgeous metals, new technology, foods from far away lands. He would bluster into port like a hurricane, and Mermista hated that she had started counting down the days until she saw the pirate sail in the bay again.

Over the next year, they became the worst kept secret in the kingdom. After all, it was pretty hard to miss the Princess waltzing around town with the local ne’er do well charmer of a pirate on her arm. It was also hard to miss that, for as long as the black, purple, and silver sails were docked in Salineas’ harbor- the colors of the neutral pirates- Mermista and Sea Hawk were inseparable.

Not that either of them really had the presence of mind to notice. For both of them, it was the first time in a long time they had ever had a real friend.

Mermista was quick to pick up that her new “friend” was absolutely infatuated with her. Almost annoyingly so. He was also not nearly as suave and debonair as he had first presented himself to be. Sea Hawk was, put simply, a stupid goof.

He made up songs on the spot, about anything he could think of; he musically narrated himself picking fruit from the street stall, skipping stones on the shore, getting a sharp bit of shell stuck in his bare foot. He serenaded her actions as she wrung water from her hair after swimming, and nibbled at salted sea-kelp snacks. In fact, it would be easier to recount the times he wasn’t singing obnoxiously in her ear about absolutely nothing.

Mermista would sooner trade in her scales than admit she found it marginally cute.

Sea Hawk was rash, impulsive, and prone to starting fires. He didn’t look before he jumped and was rarely equipped to deal with the consequences of his loud mouth and stupid actions. Luckily, she had been raised a politician, and was usually able to talk him out of jail...or being banished. Mermista found herself wondering if he'd been dropped at an early age.

But, Sebastian Hawkins was also an enigma. A greater mystery to her than any of her Mer-mystery books. And Mermista loved solving a mystery.

Some things were obvious to her, even if he thought they were well hidden.

Mermista often turned and found Sea Hawk staring at her with an intensity that scared the living shit out of her. It was concerning how fast he could switch from happy-go-lucky moron to sober, serious pirate in the blink of an eye. Mercurial didn't even begin to scratch the surface.

He was absolutely, infuriatingly, nothing like the others who had caught her eye in the past. The answer as to why she found herself preferring his company to all others' eluded her, slippery and vague like an eel.

Until one night, when they were strolling along the royal beach at dusk. He had lost his shirt a half mile back, and she'd let him take her hand in his a half mile before that.

Having sex before you learn each other's names does wonders for self-conscious jitters when it comes to not-dates.

“-and so I said, like, dude, you’re absolutely batshit if you think I’m going to agree to that, let alone my up-tight fuckwit of a dad- well, obviously, not quite like that, but that was, like, the gist of it, y’know?”

Sea Hawk’s eyes were light with mirth, and he was grinning as he nodded along. Mermista fought back her own smile, and flicked her hair over her shoulder. “Anyway, he got all huffy and stormed out, the usual blah blah about he wouldn’t even want me anyway, which, like, yeah okay, sure buddy. I’m a catch.”

Sea Hawk snorted. “Yes, quite the catch is the princess who calls all potential courters, what was it now- ah, yes- twatbags? Was it?”

“Shut up!” Mermista laughed, punching him in the shoulder with her free hand. Sea Hawk’s laugh was bright and loud, like him.

It wasn’t until he kissed her goodnight and trotted back along the beach to find his shirt (as she happily enjoyed the view of him leaving) that something occurred to her.

She had been the one talking all night. Not once had she clammed up, or drawn into herself. The whole walk she’d carried on, talking his ear off about her stupid etiquette lessons, her dad not letting her in on the war room meetings even while he increased her training hours, the orca she’d met on her swim that morning, the way the word ‘suitor’ had been getting tossed around more and more-

And he had listened. Not even in that patronizing way where you could tell that you’d lost the person’s interest but ending the conversation would be more awkward than talking to a wall. Sure, he had been kind of over the top all night, even shantying a time or two despite her very vocal protests, but he hadn’t been ingenuine. His attention hadn’t even wavered when she was talking about the suitor dilemma-

Well, why should it? It wasn’t like he… like they were… you know, whatever.

And even more than that, when they had lapsed into silence, he hadn’t rushed to fill it, or pressured her to. Which, by all accounts, he absolutely should have. He was a motormouth in his own right, a renewable and ever-burning source of energy that would cow the likes of Dryl’s princess.

But he’d let her be silent. Without judgement or annoyance or impatience.

Mermista’s stomach did funny flips all the way back to her bed chamber, right up until the moment she fell asleep.

Sea Hawk, for his part, was as head over heels for Mermista as he had been since that first night. Perhaps even more so. And it had nothing (okay, very little) to do with her breathtaking beauty, and everything to do with her never ending contrarianism.

She could be, for lack of a more polite word, a caustic bitch from time to time. Not that he would ever put it that way to her, and refrained from really defining it that way to himself. She could be uppity, rude, and impatient in a different way than him. She didn't tolerate empty or grand gestures, forced politeness, small talk, or inanity. Which could be a struggle, as some of those were things he did on reflex.

However, she was also unspeakably kind, relentlessly giving, and funny in a way that very few people were- subtle, dry, and with a sharp wit that belied deep intelligence. She was absolutely captivating. Her laugh was music, hard won. Her smiles, her real smiles, were rare but they shone on him like the sun after a storm at sea. He could listen to her talk about her kingdom and her books and her theories about both all day, because when she did, her eyes lit up and his heart swooned in a funny way. It left him breathless and waiting for more every time.

And, as if to sweeten this already impossible deal, she understood him. Him! Sea Hawk, the weird-ass pirate kid who could never stop setting things on fire- not at sea, not in Snows. It would be impressive if it wasn't inconvenient.

Alright, he still found it impressive.

Mermista didn't use words, or gestures, to make him feel comfortable. Rather the opposite. It was what she didn't say, or do, that made him want to stay by her side until the sky came crashing down.

They were at Seaworthy, in mild disguise as to avoid the King's guard from finding her there with him. He'd bought them drinks, and they had tucked their cloaked selves into a dark booth in the back of the room, where no one would bother them unless they really wanted to die.

So, like, a fifty-fifty shot at peace.

He hadn't even realized how tired he was from the day; he'd been helping to reload a friend's ship with cargo for Brightmoon, and had spent the hot morning baking and sweating in the sun. And then he'd been on his own ship, running through maintenance checks with Bill. All day, hours and hours, just talking. Talking and talking and laughing and chatting about practically nothing, and at some point his face had become plastic and his ears were ringing and his jaw hurt and -

"Hey."

He snapped his gaze up from his drink, and smiled on reflex. "Yes, dearest?"

Mermista scowled. "One, no. Two, chill."

“But...we are chilling?”

“That’s, like, not what I meant. Relax with all the stage vocals and the swashbuckling type-a bullshit. It’s exhausting. For both of us.”

Sea Hawk opened his mouth to protest, but only for the sake of protest itself. She was right, as she always was. He was tired. He’d been on the ocean for two straight months, and while it certainly left him with stories to tell, he supposed he didn’t have to tell them all in one night. So he gave in, and in a bold move that spoke to the depth of his weariness, dropped his head onto her shoulder. And there, in the darkness of their little booth-heaven, she wrapped an arm around him, and ran her fingers through his hair.

Softly, unexpectedly. Just being. Her shell was such a part of her, thick and jagged and terse, that he sometimes forgot the tender woman it protected.

“Would you like to hear about how I set the transport ferry on fire?”

“Again?”

He shrugged helplessly, and she actually laughed. “Alright, goober, what happened?”

And so they sat, cuddled in their booth (even if she'd skin him for calling it that), nursing their drinks while he told her about his never ending misadventures with fire, sea monsters, and his terrible luck at dice. He dropped his "stage vocals" as she called them (rude, but fair), realizing that she tended to pay more attention when he did. She liked his real voice over his story voice. Sea Hawk didn't know what to make of that, as it had never happened before.

Mermista didn't make sense to him a lot of the time. She laughed when he wasn't trying to be funny. She didn't react to his fantastical tales of adventure on the high seas, but she did to stories from his boyhood in Snows. She was never jealous when past romances were brought up, in fact, she teased him about them until *he* was the one blushing. She wasn't shy, but she didn't talk much when he'd start chatting with another group.

She was a walking contradiction, and Sea Hawk was finding himself slightly obsessed with unraveling her.

When he dropped her off at their meeting spot, a lightly hidden craggy overhang on the shore, she kissed his cheek softly, and looked into his eyes for a bit longer than usual, a bit deeper than normal. He waited for her to say something, but she never did; eventually she just ruffled his hair, like the moment had never happened, and sashayed her way back to the castle.

The next time he returned, in the dead of winter, Mermista didn't come to meet him. Not for a week. He came to their meeting spot each morning and each night, and even started checking in the afternoons, but he only found her there at midnight on the eight day.

She was curled up against the rocks, knees to her chin, watching the waves with empty and sullen eyes.

“Mermista!” He sprinted towards her, unable to stem his excitement. He slowed as he got closer, though, smile fading as he took in her lifeless posture. He fell to his knees beside her. “Princess, what’s wrong?”

She turned to look at him, sluggish with an apathy so thick she wore it like a cloak. No frown, no smile, smirk, scowl, nothing.

She blinked. “They’ve found me a suitor.”

“...what?”

“You heard me.”

He had in fact heard her. He sat down before her, and hesitantly reached for her hand. She didn’t pull away, but she didn’t reciprocate his squeeze either.

“Are you...happy?”

Mermista snorted, but it was empty. And then she laughed, and it was shrill, hysterical, and cold. "Am I happy?" she repeated incredulously. "Who the fuck cares? Not them!" She flung a hand behind her toward the castle. "Not my father! Not whoever the fuck this guy is!"

She rose to her feet, and stormed toward the ocean. His eyes followed her helplessly. "No one" -waves rose up- "on this miserable fucking rock" -they contorted in on themselves, convulsing angrily- "gives a shit about me!"

Her arm flew out, and the waves came slamming back into the sand, spraying them both with salt water. Immediately, she fell to her knees, and he rushed over to her. He didn't want to touch her when she clearly wasn't receptive to it, but he was at a loss for what to do.

She wasn't crying when she looked up at him, but he nearly wished she was. It would be better than the empty devastation in her eyes.

"I'm never going to be anything more than a tool, or a weapon, or a political gambit."

It wasn't a question to her, but a fact. She said it with too much finality for it to be anything else.

Sea Hawk felt his eyes filling with tears for her.

“When will you marry him?”

Mermista closed her eyes. “Seven months.”

Oh. That- that was the feeling of his heart being torn from his ribs, still bleeding and beating, for all the world to see.

He swallowed. “Should I...go?”

“...yeah, probably.” Her voice was small, and defeated.

Sea Hawk closed his eyes, and made to get up. A hand fisting in his shirt caught him

“But I don’t really want you to.”

And then her lips were on his, desperate and needing. They were salty with ocean and tears, and Sea Hawk had never tasted anything more divine.

They’d slept together since the ball, whenever it fit into whatever they were, as it was convenient for them. But not like this. When he took her, it was with everything he had, knowing this could-should- *would* be the last time he'd ever be able to make her fall apart beneath him. The last time he would make her come, crying and moaning into his neck as her legs held him to her for all they were worth.

He made sure their last was as long and fulfilling as their first had been. A coda to all they had been over the past year and change.

They lay together in the sand, chafed and sore but ignoring it all, as the sun began to rise over the now-still ocean. Sea Hawk could have chuckled, thinking of it thrashing and writhing just as its princess had through the night, if he had any joy left in him.

Mermista sighed, and he heard it echo through her chest from where his head resting above her heart. "I don't want to stop seeing you."

He hummed. "Nor I, you."

She toyed with his hair. "It's not...uncommon...for royalty to have, you know…"

"Affairs?"

"Yeah."

Sea Hawk swallowed bile. “I’d rather we not disrespect ourselves or our value to one another with that.”

Another hum. “What is my value to you, Sebastian?”

“...I think you know, Princess.”

“Yeah.” She sounded choked, and when he rose to meet her eyes, they were swimming with unshed tears. “Kind of embarrassing for you, huh?”

He chuckled at her, weak as it was. “Never, my lady.”

She closed her eyes, pained, and a tear broke free to chase a path into the sand. He kissed her cheek, softly, reverently, and she choked on a sob.

“When do you leave?”

“This afternoon.”

“N’davi’s getting to be a bit of a ball buster.”

“Ah, right, about that-“

“Your balls?”

“What- no- the captain!” He sat up, not sure if he could have this conversation being so close to her face. Mermista followed him up however, and pressed her bare chest to his back as she hooked her chin over her shoulder. “He um...there was an incident.”

“What?”

“He’s dead.” Silence fell on them, heavy, and Sea Hawk closed his eyes against the torrent of emotion. He couldn’t close his mouth, though. “He was...There was an ambush, a trap, waiting for us at a rendezvous. We were supposed to be trading a few crates of rations to the Snows kingdom forces, in exchange for something classified to be sent to Brightmoon. The drop went fine. But on the way back…”

He fisted a hand in the sand, and felt Mermista cover it with hers, lacing their fingers together.

“Somehow, the Horde was tipped off. There were four battalion ships waiting for us when we entered open water. The Dragon’s Fire is a beauty, fast and sturdy for her age, but she was no match. They had us surrounded. They boarded us, tied us up. It really...wasn’t looking good.”

He couldn’t bring himself to talk about how he was certain he was going to die, and that he had made sure his final thoughts were of her, of her laughter and her mind and her beauty. It could’ve broken him at that point.

“But N’Davi stepped forward, said he’d go with them and tell them whatever they wanted to know if they let us go on our way. That only he had the information and the rest of us would be a waste of resources, or, if they killed us, too many violations of the Piracy Neutrality Code. And so they took him. “

Mermista squeezed his hand. “He may still be alive-“

“He blew up their ships.”

She fell silent.

“If there’s one thing we all hate more than the stringent trade rules of the kingdoms of Etheria...” He nudged her jokingly, half hearted as it was, “...it’s the Horde. They’ve taken something from all of us. And so when he had the chance, he couldn’t pass it up. N’Davi took out all four battalion ships, and everyone on board. Brightmoon won’t get their missive.”

“Sea Hawk…”

He couldn’t bring himself to move.

“Sebastian.” Her hand was on his jaw, turning his eyes to focus on hers. True sympathy, not pity, she offered him. “I’m so sorry.”

He fell into her arms, boneless with grief, even when only a few tears came. They trailed down her breasts, lazy in the morning light. Her lips were in his hair, an apology, a prayer. A goodbye.

“I don’t want to stop seeing you either.”

“I know,” she sniffled. “But I don’t see a way out.”

He drew back from her after a while, but pulled her into his lap and into the shade of their overhang. He really didn’t want to deal with sunburn on his ass on top of all the emotional trauma the world seemed hellbent on giving him.

He tucked her hair behind her ears, tracing their shell with an index finger. Wordlessly, he reached up to his own and unclasped the thin gold cuffs he wore. He held them out to her silently.

“Sea Hawk,” she breathed. “We can’t...I can’t-“

“I know,” he chuckled sadly. “This isn’t a proposal. Or an offer. I have nothing I can give you, Mermista. No way to compete with a lord, or any time to know if that would be the best choice for us.” He ran a hand over her knee. “I care for you so deeply. You’re the best friend I’ve ever had, and with time...well, who knows what we could have had.”

She buried her head in his shoulder. “You’re my best friend, too, or whatever,” she mumbled.

“I really hope so, you’ve seen the weird birthmark by my b- ow!”

“Shut up,” she groaned. “You’re ruining it.”

He pecked her forehead. “That’s what I do, dearest.”

“Ugh.”

He opened her hand, and dropped the clasps in. “To remember me by. I don’t know where the ocean, or this war, will take us. I don’t know when I’ll see you again. Or even if we’ll ever be able to be in the same room again. But I want you to remember this last year.”

She pulled away from his shoulder, eyes rimmed red. “I don’t have anything I can give you.”

“Oh, princess.” He smiled. “You’ve already given me so much more than enough.”

They fell silent, save for the sound of Mermista setting the clasps into her ears. They washed in silence, the princess running water over him that she called up from the sea. They dressed in silence. And when they parted, it was in silence as well. With tears in their eyes, and grief in their hearts, they kissed one more time, before turning and walking back to their respective lives.

Six agonizing months later, Sea Hawk received word that the Sea Gate had been permanently damaged by the Horde, and wouldn’t last the year. Not a day later, he was docked in Sea Worthy, where he heard the news that the king had abdicated the throne and fled along with most of the rest of the citizens of Salineas, leaving his daughter queen of a crumbling kingdom, about to be blown off the map.

As casually as possible, he inquired about the new queen’s betrothed and the wedding. Both had been called off immediately after she ascended, as the man in question had been among the first to desert the kingdom.

Not daring to hope, Sea Hawk readied his personal ship, and made for the Sea Gate.

He docked, and took the extra time to moor his ship now that he was without a crew- No, focus on Mermista. They led him to the throne room, and his eyes widened at its grandeur. Wall murals etched with strange symbolic writing lined the room. The floor shone like the opalescent underside of a beach shell, cool and polished. His heeled boots clicked loudly in the too-empty chamber. His head was on such a swivel that his eyes found her’s last.

Gone were the ornate tunics, salwars, and saris, replaced by a thick, cropped tank top, not unlike the lehenga choli he’d first met her in. Instead of an elaborate skirt, though, she wore thick leggings with scale detailing that almost looked organic. They could have been steel and leather, or they might have been something else...he’d heard the rumors of the Salinean royal family’s gifts, the ones that had nothing to do with the runestone, but he hadn’t asked her about them. It had always seemed a bit gauche, even for him.

Her eyes weren’t empty anymore. They were carefully bored, and masking a quiet, omnipresent rage that burned just behind her put-upon.

“Ugh,” she groaned. “Who let you back in here?”

There was more bite to her words than there had been in the past, but Sea Hawk tried to push past it. She had been through hell, after all.

“Mermista!” He leapt closer to the throne before falling dramatically to his knees. “How I’ve missed you so! I heard about what happened, and I came as soon as I could-”

“Wasn’t really soon enough, was it?” she drawled. He looked up, and yes, that anger was definitely directed at him now. He swallowed.

“I- I was on the open sea near the Waste-”

“Whatever.” Her hand sliced through the air with lazy finality. “It’s convenient you’re here, anyway.” Sea Hawk’s sinking heart buoyed slightly. “I understand that your fleet had an agreement with my father, a trade agreement.”

“Yes, my prin- queen- Princess?”

Mermista rolled her eyes, with none of her usual fondness. “Whatever suits you. Anyway, yeah, I’m like, releasing you from that.”

“Excuse me?”

“Your trade agreement with Salineas. It’s done. Your last shipment and payment for it will be delivered to your ship when you leave. Which is right now.”

“Mermista, wait-”

She rose from her throne, turning to leave, and for the first time he noticed the trident in her hand. He swallowed, temple throbbing with memory. "That's all. Thanks for your time, or whatever-"

"Mermista, please!"

She whirled, and for a brief second he saw the pain her rage was hiding. "I said, that's all, Sea Hawk. Now get out. Leave. The Sea Gate is crumbling, and not even you're too stupid to miss that."

He closed his eyes, taking deep breaths. She was hurt, and abandoned, and taking it out on the only person she knew she could. He forced the pain down. Slowly, he rose, and bowed formally to her. "Yes, your majesty. Forgive my outburst."

"Whatever."

When he looked up, her back was turned to him again, as she stood by the window overlooking the struggling gate.

He had so much more to say, but like a candle in a hurricane it had all been blown right out of him, leaving him empty. Bereft. At a loss for what to do, he bowed again, and turned from the room. He was vaguely aware of the guards trailing him to the door, but they were irrelevant to him.

Only when he was back on his too-empty, too-small ship, casted off and headed for open waters, did he allow the tears to fall.

Chapter End Notes

> Welp. There we go. Next chapter will take us into the sea gate episode and out of the prologue

The Sea Gate

Chapter Summary

> Sea Hawk returns to Salineas with plot developments in tow, against all of Mermista's wishes. Afterwards, a private moment and a conversation.

Chapter Notes

> We have begun the series! Like, the canon series. Sex is implied in this chapter but not explicit. When explicit scenes come up, I will leave a cut off in all caps for those who want to skip!
>
> Also: while it's implied in this chapter that Sea Hawk sets his boats on fire for sad reasons, I also think he does it bc he's an adrenaline junkie. He's a layered man.
>
> CW: implied sex, mild anxiety/panic attack
>
> Hope y'all enjoy ! Love reading everyone's comments, they make me so happy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mermista had been certain that her heart had shrivelled up and died the day she woke up alone in her castle, while Horde cannons knocked on her front doors. Abandoned; she'd been abandoned. By her father. By Lord Fuckwit, which, really, kind of a win. No, definitely a win. Most of her guards had fled, and the people of the capitol were actively fleeing.

As the Pearl's power had surged within her, bolstering her and giving her the strength to push back the ships, her heart had turned to stone.

She was alone, and it was for the best.

She had sent Sea Hawk away, dismissed any guards who'd tried to come crawling back. Had instructed her remaining guards to bar her father entry from the castle for the rest of her days as queen. Maybe she'd get lucky, and they'd mutiny and kill her in her sleep.

At least it would beat waiting around to die like this.

But then- the nerve of this life, really, - an eight foot tall warrior princess, a pint-sized sparkling hellion, and a dorky archer had waltzed into her throne room, led by-

Yeahhh, life was really not doing her any favors.

Again, she'd rebuffed and dismissed him, feeling only a small twinge of sadness for humiliating him so publicly. But really, it was hardly her fault. He was doing that thing he did, when people were around, where he got all...much. Too much. And she couldn't cope with that and her gate, and- oh, hey, the Horde.

Even so, it felt kind of shitty when Glimmer noticed him getting ready to leave before she did. And wow, didn't that hurt? He was leaving her, too-

Because you told him to, stupid , whispered the treacherous voice of her conscience.

Whatever , she mused, *he should have known better than to leave when she told him to* .

Fucking how?

Shut up.

But then, he'd stayed. Not because of her, but because of Princess Glimmer, Bow, and Adora. And that sucked just as much as him leaving, but in a different way. Whatever. Whatever, whatever, what *fucking* ever.

One hour, a burned boat, a scratched to shit Adora, and a healed Sea Gate later, the deed was done. Sea Hawk knelt before her, reached for her hand, and on instinct she placed hers into his, forgetting to rebuff him. His grip was as warm and comforting as she remembered, if not a bit more calloused.

She was sure she was blushing, and snarked at him to cover it. It didn't matter, his head was bowed as he asked her to reconsider her position on the alliance. On isolating herself to the point of destruction.

And she did.

But, like, not because of *him* .

And when she gifted him a boat from her private fleet - probably against her better judgement if the look in his eyes was anything to go on - she studiously avoided Glimmer's eye. It was irrelevant that such a gesture would be considered a courting offer in just about any other kingdom. He didn't know that, and she didn't mean it like that. It was just a ride.

Just. A. Ride.

Even if she did catch him roughly by the now-worn jacket sleeve, and yank him close - too close - to her.

"How long will it take you to get them to Sea Worthy?"

His eyes were bright with leftover adrenaline, the thrill of adventure and fighting and victory. "In that lovely lady? Mere hours."

Mermista glanced at the horizon. It was barely sundown, and she had paperwork to sign off on. She would be up. "Return at once."

Sea Hawk's throat bobbed as he swallowed harshly. He nodded, but didn't dare to pull away. This close to him, his scent filled her senses, washing out all else. Woodsmoke, ozonic metal like his glowing blade, sweat, and something else heady and deep and spicy that could only really be described as Sea Hawk. She released him from her grip, and turned away.

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The night moon hung high and white in the sky by the time Sea Hawk made it back to Salineas. The Sea Gate, blue and shimmering in all its glory, parted for him like a veil made of water. He moored, and started to head toward the castle when a guard stopped him. He eyed the trident warily, but the man just gestured for Sea Hawk to follow him. He was lead along a winding path around the castle, through the back courtyard, and down some steps to an enclosed cove that was well hidden from outside eyes.

The guard disappeared as Sea Hawk pushed through the lichen curtains. When he emerged his jaw dropped.

Natural waterfalls fed into a deep crystalline pool, a few hundred feet across. The walls tapered down to offer a view of the open sea beyond the grotto, but a hanging willow tree made it almost impossible to see in. The water reflected the moonlight, bathing the high rocks around them with dancing white light.

It felt ethereal. This was the most beautiful place he’d ever seen.

His heart did stop momentarily, though, when he realized there was something large swimming in the pool. His hand flew to his cutlass when he saw a tiny dorsal fin, scaled in a way that dolphins weren't, crest the water to wink at him before vanishing again. Not a moment later, the most beautiful tail he'd ever seen crested the water, like a whale's but spun from gossamer and water, thin as a veil, refracting moonlight like a kaleidoscope.

Mermista.

He dropped his hand from his sword, and bounded to the edge of the water to get a closer look. As an afterthought, he removed his boots, socks, and jacket. It wasn't warm in here, but it wasn't cool either. He noticed a rock overhanging the deeper area of the water, and leapt onto it for vantage. He peered into the clear, but deep water, waiting for a flicker of movement.

Too late, he realized the golden glow getting closer and closer was not a trick of the light, but rather her eyes. Before he could scramble back, there was a splash, and cold, wet arms grasping his torso. He yelped, gulping in air on instinct, and then everything was silent.

Sea Hawk opened his eyes when he felt the arms leave him. They were at least ten feet down, he figured, and -

Holy shit.

Mermaids were myths in this age. It was well believed that they'd once existed, had even been a part of Etheria's society, but were now long gone. They'd been hunted and abused for their abilities, so the legends said they had retreated to the far depths of the oceans, never to be seen or heard from again.

Well, good to know *that* was a load of bull.

Mermista's tail was sea green and deep teal, not unlike her leggings. Each scale seemed tipped with gold, or maybe the undersides were gold. It was hard to tell. Her tail was a third longer than her legs, thick but shapely. The scales didn't stop abruptly at her waist, like the pictures in story books showed, but dripped up her abdomen, dotting her skin as they fell away to-

He swallowed thickly. She was bare chested, and ethereally beautiful for it. Her breasts were bare of scales, but now that he could really look, he noticed small clusters of them on her shoulders, her biceps, and her back as she twirled around him. Her elbows and forearms crested with a small, pale blue and ridged fin, tapered like the prow of a ship built for speed.

She swam closer to him, and yes, he was certain her eyes weren't normally that bright.

He'd thought she was beautiful - no, *gorgeous* - before. Words couldn't adequately describe her beauty to him. But this...seeing her like this was humbling, and breathtaking. Not unlike when she used her powers, but more subtle. Natural. This wasn't magic. It was just *her* . More of her. *Different* her.

She was stunning.

He reached out, forgetting himself and their weird cold war. With a flick of her tail, she was there, in his space, taking up all his senses, building a pressure in his chest-

Wait, no. That was the lack of oxygen.

It slammed into him at once, the lack of air, and he choked. Her eyes widened in alarm as he began kicking for the surface. Before he could get far, she grabbed him. For a brief moment, Sea Hawk was worried she was actually going to drown him. But then her lips were on his and he couldn't be bothered to give a damn if she did.

She pried his mouth open gently, and exhaled into him. Air filled his lungs again, a weird sensation when he hadn't breathed in. He pulled back slightly, and a minute movement on her neck caught his eyes. Slits no wider than the finest of slivers lined either side of her throat. They twitched every so often, displacing water so she could breathe. He watched them for longer than he should have, utterly fascinated.

Her hands, ever so slightly webbed, found his jaw, and pulled his lips to hers again. He wasn't sure how long they floated there, kissing lazily, hands straying and petting and admiring. Sea Hawk had never prayed before, but he was certain that this was what worship would feel like. His hands on her waist, her scales, cupping her breasts with reverence and desire. When he pressed his tongue past her lips, and nearly drew blood on molars and canines that were sharper than before, the gentle thrill in his stomach caught ablaze, howling to become more. He forced it down. He wouldn't ruin this.

Mermista regularly pushed air into his lungs, but eventually his hands started to wrinkle and prune. She noticed quickly, and gently swam away, nodding towards the surface. He understood, but paused to watch her leave. Her abdominal muscles rippled as they undulated, her whole tail rolling to push her through the water. She wasn't so much swimming as she was gliding. Her hair fanned out behind her like a waterfall, and he waited to surface until he couldn't see her in the depths anymore.

He surfaced, drawing in air greedily, swimming for shore. He heaved himself onto the grass, laying still for a moment, before sitting up and yanking off his drenched shirt, headband, bandana, and, after brief debate, his trousers as well. Wasn't anything she hadn't seen before, after all, and he really didn't want a rash.

The sound of the water sloshing snapped his head up, just in time to see her clear the water in a graceful leap, arcing against the moon. She contorted mid air, tail melting away as she did, to land on her feet. The water rushed to meet her, cushioning her landing and depositing her safely on the ground.

Stars, she was a goddess.

A thin sari that seemed to be made from little more than water and starlight was all she wore when she dropped to sit next to him. Silence reigned for the better part of five minutes before she spoke.

“Where have you been?

Sea Hawk shrugged. “Around-ish. Running errands for whatever kingdom is paying the best. Docking at Sea Worthy when I have time. Going on daring adventures in between.” He couldn’t stop the smile in his voice.

Mermista hummed. “Did you really set your last two ships on fire?”

“Ah, well, you know, sometimes these things are inevitable in the name of adventure.”

He could feel her eye roll more than see it. She shifted closer to him, and lay down on the grass. Sea Hawk swallowed. He had no idea where this night was going. Why did she call him back? What did she want? Was she still angry? He laid down beside her.

“I thought you were dead, to be honest.” Her voice was void of any emotion. She was just stating facts. The sky was dark. He was a pirate. Grass was wet. She thought he was dead.

He turned his head to face her. “Why?”

“You didn’t come back.” She wouldn’t look at him. Something like annoyance stabbed at him gently below the ribs. He pushed it down and away. Mermista had just gone through hell and was still trying to find her way out. It wasn’t fair to expect emotional normalcy from her.

‘Doesn’t make it right’ whispered a small voice in his head. He pushed that away, too.

With as much casual affect as he could muster, he spoke. “Forgive me if I’m confused, Princess, but you told me to leave.”

Mermista shifted uncomfortably, and he tensed. He shouldn’t be so forward with her. They couldn’t be those casual and careless summer lovers anymore. She was a queen, a Princess of Power. A goddess, like he’d said.

He was just a pirate. Just a man.

Words were streaming out of his mouth before he could stop them, anxiety twisting his gut. “If I misunderstood, or misheard, I apologize, I just didn’t want to cause you any more stress - not that there’s anything to stress about - or, or that I should be on your mind enough to worry- I just-”

Mermista groaned, annoyed, but instead of getting up, she rolled over and pressed her practically bare body to his. His brain sputtered, stalled, and refused to restart. Which was fine, because now she was straddling him and- oh, okay, the sari is gone, she is very naked.

He’d seen Mermista naked plenty of times now, but this… His hands, rough and worn from a life of hard labor- too rough for her soft, soft skin- settled on the outsides of her thighs. Her hair and skin caught the moonlight, the water droplets on her arms and legs still shimmering. The small scales he’d seen on her body in the water were still there, but they weren’t blue anymore. They hid in plain sight against her skin, winking at him in the night air.

He wanted to trace his hands along them, along her whole body, find the places her other form peeked through, worship her with touch and lips-

But that would have to wait. Her lips were on his now, one hand fisted in his hair, the other moving down along his abs, and in a few seconds, thought left his mind entirely, replaced by everything Mermista. Eagerly he gave himself to her, pleased he could still bring her happiness in this way.

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After, she lay on top of him still, boneless and sated and in a better mood than he’d seen her in months.

She was tracing nonsense patterns on his pec, over his heart, inches from where her cheek rested against him. He had one hand behind him, the other around her waist, holding her to him. He could feel conversation creeping back up on them, against his will. He did better with her when there was silence. Every time he opened his mouth, lately, she got annoyed.

He really missed last summer. When he could make her laugh with his goofy jokes, his over the top displays. Mostly. She was obviously still mad about the gondola, which was fair, but it was one incident in a year of affection.

One of a few incidents, granted. Either way. Mostly fun.

Hadn’t she been having fun?

His hand found her ears subconsciously, and he traced the gold cuffs there with quiet reverence.

Sea Hawk frowned. Maybe he’d been reading her wrong this whole time. She didn’t really seem the type to entertain nonsense for no good reason- okay, yeah, the sex was amazing, but still. Had he been deluding himself this whole time? His heart was beating hard now, sweat collecting along his brow. He could feel his thoughts slipping past him like a rushing river, impressing feelings on him without letting him stop to analyze any of it.

His Ma called these moments of his ‘whirlpools’. He had always found the name apt.

The need to run, to escape, to get away from his thoughts, from this stillness was becoming overwhelming. He opened his mouth to ask Mermista to move, but she beat him to it.

“Dude, are you good?” her deadpan snapped him back to reality. “Your heart is beating like crazy.”

Sea Hawk cleared his throat. “Uh, yeah- yes. It just happens sometimes.”

“Uhhhh, okay,” Mermista was obviously skeptical, but pushed on. “Anyway, I wanted to ask you for a favor.”

“Anything, Princess.”

“In a month and a half-ish, there’s this All Princess Ball coming up. We call it Princess Prom. It’s a stupid political shindig; completely neutral ground, banquet, dance, the whole nine yards. Anyway, it’s in Snows this year, and I could always, like, swim there, I guess, but I’d really appreciate a ride.”

Month and a half...yeah. He could make that work. “I’ll be there.”

“Cool, thanks,” she lifted her head to rest her chin on his chest, meeting his eyes. “Send me your measurements when you can.”

Sea Hawk tilted his head. “Measurements of what? My ship? Does Snows need to know?”

“No, you goof,” she rolled her eyes, but this time with a hint of her old fondness. “For a suit. Or rather, a kurta. I guess you could do a suit, if you wanted, I just figured I’d be wearing Salinean garb, but that doesn’t mean you have to-”

“I would be honored-” he blurted, too loud, before he could stop himself. She looked at him, and blushed. He cleared his throat. “I mean, whatever you’d like me to wear will be perfect.”

She tried to hide it behind a particularly annoyed eye roll, but that had pleased her. She bit her lip, and there was the pinching thing she did when she didn’t want to smile, but had to. Her eyes were bright again, and the blush settled deeper. He had made her happy.

Sea Hawk had forgotten what a rush it was.

Except…

“Wait, if I’m just your ride, why do I need a suit?”

Aaand, there goes the happiness. She rolled her eyes, again, and flopped her head back onto his chest. “Well, I just figured that if you’re already going to be there, and all Princesses get a plus one, then, like, you might as well come.”

Sea Hawk felt a smile creeping over him, unbidden. “Sooooo-”

“No.”

“What you’re really asking-”

“Shut your mouth, pirate.”

“Is for me to be your date-”

“No, fuck it, I’ll swim, it’s not that far-”

“It’s half the planet, dearest. And besides, I accept your invitation.”

“Don’t call me that, and I’m uninviting you.”

“Too late, I’ve already cleared my schedule.”

“You literally haven’t moved.” He couldn’t see her face, but he could hear and feel her smile.

“In my head, of course. Which means it’s official. It would be too much work to rearrange it again.”

“Yeah I can see how using too much brain power in one go would be dangerous for you.”

Sea Hawk feigned offense. “My lady wounds me!” Before she could defend herself, he flipped them over so he was above her. With one arm he held himself up, while the other moved for her hips.

Her eyes flashed. “Sebastian, don’t you dare- AH!”

Too late. He was tickling her with reckless abandon, considering the pool of water just behind them. And the entire fucking ocean a few yards away. Drowning was worth it, though, to hear her laugh.

She writhed beneath him and grabbed for his hand between snorts and shouts of helpless laughter. He was too quick, moving from hip to stomach to side to neck and back, and she was too incapacitated to keep up. Eventually, her senses came back to her, and she flung an arm out. A second later icy water crashed over them, and he had no choice but to let up.

He shook the water from his hair like a dog, breathless from his own laughter. He looked down at Mermista, who was still smiling as she wound both arms around his neck. And for one brief second, he wasn't a captain with his own schedule and ship to maintain, and she wasn't a queen at war. They were just two people, happy together, with nowhere else they'd rather be.

All too soon, it ended. He could see in her eyes as all of it caught up to her. Their state of mutual nudity, the incredibly compromising position, the weight of the world crashing back down on her shoulders. Like shutters falling, her eyes dimmed, and she cleared her throat.

"It's getting late." Her arms dropped from his neck. "We should, like, probably get back to all that." She flapped a half-hearted hand toward the outside world.

Sea Hawk sighed, and before he could psych himself out, he leaned in and kissed her cheek, softly and with no intent other than comfort. He rose to his feet, and offered her a hand. She took it, and they redressed quietly. She picked up her trident from where it rested against the stone wall, and he was careful to walk on the left side of it.

He trusted her, explicitly. But that thing made his head ache with phantom pain.

She walked him to his ship, and in the silence, Sea Hawk couldn’t stop the memories from the day from flashing in front of his eyes.

‘Ew, who let him back in here?’

‘Ugh, you’re always ruining it.’

‘He. Is so. Annoyingggg.’

Sea Hawk shook himself physically, as if that would make the memories pause. But there wasn’t an off switch to the whirlpool he felt creeping up on him. He knew when she was joking. She hadn’t been joking.

But then why did she ask him to the ball? *She needed a ride* . She’s a magical mermaid. She could swim that in a day. *Power trip.* No. *Yes.* No. She had shared something with him tonight. She trusted him. *She needed the stress relief, and who’s going to turn down a topless mermaid-* STOP!

He ground to a halt, bile and panic rising in him. Everything was feeling too close, even here on the open shore. He needed the ocean, and he needed it now.

Mermista had paused and turned to him when she realized he had stopped. “Uh, you good?”

He could barely hear her for the ringing in his ears. He looked up at her and forced a smile that felt brittle, hollow. “Never better. Anyway, you really don’t have to walk me all the way. The castle’s right here, and I’m sure you have better things to do-”

“Sea Hawk, what-?” She reached out for him, but he side stepped her with fluid ease and a quick laugh.

“Really, princess, it’s fine,” he grabbed her hand, maybe a bit too roughly, and jerked her knuckles to his lips. “I’ll see you for the ball.”

“Sebastian!”

But he had already turned, and was legging it up the beach at a pace he knew she wouldn’t match. It still wasn’t fast enough. He broke into a sprint, the salty wind that lashed at him helping to shake him a bit. Not enough. None of it was enough.

Only when he had set sail without a glance back, and was speeding into open water did he relax. He tapped the autopilot on, made sure the wheel locked, and collapsed with his back against the railings.

The silence was deafening, and not loud enough all at once. It did nothing to quiet his racing mind, or the echoes of the voices of his old shipmates. More than ever, Sea Hawk heard them in between crashing waves- laughter, shouting, reels of shanties, footsteps banging on the deck.

He grit his teeth. With his hands clamped over his ears, he fought back the urge to jump overboard, and then the subsequent urge to light one of the matches sitting in his breast pocket. It would be so easy. The *shhick* as it caught flame, the barely-there sound of it hitting the wood of the deck. It was always quiet after. At least for a little while.

But he had made a promise.

And Sea Hawk never, ever went back on a promise. Even if it killed him.

Chapter End Notes

Up next: princess prom!

Love Me Like it’s Prom Night

Chapter Summary

> Time to dance, laugh, and lose your friends to a acts of violence. Prom!

Chapter Notes

> PROM TIME YALL!! I switched mermista and sea hawk’s fits back to the beta sketches bc they were gorgeous and leaned more into Mermista’s Indian style. I also, after extensive research, gave mermista a blue bindi. Typically, bindis are red and worn to signify marriage, but a blue color can denote wisdom and leadership in faith or spirituality. If this research is wrong or incorrect or offensive in anyway, please let me know! I love learning, and I’m always open to it.
>
> So: startling revelations, more interior design porn bc I love writing about spaces, and draaaammaaaaa.
>
> Eskettit

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When Sea Hawk sailed back into port the morning of princess prom, he was back to normal. Or, as normal as he could get, which was more of a simmering and steady ‘odd’. Mermista still couldn’t shake the image of him sprinting away from her down the beach with the cagiest expression she’d ever seen on anyone’s face. Her first thought had been ‘um, rude’, followed quickly by ‘what the fuck is his deal?’.

She had racked her brain all night, not that she had lost sleep over it, over him, or anything. What was she, a lovesick teen? She was a 23 year old queen who was too stressed to let him take up any room in her mind. Now if only her actual mind would get the memo.

The sex had been great. He'd reacted better than her past flings to her, y'know, tail. And gills. And sharp teeth. The whole Thing, as it were. Better than better. No one had ever looked at her scales like that, like they were something impressive and beautiful. Like, obviously, yeah, they were, duh. But it was...nice...for someone else to be on the same page as her.

He'd accepted her invite to Princess Prom. Happily, too. He was practically vibrating out of his skin when she'd asked him.

So what was his deal?

Maybe he's still upset that you, like, threw him out of your kingdom without batting an eye. No way. Sea Hawk didn't beat himself up over shit like that. Surely he knew she'd just been...well, stressed didn't even come close to it. Ever since her dad ran off, Mermista felt certain she was going to go through heart failure any day now. *How would he know that when you never told him any of it.* How could she have told him when he wasn't there? *He came as soon as he heard.* It wasn't enough. *What is enough-*

Violently, she shook her head. She refused to listen to whatever the fuck that little voice was that just. Kept. Coming. Back.

It was sooooo annoying.

She distracted herself with the finishing touches on her updo. It was relaxed, as far as hairstyles went, but still fancy enough for the ball. There was going to be dancing and shmoozing and Mermista tended to tug on her hair when she was uncomfortable and she was definitely going to be uncomfortable at some point this stupid evening, so-

Snap *out of it,* Mermista!

Hair, done. Move on. She stood up ,and started packing her jewelry into a traveling case. It would take most of the day to sail to Snows, Sea Hawk had said in his missive, so she was packing her dress and jewelry and would do her makeup on the ship. He'd promised he had a bathroom in his captain's quarters with 'a mirror and everything' so hopefully she wouldn't look like a clown.

Jewelry, check. Makeup, check. Dress in the garment bag. His outfit, in another garment bag. Shoes for both of them. Books for the journey. Check times four. The updates on the naval bases and eastern militias that she absolutely had to read today...check, unfortunately.

She was set.

She motioned for the butlers to grab everything and then she headed for the ship waiting for her. She absolutely *did not* thrill even a little bit when she thought about the man on it.

When she arrived at the docks, he was nowhere to be found, though the gangplank had been lowered for her. Her staff went first, setting down her small chest of necessities and the garment bags, before bowing to her and taking their leave. She inclined her head in gratitude, startling a few of them. She knew the former king saw them as little more than invisible servants, let alone people. But she wasn't her dad, so.

The butlers departed, murmuring to themselves, and she climbed the gangplank. The ship she had given him was nice. Really nice. She had been gifted the fleet, sure, but she had never had time to use it. Mermista was glad they would get some use at the hands of a capable sailor.

Even if that capable sailor was nowhere to be found.

"Mermista!"

The fuck? She could hear him but she couldn't see him.

"Up here!"

Ah. Craning her neck and shading her eyes, she found him in the crow’s nest. “What are you doing?”

“Hang on! I can’t hear you very well.”

Sea Hawk jumped the lip of the nest effortlessly. He leapt from the nest onto the shroud, which he slid down at a dangerous, uncontrolled speed. As soon as his feet hit the wood of a crossbeam, he bunched his legs and jumped again, snagging a rigging rope on the way. He swung in a lazy arc, spiralling lower, until he landed with a thud not a foot from her.

“Hey!” His eyes were bright, and his hair was windswept. His jacket and shirt were gone, his torso and arms glistened- *fucking glistened!* - with sweat. This was really, reaaallyyy unfair.

“Uh, hi.” He was smiling at her like she’d put the moon in the sky, and she could really only cope with that for so long. As in, a few seconds at best. “Sooo, where can I put all this?”

“Right! This way, follow me.” Quicker than she could react, he had grabbed the chest and both bags and set off toward the back of the ship.

She kept pace with him as best she could, but his legs were long. Adjusting to the gentle roll of the waves under the ships was nothing, though. It reminded her of the swims she would take out past the breakers, where the tide didn’t pull, and everything followed its own rhythm.

He led her down a set of steep stairs, and down a narrow hallway. There were a few other doors, but Sea Hawk brushed past them for the large opalescent door near the back of the ship. He pushed through, and Mermista found herself in a large, circular room. The floor was polished marble, but a rug had been thrown over the majority of it. The back was entirely window, floor to ceiling. In front of it sat a large, sturdy desk. Shelves were built into the sides, curving with the room, and they were stuffed with maps, thick books, spyglasses, compasses, sextants, and all other sorts of nautical toolery. Off to her right was a small door, and hanging to her left was a thick canvas hammock. An overstuffed pillow and a thick blanket rested in it.

It was all so...homey.

Sea Hawk deposited the chest and bags on the desk. Mermista made her way over to the bookshelves, touching the items there gently with a polished fingernail.

“What is all this?”

“Hm? Oh!” He came up beside her, pointing to each item. “These are all antiques, from my grandfather’s time as a captain.”

"Your grandfather sailed?" He had never spoken about his family, and Mermista would be lying if she said she wasn't dying of curiosity.

"Aye." He smiled, but not like his usual smiles. Softer. Sadder. "He was the harbor master for Snows' royal port, and before that he was captain of their flagship fleet. He taught my mother to sail, and she taught me."

"Oh." Mermista nodded. "Does she still sail for Snows?"

Sea Hawk shook his head. "No, she died when I was small."

"Shit, Sea Hawk, I'm sorry-"

"No, no, don't be!" His eyes were kind and understanding. "You didn't know, and it was a long time ago. Besides," he continued, spreading his arms, "I'm my own captain now. I like to think she'd be proud of that."

Wait...captain? How the fuck had she missed that. "Captain? I thought you were still a first mate?"

He shook his head. "No, I uh, was promoted against my will. Here, get settled, I'll cast us off, and then I'll fill you in." He squeezed her shoulder as he brushed past, and that weird feeling settled in her chest again.

How much had she missed in just...well, alright, it had been almost a year since they had to break things off because of the betrothal. But then he’d come back and-

And they hadn’t really talked. She hadn’t asked. She remembered now, Glimmer calling him Captain Sea Hawk, and she’d taken no notice. In the heat of the moment, the fighting, and then everything after. Wow, this really didn’t feel good. It actually felt pretty shitty.

She shook herself out of her mild funk, and sat herself at the desk. She had paperwork to get through. There wasn’t any time for sentiment, or regret, or guilt. They were at war, and she had a kingdom to lead through it. He would understand. He had to.

An hour or so later, he came bounding back in, full of that same energy that had seized him on deck. The sea air did something to him that she didn’t entirely hate. It was different from his restless energy when he was on shore; when they went out to bars or clubs or whatever, or even when she had snuck him in, he was always so...fidgety. He couldn’t sit still, or he would explode. So he burst into song, and lit things on fire, and never. Stopped. Talking. But here, on this ship, he was focused and intense.

It did things for her.

He came over and sat on the desk, facing her where she reclined in his chair. She held up a finger, wanting to finish this paragraph, and he waited patiently. He couldn’t do that on land either.

“Alright,” she said as she tossed the papers onto the desk. “So, captain? When did this happen?”

Sea Hawk stared over her head, out the window. “Right after we cut things off, pretty much. Two months after, maybe. We’d just set off from shore leave in Bright Moon, and we were headed for the ports by Dryl to make a drop off. Some sort of old tech. We were raided by a Horde battalion, which isn’t out of the ordinary these days. When they started talking about taking us prisoner, and drafting us into the Horde, though.” He grimaced. “Our options were limited. I did what I do best, and set the Tidal Titan ablaze. The crew made it out, but Bill decided he’d had enough of my...particular brand of adventure. Can’t blame him really. He retired, I was promoted, and I gave the crew the option of staying in my service or finding work elsewhere.”

Mermista filled in the rest of the story; he’d arrived in Salineas alone, on a smaller ship than a trade vessel. She frowned. “What, they were tired of your pyromania, too?”

He waffled a hand. “Half and half. Truth be told, it’s just getting too risky out there. As pirates, we have a code. It’s sacred, and breaking it is as bad as breaking the law. We have relationships with the kingdoms, we’re more like rogues than law-breakers.”

Mermista nodded. She knew all of this, but he seemed to need to talk.

“But with the Horde trying to monopolize the seas, the code is being thrown to the wind. Fleets are turning on one another. Anyone will sell you out for a quick buck, or to stay in the Horde’s good graces. My crew was full of good people, with families and loved ones on shore. I couldn’t ask them to stay.”

Mermista nodded again. “So, you’re a captain without a crew?”

He laughed, running his thumb over her knuckles. “For now. It works out, though. I’m of more value to the rebellion as transport or intel than a pirate captain. Having a crew would make last minute assists difficult if not impossible.”

“Wait, the rebellion?” Mermista frowned. Was he insane? “You’re joining up, like, for real? Sea Hawk, you’re kind of heavily wanted by a looooot of people who, apparently, are getting cozy with the Horde. Being on the frontlines of a rebellion is going to paint a huge target on your back.”

Sea Hawk shrugged. “I’ve made my peace with it. The Horde has taken so much from innocent bystanders. I can’t live with being a neutral party anymore. I fell into piracy for the adventure of it all, not to sit idly by while evil runs rampant.”

Mermista narrowed her eyes. “And that’s...the only reason?”

“There are a few reasons. You’ll be fighting with the Rebellion, won’t you?”

“Duh, did you miss the whole Sea Gate thing?”

“Well, if that’s where you’ll be, then that’s where I’ll be.” Sea Hawk shrugged, like it was the simplest thing in the world. Like Mermista wasn’t terrified down to her bone marrow with those words. She stood abruptly.

“Come on. I want to make sure everything fits you.”

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The next few hours flew by in a rush of trying on clothes, steering the ship, and the general exhilaration of getting ready. The somber mood of earlier slipped away, replaced by their usual dance; Sea Hawk’s over the top excitement for the ball, her general distaste for the hassle it was going to be.

She currently found herself straddling a half-dressed Sea Hawk in his sturdy desk chair, laughing reluctantly as he tried to bat her hands away. His hands were gripping her upper thighs so she didn’t slide off him, though he probably wouldn’t mind if she did right then.

“Sea Hawk! Just sit still and it won’t hurt!”

“That’s what she- OW!”

“Ha!” Mermista stuck her tongue out at him. Her eyebrow tweezers she held aloft, victoriously. “See? Was that so bad?”

“Yes!” Sea Hawk’s eyes were watering, and she had to slap his hand away from rubbing them. “Why are you doing this to me, what did I ever do to you?”

“I’m still mad about the gondola-”

“Ugghhh!” he groaned, but he was smiling, and he sounded so like her that she couldn’t help but smile back. “Please, dearest, can’t you let it go in the name of adventure?”

“Definitely not.” When he pouted, his mustache drooped in the silliest way, and she couldn’t help but snort. Still, she wouldn’t be diverted from plucking her date’s unruly eyebrows. “Now, c’mon I’m almost done.”

The way he puffed up his chest promised a long-winded and theatrical announcement of her cruelty and betrayal, but the boat lurched hard before he could start. With a yelp, her knees slid off the chair and she pitched forward. Sea Hawk shifted his grip off her thighs to wrap a strong forearm around her waist, the other hand flying behind her knee to steady her.

Pressed core to core in their under garments, Mermista suddenly cared a lot less about his fucked up eyebrow shape. She wiggled in his lap experimentally and- yep, he definitely didn’t care either. From the feel of it, he hadn’t been caring for a while now. When the boat settled, he stood and lifted her, sending butterflies through her abdomen, before dropping her ass on his desk. Softly, though; everything was always so gentle with him, even when they were rough he was so careful with her.

It made her insides twist uncomfortably, and she wondered if a part of her hated it.

She didn’t have the time to analyze that, though, because his mouth was on her collarbone, and he was pushing her down, back flush to the desk. He trailed hot, wet kisses down her, stopping to lavish each breast like he always did, sucking on each nipple until it was a pebbled and stiff under his tongue. A whine spilled from her throat, and she fisted a hand in his hair hoping he’d get the memo. He did, moving on down her stomach, flicking her navel piercing as he went, making her jolt. And then he was kneeling, dragging her panties down with him, and coherent thought fell beyond her capabilities.

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Their little detour set them back a good forty-five minutes, but Mermista would be hard pressed to admit she hadn’t already factored...extracurriculars into the schedule. They were cleaned, dressed, made up, and presentable with time to spare. Hell, more than presentable. They looked fucking hot.

From the second she'd stepped out of his quarters, jewelry on, makeup perfect, and hair re-done, he hadn't taken his eyes off her. Sure, yeah, he was kind of always staring at her like that. But like, in a quiet way. This was...a lot. He was a lot. She looked damn good, she knew, but not good enough to almost walk into the mast. Part of her wanted to shake him and yell at him to be genuine, but a bigger part of her foolishly wondered if...maybe he already was.

And the way he'd kissed her, after he'd kind of-sort of shook the stupor off, was the kind of kiss she thought only existed in her books. Filled with muted passion, and ardor, and lo-

No. Not going there. Absolutely not. No, no, fucking no.

He didn't clean up bad, either. In fact, he cleaned up rather nice. The kurta she'd had made for him fell to his knees, the slits beginning just above his hip bones. The shoulder pads were a deep blue, matching the sari around her shoulders and the bindi on her forehead. They were bordered in rich gold, as was the plunging neckline that dipped almost to his navel. His toned chest, framed by the beautiful handmade embroidery made Mermista's mouth dry. Honestly, seeing him in her kingdom's colors was giving her butterflies.

He had ducked into the bathroom, slicked his hair back with some product, trimmed up his moustache, and ditched his bandana and headband. She had done a really, really embarrassing double take when he walked about. 'Cause, like, seriously- he couldn't have looked further from a singed, windswept pirate than he did right then. He looked, well, kinda noble.

She stepped up to him with the finishing touches in hand. The air was charged with intimate tension as she fastened an embossed, detailed gold collar around his neck. The click of the latch was the only sound in the cabin as she held his gaze. Sea Hawk's eyes were wide, and dark with desire, and she knew hers reflected the same. She handed him the corsage she'd had made to match her dress, and stepped out of his space.

They couldn't afford another...delay. She repeated this to herself like a mantra, even as she locked eyes with him while she was putting in her tongue piercing. Liquid lightning shot through to her core at the look in his eyes, and she was privately glad she was sitting down with how her knees trembled.

Mermista was also glad they were staying overnight, even if this castle was balls to the wall cold. Whatever. Better excuse for sharing body heat. Not that they were going to need an excuse, at this rate.

Sea Hawk docked the ship carefully, floating out of the water and tethered to the frozen piers. He helped her over the railing, and didn't let go of her hand when she had two feet on the ground. She briefly debated pulling her hand out of his grip, but then a chill caught her, and she wound her arm through his, clutching at his warm bicep.

“How the hell are you warm right now?” She grumbled, flashing her invitation to the guard at the entrance. They queued up to drop off their weapons.

Sea Hawk chuckled. “Grew up here, remember? This weather is late spring for Snows.”

Mermista tucked herself treacherously closer, rolling her eyes. “Stars, no wonder you left.”

He hummed noncommittally, but they arrived to the front of the line before she could dig into that. He was so cagey about his past, and nothing else. It screamed mystery, and Mermista wasn’t patient when it came to mysteries.

She handed over her trident, and he his blade, the laser function turned off, and they were swept away into the party. Mermista had no more time to worry about Sea Hawk’s past, because the present just became a lot more stressful. Every social anxiety she hadn’t had to deal with in years came flooding back.

Mermista dug her nails into Sea Hawk’s sleeve as she dragged him toward the dais where Princess Frosta sat. “Do not, and Sebastian, *I mean this* , say or do anything other than bow. You’re my guest, you don’t have to speak. Frosta is a kid, but she’s tough as nails, and tolerates even less bullshit than I do.”

Sea Hawk nodded, his eyes wide with trepidation. He knew she meant business using his real name like that. They ascended the steps, and executed the bow she had taught him on the way over. She rose, and spoke for them both. “Revered Hostess, we come into your halls under the ancient rules of hospitality, bringing greetings from the Kingdom of Salineas.” She bowed again, per custom. “I bring with me Captain Sea Hawk, of Snows.”

Frosta inclined her head. “You are welcome in the Kingdom of Snows under the ancient rules of hospitality. Leave conflict at the door, and please enjoy the ball.”

They bowed again in sync, and turned to leave. Mermista let out a breath she didn’t know she’d been holding as soon as they were out of earshot of the loose crowd that had gathered at the foot of the dais. She turned to Sea Hawk, only to see him smiling at her in that gross, sappy, sparkly-eyed way. “What?” she snapped.

He smiled helplessly. “I like watching you do royal stuff. It’s so...powerful.”

She refused to blush. Absolutely not. “If by powerful you mean stuffy, boring, and outdated then sure.”

He chuckled, unruffled, and offered her his arm again. She scowled and took it.

"- she's like TEN?" echoed across the room, followed by gasps. Even Mermista's jaw dropped. Who in the hell would-

They spun around, and- yep. Adora and Glimmer stood before the throne. From behind, she could see Adora's ears turning pink. "Nice one, Adora."

Even Sea Hawk was wincing, knowing better than to insult royalty so directly, child or not. That's when you knew it was rough. He leaned in. "Will you survive frostbite if I run and grab us drinks?"

"Ugh, I guess," she groaned. "Get me one of those warm earl grey things they have, would you? My scales are gonna start freezing off."

"Perish the thought." He chuckled. She scowled. Was he seriously laughing at her expense? Jerk. Even if his laugh was deep and made the corners of his eyes crinkle-

Alcohol. Lots of alcohol. And soon.

He strode away, and she made her way over to where Adora, Glimmer, and the Princess of Dryl were huddled by a pillar. Glimmer looked distressed, or maybe angry, Adora was distracted, and Entrapta was...wearing grease stained work overalls like the dock workers did.

Huh. Good for her.

She walked over, announcing herself, and was all but ignored. Rude. Yeah, Glimmer was having a full tilt Freak Out because Bow went with...Perfuma. Mermista’s heart leapt at the sight of her oldest and dearest friend. Who was, most definitely, a lesbian. But she was bored, and this was kind of entertaining, and Glimmer was kind of being a lunatic about this, so she kept her lips sealed.

And Entrapta was talking softly into a recorder, narrating the goings on for...science?

Why were all of the other Princesses like this?

Sea Hawk sliced through her train of thought with his (admittedly impressive) falsetto, and she refrained from reaching out to with her magic to smack him with the drinks in his hand. She had paid the tailor well for that kurta, and tonight that was his only saving grace.

“Sooooo...”

Adora, however, she had far fewer reservations about.

“Sea Hawk’s your plus one?”

Mermista snatched her drink from him and shoved him away. “Nooooo, he is just my ride. Just. My. Ride.”

Sea Hawk took her snarling in stride, chuckling and wrapping his arm right back around her to squeeze her shoulder. “Of course,” he soothed, and then leaned in to Adora. “I am her plus one,.” hHe whispered loudly.

Done with this, she decided to take herself over to the buffet. She vaguely heard Sea Hawk (and possibly Entrapta?) following her, but she refused to acknowledge that until she had downed half her drink and had a plate piled with kelp, sushi, and weird Snowvian hors d'oeuvres. She was about to put one in her mouth when a warm hand stopped her wrist.

“Trust me, dearest, you won’t enjoy that.”

“One, stop calling me that. Two, bet.”

She downed the phyllo cup and its contents, some weird blackened meat with garnish on top. And she immediately grimaced. Frantically, she grabbed a napkin, and spat the half-chewed mush into it. She cast a glance around, and was relieved no one was looking. That was a major, huge, offensive faux pas she had just committed.

Sea Hawk’s eyes were glittering with mirth. “Sooooo-”

“Shut the fuck up.”

He coughed into his hand to cover the bark of laughter, and nabbed the other one off her plate, downing it one go. He even *hummed* , the bastard.

“What even was that.”

He swallowed, and took a sip of his drink- something amber with blue pearls in it- before he spoke. “That was frozen, smoked Snow-Worm garnished with holly berry tree bark. And a balsamic reduction.”

“What in the hell is this place?”

Sea Hawk shrugged. “It’s good when you’ve grown up with it. I don’t like kelp, but you grew up eating it.”

“Kelp is delicious- wait what? You ate like a whole plate of it at the masquerade.”

He ducked his head and smiled sheepishly. “I, uh, didn’t want to push away my lovely partner for the evening. I was scared you’d find someone else to dance with, so I finished as fast as I could. The sushi was divine, though.”

Her heart was doing funny flips again. That happened a lot with him, especially lately. She opened her mouth, not really sure what she was going to say, when-

"Mista!"

Something- no, some *one* - collided with her torso, and she nearly dropped her plate. Arms wrapped around her, and the scent of apples, lavender, and patchouli overtook her.

"'Fuma!" Quickly, she handed her plate to Sea Hawk so she could hug Perfuma back properly. They squeezed each other tightly, and Mermista was shocked to find her eyes prickling, and a genuine, wide grin coming over her. It had just been so long…

Perfuma pulled back but didn't let go. Her eyes were big with worry as she reached up to tuck some of Mermista's hair behind her ear. Suddenly, she felt ten again, her knee bleeding because she'd fallen and scraped it playing in the woods with twelve year old Perfuma. "I was so, so sorry to hear about the Sea Gate, and your father. I can't imagine what you've been going though, Mista."

Why was there a lump in her throat? She was so over that whole thing. Right? She shrugged, but it was jerky. "It's been, you know, whatever. A lot, I guess. Adora helped. So now it's just running the kingdom."

Perfuma’s eyes traveled to her forehead. “You’re not wearing the crown?” Ah, shit. Someone had finally noticed. “Weren’t you coronated?”

“Yeah, but like...” She flushed. “I don’t need it. I’m in my armor every day. I have the trident. A crown is just another fragile thing to break, another thing to worry about. The bindi my mom gave me is, like, way more than enough.”

Perfuma nodded. She understood, because she always understood. “Why didn’t you throw a coronation party, hon? You know the alliance would have been there to support you.”

Mermista looked away. “There was nothing to celebrate.” She extracted herself from Perfuma’s hug, belatedly remembering Sea Hawk. “Oh, ‘Fuma, this is my ride-”

“Plus one-”

“Whatever. Captain Sea Hawk.”

Perfuma smiled graciously, warming them in its sunny glow. “Sea Hawk, it’s lovely to meet you. How do you know Mermista?”

They both froze. How does one put delicately ‘we met at a ball and hooked up and then never stopped hooking up but also became best friends along the way but we had to break up because my dad is a dick but then he fled and I inherited a kingdom so we still couldn’t get back together and also there’s now a lot of weird unspoken baggage between us?’.

“It’s complicated.” They said together, Mermista with a grimace, Sea Hawk with a wink and a smile.

Perfuma giggled. “That’s fine. Complicated is just another word for rich and interesting.”

“I like this girl!” Sea Hawk beamed. Mermista rolled her eyes.

“Yeah, I knew you would.”

The two of them carried on chattering for a good while, even when Bow, Entrapta, Spinnerella and Netossa wandered over. Sea Hawk was really good with crowds. He stayed close to her, but he didn’t smother her. He kept people talking and laughing with his stories, but never hogged the audience. He was...charming. At one point Perfuma caught her eyes, and gave her an excited thumbs up while glancing at Sea Hawk.

She took a deep breath. It was...nice. Knowing that Perfuma approved of his presence in her life. But, they were just friends, or whatever. Hell, somedays, they were barely even that.

They had been so close. So, so close. For the first time, Mermista had seen a future that didn't bore her. A life filled with laughter, and excitement. With him. Not a marriage of convenience, or political gain, but with someone who liked her. Maybe even loved her, as a friend and as more. And then it had all come tumbling down. And now she didn't have the time to go back and pick up the pieces. Everything was just moving so quickly, the war, her duties, everything-

A hand on her arm. Warm brown eyes staring into hers. She shook the cotton from her head. "Sorry...what?"

Sea Hawk smiled, but it was tinged with worry. "They're about to start the waltz. Would you like to dance, Princess?"

She looked down at his offered hand, and took it silently. She nodded. "Yeah, that would be nice."

They took their places on the dancefloor, facing one another as the colored spotlights came on. Blue light splashed over them, bathing Sea Hawk in a teal that brought out his freckles. He placed one arm behind his back, and held the other out to her. She mirrored him, suddenly nervous. It had been so long since they danced, save for their sneaky trips to Salinean night clubs in disguise. But that was different. This was a ball, a performance.

She took a deep breath.

The music kicked up, and they began. In and out they swayed, before clasping hands and pivoting in a turn. She kept her eyes locked on his, unwavering. His gaze was magnetic, pulling her in, and she couldn't have broken free from it if she wanted to.

Squeeze. Release. His hand on her waist now, ridiculously warm for being in a palace made of ice. Her eyes trailed to his cheeks, freckled from a life in the sun, the white scar that burst like a star by his temple and trailed down his jaw, faded but never gone. His stupid, *stupid* , unfairly cute mustache. Seriously, it should not have worked. It should *not* have made his lips look that enticing, or full. But it did. He was a walking contradiction. His shoulders were broad, clean cut by the ropes of muscles that strengthened his arms as well. His chiseled jaw, slender neck.

Dimly, she was aware her cheeks were radiating warmth as they circled each other lazily. She told herself it was from the spotlight's heat. She told herself he wasn't also checking her out, taking advantage of the rare moment where they were this close to one another and not tearing clothes off. They were just there. Just being.

Why was everything feeling so close all of a sudden?

He winked at her, and her mouth dried. She nearly tripped as they spun away, and she landed in the arms of another dancer. Someone lithe and toned. Princess Netossa.

“Hey girl!” The older woman winked. “You buzzed already? You’re glowing like a firebeetle.”

Mermista swallowed. “I, uh..no. What? No.” She shook herself as they swayed, hand in hand. “Just...flustered, or whatever. Been a while since I’ve been around this many people.”

Netossa nodded. “I feel you, hon. Been so long since we went to a real ball. In fact, I think the last one we went to was your old man’s masquerade. Sorry to hear about that, by the way. Even if he was a dick.”

That startled a laugh from her. “Yeah, you have no idea. Wait- you were at the masquerade?”

Netossa laughed, swinging her around. “I don’t blame you for not remembering. You seemed prettyyyy caught up with Mr. Tall Dark and Handsome. Phew, the way you two danced that night...” She fanned herself jokingly.

“What- what do you mean?” Mermista wanted her to stop talking. To keep talking. To never shut up, but to go away all at once. She didn’t know why, but she knew in her very bones that Netossa had the answers she refused to admit she’d been looking for.

Netossa leveled her with a Look, one eyebrow up. “C’mon girl, don’t play dumb. Can’t hide a love like that, at least not from me and Spinny." She smiled gently at her. "Besides, you guys are, like, stupid cute," she added with a wink.

Mermista was certain the floor was falling out from under her. *Love??* Love! Was she insane? This was... *this was Sea Hawk!* Not love. Just plain, old Sea Hawk. Reliable, aggravating, obnoxious. He was loud, fanciful, over the top, impulsive.

Loyal. Brave. Intelligent. Kind. Gentle.

Loving. No. *Yes.* Shut up.

Netossa spun her away, back to Sea Hawk. She stumbled, barely, but his grip on her was wrought iron, and he didn't let her fall. Mermista was hyperventilating, she was sure. And she wasn't entirely sure she could see straight. This wasn't happening. She didn't love him. Of course she didn't! She couldn't! They were at fucking war, he was never around half the time-

"Mermista?" His hand, large and calloused, was on the side of her neck, his thumb stroking the underside of her jaw. His looked concerned, that stupid charming mustache down turned with his frown. She tried to get a hold of her rapid, shallow breathing. Sea Hawk pulled her to his chest, swaying for a moment along with the music. "Do we need to get off the floor?"

No. That would be rude. She couldn't be rude, not in front of other royal families. Her father would never allow it. Mermista shook her head. He nodded, understanding. Always so fucking understanding.

Damn this man.

“I’ve got to lift you now, then, alright? Hold on.”

And then she was weightless. Sea Hawk hoisted her into the air, supporting her on her bicep, and she was brought crashing back to reality by the swooping tingle at her core. He was a skinny bastard, but a life doing hard labor on the ocean had made him jacked. His muscles flexed under her ass, his hand was squeezing her outer thigh for support, and his other hand was in hers.

She didn’t mean to smile at him, but really, when a stupidly sexy pirate who cleaned up like a dream was lifting you to the heavens and staring at you like you put the moons in the sky...well. What else could you do?

He spun her gently, and set her back on her heels carefully. Almost robotically, she leaned her back to his front, head tucked into his left shoulder as they held each other’s gaze. She was drowning in his eyes, and in the gentle smile that made them crinkle in the corners, and happily so.

Happy? Was that what this was? That swooping, the weird flutters and random bursts of unfiltered sunshine in her chest when she saw his ship on the horizon.

She felt like she was looking at him through a new lense, but with the same eyes. Sea Hawk. Sebastian. Her best friend. Her...love. Because, yeah, after everything, how could it be anything but love?

He grinned and winked again at her, his cheeks flushed with the adrenaline of the intimate dance, and she wasn't as annoyed as usual at his silliness. He removed her hand, and in one smooth motion, dipped her low. His warm forearm on her bared expanse of back was burning her skin, and that was definitely why her cheeks were baking like they were. Not because she, like, loved him or whatever.

She loved him.

Her smile was growing against her will as he righted her, and for once, she didn't care. None of it mattered in that moment. The war, the horde, the alliance, their class difference. Not one bit of it mattered because he was Sea Hawk. And she was Mermista. And he was going to follow where she went. He spun her out, and she *giggled* . This should be humiliating, a part of her screamed. You should be running, getting the hell out of here, *saving yourself!*

But she wasn't. She was here, with him. And she really didn't want to be anywhere else in this moment.

The music stopped, and Mermista surged forward. Not to kiss him dumb, yet, but to grab him in a hug. She wrapped her arms around his broad torso, and buried her face in his shoulder. Sea Hawk let out a quiet ‘ *oof* ’ as she settled against him, but didn’t hesitate to wrap his arms back around her. They stood there, just being in each other’s arms, until Mermista lost track of the minutes. At some point his arm came up to cup her head, cradling it to him. Of course, he gave amazing hugs. Why not?

“Mermista?” He sounded hopelessly confused, which made sense. Mermista didn’t hug, usually. Hell, she rarely if ever kissed him outside the parameters of turning him on. Touch was tactile to her, a tool, a means to an end. But in this moment, standing on the precipice of a realization she’d been beating back with her trident, it seemed the only reasonable action to take.

“Yeah,.” she mumbled into his neck. Why did he always have to smell so good?

He pulled her away gently, and his eyes searched her face with concern. Sea Hawk opened his mouth to reply, but a loud *CRASH!* interrupted him. They spun as one, watching with mouths agape as Adora stormed over to the Horde soldier she’d likely thrown to the ground.

“Isn’t that one of the soldiers who attacked the Gate?” Sea Hawk murmured in her ear. Mermista suddenly cared a lot less about the laws of hospitality. But before she could even break away from Sea Hawk, Frosta was there, encasing Adora in ice.

“Damn, she’s strong for a little kid,” Mermista muttered.

Sea Hawk frowned. “She is, isn’t she?” He stroked his mustache like he did when he was thinking.

Mermista bit her tongue, unwilling to let herself smile at him. She still had standards after all.

“Do you think she’ll join the Alliance?”

Mermista winced as not a moment later, Adora’s invitation was revoked, and the child ruler stormed off very regally. “Proooobably not anymore.”

“Damn.”

“Uh huh.”

Belatedly, she realized they were still mere inches from one another, as she hadn’t yet broken their embrace. A large part of her felt the stab of panic she always did when she was doing something that could be conveyed as ‘wrong’ in public, and screamed at herself to bat his arms away. But the smaller, sappy, and overly sentimental side of her that had been winning all night prevailed, and she leaned back into his arms.

One of his hands came up to stroke her bare shoulder blade. "Something on your mind, dearest?"

Ugh. Sea Hawk was still Sea Hawk, no matter how rose-tinted the lenses were that she saw him through. "Nah. Just tired I guess. Long day, you know."

He hummed, and it vibrated through his chest pleasantly. "We can retire, if you wish. We've said hello to the host and the alliance, we danced, we ate, we drank. I'd say we've checked all the boxes on tonight's adventure."

"All of them?" She smirked. "But you didn't start any physically impossible fires yet."

Sea Hawk narrowed his eyes at her, and then had the audacity to *stick* his *tongue* out at her. Like a damn toddler. She smacked his chest, biting the insides of her cheeks because laughing would be, like, the lamest thing she could do in this situation-

clink-! Plink-plonk! tinkle-

Mermista frowned, and saw powdered ice shining on the shoulders of Sea Hawk's jacket. She glanced up, and saw the cracks beginning to web across the ceiling. Unable to look away, or move, even though she wanted to- had to-

It was strangely beautiful. Until it wasn't.

A sound like hundreds of ships crashing into each other echoed through the ballroom, a haunted groaning screech that turned her brain to mush and made her eyes water. She clamped her hands over her ears, not that it did anything. There was screaming, a lot of screaming, and thunderous cracking. The ground vibrated under her, and Mermista knew the whole place was coming down.

Seconds felt like hours in that instance. She looked up into Sea Hawk's eyes, seeing the fear and concern she knew was all over her face too. He was reaching out for her, and she grabbed his arm on instinct. He couldn't protect her- hell, in this frozen desert, she couldn't protect him either. Couldn't protect any of them, not with all of this yelling and crashing and vibrating-

She looked up again, and saw a massive chunk of ice break away from the ceiling directly above them. They couldn't have outrun it even with a headstart...they were going to die. Mermista felt strangely at peace in that moment. Yeah, the war wouldn't end. They'd be martyrs and Salineas would be defenseless and Sea Hawk would never know that she…

Well, it wouldn't really matter in about two seconds. Mermista braced for the ice, and tucked herself into Sea Hawk's arms. His grip on her was a vice, and he pulled her into his chest. Wasn't the worst way to go out, really.

And then, like a switch had been flipped everything stopped.

“Mermista! Sea Hawk!”

Perfuma was barreling towards them across the dancefloor, dodging suspended bits of ice. The chunks were encased in a magical blue glow- Frosta. Thank the stars for that weirdly jacked child ruler. Perfuma crashed into them, her hug really more of a grapple, and then pulled away.

“Bow- Glimmer- the Horde-”

Perfuma’s eyes were wild and panicked, and not doing shit for her already shot nerves, so Mermista seized her shoulders to still her. “Perfuma! You’re hyperventilating and I can’t understand what you’re saying. Breathe, do your hippie bullshit, whatever. Calm down.”

Perfuma nodded frantically, forcing herself to breathe in through her nose and out through her mouth. It would be highly comedic if she wasn’t also beginning to cry. Why was tonight so emotional and messy? Mermista had never wanted more to curl up at the bottom of her grotto and sleep in the moss there for, like, a week at minimum.

“The Horde princess, the really really buff one with the claws, and the hair, and those really nice earrings,” Mermista raised an eyebrow, because, like, Earth to Perfuma; now was really not the time to be drooling over the enemy. “She and the cat one, they-

they took them. Bow and Glimmer. They have them, and Adora thinks they're going to the Fright Zone."

The room was spinning again. She didn't even register Sea Hawk's hand on her shoulder, she was too numb all over. "Where's Adora?"

Perfuma sniffled. "She took the first mass transport to Bright Moon out. I tried to make her stop but it was like she couldn't even hear me!" She grabbed her blonde curls, running her hands through it and disturbing the flowers. "I don't… I don't know what to do, Mista."

She was looking in her eyes now, expectantly, like everyone had been doing lately. In the village, at the castle, in her meetings, anywhere. Like she had all these magical answers just because she'd been given a shiny new crown.

Mermista shook her head helplessly. "I...I don't-"

"Princesses!" Entrapta was suddenly at their side, as if she'd teleported. Or maybe she'd come over with Perfuma. The woman was, like, a head and half shorter than Mermista, okay? She never really saw her all the way down there. "We need a plan."

"Yeah, no shit!" Mermista couldn't help but snark. This was a whole new level of stress, miles above her baseline. "Got any bright ideas?"

Entrapta blinked at her, unfazed. “Well, yes, why else would I be over here?”

Perfuma, bless her, took over before Mermista shoved her foot further into her mouth. “Go on, Entrapta. What do you think we should do?”

“Head to Bright Moon, of course!” The short princess raised herself up on her hair to be eye level with them. “We don’t have all the information we need to create a plan, but Adora and the queen probably do. So, we should go there.”

They all nodded. Who knew Geek Princess would be the one to keep her head in a disaster? A quick glance around for Frosta yielded no results, and they all made their peace with a rude and hasty exit.

“But what if she wants to join us? Join the Alliance?” Perfuma murmured.

Mermista snorted. “Yeah, ah, she won’t, trust me.”

Thankfully, all of their weapons were still being held by security. Not many people could say the same. Her trident felt heavy in her hands, its weight grounding her back to the present- she was ruler of Salineas, a Princess of Power, and a friend. They had work to do, and no time for anything else.

Sea Hawk finished strapping his sword back to his hip, meeting her eyes as soon as he looked up. There was so much to say, and no time whatsoever to say it. So instead,

“Ready to save our friends?”

Sea Hawk grinned at her, and that grounded her too. “Always ready. C’mon everyone!” He pumped his fists in the air. “Time for a friend-saving, horde-invading, life risking Adventure!”

Chapter End Notes

> See you soon! Leave a comment and kudos, or feel free to swing by my Tumblr (same as my handle here) to leave a review. Ciao!

Cracks in the Foundation

Chapter Summary

The aftermath of Glimmer and Bow's rescue, and Entrapta's apparent loss.

Chapter Notes

Hello! Sorry for the delay, I completely forgot to put a reminder to update in my calendar.

Also, one note in case I totally forgot to mention it. I call Sea Hawk's hair finn bc that's apparently the color it is? Like a burnt purple brown? I used a Pantone color mixer and everything, very official.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

To say everything went to shit would be the understatement of the year. No, a lifetime. They'd gotten Bow and Glimmer back...but at the cost of Entrapta. The skiff was silent, save for the stray sniffle or choked sob. Adora stared ahead blankly, emotionless. Perfuma and Glimmer were both leaning on Bow, who hadn't stopped crying since they'd escaped. Silent tears had carved paths in the grime on his cheeks, and he made no move to wipe them. And Mermista…

His beautiful, brave Mermista.

She hadn't moved from the side of the skiff. Her body was rigid, as if she were holding herself together by sheer willpower. He really wouldn't doubt it.

Glimmer, who had stopped sobbing about two miles back, lifted her head from Bow's soaked shoulder. "Sea Hawk, where are we going?"

"Whispering Woods." His voice was rough, probably from all the screaming and running for his life. "I can get to Plumeria or Brightmoon from there."

Perfuma stood, and rearranged herself back on top of the engine housing, curling up with her knees to her chest. "Go to Brightmoon first. Glimmer and Bow need healers as soon as possible."

Sea Hawk nodded, and silence fell again. He stole glances at Mermista as often as he kept his eyes on the road, which, for him, was a lot. If he'd been alone, this skiff would have taken him to Snows by now. It was in good shape, a fine engine, easy to steer. He wondered if they'd let him keep it.

Focus, Sea Hawk. They need you to get them home.

He brought the skiff to a halt just outside the magical boundary of the Moonstone. He wouldn't be able to continue as long as he was steering Horde tech. It was only a four minute walk to the castle doors from here, though. There was an uneasy energy among the Princesses now, an angry tension.

“How could I let this happen…” Adora’s voice was barely more than a whisper.

As Bow and Glimmer rushed to assure her that wasn’t the case, Sea Hawk saw Mermista’s jaw tighten, her chipped black nails digging crescents into her arms. And then, like a cord snapping, she stood to speak.

“This only happened because we were all together,” she snapped.

Sea Hawk winced, but kept his mouth shut. This was her battle to fight alone. Perfuma wiped her eyes above him, and agreed. Frosty dismissal crept into Mermista’s voice, a tone he was all too familiar with.

“Maybe there’s a reason the Princess Alliance fell apart before. Maybe this whole thing was a *bad idea.* ” She turned her face from all of them, arms crossed, and Sea Hawk knew her walls were back up. That she was done with this, and was going to remove herself from the ‘vulnerability’ of it as quickly as possible.

Glimmer shook her head desperate. “Mermista, no, you can’t say that-”

“Whatever.” Mermista cut her off acidically. “I don’t want to be a part of it anymore. Sea Hawk, take me home.”

He nodded, and said nothing. Glimmer looked between the two of them, eyes pleading with him. Sea Hawk looked away. He wasn't Mermista's advisor, and he couldn't help her mend this rift.

He was just her ride.

At length, the Brightmoon trio hopped from the skiff, and limped off toward the castle just past the trees. Perfuma stood too, dusting off her dress and hopping down.

"I'll walk from here. I need to commune with the forest, try to recenter myself." She smiled at them with shining eyes. "And I'd like to pick some flowers for Entrapta."

Sea Hawk smiled back, swallowing the lump in his own throat. Perfuma paused by Mermista, placing gentle hands on the biceps of either of her crossed arms. She said nothing, but leaned down and pressed a motherly kiss to the crown of Mermista's head. "Please, don't hesitate to call me. We don't need an Alliance to keep in touch. To be friends." Mermista said nothing, eyes still on the floor, and Perfuma sighed. "You're not alone, Mista."

"Yeah, thanks."

Realizing that she wouldn't get any more from her, she crossed to Sea Hawk. She reached to hug him goodbye, and he reciprocated politely. Perfuma leaned in, whispering so softly she barely spoke. "Please, keep an eye on her. For me."

Sea Hawk nodded, and hugged Perfuma a bit tighter.

When she jumped from the skiff and disappeared into the woods, Mermista sat back down, this time with her back to the engine housing, to the left of his feet. She dropped her head onto her knees, and said nothing until they were flying along the coast. He had kept the speed low to avoid her ire; he didn’t want her thinking he thought this was a joyride.

But she lifted her head and pushed against his leg to get his attention. “What are you, eighty million years old? Speed it up.”

He saw the challenge in her eyes, masking the grief and exhaustion. She needed him to give her a hard time, to distract her from her own mind. He grinned at her, and it was mostly genuine.

“Hold on, Your Majesty.”

Sea Hawk tapped a few of the command keys, giving the transmission time to shift gear, before slamming the handle down. The engine turned over once, roared, and then they were off like a missile. He heard Mermista yelp, and watched her scramble to her feet in his peripheral. He steered them out toward the open sea, away from the coast, where the wind was stronger and the salt stung their eyes.

His hair was whipping around his eyes, and idly he thought he'd need it trimmed soon. He yanked his headband up more to tame the fringe, grinning as the wind hit his face full on. Sea Hawk turned to check on his passenger; and fell for her a little harder than he already was. Mermista was smiling, and it wasn't sarcastic or sultry or false. It was *alive* . Her hair had come undone from its braid, either in the wind or when she was yanking on it anxiously sometime in the last few hours. Long and wild, her curls danced loose in the wind as she leaned gently over the edge of the skiff. She looked back at him, and he saw the tears streaming down her face and knew they had nothing to do with the wind.

Beautiful didn't come close to describing Mermista, not to him. Breathtaking was better. Ethereal wasn't far off either. But they would have to do, because Sea Hawk was certain there was no word in any language that could quantify her beauty.

He loved her so much it hurt, sometimes. He shoved the thought down, down and away, deep into the recesses of his chest. Now was nowhere near the time to even think of it.

Sea Hawk grinned back, and steered them closer to the water. He had to yell to be heard. "It's too flat today for anything particularly impressive, Princess."

She was smirking now, as she lifted a hand toward the water. "What's the biggest you can handle?"

Now he was blushing, and she definitely did that on purpose. He winked. "Whatever suits the lady."

Mermista planted her feet and squared her shoulders, before lifting both arms very deliberately. She always kept her wrists loose, he noticed, her hands trailing her movements languidly, as if through, well, water. A few meters away, a large bulge of water rose up from the deep, at least sixty feet high. Mermista pulled her arms back to her chest, before squaring her hands and pushing hard. The water burst upwards, clearing another thirty feet.

Sea Hawk grinned. “Hang on tight!”

He shifted gears again, giving the engine more leeway, before pressing the tiller down as far as it would go. The skiff was displacing water to either side as it sliced through the air, approaching the wave at mach speed. At the last moment, he squeezed the trigger underneath the grip, and pulled back fast. The vehicle bucked up, and he released the handle before once again depressing the tiller. They were rocketing up the wave, higher and higher, both of them whooping and laughing in the face of danger. Not that there was much, really. He was the best sailor in Etheria and she was a hydrokinetic mermaid. The sea was their friend, their home, and they had no reason to fear her.

They crested the top and Mermista stumbled at the change in g-force pressing on her. Sea Hawk grabbed her without thinking, seizing her tight around the waist and pulling her against him as closely as the tiller would allow. The wave rippled underneath them a bit, but held its form.

His face wasn’t even an inch from her's, and her warm breath puffed against his lips. He swallowed hard. “Sorry, is this okay?” Mermista nodded and he smiled. “Well, then, off we go again.”

He leaned forward, and tilted the skiff into a toe-curling, belly-flipping dive along the back of the wave. They were hurtling toward the liquid glass surface of the sea, faster and faster with each passing moment, until finally, he yanked the yolk up as hard as he could. They levelled out with a jolt, the machine shuddering only for a moment, before they were off again.

Sea Hawk let go of the princess’ waist to shift gears and steady their course. Before he could reach for her again, she had sat back down on the edge of the skiff. Her smile was softer, and fading, and he ached to see it go.

He tamped down his sadness, replacing it with showmanship. “Well? What says her majesty?”

She snorted. “Alright, fine, that was pretty fun, I guess.” She examined her flaking nail polish. “How far to Salineas?”

As if it had never happened, silence fell over them once more. Sea Hawk thought frantically of any way to keep her smiling, but he couldn’t come up with anything that wouldn’t annoy her more than amuse her. So he merely kicked up the gear and let it go.

“Just another hour, Princess.”

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Mermista had told him to take her home, and he assumed she meant to drop her off. But she turned back to him after she set foot on the wood of the sky pier, lifting an unimpressed eyebrow. “Are you, like, coming?”

He rubbed the back of his head. “I didn’t want to be so forward as to presume…”

She just stared at him some more, until he was fidgeting and fishing around his brain for words he could say that would make any semblance of sense. At length, she shrugged. “Do what you want. I’ll be in my room taking a shower.”

Sea Hawk flushed. “Right, ah, yes, I’ll just- let me- here.” He hastily cast the mooring line over the nearest post, jumping off the skiff and finishing off the knot. When he turned to her, she was already halfway down the dock. He yelped, and sprinted to catch up with her.

She didn’t slow for him, but she did acknowledge his presence with a glance.

The walk to the back entrance of the palace was quiet, and by the time they reached the second floor, Sea Hawk found himself rambling on about the skiff: how he’d like to keep it, the modifications he could make, if Bow would help him, on and on and on until Mermsita whirled on him in front of a large, pearled door.

“Would it literally kill you for one second to *stop. talking?*“ she hissed.

Sea Hawk pushed down the very small pang of hurt, and grinned at her, happy to be back in familiar waters. “It might.” He shrugged, unconcerned.

Mermista rolled her eyes, turning away from him to push through the doors.

He had been in her chambers before, but he rarely got such a good look at them; usually it was evening, and there were more important, unclothed matters that he preferred to focus on. Even so, it had been a long while since he’d been up there. He had been shocked the first time he stepped into her true bedroom, and not just from the size of it; Sea Hawk was certain his childhood home in Snows could fit in just her sleeping chamber twice over. No, his surprise came from how...homey it was. Hand woven tapestries from the street markets of Salineas hung around the room. The carpet underfoot was the plushest, softest material he’d ever walked on. Her bed, while nicely made, was heaped with mismatched blankets and furs and silks. Mermista had told him once, in a post-coital haze of tenderness, that her mother used to knit and crochet her blankets all winter because she knew how cold her daughter got. The lights around the room, including the ceiling lights, were draped in rich textiles and fabrics to soften their brightness, giving the space an hearth-like glow. Everything was in cool shades of blue or green, the occasional purple, laced with gold throughout, and yet it was impossibly warm. The story of who Mermista really was laid around them, in picture frames, hand crafted gifts, little trinkets and treasures from around the world, some even from him. Overstuffed bookshelves, a well used tea set, the lingering spice of her heady perfume. If there was a paradisiacal afterlife, Sea Hawk was certain it would look like this.

Her bed was still the massive, round beast it had always been. Sea Hawk had never seen such a bed in his life; it was circular, but there was a headboard at the top that curved with the upper third of the bed. Four spiralling pearl posters held up a gauzy, silken canopy with drapes that Mermista liked to leave closed when she slept. There was a vanity opposite the bed, and the desk that took up the back of the room was much, much larger than it'd been last time. There was a door that led to a bathroom larger than half the houses he had ever seen, and another door that led to a personal receiving chamber and living room. There was another door that led to a hallway that led to the castle’s library. And, of course, the double glass doors that led to the balcony sitting area and garden.

Everything was some shade of blue or sea green, with gold or amber accents, and pearl or opal (or, occasionally, diamond) embellishments. What Sea Hawk liked most about it was, for a princess, it always was a bit of a disaster in here. Clothes on the floor, papers all over the desk, makeup and jewelry on the vanity, stacks of books on the nightstand. The scent of stale incense or candles lingered permanently. It was all so...her.

Mermista kicked off her high tops by the door, and made a beeline for the bathroom, shucking clothes as she went. Sea Hawk felt his face heating up; he wasn’t sure if Mermista saw them as close enough that she didn’t care, or was so uninterested in him tonight (or, in general, lately) that she wasn’t going to bother with propriety. Sea Hawk shucked his knee high boots as quickly as possible, and followed after her to find out.

She was sitting naked by a large, ornate pool in the floor. It took up more than half the room, which was saying something, enclosed by decorated glass. He paused, unsure what to do, and contented himself with just taking her in.

Her hair was tangled and dirty from the sewers of the Fright Zone. She was littered with bruises, burns, and scratches. But she was still a sight to behold. He traced her curves with his eyes, the swell of her breasts, the toned plain of her stomach. Where Sea Hawk’s abs were overly defined from a life of questionable nourishment, dehydration, and hard back breaking labor, hers were covered by a bit of gentle padding, and had been well muscled by a life of swimming. His eyes flicked back up to her face, and he swallowed when he realized he’d been caught. Her honey-brown eyes were staring into his, impassive as ever.

Sea Hawk had a healthy appreciation for Mermista’s deadpan humor and never-ending sarcasm, but the moments where she just *stared* at him were always a bit terrifying. He felt like the very layers of his soul were being peeled back, that she was more looking through him than at him.

Her eyes flickered down. “Gonna be hard to bathe in all those layers, dude.”

“Ah, right.” Sea Hawk cleared his throat and reached for his sword. He untied it, propping it against the closed door. He folded his jacket, shirt, and pants and piled them on a chair by the large mirror. His bandanas followed, along with his socks, until he was as bare as her. Why did he feel so nervous? It wasn’t anything she hadn’t seen before.

When he turned back, he couldn’t help but gasp. Mermista’s legs were gone, replaced by her mermaid tail. Her eyes flicked up from where she was stroking the scales, and if he’d been a more confident man, he would have called that a blush.

He padded over to her, joining her on the stone lip of the pool. He reached out, but stopped himself from touching. “May I?”

Mermista shrugged. “Yeah, go for it. Just don’t, like, stroke upwards. It kinda hurts.”

He nodded seriously, and watched her mouth twitch a bit. Her scales were iridescent, shimmering in the fading daylight. Each was a slightly different shade of blue, but from far away, it all looked very segmented. The outer scales were lighter, more sea green, while the inner scales faded into a deep, rich navy. The flared fin on the bottom was breathtaking, and he touched it with reverence. It was translucent with muted sparkle. The bottom tapered, longer on the ends than in the middle, with faint veined ribs intersecting it.

“I’ll never get over this,” he breathed, tracing a finger down. When he looked up, Mermista was even redder. He grinned. “Your beauty knows no bounds."

She groaned, and her tail slapped at him lightly. "Would you stoooop? You're so...just...ugh!"

Sea Hawk had no idea if that was a good 'ugh' or a bad 'ugh'. Two years ago, he wouldn't have had to second guess, he thought bitterly. He immediately shoved the thought from his head. Everything was different now. She was allowed to be annoyed. Even if he wasn't always sure what he did to annoy her…

He stroked her tail once more before clambering into the bathing pool. He yelped a bit, when he realized it was much deeper than he had initially thought. The water came up to his mid chest, and if he kneeled he would be under entirely. A loud splash and small wave hitting the back of his head was all the warning he had before Mermista joined him. He felt scales brush his leg, and a moment later she was sitting on a mostly-submerged stone. A shelf next to her contained brushes, bottles of soaps, and other bathing tools.

He swam over to her, content to watch as she soaped the brush and began running it over her scales harshly. "Stupid sewer water, stupid Fright Zone," she groaned. "This is going to take for-ev-errrrr to get out."

Sea Hawk held his hand out toward her. "Would you like some help?" A brush, cloth, and bottle came flying at him in reply. He hoisted himself up next to her, and a second later had a lap full of tail.

“Just, like, start by scrubbing down with them. I’m going to have to, like, tweeze and pick the bigger chunks of what-the-fuck-ever out after.”

He hummed, and set to work. It wasn’t unlike sealing the wood on the deck of an older ship, and Sea Hawk found himself slipping into an almost trance as he went along carefully. At some point, he started humming a shanty, and Mermista didn’t stop him. She left him to her scales, and took the time to wash out her hair, scrubbing it furiously and gagging at the gunk that washed out.

As she was wrapping up scrubbing her torso and arms, she sighed. “Do you think I did the right thing?”

Sea Hawk froze. This was new, and everything he wanted. An opening to prove she could talk to him. Confide in him. Trust him. He could *not* fuck this up. He forced his voice steady, uneager, as he resumed washing her. “With what, dearest?”

Fuck. Shit. Fuck. He said The Name. But when he hazarded a glance at Mermista, her eyes were far away. She shrugged, and he forced his eyes to stay glued to anywhere that wasn’t her chest as it moved with the motion.

“The Alliance, I guess.”

Sea Hawk hummed, picking his words carefully. “I don’t know if I have that answer. Do you feel better having broken things off?”

Silence. He glanced again, and she was picking at some of the scales clustered on her shoulder.

I don’t...know. Everything all feels the same right now.”

“And what’s that?”

She huffed. “Hopeless. Stressful. Like we’re all doomed no matter what we do, and today just proved it.” Her hands moved to her hair, tugging at it like she always did when she was upset. “I feel like...my entire kingdom is looking at me to do something, and I can’t. I can’t do anything to help anyone. Not them, not the alliance…” Her voice was breaking, shivering with emotion. “Not Entrapta. I couldn’t do anything.” She shook her head, staring down at the water. “He was right about me. I don’t know what I’m doing. Salineas’ days are numbered”

Sea Hawk frowned. “Who is ‘he’?” Mermista wouldn’t meet his eyes. She picked at her nails, cleaning them out. “Your father?”

She yanked her tail from his lap. “It doesn’t matter.”

He pressed his luck. “It certainly seems to matter if you’re this upset about it.”

“It’s nothing, Sea Hawk, drop it.” She scowled at him.

“No.”

Her eyes flashed, and the little voice that told him not to blow up ships or sleep with the burly tyrosaur was begging him to shut up. But he didn’t. “Not talking about things doesn’t make them go away, Mermista. You brought it up, so why can’t we talk about it?”

She scoffed. “ *We?* There is no ‘we’, Sea Hawk. I don’t need to tell you anything.”

Something ugly was building in his chest. He’d just gone to the fucking Fright Zone for her! He had fought for her, with her. The way she’d looked at him when they were dancing at the ball… he’d thought they were turning a corner. That she was opening up, again. He was naked in her personal bathing pool, for stars’ sake!

But the bigger part of him, the part of him that knew she didn’t owe him anything- she a queen and a Rune Princess, he a pirate captain- won out. He deflated, lowering his eyes. He knew, *he knew* , that this was all coming from a place of pain and fear. That she wasn’t sleeping much, if the bags under her eyes he’d seen before she swiped her makeup on were any indicator. She was so bogged down by the weight of an entire nation of people on her shoulders that she couldn’t take any more.

He knew that.

So he swallowed down the pain, the throbbing hurt at her refusal to just *talk to him* . He refused to be a problem for her. She didn’t need any other issue to deal with, and he didn’t want to be that. She needed someone sturdy, who could take the pain she was lashing out with.

Whatever he needed, well, that wasn’t important right now. He didn’t mind coming second, not to her. Never to her. She needed him to prioritize her right now, and he could do that. He was Sea Hawk. There was nothing he couldn’t do.

“Forgive me, Your Majesty. I spoke out of turn.”

She sighed, and it sounded defeated. “No, it’s not- it’s whatever, Sea Hawk. It’s fine. Let’s just...get out. I’m exhausted.”

He nodded. “You go ahead. I need to wash, still.”

“Oh, right.” She slid off the rock. “Uh, thank you, I guess, for the, like, tail help.”

He smiled at her, praying it didn’t look as hollow as it felt. She took it without a second glance, and swam away. Sea Hawk turned away to start on his hair. He wasn’t in the mood to watch her walk away right now.

By the time he finished bathing, the ache in his chest had subsided to a dull pang, and instead of upset, all he felt was bone tired. He didn’t bother with clothing, and padded out of the bathroom into Mermista’s bedroom.

The curtains were drawn around the bed, the lights off. Darkness had crept up on them, and the night moons were glowing softly above. He was resolving himself to the brisk walk to his ship and the hammock he had there when Mermista called his name.

“Sebastian?” Her voice was thick with sleep, soft like it hadn’t been in so long for him.

“Yes, my princess?”

“Are you coming to bed?”

He couldn’t help his smile, or the way his heart swelled when she used his given name. It was nice to know that deep down, under all the exhaustion and impatience, she was still Mermista. He climbed into the bed, keeping to ‘his’ side. It was only a matter of seconds before sleep overtook him, and all he knew was comforting darkness.

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Mermista was exhausted, like she’d been training for hours without break, while concurrently being forced to address a room of advisors and lords about something she knew nothing about. Physically, emotionally, mentally exhausted.

So why the fuck couldn’t she sleep.

Sea Hawk had drifted off before his head even hit the pillow, and his soft snores were not nearly as grating as they should have been. She flipped onto her other side to stare at him, drinking in the rare sight of the placid, unmoving pirate. He was just so Much, all the time.

She shifted uncomfortably, guilt stabbing at her heart. She couldn’t stop replaying their...argument? Fight? From the pool. Couldn’t stop seeing the look on his face when she told him to basically fuck off. He had just been pushing, and pushing, and pushing-

Why was it so hard to talk to him? What was she so scared of?

Tears pricked at her eyes as she lay there, the answer coming to her in bits and pieces of memory. Telling her mother about her day while she brushed her hair, and the feeling of contention it brought her even then to be able to just talk to someone about everything and nothing. She stopped being able to do that when she was twelve, and her mother didn't come back from defending the Sea Gate in a raid.

She remembered trying to talk to her father about a training issue she was having when she was fourteen, and being told to 'try harder, then, if you're so bad at it'. Then there was the time she had tried to explain to her then-friend Peekablue that she wasn't really sure if she wanted to be queen, only to be laughed at and told 'tough luck, honey, it's out of your hands'. Confiding in Perfuma that she wasn't sure if she ever wanted a baby, and only receiving a sigh and 'people change, give it time' in return.

No one ever listened to her. And the one who did, left her.

Mermista didn't get to trust in people. She didn't get to love people. Because loving people just meant making a date with heartbreak somewhere down the line. Who was she fooling, thinking she could love Sea Hawk and it would all work out fine? He was a commoner, a nomad, and a borderline arsonist who liked to toe the line of what the law allowed. It didn't matter what he was to her, that he was so much more than any of that.

Thunder rolled in the distance, far off the coast, snapping Mermista out of her spiral. Bitterly, she huffed a laugh. Oh, right, they were also in the middle of a *war* . Sea Hawk was constantly getting missives to run supplies, transport people to different areas where the Horde was attacking, evacuate overrun towns. She didn't think he would just stop because she'd pulled out of the Princess Alliance. In fact, she knew he wouldn't. This was his fight as much as hers, and Sea Hawk seemed determined to get himself killed, or worse, captured.

Her father’s voice, cold and detached, echoed in her head. *“Love is a liability, child. People will use it against you, twist it and make it hurt. To open oneself to it is weakness, and folly. ”*

Damn that bastard. Damn him for being right about this. Sea Hawk was reckless. He was loud, obnoxious, and annoying. He wasn’t passionate, or endearing, or earnest, and he certainly wasn’t charming. She didn’t love him. She couldn’t. It would kill them both if she did.

Tears were sliding down her face in the dark, dampening her pillow. When he woke up, she would send him away. To Brightmoon, or to Snows. Anywhere that wasn’t here. She wouldn’t have to see him again, and she could get back to focusing on her kingdom. There was so much to do. If she was lucky, she’d never think about him again.

Which is why, when her hand reached out to him of its own volition, she allowed herself the moment of weakness. Just one more single moment. He didn’t stir when she touched him; he slept like the dead once he managed to fall asleep. She lifted herself up slightly on one arm, inching closer to him. Moonlight threw his features into sharp contrast, turning his finn hair an inky black.

Mermista ghosted a hand over his shoulders. At some point he’d flipped onto his stomach, leaving them exposed. His back was spattered with hundreds of freckles, so fine and clustered that there were more of them than plain skin. She traced them with a barely-there finger, sketching imaginary patterns in the constellations. He hummed in his sleep, but didn’t stir. She allowed herself a small smile - even in rest he couldn’t shut up.

His hair was thick and smooth, the texture so unlike hers that Mermista couldn’t help but marvel at it slightly. She knew he did the same with her curls. They were so different in so many ways, even in this. Her fingers tousled his locks gently, coaxing a smile from him as he dozed on. Like a wave, exhaustion crested over her. Something about Sea Hawk was inherently soothing to her, which made little to no sense as he actively irritated her at every chance he got. But maybe it wasn’t supposed to make sense.

She pressed a soft kiss to his unmarred temple, before settling down next to him. She rolled over with her back to him, ready to drift off. As she was slipping down into her dreams, she felt something warm and firm wrap around her, and then an arm was curling around her waist.

Mermista should have pushed him off. She should have scooted away, back to her own space. But her weak, soft, stupid self just covered his arm with her own, and lifted her neck so he could slide his other arm underneath.

Just one more night.

Chapter End Notes

Things are Not Going Well :)

Battle for Bright Moon

Chapter Summary

> The rune stones are on the fritz, the princesses are fighting, and the Horde is locked and loaded. Time to go to war about it!

Chapter Notes

> Thank you for all the comments and support! I read every single one and sooner or later I will respond to each! They make my DAY! Y’all are just the coolest. Enjoy this chapter!
>
> It’s really weird to be posting season 1 chapters when I’m already wrapping up writing season 3 lol. Never been so ahead with a fic. Feels good. Feels organic.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Sea Hawk wasn’t sure how long he slept, but he imagined it was the longest sleep of his life. And the comfiest too. He woke up slowly, like he was being pulled up from the depths of a warm ocean, and became vaguely aware of several things. One, he had definitely pulled his arm in the Fright Zone. Two, said arm was entirely asleep. Three, it was asleep because it was underneath Mermista. Four, there was a fucking hurricane outside.

Not the worst wake up, all in all.

Groggily, he forced himself the rest of the way awake, scrubbing his free hand down his face. He grimaced, feeling the scruff on his chin. He hadn’t shaved since before the ball, and his beard had progressed well past stubble. Gently, he tried to extract his arm from underneath the princess’ head. She grunted in her sleep, turning over and trapping him further. Sea Hawk sighed; he didn’t have the heart to wake her. Not after the past...however many hours it had been since they’d lost Entrapta.

He settled back down, resigning himself to the permanent loss of his arm, when thunder crashed loudly, seemingly just outside the window. He craned his neck, and gasped at the carnage he saw; the balcony furniture was entirely overturned or gone, which was impressive as most of it was stone. The sky was an ugly, angry grey, and the lightning that crackled through it was...red? He couldn’t see the surf, but he knew the sea would be furious.

Another bolt of lightning struck the sea, and Mermista flinched next to him. Sea Hawk turned back to her, and frowned. She wasn’t peacefully asleep anymore. Her brow was furrowed, like she was in pain, her forehead dotted with sweat. As he watched, the color seemed to fade from her cheeks. More lightning crashed, and she winced.

Sea Hawk reached out to shake her. “Mermista?” Nothing. He shook her harder now, determined to wake her up. “Mermista, wake up.” He felt panic starting to rise in his chest. She was rigid, tensed against some invisible hurt, and almost completely unresponsive save for the occasional moan. “Mermista!”

In her pained sleep, she reached out and seized his bicep in a vice grip. He couldn’t stop a wince; Mermista was the strongest person he knew, quite literally. You didn’t lift metric tons of water, or that damned trident, and not end up stacked with muscle. Sea Hawk was reasonably certain she could bench him and not break a sweat.

He tried shaking her again, harder and harder, but she remained unresponsive to him. Eventually, the moaning subsided, in exchange for small bouts of full-body seizing, as if she were bracing for an impact. Tiny strands of blue sparks laced her body periodically, dancing over her skin. Sea Hawk, hesitant to call for her guards due to their state of undress and the fact that he was certain no one could help her, had no choice but to remain by her side through this...weird, magical fit. Because it really couldn’t be anything but magical, could it?

He wasn’t sure how much time passed. His arm was going to be bruised for days from her iron grip, but he didn’t much care. At some point, he had shifted to lie down with her again, and gathered her close to his chest. His chin was hooked over the back of her head, his left arm wrapped around her shoulders again. So when Mermista suddenly gasped, and flailed violently out of his grip, Sea Hawk yelped and fell backwards out of the bed onto his ass.

He scrambled to recover, hastily yanking himself back onto the bed as suavely as he could manage. “Mermista-”

She sat upright in the bed, sheets pooled around her waist. Her chest heaved for air, and her amber eyes were wild with confusion and pain. They landed on him, and Sea Hawk would have sworn he saw relief in them before a slightly-more-than-vaguely annoyed expression settled on her face. “What the fuck was that?”

He shrugged. “I have no idea, princess. I woke up, and found you having some sort of fit.”

Mermista grimaced. “A fit? What am I, an old bag?”

“Ah- no, definitely not.” Sea Hawk’s eyes flicked down over her very curvaceous, very tight body without his consent. “But there was lightning, and it was like, sparkly magical lightning…” He trailed off at the look of disdain and annoyance she was giving his description.

She sighed, running her hands over her arms. “It’s not over, whatever it is. I can feel...something. Under my skin. Just sitting there. Waiting.” Her black nails dug crescents into her skin, and Sea Hawk wanted so badly to take her hands in his. But her body language was screaming ‘don’t touch me’, and the small stretch of bedding between them had suddenly become an ocean.

Sea Hawk felt suddenly exhausted, deep inside, at the thought, but he pushed it away. Mermista needed him, whether she wanted him or not. He stood from the bed, refusing to be self conscious about everything he had on display. Her leggings from the battle were pretty destroyed, so he grabbed another pair from the drawer, along with one of her reinforced halter tops. Her vambraces sat on her vanity, so he snatched them up and then tossed the lot at her.

He forced bravado and energy into his voice. “Well then, princess, it sounds like we have an adventure on our hands!” He fished through his pile of clothes on the floor, deciding that they would have to do for now, at least until they got to his ship, and ducked into the bathroom to change.

Sea Hawk let his shoulders drop as he did. For the entire time they'd been...friends, or whatever, he'd never minded changing in front of her. Hell, it couldn't have been more than three nights ago that they dressed for the ball together, stealing touches and kisses as they did. Now, the image of her cold eyes flashed in front of him, stripping him barer than any lack of clothing could.

He felt, very suddenly, like he was trying to pick up large amounts of sand with just his two hands, or maybe running water. The futility and desperation of trying to hold onto something that had absolutely no intention of taking a tangible shape, because it didn't want to be held at all.

Sea Hawk rolled his shoulders as his shirt settled over him, and began lacing up his leather trousers. 'That's fine,' he thought bitterly. 'She's a princess, a queen actually, and I'm a lowborn pirate. It was always going to end up this way. I'll still stand by her, because I'm Sea Hawk. I'm loyal, and brave, and I've never given up in my life. And she needs someone in her corner, even if she doesn't want them. Doesn't want me. Not like I want her. That's fine. It's all *fine* .'

He stepped into his boots harshly, and lashed his belt haphazardly around his hips. His black bandana went around his forehead, pushing his fringe up and away as best it could. His red bandana, around his neck for luck. Lastly, he grabbed his sword, and was still fiddling with it when he pushed out of the bathroom and nearly collided with Mermista.

They stumbled back, and regarded each other warily. Sea Hawk couldn’t remember the last time he’d felt...awkward around Mermista. Never, if he was being honest. He fought down a grimace, and replaced it with his most debonair smile. He swept into a low bow, gesturing toward her bedroom door. “After you, your highness.”

She grunted, and pushed past him, knowing his long legs would keep pace with her power walk. Sea Hawk shoved his blade into its scabbard as they entered the throne room, and felt suddenly nervous without the distraction of ‘calibrating’ it. Her remaining guards lined the throne room, standing at attention as she strode to her throne. Sea Hawk wasn’t sure what to do with himself, so he lingered at the front of the room by the door, and ignored the unwelcoming, cold stares the majority of her guard was giving him.

Mermista was handed her trident by the captain of her guard, and she gripped it surely as she raised a hand toward the waterfalls lining the room. Water leapt from them, swirling around her and lifting her up to the Pearl. Sea Hawk had never really paid it much mind before; usually every time he was in here, he was more distracted by the regal woman sitting below it, vastly outshining the beauty of the stone. But there was no denying the rune its own praise; the surface was a pure white, like untouched snow, while the center of it glowed an ethereal blue. At the moment, it was flashing the same hue in a steady rhythm that reminded Sea Hawk of a lighthouse.

Mermista touched the Pearl, magic flowing out of the rune and into her, making her glow a faint, faint blue, so slight it almost wasn’t there. The water in the room responded, halting its flow as if it were holding breath. After a moment, Mermista let go and lowered herself to the ground. When she spoke, it was as Queen.

“Bright Moon is in trouble. They’ve set off their distress beacon, and are awaiting aid from the other Rune Kingdoms.” A gasp rippled around the room, the guards shifting to whisper amongst themselves. “The Horde is on their doorstep. Invasion and war, are imminent.”

The whispers grew to a murmur. Some guards were shaking their heads, others nodding vigorously. One stepped forward, inclining his head gently. “Your Majesty, what would you have Salineas do?”

Mermista regarded him coolly, gaze sweeping the room. It landed on Sea Hawk, and her eyes searched his for a brief moment. He nodded, almost imperceptibly, and flashed a discreet thumbs up.

“Salineas will answer.”

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Mermista sent him to ready his ship, while she gave orders to deploy the navy and the ground troops. They were heading to the heart of the kingdom to help defend the castle, while her guards would stay behind to guard the Runestone. The navy would head to help defend the smaller civilian towns of Brightmoon, while the ground forces would stay and guard Salineas’ own people.

Watching Mermista in action was, perhaps, the greatest turn on Sea Hawk had ever experienced. Gone was the bored, apathetic princess who had greeted Glimmer, Adora, and Bow, replaced by a woman with a passion, a mission, to protect her people. She gave orders as bluntly as anything, not wavering once in her answers, dismissing troops and advisors with a regal wave of her hand. Her subjects, as if sensing a change in the atmosphere, were no longer shifting from foot to foot, looking at one another nervously. They accepted her commands with as much confidence as she gave them, and a sort of nervous excitement began building up among them. Sea Hawk himself had even received a few nods and brotherly shoulder claps from various castle personnel as he strode for his ship.

However, he had little time to dwell on just how heart-stopping it was to see Mermista actively care about something, or how breathless it had left him. Or even the shifting mood of the castle now that they had a captain at the helm again. The Dragon’s Daughter III was still in fine shape, if not a bit more waterlogged than she should have been. The waves were roiling beneath him, and any sailor with even a few years less experience than him would have been tossed out the deck. But he was Sea Hawk! Fearless, brave, and the greatest sea captain in Etheria! A storm, even a magical storm, was nothing to him.

He worked with the tilting of the dock, teetering from sail to sail, scaling the mast to untie knots and loosen lines. It was with no small amount of petty glee that he managed to unfurl the massive jib on his own, mentally sticking his tongue out at Adora. He ducked below deck, and hastily changed his shirt and undergarments to clean sets. He paused on the way out of his captain’s quarters, glancing about at his personal belongings.

Sea Hawk had a feeling today was going to get a bit...pyrotechnic.

He tossed his maps, nautical tools, hammock, and other important things in a chest that he then hauled up to the deck and tossed over onto the pier, nearly missing two younger guards-in-training. He winced. “Sorry, lads, didn’t see you there!”

The taller waved him off. “That’s alright Captain Sea Hawk! Her majesty sent us down here to help you out.”

He grinned at them. “Ah! That’s very kind of her, and you, but I’m just about set to go. However...” He stroked his mustache, considering. “...would you mind terribly bringing that chest back to the castle for me? It’s nothing of great value or danger, just some maps and baubles.”

The shorter one prodded it suspiciously with his spear. “Sure, but we’d have to let our lieutenant check it.”

Sea Hawk waved them off. “That’s fine. When he’s done, have them brought to her majesty’s quarters please.”

The two young guards balked, either at the idea of bringing anything to the queen’s quarters, or at his blatant forwardness, but nodded nonetheless. However, no sooner had they picked up the chest than did the taller one drop it, falling into a bow.

“What the hell, nitwit- Your Majesty!”

Sea Hawk smothered his laughter in his elbow, watching the boys scramble into bows. His chest was sitting, probably painfully, on the one’s foot. Mermista didn’t even pause, waving them on with a nod before boosting herself onto the deck of the ship with a column of water. Sea Hawk waved them both goodbye before turning to the princess.

“Are we ready to go?”

Sea Hawk nodded. “Yes, but, we have a major issue.”

Mermista made an impatient ‘go on, then’ motion with her hand.

He cleared his throat. “Sailing through a hurricane like this is going to be impossible. Out at sea, the winds won’t push us toward Bright Moon. In fact, we’d have to fight them. Even if it were possible, it would take days.”

Mermista groaned, raking a hand through her hair. She paced back and forth, occasionally glancing at the sky, then land, and then the ocean. Her eyes settled on the ocean. Her mouth twisted in a grimace, and she held her trident out to him.

“I have an idea, but I’m going to need both my hands and all the concentration you can give me. And a really, really steady ship.”

Sea Hawk nodded, trepidation creeping up his throat. “Uh, Princess, not to over step my place, but is it safe to use your magic?”

Mermista shrugged. “I have no idea. But it’s the only option we have. Bright Moon could be under siege by now, we have no idea how long the distress beacon was going off.” Worry was still carved into his face, and she sighed. “Please, Sea Hawk. Just trust me?”

With a sigh, he nodded and took the trident from her. “Always, princess.” He bound up the steps to the wheel, tapping a few commands into the console panel. The engine hummed beneath his feet, the anchor pulling itself up and into its housing. Immediately, the wind seized the main sail and began trying to pull them away. Sea Hawk grit his teeth, keeping his one handed grip steady. Quickly, he tucked the trident’s hilt into his belt, lashing it tight with the points to the ground, and grabbed the wheel with both hands.

“If you’re going to do something,” he shouted down to Mermista, “now would be the time!”

She nodded, and took up a steady stance at the prow. Then, as if she were lifting something heavy overhead, she raised her arms and pushed as hard as she could. The ship lurched, before they were turned away from the dock, and thrust out toward the open ocean. The wind changed, and began pulling another way. Sea Hawk grimaced. He was going to have to manually manipulate the sails as they went, which meant he couldn't steer.

The trident knocked against his knees, giving him an idea. "Hey! How strong is this trident?"

Mermista was more grunting than shouting. "Very!"

Good enough for him. He whipped it from his belt, and stabbed it into the wood of the deck as hard as he could, and wedged the hilt between the spokes of the wheel. He fished a strip of leather from the pouch on his belt, and used that to fasten the wheel further.

That done, he leapt onto the railing of the upper deck, and from there onto the rat line. He scaled it halfway up, and seized a sail's rope in each hand. Mermista had turned when the boat lurched, and waited for him to get in place. He nodded at her, and she nodded back, before raising her hands again. The ocean rose up beneath them, pushing them through the water faster than any wind could.

As they hit different air streams, Sea Hawk furled and unfurled the two sails as needed, either to provide as little resistance as possible, helping Mermista steer, or to give them an extra push away from the whirlpools and eddies that were springing up around them. She couldn't control all the water at once, and he didn't want her tiring herself before an inevitable battle.

It took them an hour to reach Bright Moon, even going at the breakneck speed they were. The ocean was fighting them as much as it was helping them. The entire time, when he wasn't reading the wind and water currents, Sea Hawk was marveling at the strength of Mermista. She was fighting an entire ocean, the most unstoppable force on earth. Her arms were trembling, but not once did she drop them. Occasionally, she ran through some sort of form, something between dancing and fighting, to give them an extra boost or block them from a riptide. And now, they were approaching land, and she showed no sign of stopping.

"Mermista! We're here! We have to dock!"

He left both sails up and slid down the rat line to stand beside her. She was sweating from exertion, but that was it. She wasn't out of breath and panting, nor did she look ready to collapse. "There's no time. Bright Moon castle isn't that far inland, it's just through that gully."

Sea Hawk's jaw dropped. "Are you mad, woman? There's no more ocean!"

She grinned at him, and he saw the blue glow of the Pearl's magic gathering in the corners of her eyes. "I think I'll manage. Hang on!" She reeled back as if gathering herself, and the water surged faster. She moved through another form, and they were nearly at the shore line. Sea Hawk braced himself, and Mermista lunged forward with a yell. They made landfall and didn't falter even a bit. He carried himself to the edge of the ship, looking down at the ground below them. Far, far below them.

Mermista had summoned the biggest tidal wave he'd ever seen to carry them over land and to Bright Moon.

He turned to stare, because that's all he could do, at her power. Her hair was whipping behind her as they tore through the canyon, her brow furrowed in concentration and a grin of pure exhilaration on her face. She was a goddess, he was sure of it now, reincarnated as a warrior princess.

They swung around a corner, narrowly missing clipping the rudder on some rocks, and the canyon opened up into a shallow lake. Just beyond it, Bright Moon castle. Water was bubbling up from the lake, suspended by the Mermista's magic. Huddled on the ground were their friends and allies, surrounded by squadrons of Horde tanks and foot soldiers. Netossa was holding up a shield, but it wasn't going to last long. They were as good as dead.

With one final yell, Mermista hurled the wave forward, barreling towards their friends.

Possessed by the adrenaline of an oncoming fight, Sea Hawk yanked one of the torches from the mast and lit it. "Ad- *venture!* "

Only to feel a frigid wave splash over him and snuff out his weapon. The water cleared from his ears enough to hear Mermista drawl, “Don’t do that.”

He shrugged, not all that broken up by it because he could hear the smile under her voice. “Sorry.”

Mermista brought the wave right over their friends, flicking her hand gently to part the water around them, more like she was waving off a gnat than manipulating thousands of gallons of seawater to her will.

Sea Hawk swallowed, the full scope of her power and ability dawning on him. Seeing her strength, her magic, made his blood sing and he gripped the hilt of his sword. Mermista released the water, at last, but with a force that sent it crashing outward and into the Horde. At least thirty tanks were washed away, into the trees and magic of the Whispering Woods. He couldn’t see how many soldiers were caught in the water, but when they leapt together from the ship, there were far fewer of them surrounding the alliance than before.

The relief in Adora’s face told them all they needed to know about the direness of the situation. “Mermista! Sea Hawk! You came!”

“Yeah, sorry it took so long, the sea kiiiiinda sucked today.” Mermista smirked, flicking her hand to put out a fire climbing the castle walls with another massive wave. Sea Hawk was sure his open adoration for her was all over his face, but when had he ever cared about that? Besides, there were more important issues at hand.

As if on cue, the Horde tried to rally at the voice of their feline commander, only to be stopped by lashes of vines ripping from the earth and holding them in place. Tanks were crushed by squeezing tendrils, laser cannons eaten away in seconds by corrosive toxins secreted from beautiful flowers. The trees opened up in full bloom, and not one second later did Perfuma burst from the woods, skating on ropes of vine.

She landed before all of them, touching Adora’s shoulder and Mermista’s cheek with open concern. “I saw the distress beacon! Are you all okay?”

They all nodded at the flower princess’ kindness, before turning as one to face the remaining masses. Before they could charge, though, an upturned tank’s laser moved into position, and fired at the pillar supporting the Moon Stone.

A massive *crack!* echoed over the battlefield, and before their eyes the supports began to crumble. Adora started running, but they all knew she’d never make it in time. Mermista and Perfuma were moving into position, water and vines rushing forward-

Only to be beaten to it by glacial ice, climbing the pillar and stopping the fall. Walls of ice suddenly erupted from the water around them, shot-putting tanks further into the woods. From behind the castle, a winding ice slide emerged, Princess Frosta gliding along it with ease. She jumped, tucked, and landed in front of them.

“I hope I’m not too late.”

Adore smiled kindly at the pint-sized ruler. “No. You’re right on time.” She stood, and raised her great sword to the heavens, the glow washing over them all. Sea Hawk had no magic in him, but he felt it swirl around him, a buzzing warmth that settled just within his skin, setting him humming with energy. Tendrils of it washed outward like a golden river, and each princess gasped.

Sea Hawk turned to see Mermista’s color coming back to her cheeks, the exhaustion lifting from her as if magnetic. But the magic didn’t stop there. Gentle blue light was washing over her like a waterfall, glowing from within like a lantern. It burst outward in a small shower of glitter, leaving her whole, hale, and recharged from whatever had transpired between her and the Pearl that morning.

She turned to him, and smiled like she hadn’t in so long. Her stress and annoyance were gone, her cold walls falling like dominos. Beaming at him like the sun, he saw only the Mermista he had first met, excited and raring to tackle whatever came at her next.

He smiled back, and if there were tears pricking his eyes, well, that was his business.

Glimmer popped into existence in front of them as the glow faded, and it was as if it had never been there in the first place. She embraced Bow and Adora, asking what she'd missed.

"The Princesses are united!" Adora beamed at them all. "This is how it's supposed to be."

Runestone secured, princesses recharged, She-Ra primed and ready. There was nothing left to do but beat off the remaining invaders. Sea Hawk grinned as he drew his light blade, hearing Mermista as she nudged Perfuma playfully. "What do you say, ready to finish them off?"

She giggled. "Thought you'd never ask." She spared them a wink, and then they were off, charging the Horde at She-Ra's command.

Mermista sprinted ahead of him and Perfuma, sending huge waves of lake water at the first squad of Horde goons. They were gone when the water settled, the tanks advancing in their place.

Perfuma made short work of them, twisting them in crushing tendrils of vine. She couldn't grab them all though, and Frosta leapt from behind to freeze the weapons and soldiers that slipped through the cracks.

A hand tugged his sleeve. Sea Hawk turned to see Glimmer grinning at him manically.

“Hey, Sea Hawk. Feel like turning up the heat?”

He grinned back, sheathing his blade. “Lead the way, Princess.”

In a flash they were on the deck of his ship. He ducked below deck, grabbing four large handles of strong whiskey, briefly mourning their loss more than his ship. Glimmer was leaned over the deck, shouting to someone-

Most likely, it was Spinnerella, because his ship was now flying through the air. He tossed a bottle to Glimmer, who followed his lead in smashing them on the wood of the deck. He snatched a match from the pouch on his hip, lighting it on the heel of his boot. They sprinted to the wheel, stomachs swooping as Spinnerella sent the ship soaring downward toward a large concentration of Horde troops.

He tossed the match with a whoop, wrapping an arm around his shorter friend. They pumped their fists as the deck went up in flames. “ADVENTURE!”

They teleported off at the last possible moment, both forgetting to be afraid for their lives. There was a rush, then Sea Hawk was falling, plummeting toward the lake, which was fine. The water would break his-

He landed in strong arms that caught him with barely a grunt, and opened his eyes to see Mermista grinning down at him. There was drying blood in her hair from the gash at her hairline, and her lip was split a bit near her cupid’s bow. Bruises trailed down her neck, already yellowing. Pollen was caked in her curls, and her arms were freezing cold. His heart flipped, dropping into his stomach. Stars, but she was *beautiful* . “Hey, handsome.”

He tipped an imaginary captain's hat to her. “M’lady.”

She set him on his feet, swatting his ass playfully. Sea Hawk had no time to return the favor, as a trio of Horde soldiers charged him. He drew his sword in a flash, blocking a stun beton as the soldier tried to swing it overhead. He kicked out forcefully, sending his attacker sprawling in the water, before spinning and parrying another baton.

He danced with the two soldiers for a moment, feet working separately from his brain as they carried him away from Mermista and the other two princesses at her back. They were ranged fighters, mostly, even though he knew Mermista could handle herself with that trident-

The trident he left on board the ship that had just blown up. Fuck.

Regardless, he wanted to keep the hand to hand away from them. Sea Hawk ducked a slicing swipe meant for his throat, before grappling the knees of his opponent. He recovered quickly, standing with a grunt and tossing the soldier for all he was worth. The person went flying, but Sea Hawk had no time to be proud.

He turned to face his other opponent, only to find them gone. He cast about frantically, searching for the soldier-

A burning sting exploded across his right side, crackling up his ribs and across his abdomen. It was sharper than fire, like getting stabbed by lightning. Unthinking, Sea Hawk grabbed his sword, thumbing the laser function as high as it would go, and swung with as much force as he could muster in that moment. The pain stopped, leaving him breathless, as something fell into the water with a large thud.

The soldier sat passed out, missing the hand that had been holding the stun baton. His blade had cauterized the wound immediately, leaving behind a mangled mess that smelled of burning flesh. Sea Hawk did the bare minimum, kicking the body over so they wouldn't drown, before moving on.

The princesses were rallying around a now supernova She-Ra, her sword a beacon of pure light. He made his way over, taking his place at Mermista's side. He wasn't in much pain, but he didn't want to find out how much of that was adrenaline doing the work. Awe quickly rushed in to replace his discomfort, though, as one by one the princesses grasped one another, the energy from She-Ra's sword rushing through them.

Mermista turned to look at him, and he placed his own hand on her shoulder. She smiled with her eyes again, and he watched in amazement as they shifted from amber to the same staggering blue from earlier. Now, though, it was all encompassing, washing over her and staying there. She was glowing like he’d never seen, light and magic and the unbridled power of the ocean rolling off of her, mixing with the other Princesses auras.

A liquid rainbow of magical essence burst forth from the alliance, spiraling outward and pushing back what was left of the Horde invaders. When it faded, they were left standing triumphant, as the last of the soldiers fled on foot or skiff. The princesses began whooping, jumping for joy. Sea Hawk’s own victory cry of “Adventure!” was met with hollers of agreement from Frosta and Netossa. He saw Mermista and Perfuma embracing and laughing, and grinned for his princess’ joy.

Everyone was hugging, and Sea Hawk found himself being embraced warmly by Spinnerella, who pulled back to brush dirt and muck from his jacket in a kind, motherly way. He thanked her, before someone collided with his legs.

Frosta was grinning up at him. “We did it, Pirate!”

Laughter boomed from his chest, and he wrapped an arm around the girl. “Haha! That’s how we do it in Snows, eh?” He winked at her conspiratorially and she beamed back at him.

“Heck yeah!”

Spinnerella laughed at them, before her wife tackled her in a hug. They laughed together, love and light shining from them almost tangibly as Spinnerella picked Netossa up and spun her.

Sea Hawk felt his heart clench with pure want, and he ruffled Frosta's hair before trotting off through the other princesses.

"That's how it's done in the *sea!* " Mermista whooped, smiling broadly as she slapped Perfuma's hand in a low high five.

Sea Hawk's heart felt so full to bursting with pride and love, he could only guess at the expression on his own face.

He wrapped an arm around her shoulder, and she turned to him. She didn't hug him back, but she did lean into his side heavily as she smiled at him, eyes crinkling. "Really good job."

Sea Hawk could only smile more. He glanced, saw no one was watching them, and pressed a kiss to her clean temple. "You were… amazing. No, radiant! A sight to behold, dearest."

Mermista flushed, and looked away, still grinning. "Yeah?"

He grinned. "I'll be writing songs of your battle prowess for years to come- no, decades- eons!"

She shoved him lightly, rolling her eyes. "Uuuuugh, whatever, goober."

He inhaled deeply, ready to provide her with a sample of the odes he had in mind, but he was interrupted by the flapping of large wings and a gust of wind. Quickly, the Alliance sobered enough to be proper as Queen Angella stepped into view. She was beaming at them, happier than Sea Hawk had ever seen her. Granted, he'd only ever seen her from a distance, but he knew she was a stern, revered woman.

She walked through their crowd, grinning and nodding at all of them. They bowed in unison, and she touched first Netossa's shoulder in thanks, and then Mermista's. There was more than gratitude in her eyes as she nodded to the water princess; Sea Hawk would have guessed pride, with something a bit softer.

Then she moved on, embracing her daughter, Bow, and She-Ra in her arms and wings. Mermista's one hand was still on the shoulder the queen had touched, the other reaching down to hold his. He ran a thumb over her knuckles, sensing a slight shift in her mood.

Queen Angella turned to them. "Please, I invite you to rest in the castle for as long as you need. I'll have messengers deployed to your kingdoms to report back their status', and from there we can discuss our next steps as a unified Alliance." She bowed to *them* , and a gasp rippled through the princesses. "You answered Bright Moon's call to aid, when you owed us nothing. I will work every day to repay you all, and your people. Please, come rest, eat, and be seen by our healers."

They all nodded, and began the short trek to the castle. Mermista pulled away from him to walk alongside Perfuma, and Sea Hawk pushed down the ugly little feeling it stirred in his chest. That was her best friend, man. Let her enjoy their time together. As they reached the steps, a small fleet of guards in long white robes came hurtling down the steps.

“Your Majesty!” They skidded to a halt before Angella, bowing quickly. “There’s a small faction of Horde soldiers hiding in Thaymoor. They fled from this battle quickly, and are squatting there. They’re using up the people’s supplies, and they’re starting to raid civilian homes.”

Angella nodded. “Go, gather what guards you can. Permission to use whatever force necessary is granted.”

Sea Hawk, whose blood was set boiling at the mention of home raids, stepped forward. “Your Grace, if I may, I would like to go with them.” The Queen turned to him, giving him a once over and a questioning look. “I’m fit for battle, as the princesses did most of the heavy lifting here.” He gave her the same lop-sided, self assured grin that had secured him many a spot on different working ships in his youth.

At length, Angella nodded. “Go, then, Captain Sea Hawk. Bright Moon thanks you for your valor.”

The guards nodded at him as he approached, and climbed into the Etherian skiff that had just pulled up. Two others floated nearby, waiting for them to load up. It was only when he was settled that he looked back, and saw the Alliance staring at him. Mermista's eyes were searching his with concern, and maybe even worry.

The notion was sweet, if far fetched. Mermista never worried about him, she knew he was capable of handling himself. Nonetheless, he winked at her, her blush being the last he saw of her before rocketing off into the woods with the battalion.

Chapter End Notes

> Next up: the aftermath. A warning in advance- there will be smut in the next chapter but I've labeled where it begins and ends so anyone who wants to skip it can.

Standing on a Precipice

Chapter Summary

A conversation long overdue, gossip, and Sea Hawk’s return

Chapter Notes

Cap’n! There be Sex here! I’ve marked the explicit material between bold headers with many exclamation points for any who would prefer to skip over it.

I took,,, many liberties with what people can do while injured in this chapter. Also with etherian men’s refractory periods.

Please- never have sex with bruised ribs. Don’t be stupid like these guys.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mermista followed the other princesses up the stairs into the castle. The adrenaline from the battle was leaking out of her like a sieve, and with each step she became more and more drained. Her temple was throbbing, her hair was disgusting, and her lip hurt like hell. Perfuma was fussing over her, and she swatted her away half-heartedly.

Glimmer began leading them all to their guest rooms, with attached baths and plush beds for them to rest. It was Bow who lit up like a lighthouse, and started dancing from foot to foot.

Frosta glared at him. “Are you concussed?”

“What? No!” Bow gaped. “I’m excited, because this is the first time we're *all* together, and we *won,* and we should absolutely, totally have a Princess Alliance sleepover!” His voice was cracking like sea glass in his enthusiasm, and Mermista hid her grin behind her bruised knuckles.

One by one, they glanced at each other. Perfuma was bobbing her head happily, Frosta looked completely uncertain (Mermista wondered if she even knew what a sleepover was), and she just shrugged.

Bow pumped his fists in the air, undeterred. “That’s a yes to me!”

Glimmer smiled at her best friend’s boundless energy. “How about we all go clean up, see the healers, and then reconvene in my room?”

Adora, who was looking more and more like a zombie by the second, just mumbled and nodded. She started to sway, and Bow and Glimmer each looped an arm around her to frog march her away. The sparkly princess threw over her shoulder. “I’ll have someone bring you all comfier clothes! See you later!”

With that, they dispersed, and Mermista all but fled to her room. She shut the door with a sigh, leaning against it heavily. She liked the other princesses, even if she had a hard time saying it (even to herself), but they were all *so much* . She understood why Sea Hawk loved hanging around Bow and Glimmer, they were as high strung as he was. Only they were about six years younger than him, and therefore had a reasonable excuse.

Mermista pushed all thoughts from her head as she stripped to bathe. Her metal pauldrons fell to the ground with twin clangs, her shoes went flying, and her armor, as it were, she left in puddles that led to the bathroom. There was a deep clawfoot tub that she knew wouldn't be able to hold all her tail, and a waterfall shower area. For the sake of efficiency, she turned on the shower.

She became aware of the silence slowly, and didn't loathe it even slightly. No one was talking to her, asking for her opinions or to make a decision, or even just her attention. No yelling princesses, over excited archers, and no pirate showman who crowded her brain and forced out everything coherent. It was amazing.

Until it wasn't.

The worry and isolation hit her like a strong tide, all at once and knocking her breath out. She fumbled in scrubbing soap through her hair, and grazed the cut on her head. She hissed, immediately dunking it under the spray. Even when he wasn't here, he was so annoyingly distracting.

He wasn't here, and it felt weird. It shouldn't have felt anything other than normal, but it did. They'd been together for… yikes, almost a week straight. Between prom, the Fright Zone, the aftermath and now this battle, Sea Hawk had become a fixture at her side. She could turn and see his smile, knowing he was right there. Safe. Not off on some grandiose, suicidal adventure, setting ships on fire as he pleased with no regard for his safety, battling the Horde and everyone else who wanted him dead.

It was selfish of her to want him by her side, when just last night she'd resolved to let him go, to push him as far from her as she could manage. She pondered her decision as she scrubbed the blood off her face and neck. She'd had moments of weakness today on the battlefield. But the way he'd looked at her on his ship, the awe and desire in his eyes, had knocked her off course. And then in the battle...the way he moved.

Sea Hawk was a goof, but he wasn't a fool. Usually. When things got rough, he got even rougher. It was easy to forget that he had been raised on pirate ships and grimy ports when he was such a debonair lunatic, charm and manic glee radiating out of every pore. But today, watching him figh had been something else. Something that made Mermista's core tingle, her insides squirm. He didn't fight like a princess, or even like a trained guard. He was angry, fast, and dirty, not to mention fearless. He'd thrown himself into several throngs of guards, sometimes so thick she could only see his glowing blade. She had seen him take hits to the face and body that would've dropped most people, but only seemed to make him angrier.

It was undeniably hot. And the way he'd looked at her, fighting off swathes of enemies with huge tides of water, she knew he felt the same. Maybe she should invite him over to spar more-

No. She was letting him go. She had to, and today only proved it.

The image of him being electrocuted in front of her flashed before her eyes. She'd frozen, hearing his agonized scream, turning around a second too late to help him. Sea Hawk had sliced the soldier’s hand off before she could move, and her brief hesitation had left her open to the attack that almost decapitated her.

Weakness. He was nothing but a liability. Her father’s voice was louder than ever, seemingly echoing around the tiles of the bathroom. Sea Hawk was going to get himself killed, or she was going to let herself be killed for him. Neither was an option; her people needed her.

She shut off the water, and pulled the moisture off her body to flick it down the drain before stepping out. Just as Glimmer had promised, there were clothes waiting for her on the bed. Soft blue pants, cuffed slightly at the ankle, a cropped short sleeve top in a heather gray, and the softest socks Mermista had ever worn. After quickly braiding and bunning her hair, she stepped into the corridor intent on finding a healer for her growing migraine.

She blamed said migraine for not better seeing where she was going, and crashing directly into someone. Her ass hit the ground with a thud. “Ow! Hey, watch it!”

A melodious chuckle, and a pale hand offering her help made the blood drain from Mermista’s face. “My apologies, Queen Mermista.”

She grabbed the hand and allowed herself to be helped up, already stammering apologies and bowing. “Queen Angella! I am so sorry, if I had known it was you I would have never- that is, I didn’t mean to say-”

The Queen of Bright Moon chuckled kindly, touching a hand to her chin to pull her out of her bow. “All is well, Mermista. I am not offended. In fact, your candor is...refreshing.”

Had her cheeks ever been this warm? “Uh, thanks, I guess? I’m still, like, really sorry.”

“You have my forgiveness,” Angella nodded gently. “Are you on your way to the healers?”

“Yes, Your Grace.”

“Would you mind if I walked with you?”

Hadn’t she been heading in the other direction? Confused, Mermista nodded. “Of course not. Honestly, I’m not sure where I’m going so I’ll follow your lead, if that’s alright.”

Angella smiled again, turning to walk alongside her. “That’s right. It’s been many, many years since you last visited my halls, hasn’t it?”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Please, Mermista,” she sighed. “Angella is fine. After all, are we not both queens?”

Mermista scowled before she could stop it. “Technically, yeah, I guess,” she muttered. They walked in silence for a few seconds before she cracked and sighed. “It’s just weird, I guess, I don’t know.”

Angella hummed. “How so, if I may ask?”

“It’s just that, all my friends are princesses. I’m part of the Princess Alliance, they all call me Princess. I mean, if I’m being honest, I don’t feel like a queen. I still feel like a stupid little kid playing dress up games most days. I wasn’t meant to do this. At least, not yet.” Her voice trailed off at the end, and she kept her head down. “It’s easier to forget that I’m a queen, to be a princess, even if it’s just in title. It doesn’t all feel so...much.”

Angella was nodding, her eyes full of sympathy, but without any pity to be found. “You’ve been dealt a very hard hand, Mermista. And I’m sorry for it.” She sighed, and looked away, coming to a stop. “You have to know, your mother never meant it to be this way.”

Mermista froze at the mention of her mom. “She...what?”

Angella smiled sadly. “Your mother and I were close, back during the first alliance. I found her honesty and her humor so, well, refreshing, in a war room full of bureaucrats. She never hid behind decorum, always spoke her mind.” The queen's eyes were far away. “When she found out you were coming, she nearly flooded the ports, she was so happy.” Angella laid a hand on the side of her face, staring directly at her. “She loved you so much, Mermista. You were the moon to her tides, and she never wanted this war for you.”

Mermista was only vaguely aware of the tears spilling down her cheeks. Yeah, she was definitely concussed. But still...it had been so long since anyone had even mentioned her mother. Her father was so warped with grief that he’d forbidden anyone to speak her name in his presence. Eventually, everyone became too afraid to talk about her at all, and Mermista’s mom was lost to time.

She clamped a hand over her mouth to stop an ugly sob. “I wish she were here,” she whispered. “I know it’s horrible, but I wish it had been my dad, not her. I needed her.”

Gently, Angella wrapped her in a hug. “I’m so sorry she had to leave you. And I’m so sorry I never came to see you,” she sighed. “She was a dear friend, but I let my grief and anger push her away. And then she was gone.” The queen was silent, before laughing bitterly. “If I may be honest, I wish it had been your father, too.”

Mermista pulled back to look at her in shock. The queen’s face was somber. “He should never have been king. And he should never have left you as he did.” She levelled her with a very serious look. “He is a coward, and your mother would be furious and ashamed at his actions. Do not ever think that she would have condoned them for a second.

"Mermista, you are one hundred times the ruler your father ever was. I know it's all new, and downright terrifying for now. How could it not be? When the other thrones ascended, there were advisors, and former rulers to help. What your father did is just simply not done. And yet, here you are!" A motherly pride shone in the queen's eyes. "My dear, you are doing splendidly. Your mother would be *so proud of you* ."

Mermista sobbed openly, and Angella wrapped her in another tight hug. After a few moments, she pulled back, wiping her eyes. She was fighting down the feelings of embarrassment and weakness clawing at her. Her father may have been the biggest asshole in Etheria, but one conversation couldn't erase years of emotional toil. "Thank you, Angella. I...can't tell you how much I needed to hear that."

Angella nodded. "All is well, Mermista. Just try to remember all I've told you when it all feels so...much." She smiled softly. "Now come, that lip and that cut need a healer before they scar any worse. And we should have your head checked."

She could say that again.

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Two hours later, darkness had fallen and the Alliance was draped around Glimmer's room being, well, the teenagers they really hadn't gotten to be. Except Bow and Glimmer. But they were like, nineteen so they didn’t count. Babies.

Perfuma was braiding and unbraiding Mermista’s hair, which was difficult considering how low the mermaid was slouched in her bean bag. “Can you sit up?”

“Hmmmm, nope.” Mermista craned her neck back to stick her tongue out at Perfuma, drawing giggles from the others.

“Alright, alright, Bow, you’re next.” Glimmer tossed a pillow at the archer, who was leaned against the chaise lounge Frosta was curled up on. “Truth or dare?”

“Ahhhh…" He rolled his eyes in thought. “Dare.”

Adora snorted. “Wow, getting bold are we?”

Bow made a face at her.

“Bow, I dare you tooooo...” Glimmer trailed off. “Go get us some snacks from the kitchen. Especially popcorn!”

The girls cheered their agreement, and Bow rose to his feet with a sigh. “Fine, your majesties,” he teased. “But I want an actual cushion when I come back. My ass is sore."

"Oooooooh, Bow said ass," Mermista teased. "Is that anyway to talk around Frosta?"

The almost-twelve year old rallied a bit at the mention of her name. "Wha- I'm up, I'm up, I swear!" She rubbed her eyes with small hands, a sight that Mermista privately found adorable. Especially coming from the little hellion she was quickly learning Frosta was.

"Sure, kid."

The princesses murmured amongst themselves for a bit, giggled or dozing off, until Glimmer rounded on Mermista with an almost predatory look in her eyes. It didn't help that Adora was smirking at her. It was really unfair how hot Adora was, especially when she clearly had no idea.

"Sooooooo, Mermista," Glimmer singsonged. "How are things with *Sea Hawk?* "

Mermista scowled. She should have known. "What are you talking about?" She didn't need to affect annoyance, since she was actually, you know, annoyed.

Glimmer scoffed and rolled her eyes. “Oh, please, we all know you guys are together! Give us the details!”

She rolled her eyes. “Okay, well, one: we aren’t together. And two: there are no details because, as I just said, we’re not dating. Or courting. Or whatever you want to say it isn’t."

Adora tilted her head like a confused puppy. It was such a Sea Hawk move. “Wait, but you went to Princess Prom together? And he fought with us in the Fright Zone. And he was here!”

Mermista shrugged, examining her battered nail beds. “He’s an ally. And I guess, like, a friend. He was my ride to the ball, our collective ride to and from the Fright Zone, and my ride here. Plus, he loves a good fight.”

Frosta popped up from her reclined position. “He kissed the side of your head after the battle today. And you danced the Snows Waltz together, like, really well. Doesn’t that make him your boyfriend?”

“No?” She was getting prickly, and very tired of this conversation. “He’s from Snows, of course he knows the dances well. That has like, nothing to do with anything.”

Perfuma hummed behind her. “When I asked how you met, you both said it was complicated. How can it be complicated if he’s *'just your ride'.* " Mermista could *feel* the air quotes the other girl put around her wording.

All eyes in the room were on her now, and she hated it. Loathed it, even. Being the center of attention never got easier. "Ugh! It's like, not a big deal. And even if I were to elaborate, which I won't, it's not really a Frosta-appropriate story."

The younger girl blinked, unimpressed. "Is it because of sex? I know about sex, Mermista."

Well, shit.

Her cheeks were on fire as Glimmer and Adora's jaws dropped. Glimmer was floundering for the right words. "But- you're not supposed to- you're a princess!"

Mermista shrugged. "So?"

"In Bright Moon, you're not supposed to have sex until you're, like, betrothed!"

She wrinkled her nose. "That's fucking stupid."

Perfuma nodded behind her. “I agree with Mermista, that doesn’t seem smart.” The younger three girls looked at them. “Sex is...important in a relationship if you choose to have it. It’s not something to be taken lightly. If you’re going to be having it with someone for the rest of your lives, doesn’t it make sense to check your compatibility before agreeing to forever?”

Mermista smirked. “Test drive the boat before you sign the lease, ladies.”

Perfuma sputtered. “Well that’s ...I mean, yes, but, *really* Mermista-!”

A laugh bubbled out of her, breaking some of the tension in the room. She’d forgotten how much fun it was to fluster her earthy friend. She turned to the other girls, the knowledge that Perfuma supported her bolstering her. “Yeah, we fucked. The first night we met actually, which was at a masquerade ball my dad was throwing.”

Adora blinked. “Wait you, uh...slept together, or however you put it, without knowing what he looked like?”

Mermista shrugged. “I knew he had a stupid mustache. But yeah.”

Frosta, now looking a bit more scandalised, leaned forward. “But then, how did you know you wanted to...do that with him?”

She refused to blush. “We talked the whole night, pretty much. And danced together. He had good rhythm.”

Glimmer, sensing she wasn’t going to get more than that, pushed on. “And then you’ve been together since?”

Mermista rolled her eyes. “Girl, how many times do I have to tell you we’re not together.”

“But you had sex!”

“So?” She rolled her eyes. “We fucked, he left the next day because he’s, you know, a *pirate* . And then he would come back every once in a while and we’d hang out.”

Perfuma’s hands were tense in her hair. She knew there was more to the story than Mermista was letting on. But really, this was her personal life, not their soap opera of the week! She was entitled to her privacy.

Glimmer looked bummed. “That’s it? Just hang out?”

She shrugged. “Yep. Sorry, Sparkles, it’s not the whirlwind romance you wanted.”

Perfuma had reached her limit, apparently. “But, Mista, the way he looks at you…”

“So what?” she snapped. “I can’t control his eyes. And I’m pretty damn hot sooooo-”

“You know that’s not what I was getting at.”

“So you’re saying I’m not hot?”

The plant princess sputtered. “What! No, I-”

Adora interjected softly. “He makes you smile.”

Mermista had officially reached her limit. She needed the topic to change, like, yesterday, or she was going to storm out. She shrugged as apathetically as she could manage. “What about Glimmer and Bow? They’re always smiling together. Pluuuus, Glimmer had that huge freak out when Bow went to the ball with ’Fuma, soooo…”

Mission accomplished. All eyes were now on the scarlet red princess and not her. Mermista crowed internally. That’s what she gets for sticking her nose where it doesn’t belong.

“We- I- No! Of course not! Why would you even- No!”

Perfuma hummed. “It *did* seem like there were a lot of big emotions regarding the whole prom date situation.”

The younger girl dropped her gaze. “Yeah...I’m really sorry about that, Perfuma. I was just-”

“Jealous?” Mermista supplied.

Glimmer glared. “No. Well, kind of. I just...never had any friends growing up. It was just me and Bow in our own little world. And then the Alliance happened, and I love all of you guys so much! It’s just...been hard to adjust to sharing him.”

Perfuma nodded, coming to sit in front of Mermista, wordlessly expecting her braiding favors to be returned. “I understand, Glimmer. And thank you for your apology. And, if it makes you feel any better, I’m a lesbian anyway.”

Glimmer blushed even harder if that were possible, as Adora fought to contain her laughter behind her. “I’m such a moron.”

Mermista snorted, jostling Perfuma into a better position. “It’s okay, admitting it is the first step to doing better-” She was cut off by a pillow to the face. “Ow!” She whipped it back at Glimmer, who ducked and let it slam into Adora.

Adora attempted to retaliate, but hit Perfuma, and from there it was an all out war. Feathers were flying in record time, the princesses leaping around the room with energy they really didn’t have after the battle. Mermista couldn’t help her laughter, or the grin that seemed glued to her lips. When was the last time she’d just had fun like this?

The answer was, like, waaaaay too depressing to ponder.

It was as she was ducking a hit from Adora while also trying to nail the back of Frosta’s head that the door creaked open. Mermista had little time to process it, as Perfuma was winding up to fucking decapitate her from across the room, and ducked without thought. The pillow-turned-shotput hurtled through the now open door, and the ensuing scream and crash that followed brought the game to a halt.

“Bow!” Glimmer dropped her weapon and bounded over to her friend. Luckily, the food was in lidded, non-glass containers (Mermista wrinkled her nose briefly- she’d seen the same containers buried in the bottom of the sea floor) and so nothing was spilled or broken. Except for maybe Bow. And the person he’d fallen on top of.

Perfuma gasped, also rushing over. “Oh my gosh! Bow, I am so sorry!” Glimmer hoisted Bow to his feet, and Perfuma leaned down to help up...

“Sea Hawk! Are you alright?”

Sure enough, the pirate was the one who had broken Bow’s fall, and he all too happily took the hand offered to him. “Never better,” he wheezed.

Mermista fought the part of her yelling to go help him, to take him from Perfuma’s arms and into her own. He was doubled over at the moment, even upright, and breathing heavily. After a second, he righted himself, his stage smile in place. “Bow found me on my way to the kitchens and told me you were gathered in here. I hope I’m not intruding.”

Glimmer flapped a hand at him. “Of course not! Come sit down and tell us about the Elberon.” She dragged Bow over to a bean bag chair, snatching the tub of popcorn from him.

Sea Hawk pushed fully into the room, and Mermista realized he hadn’t come empty handed. He held her trident out to her, almost shy. She blinked at him.

“When we set the boat on fire, it was still holding the wheel in place. It fell into the lake when the ship crashed. I figured you’d be wanting it back.”

Mermista didn’t need to turn to hear the collective, whispered ‘awwwwww’ rippling through the group. In fact, she knew instinctively that Perfuma was making That Face she made when she found things unbearably sweet. Calmly, she took the trident, it’s weight familiar and comforting in her hand. She turned it over for damage, knowing there would be none, before resting it against the wall. She nodded to Sea Hawk, being sure to look him in the eyes when she said, “Thank you.”

He smiled at her, bright and proud, as she turned away to go sit. The looks Adora and Glimmer were giving her were so ridiculously smug that she briefly debated turning around and walking out.

Like a magnet, Sea Hawk gravitated to her side, and smiled at her when she scooched over just a smidge on the absurdly large beanbag. She kept her eye on him peripherally, as he lowered himself gingerly into the cushion.

Perfuma sat down on the chair next to Mermista, offering her a pickle spear. She took it, and wordlessly handed it to Sea Hawk. She hated pickles, but he loved them and could probably use the energy.

Frosta leaned forward eagerly, impatient for the man to finish his snack. “Well? What happened? Did we win?”

Sea Hawk nodded as he chewed, the relief washing over the princesses buying him some time to swallow. He leaned forward, and Mermista rolled her eyes when she realized he was about to start narrating.

“It was a battle of slightly less epic proportions than the Battle for Bright Moon, but epic nonetheless! The place: Elberon. The time: Mid-Noon. The sun was starting to lay low in the sky, but it mattered not, as much of the forest around the village was on fire, swarmed with Horde foot soldiers and battle droids.”

Mermista fought back a smirk when she realized that his stupid, deep narrator voice was actually working, the princesses and Bow all leaning in slightly.

“We had no time to prepare, or think. We leapt from the skiffs, and charged into the town! Half the fleet decided to focus on rescue, while the other half attempted to drive out the Horde. They became one and the same, however, when the Horde began focusing on taking over houses as battle forts.”

Glimmer’s eyes widened. “They held people hostage in their own homes?”

Sea Hawk sobered momentarily. “Sometimes.”

The implication hung heavy in the air, Adora looked away in a mixture of grief and shame, angry at her past, furious with the present.

“We started busting into houses to take them on in factions, and claim back the people’s homes. Or, if the cause was lost, we focused on recovering civilians from their homes and getting them to safety. It took us hours to get everyone we could out, between the fighting and the harder people to move.”

Frosta tilted her head. “Harder to move?”

Sea Hawk smiled sadly. “You can only carry so many children and elders at a time. Especially when you always have to have one hand on your sword.”

Glimmer’s eyes were bright. “How did you win? In the end, how did you make it?”

He grinned now. “Actually, it was my idea!”

Mermista couldn’t stop her snort this time.

“Really! We used a spread out attack pattern to herd the majority of the Horde soldier’s into the center of the village. One of the guards here is a sorcerer of great renown, and she managed to grab most of them in a binding spell. From there, we knocked them out, and now they sit awaiting trial.”

Frosta blinked. “That’s it? What a lame ending!”

Sea Hawk gaped as if personally offended. “What more do you want? The details of how I fought off two- no, it was three- horde soldiers one handed? While holding a toddler?”

The ice princess leaned forward. “Yes!”

“Ha! Say less!”

Sea Hawk launched into the tale with more zeal than he had the general report, and the grief in the room faded away with his narration. Reactions varied from eye rolls, smirks of disbelief, polite curiosity, and hungry avarice for the ‘epic tale’. The last was mostly Bow and Frosta, who were eating up Sea Hawk’s words.

Mermista had been only paying attention to the story at minimum, though, as she was more concerned with the way the pirate’s hand hadn’t left his right side. When his breathing started to take on a labored quality, she started brainstorming ways to go to bed. Luckily, Perfuma had always been tactful. When the story was winding down, and the snacks were dwindling, she stretched and yawned audibly.

“I’m terribly sorry, Captain, but could we pick this up over breakfast? I’m exhausted.”

It wasn’t a lie, either. Perfuma had bags under her eyes, bags that Mermista knew she mirrored. The two of them and Frosta had expended more magical energy today with transport and combat than anyone else, bar maybe She-Ra. Everyone nodded, and began rising to their feet. Mermista subtly dragged Sea Hawk up with her, so he wouldn’t hurt himself further.

She wasn’t, like, heartless.

They said their goodnights, hugs and cheek kisses and shoulder claps abounding, before they each set off for their own room. Mermista made sure to grab her beloved weapon on the way out. Eventually, it was just her and Sea Hawk walking in silence through the dark halls. He cleared his throat. “Princess, would you know where my room is? Glimmer forgot to show me before bed.”

Mermista bit the inside of her cheek, debating only for a second before caving into that (evidently) permanently soft, weak part of her. “Yeah, right here.”

She opened the door to her room and pushed inside. She knew he realized where they were when he saw the piles of clothes on the ground she hadn’t bothered to pick up. He drew in a sharp breath. “Princess-”

“It’s fine, Sea Hawk.” She turned to him, searching his eyes. “Isn’t it?”

He seemed to freeze up for a second, and Mermista felt her heart stutter. Did he...did he want to sleep somewhere else? Her brain kicked into overdrive, half of it screaming at her to abort mission, to throw him out, while the other half frantically raced through why he could possibly not want to stay.

With a sinking feeling, she realized the last time they'd really talked, she had yelled at him to essentially leave her the fuck alone, that her life was none of his business. And then she'd had a magical seizure, and then they went to war. So, yeah, it had been a hot minute. Was he really still upset about that? Should he be upset? Did she want him to leave her alone? Obviously, she didn't, but wouldn't it be easier that way, easier to keep him at arm's length for both their sakes?

She felt a migraine coming on.

But then Sea Hawk smiled, and nodded. "I would be honored, Princess."

Something ugly and mean flared in her, illogically angry at the word 'princess'. "Um, did you get hit in the head one too many times today and forget my name?"

"What? No, I just…" He shrugged, and then winced mildly. "I don't want to be disrespectful."

"You never cared before."

He froze again, and she suddenly had the feeling that they were circling a large, proverbial elephant in this room. “Things were different. Before.” A wave rippled over his face, and at once, he looked much much older and more tired than he should have. Mermista’s insides twisted with something like guilt.

She sighed, letting it all go for now. “C’mere. You’re hurt.”

Sea Hawk shook his head. “I’m fine, I’ll be right as rain after some rest-”

“This isn’t a debate,” she said. She jerked her head toward the bed. “Lay down and take your shirt off.”

He mustered the energy to smirk before pushing past her. He sat on the bed with a grunt, kicking off his muddied and bloodied boots. Mermista set her trident against the wall, going over to help him shrug out of his jacket, and his torn, dirty shirt. She couldn’t hold back her sharp inhale, or the hollowed out feeling in her chest at the sight of him.

Where the stun baton had struck him was stark and pale against the rest of him, but warped and charred at the edges too. It was as if he’d been burned, and immediately scarred over. Thin lines of the same pale skin webbed out from the spot, following the path the electricity took through his body. They stopped dangerously close to where his heart was beating. Beneath the burn scar, an ugly purple bruise took up the rest of his side. He’d either broken or severely bruised his ribs. There was a new cut along his pectorals as well, where a blade had obviously caught and sliced. His neck was fine, his jaw bruised as if he’d been punched a few times. There was a still-bleeding cut through his right eyebrow, but it was small.

Her hands were moving of their own accord, tracing the maps of wounds along his body, shaking without her consent. “Sea Hawk…”

“I’m fine, princess, I just need rest-”

She snapped her eyes up to his, glaring him into silence. “Sebastian.”

His eyes fluttered shut, knowing he’d officially lost this game. “I’ve...felt better, if I’m being honest.” He took a labored breath. “But there’s nothing to be done. The biggest issue is my ribs, and there’s no way to heal them quickly.”

“Let me get Adora, she can-”

He grabbed her wrist firmly. “No, please. She’s exhausted, and I’ll be fine. Truth be told, I’m exhausted myself. I really, really want to sleep.”

Mermista frowned. “At least let me wash these out. You’re filthy.”

Sea Hawk nodded. He went to fumble with his belt and pants, but she stopped his hand.

Mermista swallowed harshly, her voice little more than a hoarse whisper. “Let me. Please.”

‘Don’t do this to yourself,’ her mind screamed as she began to undress him. ‘You said it was ending, why are you doing this!’

She’d gotten very good at ignoring the little voice, she found, and pushed it back down into her mind. Carefully, she unwrapped the belt he slung twice around his hips, placing it on the nightstand, before moving to unlace his pants. Why was her mouth so dry? She shimmied them down his hips, letting them crumple on the ground. Her eyes flickered to his when she came to the waistband of his boxer briefs, checking to make sure this was alright. His eyes were wide and dark as he nodded, and she knew his breathing was labored for a different reason now.

EXPLICIT!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!!

He was half hard for her when she discarded his undergarments, and she couldn’t resist palming him gently as she moved to sit alongside him, facing him. Sea Hawk’s eyes fell shut with a groan, head leaning back. Mermista flushed; he was always so vocal in everything he did, and this was no exception.

Gently, she untied his red and black bandanas, running her fingers through his dirty hair. The sight of him completely naked, sprawled before her on the bed, wiped her mind of all reasoning. She raised a hand, calling forth warm water from the taps in the bathroom, and set to work taking care of him.

She rinsed his hair of grime first, before taking clean water and rolling it gently down his body. She made sure it was just hot enough to bite, but not to burn. With one hand she cleaned, washing away the surface layer of sweat and blood and dirt, while the other pumped him lazily. He was fully hard for her now, which was exactly what she needed for this next part.

Fresh water, cooler now, hovered just over his open wounds and his scar. It was going to hurt like hell, cleaning out all the grime she could see in the cuts, but Mermista figured she could temper the agony with some bliss. She lowered the water to his chest at the same time she lowered her mouth to his cock. They descended as one, and Sea Hawk groaned in primal confusion. One hand flew to her hand, his other attempted to get the water away from him. She reached up, and grabbed that hand in hers. He tried to pull away, hissing in pain, until she started moving her head.

Despite her earlier implications and protests, Sea Hawk had been her only lover for the years she'd known him, and she knew she was his as well. They knew exactly what they liked, even if lately that hadn't extended past the bedroom. Mermista hollowed out her cheeks, relaxing her throat to take him as deep as she could. His thigh muscles twitched under her, tensing and relaxing in rhythm. Quietly, she spread the water on his chest further, incorporating the burn.

Sea Hawk jerked, all but yelling as she gently cleaned the warped flesh. In response, she sucked a bit harder, using her tongue to lathe at the sensitive spot just under his head. He gasped, fisting her hair roughly, and Mermista ignored the tears it brought to her eyes. It hurt, but in a way that made her want more. She bobbed her head up and down with more vigor, and moaned when his hips snapped up to meet her. He slid impossibly further down her throat, and Mermista silently thanked whatever deity had decided she didn't need a gag reflex.

In moments, his wounds were clean, and Mermista flicked the dirty water in the vicinity of the bathroom. She'd deal with that later. Right now, Sea Hawk was pulling her off his cock by her hair, and she heaved deep breath in through her lungs.

"Princess-"

She snarled. "Sebastian, seriously?"

"Mermista," he groaned, dragging her up his body. "Please. I want- I need- to be in you."

She nodded, ire already fading, and she reached up to yank off her shirt. She'd forwent a bra, a genius move on her part as he pulled her down to his mouth. She inhaled sharply when he drew a nipple into her mouth, sucking on it until it hardened beneath his tongue. He went to move to the next one, but stopped short with a groan and a muffled curse. Mermista pulled herself away to see him grabbing at his ribs.

“Your ribs...maybe we shouldn’t-”

“I’ll be fine,” he swore. “They’re just bruised. I’ll be okay.”

She worried her bottom lip between her teeth, debating the soundness of his mind. But then she rocked back onto her heels, and his hard length pressed into her core. Her decision was made for her. She sat up, ripping off her bottoms and socks, before straddling his hips. “We’re going to have to be more gentle than usual.”

Sea Hawk was breathing heavily as he gripped her hips with enough strength to bruise. She thrilled at the thought. “I think we’ll manage. Your, erm, blockage spell is in place?”

Mermista snorted. He asked this every time. “Yes, always. Slept with any port wenches I should know about?”

He smirked. “Not without you.”

She barely had time to gape, flushing at his boldness before he was lifting his hips up and pressing against her entrance. Mermista reached down, placing his tip just inside, before lowering herself onto him in one motion.

“Fuck,” Sea Hawk swore, exhaling harshly.

She groaned, leaning back into his lifted knees to help his angle. Not that he ever needed help. He’d been a near master at this from day one. A master at her.

They were both panting as he settled within her, taking the moment to adjust. Mermista had slept with two other people before Sea Hawk, one very nice merchant girl, and one guy from another kingdom. He had not been nearly as endowed as Sebastian was, and she wasn’t sure if she could ever down size at this point. He filled her so completely, it drove her wild in ways she didn’t know were possible. Not that she would ever tell him that; his ego was unbearable enough most days.

As soon as they had both caught their breath, she started rolling her hips gently. Their usual preferences fell on the side of fast and rough, passionate and full of fire. Slow and soft wasn’t typically in their vocabulary, but Mermista was a bit desperate and willing to try anything. She couldn’t remember the last time he was inside her, and that was truly a crime.

The gentle thing seemed to be working out, though, if the sweat shining on Sea Hawk’s chest was anything to go by. He couldn’t lift his hips much to help her, but Mermista was nothing if not creative. Careful to control her force, she lifted herself up gently before dropping softly, grinning at the groan it pulled from his chest. She had found her rhythm in seconds, bouncing on his cock, his hands on her ass for support. The embers burning in her core were starting to catch fire, and restraint was becoming difficult. She attempted to close her eyes to focus on lasting for longer than mere minutes, but it seemed Sebastian had other plans.

Mermista felt two fingers at her mouth, and she took them deep as her eyes snapped open. She held his gaze as she sucked and licked at them, making sure they were soaked before releasing them with an obscene popping sound. Sea Hawk's eyes were blown impossibly wide with arousal, and she grinned at him in a challenge. He took it, like he always did, diving down to run his fingers over her clit at a merciless pace. Mermista's mouth fell open, the sounds coming out of her almost animalistic in their desperation. The fire was not only catching, it was blazing out of control, eating her alive in white heat. She clapped a hand over her mouth, and then her elbow when it wasn't enough. Sea Hawk reached up with his other hand, cupping one heavy breast in his hands, flicking over her nipple roughly. Inside her, he was iron, flexing so close, so fucking *close* to where she needed him.

As if he could read her mind, he dropped his knees a bit, taking her with them, so she was leaning back as far as she could go without losing her support. He flexed his legs outward, spreading her so far it almost hurt. Like lightning striking, his cock found that soft, sensitive bundle of nerves deep within her and she was gone. She bit at her elbow, but it did nothing to stop the sound that came out of her, something between a sob and a scream. Liquid all but gushed out of her, pouring into his lap, dripping down his sex. Mermista's legs were shaking, her walls clenching tighter and tighter around him.

Sea Hawk, silent until now, choked out a very strained, *"Mermista-!"* before she felt him coming deep within her, pulsing and throbbing until finally, she reached the peak she'd been chasing. She came around him, her velvet heat gripping him so harshly he was unable to stop himself from snapping his hips up into her. The shaking spread from her legs to her whole body, sending her mind into a blank. Her trembling muscles were completely unable to support her, and she fell forward, with just enough presence of mind to catch herself before she crushed Sea Hawk's ribs.

But whether it was the shift in angle, or her unrecovered, sensitive nerves being jostled, she found herself at the edge of another peak. Sea Hawk was miraculously still hard inside her, nestled in tight, wet heat that wasn't letting go.

"Sebastian," she whispered, hoarse from her scream. "Please."

She couldn't articulate what she wanted, what she needed from him, but he seemed to know anyway. It was infuriating, how he did that. He reached one hand between her legs, stroking her so feather light, it almost wasn't there. The sensation was maddening, somehow too much to her already shot nerves, and not enough all at once. Her mind was blanking, and she was helpless to hold in her staccato whimpers. She buried her face in his neck, as her moans grew again to sobs. Sea Hawk was panting in her ear, words spilling from him like a waterfall.

"So beautiful, so gorgeous," he grunted. "You're a goddess, Mermista. So beautiful when you come for me." A keening sound was clawing up her throat as that heat began coiling tight all over again. "Come for me, my queen. I know you can." His voice, so deep, so sensual, cut through to her core. "I want to see you come, Mermista, please come-"

They were forehead to forehead now, his breath ghosting over her face. Why did that feel so cold? Why was her face wet? All coherent thought cut off as he sealed his lips to hers, tongue running over hers in the same rhythm he was massaging her clit. He drew back, biting her lower lip as he did.

“Sebastian,” she sobbed. “Please.”

He grinned at her, and it was so full of ardor that she nearly closed her eyes. But she couldn’t not when he was looking at her like that. “Let go, Mermista. Come.”

Maybe it was the fact that he had never commanded her to do anything, ever, especially not in that tone of voice because she would certainly remember that, but something within her snapped loose, and the pressure that had been building in her reached a crescendo. She felt herself flying apart, her body ascending to the fabled stars in his arms, under his fingers, on his cock. He grunted, and she vaguely felt him spill in her again, which only served to push her higher and higher, until she was certain she’d be floating in this ether forever.

He was stroking her hair when she came back down to earth, aftershocks wrecking her body in spasms. Gently, she raised her hips so he could slide out of her, groaning slightly at the new wave of fluids that rushed down her legs as she did.

EXPLICIT OVER!!!!!!!!! :(

Sea Hawk’s eyes were closed, but his grip on her was iron. His chest heaved as he struggled to breath from exertion and probably pain. Mermista slung her leg over and away from his hips, settling alongside him. She tapped at the fingers bruising her waistline, a silent ask to let her go.

He merely grunted, and pulled her impossibly closer. Mermista rolled her eyes. Summoning more water from the bathroom, she made short work of cleaning them and the bed off, leaving behind dry and pristine sheets. She nudged him lightly.

“Do you think you can shift over? Or did we grind your ribs into a fine powder.”

He smiled a bit. “I think I can manage.”

And he did, with a lot of wincing and some harsh swearing. Mermista resettled herself quickly, the chill of the room finally starting to get to her exposed skin. She scowled as she shuffled under the puffy duvet. “Why is Bright Moon so fucking cold all the time?”

Sea Hawk hummed, lifting his right arm in invitation to her. She was too tired to do much more than scowl a little before tucking herself into his side and resting her head on his collarbone. “It’s a northern mountain region, closer to Snows than Salineas is.” He yawned, his jaw cracking concerningly. “The wind chill alone is enough to drop it ten degrees, not to mention it's still early spring, and the air coming off the coast won't be warm for-"

Mermista closed her eyes, hoping he couldn't feel her smiling. His voice was reverberating through his chest, making her brain tingle in the most soothing way. It was easy to forget Sea Hawk was actually a smart man, since he was such a dumbass all the time. Oxymoronic? Maybe. But that was Sea Hawk, an enigma.

Before she dropped off completely though, the thought that had been bothering her since he left for Elberon on the skiff came rushing back at her. "Hey, Sea Hawk?"

His rant about whatever- agriculture, it seemed- cut off. "Yes?"

"Why did you go with the battalion to Elberon?"

She felt his frown near the crown of her head. "Because they needed help?"

"No, like, obviously yeah," she groaned. She hated words. They clogged her throat and slipped through her brain. "But why *you* ? You were hurt, they had enough men. I dunno it seemed...personal?" She drummed her fingers on his chest lightly.

Sea Hawk was silent for a long time. Mermista had picked up early on that he didn't like talking about his youth in Snows, the years before he became a pirate. But sex and exhaustion were making her tongue loose, and her usual patience and respect for his privacy were wobbly at best. At length, he sighed, and when he spoke his voice was softer and quieter than she'd ever heard it.

"I was twelve when the Horde attacked Snows for the first and only time. They weren't prepared for the cold, or the sheer size of the population capable of fighting back, so the Seige lasted all of a weekend, practically. But it was bloody, and violent."

Mermista nodded. She knew this, everyone knew how Frosta had lost her fathers and came into her full power so young.

"They made right for the castle, and the capital city. When they realized they weren't going to be able to get into the castle proper very easily, they started raiding the city. And when that ran dry, they moved outward to the port villages."

Mermista watched him swallow, tracked the swell of his throat as it worked. "You lived in a port village?"

"Yeah," he whispered. "Innshe. It was nearest to the capital, where all the goods and mail came in that went right to the castle. The day the Horde raided our town, I was out on the water with some other kids from the village. We were fishing, trying to catch more food for the relief efforts that were going to be sent to the city. Then we started to hear the screaming, the gun fire, the explosions. By the time we got back, Innshe was entirely under siege.

The Horde was going home to home, raiding homes for supplies, prisoners, information. And if they couldn't find any, they set it on fire. When I got back home…" He trailed off, remaining silent for so long Mermista began to assume he'd drifted to sleep. But he shook himself from whatever haze he was in, and pressed on. "It was too late. My home was gone. On fire. I tried to run in, I could hear her in there, but the roof caved in, and the explosion pushed me back."

"Who?" Mermista didn't want to know, but she had to.

"My mother."

She nodded, knowing too well the particular brand of pain losing a mother caused. "And your father?"

Sea Hawk snorted, derisive. "Never knew him. He left my mother before I was born. Stars willing, he died a long time ago."

Mermista didn't really know what to say to that, to the uncharacteristic vitriol coming from him, so she just nodded again. They lapsed into silence, before Sea Hawk sighed and finished his story. "Come morning, the Horde had razed the town to ashes. Those who weren't dead were prisoners, or on the run. The surviving children younger than ten were taken as recruits, I assume. I didn’t know what to do. That’s when Bill found me, lying in the dirty snow. He was a sailor from another town who’d come to help when he saw the smoke. He picked me up, dusted me off, and gave me an offer. Said I could try to stick it out on my own, or I could go with him, work on his trade ship as a deckhand. Winter was coming, and I had no food or shelter or family, so it was a no brainer. We received word of the insurgence’s defeat, and the Kings’ death, just before we cast off.”

Mermista adjusted slightly to look at him. “So that’s why you went today?”

Sea Hawk shrugged with his good shoulder. “I couldn’t stomach not going, not when there was the potential for another kid to end up like me. Like so many of us did.”

She was struck then, square in the chest, by the realization that Sea Hawk was a much, much better person than she was. He would argue, say that wasn’t true, that they were equally invested in the war for different reasons. And maybe that was true. But she hadn’t even considered going with the battalion today, aiding the civilians on foot and in person. Self-loathing, hot and nauseating, bubbled up, manifesting in her usual blank stare. She nodded, and pressed a light kiss to his shoulder, before mumbling something- maybe a good night, or a reassurance, she wasn’t really in the driver’s seat of her brain at the moment- before rolling over.

She heard him drop to sleep quickly, exhausted from an entire day of exertion. She, on the other hand, was not so lucky. It took her hours to drop off, and when she did, her dreams were plagued by images of a crumbling Sea Gate, scorn on the faces of her people, her father’s eyes- smug and hateful and vindicated. And her mother, as beautiful and regal as the day she died, disappointment radiating from her. She was calling out to them, reaching for help, but Mermista was chained to the throne with pearly manacles, forced to watch them all walk away.

Chapter End Notes

It’s a slippery slope into Bad Times from here y’all.

Tell Me That You’ve Had Enough

Chapter Summary

> It’s easy to go downhill when you never had your footing in the first place.

Chapter Notes

> I’m so sorry I completely just lost track of my posting schedule. Holidays huh? I’m also working on a short, silly seamista Christmas story that plays like a hallmark movie.
>
> This and next chapter were all one doc but it’s huuuuge so we breaking it up.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When Sea Hawk woke the morning after the battle, he was alone in the guest room. Disappointment and hurt, and maybe even a bit of anger, warred in his chest, before he tamped them all down. Mermista was a monarch, and they were well and truly at war now. She had much more important things to do than wait for him to wake up.

And, as it turned out, so did he.

When he finally stumbled upon Bow’s familiar face, he was taken immediately to the Alliance’s war council room. He had barely taken his seat before the Queen was interrogating him, asking his opinion on supply routes for allied regions, Horde activity on the open sea, the general temperature of “unaffiliated sailors”, so on and so forth. Sea Hawk’s head was spinning.

The Queen was an intense woman, and Sea Hawk had immense respect for her, so he tried to keep his answers as straightforward as possible. After a while, she nodded, almost to herself, before regarding the projections on the war table. He remained standing at a loose attention - he was a pirate, not a trained soldier, cut him a bit of slack - all too aware of the Alliance's eyes on him. He tried not to overthink it, or focus on the fact that he knew they all saw him as an extension, a reflection, of Mermista. A notion that he knew she was hyper vigilant of, and resented immensely as he was "like, a total buttmonkey". Her words.

Queen Angella nodded again, before turning to him. "Captain Sea Hawk."

He straightened up. "Your Grace."

Her eyes softened, and her mouth may have smiled a bit. "I know it's not your usual...style. But, I would like to commission you for Bright Moon's navy. I am in need of a captain who has first hand experience dealing with the Horde, and getting people and supplies around them. If this Alliance is to work, we will need control of the ocean routes. You will be paid in full, of course, a salary reflective of your position and experience."

Sea Hawk was already nodding. "It would be an honor, your majesty."

"The journeys will be long and treacherous. You will see combat, and no small amount I suspect. As you know, Bright Moon's navy is small, so you’ll be working almost around the clock for us. Are those amenable conditions?”

He grinned a bit. “I assure you, ma’am, it already sounds much nicer than working on some of the ships I have. Even the best pirate is still a pirate.”

Angella did smile at that. “Well put, Captain. In that case, you ship off today. My guard will escort you to the docks after She-Ra is through healing your ribs.”

He smiled wryly. Guess he wasn’t doing as good a job hiding that as he thought. Adora stood, clapping him on the shoulder before they set off for the kitchens. He tried to catch Mermista’s eye as he left, but she didn’t look up from where she was going over some report with Perfuma.

No matter. He’d see her in a few weeks.

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Those few weeks turned out to be closer to a month and a half. Sea Hawk had spent his duration as captain of the *Sky Dancer* running between Bright Moon, Salineas, and Snows in an official capacity, moving squadrons of rebels, food, medical supplies, weapons, and whatever else the rebellion needed. They’d even gone sky-side a few times, docking at Mystacor to retrieve sorcerers or magical supplies for the kingdoms.

In his almost-twelve years as a sailing man, he'd never been so exhausted. He'd also never been so respected. It was a weird feeling, people actually looking to him for direction. He'd become captain and immediately lost his entire crew, so it was a new experience all around. Many of the sailors on board were young - fresh out of training. A few were saltier sea dogs, not unlike Bill and N'Davi, come out of retirement to fight for their homes. Sea Hawk may have been the captain, but those men had all of his respect.

They returned to Bright Moon whole and hale, but utterly exhausted. He was so wiped, he didn't even notice the ice and snow still caking the Whispering Woods. The palace was practically empty upon his arrival, the war room only seating the queen when he entered.

He bowed low. "Your Majesty."

"Captain Sea Hawk." She nodded. "How fare you and the seas?"

Sea Hawk gave his report as succinctly as possible, and was doing a fantastic job of not yawning right in the immortal angel's face. Major brownie points, in his opinion. He was just getting to the Horde sightings when the doors to the councilroom banged open, letting in a blast of cold air and an armada of disgruntled princesses. And Bow.

“Uuuughhh!” Glimmer dragged her hand down her face. “Nothing is working! The stupid forest is still stupid frozen and we can’t stupid fix it!”

Perfuma brushed snow from her hair. “I still think we need to work toward a more harmonious solution-”

“Perfuma.” Bow’s sigh was beleaguered, as if he’d had this argument already today. “Harmonious anything won’t work as long as those bots keep- Sea Hawk!”

Adora blinked. “The bots have Sea Hawk?”

“What- no!”

“Hey there crew!” he called, laughing at Adora’s gasp of realization. “How’s it sailing?”

Bow bounded across the room, catching him in back-thumping hug. Adora offered a hand, which he clasped lightly in greeting. Glimmer smiled, but it was strained, patting his shoulder as she passed to go argue with her mom. Privately, Sea Hawk was relieved. Maybe the queen would dismiss him and he could go-

“Oh, hey.”

Not sleep. He could go Not Sleep, as the deadpan voice that greeted him sliced through his exhaustion, clear through to his heart. He whirled around with a grin.

“Mermista!” She looked as tired as the rest of them, bags under her eyes and trident hanging loosely at her side. He broke away from Bow, nodding to Perfuma and Frosta as he crossed the room to his princess. “I’ve dreamed of you-”

“Night and day, yeah I know.” She dismissed him with a flick of her eyes toward the ceiling. “Why are you here?”

Ouch. Still, not her coldest greeting. “My ship-”

“Ugh, did you set it on fire?”

“No!” he scowled. “Our route ended, and we’re on shore leave for two days. We need to switch out some crew, we have a few injuries. Not to mention a resupply-”

“Uh huuuuuuh,” she droned, looking past him entirely. “So like, are you done in here ‘cause we kinda need to brief the queen.”

Sea Hawk’s mood had gone from over it, to elated, to absolutely over it with a side of fuck this. He opened his mouth, not really sure what he was going to say but reasonably certain it was going to be incendiary and very rude, only to be interrupted by the queen.

“Captain Sea Hawk?”

“Yes, ma’am?” He whirled, turning his back to Mermista abruptly. The act made him bizarrely anxious.

“Is there much more of your report left?”

“Just the Horde fleet patterns, and then the resupply and crew staffing lists.”

She nodded. “Shall we continue tomorrow morning? I think you’re due some rest in a proper bed.”

Did her eyes...did she look at Mermista? He was going to pay hell later if she had. He swallowed. “Yes, your grace. Thank you. Good night, princesses.”

He bowed, turning again. He met Mermista’s eyes briefly, and there was definitely...something there. He couldn’t tell if it was anger, annoyance, or something else. And frankly, he was too tired to care. He strode from the room without another glance, allowing the guard who’d taken him to escort him to his room.

It was hours later, in the middle of a dead sleep, that cold feet pressing into his calves woke him with a start. He whirled around, half-fumbling for his sword at the edge of the bed, when blue hair and lavender perfume filled his senses. Sea Hawk settled, regarding Mermista with wary, sleepy eyes.

She stared back, her amber gaze intense, almost electric. The tension that had started in the councilroom was still there, but now it was laced with something else. She shifted closer to him, wrapping a manicured hand around the back of his neck and pulling his lips down to hers. His sleep-addled brain was struggling to make heads or tails of any of this, to formulate a single thought.

Her hand dipped below the waistband of his sweatpants, and he decided that critical thinking could wait for morning.

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She was gone when he woke up, and the hurt and anger from yesterday’s greeting came surging back, just a bit stronger. He sighed through his nose, taking the time to ground himself, and push the negative feelings away. Perfuma would be proud, he snorted.

When he stepped out of the room, an escort was waiting. “Her Majesty and the Alliance are taking breakfast on the grand terrace. She requests your presence to finish your report.”

He nodded, scooping up his jacket with the lists tucked in the inner pockets. Also, it was still freezing in Bright Moon thanks to the snow in the Woods, and while he wasn't chilly, he knew someone else who might be.

When he arrived, he bowed to the queen and the princesses, before lowering himself into the empty chair between Bow and Mermista. The tiny, petty part of him that was angry refused to acknowledge her in anything other than an official capacity, while he greeted Bow with a clap on the shoulder.

"Sea Hawk!" The younger man grinned. "You look much better this morning than you did yesterday."

He couldn't help but laugh. "Yes, the sea isn't always as loving to her sailors as they are to her," he mused. Mermista tensed beside him, fork scraping slightly as she missed the piece of melon on her plate. "But I'm right as rain, now, and ready to go on another adventure!"

Bow leaned in, stars in his eyes. "Did you see any Horde ships? Did you fight any? Loot them?!"

Sea Hawk cleared his throat, all too aware of the queen staring at him. "I'm not pirating on behalf of Bright Moon, lad, just running transport. But yes, there were a few engagements with the Horde!" He leaned into his chair, stroking his mustache. He grimaced. He'd need a trim and shave before they pushed off tomorrow. “Nothing old Sea Hawk and his crew couldn’t handle, though, I assure you.”

“How many bots did you punch?” Frosta was leaning across the table, practically standing on her chair. “Like, twenty?”

He chuckled, nodding to the server who deposited a pile of eggs, fresh cooked meat, and steaming fried potatoes on his plate. “No bots on the open sea, lass- erm, your highness.” He flushed at his gaff, feeling Mermista’s glare on the side of his head, but Frosta didn’t waver. “We crossed paths with a resupply ship heading to the Fright Zone, and a battalion leaving it. Not at the same time.”

The queen shifted. “Did you engage?”

They hadn’t reached this part of the briefing yet. “Not the resupply ship. But the war vessel fired at us first, and we had little choice but to fight back. The *Sky Dancer* is fast, but not that fast.” She nodded at him to go on, and Sea Hawk became aware of his royal audience, all five princesses staring at him with interest. “We saw them steaming toward us just as the dawn light was rising. There was no time to escape, so I sent the crew to their battle stations, and started evasive maneuvers. A good thing, too, since they fired on us within the minute.”

Bow gasped, and Frosta leaned impossibly forward, despite Perfuma tugging at her tunic in an attempt to get her seated again. “Did they blow a hole in the ship?!”

“Ha! You’ve gotta be smarter than the Horde to get one over on me!” He smirked. “I turned her enough that the laser cannon’s shot glanced the hull. There’s a scorch mark, but no loss in integrity, I assure you.” He nodded to Angella. “So, with the momentum, I lined us up to face them, and raised the mainsail and jib. My initial goal was to rush them and make sure they couldn’t turn the turrets fast enough to nail us so we could make our escape. But one of them saw it coming.”

A gasp rippled around, everyone leaning in now. Even Mermista had put her fork down, eyes on him while he narrated.

“Two soldiers, one with a face like an octopus, and the other a very scrawny young lad, poor thing-”

“Octavia and Kyle,” Adora scowled. “Does she still have a dumb face?”

“The dumbest.” He nodded solemnly. Adora nodded back. “They already had a turret lined up to fire at us. So, I gave the order to fire off the portside, and as luck would have it, we managed to hit them before they hit us.”

Glimmer was vibrating. “Did the other ship go down?”

Sea Hawk frowned. “Not that I could see. My goal was to get the crew out of the situation, not stick around and keep firing.”

The sparkling princess scowled. “Why not! You had them right there, you could’ve taken them out.”

He scowled back. “There are codes, your highness. Not to mention we were a merchant vessel. Combat isn’t permitted under naval law unless in self-defense. To have taken it further would have been to break the law.”

“You’re a pirate!” Glimmer shouted, exasperated.

He clenched his jaw, suddenly feeling very awkward. He was by no means unaware of his status. How could he be? But having it tossed in his face for leverage was making him feel like a sore thumb. Before he could speak though, Mermista swooped in.

“Glim, there are still, like, codes and sh- such.” She glanced at the queen, who was thankfully too busy glaring at her daughter. “If we started offering no quarter, we’d be just as bad as the Horde.” She paused, considering. “Actually, we’d be worse.”

“Glimmah!” The queen’s voice was clipped. “That’s quite enough. Furthermore, pirate or not, Sea Hawk is currently a Captain for our navy. He behaved amenably.”

Sea Hawk flushed, eyes on his plate. At a loss for what to do, he reached into his jacket and produced his lists. “Right, well. These are the observed routes of the Horde vessels we saw, the supply lists from the pickups and dropoffs, as well the items we need for resupply, and a list of positions we need filled before tomorrow.”

The queen took them, looking them over with interest, while he set about finishing his breakfast as quickly as possible and not making eye contact. He was under the distinct impression that he had screwed up, if Mermista’s tense body and Bow’s frown were anything to go by. It didn’t matter that he was right- Glimmer was a princess. She outranked him, and besides all that, she had a point. He was a pirate. Maybe he had a shiny new ship and pretty badge at the moment. But he was no kingdom’s errand boy. He had wanted to go back, had wanted to sink their ship and fish the survivors out of the sea to be interrogated and arrested. But he couldn’t, because he was on a leash.

His plate was empty, but his head was full and racing, spinning around him. The conversation that had resumed sounded far away and underwater. Why was it so hard to breathe? He was on a balcony.

Sea Hawk pushed his chair back abruptly, skirting a hasty bow to the table he couldn’t even see through his tunnelling vision, and all but fled up the stairs and into the castle. He needed air. He needed out of these walls, this palace, the rope around his neck, chaining him here to this palace, to this kingdom who he didn’t serve, who hadn’t earned his respect-

His feet had carried him to his room without thought. In a fugue, he tossed his freshly laundered garments (compliments of the castle) in his rucksack, arranging them hastily around the trinkets already in there. Trinkets- wait-

Sea Hawk scooped out the loosely wrapped parcels he'd picked up in Snows. A necklace he'd seen at the port markets, and crystallized flower, preserved forever in delicate, unmelting ice. He considered the box, swallowing around the sudden lump in his throat. Would she even want them? She didn't seem to want much to do with him at the moment.

He frowned. 'It matters not,' he thought. 'I bought them with her in my heart.'

He left them on the bed, on top of the nightstand where her trident still rested, forgotten in her…haste that morning, he supposed. Bitter bile swam in his throat. He glanced around the room, taking in the ornate furniture, fine bedding, rich colors and metals, and was suddenly mired in the feeling of having overstayed his welcome.

He nodded to himself. There was much to do on the boat before departure the next morning. No reason to dally here, where he was only tolerated for his...use. In a flash, he was pushing through the doors and striding out of the castle, into the courtyard, and through the castle village. He was at the docks within the hour, and the brisk, salted air that whipped at his face was a balm. His swirling thoughts, and the torrents of emotion they dragged with them, abated slightly.

Sea Hawk belonged here, working and sailing and being generally useful. He fit here. He made sense here, no matter the circumstances. This was for the best.

With a shake of his head, like a dog swatting away fleas, he climbed aboard his ship and set to make preparations.

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Mermista spent the next few hours oscillating between indifference, frustration, and a mild but righteous fury. How dare Glimmer talk to him like that? Like- like -

Like you do?

She repressed the stab of guilt. It was different with them. She knew that. He knew that. They had an understanding. And besides, she was working on...untangling the understanding. Untangling them from one another. Last night was another shining moment of her ever-present weakness, but, like, he'd looked so tired and sad after their little talk in the war council.

Mermista hadn't meant to be so rude. Well, she had. But, she hadn't meant to interrupt him like that. He just never. Stopped. Talking.

Ever.

Really, how could he be so unaware of it? He just went on and on, even when people had stopped listening eons ago, or were giving him the most annoyed looks. He just didn't care. How could he not care? She cared, especially because, for some reason, after a while, those looks started coming *her* way. Like she was somehow in control of him, or responsible for him. Like they were *together* . She hated it. `

Hence her current mood.

After Sea Hawk had abruptly left the patio, Queen Angella had really leaned into Glimmer for her insensitivity toward social decorum regarding class, or whatever. Mermista tuned out after a minute, years of practice ignoring her dad kicking in without thought. But she was all too aware of the glares Glimmer was shooting her, and the questioning looks from Perfuma and Bow. Like what had happened was supposed to impact her somehow.

After breakfast was another war council meeting, drafting up yet another strike plan toward the amassing Horde bot presence in the Whispering Woods. Then a meeting with her own advisors from Salineas, who had arrived that morning. She had to return to the throne within the month, having already spent too much time trying to help out Bright Moon. In the meantime, she gave verdicts, voiced opinions, and made decisions regarding resource allocation, defense strategies for the open sea, and on and on and on.

Salineas obviously had the best navy in Etheria. And they were also the only navy currently engaging the Horde in open combat. She scowled to herself; where was Bright Moon now? She'd been here for a month and a half, as a member of the Alliance, and so far the only kingdom reaping the united benefits was Bright Moon. Maybe also Plumeria, but not even. They were keeping their crops from blight, and that was just barely.

Once again, she pondered if her father had been right about this as well.

Finally, at around five, she dismissed her council delegation to dinner, with every plan of retiring to her rooms for a bath and wine. Bright Moon had awesome wine, being so close to Plumeria. She warred with herself as she walked, before caving and detouring to Sea Hawk’s room. There was plenty of distance between them now, him pushing off again tomorrow. What was so wrong with two out of thirty nights spent in his bed?

She knocked, waiting, and then knocked again, louder. Strangely enough, there were no escorts stationed outside his room. If he were in there, his escort should be here. Frowning, she pushed open the door, and hated herself for the way her heart plummeted into her stomach.

Any trace of him was gone. Clothes, sword, boots, even the weird assemblage of good luck charms he kept in his pocket at all times, or on the nightstand when he slept, all gone. Mermista closed the door behind her softly, looking around the room as if he might jump out of thin air, grinning wildly and laughing for having gotten one over on her.

But there was no grin, no loud booming laugh. No sparkling mahogany eyes, no stupidly handsome mustache. No Sea Hawk.

She sighed heavily, eyes falling to rest on her trident. She hadn't even meant to leave it here, but she'd woken up pleasantly sore, sweaty, and late for the Alliance breakfast, and had scrambled out of his arms in her haste.

Mermista's thoughts stuttered to a halt as her eyes fell on the wooden box sitting next to her trident. Her heart thumped loudly, already knowing what it was; he'd never not brought her some trinket or gift from his travels, no matter how far or near. She walked over, picking it up carefully as if it might explode. The twine string and bow slid off with ease, and she couldn't help but gasp softly as the lid came off.

A necklace, clearly from Snows. It was plain, made of woven grey and white lace studded with tiny fractals of blue gems, light and dark alike. There was a circular gold painted emblem in the middle, stamped with a foreign symbol. It wasn't regal, or fine, or even that expensive. But it was perfect, and she loved it. She always loved it.

Next to it in the box was a frozen flower, encased in crystalled ice that she knew was enchanted to never melt. He'd brought her these before, and she kept them on her bookshelves, vanity, and nightstand. Or on the tables of her balcony. He'd brought her dozens, and would bring her dozens more.

Would he ?

Of course he would.

But I thought we were trying to, like, untangle? Why would he bring you gifts if you're aiming to drop him on his ass?

It wasn't like that- it was for both of their own goods!

You cannot have this both ways.

She knew that. She did. Mermista took a deep breath, willing away the moisture that had gathered in the corners of her eyes, making them burn when she blinked. She carefully replaced the necklace and flower within the box, tucking them into the slim pocket along the leg of her pants. She scooped up her trident, drawing strength from its weight, the feeling of power and purpose it gave her.

Sea Hawk had left without saying goodbye. That was fine. It was for the best, even. He'd done it before, and would no doubt have to do it again. They weren't kids anymore, if they ever were in the first place.

It was time to get serious.

She strode from the room, deposited the necklace and flower in her chambers, and moved on to her next set of meetings, pushing the pirate captain far from her mind.

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter by Friday!

one last time

Chapter Summary

> Shore leave shenanigans; with the threat of all that's brewing below the surface, the young rulers still find some time to unwind

Chapter Notes

> Second part! warning for drinking, but I've decided they're all of age (except frosta). Language, mentions of sex, piercings, y'know. Young adult stuff.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Not far enough, apparently, as two weeks later, Sea Hawk was once again afoot in Bright Moon Castle. Apparently he'd set a fleet ship on fire and was now in a hearing with the queen and some other sailors going through what happened. As soon as she heard the news, Mermista had every urge to jump off the balcony of her room into the shallow lake and sprint for the open seas, followed by anger, and then embarrassment. All of this on top of the incredibly tense strategy meeting she was currently in for her own kingdom made her want to tie a heavy rock to her fins and let the tide take her.

"Your majesty." One of her generals grit his teeth. "We simply do not have the resources to protect the small towns on the Shoals right now. We need to be concentrating our efforts around the capitol-"

"Why?" she challenged, leaning back into his face. Their hands were planted on the tables, their shoulders squared off with frustration at one another. “Because that’s where we collect the most taxes from?

He spluttered. “What- no! I would never imply-!”

“Oh we’re well past implication,” she snarled. “No town in our kingdom is less deserving of protection than any other. And the Shoal towns harbor most of our fishing fleets, anyway. So unless you want to cope with, like, a vastly diminished source of food on top of an invasion, I suggest you move these three ships to the Shoals. Especially since I have it on good authority that the captains of these ships have been seen in the bars more often than their quarters.”

The general clenched his jaw, before nodding stiffly and sitting down. Mermista feigned boredom as she gestured to the next speaker, but internally she was a tight ball of nerves. The general… General Hache, or something like that...was extremely politically powerful in Salineas, and had been well liked by her father. He’d hated her from the moment she took the throne, and genuinely, Mermista wouldn’t be shocked if he was at the forefront of any coup.

She swallowed her anxiety, and focused on the next speaker; Ambassador Sunye, from the inland village where the metals they got from Dryl were forged into beautiful weapons. Sunye was a small, soft spoken individual who had never shown Mermista anything but kindness. She gladly yielded the floor to them, and their report on weapons supplies for the front lines.

The report meandered, no news being good news, before another counselor took the floor, and another and another. All the while, Mermista felt like she was crawling out of her skin, like the walls were too close, and then too big. The room was getting brighter and then darker, and her breathing had stopped being regular about twenty minutes ago. Not that this was visible. Mermista had learned to completely hide her panic attacks by eight.

At long, long last, the meeting concluded with little agreement reached. The only thing of unanimous decision was that Mermista was needed back in Salineas within the next two weeks. Personally, she couldn't be happier. Bright Moon was nice, gorgeous even, but it wasn't home. It wasn't her open, airy castle and the loud city market stalls and the clanging bells and shouting of the harbor, all backdropped by the sights, sounds, and smells of the beautiful ocean. Mermista wanted to go home.

She pushed her way from the meeting with every intention of heading to her rooms to grab a long soak and then maybe try to make a dent in her latest Mer-Mysteries book. As she rounded the corner, though, her hopes were thoroughly dashed by the sight of a long leather great coat and worn, gold tipped boots.

"Nice coat," she drawled. Sea Hawk swung around to face her, and she hated the way his eyes lit up when they met hers. But, she hated it more that he didn't smile, and that the light in his eyes dimmed very quickly. Oh, yeah. Things were weird. She'd almost forgotten. "Did the Queen give you a commendation for property damage?"

Sea Hawk smirked a bit, the dimple on his right cheek winking. "Something like that. It was actually an incredible tale-"

Mermista brushed past him. “Save it, please. I really, really don’t have the patience right now.”

“Oh...okay,” He always sounded like such a kicked puppy when she wouldn’t entertain his obvious bullshit, it pierced her chest with guilt and frustration. “Are you going to the balcony thing later?”

He was keeping stride with her, despite his apparent lack of joy at seeing her. Whatever. “Balcony thing? I have no idea what you’re talking about.” Her brain was pulsing behind her eyes.

“Bow said that the Alliance was doing drinks on the balcony later. He said he mentioned it to everyone-”

“Yeah, well, I’ve been in meetings all day.” Mermista pushed her door open with no small amount of force, a dark satisfaction curling in her at the way it banged against the wall. “Dealing with, like, actual shit of importance. Trade routes, frontlines, allocations- y’know, all the war stuff that isn’t punching Horde bots till they stop moving?” She whipped her top off and threw it to the far side of the room. Her soak was out of the question, but she was at least going to change into something that wasn’t armor. “We can’t all be gallivanting around the woods playing hero while our mommies keep the kingdom operating.”

Oof, that might have been showing her hand a bit too much. With a frustrated groan, she yanked a soft cotton shirt over her head before discarding her leggings. She knew if she turned around, Sea Hawk was going to be giving her that Look, and she didn't want to deal with it.

"Bad day?" was all he said as she rooted in her drawers for sweatpants. Mermista faltered at the softness there, at the gentility she hadn't heard from him in months.

"Yeah," was all she said. She turned to him at last, dressed, only to find there was no Look. In fact, Sea Hawk was staring out the window. His coat was hung up on the peg by the door, leaving just cotton boob-window shirt and pants. The boots had disappeared as well.

Mermista was suddenly gripped by a surge of anger, acute and spiteful. So she'd just been complaining to his back the whole time? He couldn't even be bothered to look at her while she fought off a panic attack? Fine. Whatever. It was *fine.* "When are drinks?"

"An hour." He turned then, expression guarded and closed off. She knew then that she must have imagined the kindness in his voice a moment ago. Clearly, whatever had been eating him from last visit was still festering between them. Mermista felt as though a chasm, not a few feet of tile, laid between them, and her chest ached.

She'd wanted to get some distance between them, for both their sakes, but maybe she hadn't fully prepared herself for what that would look like. Mentally, she kicked herself. What had she expected? A peaceful drift? She loved him, even if the thought made her stomach grow razor blades in place of butterflies now. This was always going to happen. This would always happen, for as long as she loved.

The room was caving in, faster this time. Her breathing was speeding up beyond her ability to hide, and her vision was starting to tunnel. In a desperate attempt to save herself, she turned away. “Fine, okay. I’ll see you then.”

“Princess-”

“Just leave, please.”

“Mermista-”

“GET OUT!”

Her yell echoed sharply around the room and in her ears, making her head throb even more. She wasn’t sure what happened next, only that the door slammed shut within a few seconds of her shout, and that she was alone. Just like she was supposed to be.

Mermista crumpled to the floor, curling in on herself, and tried to remember the breathing exercises Perfuma had taught her as a kid. They must have started working at some point, or she simply passed out, because when she next raised her head, it was pitch black out, and someone was knocking on her door.

“Mermista?” It was Glimmer. “Are you coming?”

“Uh, yeah.” She winced at how her voice crackled, like glass being dragged over stone. This was why she didn’t yell. “Just give me a sec, I fell asleep.”

There was a giggle. Perfuma. “Why am I not surprised? C’mon sleepyhead! I brought the good wine.”

That did entice her. She pulled some water from the pipes in the bathroom and mopped up her face quickly, pulling off any tears as she did. She kicked on some slippers, and was still trying to bun her hair when she opened the door. It looked like they were going as a pack, collecting princesses along the way. The last was Frosta, who was allowed to come but not drink.

Mermista fell into step between Sea Hawk and Perfuma, who were having a passionate conversation about growing spirits, specifically the growing of the crops used in them, and which area’s spirits tasted the best. Perfuma was, of course, lobbying for Plumeria’s sweet floral wine, while Sea Hawk was adamant that the vodka made in Snows was as good as it got.

When they paused outside Frosta’s door, Perfuma turned to her. “Mermista what do you think?”

Hair finally up and out of her face, she froze. “Uh, about what?”

“Which kingdom has the best drinks?”

“Salineas, duh.”

“Nooo!” they both groaned. She turned her glare on Sea Hawk.

“You love the drink in Salineas!”

“Sure,” he said with a shrug, “but they’re not Snows vodka.”

“Uh, yeah, because our rum is way better than that paint thinner you call vodka.”

“Paint thinner!” Sea Hawk gaped, while Perfuma snorted. “We’ll see about that.”

“Huh?”

He grinned at her, producing a glass bottle of clear liquid from his inner pockets. “I come bearing gifts, as I always do,” he preened. “Everyone can try and we can put it to a vote.”

Frosta dropped back to walk with them. “Everyone?”

“No,” they chorused. The young princess hung her head and sighed.

“Being the baby sucks.”

Perfuma gasped. “Language!”

Mermista and Sea Hawk laughed, falling into step beside each other as Perfuma moved to lecture Frosta on decorum. They locked eyes as their mirth faded, and that swamp between them opened up again.

“Uh, hey.” She tucked a strand of hair behind her ear.

“Hi.” He smiled at her, but it was strained, his voice clipped. Mermista wilted inside. Sea Hawk was mad at her; she’d seen him genuinely pissed enough to know the signs.

“Look, about before-”

She was cut off by the doors to the balcony being tossed open, and everyone surging forward to flop into a seat. It was a gorgeous little spot, not massive like the courtyard balconies, but not small like the one attached to her own guest room. There was space enough for two large couches, a large hanging chair stuffed with cushions, two overly plushy papasan chairs, and cushions strewn along the ground. With the door shut, the bright castle lamps were muffled, and the space was lit by soft, warm string lights placed carefully around the space. It shone delicately on the greenery, and Perfuma cooed in awe before running over to caress a fern.

Mermista made a beeline for the massive swinging chair, her inner child delighting at the novel feeling of burrowing into a floating nest. There was more than enough room for another, and she looked to Sea Hawk. He stared back at her, but he hesitated, and in that moment, Bow clapped a hand to his back. "Couch, man?"

Sea Hawk lit up like a beacon, grinning at the younger boy. "Certainly!"

Suddenly, the swinging chair felt far too big. Mermista hugged a pillow to her stomach, feeling that same lonely, crushing wave start to overtake her, before Perfuma jumped up to sit next to her. The older princess smiled softly at her. "Mind if I join you? It can be like a little girl's night in here!"

Mermista couldn't help but smile. "Sure. But only if I can have some subpar wine."

Perfuma faked a gasp of offense. "Rude!" She pinched Mermista's side, eliciting an embarrassing yelp. "But yes, always."

Drinks were passed around to all but Frosta, who was given juice and only rolled her eyes about it a little. Mermista sat back, cuddling into Perfuma like they did when they were goofy preteens, giggling and gossiping under their breaths about anything and everything, at sleepovers after stuffy parties. They chimed in when someone called them, before dissolving into giggles again.

In between stories and scandals, Mermsita kept sneaking glances at Sea Hawk. He was sat next to Bow on the couch, and it was actually hilarious how much the young archer was imprinting on the pirate. They leaned over the same way, listening intently to some story Netossa was telling, elbows on their knees, glass gripped loosely as it hung between their legs. Mermsita knew Bow was mimicking Sea Hawk, though, because that was how he always sat when they would drink on her balcony in Salineas.

Was she bothered by Bow’s crush? Not really. But it wasn’t making her feel, like, wonderful at the moment, especially considering the rough time she and her...not-boyfriend have been having lately.

More often though, she focused on Sea Hawk himself.

She often felt that there were two of him in one body. There was Sea Hawk, the shanty-singing pyromaniac who was allergic to silence. He couldn’t go more than ten minutes sitting still, especially in a group setting like this. Even now, his legs were bouncing, and when he chimed in, his hands gesticulated wildly. And that wasn’t even mentioning his voice. Tonight, it was carrying strangely; his laughter was a bit too hard, volume a bit too loud. Mermista had always likened it to a performance. Sea Hawk was always putting on a show, performing for an audience and enticing them to like him.

But when it was just them, he couldn't have been more different. The side of him that she referred to as 'just Sebastian' in her head. He was still a raving madman, an unstoppable ball of energy, when they were alone. That was just who he was. But he was softer, tempered like the tide and less like a hurricane. His laughter was genuine, and he smiled more with his eyes. Sebastian could sit still with her, lay his head in her lap and just listen without speaking for a while. When he sang to her and her alone, his voice was heartstopping; crooning and deep and full of ardor and romance. She could roll her eyes all she wanted, they both knew she loved it.

She had always assumed Sebastian was his true self. But now, looking at him laughing with Bow and Netossa, and considering his earlier attitude, she found herself doubting that for the first time. Was it just an act, how he was around her? A weird ruse to endear her to him, just like she assumed his Sea Hawk-ier side was now?

"Guys," Glimmer whispered from next to Spinnerella. "Frosta's totally knocked out. Want to play a game?"

"Oh!" Perfuma bolted upright next to her, jostling Mermista. "I love games. What game?"

"Truth or dare?"

Netossa waved a hand. “Nah, nothing to win. What about Never Have I Ever? Put a finger down, take a shot of Sea Hawk’s vodka.”

“We will literally die,” Mermista deadpanned.

Sea Hawk backed her up. “Yes, a sip might be better. Believe me when I say it will still get us where we want to go.”

Netossa shrugged. “As long as I don’t wake up before three in the afternoon.” Spinnerella rolled her eyes at her wife, even if she was smiling.

Sea Hawk topped off glasses with about a finger and a half each of vodka. Their fingers brushed when he got to her, and Mermista suppressed a shiver. It was just the alcohol.

“Who’s starting?”

Bow perked up. “I will! Okay….never have I everrrrr…”

They played round and round, starting a new set after each victor. It only took about half an hour for the questions to take a turn for personal.

Perfuma sat up, cheeks flushed red. “Okay, okay, uhhhh never have I ever gotten off using a shower.”

Glimmer sat up and gaped, at the same time Mermista groaned.

“What!”

”You bitch.”

Perfuma shrugged. “Never had the right...equipment, I guess.”

Mermista snorted into the back of her hand, before taking over. “Okay uhhh….hm.”

“This game seems to be getting harder for you as we go on.” Netossa smirked. “Little Miss blah-de-dah secretly a wild child?”

“Uh, totally not a secret.” She smirked at the older woman. “Okay, never have I ever been hungover.”

The balcony erupted into roars of anger and disbelief. Even Sea Hawk was gaping at her. “What?!”

Mermista shrugged with superiority. "In the genes I guess. Plus, hangovers are all about hydration, and I'm never dehydrated sooooo suck it."

Sea Hawk wouldn't let it go. "What about after that one night- the drag show in Pearlona we snuck out to, like, two years ago. You couldn't move the next morning."

Her face was on *fire* , and she was all too aware of several sets of eyes boring into her skull. But liquor was loosening her tongue, and inhibitions. "Yeah, that wasn't from the liquor."

He frowned. "What- *oh* -"

Laughter and cat calls filled the night air, and Mermista cleared her throat. "Alright, next."

A very, *very* drunk Bow took over. "Never have I ever...hm. Uh. There's lots I haven't done. Like pottery- no! That's lame. Ummmm. OH! Oh! Never have I ever sucked a dick!"

Glimmer and Adora's mouths dropped open comically, at their golden boy saying 'dick'. Mermista snorted and put her finger down, locking eyes with Sea Hawk as he followed. She winked at him quietly, and he smiled back at her for the first time that night. Before-

“WAIT! Sea Hawk?!” Bow was flabbergasted, while Sea Hawk was quietly amused.

“Bow, you know I’m bisexual, we had an entire conversation about this only an hour ago.”

The archer was doing a solid karp impression. “I know but like- I didn’t-”

Netossa took over. “We thought you and Mermista had been together for, like, ever.”

The temperature of the balcony dropped a few degrees, but only the two of them seemed to notice it. “Oh, uh, well no. I met Mermista when I was twenty one. It was, uh, before that.”

Mermista’s ears were roaring. Together? They all thought they were together? Even after…? Her headache was returning in full force, but luckily Sea Hawk pushed it along. Adora was next.

“Uh...never have I ever gotten a piercing.”

She groaned loudly, putting her second to last finger down. Sea Hawk wasn’t fairing much better. Glimmer piped up. “Wait are we putting down a finger for each piercing?”

"No way, I'll be in the negatives!" she growled.

Perfuma turned to her. "How many do you have now?"

"Ugh, jeez." She rolled her eyes and started tapping the various points on her body. "One, two...four...six. No wait, seven."

Adora tilted her head. "How?"

Mermista quirked a brow. "With a needle?"

The warrior blushed. "No, I mean, like, you only have two ears?

"You can get more than your ears pierced, Adora," Bow chuckled. "I have a nipple piercing!"

Sea Hawk choked on his drink. "You *do?* "

"Yep! Got it when I turned seventeen."

"Huh!" The pirate sat back. "I don't know anyone with a nipple piercing besides myself."

Perfuma tilted her head, and Mermista couldn’t shush her quickly or quietly enough. “Yes you do.”

“Perfuma!” she hissed.

“I do?”

“Yeah.” The plant princess frowned. “Mermista has two. I mean, I also have one. But you don’t really know me, so I guess that doesn’t count. We got them done together when we turned eighteen! Well, the right one. Mermista had the left one pierced when she was thirteen. It’s a cultural thing, right?”

Mermista just grumbled, head in her hands as her friend prattled on. She could *feel* Sea Hawk’s eyes boring into her in confusion. She’d never kept her chest piercings in when they were together; they got irritating after a while. It, like, wasn’t a big deal he’d never seen them.

Eventually they moved on, and Mermista made it through a whole other round until they landed on Spinnerella.

“Hmmmm...” She smirked, before sending a dirty look to her wife, who only had one finger up. “Never have I ever gotten a tattoo.”

Most of the balcony groaned and ‘booed’. Mermista, Sea Hawk, Perfuma, Glimmer, Netossa, and even Adora slammed their final fingers down, before shuffling forward to take their last half-shot. Belatedly, Mermista regretted skipping dinner that evening. The room was already spinning, and she wasn’t entirely confident she could walk straight, but she never backed down.

Drinks were poured, glasses tapped the table and then each other, and down the last of Sea Hawk’s vodka went. The burn had stopped bothering her two shots back, but Perfuma still grimaced and shook her head in disgust. “I don’t know how you think this is better than wine.”

Sea Hawk just laughed, before climbing to his feet with an unfair amount of balance. He turned first to help Bow up, and then to Mermista. She took his hand with surprised hesitation, and he yanked her to her feet with little effort. Surely enough, the room was spinning harder now, and she was helpless to do much but lean into Sea Hawk.

“Sorry,” she mumbled into his shoulder. “You don’t have to help me.”

Sea Hawk looked at her bemusedly. “And why not? I don’t know if you’ve noticed, but you can’t walk, dearest.”

She scowled at him, but tightened her grip on his shoulder. She could feel the words bubbling up, coming to spill out of her liquor-loose lips, and trying to stop them was like grabbing at water with her bare hands. “You like, hate me now.” Her fucking chin was trembling, and she grit her teeth. She would *not* cry here, in front of their friends. "S'okay. I get it. Lots of people hate me."

Mermista refused to meet his eyes now, staring at the floor while her forehead leaned on his shoulder. At least it made the balcony spin less. Vaguely, she heard Sea Hawk say something to the others, before his arm snaked around her waist like iron. He led her from the balcony and into the hall, and then stopped her. She tried to focus on him, but he was there, then he was gone, and then she was in the air.

She yelped, wrapping her arm around his neck. "Sebastian, what-"

"It's easier this way," he said. "And I do not hate you, Mermista. I could never hate you."

She sniffled, resting her head on his chest. "You don't like me, though."

There was a lengthy silence, before gentle lips pressed a kiss to her forehead. "You're drunk, dearest. We can talk about this later."

She snorted. "When? The Queen's sending you off again tomorrow. And then you'll keep coming here, and not Salineas."

"I'll always come back to Salineas."

Mermista scowled, and said nothing. Her emotions roiled inside her as volatile as the vodka, but the drowsiness overcoming her was much stronger than the desire to keep talking. She closed her eyes, letting her head flop onto his chest. He'd thrown on his regular jacket, the soft blue one that made his freckles pop. It smelled like ocean brine, and woodsmoke, and something warm and spiced that reminded her of the winter solstice celebrations. And like Sea Hawk. She couldn't really describe the smell, but it was so undeniably him that it made her smile.

After what could have been an eternity, or only a half of a second, she was being laid down on a soft bed and covered in a puffy duvet. Eyes shut, she reached out for him, clutching his shirt when she found it. And hand came up to cover hers, calloused and warm. Mermista pried an eye open. "Stay?"

A kiss was placed to her palm when he pried it from his shirt. The moustache hairs tickled and made her giggle. "Not tonight, love. I have to be up early and I don't want to wake you."

Mermista sighed, disappointment and sadness rolling off her in waves. "Kiss?"

Her space was suddenly filled with Sea Hawk as he leaned over her, pressing kisses to her forehead, her cheeks, her eyelids, the corners of her mouth, even her earlobes. They were gentle, and soft, and for some reason they made Mermista want to cry. At last, he pressed his lips to hers, and she sighed in bliss. She'd take it to her grave, but there was literally nothing better on this earth than kissing Sea Hawk. Her hands trailed up his chest, his shoulders, his neck, nails scraping lightly, before tangling in his finn curls. Their mouths moved like tides, pushing and pulling and chasing. Occasionally his teeth scraped the soft flesh of her bottom lip, tugging gently, or he sucked on it just enough to bring it into his mouth, but there was no fervor, no rushing heat. Just this, their lips saying all the things they couldn't. Gently, his tongue ran along her lips, until she opened enough for him to lick into her mouth, stroking her tongue to a lazy rhythm. Mermista hummed, smiling into his lips.

In all the pandemonium of war, she'd almost forgotten what she'd realized at the ball. Well, not forgotten, but it was rarely at the forefront of her mind. Now, here with him, the words beat against her chest with fists of steel, thumping their rhythm into her heart. *I love you, I love you, I love you!* they cried.

And when he pulled back, and his eyes were as soft as they'd been the first morning she woke up next to him, she nearly cried it herself. But he was too fast; he kissed her once more, chastely, before rising to his feet. "Sleep well, princess."

Mermista watched him leave, before shutting her eyes and rolling over. The bed suddenly felt miles too wide, and colder than the ice in Snows.

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Sea Hawk woke up to a pounding on his door and in his head.

“Summons from the queen, Captain.”

“Right,” he called, voice hoarse from sleep. “Be right there.”

He dressed quickly, arranging his hair into something slightly organized, before flying from the room. His ‘escort’ had to jog to keep up with him. The war room was empty, save for the queen.

“Captain.”

Sea Hawk bowed low. She sounded calmer today, but he wasn’t letting his hackles down yet. “You wanted to see me, Your Majesty?”

“Please, sit.” She gestured. He did so. “I have a new job for you.”

“Uh- okay, yes.” He cleared his throat. “Certainly, your majesty.”

Angella activated the holo-table, pointing to several flagged ports along his route. “I need you to start gathering intel regarding the Horde’s plans wherever you can. Adora has told me that these locations see Horde activity fairly regularly, but not so concentrated as to be considered hostile.” She paused and pursed her lips. “I do not wish to presume your...ability to function within these spaces-“

Sea Hawk smiled. “I’m a pirate, your majesty. It is not a dirty word, or an insult, not to me. Especially when it can be of use to you in these trying times.” His grin dimmed. “I am familiar with these places, and I can try to gather information for the Rebellion. But I can’t make any promises.”

Angella nodded. “Your willingness to try is already plenty. You’re scheduled to cast off tomorrow, yes? I’ll be expecting you back in three weeks time with as much intel as you can gather.”

Sea Hawk nodded, rising. “I’d best get to the docks then. Good day, your majesty.”

He strode from the chamber, moving back to his own rooms to gather his things. Once again, he paused at the parcels he’d left in the bottom of his bags. Last night had been...a mess. Mermista thought he hated her? Sea Hawk was at a genuine loss as to what could have possibly given her that impression. Of course he didn’t hate her. Truth be told, he loved her more than life itself, and it was that very emotion that kept him here, in her hands, letting himself be yanked about like this. What she had said after, was, unfortunately true. With guilt crushing his sternum, he was forced to admit that yes, at the moment, he did not like Mermista very much. And the very thought made him want to toss himself from the Sea Gate.

He sat down heavily on his bed, cradling his head in his hands. It was aching in every possible way, and he really just wanted to crawl back into bed. Mermista was clogging his brain, his heart, his senses, everything; she was ripping him up from the inside, and he wasn’t sure how much more he could take. He flopped backwards, trying to categorize his thoughts.

From the first moment they met, he’d been...overwhelmed by her. Her beauty, her effortless grace, even just the assured way she held herself. As time went on, his ardor and admiration grew exponentially; her rune magic, the power she held within her body, literal oceans at her beck and call, all offset by her casual air, snared him like a fishing gaff. And her mermaid form...stars, she was a goddess to him and there was no denying it.

But, was all of that enough to let himself be treated like this? He wasn’t stupid, no matter what people thought, and he was more intune with emotions than most men, thank you very much. And Sea Hawk was growing tired of this weird back and forth. Tired of Mermista pushing him away, brushing him off around others, dismissing him at the drop of a pin, only to lure him back in when she wanted him around. And lately, the only time she seemed to tolerate him enough to want him around was in bed. While Sea Hawk was in no way complaining about the sex, he wasn’t exactly feeling...good.

Memories of their first year together flooded his mind. He used to make her laugh, with his tall tales, his silly shanties, his rowdy and occasionally inappropriate jokes. The smiles she used to give him...they shone like the sun, and warmed him twice as much. He started bringing her gifts just to coax it out, when things started getting worse with her father and the Horde. Nights under the stars, laid on the beach and talking. Just talking, for hours and hours, about everything. She had trusted him back then, enough to confide in him about her fears, her stresses, even the hopes and dreams she didn’t feel she was allowed to have. And he had trusted her, too.

Mermista was as intoxicating now as she had been then; curves like rolling waves, eyes that burned with heat lightning. She was the human embodiment of the sea, the ocean herself. And he'd been addicted to the ocean since he was old enough to want anything. But the thing about the ocean, about loving the ocean, was that it took and took, and was incapable of returning your love for it…

He was only a man. And the ocean was an arcane force of nature. It was dawning on him that this...thing...was maybe never going to work like he wanted it to.

And stars, did he want it to.

Sea Hawk's chest was burning, clogged with emotion that was creeping toward his eyes. His breath was hitching as visions, dreams he'd had for his- no, their- future, floated before his closed eyes. The chronic optimist in him was wailing, banging on the walls and begging him to relax, to hold out, to see the brighter side. But frankly, Sea Hawk was just too tired.

Gathering himself as best he could, he sat up. His efforts in not crying hadn't exactly paid off, and he carefully blotted his cheeks; he didn't want his face looking ruddy and exhausted when he still had a whole day ahead of him. As emotionlessly as he could manage, he removed the parcels from his bag and set off for Mermista's chambers. Maybe luck would be on his side for once, and she would be elsewhere.

He knocked on the door, fingers crossed for silence. He had never been Lady Luck's favored son though, and Mermista answered the door with wet hair and her usual neutral scowl. The bags under her eyes were a bit heavier than they usually were in the morning, but other than that she seemed no worse for wear.

It deepened a bit when they locked eyes, and Sea Hawk's heart crumbled that little bit more. It was very obvious she didn't remember their gentle talk the night before.

"What?"

He opened his mouth, but really had nothing to say. So instead he shoved the package at her roughly. "Here."

Surprise ghosted her face, and maybe a bit of embarrassment. Mermista glanced up and down the hall, almost as if to make sure they were alone. The simple action incensed him, the idea of her being embarrassed by him more painful than a knife to the stomach. "Uh, thanks, I guess."

"Whatever." It felt weird, saying her usual turn of phrase. He turned to go, very aware that staying here much longer wouldn't be good for either of them.

"Wait!"

He did. He always did what she asked. *Why?* He asked himself. “Yes?”

She shifted from foot to foot, uneasy. “Did you...want to come in?”

Astonishment, at her gall, or maybe her sheer determination to ignore whatever was curdling between them, opened his jaw for him. A laugh, mean and disbelieving, barked out of him, and he shook his head. Mermista’s casual indifference morphed into something like shock, and no small amount of hurt. He was furious with himself, but at that very moment, he was far angrier with her.

“No, thank you, your majesty,” he said, the words as hollow as he felt. “I have to be going. I’ll see you next time, or something.”

Mermista scowled. “Uh, no you won’t. I leave for Salineas in three days.”

His heart dropped, but he refused to let it bring him down with it. “Then I will see you there, I imagine.”

Her throat was working, and for a moment he thought her eyes were shining. For one brief second, their walls came tumbling down around them as they held each other’s eyes, and he *saw her* . The real Mermista, the one kept under lock and key for her own protection; hurt, confused, her eyes asking him to come back and explain.

But he refused to be fooled again. Sea Hawk swallowed his own sadness and regret, and offered her a genuine, if very feeble, smile. He wavered for only a second, before striding back to her. Hesitantly, he took her face in his hands, and pressed a gentle kiss to her forehead. It felt like a goodbye, but for the life of him he didn’t know why. Of course he’d see her again, whether in Bright Moon or Salineas, or on the open sea. Wouldn’t he?

She reached out, seizing his wrist in her hand. “Three weeks, there’s supposed to be an eclipse or something. A meteor shower? I don’t know. Something with the moons. Come to Salineas?” She lifted her head, and yeah, there were definitely tears in her eyes. “I...I’d like you to come and watch with me. On the beach. Or- or my balcony. Just...come?”

He regarded her silently, gaze boring into hers, probing and searching. There was genuine want there, not just desire, and something akin to hope, he thought. But there was still a turn of her mouth, some subtle way she held herself, that led him to believe asking him to do this was painful for her.

Nonetheless, he nodded. “As my queen commands.”

She snorted a bit, a ghost of a smile flickering over her lips. “I’m not your queen, doofus.”

His smile was soft, and he hummed enigmatically. With one more kiss to her forehead, he pulled back. Sea Hawk let his gaze flick over her once more, as it always did when he had to go; one last chance to look his fill before he would leave, like a starving man to a desert.

She looked at the package in her hands, then back up at him. She mouthed a gentle ‘thank you’, before retreating into her rooms. With a slightly bouncier step, Sea Hawk set off for the harbor, intent on making the most of the beautiful day, and getting his new ship ready to sail.

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter… the fight

another time, another place (what could we have been?)

Chapter Summary

> Sooner or later, something's gotta give

Chapter Notes

> Sorry not sorry. I hope everyone enjoys the delightful pain of reading this, it was a blast to write. Cathartic.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mermista was covered in pollen and frozen to her bones thanks to Perfuma and Frosta, but she was cheering just as loudly as the other princesses as Scorpia and her goons ran back to the Fright Zone, tails between their legs. High fives and hugs were passed around as they made their way back to the rebel camp to pack up. This little excursion in the name of diplomacy had been fun- Mermista never turned down an opportunity to flex her magic muscles- but Salineas needed all hands on deck now more than ever. Not to mention this Friday night…

When Peekablue, Sweet Bee, and the Star Sisters had suddenly popped back up on her radar, her first instinct had been to shut them out and turn them away. Where were they when the Sea Gate was failing, when they lost Entrapta, when Bright Moon nearly fell? They were princesses, too, even if they'd never felt 'let in' to the inner circle or whatever. Privately, Mermista thought they were just jealous they didn't have elemental powers, and chose to harbor some made up victim complex whenever things got tough. Not that she'd ever shared that.

Anyway, they had suddenly appeared in her throne room, specters of her past social life. Especially Starla- Mermista had tried very hard not to blush when they locked eyes. Starla had been her first kiss, first...everything. It was nice, and fun, but they were stupid kids and it had been a half-hearted fling. Although, the way Starla was looking at her on the throne, she wondered if maybe that sentiment had been more one sided than she assumed. They'd stood before her, almost bored, and demanded she go to the Dolphin Social that Friday night with them.

"Drinks, dancing, dudes and dolls," Peekablue had drawled, examining his nails. "The works, darling. Unless, of course, you have something better to do." And the way he looked at her on the last word sealed Mermsita's certainty that he knew about Sea Hawk, and most certainly did not approve.

Annoyance, shame, and the childhood desire to prove to her ex-best friend that she was just as cool as him flared in her chest, and she rolled her eyes. "Fine, whatever, but I'm, like, bringing Perfuma."

They had all shrugged, and turned from the throne room without formal dismissal. Next to her, Butler Guard had bristled. She waved him off. "Seriously, they're like, not worth it."

And so, here she was leaning casually against a rock while she rattled off the details to Perfuma, who was packing her stuff. The Plumerian princess hummed thoughtfully. "Didn't Peekablue abandon Salineas when it was threatened, despite being a princess of a smaller provine within the kingdom."

Mermista picked at a cuticle. “Yep.”

“And then the Star Sisters dropped you like hot bread when you wouldn’t hand over full battlefield authority to their family?”

“Uh huh?”

“And hasn’t Sweet Bee always been, and I quote, ‘a mega bitch’ to you?”

“Not wrong.”

“Mermista.” Perfuma stood in front of her now, hands on her hips in that ‘I mean business young lady’ way. “Why do you want to go, then?”

She groaned. “It’s stupid, I know, but I feel like...like-”

“You want them to see you as successful and flourishing without them?”

“Yes? Maybe?” Mermista sighed. “I don’t know. I just feel like I have to, and if I have to, I at least want one person there who isn’t going to be like, making passive aggressive comments at me all night.”

Perfuma hummed noncommittally. “What about Sea Hawk? That man isn’t passive about anything.”

“Hard no,” Mermista scowled. “Sea Hawk is going to embarrass me.”

“Mermista!” Perfuma frowned. “He would never...intentionally. He can be a little much, sure, but he cares about you so much!” She took Mermista’s hands in hers. “He’d love to be there to support you, if you explained the situation to him.”

She scowled. “I just can’t right now, okay? Things are weird, and stressful, and last time he was here it was- look, forget about it.” She shook her head to clear the image of Sea Hawk’s glare, the same glare that had been haunting her for a little over a month. “I don’t know where he is, if he’d even be able to make landfall by then. Or if he’d want to go. And if he did, I don’t know if I could cope with him and them and keep my nerves together, alright?”

Perfuma sighed. “I understand, Mermista. Just, please, be honest with him when you cancel?”

“Cancel?” Mermista frowned. “Cancel what?”

The other princess tilted her head in confusion. “Uh, wasn’t your stargazing date supposed to be this weekend? It was, like, all you were talking about the other night when we were drunk.”

Oh shit. Oh *fuck* .

“Uhhh, yeah, we ended up cancelling that anyway, it’s fine,” Mermista waved Perfuma off casually, grabbing her trident and travel pack. “C’mon, it’s a good hour’s walk back to Bright Moon for briefing.”

On the trek back, Mermista was assaulted by Bow and Adora, bickering over semantics and a broken looking tracker pad. “Mermista, do you know when Sea Hawk will be back?” Bow asked her.

Adora groaned. “Bow, there’s no way you actually picked up a signal from the northern reach! It’s a glitch.”

Mermista shrugged. “I dunno. Sometime this week, I think.”

“Good, we need a ride up to Snows.”

“No, we don’t-”

The path shifted from sod to gilded pavers underneath them, indicating they were nearly at the castle. The way back led them over a small mountain, and down some steep carved stairs. One path veered toward the harbor, the other toward the castle. Mermista turned her head toward the harbor, squinting. "Tell you what, I'll go ask him for you."

Sea Hawk's bright, opalescent sails were billowing in the wind, and the noise of an unloading ship reached their ears even from their lofty position. The smell of brine bolstered her; Sea Hawk would be chill. He always understood when she had to put royal stuff first. Even if this was more of an extracurricular than an actual duty.

She split from the Alliance, picking her way down the steps and winding her way along the stone harbor walks toward the ship. Sea Hawk's eyes found her almost immediately as she came into view, lighting up in a spine-tingling, embarrassing way. He whooped loudly, and took a running leap off the ship, just barely catching himself on a stray rat line. He landed before her in a slight heap, and Mermista's cheeks lit up as she heard muffled laughter around them.

"Mermista!" Sea Hawk sprang up like jack rabbit. "What brings you to the harbor?"

She picked at a nail with feigned disinterest. "Nothing, I just need to talk to you about, like, official business and this weekend."

Sea Hawk nodded, wide grin still firmly in place, and led her off to a more secluded stretch of the harbor. The ships and boats here were old, and dusty in their retirement. Sea Hawk plopped down on a small wall, long legs jumping underneath him. He always had such a hard time sitting still, and it was making Mermista antsy.

“So, Bow and Adora and probably Glimmer need a ride to the Northern Reach, like, as soon as you can give them one. Something about some sort of tracker signal, first ones blah-blah, I don’t know. But you can, right?”

Sea Hawk bobbed his head. “Certainly dearest. I’ll take them Saturday, after the meteor shower?”

Mermista gulped. “Uh, actually, they were kind of hoping you could take them tomorrow. And I think that might be...best.”

If one could take the feeling of watching a puppy get punted across a lake, condense it, and then sculpt a face out of it, it would look like Sea Hawk did right now. “But...what about our d-plans?”

She sighed. “Look, it probably wasn’t going to happen anyway. It’s not personal, but something came up. Something I can’t really avoid.”

“Princess stuff? Queen stuff? Mermaid stuff?”

“Uh, sort of.” Mermista rubbed the back of her neck, pondering phrasing, before deciding that the least she could do was tell him the truth. "Peekablue, Sweet Bee, and the Star Sisters showed up again, and made me an offer that I can't exactly refuse unless I want to alienate them further."

Sea Hawk stood up, and it was moments like these where Mermista was forcefully reminded how much he towered over her. His eyes smoldered, and she forced herself not to shrink away from the potent mixture of hurt and anger in his eyes. "You don't even like them, Mermista."

"It's not about who I like and don't like, Sea Hawk." She frowned. "You know that. Look, it's non-negotiable, I have to go to this to keep them, and more importantly, their city states happy."

Sea Hawk scoffed, and crossed his arms. "Fine, then I'll go with you, and we can still spend Friday night together before I take them up north."

Ah, shit. Now they were really in it. "I don't think that's such a good idea."

"And why not?"

"Sea Hawk, c'mon," she groaned. "You know how I feel about mixing my social lives! It's messy, and hard, and way too stressful. Peekablue is an asshole, he'll chew you up and spit you out, or he'll try to fuck you, and I don't really want to deal with either-"

“Excuse you! I can handle myself, thank you-”

“And Sweet Bee is, like, the most passive aggressive person I’ve ever met, and she’s going to be making comments all night, I can already hear them,” Mermista raked a rough hand through her hair. “And the Star Sisters...Sea Hawk, seriously, it would just be too much for me to have to manage you and them-”

Sea Hawk’s jaw dropped open incredulously. “M- *manage?* I don’t know if you’ve noticed, Princess, but I’m a fully grown man who can ‘manage’ himself.” His stupid air quotes and flippant attitude irked her.

“Oh, really?” She laughed sarcastically. “How many boats have you set on fire? How many bars, restaurants, and socials have you gotten us banned from? How many meetings have you crashed, huh? You don’t manage shit, Sebastian!” She was in his face now, words she’d carefully compartmentalized spilling out of their shelves. “You do whatever the hell you want, and then wait for me to pick up the pieces and do damage control!”

To her surprise, Sea Hawk got right back in her face. “No, *you* fabricate these offenses and these-these- faux pas so that you have something to control!” She reeled back like she’d been slapped. “Because you *hate* that you can’t control me, Mermista. Admit it!”

“Fine,” she snarled. “I do. I really, really hate it. Because if you would just listen to me when I ask you to tone it down, for once, maybe I wouldn’t be so *embarrassed* to be seen with you!”

It was Sea Hawk’s turn to pull back, looking like she’d just thrown his favorite compass into the ocean. Mermista was vaguely aware of the sea just behind her, roiling and tossing with her anger and frustration. They stood in silence for a moment, chests heaving. She was vaguely aware of the burning prick in the corners of her eyes, but she willed the tears down. She would not cry, she would *not show weakness* . Not here, where he could see.

Sea Hawk looked down, scuffed his boots against the cobbles, and jammed his hands in his pockets. When he looked back up, his eyes were empty, and he was staring past her with his jaw so tense it was ready to snap. He nodded, jerkily. “Right. Tell Bow and Adora I’ll meet them here tomorrow afternoon. Good day, Princess.”

Regret and guilt started gnawing at her stomach. “Sea Hawk-” He turned and strode away from her, not even sparing her a final glance. “Sebastian!”

His steps faltered, but he didn’t stop. Didn’t turn, and wink at her. Or give her one of those cheesy smiles that he loved to flash before he went off to do something stupid.

Eventually, he melted back into the hustle and bustle of the harbor, and Mermista turned, robotically making her way back to the castle. She had a party to get ready for.

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"Embarrassed to be seen with you!"

Mermista's words plagued him all that night, as he laid in the v-berth of his ship, tossing and turning. He slept in fits, his dreams punctuated by roaring fires that turned into smoldering amber eyes, or predators circling him in open seas, just out of sight. In some, he was chasing a young child through a forest, but they were always just barely beyond his reach, giggling at his expense.

He woke in the morning with a start. He rubbed his head, pounding as it was, and realized there was someone on his deck. Sea Hawk frowned. The crew should be in their bunks ashore until noon, when he'd switch the boat over to another captain for his shore leave.

He dressed quickly, into his usual cotton shirt, slacks, and blue jacket, leaving the captain's coat and hat behind. A courier was standing on the deck, shifting from foot to foot as the waves rocked the boat. They thrust a letter toward him, looking green around the gills.

"A letter from the Princess of Salineas. Good day."

They all but flung themselves from the boat. Sea Hawk chuckled, before popping the wax seal- shining blue, with gold flecked through, depicting a mermaid and a trident- on the letter with a pinky nail. Serpentine script winked at him, flowing like the waves its author controlled.

Sebastian,

Pier 8, Slot 1.

Mermista

He grimaced, and their fight from yesterday came howling back into his brain. He crumpled the letter and shoved it in his jacket before jumping the rail of the deck; what was in slot 1 at pier 8? He rounded the corner of the pier, and his jaw dropped a bit. A new boat sat waiting for him, fuschia sails shining in the sun, its rosewood freshly lacquered. ‘ *Dragon’s Daughter V’* was scrawled along the bow in the same script as the letter, detailed in gold.

It was sleek and small, built for speed and personal use. He hopped aboard, automatically checking lines and weights and levers. Once satisfied, he ducked below deck. It was snug, but not cramped, in the captain’s quarters. Instead of a hammock, there was a v-berth tucked into the back, a solid mahogany desk, and shelves. A trunk sat on top of the desk, and Sea Hawk realized it was the same one he’d handed the guard boy before the Battle for Bright Moon. His maps, and most beloved treasures, sat within. He picked up the compass that sat on top, running his hands over the battered gold and wood lid.

He clicked it open, and ran his thumb over the picture that sat above the glass face; he and Mermista on the beach, smiling and laughing. She'd been showing him the new datapad she'd gotten, and they were fooling around with it when it had snapped the most perfect picture of them; she was sitting in front of him, bracketed by his gangly legs with one of his arms around her shoulders. She was laughing, really laughing, at something he'd said, her face turned towards his. They were nearly nose to nose, and he knew in the next instant he would kiss her. Sea Hawk saw in his own still gaze the emotions that were tearing him up inside.

Devotion. Adoration. Love.

Because of course he loved her. How could he not? She was the star he'd been steering his ship by for years, the only home he'd known since he left Snows. His sun, his moon, the only goddess he'd ever believe in. He loved her so much it was killing him.

Sea Hawk snapped the compass shut and tucked it away in his jacket. He wiped gently at his eyes, brushing off the tears that clung to his lashes.

"Sea Hawk? Hello?" Bow's voice echoed across the deck, and he straightened up. He bounded up the steps, a genuine smile tugging at his mouth when he saw his friend.

"Bow! My good man, are you ready for *adventure* ?!"

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Well, that had certainly been the most unorthodox mission he’d ever partaken in. He had found himself depressed, angry, frustrated, and then comforted and bolstered by the most unlikely friend he’d ever made. Which was seriously saying something for Sea Hawk.

Scorpia’s words rang in his ears as he pulled the ship into Bright Moon Harbor. *Is there something wrong with us?* Was there? Possibly. Well, in his case, definitely. But not in the way that she meant; Sea Hawk firmly believed that he was a good man. He’d spent his whole life trying to be a respectable pirate, after all. And Scorpia...for a Horde Captain, he’d found himself connecting to her more than he’d ever thought possible. A kindred soul indeed.

Watching how the other woman, Catra, had treated Scorpia, was eye-opening. Scorpia threw herself at Catra, begging her for scraps of affection, and being grateful when she received little to nothing in return. Sea Hawk saw himself in how she purposely put on a smile, looking past the obvious because she simply did not want to see it, did not want to have to confront what it meant.

So, yeah, maybe there was something wrong with both of them; they loved to the point of martyrdom.

That changed today, for Sea Hawk. What he’d already known was going to happen before he left the Harbor yesterday was now an inevitability that weighed him down like a stone. It was for both of their own goods, he reminded himself.

Then why does this feel like a funeral procession?

He dropped the ‘Best Friend Squad’, as they called each other, off in Bright Moon. He felt a brief pang of jealousy for their closeness, and longed for the days he’d called Mermista his best friend. He’d sent along a letter with Glimmer to her mother, resigning from the Bright Moon Navy and thanking her for the opportunities she’d given him to help the Rebellion. He’d also told her, in code, that he would continue to collect intel and send it along when possible.

He had no more reason to stay in Bright Moon. He was going to Salineas to restock per the pirate trade agreements, and then he was going underground for a good, long while. Until he stopped having dreams about ocean monsters and little children in forests, until he stopped smelling her perfume on his clothes, until the howling in his chest died down, or went away entirely.

He arrived in Salineas in the late afternoon, pulling into his designated spot and immediately tossing ropes down to the decks. Once, this port had been bustling, deckhands and sailors and pirates all milling about, trading their wares, recruiting crews, selling what they could to who they could. It had been an eclectic melting pot of individuals from all walks of life. Now, it was practically empty.

He made a trip to one of the remaining open stalls, stocking up on non-perishables, gunpowder, laser cannon cartridges, reams and reams of paper, automatic pens and refill cartridges, and, after careful pondering, a fan-tailed jaeger of a stunning blue variety. Sea Hawk clicked at the raptor through the cage, smiling when it cooed back at him. The shopkeep assured him it was recall trained, and could deliver letters.

Sea Hawk loaded up a trolley with his crates, sacks, bins, and assorted loose items. It should be enough to last him eight months, a year if he was careful. He turned the corner toward his ship, and the tune he was whistling died on his lips. Leaned against the mooring stone, looking decidedly bored, was Mermista.

Her head snapped up as he approached, and he froze in place. They stared at each other for a long moment, and all the emotions Sea Hawk had been working to tamp down reared their ugly heads; hurt, love, anger, love. The usual, these days.

Finally, she spoke. “Uh, what’s all that?”

Sea Hawk looked at his cart, then at her, and blinked. “Supplies?”

“Yes, obviously.” She rolled her eyes. “For what? That’s like...a year's worth of shit.”

“Eight months, technically.” He shrugged, rubbing his neck. “But you know I hate breakfast on the open sea, so…”

When he looked back at her, she was staring at him with trepidation and wringing her braid. “You’re...leaving?”

He swallowed, hard. “Uh, yeah. Yeah, I am. I have to get more Horde intel, I’m kind of the only one who can right now, so I’m going underground for a while. A long while, I guess.”

Mermista stepped closer. “Are you...will you write? Or visit?”

Sea Hawk sighed. The moment of truth was here, and he wanted to curl up under a rock and die. He met her eyes, and knew his own were shining as he shook her head. “No, I ah- I don’t think that’s such a good idea.”

“Sea Hawk…”

Ht took a deep breath. “What you said, the other day, Mermista...” He had to get it off his chest, he had to get these words and feelings out, out, *out.* “It hurt. It really, really hurt. But what hurts more is you pushing me away, and then pulling me back in when it’s convenient to you. I can’t-” His voice broke and he cleared his throat. “I won’t let it happen anymore. I- “

He took a deep breath, willing his voice not to shake as he plowed on. “I love you, Mermista.” He watched fear, anxiety, and shock flit across her face. “I love you so much and it’s just...not enough for you. I’m not enough for you, and I have to make my peace with that.”

“Sebastian-”

“I need to be enough for me, though. I know who I am, and I don’t need anyone’s validation but my own. Not even yours, Princess.”

Her eyes flashed, and a wave crashed off in the surf. “So that’s it? You tell me you love me and now you just, what, walk away? From this? From us?” Her breath hitched. “From me?”

“What us, Mermista?” he laughed mirthlessly. “You can’t stand being around me lately, unless we’re having sex. You won’t bring me around your friends because you are *actively embarrassed by me* -”

“Oh my god, is that seriously what this is about!” She threw her hands up. “Sea Hawk, I didn’t want to expose you to them because they’re assholes who look down their noses at anyone who isn’t royalty. I didn’t want you to embarrass yourself-”

“Ah, ah, ah!” He shook his head, dropping the handle of the trolley so he could stand in front of her. “You said you were embarrassed to be seen with me, end of story. You don't get to change the narrative now, because you feel bad for all of this and can't cope with it."

For a brief moment, he was certain he was about to be hosed down with ocean water, but Mermista only scoffed. "It was a stupid eclipse, Sea Hawk, there will be other dates!"

"No there won't, Mermista!" he yelled, and then immediately hated himself for how she flinched back. "There won't, because you don't want there to be. You never want to see me-"

"Oh, no, no," she interrupted. "This is not all on me! You leave for weeks and months on end with no notice and no contact. You always have!"

"I'm a pirate!" He flung his arms wide. "What do you expect?"

"Support!" she yelled. He saw now that her eyes were brimming with tears, and even now, all he wanted to do was wipe them away. "I expect support, and someone who will listen to me for five minutes, not just run off the second he's bored of being on land regardless of who's stuck there!"

He flinched. "Run off? Mermista, you push me away! The other night, in Bright Moon, you literally screamed at me to get out!"

“I was having a panic attack, and you didn’t even notice!” she screamed, before clapping a hand to her mouth and glancing around. Sea Hawk’s heart dropped, and he tried to speak, but she cut him off. “I needed you to notice, but you’re always so stuck in your own damn head that you can’t see when someone else needs you to be serious, or to slow down, or to just fucking *sit there and listen* .”

Sea Hawk sneered. “How can I listen when you won’t even talk to me anymore?” He raked a hand through his hair. “Mermista, this is- *you’re* a mess-”

“Ha!” she barked. “Takes one to know one, Sebastian. I can’t cope without control? You can’t cope with reality. You have this whole other self living inside of you who sets shit on fire for fun and battles sea monsters and is living some grandiose adventure because the real world is terrifying.”

Sea Hawk flushed, and gritted his teeth.

“You’re running scared, from the consequences of your own actions, from commitments, from any serious emotion-”

“I would never run-”

“What, from me?” Mermista scoffed. “You ran the night I asked you to prom, the night of the battle, and for months after that whenever shit didn’t go your way. And now, you’re running again.”

Sea Hawk felt himself starting to hyperventilate. She was wrong- she *was wrong* -

“I am leaving,” he raised his voice. “Because I refuse to let you keep treating me like your personal plaything. I’m leaving, because you pushed me away, Mermista. You’re always so anxious that everyone is going to leave you, going to abandon you, that you wall them off before they can get close. And if they get too close, you drive them away so you can turn around and say ‘oh, look, I was right’.

“How dare you-!”

“I dare because I’m sick of it!” he shouted. His chest was heaving, and his eyes were burning, and the whirlpool of fear and anger and heartbreak inside of him was threatening to drown him. Like a candle blowing out, the anger abated briefly, replaced by a bone-deep exhaustion. “I’m tired, Mermista. I’m so tired.”

Her hand shot out, and grabbed his own. She looked almost frantic now, her eyes searching his for something he knew he couldn’t give her. He could never give her what she needed. “Please, Sea Hawk. I...I lo-”

He jerked his hand back, and shook his head violently. “No, Mermista, you don’t.” His own eyes finally spilled over, and he choked on a sob. “You can’t just...say that now, when everything’s gone to shit. You can’t, and you don’t.” His chest rattled around a deep breath that felt like knives. “Because if this is how you show it, I don’t want it.”

Tears were rolling freely down her cheeks, and her sobs were grinding his heart to dust. She looked at him, pain and sadness clouding her honey brown eyes. “You swore, Sebastian,” she hiccuped. “You swore you would always stand by me. You swore.”

He squeezed his eyes shut, and stepped away from her. “I will always, *always* stand by you Mermista. As Queen, and as Princess, and everything else you are. Even if I have to do it from afar.”

He picked up the handle of his supply cart, and resumed his path to his ship. He paused by her, letting himself linger in her presence one last time. “Goodbye, Mermista.”

Her arms were wound around her torso in a desperate hug, trying to stop the shivers wracking her body. When she looked at him, it was with a profound sadness and grief he knew was reflected back at her, even as she held her head high. “Goodbye, Sebastian.”

Chapter End Notes

Wheeeeeee! Don’t throw sticks! It’ll get better!

As always, thank you all for the wonderful, incredible feedback. I’m trying to respond to each comment but aaahhh holidays. Also- seamista hallmark fic going up this week ideally.

All I Want

Chapter Summary

Growing, together and apart and everything in between

Chapter Notes

This chapter was absurdly fun to write. And also painful. Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The month following ~~their breakup~~ Sea Hawk's departure passed in a blur for Mermista. She had vague recollection of making her way back to the castle, sending a short message to Perfuma via her datapad, and collapsing into her bed to cry. It was an ugly, deep cry that left her feeling wrung out and unsatisfied, like a damp towel. She fell asleep, and woke up to her attendant knocking gently on her door.

By lunch, she realized that her staff was well aware of their (she now realized) very public fight. It was probably all over the kingdom. Some part of her stirred, like a dead ember being gently blown on, telling her she should feel ashamed and embarrassed, but she didn't have it in her. Mermista didn't have much of anything left in her. She finished her lunch, chewing robotically, and returned to her office to sign off on resource allocation documents. And so the days passed.

In the mornings, she rose feeling more exhausted than when she went to sleep. Days passed by in snapshots, ones she looked at from outside her body. She took her meals in her office only. The one time she had tried to eat breakfast on her terrace, the view of the ocean, and the ships in the harbor made her sick to her stomach. She slept alone, curled up in pillows and blankets that felt ice cold. Her powers were waning, her connection to the Pearl utterly overtaken by the depression she found herself mired in.

Mermista saw the glances shared among her staff, and surmised it was only a matter of time until a coup arose. Internally, she shrugged, apathetic at best to the concept. Maybe her staff liked her enough to make it painless. It's not like Mermista wanted to die, but at this point, it wasn't like she had a loving relationship with her life thus far…

At the end of the month, Perfuma came to visit. Well, visit would be a gentle way of putting it. One moment, Mermista was taking audiences in her throne room, the next, the doors were being pushed open by the flower princess as if they were made of paper. "Mermista!"

"Uh, hey?"

She excused the now very bewildered farmer she'd been speaking with- well, really, he had been lecturing her, but whatever. The man scrambled to his feet from his seated position, and bowed to both princesses before leaving the room. Perfuma smiled at the man before turning her heated, borderline frantic gaze on Mermista. "I'm sorry it took me so long to get here. I only just got a replacement datapad- I left mine in the fields overnight, and it rained, and it was a whole thing- anyway!" She took a centering breath. "You and Sea Hawk...you broke up?"

Mermista kept her purposely bored gaze at a spot on the wall just over Perfuma’s shoulder. “Yup.”

“Are you… are you alright?”

“Fine.” Next to her, ButlerGuard shifted uncomfortably. Tattle tale. “Listen, why don’t we head to my rooms…?”

Perfuma nodded, and Mermista just then noticed the large basket she had hanging off of her arm, as well as the pack on her back. So this was not just a quick pop-in then.

She led her friend up into the residential areas of the castle, mutedly proud of how Perfuma’s head swiveled to take in the architecture of her home. She knew the hippie preferred her rustic home life, but Mermista had always been proud of her kingdom’s natural grandeur, and how the castle reflected it. Much of the castle was open air, and what wasn’t was covered by etched or stained glass skylights. Mosaics of sea glass, shells, and rare minerals and gems decorated the halls, along with portraits painted by their citizens. The lower catacombs were underwater, but the walls were made of glass a foot thick. Mermista remembers hours and hours spent in the lower halls, watching sea life swim by, hiding from her father when her mother wasn’t around to protect her from his disdain.

Mermista swallowed those memories down; the loneliness that had hollowed out her tiny chest as a kid was far too similar to the emotions threatening to crush her now. She tugged at her braid, suppressing the little voice in her head that had only grown sadder with Sea Hawk's absence. *'I don't want to be alone anymore.'*

'Yeah, well,' she thought bitterly. 'We are. Sea Hawk left, Father left... *Ami* left. They're all gone. So it's about time we got used to it.'

She pushed the door open to her rooms, and Perfuma deposited her rucksack by the plush couch in the common area. She kept the basket on her. "Want to sit by the terrace pool?"

"That sounds lovely."

Perfuma's smile was soft, and genuine. Mermista found herself unable to return it, and simply turned to lead her outside. The sun was beginning to set; it would be winter soon in Salineas, and the days were getting shorter, and ever so slightly colder. Mermista tugged her sari a bit tighter. It was probably tropical to Perfuma, but she was used to the eight months of balmy, humid warmth. Mermista hated winter.

They settled with their feet in the shallow infinity pool that seemingly vanished over the edge of the balcony. Mermista fastidiously made sure the Harbor was out of her line of sight.

"So..." Perfuma leaned in. "What...what happened? Everything seemed so normal, that night we played Never Have I Ever."

Mermista snorted humorlessly. “Things were already shit by then. We’d been kinda tense since the raid on the Fright Zone.” That was a lie. Things had been going steady downhill since she became queen.

“Mermista.” Perfuma reached out to clasp her hand. “What happened?”

“I- I don’t...” Somehow, despite a month of on and off crying, Mermista still had tears in her body to shed. Stupid hydrokineses. Stupid humid air. “It was so many things, ‘Fuma. So many little things that we didn’t even know were circling us until it was over. And now, I keep looking back, and seeing everywhere we went wrong.” Mermista raked a hand through her hair, blinking up at the sky. “I blew him off to hang with Peekablue and the others, and it was the straw that broke the camel’s back, y’know? We had a fight, he left for the northern reach, and then I saw him in Salineas and…”

Perfuma scooted closer, wrapping an arm around her when Mermista’s emotions clogged her throat. “It’s okay, hon. Take your time.”

She drew in a shaky breath. “He was stocking up for a long voyage. A personal trip. He had enough supplies for a year.” She choked on a sob. “He was leaving and he wasn’t even going to say goodbye!”

The water in the pool sloshed with her shaking shoulders as she buried her head in Perfuma's shoulder. The older girl rubbed soothing circles on her back, and Mermista felt eight years old again. "'Mista, how did it get here? The first time I met Sea Hawk, at Princess Prom, he was so head over heels for you, and you..." She shook her shoulders for emphasis. "Mermista I hadn't seen you that happy in so long."

Mermista scoffed and pushed her away. "It was just a stupid dance. I was drunk."

"Okay, so, *this,* " Perfuma waved a hand at her. "This might be part of the problem. You can't even bring yourself to tell me you actually liked going to a ball with the man? Mermista, seriously, what is up with you?"

Mermista drew in a deep breath, and in bouts of tears, and laughter, and fury, told her everything. How they'd met, how they had become thick as thieves, best friends really, the mind-blowing sex, and how it had all started to fall apart when her father abandoned the kingdom. Here, Perfuma's brow furrowed.

"Mermista, I don't want to overstep here, but I also don't know how to ask some of these things without being kind of a bitch."

"Go ahead." She shrugged. "It's refreshing, to be honest."

“Why did you push him away when you took the throne?” The flower girl frowned. “Wouldn’t that have been the time to lean on him the most?”

“Ugh! No,” Mermista scowled. “Back then, he was never around for more than, like, two weeks, maybe a month, at a time. He was off being a pirate, and he wasn’t a captain yet so he couldn’t, like, just turn up whenever he wanted. He’d blow into town, we’d have fun, and he’d leave. That kind of lifestyle just doesn’t work with ruling. You know that.”

Perfuma nodded understandingly. “That’s fair. But did you ever ask him to stay?”

She shook her head. “No. I couldn’t. He’d get, like, wacko bonkers if he stayed on land too long. He starts going stir crazy, can’t sit still, and then he sets things on fires, or challenges doormen to duels, or-or- ugh!” Mermista’s head flopped into her hands. “I tried, okay? I tried to get him to stay, in not so many words. But every time, he went nuts.”

Her friend sighed sadly. “I see. Still, there’s never any harm in communicating expectations, you know?”

“What?”

“Like, well...” Perfuma paused thoughtfully. “I see it like this. You can’t expect anyone to read your mind, right? Not even Angella can do that. If you want a friend or a partner to be somewhere, or do something, you need to communicate to them that you have expectations. Otherwise, how could they know? And then the need doesn’t get met, and feelings get hurt. Right?”

Mermista was staring impolitely, she knew, but she couldn't help herself. “You and I had drastically different upbringings.”

“Wha- !” Perfuma spluttered like she always did when Mermista rebuffed her ‘hippie dippy touchy feely bullshit’. “What do you mean?”

“It just doesn’t work like that here.” She gestured vaguely at the castle. “My father had expectations, and I met them. He didn’t need to ‘communicate’ them to me, I just had to know. And if I didn’t-” Several things were starting to click into place rather uncomfortably, and Mermista had the sudden urge to throw herself over the balcony.

“And if you didn’t?” Perfuma prompted her gently.

“I don’t remember,” she bluffed.

Perfuma smiled sadly, and took her hand again. “I do,” she whispered. “You were...ignored. Put away, like a...toy or a weapon that didn’t work. I remember getting the impression that you were only allowed to exist in his life when you were performing to his expectations.”

Mermista’s eyes were filling again, and a terrible sense of guilt and anger, and the familiar burn of self-hatred were rising in her. “I think maybe I fucked up.”

Perfuma wrapped an arm around her. “I don’t think this is all that one sided, hon. But I think you’ve just made a really important step. The second hardest thing in the world is having to look at ourselves, and make peace with the fact that we don’t like who we see.”

She scrubbed at her cheek. “What’s the hardest?”

Her friend smiled sadly, and pressed a kiss to her hairline. “Changing what we see.”

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A month had passed since Sea Hawk had left Salineas, and the main ports of Etheria behind. In that time, he’d sent three letters to Bright Moon via Scallywag, who was proving to be a helpful, if lazy, bird.

A month had passed since Sea Hawk had been completely sober, as well. There was probably some strong correlation there. Currently, he was seated at Seaworthy for a lighter stop off before he would make his way down to the Dead Zone. The unclaimed territory just outside the Fright Zone that was nigh uninhabitable, but too close to danger to annex into Etheria. There were several bars, brothels, and other such dens of depravity there that Sea Hawk was certain would yield results.

He'd walked into Seaworthy with nary a shanty, song, or tale, and made his way to his usual alcove table. There had been a younger sailor there, but he'd cleared off once he saw Sea Hawk's less than pleased face. At least some people still knew him as a pirate of some renown, he mused. And here he had sat, for the past few hours, drinking as he pleased (frequently) and scribbling routes on maps.

Someone landed in the booth, and Sea Hawk finished his sketch of his Plan R route before looking up. It was a lilac skinned dryad, pointed ears flicking as they scanned him. Sea Hawk took another pull of his whiskey. "Can I help you?"

"Can you?" They inched closer, and placed an intentional hand on his upper thigh. His *very* upper thigh. Sea Hawk's first instinct was to gently put firmly pry their hand off, but he paused. Why? He was...unattached. Depressed. And hurting for distraction if he was being honest. He leaned in, smirking back.

"I think I can."

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Perfuma left a week later, and Mermista felt better than she had in a long while. They'd stayed up most nights, talking into the wee hours of the morning, sometimes splitting a bottle of wine or rum. She felt...settled. Stable. More assured of herself than before.

She knew she had hurt Sea Hawk badly. Understood that pushing him away was self-sabotage, and that it was unfair of her to keep yanking him back to her at her leisure. But she also understood that Sea Hawk had allowed much of this to happen, and had done his fair share of not communicating anything. She'd stayed up with Perfuma night after night, unpacking how much it hurt when he left, and how she lashed out at him later for it. And she knew she had every right to be hurt, if not entirely shattered, by the fact that he was going to walk away without a goodbye. Mermista had never told him the finer details of the morning she woke up to find her father gone, but the parallelling situations haunted even her most peaceful dreams.

Abandonment issues was what Perfuma had called them. *Control problems* . Post traumatic something or whatever. That one didn't make sense to her; she wasn't 'post' anything. None of them were. In fact, the whole world was fairly Midst Trauma. But there was only so much she could control, Perfuma had told her. Herself, her emotions, her reactions, and her kingdom.

So Mermista dove into her work. Two months after Sea Hawk had left, she was no longer just a piece of furniture in her own meetings. She didn't tune out her citizens during audiences. She didn't leave things to her advisors, or blindly sign paperwork. She stayed up late, pouring over documents, old legal tomes, thick books on political philosophy. She began writing Angella regularly, asking for advice, or even just to say hi. She struck up regular check-ins with Plumeria and the Kingdom of Snows.

When it was possible, she met with the generals of her army and navy, listening to their strategies, offering advice if asked, and support when it was needed. Slowly, plans were drafted to build reinforced sea walls, and check gates around the harbors and ports. The economy of Salineas depended on the ports, and therefore on how safe she could keep them.

Three months after Sea Hawk left, the first trade ships in months made landfall in Salineas, bringing a much needed economic boom. The noose Mermista had felt sitting around her neck was loosening bit by bit. With the shift in available resources, she began redistributing their recent wealth to the areas of her kingdom her father had long since neglected. Schools were funded double than what they'd been, family care and aid was replenished, and the farmers she'd been listening to for months finally stopped coming with complaints. Instead, they brought her gratitude, and fresh produce from their field.

Being queen was amazing, actually.

Four months after he left, Mermista was touring one of the newest charter schools. Refugees from Dryl had settled in Salineas with immunity granted and full working opportunities available, and her kingdom was prospering for it. The people of Dryl were brilliant, resourceful individuals with the ability to make technological dreams a reality. This school along the coast was a prime example, as was their new aqueduct system.

She arrived with just two guards, entirely unconcerned with any supposed threats a school could offer. The children who attended here were learning to sail, or make maps, or, if they were older, how to broker trade deals. Mermista’s heart ached gently, but it was getting easier to push away.

“Everyone!” The headmaster, a siren with beautiful teal scales and fuschia locks of hair, clapped gently. They were walking through a courtyard, being shown the details by the Dryl architect who had designed the school. Children clambered on a playset just off the main courtyard, but paused when their headmaster called them. “We have a very special guest visiting us today, so please, be on your best behavior.”

“Who’s’it?” a little girl with curly emerald hair and pointed ears called, craning to see over a burly reptilian boy with purple scales.

“It’s the Queen, dummy!”

“You’re a dummy!”

“Eliza, Inigo!” the headmaster snapped. The children fell silent, and Mermista pinched back a smile. “What did I literally just say?”

“Sorry, ma’am.”

“And who else should we apologize to?”

“Sorry, your majesty.” The children shuffled their feet self-consciously.

Mermista smiled. “It’s totally okay. What are you guys up to today?”

The children surged forward, all chattering at once, pointing and laughing. Mermista laughed and sat on a bench, content to let them swirl around her. She nodded and smiled and said ‘wow, really?’ when it was appropriate. But children are bloodhounds, and they soon turned to interrogating her.

“Your majesty, is the war over yet?”

“Not yet-”

“Queen Mermista, my mommy is in your navy! She said you gave her a medal last week!”

“I did. Your mother is very brave-”

“Your maj’sty, why did the pirates stop coming to Salineas?”

That brought her up short. “Sorry?”

The same little girl from before, Eliza, pushed her way to the front, only to trip on the pearly cobblestone and latch onto her skirt for balance. She couldn’t have been more than six, Mermista mused. “The pirates, they used to come all the time to the markets! And they brought the coolest stuff with them. Where’d they go?”

“Yeah!” another child piped up. “The one always had exotic birds, and the other guy, with the eye patch, he brought jewelry.”

“The mustache man with the books and sweets!” a young tyrosaur called. “He juggled too! ‘Member him?”

“Yeah!” the lizard boy cheered. “He did cool sword tricks, and he would tell the best stories!”

“I dropped my doll once at the market,” a quiet child murmured, hugging said doll close. “He chased after me and made sure I got it back.”

“Where’d he go?” Eliza pouted.

Mermista’s heart clenched. Of course the kids knew Sea Hawk. Of course he had built up a relationship with the next generation of Salinean sailors. Because he was Sea Hawk. “The pirates left because of the Horde," she said softly, and the kids turned back to her with a gasp. "Many of them were...taken, or they're hiding because it's not safe right now." She glanced at the headmaster, who nodded at her. Mermista didn't believe in lying to kids, but she didn't want to scare them either.

Eliza's lip wobbled. "Even the mustache man?"

Mermista sighed, and hoisted the girl into her lap. A few other young kids scrambled onto the bench to sit closer to her, and she was glad she left her trident at home. Eager kids and big pointy fork do not a happy time make. "No, the mustache man wasn't taken. He's helping the Rebellion beat the Horde."

"You know the mustache man?" Tyrosaur child rumbled.

Mermista forced a smile. "I do, yes. He's…" How the fuck should she say this to kids? Keep it simple, probably. "He's my very best friend."

The kids all gasped in delight at this revelation. One pink haired nymph danced forward. "Is the mustache man gonna be Mustache king?"

"Uh-" Mermista flushed.

"He can't be king, silly, he's a pirate!" Inigo sighed. "Right?"

"Well-"

"That's dumb," Eliza scowled. "He should get to be king. He can balance a spoon on his nose."

"That's true." The other children nodded sagely, as if this was the most important factor when determining the line of succession.

Thankfully, the headmaster swooped back in from where she'd been standing off to the side, letting Mermista control the situation. "Alright, landlubbers. It's time for lessons to begin, and for the Queen to continue her tour. Say goodbye now."

"Awwwwwwwwwww!" all the kids whined. Little by little, they waved or called goodbye, and began to trickle back to class. Eliza stood on the bench, and wrapped bandy arms around Mermista's neck.

"I hope you get to see mustache man again soon, Your Majesty. If Inigo left, I'd miss my very best friend, too." The little girl smiled at her, missing teeth winking at her.

Mermista tried to smile despite the sudden lump in her throat, and the pricking in her eyes. "Thank you, Eliza. Have a good day of lessons, alright?" Mermista set her down on her feet, and the little sailor-in-training dashed off to join her friends. The queen noticed with a pang that the little boy from earlier, Inigo, had waited for her by the door. The two linked hands and ran off together. She pressed her manicured nails to her lips gently, breathing deeply just like Perfuma had told her to do in these moments.

“Your Majesty?” A hand landed gently on her shoulder, and Mermsita looked up to see the headmaster staring at her intently. She had gorgeous eyes. “Are you alright?”

“Fine, yes.” She cleared her throat and stood, brushing off the lehenga of her dress. “Just, y’know, a bit tired. Meetings ran late last night.”

The woman nodded. “I see.” Her lilac eyes flicked over Mermsita. “Your Majesty, forgive my boldness, but would you like to join me in my office for...afternoon tea?”

Mermista’s eyes widened gently. The ways of sirens were not unknown to her- some members of her own family were half-siren. And when a siren invites you for tea, or cards, or a chat, it is rarely ever just that. There was nothing garish or unseemly about it, in her mind. Different species had different cultures, and who was she to judge those practices? As it were…

“Yeah, I think I would like that.”

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Sea Hawk surfaced from the inky black pool of his drunken slumber aware of several things- he was naked, he was sore, he was hungover as hell, and he needed to get the fuck out of there, like, yesterday.

He peeled himself off the questionable sheets, rolling to his feet and immediately regretting it. Nausea was clambering up his throat, and the sweaty, cloying scent of the room wasn't helping. He sidestepped the equally naked bodies strewn around the room in varying states of their own drugged sleep, pushing away the memories of these people from the night before. He dressed quickly, and stepped from the room into the hall of Seaworthy's brothel. He wrinkled his nose, and left as quickly as he could.

It had been five months since he'd left Salineas, but he would be pressed to remember that number on a good day. Sea Hawk couldn't remember the last day he'd been fully sober. He marked the passage of time by the memos he sent to Brightmoon. In these months, he'd busted a weapons trading ring, three plans to take over Alwyn's farms, and sent along the whispers of something involving the turncoat, Entrapta, and First Ones tech. He'd also personally fought about a dozen (two dozen?) Horde soldiers in various bar brawls when he was down in Noman's Land. And when he wasn't doing that, he was under, on top of, or between whatever paramour he picked to get him through the nights where his thoughts were too loud.

But, no matter how he tried, how much he drank, or fucked, or smoked, *she* never left his mind. Her voice, deep and alluring, sexy and soothing all at once, whispered in his ear. Her eyes winked at him from mirrors and the bottoms of whiskey glasses.

And her body, those gorgeous curves, the hills and valleys of her, was always just out of reach when he was tangled in strange sheets. No one grabbed his hair right, no one took him in hand or mouth like she did, no one challenged him, or submitted, just quite right.

And so, he'd started setting more ships on fire, just to feel the flicker of warmth it gave him. Or, in one particular eye-patched man's case, because it was the only way he was getting out of there alive. Falcon may have been the best fuck he'd had since he left Mermista, but the man was absolutely deranged, and not in the fun way. Sea Hawk had also set more than his fair share of Horde ships on fire, but he was practically getting paid to do that, so it didn't really count.

Sea Hawk stepped out into the light of a new day, and silently cursed the sea for daring to look so beautiful. He hopped aboard his ship, checked the lines, and was casting off in a matter of minutes. The queen had requested he go to the Enchanted Grotto that evening, and Sea Hawk didn't feel like hanging around shore until then. Seaworthy was too close to Salineas, and it was easier to avoid detection on the open sea.

He whiled away the day sending a letter to Bill, retired but still invested in the war efforts, and another to Bow, who claimed he missed him and wanted to plan a "Boy's Night". Sea Hawk smiled at that; the lad was genuine, and a roaringly good time once he got some booze in him. Idly, he wondered if he'd have ended up someone like Bow if he'd never joined up with Bill. Rather, never had to join up with the pirates. Not for the first time, his thoughts turned to his old home in Snows, and his mother. His thumb ran over the compass he kept in the lining of his jacket, before it caught on the other item he'd taken to keeping there, and now couldn't bring himself to toss.

He pulled the ring out of its confines, frowning when it caught the sun's rays and winked at him. It was pure gold, two bands running over and back like streams of water. The diamond was solitaire oval cut, surrounded by tiny sapphires, opals, and barely-there flecks of emeralds. Each gem was inlaid in gold. Sea Hawk had had it custom made on one of his Bright Moon expeditions, by a jeweler in Salineas. The man had recognized him, but had said nothing. At the time, Sea Hawk had assumed it was kindness. Now, he wondered if it was out of pity for the delusional man who thought he had a shot with the queen. He snorted, and shoved the ring back into the lining of his jacket. It was time to get ready.

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Mermista met up with the siren thrice more before they reached the mutual conclusion that it wasn't really for them. It just so happened that they reached this conclusion when Mermista's guard were holding the woman at spear point for selling out trade information to Horde spies. She had fought them briefly, but the evidence was overwhelming, and she soon gave in. She was escorted to the detention center, and Mermista was once again left alone, fuming at herself. Not for her weakness, this time, but for her sheer dumb luck.

Five months after Sea Hawk left, Mermista set her first boat on fire. It had been a matter of simplicity to pull up the siren's licenses, and after a quick stroll to the docks to find the correct ship, well. It was really a no-brainer. Still, as Mermsita watched the flames climb higher and higher with no small amount of satisfaction, she felt...cold. The phantom sensation of arms around her waist, a strong chin hooked over her shoulder, whooping in her ear. Kisses on her neck...teeth scraping downward while a hand climbed up…

Fire had always done something for Sea Hawk, flipped a switch in him. Mermista was completely beginning to understand why. For now, though, she turned, shaking off the ghosts, and went back to her castle.

Three days later, Princess Perfuma was once again announced to Mermista as she sat on her throne. Her friend bustled in, basket and pack in hand just as she had before. Only this time, she looked harried, the twitch in her eyes betraying her lack of inner peace. “Mermista, we have to go to Bright Moon. Adora, Glimmer, and Bow are missing, and the queen is calling on the Alliance.”

Mermista was up and out of her throne before Perfuma finished speaking. Together, they jogged to her rooms so she could change out of her simple kurta and a harem pants, and into her reinforced leggings and shoulder plates. She lashed them to her armored crop top and shoved her feet into her high tops in the same motion, and snapped her gold belt around her waist as they left the room. She took her trident from her Guard (formerly ButlerGuard, but now that some of her staff was back, he happily reclaimed his single title) with a quick ‘thank you’ and the two were out of the castle and on the road to the docks in under fifteen minutes.

“Will Salineas be alright without you?” Perfuma asked. Though, even as she said it, it was obvious she had noticed the change in the air of the kingdom. People bustled in the rejuvenated markets, ships filled the harbors, and children ran to and fro among the wet cobbles of the castle town square. Life had been breathed back into Salineas at the hands of its queen. People waved, nodded, smiled, and shouted greetings as they passed, and even in her haste, Mermista returned each one with at least a nod. Perfuma beamed. "Nevermind, then."

"My advisors know what to do, like, specifically for moments like this. We have several really detailed plans, which, yeah, may be overkill. But, y'know-"

"Better safe than sorry." Perfuma grimaced. "I know what you mean. I've already named an emergency successor to the Heart Blossom, in the event of, well. You know."

Mermista did know. Their lives had never hung by a thinner string. "I should consider that for the Pearl when I get back. Doesn't the Heart Blossom need a direct descendant?"

Perfuma shook her head. "No, it's different from the other Runestones. It's called the 'heart' blossom for its shape, yes, but also for its ability to read the contents of one's heart, their intentions and wishes and so on. So we had those interested step up to it, and allow it to scan their souls. The one chosen was one compatible with its powers, yes, but also one who could uphold the beliefs of Plumeria."

"Wow." Mermista was tying her hair up as they reached the end of the stone pier. "That's intense. But also, like, genuinely smart. In case you don’t want kids or can’t have them.”

“The Pearl is bound to your bloodline?”

“Yup.” She popped the P as she rolled her shoulders. “Only merfolk can connect to it, and we’re the only remaining merfolk who can live on land and sea, apparently. My distant cousins in the sea refuse to learn the spells, claiming it taints the blood or some bullshit, I don’t know. Point is, I need to have a baby.”

She summoned a wave, and waited for Perfuma to fashion herself a vine platform so she could surf it along with Mermista. This was their usual way of getting to the Whispering Woods when taking a ship would just eat up too much precious time. That and their usual ride had fucked off to who knows where for the past five months. They were well underway, coasting along on the open sea, before Perfuma spoke again.

“Do you want that?”

“Want what?”

“A baby.”

“Oh, uh...” Mermista swallowed. She hated this conversation. “I don’t really know. I’ve never thought about it in terms of, like, wanting, you know? It’s just something that, like, needs to happen. I’m sure I’ll love the kid, or whatever, I’m not worried about that.”

Perfuma hummed to herself. “Will you use magic, or the biological approach?”

Mermista flushed. “Depends, I guess, on where I’m at in life. Right now, the biological approach isn’t looking all that feasible.”

“And why’s that?” Perfuma was not as coy as she thought she was. “I’m sure you could find a suitor in a snap.”

“You know damn well why,” she grumbled, jostling the waves a bit on purpose. “I don’t want to have a random ass kid with some random ass dude. I’ve never wanted that. I’d rather do it on my own.”

“Mermista...” Here comes the Motherly Tone. “You know that there is an obvious...solution here, right?”

She snorted humorlessly. “Maybe it was obvious last year. Now, it’s anything but.”

“And why not?”

“Because I don’t even know where said solution *is* , Perfuma!” she snapped. “And even if I did, he wouldn’t want it anyway.”

“How do you know?”

“He’s a pirate, girl,” Mermista groaned. “He hates staying on land. We’ve been over this. He hates...tethers. And mess. He doesn’t handle commitment well, clearly-”

“Now that’s unfair to him, Mermista-”

“And there’s nothing more tethering than a baby! Except like, marriage,” she sighed. “He wouldn’t...it just wouldn’t work.”

Perfuma placed her hands on her hips sternly, which was impressive considering she was surfing on a vine mat going about 48 clicks per hour. “Mermista, do you want it to work?” Mermista shrugged indifferently, even if they both knew it was a front. “Honey, what...what do you want?”

“It’s just not that simple, Perfuma.”

“Why can’t it be? Because you won’t let it be?”

Mermista ground her teeth together, and focused on the pull of the ocean.

“When you picture your future, what do you see?”

“Perfuma, I really don’t know.”

“Mermista-”

“ *I don’t know, okay?!* ” The waves lurched as Mermista sliced a hand through the air. “It is literally impossible for me to picture any sort of future when we’re in the middle of a war! All I know is, a year ago, when I tried to- to dream, or whatever, about what could happen one day, Sea Hawk was there. And now, he’s not, and I don’t know what’s going to happen next. Even then, even with him, I couldn’t see a whole ass future. I couldn’t see a wedding, a second throne, a- a baby...” She choked on the words, and closed her eyes against the vague burn. “I just don’t know, okay? I never have. My whole life has been ‘do this’ ‘go here’ ‘train more’ ‘sit there’, okay? I don’t know… I don’t know-”

“...how to want more?” Perfuma’s voice was soft as she angled herself close enough to lay a hand on Mermista’s shoulder. The ocean princess nodded sadly. “I understand, hon. But, now, you’re the queen! And more than that, you’re your own person. A person who is allowed to want happiness for herself.”

Mermista grit her teeth against the tears. She nodded jerkily. “I can promise I’ll try, but…war, y’know?”

Perfuma heaved her own sigh at that. “I certainly do. C’mon, let’s pick it up. We can meditate on this later.”

“Joy.”

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Sea Hawk slicked his hair back as he stepped into the elevator, pushing the handle down and letting it carry him to his mission. The lounge he walked into was a wonder, a feat of engineering that left him momentarily breathless. The occupants of said lounge, however, had him on high alert. Sirens, thieves, mercenaries and assassins, and no small amount of pirates. Himself included. It said something about his conduct these past few months that he was even allowed in. Despite the glitz and glam, this was a den of depravity, and getting in was as much an accomplishment as it was a scourge.

Sea Hawk meandered about, nodding to old cohorts, chatting up new ones, and fending off advances from an increasingly handsy Octavian individual. If anything, these weeks away from the Alliance had been an ego boost regarding his attractiveness. It was hard to hang around magical royals capable of snapping a mortal in half and not become a bit self-conscious.

A flash of blue caught his eyes, and he cursed himself. Even after all this time- wait, no, there it was again. And it was a lighter blue, like the sky, hints of sea green. Sea Hawk pushed himself off the bar, making his way toward the blur weaving in and out of groups. They were headed for the exit. Suspicious, as the club had only opened a half hour ago. Sea Hawk lunged forward, and grabbed a handful of fine silk. He spun the person around to see-

“Peekablue?”

The sea nymph blinked at him, teal eyes flashing gold and fuschia quickly, before he grinned like a cat. “Well, well, well, if it isn’t Mermista’s old boy toy. What brings you here, Hot Stuff?”

Sea Hawk frowned. “Could ask you the same thing, seeing as you’re a prince and this is a smuggler’s den.”

“Hey, hey!” the prince hissed. “Keep it down, would you? If these yokels find out who I am then I’m finished here.”

“Why are you here, Peekablue?” Sea Hawk reiterated, backing him up further against the wall.

The nymph grunted, but chuckled. “Hmmm, testy aren’t we? What’s wrong, hon? Panties in a bunch because Mermista, let’s see...” His eyes flashed again “...ditched you like yesterday’s tuna catch for her socially appropriate friends? Or is it because...”

Another flash. "...you, oh my god, tried to leave her behind without saying goodbye? Now that's rough-"

"Stop-"

Another flash. "Or is it Entrapta, and her new Alliance? Or the five months you've been at sea with no friends to talk to, or sing with, no crew to get by?" Flash, flash, flash. "The increasingly larger advantage the Horde is creating despite all of your best efforts to stop them?" Flash, flash. "Your village, burned to the ground by the Horde and sacked for all its worth, but no one noticed because you were just a bunch of sailors-"

"Enough!" Sea Hawk pulled Peekablue off the wall to slam him against it, hard. The prince just grinned.

"Or is it that ring burning a hole in your pocket? The ring that you will never, ever give her because you're a filthy little pirate, and she's the stars-damned Queen of Salineas?" His voice was a whisper now. "You are so far out of your league, it's *embarrassing* ."

Embarrassing. Sea Hawk's eyes widened, and he dropped Peekablue to his feet. The prince dusted himself off, and kept talking. "Listen, I've no great love for Mermista. Nor she me. But, I can tell you exactly how this is going to go." He started circling Sea Hawk idly. "She's going to live out the rest of her life trying to keep the Horde from overtaking that little island she's so besotted with, and hey, maybe she'll succeed. Whatever. In the meantime, a marriage with some other kingdom will be arranged, probably

Plumeria. Nothing powerful, since she is, just, y'know, queen of a bunch of islands and not, say, Snows. She'll dump out a brat or two, raise them to be just as...mediocre...as she is, and Salineas will slowly whittle away into the shanty town we all know it's pretending not to be. Unless, of course, there's a coup. Never not an option. And you?" Peekablu snorted. "You're not even worth the effort of far-sight, darling. You'll live an ordinary, sad life, and then you'll die. And that's it. End of story. Goodnight. No fairy tale endings, no derring-do, no heroics. A washed up has-been pirate, and the queen no one will want to remember-"

Sea Hawk's hand snapped out, grabbing Peekablue around the throat. The prince choked, but the pirate paid him no mind as he lifted him off his heels. "No," he snarled. "That's not what's going to happen."

"Give it up, would you?" Peekablue spluttered. "Trust me when I say *I know-* "

"You don't know shit," Sea Hawk snarled. "I love Mermista, and for better or worse, she...she loves me. I know it. And you know it." He gripped the nymph's throat tighter. "Just because I walked away doesn't mean I can't walk back."

And it was true, wasn't it? Somewhere along the line, between the drinks, the drugs, the people, the bar fights, the letters, he'd come to the conclusion that he loved Mermista more than life itself. She was capricious, mercurial, and sometimes, downright mean. But those were all bits of armor she wore to hide the fact that she was, at heart, kind, empathetic, loyal, and so protective of the things and people she cared for that she'd rather kill herself, and any chance of happiness she may be entitled to, than see them hurt. He believed her when she said that she thought she was pushing him away for his own good. And the rest of it? Well, it wasn't like Sea Hawk had ever backed down from a challenge. Mermista was, like he'd said, a mess. But she was his mess, and more so than that, he was hers. If she'd ever have him again.

Now, it was just a matter of swallowing his ego and pride, sobering up, and sailing back into Salineas to talk. It was, truthfully, much easier to stay out here and hurt. But if he never went back, Peekablue would be right, and he'd die a coward.

Said prince was sneering at him in derision, despite the vice Sea Hawk had on his throat. "I'd love to see you try, you flea-infested-"

A shrill scream broke the growing tension between them. Sea Hawk whirled around, and Peekablue used the distraction to break out. He dropped to his heels, coughing and rubbing his neck. He looked back up at Sea Hawk, and smiled a nasty, slimy grin. "Good luck with your future, Sea Weed. If the whispers are true, the Horde is cooking up something that's going to make all of this...triviality a thing of the past."

"The Horde- what-" Sea Hawk lunged for the prince again, but he was dancing away, cackling at his expense.

"So long, pirate! Tell Mermista I said hi!"

Sea Hawk turned and gasped. White hot light was filling his vision, swallowing up the grotto inch by inch, approaching faster than he could ever hope to outrun. He squeezed his eyes shut, his hand flying to the ring in the lining of his jacket.

'I love you, dearest' were the last thoughts he had before it all faded away.

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Mermista was panting heavily, but hadn't felt so alive in months. She and Frosta had effectively held off the guards in this area of the Fright Zone, encasing most in frozen sewage water. Those who'd gotten past the icy barrier had quickly been knocked out, and now lay in various heaps around them.

Frosta pumped her ice fists. "Woo! Take that, losers!"

Mermista chuckled, and ruffled the younger girl's hair. "Nice, kid. C'mon, let's go find the others."

No sooner had they turned to run after Glimmer and the rest than did a loud *BANG!* crack throughout the Fright Zone, clattering around the walls and leaving their ears ringing. Immediately after, everything began shaking apart. The metal structures rattled around them, chunks of debris and chips of rust falling to the ground. They froze in the hall, Frosta's ice fists melting away. The younger girl's neck craned to see above them. "Mermista?"

Another *BANG!,* followed by a loud groan and rush of heat. Frosta yelped, and backed into the older girl's legs. Mermista's hands came up to grasp parka-clad shoulders. "It's alright, Frosta-" An air vent crashed down in front of them, and Frosta screamed. Mermista hunched over, using her shoulders and arms to tuck Frosta into her abdomen. As fast as she could manage, she summoned whatever sewage she could from the depleted pipes and moved it above them. "Freeze it! Hurry!"

White hot light flashed in Mermista's peripheral. She glanced down, and felt the blood drained from her face. A surge of...something was coming at them, and fast. She only had enough time to push Frosta to the ground and throw an arm over the younger girl's back. "Mermista!"

"Hang on, Frosta!"

It was so easy to forget how young Frosta really was in the heat of battle, or in the war room. But in moments like these, with their own mortality staring them in the face, it was painfully obvious- in the way her eyes filled with scared tears, the way she curled into Mermista as much as possible, the whimper she couldn't bite back- that she was still barely more than a literal child.

Mermista's thoughts were racing, but as the light consumed them, they all fell away, save for the one that never left her; whether she was sleeping, fighting, ruling, or even just eating, there he was. Sea Hawk. Never far from her mind, and, despite the past five months of continual effort and meditation, even less far from her heart. Tears filled her own eyes, at the suddenly very real possibility that she may never see him again.

'I love you, you absolute moron.'

Everything faded to white, and Mermista knew no more.

Chapter End Notes

Next up: portal adventures!

this ship will carry our bodies safe to shore

Chapter Summary

> The Portal

Chapter Notes

> I hope this chapter is up to snuff. I struggled with it A LOT, and this is where it wound up.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mermista peeled her eyes open slowly, groaning when the white hot morning light temporarily blinded her. She rolled over, yanking the duvet up above her head. She grunted, feeling...unwieldy. Her center of balance was all fucked up, that much was obvious even from bed. She must have taken a hit to the hips during the...Fright Zone...raid…? What? Like a tadpole in a stream, the thought slipped through her clumsy morning-brain fingers. She sighed, pushing the lingering feeling of wrongness the thought left her with, and focused instead on stretching. Her knees popped, her ankles crackled, and her shoulders made a dull *thunk* when she reached them out. Either she was more stressed than she realized, or her age was catching up to her faster than was healthy. Probably both.

When she went to starfish her limbs to pop her back better, her left foot and hand brushed something very warm, and very...breathing? Mermista yelped, yanking her extremities back to her body. She pulled the duvet off the thing in her bed, ready to reach out for the water sitting on her night stand. Her heart stuttered in her chest, faltering like a skiff engine when she saw who laid next to her.

Sea Hawk whined, burying his head into his pillow. “Five more minutes, love, please.”

Love? Mermista blinked. Yes, love. He called her love, like, a kajillion times a day. Just yesterday he said it enough to fill a tome six inches thick. She passed a hand over her eyes, groaning in frustration at this weird mental fog that wouldn’t leave her. Sea Hawk’s head popped up at that, warm brown eyes full of doting concern. “Are you alright, dearest?”

She flopped back down, tossing his allotment of comforter back over him. She couldn’t stop staring at him, like he was some sort of wonder. She couldn’t shake the feeling that it had been a long, long time since she’d seen him. The way her heart ached at the sight of him, the way she missed him even though he was *literally right there* . She scooted closer, and he rolled onto his side to open his arms to her. She settled into his chest, and it felt like a part of her that had been rolling around like a loose screw suddenly slotted into place. She was *home* . “Yeah. Perfect.”

The fog dissipated more now, as she breathed in the scent of him. Sandalwood, pine trees, something spiced like cinnamon. The ever lingering tang of salt and sweat and musk from working on ships day in and out. Mermista frowned, and shifted. And shifted some more. And then again a third time. “Dear?”

“Ugh, sorry, I just like, cannot get comfy right now.”

Sea Hawk nodded in understanding. “Is he on your bladder again?”

What. “Is...who on my bladder?”

“Uh...” He frowned at her. “The baby?”

Mermista was certain that if her train of thought had brakes, they had just screeched, broken off, and now the whole train was on fire and careening toward a wall. “The...baby.” She pushed back from him, and scrambled out of bed to her full length mirror. It was clear before she even saw her unrecognizable reflection- Mermista was, in fact, solidly pregnant. The gentle swell of her stomach, the fullness of her boobs, and the fact that she really, really had to pee. “I...yeah. Be right back.”

Of course she was pregnant. She was four and a half months along, they were reasonably sure it was a boy. Mermista shook her head. This wasn’t news; one didn’t become pregnant overnight- well, okay, yes they did. But not four months pregnant. She sighed, took the time to relieve herself, and made her way back to the bedroom. She grimaced as she walked. She had the strangest feeling, as though her stomach wasn’t really...there. Like, duh, obviously it was. But when it wasn’t in her immediate vision, or she wasn’t thinking about it, she felt her balance return to normal, her body loosen up.

Sea Hawk frowned at her as she sat back on the bed. “Dearest?”

“I’m alright, just...” She waved a hand vaguely in the air. “Pregnant stuff, I guess.”

He hummed noncommittally, but dropped it easy enough. She frowned at that; Sea Hawk had never dropped anything in his life. But he pushed up off the bed before she could grill him about it. “We should dress, then. We’re meeting your mother for breakfast, and then we’ve got that meeting with the new Harbor Master.”

“Yeah, alright.” Mermista yawned, and got back to her feet. Something was itching in her brain again, but at this point she was so annoyed by her own mind it was all too easy to ignore it.

She dressed in a navy kurti gown, embellished with gold, and left her feet bare. Her hair felt longer than she remembered it being yesterday when she went to braid it, but she chalked it up to pregnancy hormones. At her vanity, she saw the red bindi sitting in a place of honor, inlaid in gold, alongside the most beautiful ring she’d ever laid eyes on. The band ran over and back like water, swirling around an opulent oval diamond, studded with blue and green and white gems. She slipped it on, and it felt...right. It felt perfect. Applying the bindi was rote motion, they’d been married for over three years, but it still felt new. Thrilling. Tracing her hairline part lightly in sindoor elicited the same feelings.

By the time she stood, Mermista’s heart was full and the rest of her was incredibly annoyed about that. Sea Hawk stepped from the bathroom, and her breath hitched. He wore a long blue leather great coat, embellished in gold just as her kurti was. His shirt underneath was simple and white, her pants a deep charcoal. The boots he wore were knee high, fine and supple leather more expensive than she could recall him wearing. Around his head sat a thick banded crown, the gold swirled and stamped and finely crafted like nothing she’d seen before. Each peak of it held a small opalescent gem, remnant of the Pearl. Sea Hawk grinned at her when they locked eyes. He crossed the room and leaned in to capture her lips.

Mermista sighed into the kiss, smiling helplessly. She had missed this...but why? They kissed so much it was borderline ridiculous; wake up kisses, morning sex kisses, kisses in the bathroom and closet as they got ready, on the way to their respective jobs, so on and so forth. It was absurd. She pulled away softly, grinning when he chased her lips to kiss them again. She opened her eyes-

And they were in the dining room down the hall. Mermista frowned, shifting on her pillow. Sea Hawk sat beside her, his hand resting on hers on the low table. She turned and caught him looking equally confused, blinking at her in surprise. He opened his mouth to say something, but the door opening behind him cut him off.

Mermista glanced past him, and felt her chest give way. " *Ami?* "

Queen Nerida smiled at her daughter, and it was as kind and warm and playful as she remembered. "Good morning, beta. How did you sleep?"

Mermista was up and off her cushion in a blink, helpless to stop herself from all but charging her mother. They collided with an *oof* , but when Nerida wrapped her arms around Mermista, it was with as much desperate strength as her daughter. A kiss was pressed to her temple, and the younger woman felt her eyes fill with tears. "Ami...I've missed you."

“Mermista...” Her mother chuckled. “I saw you yesterday, love.”

“I...I know. I just-” How do you explain to your mother that it feels like there’s a hole in your chest, and in your brain, where yesterday should have been? Where *she* should have been?

They separated, and Nerida brushed the tears from her daughter’s cheeks with a gentle sweep of her thumb. “I remember how it was, being pregnant with you. Everything was so much, all of the time. Eh?”

Mermista smiled, though it was wobbly. “Yeah. You know how it is.”

Nerida grinned back, and winked conspiratorially. “Plus, I don’t imagine you get much sleep with that husband of yours around, beta.”

Her cheeks flamed. “Ama-!”

Nerida laughed, full and bright and beautiful, just like Mermista used to.

Used to? What-? She blinked, and they were all at the table. Empty plates and bowls sat in front of them, and she felt full but...Mermista had no recollection of eating.

She blinked away that fog again, and tried to tune into whatever Sea Hawk and her mother were discussing. Talks of Sea Hawk's mother's impending visit gave way to discussions of trade agreements...trade routes...ships...blah blah blah. She settled further into her pillow, and placed a hand on her stomach. This day was one never ending out of body moment. Mermista heaved her usual sigh, and closed her eyes.

Bright light flashed behind her eyelids, and she opened them with a yelp. It was morning again, a different morning? She was standing half-dressed in the large walk-in closet she shared with Sea Hawk. Her husband stood in his sleep pants, hair mussed and chest bare as he stared at the folded clothes on the chair in front of him. It was royal garb, like he'd worn yesterday, but now he stared at it perplexed. He held up a velvet coat, staring at himself in the full length mirror. Mermista came up behind him, wrapping her arms around his torso as she pressed gentle lips to his inked shoulder. "Sebastian?"

He started, like he hadn't realized she was there. Their eyes met in the mirror, and he smiled shakily. "Sorry, I just. I don't remember this coat. It's...it's nice."

She peered at it. "It's the one I got you for our second wedding anniversary, remember?" She watched as the gears clicked into place in his mind, and he shook his head self-deprecatingly.

"Too many knocks to the ol' steel trap, I guess." He rapped his knuckles on his skull before turning in her arms. "How are you, my love?"

Mermista leaned her head on Sea Hawk's shoulder, sighing blissfully when his hand crept up to scratch gently at her scalp. "Fine. Sore. Growing a person is tough."

"She'll be here soon." Sea Hawk pressed a kiss to her hair. "And it'll all be perfect."

Perfect, yeah- wait. She? Mermista frowned. "Didn't the healer say the baby was-" She lifted her head from Sea Hawk's shoulder, and in the next instant he was gone. Electricity buzzed faintly in her ear and-

She was in the throne room, now. She clasped her trident in one hand, and the arm of her throne in the other. A messenger stood in front of her, staring at her expectantly. She cleared her throat. "I'm sorry, I didn't hear you. What was that?"

"The Horde, your majesty. New ships have been spotted just outside our waters. What should we do?"

Sea Hawk spoke from her left, and she whipped her head around. When did he get there? "Double the border patrol, send no ship out on its own. Sail only those vessels that are battle ready, and begin arming the ones that aren't."

“Yes, Your Highness.” The messenger saluted, and sprinted off. Mermista turned to Sea Hawk with alarm.

“The Horde? Didn’t we just send them packing like, a month ago?”

Sea Hawk frowned. “I...I thought so, as well.” He smoothed his mustache with his forefinger and thumb, pinching an end. He always did that when he was deep in thought. “No matter. If they’re coming back so soon, we’ll be ready.”

Mermista frowned. He was so...serious. She remembered an idle wish of hers from long ago, that he’d stop being such a reckless goofball and take this war seriously. But now… “C’mon, I’m hungry.”

He cracked a grin at that. “Already? We just had breakfast.”

“Blame it on the baby, I suppose.”

“I don’t know if you can do that once she’s been born.”

Wait, *what?* Her hand flew to her stomach, only to find it utterly flat, if slightly less toned than it had been before her pregnancy. Glancing down, silvery stretch marks, like water rippling under the sun, kissed her abdomen, visible through the gap in her lehenga choli. *What the f-*

"Ama! "

She glanced up. They weren't in the throne room any more. Mermista stood in the doorway of a soft, sky blue nursery. Plush carpeting, soft toys on the floor, bright and blocky books on tiny shelves. A white crib, detailed with carvings of waves, with a nautical and aquatic mobile hanging above it. Standing in the crib was a baby, nearing one year old if she had to guess. Mermista blinked, and the baby was out of the crib, standing on wobbly legs in front of it. One of the bars was grasped in a tiny, pudgy fist for balance, while her other hand was flung outward toward her.

The baby- her daughter- wore a soft white cropped tee, and a scalloped floor length navy skirt, each layer rimmed in shimmering gold. Her hair, navy and teal like Mermista's own, was curling wildly, just brushing her shoulders.

"A-ma!" Her tiny mouth held even tinier teeth, bared in an ecstatic grin. Mermista's body took over, kneeling down and holding out her arms.

"C'mere, beta."

Her daughter shrieked, and toddled over haphazardly. She stumbled just as she reached Mermista, spilling into her arms. She felt herself laughing, feeling lighter than she could remember ever feeling. Deep mahogany eyes peeked out of blue fringed bangs at her, heart-achingly familiar. She moved to brush her daughter's bangs out of her eyes, but suddenly she was gone.

She and Sea Hawk were in their bedroom again. Mermista sat at her vanity, Sea Hawk behind her. Their eyes locked in the mirror. "Sebastian-"

"Mermista-"

"What the hell is happening?" Their reflections asked in tandem. A *BOOM!* shook the castle, and Mermista stood from her seat to grab Sea Hawk's arms. She looked out at the balcony- but the balcony was gone.

"Where's the...where's the balcony?"

"What balcony?" Sea Hawk frowned. "We never had one in this room."

"But-" Another explosion cut her off. She yelped, and Sea Hawk pulled her tighter. "What's happening? Where's our daughter?"

"Who?"

“The- the kid! The kid I saw in the nursery!” Mermista wracked her brain for a name, and came up empty. What was her name? “Nevermind, where’s my mother?”

“I don’t know. I last saw her-”

“At breakfast?”

“No.” Sea Hawk flinched as something hit the wall of the castle just beyond them. “In the gardens, for tea. That was this morning, right?”

Mermista’s brain was flying apart at the seam. Every detail she tried to grab slipped away, replaced by something else she couldn’t understand. Her head was pounding, and she buried it in Sea Hawk’s chest. A hand came up to cradle the back of her head. This was...wrong. It was all wrong.

She pulled away from him. “You’re not my husband.”

Sea Hawk did a double take. “What?”

“This is wrong!” Mermista had to shout to be heard over the dull roaring that was growing louder by the second. “We didn’t get married, Sebastian. We- we broke up, remember?”

He let go of her, seizing his head with a groan. “Yes...no...I don’t know!”

She laid her hands over his, feeling the tears gathering in her eyes. It was getting brighter, just like before. The light was coming back to take them somewhere else. They were out of time. “My mother...she’s dead. So is yours. They’re not…” She choked on a sob. “They can’t come back. And we-”

“No, please.” Sea Hawk leaned his head against hers, tears carving paths in his ruddy cheeks. She pressed in, kissing his temple.

“We don’t have a baby.” Her voice cracked. “We didn’t get married. The Horde is coming, and we’re at war, and everything is going to shit and-”

“I love you,” Sea Hawk sobbed against her lips. “I love you so much, and I’m sorry, and-”

She cut him off by pressing her lips to his, hungry and sad but so, so gentle. “I love you, too. I meant that then, and I mean it now. And I’m sorry, too, Sebastian. I’m sorry for being so cold, and cruel, and- and mean. I love your stupid shanties, and your dumbass theatrics, all of it. I love *you.* ”

Tears flowed freely down his cheeks. “Mermista…”

The walls around them were gone, sucked into a violent pink and white ether that was closing in, waiting hungrily just beyond them. The white flames licked up her arms as she wound them around Sea Hawk, capturing his lips again. If this was how she had to die, it really couldn’t have been better. One of his arms wrapped around her waist, the other circling her shoulders. She pulled back to whisper against his lips. “I love you, Sebastian.”

“I love you, too, Mermista.” He recaptured her lips. She cupped his jaw in her hands, and let the celestial fire burning around them swallow them up.

Chapter End Notes

> Here we are,,,, who’s to say what happens next? (Me, I am, and I’m very excited)

come and crash into me ‘cause i want us to collide

Chapter Summary

In the wake of tragedy, it often becomes clear what the most important parts of life are, and how dearly we need to hold onto them

Chapter Notes

I couldn’t leave them apart long… c’mon now

I grappled a lot with this chapter and the next so i hope it’s up to snuff.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mermista woke up on the floor with a gasp. She was...wet? She groaned, rolling over onto her back and sitting up. Her muscles screamed, as if her whole body had been pulled taught and then suddenly released. Vaguely, she became aware of her surroundings. The Fright Zone, right. They’d been raiding the Fright Zone. The creaking metal, grunts and moans of injured people, and...sobbing.

She whirled to her right, only to grind her teeth against the flash of pain. She felt like one big bruise. Frosta lay curled in a ball next to her, hiccupping into her sleeve. Mermista gathered the girl to her, rubbing her back and doing her best to soothe the young princess. “Hey, hey, it’s okay. C’mon Frosta, it’s alright.”

“I- I saw them-,” she wailed into Mermista’s shoulder. “I saw them! They were right there.”

“Saw who?”

“My dads!” she cried. “I saw my dads. They were alive, and they hugged me, and- and everything was…”

“Perfect?”

“Ye-e-es!” She sobbed. Mermista’s heart clenched. Frosta was so young...too young for all of this. But as the Princess of the Fractal Flake, she had no choice but to be here.

“I saw my mom, too,” she murmured. Frosta sniffed and pulled back, wiping her eyes in shock. “It was...she was right there. I think I…”” Her eyes started to fill with tears. “I think I was starting to forget what she looked like, y’know?”

Frosta nodded miserably. “I didn’t recognize them, at first. I’d only ever seen a picture or two…”

They sat in sullen silence until Frosta got her breathing under control. Mermista dried her eyes, and sifted through the alternate, “perfect” reality. A hand ghosted over her abdomen, where the aching was worst, and the flat planes of her stomach shocked her. She glanced down, prodding her belly. No stretch marks, no bulge...no baby. Nausea welled in her throat, but she pushed it away. That kid hadn't even been *real* , she scolded herself. Just a figment of stardust and tech and...want.

Was that what she wanted?

Images flashed like lightning before her eyes; waking up next to Sea Hawk, marking herself as his wife, Sea Hawk as King of Salineas, Sea Hawk next to her on his own throne… Sea Hawk's daughter. Her daughter. Their baby.

An surge of *want* rose up in her like a tidal wave, so strong she had to squeeze her eyes shut. *Yes* , she screamed inside, *I want that* . *I want that future, with him.* And when she opened her eyes, Mermista knew the truth of it in her heart; she would fight anyone, do anything, win this whole damn war, to have that dream become their reality. She rose to her feet, and held a hand out to Frosta. "C'mon, kid. We've gotta get out of here and find the others before they all wake up."

Frosta wiped the last of her tears away and nodded. She'd schooled her features into somber determination, and Mermista saw the strength in her eyes. She was still too young, but she would be okay. She grabbed the older woman's hand, and together they ran off to find their friends.

They rounded a corner and collided with Perfuma, who surged forward to grab Mermista in a desperate hug. "Thank the stars, you're alright. Both of you." She ghosted a hand over Frosta's head and down her cheek.

“Let’s go. Now.”

From there they took off toward the Sanctum, or where they figured it would be. At the end of the next hall, a door opened, Catra and Hordak spilling out of the darkness and making a break for it. Collectively, they decided against the chase, and instead made for the dark laboratory. She-Ra, Bow, Glimmer, and Shadow Weaver were already in a circle; Glimmer and Shadow Weaver’s hands were joined, the teleportation rune spinning to life around them. Hastily, they all grasped hands, and in the blink of an eye, the Fright Zone faded away to Bright Moon. There was a pause, and then-

“We did it!”

At once, Bow surged forward and lifted Glimmer in a victory hug. Frosta and Perfuma collided, while She-Ra all but tackled Mermista in a hug. Mermista flushed, because, like, c’mon. It was She-Ra. She returned the muscley, glowing embrace with fervor, though, allowing herself this moment of emotion. Her friends were okay, they were all okay-

“-gonna be grounded for life, but-”

At once, She-Ra’s smile faded when she heard Glimmer speak, and she turned to the glittery princess. Like a receding tide, the warrior vanished, replaced by a very tired, and very miserable Adora. She turned to Glimmer, and placed her hands on her shoulders. Mermista allowed them the space, but drifted closer to Perfuma and Frosta to listen.

“Angella…”

Oh gods, no. Please no. Mermista gripped Frosta’s shoulder in one hand, and tangled her fingers with Perfuma’s in the other.

“She stayed behind, she...she…”

Mermista watched as Glimmer’s face morphed from uncertainty, to shock, to an abject misery she knew all too well. Tears filled the younger princess’ eyes, and she squeezed them shut as she clung to Adora.

“She saved us.”

Glimmer pulled away, and Mermista had never seen the headstrong girl look so...lost. As one, they moved to Glimmer and Adora. Mermista placed her hand on Adora’s shoulder, but kept her eyes locked on the new Queen. She knew...she knew this pain. Knew what Glimmer was feeling. The guilt, the sorrow, the all encompassing grief, and the feeling that she was suddenly very, very alone. Even circled by her friends, the loneliness was tangible.

They broke apart when the guards came running in, ushering Glimmer inside to her Aunt Castaspella. The rest of them shifted from foot to foot, unsure of what to do. Bow and Adora locked eyes, and nodded, before turning to them. “We’re going to go be with Glimmer, but the rest of you should head back to your kingdoms. Make sure everyone is alright.” Did Adora’s eyes linger on her when she said that?

Bow cleared his throat, even as tears streamed down his face. He had been very close to the Queen, everyone knew she had seen Bow and Adora like her own kids. “I’m certain that...invitations to the coronation will be sent out within the week.”

They nodded somberly, and Mermista thought of her own solitary coronation. The loneliness had been the worst then.

The three of them walked as one to the castle’s main entrance. “Will you guys get home alright?” Perfuma murmured.

Frosta nodded. “I have a ship waiting in the harbor. Mermista, do you want a ride?”

She shook her head. “No, I’m gonna swim it. I need to clear my head and…” She looked up into Perfuma’s eyes. “There’s someone I need to see.”

“Is it Sea Hawk?” Frosta asked, unimpressed. “Because he hasn’t been around in, like, forever, and you’ve been kinda crankier than usual.”

Mermista sneered at her and stuck out her tongue. “Maybe. What’s it to you, Tiny?”

Frosta balled up her fists. “One day I’m going to tower over you, Fish Stick-”

“Okay!” Perfuma stepped between them. “Time to go home, everyone.”

“Fish Stick?! You little brat-”

“Mermista,” Perfuma snapped. “Walk away.”

“What! She started it-”

“She’s twelve-”

“I’m thirteen!”

“See! Old enough to learn the cardinal rule of ‘talk shit, get hit’.”

“Mermista!” Perfuma turned her forcefully by the shoulders toward the bay. “Don’t you have somewhere more important to be?”

“Ugh! Fine!” she stuck her tongue out at Frosta again for good measure, who all too happily returned the gesture. “We’ll pick this up at the next Alliance meeting, ladies.”

She sauntered away towards the docks, and only when she was certain the other two couldn’t see her anymore did she break into a run. She tore through the harbor, dodging confused sailors and deckhands alike, until she reached the end of an empty pier and threw herself headlong into a (perfect, thank you) dive. The water rushed around her, and she felt the transformation creep up, allowing her full form to come through; she had no idea where Sea Hawk was, exactly, so she felt no need to limit herself to just her tail when she might be swimming around for hours.

The ocean welcomed her as it always did, and Mermista took a moment to revel in the freedom of the open sea. She tore through the tide, leaping from crest to crest like a dolphin. Once past the breakers, she took off as fast as she could, dancing between beams of refracted sunlight, kicking up sand and disturbing bottom feeders. Occasionally she broke the surface to get her bearings, and if she happened to do a somersault or two- well, it wasn’t like anyone was around to witness it.

She arrived at Sea Worthy in record time, and peeked carefully out of the water at the docked boats. The pirates who hung around here were nothing like Sea Hawk- they’d sell her scales in a heartbeat, royal status be damned. She saw nothing, though, no trace of her particular marauder, and so with a huff, she ducked back below the waves.

Mermista made her way back to the open sea, deciding to head for Salineas and take it from there. She could send a message to him with a seagull, or maybe a dolphin. They tended to be smarter, when they weren't being assholes. She was just leaving the main oceanic current for the gulf stream that would carry her to her kingdom when she sensed it- a ripple in the water, a shift in the way it hugged her. She spun around, and saw a rudder cutting through the surf. Not even daring to hope, she pivoted and made for the ship. Halfway there, she broke the surface, and nearly shouted for joy when she saw the fuschia sails. He was right there, *Sea Hawk was right there after almost half a year-*

She didn't slow as she approached, in fact, she sped up. Jumping between waves, gaining momentum with each leap, she gathered her magic behind her and *pushed* . She vaulted herself out of the ocean, clearing the railing with ease. Sea Hawk must have seen her coming, because there he was, standing in the center of the deck, waiting. In the split second before she hit on the deck, she traded her tail for her legs. She landed in a skid, slipping on the water she'd brought with her, but caught herself before she ate shit, thankfully.

Time seemed to grind to a gentle halt as she stood there, chest heaving from her swim, staring at Sea Hawk across the deck...

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Sea Hawk had peeled himself off the floor of the Grotto as fast as he could. His head pounded, and his body ached, like the worst hangover he'd ever experienced. But he had no time to worry about that.

Mermista- I have to get to Mermista

He shouldn't have stayed away- hell, he shouldn't have left. The princesses were in trouble; they had to be. Why else would Etheria be swallowed in a spooky-ass light bubble that showed you a freakishly Perfect world? Magic was the only answer.

He staggered to his feet, and once on them, didn't stop running until he reached his ship (well, he stopped briefly in the elevator so as to not slam into a wall. But he hadn't wanted to, was his point). Sea Hawk had never readied his ship so fast, and within moments, was casting off. He groaned at the realization that it was at least an hour's ride to Salinean waters. And another five until he reached the kingdom itself. Resigning himself to pacing while the boat piloted itself for a bit, he raked his hands through his hair as he tried to process what he had seen.

He and Mermista had been married, and happily so. He'd been the King. Him, *Sea Hawk* , a King! It was truly laughable, and for a moment he wondered if the bubble thing only showed people realities that could never come to pass. It was possible. None of it had really been feasible. It was all 'perfect', yes, but utterly impossible. His mother...Mermista's mother… they were both dead and gone. He reflected on the former queen he'd seen in the other place; Nerida had been stern, but kind. Her voice was soft, and playful when she teased her daughter, but underlined with a quiet, regal strength one only got from years of self-assured ruling. He heard the same in Angella's voice, and even in Perfuma's. And sometimes, when he really listened, he could hear the beginnings of that same tone in Mermista. The queen had also been, to be on-the-nose about it, drop-dead gorgeous. Sea Hawk may have been biased, though, as Mermista was the spitting image of her late mother. Nerida's hair was slightly darker, and her eyes were more brown than amber, but the rest of it might as well have been a clone.

He shook off the phantoms of the former queen's presence, and moved on. Mermista had been... incredible. Calmer, happier, more carefree. She laughed freely, even if she rolled her eyes just as much. She practically radiated contentment. Sea Hawk had almost forgotten how she looked when she wasn't combat-ready; he had forgotten how much she loved full skirts that flared when she twirled. She wore her more decorative piercings, and bangles and bracelets rung her arms. Mermista was tough as nails, but she was also capable of such...softness. Sea Hawk felt ashamed to realize how many of her other facets he'd forgotten over the year or two of this war. Of course she wasn't just stress and anger and cold hostility. Of course she was still gentle, hopeful, kind Mermista, empathetic to a fault, obsessed with mystery novels. He'd come to expect the worst of her, toward the end, so of course that was all he saw.

He hung his head, and pressed the heels of his hands to his eyes. He couldn't afford to break down right now, he needed to focus. In the distance, he heard a sparrow chirp, and his mind pulled forth the other...aspect of the portal he'd been actively not thinking about. Their baby. Sea Hawk's breath rattled in his chest as he thought about the swell of Mermista's stomach, pregnant with their child, and then the little girl herself. She'd been...so vague, so unreal that Sea Hawk couldn't hold onto any true details of her. But he had known she was there in his heart, as fake as that world was. The swell of joy in him as he held his giggling daughter had been real, the shriek of laughter as he’d scrubbed his mustache against her cloud-soft tummy. He’d only held her for seconds, the ghost that was the possibility of his child, but there was a gaping hole in his chest where...someone, or something, should be right now.

A loud splash pulled him from his thoughts, the chattering of dolphins and crying of gulls following. He made his way to the main deck, scanning the port side for any sign of disturbance. The ocean was still- wait, no, something was jumping from wave to wave. He frowned. Only dolphins did that. He leaned over the side, peering hard-

There! Something flashed under the water, the sun catching on a bright spot of...scales? Yes, definitely scales. Sea green and deep navy and-

Sea Hawk’s breath hitched. Once again, the creature broke the surface, zooming closer and closer to his ship. He blinked, and there again, it leapt. Blue hair, deep mocha skin, glittering scales.

Mermista.

No sooner had he stepped back from the deck than did she breach the side of his ship- no small feat, as they were at least forty feet in the air. She landed in a skid so dramatic that he had no choice but to be impressed. His train of thought hit the brakes, and time stuttered to a pause around him. In that second, there was no ship, no ocean, no war; just him, Mermista, and the beat of silence before-

A heart-breaking, desperate sound clawed its way out of Mermista’s throat at the sight of him, one he felt to his own core, but neither of them even startled at it. She came to life all at once, tearing across the deck toward him. Sea Hawk had just enough time to open his arms before she slammed into him, leaping off the deck. The air was pushed from his chest in one motion, but he didn’t care, not even a bit. Her arms wrapped around his neck with iron strength, her hands clutching at his shoulders, while her thighs found purchase around his hips. One of his arms held her fast around the waist, while the other wrapped under to support her from below.

Sea Hawk had the brief, concerning worry that he’d died in the weird portal, that they’d all died, and this was just whatever came next. After all, eternal paradise for him couldn’t be anything more than this; Mermista in his arms, his face buried in her tight, wild curls, the aphrodisiac that was her scent filling his head like a cloud. Lavender, sea salt, spiced incense, pressed flowers, old books and strong coffee...everything that she was. Yes, this could only be paradise. Except-

Mermista was crying. Hard. Her head was buried in his neck, moisture that could only be tears soaking through his neckerchief and sliding down his chest. Her shoulders heaved with sobs, and she was saying something, but for the life of him he didn’t know what.

“Mermista?” Stars, how good did it feel to say her name? “Your Majesty?”

A strangled noise bubbled out of her. She pulled back just enough to speak clearly. "Don't you dare call me that- don't you *dare-* "

"Alright, okay, I'm- I'm sorry." The familiar anxiety, now five months gone, knocked politely on the door of his psyche. Anyone home? Remember me? It called. At a loss for what exactly to do, and very confused in general, Sea Hawk settled for adjusting his grip so he could hike Mermista up higher, swaying gently with the motions of the sea. After a while, the princess' shoulders stilled, and her grip loosened enough to be more intimate than intimidating. Her hand found the curls at the nape of his neck, growing out wildly, and stroked them idly. Sea Hawk shut his eyes and sighed, resting his chin on her shoulder.

"Sebastian?" Her voice was rough, like she'd been yelling instead of crying. "We...we need to talk."

He sighed heavily. "Yes, I rather think we do. My cabin?" She nodded, reluctantly unwinding her legs from his hips so she could drop down. "I have to anchor, give me a moment."

"I can help," Mermista wiped the remaining moisture off of her cheeks. "I know it's...harder...with just one."

Sea Hawk studied her, the way she was hugging herself, the slightly hunched posture, and the way she couldn't fully look at him. At length, he nodded, and they set to bringing the ship to a gentle halt.

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Mermista followed Sea Hawk down into his cabin once the anchor was weighed. It was smaller than the Dragon's Daughter… something. Whichever one they went to prom in. And it was, frankly, a mess. Mermista's heart clenched at the many, many empty bottles, the trashed desk, the stacks of unopened letters from Bright Moon. From...Angella. Oh gods, he wouldn't know. She'd have to tell him-

"Sorry, it's a complete mess. I haven't been living here so much as crashing." Sea Hawk grimaced.

"It's fine, Sea Hawk," She cleared her throat. "Where have you been living?"

He leaned up against the desk, shrugged. "No where, really. I've been, you know, on mission the whole time."

Mermista leaned against the wall opposite the desk. "On mission where?"

He blew out a gusty breath, looking anywhere but her. "Y'know. Seaworthy, Noman's Land, the Grotto, the Crimson Waste, briefly, but that was a dead end, and I'm not super useful the more inland I go. I don't know anyone there, I just hang around the ports-"

“Noman’s Land?” She cut off his anxious rambling. “As in, the Fright Zone bar?”

“It’s not technically the Fright Zone-”

“Sea Hawk.”

He shrugged, more heavily this time. “Yes, that one.”

Mermista exhaled softly through her nose. “Was it...were you safe?”

“No,” he spoke softly, running his hand through his hair. “Not once, in the past five months, have I been safe.”

She swallowed, hard, and willed away the tears pressing at her eyes. They lapsed into silence, broken only when the bird in the corner woke up and flew over to Sea Hawk’s shoulder. He smiled, and ruffled the bird's chest feathers with a gentle finger. The raptor cooed, and then seemed to clock her. Its head tilted, it clicked a few times, before flying at her. Mermista made an *eep!* sound, arm flying up on instinct. The bird landed on her gold vambrace with a metallic *cla-k* and regarded her with beady eyes.

“Uh, hi…” She looked askance at Sea Hawk for a name.

“Shoelace.”

“Fucking what,” she muttered. “Hi, Shoelace.”

The bird preened at the attention from a new person, and even Mermista had to admit he was cute. He tapped around on her metal bracelets for a while, examining them with his beak, before flapping his wings and taking off through the open window. Sea Hawk watched him go with a smile, and when they looked back at each other, the tension in the room was not quite so bad.

Swallowing her pride, Mermista walked over to lean on the desk next to Sea Hawk. When he didn’t move away, or stiffen up, she decided to risk it all and lean into him. Tentatively, an arm came up to wrap around her shoulders, pulling her tighter against him.

“I don’t…” Mermista cleared her throat. “I don’t know where to start, and I’m going to be really, *really* bad at this. So just, like, bear with me?” She felt him nod, and took a deep breath. “I’m sorry. I’m so incredibly, ridiculously sorry. I’m sorry that I made you feel unwanted, and used. I’m sorry that I said you were an embarrassment. It was...wrong. Really wrong of me. To take out my own insecurities on you.” She swallowed hard, looking up at the ceiling and willing away the tears she knew were already dripping down her face. “I’m sorry that I’m bad at words, and-and feelings, and showing you how much I...I love you. Because I do. Love you, I mean.”

“Mermista…”

“Please, wait. I need to get through this now, or I’m never going to do it.”

“I understand. Can you...can we look at each other, please?" He sounded so scared, to even ask this one little thing of her.

Self-hatred stabbed at her, and she nodded. “Of course.”

He pushed off the desk, coming to stand in front of her.

She looked at him, really looked at him, for the first time in months. She drank in the tired eyes, the less-shiny-than-usual mustache, his stubble and overgrown hair. “You look like shit.”

Sea Hawk cracked a smile at that, chuckling slightly. “I missed you, too.”

Mermista smiled against her will, rolling her eyes gently. The mood settled again, and she took a centering breath, like Perfuma had taught her. “What I’m about to say is going to sound bad at first. But it’s not. Just...give me a chance here, please?” When he nodded, she sighed. “Sebastian, three years ago you walked into my life and absolutely ruined it. I had everything laid out exactly the way it was supposed to be; I knew who I was, who I was going to be, and what was expected of me. And then you!” She jabbed a gentle finger into his chest. “You just blew it all to shit. With your adventures, and your arson, and your...passion. I’d never met anyone so in love with life before I met you. And it was like, all of a sudden, I was seeing everything I’d never had, or could never be, personified. And it made me feel...a lot of complicated shit.”

Sea Hawk smiled, reaching up to toy with the ends of her hair. “I know what you mean.”

“On one hand, I'm kind of jealous.” Mermista smiled at his confused look. “Hear me out. You are...loud. And blissfully unaware, or maybe uncaring, of what everything thinks of you. Sebastian, you do whatever you want whenever you want, opinions be damned. You sing off-key just because you can, you light fires, you make people laugh when they don’t want to. You are obnoxious, and over the top, and ridiculous on purpose and you own it. And have never been able to understand why or how.” She sighed, pushing on the corner of her eye to still some tears. Which seemed really stupid considering her entire face was soaked but like, whatever. “Honestly, Sea Hawk, I get jealous. And then I get frustrated because I just don’t understand you sometimes. I don’t understand how you can be so you, and I can’t even be me. Or why, someone so...bright and burning would ever want to be with an emotionally stunted, caustic bitch like me.”

“Hey.”” Sea Hawk’s voice was firm, and deep. “That’s not fair, don’t talk about yourself like that.”

Mermista shrugged. “Whatever. We can talk about that later.”

“And we will.”

“Yes, okay,” She rolled her eyes. “Like I was saying, I just...don’t understand you. I really don’t. Sometimes you’re right there, with me, completely in the moment. And other times you’re running away from me, from responsibility, and I’m left standing there, wondering what happened.” Her voice cracked, and she clenched her jaw. “And sometimes, you’re frustrating on purpose, and over the top on purpose, even when you know it’s driving me insane.”

Sea Hawk sighed, pushing a hand through his hair. “Can I speak yet?”

Mermista nodded, massaging her temples.

“I...am not a consistent person. And that’s very fair, and I understand your frustration. But Mermista, I’m not always great at picking up on your signals. Which, clearly, you’ve noticed. I don’t always know when you want me to stay, or go, or tone it down, or kick it up. I’m...I’m not a mind reader, and I don’t think that it’s very fair of you to expect me to be, when I don’t expect the same of you.”

Mermista snorted. “You never give me a chance to read you, Sebastian. As soon as you're upset, you bolt.”

“I do not-”

“Princess Prom,” She held up a finger, ticking off boxes in her head. “After the battle at Bright Moon. My panic attack about my kingdom during one of your shore leaves. Five months ago, when you were just going to leave without saying goodbye.” Her breath hitched on the last few words, her lips wobbling. “I know I fucked up a lot, Sea Hawk. But you really hurt me, too.”

Sea Hawk hung his head, nodding morosely. “Yeah, that’s...fair.”

Mermista inhaled shakily. “You left, Sebastian. You left like everyone else and I- I completely fell apart. And I’m furious with myself that I could let myself hurt that badly over anyone. It scared the shit out of me.” She swallowed a sob. “I’m good at being a queen. I’m good at being a Princess. I’m good at politics, and infrastructure, and so many other things that I didn’t think I’d ever be good at. But I’m not good at this. At people, and feelings, and- and-”

“Love?” he whispered.

Mermista closed her eyes against the tears and nodded.

Sea Hawk sighed, and tugged her into him, wrapping her in a gentle hug. They stood there for what could have been hours but was probably only minutes before he kissed the top of her head and tugged her away so he could continue. “Mermista...I just want to talk.”

She frowned. “But...we are?”

“No, I mean, like, all the time.” Sea Hawk chuckled. “All I want is to be able to talk. To tell you I’m upset, or feeling pushed away, or even just that I need to go sail for a bit because I’m getting landsick. I want to tell you I’m hurting, and sad, and have you hear me and listen. And I want you to talk to me, and tell me when you need me to listen, to tell me when you’re stressed, or panicking, or even just that you need to be alone. Because I can’t know any of that for sure unless you tell me.”

Mermista nodded slowly, and he reached up to tuck a stray lock of hair behind her ear before cradling her cheek. Her hand came up to cover his.

“I want to talk, because I love you. I want to talk so I can support you, and vice versa. I want to talk because I like the sound of your voice.”

He watched her eyes fill with tears again, even as they tried to roll in exasperation. They only got about halfway through, before they were cut off with a small smile.

“I can...try,” she said. “To be better at talking. I’m not...I’m never going to be good at feelings. Or PDA. I’m not good at showing affection, in public. And clearly I’m not even that great at showing it in private. I don’t understand it fully, and even when I do, I doubt its sincerity. Even coming from people I trust. My whole life, Sebastian, I was told that to show emotion is to show weakness. And I don't… I just don't know how to get better at that." She shrugged, jerky and angry. "I want to, though. And I will. Try, that is. If nothing else, then at least when we're alone together."

Sea Hawk beamed at her, like she'd just hung a new moon in the sky. "That's all I've ever wanted, Mermista. For you to try. And I hope you know that I would never, ever ask you to do anything you weren't comfortable with. That's not fair."

Mermista nodded, mulling over his words. "I...wouldn't have known that before. Truthfully, I didn't think you cared all that much about my comfort in public. With, y'know, the serenading and the hugging and all that. But I know now. So thank you."

"We can work on boundaries," he murmured. "What is and isn't okay, when and where, ways to let me know when its too much. So, if you can try to do more in private, than I can try to be...less, in public. If it would help."

Mermista chewed her bottom lip, searching his eyes. "Is that...okay? You don't feel...bad about that? I don't make you feel bad for needing less sometimes?"

Sea Hawk's heart clenched. "No, dearest. Of course, it's okay."

"Okay," she sighed. "Okay. Good."

They lapsed into silence for a bit, before Sea Hawk noticed Mermista’s eyes filling with tears as she stared off at something. “Mermista?”

“I just- I’m not-” She inhaled shakily. “I’m never going to be as good at this as you want me to be. And I know that, and you know that. And it scares me shitless because one day, you’re going to wake up, and realize just how bad I suck at this, at being...a person, and you’re going to leave.” She sobbed, clapping a hand over her mouth. Sea Hawk wrapped her in another hug. “You’re going to leave like everyone else. Because- because I’m n-not good enough.”

Well, now he was crying too. “Mermista, darling, no. I swear to you, no. I will never leave you, not again. I’m...I’m sorry. I’m so sorry. And I haven’t said it yet, and that’s horrible of me. I shouldn’t have just tried to leave without saying goodbye-”

“No, you had every right to be mad-”

“Mad, yes. Cruel? Absolutely not,” he said. “I can’t fix, or make better, the trauma your father put you through. Both by being there, and by leaving. But I can promise you that I’ll never leave you like that, ever again. I swear it.”

“But I’m-”

“Wonderful? Yes, I quite agree.” He chuckled when she smacked his chest half-heartedly. “Mermista, I don’t want you to ever be anything other than yourself. I don’t care that you can mean sometimes. So can I. I don’t care that you’re a grouch in the morning, or that when you get stressed you start snapping. I only care when you shut me out, and then take things out on me. Because I know you’re so much more than that person.”

“What if I’m not, though?” She pulled back to wipe at her eyes. “What if I’m just… like this?”

“You’re not,” he said calmly. “And right now, these thoughts you're having, they’re a nonsensical spiral. They’re not real, or logical. I have them, too.”

Mermista groaned. “I hate them. I hate this.”

He nodded. “My mother used to call them whirlpools.”

She smiled at the mention of his mother. “What do you do?”

“Well…”” He sighed. “She would say to talk yourself through them. And when that won’t work, talk to someone you trust. And ask them to help pull you out.”

She stuttered a breath, and thumped her head back on his chest. “How?”

He mulled it over for a moment. “What about...a grounding technique? Perfuma talked about those a lot, right?”

Mermista nodded against him.

“Something we can say to each other? That says ‘I’m here, and I care about you, and you’re going to be okay.’”

Mermista pulled back just enough to look at him, keeping her chin on his chest. Her cheeks were flushed red, not the ruddy splotches from crying. “What about ‘I love you’?

Sea Hawk’s own cheeks burned, and he gaped. “I mean...if you’re...are you sure?”

Even though she looked like she was getting teeth pulled, she nodded. “Yes. I have to get better at saying it anyway, so…”

“Alright, then.” He gently took her jaw in his hands, brushing a thumb along her bottom lip. He leaned in until he was less than an inch away, breathing against her lips. “I love you, Mermista.”

“And I love you, Sebastian.”

It was all the invitation he needed to capture her lips with his. Soft, if slightly chapped from the ocean, and warm, her lips moved against his gently at first, and then with fervor. Kissing her was like coming up for air from a deep dive. Pressure he hadn't even realized was on his chest lessened, his shoulders dropping as if they'd been tensed for months. And they probably had. His hands moved to her waist, tugging her flush against him while he ran his tongue along her lower lip. She opened for him with a breathy sigh, tilting her head gently to allow him better access. Her hands tangled in his hair, pulling him impossibly closer. Her tongue, hot and soft, met his gently as he licked deeply into her mouth. Her quiet moans were a symphony, and he was helpless to smile against her lips.

She pulled back slowly, sucking on his tongue just enough as she came away that he groaned. No one, in his months of exploits and hookups, kissed him like that. He was left breathless and spinning and oh, so wanting, but he stopped himself. Mermista looked dead on her feet; the dark circles under her eyes were truly impressive. But she was smiling softly, and looking more at peace than he'd seen her since the war began. He leaned in, and nuzzled her cheek with his nose before pressing a kiss to it. "Do you want to rest in here while I get us to Salineas?"

A look of abject fear flashed across Mermista's face, and she gripped his hair almost painfully. "No...it's- I-"

"Take your time," he soothed, moving to kiss the shell of her ear. "I'm not going anywhere."

Mermista grit her teeth so hard he could feel her jaw move against his. "I don't want…to be alone right now. I want you to stay here. With me.”

Sea Hawk nodded, thanking her silently with another chaste kiss. “I can do that. We’re not in anyone’s way here, I was taking a back route. We can just go to bed.” Mermista nodded and he pulled away to lead her to the v-berth. “I really am sorry for the mess.”

“It’s seriously fine, just…” Mermista twisted her mouth in a grimace. “I’ve never known you to drink quite this much.” The end of her sentence tilted up like a question.

“I was, uh...” He cleared his throat as he took his jacket off. “Not doing great. For the first, like, three and a half months.” He wouldn’t meet her eyes, and Mermista frowned.

“Drinking, I can see. Drugs?”

He nodded apathetically.

“Did you...was there…”

“Did I sleep with anyone?”

“Yeah.”

“...Yeah. A, uh, a lot of someones. I’m sorry-”

Mermista shook her head and held a hand up. “It’s not- Look, we broke up. Like, explosively. I have no right to be mad at you for sleeping with others. It doesn’t...feel good. It hurts, like, a lot. But I slept with someone else, too, and I can’t get mad at you for what you did while we were apart. So, it’s fine. Let’s just move on.”

He nodded, even if the self-loathing in his eyes was jarring to see.

Mermista grabbed his jaw gently and tilted him down for a kiss. She took a breath, like she was about to dive into Snows’ Sea. “I love you.”

He deflated, falling into her arms. “I love you, too.”

“Hey, this doesn’t work half bad,” she joked, jostling him a bit. He snorted. “Might just have to keep it up.”

“Perish the thought,” Sea Hawk sniped back. He pulled away, smiling, and kissed her forehead. They set about undressing each other and themselves. Mermista’s shoulders ached too much to undo her pauldrons, so Sea Hawk took care of the buckles and straps for her. She flopped on the bed in one of his sailing shirts while he unlaced her sneakers and let them tumble to the ground so he could peel off her leggings. He wrinkled his nose. “What is that smell?”

“Just what every girl wants to hear when her partner’s down there.”

“No! I meant-” Sea Hawk tried to correct himself, but thankfully Mermista was laughing. “You think you’re funny, huh?”

“I’m hilarious,” she chortled. “It’s Fright Zone sewage, and like, a metric fuck-ton of sweat.”

Sea Hawk stuck his tongue out. “Eugh- wait, the Fright Zone?” He checked the lights briefly, made sure they were dimmed, and crawled into bed next to Mermista. He’d retrieved all the spare blankets from his chest for her; Mermista always got cold in the night, especially on a ship. He covered them in blankets, and then paused. He didn’t want to overstep-

“Sea Hawk?” Mermista’s voice was small. “You can...I know I used to make you wait for, like, permission or whatever to hold me...and stuff.”

He nodded.

“I don’t think that makes us very equal. So, like, fuck that.”

"But…"" He swallowed. "I hate to point out the elephant in the room, love, but we're not equal."

Her eyes flashed. "And why not?"

"Um, because you're a queen and Princess?" Sea Hawk frowned. "And I'm a low-born pirate from a town that doesn't exist anymore."

"You're a sea captain," she challenged. "And I don't give a horse's ass where you were born."

"Your kingdom will," he sighed. "I'm just-"

"Mine." Mermista scooched closer, and wrapped her hand in his. "You're mine. Mine to me, and I don't care what, like, society says. Ugh, that's so cliche. Whatever." She flushed, but pushed on. "I don't want anyone else. I don't want a prince, or a Princess, or a king, or landholder. I just want you."

"Mermista…"

"And besides, like, I'm kind of the queen and all sooooo..." She flipped her hair. "What I say goes, and they can all deal with it." She saw his hesitation, and smiled sincerely. "You're my equal, Sea Hawk. You always have been, and I’m sorry I made you feel like you weren’t. You have as much right to touch me, and talk to me, and be with me, as I do to you. And I’m sorry, but this is one thing that will never be up for discussion.”

Sea Hawk blinked away tears, for once at a complete loss for words. Instead, he reached across the foot or so of bed between them, and pulled Mermista to him bodily. He buried his head in her ample chest. “I love you.”

She sighed happily, carding her fingers through his hair. “Not to be a complete sap, but I’m never going to get tired of that.”

“I’m pretty sure this entire conversation has shot your reputation to shit, dear.” He smiled against her skin.

“Fair.”

They lapsed into silence for so long that Sea Hawk assumed she fell asleep, and decided to save his questions for the morning.

But eventually, Mermista shifted to lay her head on his chest. “We received a distress call from Bright Moon two days ago. Bow, Glimmer and Adora had gone missing. Perfuma came to collect me, and when we got there, we found out the Horde had Adora, and the Sword, and they were going to open a portal. Long story short, Glimmer freed Shadow Weaver, who, by the way, is a Bright

Moon prisoner now, and we used dark magic to teleport to the Fright Zone.

I hung back with Frosta to hold off the guards, and the next thing we knew, we were in some...perfect fantasy world. Everything was, like I said, perfect, but it was…"

"Wrong," Sea Hawk finished. "It was all wrong."

Mermista pulled back. "You were...that was really you?!"

He nodded. "Yeah. I woke up next to you, and I was king. It all felt so surreal. You were-" He cut himself off, not sure how to continue.

"Pregnant." Mermista sighed.

"Yes."" He cleared his throat. "That."

She snorted at him. "What, is it really so disturbing?" She started to roll away, but he kept his arms tight around her.

"Not disturbing, love, don't put words in my mouth, please." He frowned. "It was just- I didn't know that was what you wanted. I didn't know that that was part of your perfect."

“I...didn’t either.” She blushed. “Not ‘til right then.” She ghosted a hand down her body to drum her fingers lightly on her abdomen. “It felt so real...and then it was just, poof- Gone.”

Sea Hawk nodded quietly. “Tell me what you’re feeling?”

“Uhhhh, hm, like- okay...” Mermista grimaced. “I will...try, or whatever.” She shut her eyes for a bit, clearly thinking.

Sea Hawk amused himself by undoing what was left of her braid.

Eventually, she spoke. “I’m...sad, in a way. I feel, like, empty. Physically and a little bit emotionally, even though I was never actually pregnant, obviously. But it’s fading, like a dream, that feeling of ‘something should be here’. I do miss my mom, though, more than ever now.” She opened her eyes and swallowed hard. “Because she was right there. I hugged her. I spoke to her. But it was never real and I-”

She cut herself off with a shrug. Sea Hawk could tell she was reaching her limit. “I understand.”

Mermista turned to him. “And you? How are you doing with all the magical freakiness?”

“Confused, mostly.” He frowned. “I don’t fully understand what happened. But that’ll come with time. Empty, the same way as you, but it’s also fading. Mostly just confused, yeah.” He nodded to himself.

Mermista snuggled deeper into arms. “Sometimes I really fucking hate magic.”

Sea Hawk chuckled, carding fingers through her hair. “You were beautiful there. You’re beautiful anywhere, clearly, but I mean... In your dresses and with your bindi and your jewelry all back on. I miss seeing you like that. Carefree- well, ish. More relaxed.”

“I miss being that person,” she murmured. “I have so many cute dresses I don’t get to wear anymore. Like, that shouldn’t be my main gripe about this stupid war, and yet here I am. Kind of selfish, huh?

“No, not selfish,” Sea Hawk mused. “Just...observant. Realistic.”

“So poetic.”

“I’ve been thinking about a book deal.”

They were both drifting off now, even as Mermista tried to fight it. “There’s more, though. There’s...there’s really bad news.”

“Is there anything to be done about it tonight?”

“No, but-”

“Then, please...” He tucked her tighter into his chest, the steady rhythm of his heart and the warmth of his body creating a potent sleeping draught. “Let yourself rest tonight, Mermista. We can handle it in the morning.”

“Alright,” she murmured, pressing a kiss above his heart. “In the morning.”

And like a switch had been flipped, sleep washed over her at once, bowling her off her feet and into a dreamless slumber.

Chapter End Notes

Next up: the morning after and all that ensues

come on and show me how we’re good

Chapter Summary

> The storm has calmed, and left them with the debris of the wreck they made.

Chapter Notes

> Walk me home by pink is such a good song now that I don’t hear it every fucking day at work. Anyway.
>
> Here we go!
>
> WARNING: smut. It’s marked out.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Sea Hawk woke up first, as he always did. It took him a moment to orient himself; he knew he was on his ship, passed out in his v-berth instead of on the floor for once, and that he didn’t have a hangover. He was also sweating like Adora’s horse, buried under about a hundred more blankets than he usually used. The hell?

The bed shifted next to him, and he flinched. Had he brought a hookup onto his ship? He never did that, in case he had to make a getaway or push off for a new mission at a moment’s notice. Resigning himself to a very awkward conversation, he rolled over, only to stifle a gasp when he saw rich brown skin and messy azure hair splayed over his extra pillow. Mermista? What-?

It all slammed back into him then, with a vengeance. Peekablue, the portal, Mermista crashing onto his ship (and into his arms). The conversations they’d had, the tears and embraces and kisses. Tentatively, Sea Hawk reached out to run a hand over the princess' exposed upper shoulders. She was sleeping on her front, and at some point in the night, had discarded his shirt, leaving her upper half bare. Her face was turned away from him, and she didn't stir at his touch, so he dared to scoot closer. He also dared to shuck his own shirt, as he was about ready to melt through the wood of his cabin. He smiled, the memory of many many nights spent like this, disagreeing on the temperature of the room before bed, the layers and blankets. It was comforting to know that despite everything between them, behind them, and ahead of them, some things never changed.

Sea Hawk shifted, turning onto his side and snaking a gentle arm around Mermista's waist. He sighed through his nose. Touching her again was paradise incarnate; her skin was impossibly soft to the touch, thanks to her stringent skincare routine. She worried about the salt in the water and air in her kingdom drying her out, and took the utmost care. He tugged lightly, grinning when she moved in her sleep. Still entirely knocked out, she turned and pressed herself into him, chest to chest, her lips puffing warm air over his collarbone. He swallowed, hard, the feeling of her breasts pressed to his skin beginning to drive him insane. Sea Hawk bit the inside of his cheek, willing himself to relax and go back to sleep. And it worked. It worked so well that when a hand snaked into his boxers to grab him, he startled awake so badly he nearly leapt out of the bed. The hand recoiled quickly.

“Sorry, sorry!” Mermista placed a calming hand on his chest, eyes wide with remorse. “I didn't mean to- I thought you were awake.”

“Haaaa…”” Sea Hawk placed a hand to his beating heart, over Mermista's hand, fairly dramatically. “Well, I am now.”

Mermista snorted, but made no move to continue her previous endeavors. She kept her eyes locked on his chest until he tilted her chin up with his fingers.

“Do you want to...I don’t want to assume anything right now, so-”

“No, no, I totally get that,” she stammered. “I just- It was poking me and you turned me over and we’re both, like, half naked-”

Sea Hawk made a show of raking his eyes down her mostly bare body. “Half?”

“Ugh, shut *up* .” She rolled her eyes. “But you’re right, I shouldn’t have, like, assumed- I don’t know where we are with...this.”

He blew a gusty breath through a twisted grimace. “Should we, um, talk about it, or…?”

Mermista groaned. “I’m tired of talking. Not ‘cause of, like, you,” she hastened to amend. “Just, in general. I’ve talked more than I ever knew I could these past few months. I’ve been doing the whole giving orders and making decisions thing, and just talking, nonstop, to everyone. And then last night…” She swallowed. “It’s not the same kind of talking. It’s not as exhausting. But…”

He shifted closer, tucking a strand of hair away from her face. “Take your time, love.”

She flushed very prettily at that, and he filed it away for later. Mermista sighed, and pressed the heels of her hands to her forehead, one of her universal 'I'm getting overwhelmed' signs. "I'm so scared I'm going to say the wrong thing, and push you away again, because I'm bad at words. I am, and there's not much changing it. I'm blunt, and rude, and I interrupt and say the wrong things and-"

"Hey, hey, hey..." Sea Hawk pulled her hands out of her scalp, where she was tugging almost viciously at her hair. "I told you, I'm not leaving. Ever again. There's nothing you can say that will make me leave."

"What if I hurt you?" she whispered miserably.

"Then we will deal with that if it happens." He hesitated, and then leaned in to kiss her softly. "It's...easier now, knowing you aren't trying to hurt me. It's different than before."

Mermista frowned. "I'm still sorry."

"So am I."

"Are we...ever going to be okay again? Be us?" Her head flopped into his chest. "I hate the eggshells. I hate the way we're treating each other like we'll break apart if we, like, blink wrong."

Sea Hawk shrugged. “So then we won’t. And if we overstep or annoy, or go too fast, we’ll say something.”

She eyed him shrewdly. “Just like that? You snapped your fingers and suddenly we’re normal again?”

“No,” he laughed. “First of all, we were never normal, so jot that down. Second, I’m not going to snap my fingers. However…”” He shifted to lean over her, supporting himself with his left forearm. “I’d like to try doing something else with them, if that’s alright with you.”

Mermista blushed from her cheeks to her chest, but smirked. “It’s more than alright with me,” she said. He was leaning in when she paused and bit her lip. “I- uh- I mean, I have- Ihaveaweirdrequest,” she blurted.

Sea Hawk blinked, then nodded. “Anything for you, my love.”

“Whyyyy are you like this,” she sighed lovingly. “I’m...really sore. And really, really like. Mentally tired. I don’t...ugh!” Mermista squeezed her eyes shut, pushing the words out like splinters. “I know I usually take control, but I don’t want to right now. And I didn’t let you before because of the whole ‘push you away because I’m a self-destructive dumbass’ thing, so-”

He swallowed. “You want me to...take over? Like, regularly.”

Mermista nodded firmly, even if her eyes were shut. “Yeah. Not all the time, obviously, I’m still me, duh. But, I need to work on, like, control, Perfuma said. Especially, um, here.”

This was…somewhat unprecedented and not a little shocking. Sea Hawk could count on one hand the number of times he’d initiated anything between them, let alone stayed in that position, as it were, during the act. Mermista hated feeling any lack of control, obviously. She preferred being on top, introducing the idea of anything, so on and so forth. He’d always wanted...this. But he’d never known how to ask, not when it seemed like it would severely upset her. Now, though-

“Alright,” he murmured. “Let me know if anything isn’t what you want, okay? This is still, and will always be, a mutual thing. No matter who’s on top.”

She snorted. “God, you’re such a sap. Like seriously, what storybook did you jump out of?”

He stuck his tongue out at her, before wiping the smirk off her face with a kiss. He leaned over her fully, and she ran her hands up his biceps. She sighed into his lips, fingers tangling in his thick, wavy hair. What started soft and sweet soon turned rough and hard, and before long, Sea Hawk was kissing his way down her jaw, teeth grazing her pulse point rougher than he’d ever been before. Mermista gasped sharply. He pulled back quickly.

“Is that alright?”

She only groaned and yanked his lips back to her neck, sighing out an affirmative.

“Rough, then?”

“Not too rough, but yeah,” she said. “No more treating me like glass, remember?”

EXPLICIT CONTENT BELOW

Sea Hawk smirked, and pressed a fast kiss to her cheek before returning to her neck. He scraped his teeth up to the spot beneath her ear, where he sucked hard, jolting a cry from Mermista. He moved down to the juncture of neck and shoulder and bit gently, just enough to draw a whine, before ducking lower and taking a nipple in his mouth. He lavished attention on her breasts, unable to stop himself from moaning at the feel of them in his hands, his mouth. It was only when she tugged at his hair, whispering *‘more, Sea Hawk, please’* , that he moved even lower. He kissed his way up her inner thighs once he was settled between them, nipping occasionally just to watch her muscles twitch. He yanked her panties off in one motion and tossed them elsewhere.

Mermista's body drove him wild, more than any other being on this planet ever had. She had curves that dipped and rose like the gentlest of currents. Her ass was pure muscle like the rest of her legs, but that didn't stop it from curving in the most delicious way. Sea Hawk had walked into many a doorframe following the sway of her ass when she walked away from him. Her breasts were perfect, pillow soft and beautifully round, dark nipples that enticed his tongue more than any whiskey or chocolate. And her legs, by the stars, her *legs* . Long, thick with muscle sculpted by years of swimming and fighting. He'd seen them carry her with grace and poise, with urgency, dance through armies of Horde soldiers, even watched them turn into a tail. But it was when they were spread for him, or wrapped around his hips, that he loved them most.

It was said throughout the lands, in bars and brothels and ports alike, that every single Princess was endowed with great beauty, that it was their birthright as much as their magic. And after meeting all of the Alliance, Sea Hawk had to agree; each possessed a sort of ethereal beauty and grace, something otherworldly. But none compared to Mermista in his eyes. Not even She-Ra. Mermista's eyes could put him on his knees, her lips could tell him to burn a hundred ships and he would (happily), her hands could reduce him to putty figuratively or literally. And so here he worshipped her, at the altar between her legs, her divine center. Her body was the only church he'd ever known, his faith in her all he would ever need. The prayers he sang for her there delivered them both.

Satisfied with the number he'd done on her thighs, he threw one of her legs over a shoulder and leaned in to set to work. He eased her into his presence with gentle kisses along her soaked outer lips, and when he felt her fully relax, he ran the broad of his tongue along her slit. She moaned, and fisted her hands in his hair.

He moaned against her. “Stars, Mermista, you’re so wet, so delicious.”

“Sea Hawk, more-” she groaned.

“Patience, Princess.”

Mermista grumbled something, and he smirked. Quickly he pressed in and sucked her clitoris into his mouth, flicking it with his tongue. Mermista cried out sharply, not expecting the sudden motion. Her legs tensed around his body, but Sea Hawk didn’t relent. He moved his head with her as she writhed, alternating between sucking, flicking, and licking her clit until she was moaning brokenly into her hand. He pulled back just enough to readjust so he could brush his fingers against her entrance. She jolted, legs spasming.

“Sebastian *please-* ”

He smirked, and slid a finger into her. She moved to grind down on him, but he pulled out just enough so that she had no friction. Mermista growled, squeezing his hair until he hissed. Sea Hawk pushed back into her, and took her clit back into his mouth. She whimpered above him, and he smiled. Sirens couldn’t compare to Mermista in bed. Before she could adjust, he slid another finger in and started pumping her in time with his flicks to her bud. Her cries became staccato, her legs shaking around him. When the edge started to fall off, he slid his third finger in, and sucked *hard*

. She flew off the bed, curling her upper body forward without control. Her whole body was shaking around him, and he pulled back just enough to push her back down into the mattress. Once she was prone again, albeit reluctantly, he curled his fingers upward into her g-spot. Mermista wailed, unable or possibly unwilling to quiet herself. In the palace, there was always someone to worry about. Out here? She could scream herself hoarse if she wanted to. And Sea Hawk wanted her to.

He stroked up into the softest part of her, and resumed his assault on her clit. It took only seconds for her legs to shakily fall off his shoulders, and when they did, he pushed one up into her chest by the underside of her thigh. Seconds later, he felt her tightening around his fingers, her moans having lost their individuality and instead becoming one unending note. When she just seemed to get impossibly tighter with no give in sight, Sea Hawk folded his fingers together and slid in his smallest fourth. Like a band snapping, she came hard, squeezing his fingers in a pulsating vice. She screamed his name, and he moaned into her, the vibrations triggering a chain reaction that made her whole body seize. Hot liquid gushed from her onto his chin and throat, and Sea Hawk had to let go of her clit to bite his cheek so he wouldn’t come untouched right there.

At length, she came back to herself, heaving for air. He wiped his face on the blanket, making a mental note to have it laundered. He started to crawl back up to her face, but she yanked him up there bodily. She crushed her lips to his, her tongue in his mouth making his mind go blank. She pulled back just enough to say, “In me. Now,” before kissing him again.

Not a man to think twice, Sea Hawk slid his boxers off, hissing when his erection slapped almost painfully against his abdomen.

He pulled her legs apart, groaning when his tip slid snugly into the edge of her warmth. He had enough presence of mind to pause, though,

“Protection?”

Mermista was panting, still. “Fertility blocking spell. Good for a year. Did you...with the others-?”

“Never raw.” He wrinkled his nose. “Condom, always.”

“Then what the hell are you waiting for?” she challenged. He grinned, and with a firm roll of his hips, slid into her. She was so wet and relaxed from before that it only took two thrusts until he was hilt-deep in her warmth. He paused, giving himself a minute to adjust, to revel in her body, in the feeling of rightness that being inside of her and only her gave him. He leaned his forehead against hers, sharing her air.

“Love you,” he murmured, and the smile she sent him could make a maelstrom stop dead. “I love you so much.”

“Show me,” she whispered against his lips. “And I’ll show you.”

He smiled against her lips as he kissed her, and began rocking. Gently at first, and then when he was sure he wasn’t going to fall apart in seconds, with single-minded passion and focus. Mermista found the energy to lift her legs and wrap them around his hips, the angle making her groan against his mouth. Sea Hawk was losing an uphill battle, and from the smirk on her face, his princess knew it. She leaned in, running her tongue hot and wet along the shell of his ear before blowing softly. He grunted, mind whiting out briefly. She drew an earlobe into her mouth and suckled softly. Sea Hawk buried his face into her neck and shoulder, moaning. Carefully, she snuck a hand between them and cupped his balls gently, rolling them gently.

“Mermista- ah!- don’t- I won’t last-”

“Then let’s speed this up.” He could hear her grinning. Her hand left his balls and moved to her own clit. He couldn’t see what she was doing, but he felt her warmth start to tighten around him, and he cried out.

“I-I’m not- ah, Mermista, I-I’m going to come-”

She was moaning in his ear again, one hand between them and the other fisting in the shorter hair at the nape of his neck. “Hang on, just a bit, I’m right there *right there- ah!”* Her body jolted underneath him, and seized like a vice around his cock.

Sea Hawk cried out, and bit the soft flesh of her neck hard enough that he knew it would bruise badly. At the moment, though, it really wasn’t a concern. His mind was blanking, his balls drawing up close to his shaft, world shrinking to the feeling of her pulsing body gloved around his member. “Memista-”

Her mouth was back against his ear, murmuring sweet nothings. “I’ve got you, Sebastian. Come for me, I’m right here, I love you-”

If she said more, he didn’t know, because Sea Hawk’s hearing cut out as he came, harder than ever before. He moaned loudly into Mermista’s shoulder, almost sobbing with the force of it. His hips stuttered and snapped into her without control, coming deep inside of her. When he had nothing left to give, he collapsed completely, knowing Mermista could take his full weight without issue.

When his ears stopped ringing and his vision reoriented enough to see straight, he became aware of nails scraping gently against his scalp, and hand rubbing circles into his back. Mermista was heaving for air beneath him, but when he tried to get off of her, she whined and tightened her arms around him. He chuckled into her shoulder, and let himself go limp in her embrace. Covers came up to drape around his bare shoulders, ensconcing him in delightful warmth; Mermista’s body heat felt like the burn of his sun saber just before it scalded him. Sea Hawk hadn’t realized just how cold he’d been these past few months. He shifted enough to slip out of her and move his body to the side. He pillowed his head on her breasts as he snuggled closer. “Mmmmm, missed this.”

“Yeah,” she whispered, settling against him. “Me, too.”

They faded back into sleep with the cries of morning gulls and the soft lapping of water against the boat as their lullaby.

END EXPLICIT CONTENT

Mermista woke up alone this time, and groaned at how cold the bed was without her...boyfriend? The term seemed so trivial, so juvenile, for what he was to her. For whatever they'd become. But they could argue semantics later. Right now, Mermista needed food. The past 24 hours had finally caught up with her body, and judging from the slant of the light through the windows in the study, she'd rested more than enough.

She fished the sleepshirt she'd worn to bed off the floor and yanked it over her head, forgoing her bra for now. Her leggings smelled like hell, and she gagged at the state of them. Instead, she grabbed some slacks from Sea Hawk's drawer, making sure they weren't leather. They were somewhat tight around her ass, and a bit loose on her hips, but a strip of old belt took care of the latter issue and, well… the first bit wasn't really an 'issue', as much as it was an opportunity.

After forcing her mane into something resembling a braid, she pushed out of the room and made her way up onto the deck. The rocking of the ship told her they were already moving, albeit slowly, and she turned to see Sea Hawk lazily manning the wheel with one hand, while his other held an apple. Mermista climbed the steps up to the top deck, enjoying the feeling of the sea breeze on her face. It had been so long since she was on a ship for pleasure, and not work, and she turned her face to the sun, closing her eyes, to revel in the feeling.

Sea Hawk was grinning at her when she finally turned to him, and she rolled her eyes on instinct, even as she tucked herself against his side. “Hey.”

“Morning, dearest.” He gently palmed the wheel. “Sleep alright?”

“Yeah, I did. What time is it?”

Sea Hawk glanced at the sun, then at the shadows on the deck. “Nearly three. Are you hungry?”

“You have no idea.” As if on cue, her stomach growled *loudly* , and she flushed as Sea Hawk laughed. “Do you have more fruit?”

“Down the steps, before my quarters there’s a supply room. Purple door. There should be plenty in there.”

And there was. Crates and piles and sacks of all sorts of provisions; most of it was hardtack, salted and dried meats, hearty grains. But near the door there were some crates of fresh fruit that he must have picked up within the last few days. Grabbing a metal bowl off of one shelf, she tossed an assortment of fruits in, and grabbed a handful of what smelled like seal jerky on the way out. Merfolk were carnivores, after all.

Back on deck, Sea Hawk had keyed in Salineas’ coordinates and was letting the ship steer itself for a bit while he was lounging on some large crates at the prow. Mermista hoisted herself onto one opposite him, despite her muscles’ protest at the movement. Together, they picked through most of the bowl of fruit, and it was only after her stomach had stopped cramping that Mermsita spoke.

“I have to tell you something.” She nibbled at a corner of jerky. “And I need you to just, like, be chill while I talk.”

Sea Hawk nodded as he chewed, wide eyes focused on her.

“So the portal...I don’t know how to explain the, like, science of it. But it had to be shut down from the inside. Someone had to stay behind.”

Sea Hawk swallowed. “...who?”

Mermista kept her eyes focused on the horizon, so she could blame their watering on the sting of the air as it blew past. “Angella.”

“No,” he gasped. “No...it can’t be.”

“It is.”

Sea Hawk was up and pacing, one hand fisted in his hair as he shook his head. Finally he whirled on her, eyes frantic. "So, how can we get her back? It's a portal, it goes somewhere, we just need to go there and get her."

"It's not that simple, Sea Hawk-"

"Why not?"

Mermista squeezed her eyes shut, head already starting to pound. She'd forgotten how much Sea Hawk could be, which sounded hilariously and tragically ironic when one considered the hell they'd put each other through over that exact reason (among others). She grit her teeth. "Sea Hawk, I really need you to be serious right now."

"Wh- I am being serious!" He threw his arms wide. "We need to get her back-"

"She can't come back!" Mermista yelled, hopping off her crate. "What about that aren't you getting? She's gone. She's as good as dead, and we all have to make our peace with that." She turned around, pressing the heels of her palms to her eyes until stars danced in the darkness. "Gods, Sebastian, please! I just asked you to be chill about this, what's the point of asking you to do things if you won't even listen to me-"

Hands came up to rest on her shoulders, warm and broad, and she leaned into them despite her frustration. They stood there, just breathing for a minute, before Sea Hawk turned her around and pulled her into his chest. “I’m sorry,” he whispered. “I...got angry. Not at you, just at the whole… everything.”

Mermista sniffled against him. “Is this ever going to get easy?”

“Yes,” he said with surprising conviction. “It will, I swear it. I just…”

When he trailed off and didn’t seem to have anything else to say, Mermista picked up the thread. “Sometimes, it’s...hard for me to tell you things because I know you’re going to get all, like, flashy and theatrical and dramatic. And even though I love you...” She only stumbled over it a little bit this time. “And I love every part of you, that part of you can be...challenging. For me.”

He nodded against her. “I feel the same way about your apathy, if we’re both being honest. I know you have a hard time showing your emotions, and I understand why. But sometimes, I just want you to get mad with me, to be as angry or upset as I feel. Or as happy.”

“I am, though,” she sighed. “I just...can’t show it. Not yet. But, like, I can work on it, I guess.”

Sea Hawk nodded. “And so can I.” They lulled into silence, standing in each other’s arms and swaying with the ship. “She’s really gone?”

Mermista nodded against his chest, shoulders trembling. “I’m so tired of crying. Is that selfish?”

“No, darling,” he murmured against her hair. “Everyone has a limit.”

She pulled back, wiping futilely at her cheeks. “She was so strong. She was the strongest of any of us, really. An immortal, angelic being with the power of a runestone? And now…” She inhaled shakily. “She’s just- bam!- gone. It’s bullshit.”

Sea Hawk nodded, watching her carefully. “It’s hard to imagine any Rune Princess dying. You’re all so powerful. You know that common people see you as gods, practically?”

She snorted mirthlessly. “Not in Salineas. Not my people.”

“Your people love you, Mermista.”

“Maybe they do.” She shrugged. “But it doesn’t change the fact that most of them have already seen one queen fall. How could they possibly have even half as much faith in me?”

Sea Hawk sighed. "No Etherian with half a brain thinks less of any of you because of what your parents did."

"That's where you're wrong, love," Mermista was so preoccupied in thought that she didn't even notice the endearment, or Sea Hawk's brief grin. "And you'll see it, too, at the funeral and the coronation." She turned to him, and for a moment she looked so much older than she was, so much more tired, and wiser. "For Glimmer's sake, I hope the people of Bright Moon are different. But some things just can't be helped."

Sea Hawk frowned. "How is Glimmer?"

"She was in shock when we left the castle, but I don't know how long it's gonna keep her going. It was bad, Sebastian. The last thing they did before we left was fight…" He walked up behind her and wrapped his arms around her waist. "I can't imagine what she might be feeling."

"Forgive me, if I overstep..." He paused, but she waved him on. "You were so young when she died. Do you remember…?"

"My last moments with my mom?" Mermista finished for him. "Yeah. She was putting me to bed. We'd spent the day at the markets, and I was still wired and I didn't want to sleep. So she took me out on her balcony, and we sat in the hammock, and she sang me to sleep." Her breath hitched. "I don't remember much after, just flashes; the hallway when she carried me to bed, her necklaces dangling over me when she laid me down, my socks coming off. And then I woke up, and she was gone." Mermista squeezed his hand where it rested on her waist. "What about you?"

Sea Hawk smiled sadly. "She was warning me to not lose my new scarf. The attack was just after Yule, and I wanted to wear it out fishing. It's like looking back through sea glass, now, but I remember her fixing it for me so it wouldn't come undone on the boat, so that I could keep my gloves on the whole time. She said I needed a haircut, and that we would do it tomorrow, and to catch something for dinner. And then she hugged me goodbye and went back to her carving- she was a woodworker in her spare time, a hobby really. And that was that."

Mermista leaned back into him. "We never forget those moments. Those last words. And now Glimmer has to live with that argument forever. I feel horrible for her."

Sea Hawk hummed in assent, and they lapsed into contemplation. Finally, he pressed a kiss to her neck. "We'll be in Salineas within the hour, I should get back to the helm. Want to come?"

"Nah." She shook her head and plopped down on a smaller crate. "I think I'm just gonna hang out here. Enjoy the breeze."

He frowned. "Do you want my jacket? You get cold." Before she could voice an opinion, he'd whipped his blue jacket off and draped it around her shoulders.

“Thank you.” She smiled almost shyly. He rubbed the back of his head and shrugged, and suddenly they were nineteen again, fumbling around each other. She beckoned him to lean down and meet her where she sat. She pressed her lips to his when he did, smiling when the angle made his mustache tickle her.

He trotted off back to the wheel once they separated, and Mermista watched him go with the jaunty spring in his step that she’d missed a truly stupid amount. She turned back to the sea, it’s welcoming waves winking sunlight at her. A smile found its way across her lips, and she let it be. Wasn’t like anyone could see her. A cold, sharp breeze whipped past her, and she yanked Sea Hawk’s coat tighter. It was more worn than ever, and smelled like it could use a gentle wash once they got back, but other than that, it was just as soft and warm as she recalled. The gold lapel strips, marks of his captaincy, were scuffed and scraped, nowhere near as immaculate as those of the captains and admirals in her own navy. She preferred the look of his.

Something solid brushed her ribs, and she frowned. He must have left something in the interior pocket. She rummaged around until her fingers brushed metal, and withdrew his beloved compass. Mermista ran her fingers reverently over the old surface; one of the few family heirlooms he had, she knew Sea Hawk prized this compass higher than any treasure or loot, more than jewels, gold, spirits, anything. She gently clicked it open, and smiled at the picture inside. That had been one of their last good days, before her dad had left and everything had gone to shit. Her sentimental pirate…

She went to replace it in the inner pocket, only to hear it *clack!* against something else. She dug into the lining again and-

Oh fuck. Oh hell. Stars damn it.

As covertly and gently as possible, she withdrew a ring. It was...Mermista wasn't good with words, and even though 'gorgeous' was the only thing coming to mind, it didn't do the ring justice. It was like he'd taken a drop of water out of the ocean, mixed it with pure moonlight and precious gems, and molded it into a band. It was stunning. It was hers. She knew it was, as sure as she knew the moons would set in the west and rise in the east. Sliding it gently onto her right hand, she marvelled at the perfect fit. Mermista bit her lip, considering...and left it there. She put the compass back in the pocket, making sure it was shut tightly, but kept the ring on. Hell, she didn't think she'd ever take it off.

Was it presumptuous? Yeah, sure. But as many steps as they'd taken in the past two days alone, let alone the complicated dance of their life together thus far, Mermista was still herself. And she had never been a patient woman.

Now to wait and see how long it took Sea Hawk to notice…She grinned in delight, and the ground under their feet solidified that little bit more.

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They docked in Salineas as the sun was setting, and to her eternal chagrin, two advisors, a lady in waiting, and her head Guard stood waiting for her. Sea Hawk shuffled his feet, and she could already see his mouth opening to make excuses.

She grabbed his hand (with her left, very carefully), and held on. “Sea Hawk, I’m wearing your clothes, we’re on your ship. They’re gonna know as soon as they see me. Please…” She rested a hand on his chest, “...walk with me?”

“But I...you’re…” He fidgeted nervously. “It wouldn’t be right, or-or proper. I don’t want to emba-”

“Stop.” She fixed him with a stern look. “I regret ever saying those words to you, or making you feel that way, remember? Don’t even think on them for a moment.” At his continued recalcitrance, she grabbed his chin gently and tilted his eyes to hers. “I love you. Please, come with me.”

They really were proving to be magic words. He didn’t stop jittering, but he did calm down a good bit. He nodded, and took a steadying breath. “Okay.”

She smiled at him. “I don’t know what you think they’re gonna do, love. I’m in charge, remember?”

He smirked. “I don’t know how I could ever forget.”

“Ass.” She snorted, but didn’t pull her hand from his until he had to toss the mooring lines out and lower the gang plank. And after he was done, she slid hers right back in. The right one she kept in the pocket of Sea Hawk’s jacket. Forcing away her own nerves and instincts to drop his hand and run, she tossed her hair back and walked down the gangplank with all the regal grace that had been drilled into her from birth.

Her guard, Maevik, stepped forward first. His usual mask of calm indifference was cracked, concern leaking through. “Your Majesty, are you alright? We saw the light, and what followed-” As if remembering himself, he snapped his jaw shut, and flushed. “Forgive my boldness. I was...concerned.”

Mermista dropped Sea Hawk’s hand to place it on the shoulder of her oldest confidante. He stiffened, uncertain. “Your concern is very appreciated, Maevik. I’m fine.”

He relaxed and raised a brow at her, amusedly glancing behind her. "Yes, it would certainly appear that you are, Your Majesty.” Was that a smile? He dropped his voice. “Shall I tell the staff to prepare a guest room?”

Okay, now he was taking the piss with her. “No, thank you,” she grit. “I think we’ll manage fine.”

Eyes still swimming with mirth, he nodded. He glanced behind her, and nodded to Sea Hawk. “It’s very good to see you again, Captain. You’ve been missed around here.”

She stepped back to stand beside Sea Hawk, and watched his eyes grow wide as the advisors nodded, and the lady in waiting smiled gently. “Yes, well, I can’t tell you how much I’ve missed Salineas.” He took her hand this time, and grinned down at her. “There is truly no kingdom so lovely as this one.”

Mermista flushed, but stayed her ground. She cleared her throat, and turned back to her ridiculously overjoyed staff. “Right, unfortunately, there’s still business to attend to. I need you to send word to the state heads, the ambassadors, and our representatives, and have them gather in the throne room as quickly as possible.”

“Your Majesty?” Her advisors frowned.

Mermista sighed, and decided to just bite the bullet.“Queen Angella is dead.”

Shocked gasps and murmurs flew out of the assembled, who turned to each other frantically. The advisors immediately bowed, and rushed off to begin preparations for the funeral of a monarch. Gifts had to be sent, letters of condolences both formal and not.

There was only so much time before a funeral would be held and Mermista would have to travel again, so there was also the matter of her backlogged work. A migraine was coming on quickly.

“Princess?” Her head lady in waiting, Lady Ofeni, stood in front of her. “There are some...sensitive matters that need to be discussed as soon as you’re available.” Why did her eyes flick to Sea Hawk when she said that?

Mermista frowned. “Give us a moment to get back to the castle and settle, and then I’ll come find you?”

Ofeni nodded, and took her leave. Sea Hawk took a moment to recheck the mooring lines, because apparently that always had to be done, and while they waited, Maevik sidled up to her.

“So, do I hear wedding bells?”

Mermista scowled. “You need your ears checked, old man.”

“Hmmm,” he hummed lazily. “Do I? See, I thought I would need my eyes checked, because I haven’t seen your right hand since you stepped off the ship.”

“Shh!” She turned to make sure Sea Hawk was a good ways off. “Keep it down will you? He doesn’t know.”

“He doesn’t know he proposed?” Maevik snorted. “Poor lad, concussed himself again, did he?”

"It's a long story, alright?"

Her guard chuckled, and glanced behind them. "Soooo, can I see it?"

Mermista debated continuing to play dumb, but quickly realized that she would only come out looking more the fool in the end. She extracted her hand and laid out her fingers. Maevik's sharp inhale filled her with prideful satisfaction.

"My *gods* , Mermist- I mean, Your Majesty."" He cleared his throat, even as his eyes stayed fixed to the ring. "It's stunning. And- *stars* - that's a small fortune right there on your finger! How did- I mean, I know he's a pirate but-"

"Technically he's a sea captain." She shrugged, tucking her hand away. "And to be honest, I think he may be an admiral and not even know it. And if he's not, then he will be. I'll, like, promote him."

Maevik nodded. "You really do intend to marry him, don't you?" There was no judgement in his voice, just calm understanding.

Mermista nodded. "Life's too short. I'm too tired. This war has gone on too damn long. I- I want him." She still couldn't look him in the eye as she said it, but saying it was already a massive victory. Baby steps. “And it’s just stupid to pretend other wise at this point.”

“Your Majesty,” her guard said. “May I speak freely?”

She nodded at him to continue.

“I didn’t think much of him when he first started showing up, and I was just your father’s vanguard. I watched him sneak out of that guest room, and I thought, he’s going to be trouble. And, really, I was right. But then, he kept coming. And coming. And coming...”

Mermista snorted.

“And I started to like him. When you ascended the throne, and he...left, I was disappointed.”

“Why?” Mermista turned to check on Sea Hawk, and watched as the sails came down.

Maevik turned with her. “Because he made you laugh. And smile. After your mother passed, I wasn’t sure I’d ever see you truly happy again. But then he came around, and everyone started smiling a little bit more. Even if it was at his expense, more often than not. What I’m saying is, he’s good for you. And you for him. And that your kingdom will be more accepting, and dare I say, supportive of this than you think they will be.”

Mermista dipped her head and cleared her throat to hide her eyes. “Thank you, Maevik. That, like, means more than I can say.”

“Your people want you to be happy, my Queen.”” He smiled. “And I don’t think they’d frown at a new king either.”

“The viziers will,” she sighed. “He’s not of noble birth, and he’s already so painfully aware of it- I don’t know what the reaction will be.”

Maevik shrugged. “I am no lawmaker, or politician. But I know that some laws exist to protect people, and their interests. Some laws exist to keep them safe. Others exist only to maintain the status quo of the time they were written. How does it benefit the people to have a king from a certain lineage?”

Mermista hummed, considering. “Hey, wanna be a grand vizier?”

“No,” Maevik snorted. “I’ll stick to guarding your life with my fork.”

“Fair.”

Sea Hawk jogged back to them, ship fully docked and ready to be cleaned. She grabbed his hand in hers again, and they set off for the castle with Maevik trailing a few steps behind. Sea Hawk’s head was on a swivel as they strolled through the docks and then the port markets. Despite the late hours, stalls were open for business and hawking their wares. Several shouted greetings as they passed, some to her, but many to Sea Hawk. Several merchants jumped from behind their stalls to shake his hand, or thump his back in greeting. His grin had gone from polite and nervous to genuine and excited. He turned to her with bright eyes.

“The markets are back! The pirates and the merchants! How-” He cut himself off with a shake of his head, and wrapped his arm around her shoulders. “You’re incredible, Mermista! Salineas is blessed to have a you as queen.”

She blushed. “I just, I dunno. Buckled down. Started moving around some of the money my dad was keeping locked up in dumb shit. Repaired Horde damage, made things stronger and better. We took in a ton of Dryl refugees, and they’ve been helping update, like, all the infrastructure. I think we’re going to start buffing up the Sea Gate next year. I don’t ever want it glitching out like it did before Adora came.”

Sea Hawk grinned at her and hugged her tighter. After a moment, Mermista shrugged out of his arm and took his hand again, and he nodded in understanding. Baby steps.

They were nearly at the palace’s promenade entrance when a shriek drew them up short. They whirled, only to see a veritable mob of children charging at them. “What the f-”

“MUSTACHE MAN!” they shouted. “HE’S BACK! MUSTACHE MAN!”

Mermista groaned before giving into laughter, even as Sea Hawk dropped her hand to meet the kids halfway. There were about seven of them, maybe eight, she couldn’t tell because they never stopped moving. Sea Hawk scooped two of them up, while the rest clambering up his body like a tree. He kept himself upright, but just barely, laughing loudly the whole time. “Hello kids! How are you?”

A chorus of “good” and “awrigh’” and “okay” answered, before the questions began. Mermista leaned against one of the pillars by the entrance, waving Maevik inside when he hesitated. There was literally no possible threat right now, and besides, the ocean was, like, right there. She could head inside, but this was absurdly entertaining.

“Where have you been, Mustache Man?”

“My name is Sea Hawk and-”

“Nuh uh! It’s Mustache Man!”

“Ah, well then, excuse my ignorance. I’ve been on a grand *adVENTURE!* ” He hoisted one little girl into the air for emphasis, and she shrieked with glee.

Mermista squinted. She looked very familiar.

“Didja bring back any books? Or candy? Or stories?”

“Well, you see kids...” He dropped the last child to the ground, but crouched to their level. “I can’t tell you any of my stories because they’re *top secret* .”

The kids gasped as one, absolutely eating it up. One leaned in very close. “Didja hafta punch anyone?”

Sea Hawk nodded sagely. “Yes, but only as a last resort. Violence is always a last resort, kids, remember that.”

They all nodded back just as seriously, and Mermista felt something inside of her melt. The portal came back to her then, for a second, a flash of blue hair and brown eyes and wide grin. Her heart clenched for a moment in a fit of pure *want* , as she watched her...betrothed? Unwittingly betrothed?

They should probably talk.

The kids and the pirate carried on for a while before the little girl from earlier saw her leaning off to the side. She was a sea elf of some kind, with fanned ears and green hair and sharp little teeth that stretched in a grin. “Queen Mermista!”

Oh shit.

She took off for her like a bullet, and Mermista had just enough time to crouch down before the girl was in her arms. It was a complete breach of decorum, but the girl was like, what, seven? Who cared? It was refreshing. The little girl hugged her tight.

“I missed you!” Who was she, who was she. “Inigo said we’d never see you again, but I told him he was a total downer.”

“Eliza!” It came back to her at once. “How are you?”

“Good!” she chirped in her ear. Then she leaned in to whisper. “I have a super secret question to ask you.”

Mermista bit back a grin. “Is it about Mustache Man?” When Eliza just shook her head, she frowned. Why the sudden silence?

She became aware of several of the kids looking at them and whispering, and realized that Eliza didn’t want to ask in front of the others. She stood with the little elf in her arms, letting her wrap her legs around her waist as she walked off a few steps. Sea Hawk frowned at her, but she waved him off. She found a small bench in the courtyard just inside the palace promenade, and sat down with Eliza on her lap. Sure enough, when she pulled away, there were tears in the little girl's eyes.

Entirely unsure of what to do, she jostled the young girl a bit. “Hey, it’s okay, Eliza. What did you wanna ask me?”

Suddenly more shy than Mermista knew a kid could be, Eliza shrugged. “It’s my birthday next week, and- and my mama-”

That’s right, Eliza’s mother was a naval captain.

“She said she can’t make it. And I knew that if I talked to you, you could tell her to come home, cuz you’re the queen and stuff.” She rubbed her eyes with tiny webbed hands and looked at Mermista plaintively. “Can you bring my mama home for my birthday? For just a little? It doesn’t even have to be the whole day!”

Mermista’s heart broke for this kid, this kid she had been once, her only wish on her birthday to spend time with the two people she never got to see, and loved more than anyone else. She found herself nodding. “Yeah, kid. I can look into that. I don’t see why she can’t take a day of shore leave if her ship is nearby. And if it’s not, well...” She looked around like she was telling a big secret. “I can have Sea Hawk go get her.”

“Really!” Eliza had snapped back to exuberance faster than light. “You can really, really do that?!”

“Duh!” Mermista tossed her hair dramatically. “I’m Sea-Ra, princess of the oceans, and I’m queen of Salineas. I can basically do whatever I want.” Eliza giggled, and Mermista was glad her moment of goofiness had landed, and that her only audience was a child. “Now, I think it’s time you all got back home. It’s getting dark, and the lanterns are already on.”

Eliza scrambled to her feet, and took off for the gates, but not before she paused to call, “Thank you, Your Maj’sty!”

Mermista waited inside, tapped out from the day and not willing to risk granting more wishes to children. This one was already going to be a little tough. Moments later, Sea Hawk rounded the corner and found her on the bench. He pulled her to her feet, and wrapped her in a hug. “I missed those little skippers.”

“You’re so good with them.” Her hand slipped into his as he shrugged.

“It’s easy to be good with them when you’re practically a fairytale hero. I bring them goods, and stories, and I listen to them.” He yawned. “That’s the thing with kids. No one listens to them, so when you do, you become their new best friend.”

Mermista considered that surprising nugget of wisdom from Sea Hawk. “I guess that makes sense.”

Sea Hawk preened. “Yes, well, I’m very-” He stopped short, tugging her to a stop by her hand.

Her right hand.

Mermsita bit back a grin, and watched as he turned her hand over, staring at the ring on her finger like he wasn’t quite sure whether he believed it was really there. In the lantern light of the courtyard, the gems sparkled like fire. He stared, gaping, at the ring, then at her, then at the ring, and then at her again.

“You good?”

“Am I...am I good?” He blinked at her. “You...you found the ring.”

“It wasn’t exactly hidden.” She rolled her eyes gently, even if her smile dampened the effect. “You practically handed it to me.”

“I...handed it to you.”

Mermista was starting to become concerned that he somehow gave himself a concussion from the shock. She tugged him close, bringing a hand up to his jaw and closing his mouth, his teeth making a muted *click* .

“Sorry,” she murmured. “If I ruined some grand proposal. I just saw it, and I...I knew. And then when I tried it on, I-” She took a steadying breath and glanced away towards the fountains. “I realized I didn’t, like, ever want to take it off. Sooooo I didn’t.” She shrugged, despite the butterflies. “Say something?”

He didn’t. He just kept staring, until Mermista started to feel the tickling edges of panic. And then he surged forward, capturing her lips with his in a searing kiss. A noise like a sob bubbled out of him, and he grabbed her waist and shoulders to dip her. She yelped into his mouth, her hands coming up to grip his collar. They didn’t come up for a long time, not until Mermista’s lips were swollen and they were out of breath. He pulled her upright, but held her close. She opened her eyes to see a single tear slipping down Sebastian’s face.

“Are...are you sure? We just- I don’t want you to feel obligated-”

She silenced him with another kiss, before replacing her lips with a gentle thumb. He pressed a small kiss to it and her heart fluttered.

“I love you. And I want you. I don’t know when this will happen, like logistically, with the war and everything else. And we should probably wait til well after the coronation to announce. But yes, Sebastian. I’m sure.”

He nodded along with her words, before he grinned like a maniac. He swept her off her feet, hoisting her into a small lift, while he laughed his booming laugh and sang his stupid shanties. Even as she rolled her eyes, and groaned, she was smiling just as widely. And when Maevik called them in for the meeting, and they had to sober up quickly, her hand never left his.

She changed out of his clothes, and into a simple lehenga choli, and met him by the doors to the throne room. He looked as he ever did; headband, worn coat, neckerchief, stupid boob window shirt, and thigh highs that on anyone else would look absurd. But he held himself differently, slightly, head higher, less fidgeting, and kissed her cheek gently in front of, like, six guards and three advisors. And she let him.

No one made mention of the ring at the meeting, which dragged on for hours. No one looked at him with judgement, or at her strangely for letting him be in here. It was...freakishly smooth, and felt normal. Briefly, Mermista wondered if they were back in the portal. Afterwards, as everyone began to disperse, she pulled Maevik aside to ask about it.

He merely smiled enigmatically in response and said, “Perhaps your people have simply been preparing for the inevitable.”

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Sea Hawk was lounging in Mermista’s bedroom while he waited for her to come back from her meeting with her lady in waiting. Twilight had fallen, and he was absolutely exhausted, but he didn’t want to fall asleep. Not without her, his betrothed.

The thrill that ran up his spine and made him shiver at that was enough to leave him grinning to himself in an empty room. Mermista had said *yes* !

In her own coy, dry way, that is. They were going to be married… the thought left him dizzy, like he'd just danced a reel on a stomach full of whisky. She would be his *wife* . Mermista, Queen and Princess-

He would be King.

That thought catapulted him upright, and onto his feet to pace nervously. Oh stars, he hadn't actually thought about that part of it. Like, he had, of course, kind of, in the abstract. But now it was real. Frighteningly real. King of a nation that was arguably in the riskiest position on the map during the war. A nation the Horde would stop at nothing to annex. Suddenly, he had a vastly greater understanding of Mermista's ever-simmering level of anxiety.

He wasn't sure how long he paced, tugging at his hair and running a thumb through the hair of his mustache, but eventually the door opened, and Mermista stormed in looking haggard and furious. He opened his mouth, but she sliced a hand through the air in a clear message of 'if you love breathing, you will stay silent'. She all but collapsed into the chaise bench at her vanity, and dropped her head into her hands.

After a few minutes of fidgeting, rocking on his toes, and trying not to hum, Sea Hawk couldn't take it anymore. He approached her back, and laid a tentative hand on her shoulder. She reached up, and instead of batting it off, gripped it tightly. Her eyes came up to meet his in the mirror, and he frowned at the exhaustion in them. “Dearest?”

Her eyes shut again at the nickname, but she didn’t groan.

Progress, he cheered internally.

“Do you remember when I mentioned that guy who wanted to court me? Who ran off when the Sea Gate started crumbling?”

Sea Hawk scowled. “Swine. Yes, why?”

“He’s back. And he wants to resume courting.”

The floor underneath Sea Hawk didn’t drop out, but it did wobble. A lot. He cleared his throat. “Ah, I- I see.”

“I went to the meeting and he was just...there. Like he had all the right in the world to be in my castle.” Mermista began removing her makeup, two days old and caked on with vengeance. “Like what he did wasn’t heinously insulting and cowardly, not only to me but my people. And he has the *audacity* to come back here and *ask to be king* ?” Mermista didn’t shout, but she did get progressively more loud and repulsed by the man.

Sea Hawk merely nodded empathetically.

“If there hadn’t been witnesses, I would have absolutely throttled him. Like, seriously, *who does that* ?!” She flung the makeup wipe into the trash, and pulled some water out of one of her wall fountains. Even as she pulled the oils and residual makeup off her face, she kept ranting. “I swear to the Moons, if I ever see his stupid, ugly, meerkat-ass face in my kingdom again, there will be blood. Ugh! I could just-”

“Wait, he’s gone?” Sea Hawk frowned. He didn’t know much about diplomacy but…

Mermista dropped the water back into the fountain basin. “Yeah, I threw him out.”

“ *What?!* ” He balked. “Mermista- he’s a duke, right? Couldn’t that have repercussions?”

She merely shrugged, pushing her hair back with a headband and reaching for one of the many glass vials on the vanity. She put a few drops of serum in her palm and began massaging it into her face. “It could. I don’t really care, because if he starts shit about it, I’ll have my courtiers leak the oh-so-sensitive rumors that he’s been sleeping around with his ladies in waiting, fled when the Horde attacked, and then strutted in here demanding to be King because he ran out of money.”

Sea Hawk couldn’t help but grin, even as he hid it behind a fist. “You truly hate this man, hm?”

Mermista snorted, even as she reached for a pair of tweezers and began plucking at the fine hairs of her eyebrows. Sea Hawk winced.

“I knew from a very young age that whoever I married would have to care about my people, not just the perks of being a king. Yes, we’re a reasonably wealthy nation. We’re not Bright Moon, but we’re a trade kingdom. Our coiffures have never hurt, and everyone knows that. It’s stupidly obvious when someone just wants the crown for the gold.” She sighed, and rolled her neck before grabbing a bottle of some lotion.

Sea Hawk moved behind her, rubbing his thumbs into the back of her neck, digging in gently until she groaned.

“So,” he murmured. “How does your current choice shape up? For the crown, and all.”

She stared at him in the mirror, those amber eyes boring into his until he had to look away. It felt like she could read his thoughts when she did that, and he didn’t want Mermista seeing the insecurities he was hiding.

“I think he’s a former pirate, so he’s independently wealthy.” She started massaging her cheeks with the lotion. “I think he’s much smarter than he lets on, when he’s not being purposely obtuse, or a doofus.”

Sea Hawk snorted at that, ducking his head to hide his smile.

“And I know he cares about my kingdom, and its people, and their wellbeing, and I’ll never have to worry about him growing bored of caring for them.” Mermista stood, kicking off her shoes at last and bringing their height difference to its natural five inches. She ran gentle hands over his chest, his hands falling away from her neck. “More importantly, I think he needs to stop worrying about archaic, classist bullshit, and get ready for bed because he’s exhausted. And most importantly...” She broke off and blushed, looking away and rubbing her ear. “I love him, and I didn’t think I’d ever get to marry someone I love. So...yeah. I think he shapes up, like, pretty well.”

Sea Hawk grinned. “You’ve been saying so many things, and they’ve all been so wonderful.”

“Ugh, I know” Mermista groaned, and rolled her eyes, and Sea Hawk delighted in the familiarity. “It’s, like, so much. Can I stop now?”

“Yes, dearest.” He kissed her forehead. “Let’s go to bed.”

Chapter End Notes

One could say they’re in the eye of the storm for now…

pray for me child (just for a while)

Chapter Summary

Goodbyes

Chapter Notes

I really should make a Spotify playlist for this fic bc I have a timeline of songs I've been using for inspo and fic titles.

Anyway. Angela's funeral. I took a lot of liberties and headcanons in this chap and the next so I hope y'all enjoy them!

There is slight sexual implication at the end of this chap but nothing explicit

See the end of the chapter for more notes

New beginnings always had a learning curve. Sea Hawk knew this, as he'd had more beginnings in fifteen years than most people had in a lifetime. He'd been a good fisherman, but a bad crewmate to start with. Then he'd been a bad pirate, and a good crewmate. Then a good pirate, but a...rougher man overall. He finally felt like he was getting a handle on being a good man. So, logically, that meant he had to be a bit behind the class in another area. Learning to be what Mermista needed? It was possibly the toughest curve yet. His only comfort was the fact that he knew she was right there with him.

Reading her moods had always been easy for him. Reading his own moods, in those moments, and reacting in a supportive and appropriate way? He might as well have been reading Entrapta's robotics notes. His instincts told him to be loud and boisterous when Mermista was feeling low, but that got him a very annoyed significant other. Moments where he felt that being quiet and letting her talk was best, were actually moments where she was looking for input. He mixed up her ‘leave me alone’ and ‘please come here’ sighs, and more than once had completely misread her desire for overt, grand, romantic gestures. Well, to be fair, he’d never gotten that one right.

But, this was a learning *curve* and not a learning block. Things were getting better, and progressively. Mistakes were opportunities to gain new understanding and succeed the next time. He learned that, when they had time, she always wanted to watch the moons set with him. He knew now that ice cream and hot toddies on the balcony were never unappreciated. He had learned now that her head in her hands meant ‘I need you’, while fingers at her temples meant ‘give me some space’. He knew which eye rolls were genuine, and which were a feigned front, just from the tug of her mouth when they happened. And most things hadn’t even needed changing, just gentle correction and adjustment. Sleeping together, in every sense, was better than ever. They talked now, about everything and nothing. They sat and read together, or worked alongside each other in her study.

It was everything Sea Hawk had ever wanted with her, and he was finally confident in knowing she wanted it just as much, even when she struggled to show it.

And she did struggle still, Mermista. She wasn’t affectionate in public, hell, she could be downright frosty in the worst of moments. Being touched, kissed, fawned over, and so on, were all definite no’s. Especially at court. Sea Hawk saw better than ever how she used her indifference as armor, and any implications to the contrary were chips she didn’t feel she could afford. And he understood that now. He kept his hands to himself, and his affection was limited to subtle winks and words instead of public serenades and embraces. In the interest of compromise, he was able to get away with a lot more when they were alone now, and it worked. It worked really well, from where they were standing.

But now, the ball would be out of Mermista's court. They were in Bright Moon for the funeral and coronation, and Mermista was more nervous than he'd seen her in a while.

"This is, like, the first thing I've had to do diplomatically," she was saying as she twisted her hair into a tight braid. "What if I say the wrong thing, or the memento gift is, like, not okay at all? And then I have a roll in the coronation, and no one else does-"

"Dearest," Sea Hawk called from the bathroom, where he was shaving his stubble. "Your roll in the coronation is parting a sheet of water. You could do that in your sleep."

"But what if I fuck it up," she whined. Sea Hawk bit down a laugh, aware that it would not be well-received at the moment. "I have to do, like, the formal motion for it, and usually I just flick my hand like a bitch-"

He couldn't stop the bark of laughter in time. "What does that even mean?"

"You know what it means! " she groaned.

Sea Hawk shook his head and rinsed his face off, patting it dry as he crossed into the bedroom. His blacks for the funeral were laid out, accented with Salinean gold. Even though they had yet to formally announce their betrothal, word had spread around the castle, and the staff's treatment of him had shifted ever-so-slightly. Newer, nicer day clothes in Salinean colors had been made, formal wear, jewelry. Sea Hawk wasn't sure how he felt about it most days, and this wasn't even the official welcome wagon yet. Today, though, he was grateful. He hadn't ever attended a funeral that didn't end in a ship being set ablaze, and one didn't exactly wear their finery to such an event.

Despite the somber occasion, Mermista was a knock-out in her black jumpsuit; the straps were thick, and flared into hints of sleeves without actually being full cap sleeves, while the front of the suit dipped into a V that reached her navel. The slit was covered in gauzy black mesh that was woven through sporadically with gold threads. Her lipstick was black, and her eyeshadow smoked out in a way that left Sea Hawk's mouth dry. He wasn't sure if she was giving him bedroom eyes, or if it was just the makeup. She had dabbed some gentle gold glitter into the corners of her eyes, complimenting the gold in the mesh perfectly.

Sea Hawk's own suit was black, from the slacks to the waistcoat to the button up underneath it. The clips and breast pocket of the waistcoat were gold, along with his cufflinks, and the metal fasteners of his new boots (his old, favorite boots were stashed lovingly in his part of Mermista's massive closet). He dressed quickly, pausing only when he got to the cufflinks and the gold chain that would connect the open top buttons of his shirt.

Mermista stood, hair braided in an elaborate and jewel studded fishtail, secured by a gold and pearl encrusted hairpin. A jeweled hand chain twinkled and clinked on her right hand. She still refused to take off the ring, but the large piece of jewelry she wore now more than hid it. She slipped into her shoes, lifting herself five inches, and crossed over to him. Wordlessly, she clicked the cufflinks into place and clipped the chain shut. She turned, and he tightened the interior laces of the bodice- she hadn't wanted a corset top, and this was the best compromise the tailor could come up with.

Last, but so, so far from least, Mermista reached into the gilded velvet box that sat like an omen on the dresser and lifted out the crown she never wore. It was a simple circlet, the band made up of strands of silver that varied in thickness, woven together in delicate waves. Gems in varying shades of blue studded the metal in random patterns and clusters, broken up by white and opal jewels. The silver came to a gentle point in the center of her forehead, from which a miniscule, circular pearl hung. From the circle, a tear drop shaped pearl swayed gently, resting just above her brow bone. Mermista set it on her head with all the zeal of someone putting a sea urchin on their head. When she turned to him, she was grimacing. "I hate this thing."

"I've noticed," he replied diplomatically.

She smoothed her dress out with rote motions, and her mouth opened gently as if she had more to say. Sea Hawk waited patiently, but she just shook her head and gave up on verbalizing whatever she was thinking. They gave each other a quiet once over, and when Mermista nodded, they left the room. In the main hall, they joined Perfuma and Frosta, each dressed in their own somber attire. Perfuma wrapped Mermista in a hug, whispering something in her ear that made the mermaid blush but smile gently. Perfuma moved to him next, hugging him tightly.

“It’s so good to see you,” she murmured, and pulled back. They exchanged sad smiles. “If only it were under better circumstances.”

Frosta nodded to both of them, but kept her arms wrapped around herself and stayed leaning against the wall. Perfuma shrugged helplessly, like she didn’t know what to make of it either.

Mermista cleared her throat. “You alright, kid?”

The ice princess shrugged. “Are any of us?”

The point was well taken, and they lapsed into a reflective silence until Netossa and Spinnerella rounded the corner. Netossa wore her usual fur stole, but underneath she’d swapped out her battle gear for a corseted gown in deep navy, nearly black, with silver and white lace detailing. Spinnerella’s own dress was as flowing as the wind she controlled, a rich plum Bright Moon gown. Their swapped chokers- their wedding tokens- sat proudly on their necks. Netossa smiled sadly at them. “Hey girls. And Sea Hawk.”

Hellos were murmured, hugs exchanged, and then they were back to the waiting game for the next half hour. Eventually, Bow and Adora, dressed to the nines with red rimmed eyes, rounded the corner to meet them. Bow smiled genuinely when he saw Sea Hawk, and he all but jogged the last few feet to meet him in a hug. Adora’s eyes remained unfocused, the most she could offer being a hollow smile and a nod. Mermista understood the feeling; Angella might not have been Adora's mother by birth, or even by choice, but she'd been the closest thing the warrior had had to a healthy maternal relationship. Her devastation was no less than Glimmer's, even if it was a different depth.

Shocking herself, Mermista joined Perfuma in crossing over to the blonde and wrapping her a hug. In her heels, Mermista stood a few inches taller than Adora, about the same height as Perfuma, and the two older girls practically swallowed her in their embrace. Adora's breath hitched. "Thanks, guys."

"Always, Adora," Perfuma whispered, smoothing a hand through sleek blonde hair.

"Yeah." Mermista sniffed. "We, like, understand what you guys are going through. If you need, you know, anything- talking, punching, drinking-"

"Mermista!" Perfuma scowled.

She shrugged. "Whatever you need, just come find us."

They pulled back when Adora nodded. She swiped at her eyes, only to squeeze them shut again when Sea Hawk approached her with his own strong hug. It was almost comical, how short Adora was compared to him when she wasn't She Ra. And Sea Hawk spent so much time being ridiculous, it was easy to forget that he was the tallest among them, save for Spinnerella. He wasn't a wisp either, his broad shoulders and thick biceps flexing as he squeezed Adora. Mermista wasn't worried, she'd watched Adora slam him into the dirt too many times for that. She hugged him back just as tightly.

Mermista yanked him gently back by the collar when it seemed like the hug was becoming more a dick-sizing contest of strength than a means of comfort. Sea Hawk sheepishly rubbed the back of his neck, and she rolled her eyes. They all murmured amongst themselves until a troupe of guards and attendees rounded the corner in formation, flanking Glimmer. She led the party with a depressed, resigned air, though the look in her eyes still hinted at shock and disbelief. Mermista remembered going to her own mother's funeral as if looking back at it through an old, warped mirror. The entire affair had been an out of body experience; she'd shed no tears, and while her father commended her for her 'brave face', she could only nod robotically. She could imagine that Glimmer was feeling much the same right now.

She nodded at each of them, and they fell into rank behind her. They may have all been sovereign leaders, but Angella had been head of the Rebellion. Their leader, their general. To Mermista, she'd been an idol, someone to aspire to, a queen to turn to when she needed help. Now, Glimmer would have to take up that mantle whether she was ready or not.

So they stood behind her, in support and solidarity of their fallen Queen.

The procession moved through the main halls of Bright Moon castle, out into the public courtyard where civilians began to file behind them, all dressed in black and carrying white roses. People from Thaymoor, Alwyn, Erelandia, and other colonies and towns of the Woods stepped forward first. Next, the people of Plumeria; Perfuma had no ranked military, and her cabinets and assemblies were much looser than other kingdoms, so there was no order. Next, the Salinean military generals, then the heads and representatives of the city states (Peekablue avoided any and all eye contact, and that suited Mermista just fine), the ambassadors, and so on. They fell in line behind her, and Mermista held her head that much higher, for her people. Snows' sparse political cabinet, including Frosta's advisors, fell in next. Shocking them all, several residents of Dryl had come to represent their fallen kingdom, rounding out the procession. By the time they reached the lofted monasterial structure that sat on one of Bright Moon's lower mountains, they had amassed a crowd hundreds strong.

Mermista remembered Spinnerella and Netossa being married here when she was very young. A few years after that, Micah's memorial had been held here, and they'd never returned. It looked much the same; a massive open building with vaulted pillars, stained glass windows in lilac and rose and white. The sun was shining brightly, and there was a cool breeze ruffling the cherry blossom flowers. It was too cheery for a funeral, let alone one so devastating.

They filed in, royalty and nobility and gentry taking their seats, though many gave theirs up for the elderly, pregnant, and young among them. The rest stood, some in the building, most out. Mermista sat like she'd been instructed to in her etiquette classes, like she never did in her own throne room; back straight, chin and neck at ninety degrees, hands folded left over right in her lap. Usually she would cross her legs, but that felt too...casual. At least for the moment. Sea Hawk, bless him, did his best to mimic her posture. Without turning, she pushed his shoulders down and back a bit so he looked less like a marionette with taught strings. He nodded silently, thanking her, and she nodded back.

He'd had a...mild freak out the night before about sitting next to her at the funeral. He felt he should be with the citizens, the gentry at best, but she'd been insistent. The more he fought her, the more irate she got

"You put a ring on my finger, you don't get to pick and choose when to commit!"

He had paced in a violent circle, hands flapping ridiculously at her where she laid on the bed. "Technically, you put the ring there yourself-"

When that had only gotten him a twenty minute cold silence in the guise of Mermista taking a shower (she had, but it hadn't taken twenty minutes. She was working on it, alright? She wasn't going to stop being petty over night), they'd realized that bickering wasn't going to solve anything. Sex didn't either, but she was glad they ruled it out. Just to be safe. Eventually, she'd taken his hand in the quiet dark of the guest room, and twined her fingers with his. "I...understand why you're nervous. But I'm fucking *terrified* , Sea Hawk. Maybe it's selfish of me, yeah, but I need you there tomorrow. Next to me. For as long as I have to wear that...that thing. Okay?"

He'd stared at her long and hard, before he rolled closer and pressed a kiss to her hair. "Alright. I understand. Just, please, don't let me embarrass either of us."

“Deal.”

So here they sat, side by side. And while Mermista felt like she was wearing about fourteen pounds of raw metal and stone on her head, she wasn’t as petrified as she thought she’d be. The ceremony began with a flash of brilliant light, and the melodious strains of a violin concerto from some unseen orchestra. They all stood together, shoulder to shoulder.

It was beautiful as far as funerals went. Glimmer, Adora, and Bow spoke, as well as Castaspella, Glimmer’s sorceress aunt. Juliet, the head guard, moved them all to tears, even Mermista and Netossa. She was grateful when Sea Hawk pressed his pocket handkerchief into her hand, and she gave him a wobbly smile as she blotted her eyes. She ended up giving the fabric to Frosta, who hadn’t stopped crying for several minutes now. Perfuma and she took turns squeezing the girl’s shoulders, offering her what comfort they could. At some point, during the final eulogy delivered by Glimmer, on Angella as a mother, and not a queen, she thought *‘to hell with etiquette’* , and grabbed Sea Hawk’s hand in hers. He held it as tightly as he could, and it was that sturdy, slightly painful grip that kept her grief from bubbling over.

They did not proceed back to the castle, instead leaving the crowd of non-princesses to disperse first. Once they were alone, Perfuma conjured them all flowers in their kingdom’s colors. There was no casket, but there was a portrait of Angella, placed on an altar strewn with flowers, and ribbons, and tributes from all the kingdoms, and even those civilians who felt like making them. The altar would be enshrined in the catacombs below Bright Moon, where all the other angels laid.

One by one, they approached the altar, leaning forward to kiss the enchanted wood before setting the flower on it, where it bound itself by embedding its roots in the surface. They each whispered something in their native tongue, a prayer or oath or goodbye to the woman who had decided to take up her mantle when it mattered most, leading them to victories and, in the end, saving them all with her sacrifice. No one batted an eye when Sea Hawk walked up with Mermista. Perfuma even grew him his own flower.

"Thank you," Mermista whispered in Salinean. "For everything. For letting Glimmer bring us together, for...for helping me when I needed it most. Please, tell Ama I say hi, and that I love her…" She wiped her eyes. "Goodbye, Queen Angella. May you sleep where the waves are gentle, and warm with sunlight."

Sea Hawk stepped forward, and spoke his own piece in a dialect of Icsarin that Mermista didn't know. When he finished, she stepped up beside him, and together they placed their flowers on the altar, side by side. They turned as one, and with just their friends present, leaned into each other more than they would have. Mermista still wasn't over the moon about PDA, especially when she was already so vulnerable, but she was thoroughly wrung out.

When the last flower was placed, they left the temple together, huddled around Glimmer (and Frosta, who had clung to the older girl in a hug, and been hugged back just as tightly; they had yet to let go). Adora was stumbling, hiccuping occasionally even though her tears were few and far between. Bow and Sea Hawk walked on either side of her, ready to support the solidly muscled girl should she stumble. In the back, Spinnerella and Netossa clung to each other, the latter tucked into the former’s shoulder. They gave the older woman her space; her shoulders shook with silent sobs, while her wife had tears streaming silently down her cheeks. This left Mermista and Perfuma to lead the party back to the castle. At one point, Mermista used Perfuma’s shoulder for support while she whipped off her heels without breaking stride, which made the older girl crack a smile. “I’ve never understood how you could wear those for as long as you do.”

Mermista snorted. “You know me, always a glutton for self-punishment.” Perfuma just sighed fondly, wrapping an arm around her shorter friend’s shoulders. She leaned into the plant girl’s body, slinging a loose arm around her rail thin waist.

“How are you holding up?”

Mermista knew the others could hear them, and were probably listening in as there was nothing else to be heard, but she was too damn tired to care. “Oh, y’know. Shitty.”

Perfuma nodded. “Reminds you, huh?”

“Yup.” Mermista clenched her jaw, feeling the bone near her temple click.

“Do you remember? Your mother’s?” Perfuma was staring off into the night that was falling around them. “I don’t remember my mothers’, not really. I remember the, um, the flowers, that my dad picked. And the way the sun fell through the trees. But I don't remember their caskets. Or- or the ceremony."

Mermista was silent for a while, listening for the distant sound of the ocean's roar and letting it soothe her. "I remember bits. I was, like, a *kid* kid, you know? I remember it was lavish, and beautiful, and gold. But I always got the feeling it was, like, cold. Performative. Like everything else he did." Her voice grew bitter. "We didn't...there wasn't a body that could be displayed. After the attack, they let her return to the sea, or whatever, so it was more of a memorial type thing."

"I remember," Netossa's voice, hoarse and choked, cut through the night. "Both of your parents' funerals. They were beautiful."

Mermista offered her a wan smile. Adora and Bow were shifting uncomfortably, staring at one another before Adora spoke up. "Wait...both of your moms…?"

Perfuma spoke when she realized Mermista wasn't going to. "Yes. My moms died when the Horde first attempted to take the Woods. They and my dad went out to try and stop the fleet, but they were so, so outnumbered. They pushed my dad back, sent him for reinforcements, but when they got back it was too late. I was five."

Mermista swallowed thickly. "My mom died defending the Sea Gate. The Horde had just built ships with guns on them, and we...we didn't know. My mom hated carnage near the city, so she went under to try and push them out to open sea with a tidal wave. She never even saw the guns, my father said."

Adora's eyes swam as she took in the group around her. "All...all of you?"

Netossa and Spinnerella nodded sadly, though the grief was a long healed scar now. Their parents had perished during the first invasion, when the Scorpioni Kingdom fell. Angella had taken them under her wing, quite literally, and raised them to be strong and powerful rulers of their city states. But they all knew the pain never really went away.

Sea Hawk merely nodded, and when Bow turned to him with swimming eyes, he shrugged. "Horde raid on my home village. It was the same attack that took the Kings." Frosta sniffled, but reached out from beside Glimmer to squeeze Sea Hawk's hand in her own. He smiled at her, a shared moment passing wordlessly between them.

Glimmer, who hadn't said a word since her eulogy, looked at them all in turn. "We're going to end this war. For them." She inhaled, shaking. "Our parents didn't die in vain. We're going to make a better world, for ourselves, and for our children, and all who come after."

Mermista was bolstered by the fire in the young queen's eyes, and gave her a soft smile. With just those few words, the energy shifted from morose and somewhat lost, to a quiet, burning resolve shared among them. This would be the end. It had to be.

The little girl from the portal flashed in her mind's eye, and she vowed to the phantom child that she would never, ever wear her mother's armor.

The repasse lasted only an hour, before everyone was turning in or sailing home. Mermista shook the hands of the nobility who had come to the funeral from Salineas, wishing them safe passage, before she and Sea Hawk made their escape. The door to their room shut softly, and they wordlessly set about preparing for bed. Sea Hawk turned down sheets while Mermista began running a bath in one of the deep Bright Moon tubs. Well, deep-ish, by Salinean standards. They met back in the room and began undressing one another. Moments like these were her exact perfect speed; the soft intimacy of knowing one another, and the silence where actions mattered more than words.

Mermista unclipped the chains and cufflinks, and even reached up for his heavy pirate earrings. He left them in so often, and she knew one of these nights he'd tear an earlobe and she'd have to hear him whine about it for the rest of their lives. She unbuttoned his waistcoat, his shirt, the belt and fasteners of his pants. Her hands roamed (seriously, how could they not? He spent so much time being a buffoon that it was easy to forget he was, like, shredded) but without much intent. Once he was divested of all but his underwear, she wrapped her arms around his torso and leaned into his space-heater chest. He was always so damn warm. Even with the awkward angle, Sea Hawk undid the interior laces of her body suit, and she stepped away to let it pool at her feet. Her shoes had been tossed off the second they got up here, so she stepped out of the silk easily.

Mermista shivered in the cold night air, exposed as she was. Carefully, she peeled the adhesive concealing strips off her nipples, laughing when Sea Hawk grimaced and shuddered at the idea. He removed all her jewelry, taking special care at her neck; no one could see the flat gills on her neck without her tail, but he knew it would hurt if he rubbed them wrong. He leaned in, and pressed a gentle open-mouthed kiss to each side of her neck. She sighed against him, the sensitive skin twitching underneath his lips. He pulled away, and carefully, oh so carefully, lifted the crown from her head. He placed it reverently in its velvet-covered steel case, closing the lid. Mermista flicked her hand, and the sound of running water stopped. She lifted her arms out to him, intending for a hug, and shrieking when she found herself lifted off her feet. "Sea Hawk- what-!"

"You've been in those heels all day," he said. "Allow me."

"Ugh, you're such a goober." She couldn't stop her smile, but she could be annoyed about it. He set her to her feet on the cold tile, and she stripped her underwear off as fast as she could. She scrambled into the tub, ready to stop being cold, while Sea Hawk chucked. "Shut up."

"Yes, princess." He climbed in behind her, and she scooted back against his broad chest, sighing when his arms and knees came up to bracket her in. The water pulled at her legs, but she ignored it for as long as possible. Sea Hawk pressed a kiss to the top of her head. "No tail?"

"It's gonna hang out," she groused. "I'll look weird."

"You could never look weird, dearest."

She scowled and flicked her hand at him, splashing his face with water and soaking his mustache so it drooped. Mermista giggled at the sight, only laughing harder when he stuck his tongue out at her and tried to smooth it back into shape.

Eventually, the prickling became too much, so while Sea Hawk was scrubbing shampoo into her scalp, she let her legs swap themselves for her tail, the glow of magic filling the room briefly. She heard Sea Hawk gasp in delight behind her and she snorted. The transformation never lost novelty with him. He scooped water down her head, rinsing her scalp, while she set about removing her makeup. It took the better part of ten minutes before her face was clean and she could toss the dirty water to the floor of the shower across the room. She reclined against Sea Hawk again, sighing in bliss as he massaged soap into her collarbone, down her chest, and-

She bit back a moan as he rolled a nipple between his fore and middle fingers. "Sebastian…"

"Yes, love?" God it was unfair that his voice could get that husky when he spent half his day yodelling about jack shit.

"Don't start what you can't finish- ah-!" He flicked her nipple gently.

"When have I ever left you hanging?" He pushed her up so he could start trailing his tongue down the back of her neck, along her spine. Mermista groaned, with just enough presence of mind to shift her tail back into legs so she could get to shaky- and sore- feet. She used the water to displace the plug, and pulled Sea Hawk to his feet. He dried off haphazardly, tripping over the towel as she sashayed her way back to the bedroom, putting just a little, teeny bit of extra sway into her hips. He caught up to her just past the threshold of the bathroom, and lifted her into his arms again. Mermista's legs wrapped around his waist while he held her ass in a bruising grip. He caught her lips with his and she moaned into his mouth. He all but threw her on the bed, eyes blazing as he crawled on top of her. She had just enough time to flick the lights off and lock the door with a tendril of water before Sea Hawk's head was between her legs and thought became very difficult for the rest of the night.

Chapter End Notes

> Next: coronation day ! A favored chapter of mine. But so was this one. Thank you for all the comments and kudos I'm working on playing catch up with replies!!
>
> Also working on an ensemble modern AU that I hope will hit the shelves this week

make my whole world feel so right when it's wrong

Chapter Summary

Glimmer's Coronation

Chapter Notes

Guess who completely lost track of her updating schedule ayooooooo!

Here's the coronation chap, easily one of my favorite to write. After this is a series of vignettes, then the Big Sad :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Sea Hawk woke up slowly, sunlight streaming into his eyes and making him grimace and turn over. He yanked the blanket up higher, attempting to not wake up yet, but knowing it was probably a lost cause. Never in his life had he been able to fall back asleep after waking up in the morning, the idea of a full day of adventure and tasks jolting him into awareness without his consent. At least these days he was better at just relaxing in bed for a while before he had to get up and move. It probably had something to do with the teal-haired princess currently burrowed into his chest, utterly submerged in a sea of blankets. He wasn't sure how she breathed at night.

He settled back in, idly running his finger tips down the smooth skin of her back, taking stock of himself. Today was the coronation, and then the ball. Sea Hawk wasn't going to lie to himself, he was kind of scared shitless. They'd agreed to keep the engagement (his heart swooped, and he held her a bit tighter) under wraps for now, in the light of everyone's grief, including their own. But he was still here as her formal guest, and a guest of Bright Moon, and he felt like he was drowning, in over his head and tangled in ocean weeds that wouldn't let him surface. He didn't want to embarrass her, or himself, or Salineas. He didn't want his friends (her friends? No, Bow was his friend) to look at him with That Look, or worse, her. He was terrified of her hand leaving his while her face burned with shame because he said or did something wrong, or dumb, or- or disappointing.

Sea Hawk wasn't even aware he was hyperventilating until Mermista's hand was squeezing his shoulder, head emerging from her cocoon. Her face was a sculpture, a marvel, etched in bleary confusion. "Sebastian? What's wrong?"

"Nothing," he squeaked. "Go back to sleep."

"Fat chance." She yawned, jaw stretching wide and giving him a glimpse of pointy, alien molars. He swallowed. "Talk to me?"

"I'm scared." The words spilled out of him without control, sand between his mind's fingers. "I don't…I don't want to fuck up today. But I know I'm going to and- and maybe I should just hang out up here, y'know? You're more than capable of doing these things on your own, and-"

"Hey." She was wide awake now, propped up on one shoulder as she leaned over him. "Quit it, alright? We talked about this."

"I know but-"

“Nuh-uh, no buts, dude.” She frowned. “You…you said you wouldn’t leave again, right? That means no, like, abandoning me at formal events that give me hives, kay?”

“But what if I embarrass you?” The words that swam in his mind like a shark breached at last, small and scared even as he gripped the manicured hand on his chest.

But Mermista just shrugged. “Then I'll groan, and roll my eyes, and get over it. What I won’t get over is you, like, running and hiding when I need you. And I- I do. Need you, I mean. Need you to keep me from having a total breakdown today.”

Sea Hawk nodded, the whirlpool slowing its spin, releasing him for air. “Are you sure?”

“Yup.” Ehe scratched the side of her nose, endearingly bored. “Wearing the ring and all, so. Kind of super sure, y’know? And I… want you there. You make these stuffy parties more, like, fun, or whatever.”

He smiled, touched by her leaps and bounds in emotional communication, but smart enough to keep his mouth shut about it lest she clam up for the rest of the day. Instead, he leaned up to kiss her softly. He pulled back quickly, if reluctantly. They had a massive day to get ready for. “We need to get up, dearest.”

Mermista groaned, and snuggled back down. “Nooooooo…”

“Yesssssss,” he groaned back, but the effect was ruined by his laughter. She kicked at him under the blankets. “Ow! Hey, this is- stop!- spousal abuse! Mermista, really, your feet are- quit it!- freezing.”

She was laughing now, tiny giggle-snorts that only he got to hear. “Shit luck, you signed up for this.”

“Well, technically, you stole the ring from me-Ow! Okay, that’s enough-”

They ended up being late for breakfast, thanks to a tickle fight that turned into a wrestling match that turned into- well. They were late, but only by a few minutes. Thankfully, everyone was too engrossed in preparation for the ball, and coronation, that no one noticed their delayed entrance. Except Perfuma, who winked at them, earning herself the middle finger from her oldest friend.

After breakfast, Sea Hawk and Mermista were pulled in different directions, barely time for him to press a quick kiss to her cheek before Bow was tugging him away for something. She was hustled off by Castaspella, to the waterfall that had apparently been a gift from her great grandmother to the kingdom of Brightmoon. She spent the morning there, while Castaspella ran off to handle some other thing. Mermista spent an hour trying to figure out the most elegant way to part the water- whatever spells her Great Grandma had put on there were sticky and snobby, and didn’t listen to her when she just flicked her wrist at them. So that took the better part of two hours, leaving her feeling like a novice again- frustrated, soaked, and kind of tired. But she got it, and that's what mattered.

She passed Sea Hawk in the hallway between tasks, where he looked up from some map that Castaspella was showing him- and, uh, okay, she did *not* need to be hugging his arm like that, but whatever. She didn't care (she did. Immensely.). He looked up, as if sensing her presence from down the hall, and gave her That Smile as he pulled away from Castaspella to bound over to her. Something in her eyes must have given her mental state away, because he didn't try to hug her, or kiss her. He just bounced on his feet in front of her, smiling. "How's it going, dearest?"

"Ugh." She rolled her eyes. "Stupid waterfall is finally figured out. There were spells on it, and now I can't just pull this water off of me, so I'm going to go change into my leggings I guess. What about you?"

"Bow has me working on some odd jobs around the courtyard and ballroom. It's been almost fifty years since Bright Moon held a ball, so there's sweeping and mopping and waxing and some spackling and painting and shining and polishing-"

"Whoa, uh- that's like, a lot. You good?" Her body language was bored, casual, but her eyes betrayed her concern.

Sea Hawk just nodded. "Yeah! It's been a while since I've done the whole manual labor thing. I missed it! I like working with my hands."

She gave him a subtle once over. “Yeah, well. That much I know.” His face flushed, and he smiled shyly at her.

“Some tasks are preferable to others.” He winked.

She let herself smile a little, aware of Castaspella tapping her foot impatiently a few feet away. Mermista stepped that much closer to Sea Hawk, their bodies brushing. “Come find me after your chores. I might have some other things for you to…help with.”

His face was bright red now, while hers remained impassive, and the strangled noise he made as he nodded was more than enough to sustain her for the rest of her afternoon. She bumped him gently with her hip as she brushed past, off to whatever they needed her for next.

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She…may have gotten a bit carried away with her childish need to peeve Perfuma off. Just a teeny tiny bit. Guilt wracked her body as Glimmer stormed away, clearly telegraphing her grief and sadness. Mermista shook her head. Of course this wasn’t a party, and they needed to stop acting like it was. The melancholy she’d been pushing off all day came back in full force, the memory of her own coronation coming back to her. The phantom emotions of loneliness, panic, and helpless fear nudging at her. She shook off the cobwebs, and looked around for a lifeline.

Her eyes fell on Sea Hawk automatically.

“Hey, Frosta,” she drawled, not letting her annoyance with the younger girl get the best of her. She was, like, a kid. “Can you unfreeze my date? He needs to finish polishing or whatever he was doing before you, y’know, ‘bounced’ him.”

Frosta had the good graces to look guilty. “Sorry,” she mumbled to both of them as she let Sea Hawk drop. He shook off the ice with a brusque shiver, and she pulled the remaining water off of him. “I guess I just got carried away. I wanted today to be good for Glimmer…but I guess that’s not really going to happen?”

Mermista groaned internally as she crouched to Frosta’s height (seriously when was she going to have a growth spurt?), placing a hand on her shoulder. “I know you just wanted to help. I get it. And it can still be a good day without being, like, a happy day. Because while we’re all glad to see Glimmer be Queen, we’re all still mourning how she got here.” She glanced around the clearing at her…friends. “In fact, I think a lot of us are fighting off the ghosts of how we all got here today. And that’s not what Glimmer needs from us now.”

Frosta nodded, brushing at her eyes harshly. “I don’t even remember my coronation.” She whispered. Mermista hesitated before she spoke. She’d never really talked about her ascension to the throne. It still gave her nightmares.

“I wish I didn’t remember mine, if I’m being honest. So let’s just… try to hit somewhere in the middle for Glim, yeah?”

“Yeah.” Frosta nodded, and she got to her feet. She grunted as the smaller girl hugged her around the waist. “Thanks, Mermista.”

“Uh-huh, sure.” She hugged her back briefly. “Next time you’re… feeling things…trying to feel them near Perfuma. She’s way more equipped for this than I am.”

Frosta giggled. “Kay.”

Speaking of the plant princess, she was coming over to them. “Netossa says it’s time to change. The ceremony will begin at the first sign of sundown.”

“Huh.” Sea Hawk stroked his mustache. “That’s oddly specific.”

Spinnerella walked over serenely. “It’s so that she can be formally crowned under the light of the full moon.”

“Do all kingdoms have caveats like that?”

“Yep!” Perfuma smiled. “Plumeria only crowns at harvests, summer solstice, or spring equinox. Days of plenty, and of bloom.”

“Snows holds coronations at winter solstice, or in a blizzard, but it’s harder to time those.”

Mermista nodded. “Salineas crowns at a full moon’s high tide, when the pull of the waves is strongest.”

“And no one knows about Dryl,” Netossa finished, coming up behind her wife. “They’ve always been private, and now…well...” The thought lingered between them all, the ghost of their turncoat friend sitting heavy on their shoulders. “Anyway, the specific coronation times come from the arcane titles, so we stick to them now.”

“Arcane titles?” Sea Hawk frowned. “What are those?”

“Oh, you know...” Perfuma tapped her fingers together as she thought. “Like, uh- oh, what’s mine again? Queen of the Harvest, Daughter in Blooming Glory, um, what was the rest-”

“Isn’t it, like, She Who Plants the Seeds of Protection, Serenity, and Grace, or something?” Mermista was smirking.

Perfuma scowled. “It’s not like yours is better. Queen of Tides, Tempest Tamer, or was it Wave Rider, Daughter Born to the Hurricane, Calmer of Storms? It’s so long-”

“Shuuuuuut uuuuuup,” Mermista groaned, burying her head in her hands. “It’s so obnoxious. Frosta’s is the best.”

Netossa nodded. “Blizzard Whisper, Queen of Dancing Snow, Winter’s Bane-”

“Wait, that’s not just a silly role playing name?” Perfuma frowned.

Frosta scowled. “At least I’m not a Seed Planter. Who are you, Farmer Brown?”

Mermista snorted behind her hand while Perfuma gaped. “Rude!”

“How do you get these titles?” Sea Hawk smoothly redirected the conversation. Spinnerella smiled at his subtlety.

“One is given based on parameters of your birth, one is based on your mother’s title, and the other is personal, a gift from whoever bore you. Some also get one from their godparent or shaman or such, depending on the culture. It’s supposed to be some sort of portant, what kind of ruler you’ll be, but it’s more accurate to say it’s what they wished for you at the moment of your birth. Who they hoped you’ll be.”

“So I was born at spring’s full bloom.” Perfuma smiled. “And was named to plant the seeds of a better future.”

Mermista nodded. “And I was born in, like, a literal hurricane, and named to calm storms. Which is delightfully circular, if you go for that.”

“And I was born in a blizzard.” Frosta nodded, then frowned. “But I still don’t really get how I’m supposed to be winter’s *bane* if I freeze things.”

“Maybe it’s a metaphor?” Mermista shrugged.

“That sucks, you and Perfuma got easy ones.”

“Planting seeds is pretty easy, yeah.”

Perfuma frowned. “Haven’t seen you calm any storms lately.”

“Wanna see me start one-?”

“Okay!” Netossa clapped her hands. She had a very effective mom voice. “Ladies, and Sea Hawk, it’s time to get dressed. We’ve got a little under an hour until Glimmer begins her quest, which means we have half an hour to get assembled. Let’s move!”

They broke apart, arguments forgotten. At some point, Sea Hawk’s hand slipped into Mermista's, and she didn’t pull away. She pushed open the door to her room, only to find herself pressed against it while it slammed shut under her. Sea Hawk’s lips were on hers, and she smiled into his kiss. His hands skirted her sides, settling on her hips and tugging her closer to him. It was lazy and loving, but not without heat simmering just under the surface.

They broke apart softly, barely pulling away. “What was that for?” Mermista breathed against his lips.

“Nothing,” he hummed, resting his forehead against hers. “Everything.”

“Vague, mysterious. I like it.”

He smiled at her shyly. “I like your big, long, fancy name.”

“Ugh.” She rolled her eyes. “You can have it.”

“Will I?” His nose brushed against hers. “When I’m…you know.”

“King?” Mermista still felt giddy at the idea, even if she kept it down. “Yeah. Well, sort of. You’ll have your own.”

“Who picks?” Sea Hawk was getting distracted, kissing along her jaw, back toward the spot under her ear that would guarantee their tardiness. She gripped his hair to stop his path.

“Me.”

That caught his attention. “You?”

“Yeah, when you marry into royalty, your spouse picks your title. It’s approved by, like, counselors, and, in other circumstances, both families, but…yeah. Me.”

He smiled at her. “Will it be cool?”

Mermista chuckled, stepping out of his arms so she could start getting ready. “As cool as you are.”

“Awww- wait. Hey. That’s not nice, Mermista. Stop laughing!”

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The quest went off without a hitch. Mermista parted the falls, the water listened to her, and the Best Friend Squad returned in one piece. Glimmer was crowned under the whole of the moon, full and brimming above them, before the night-long party started.

Her first stop was the espresso bar, where she downed two shots of the heady drink in rapid succession. She wrinkled her nose; Bright Moon always made the stuff too weak.

She brought one over to Sea Hawk, who was talking animatedly with Adora. Mermista hovered for a moment, appreciating the two most attractive people she knew chatting together. Sue her, she would always find Adora hot. So did most of Ethera. But…if she were being cheesy and honest, her eyes drifted to Sea Hawk over and over, as if pulled by a magnet. He noticed her after a moment, and said something to Adora before trotting toward her.

"Here." Ehe pushed the coffee into his hands. "You probably don't need this, but I figure it's better than whatever adrenaline rush you're on."

"I think it's anxiety, but thanks." He downed the scalding liquid in one gulp. "How are you doing?"

She was still adjusting to the whole checking in with one another thing, but she wasn't immediately clamming up anymore, or offering a knee-jerk 'fine thanks'. She took his cup from him, making her way toward the cutlery drop-off with Sea Hawk in tow. She spoke as they walked. "Good, I think. It's weird, since this is so…different from my own coronation. No one's happy, but no one is sad. No one seems nervous that Glimmer is taking the throne, so that's wild."

"Nervous?" Sea Hawk frowned. "Why would they be nervous?"

Mermista glanced around, and decided there were too many people, too many ears. She was pretty sure she'd seen Peekablue hovering. She tugged Sea Hawk into an alcove mostly hidden by heavy drapes. "It's…risky. When a young ruler takes the throne, especially in the wake of such a devastating loss. The stress of the crown is enough to break someone in the best of conditions. In Etheria, it's very uncommon to take the throne after a parent dies, because they're meant to hand it off to you with enough time left to teach you what you need to know. That's what our parents had."

"And not what any of you had." Sea Hawk nodded in understanding, brushing a stray lock of hair behind her ear. She shook her head.

"No." She swallowed a lump. "None of us. And now, Glimmer is the leader of the Rebellion and her kingdom. It's a lot."

"Couldn't some of you offer to share the leadership while she adjusts?"

Mermista checked the shadows around their hiding spot, making sure no one was listening. "Perfuma and I…discussed it. And, to be honest..." She fixed him with a hard stare. "And, Sebastian, what I'm about to say never leaves here-"

He leaned in to peck her temple, and murmur in her ear. "I know, dearest. You can trust me to keep your secrets."

Well if that wasn’t a head rush. “We feel that if we were to offer...” she murmured back in his ear. “It would be taken as an offense. Glimmer is…proud. She still feels that she has something to prove, and that can be dangerous.”

“As we both know.”

“Yeah.” She snorted mirthlessly, carding gentle fingers through his styled hair. “We don’t want to cause any fractures right now. The Alliance is…I can’t explain it, but something’s off. Perfuma feels it, too.”

Sea Hawk nodded against her. “Bow has seemed on edge all day. More than usual.”

Mermista could only sigh, the stresses of their situation circling her like sharks. The Rebellion was in trouble, rudderless at the moment, and it would only be a matter of time until the Horde rallied for a devastating blow. She just wished she could see where it would land. Salineas was an obvious target, and she’d ordered their navy to double patrols. She almost wanted to put them on yellow alert, so they were prepped for red alert if (when) it came. But Plumeria would be a strong victory as well, cutting off food supplies for much of Etheria. And then there was Snows…untouched and tantalizing.

Her head was swimming.

“I wish my mom was here.” She found herself shocked as she whispered aloud the words that she thought more than a hundred times a day. “She would know what to do.”

Sea Hawk held her tighter. “Is it…harder today? Thinking about them?”

“...yeah.” Her eyes watered. “It’s like her ghost is following me around today, with all of this going on. I just keep thinking about her, if she’d be proud, or disappointed. I know she’d be worried. I’m worried.”

“I didn’t really know your mother,” Sea Hawk straightened up, letting her rest her head on his chest. “But the woman in the portal…I can’t imagine her ever being disappointed with you. She didn’t want this for you, none of your parents did. But, I think it’s very obvious that she had the utmost faith in you, even now.”

“How do you mean?” Mermista inhaled his cologne and aftershave, letting it soothe her.

“Calmer of storms, right? She knew you could do this. She might be gone, but her faith in you isn’t.”

It was unfair, how brilliant Sea Hawk was when he wasn’t preoccupied being a menace to society. “That was ridiculously profound, and very sweet of you.” She leaned up to peck his lips. “Thank you, love.”

Maybe she should call him ‘love’ more, if he was going to look at her like this every time. She kissed him again, just because she could, and promptly lost track of whatever it was they were meant to be doing. Seconds wheeled into minutes, and his lips led her mind down rivers and eddys of languid pleasure, his calloused hands brushing her skin like fire. She’d settled on the two piece dress she hadn’t worn to Princess Prom, and the matching suit she’d had made, and was grateful she did. Her bare midriff was driving Sea Hawk mad, she could tell from here, as his thumbs slipped under her top to brush the undersides of her bare breasts. She gasped into his mouth, and he slipped his tongue in, licking deep into her mouth until he was swallowing her groans.

The sound of the curtain whisking away registered in her brain too late, and she pulled back from Sea Hawk to meet teal, then fuschia, then teal eyes. “Prince Peekablue.” Sea Hawk tried to pull away, but she kept her arms around him. Let Peekablue stare. She had nothing to hide anymore.

“Mermista,” he sneered. “Enjoying yourself, I see.”

She smirked, unbothered. “You have no idea. Can I help you?”

The state prince scowled. “The dance is starting. The archer asked me to find you.”

“How unfortunate,” she hummed, before turning to Sea Hawk. “Care to dance?” He nodded dumbly at her. She brushed another kiss to his lips, thrilling at the noise Peekablue made. She took Sea Hawk’s hand and brushed past Peekablue, prepared for how the far-sightseer grabbed her upper arm.

“I know what you wear around your neck,” he hissed into her ear. Sea Hawk clearly heard, from how he stiffened. “You can’t hide it forever.”

“I don’t intend to.” She whirled on him, yanking her bicep from the nymph’s hand. “You have no power over me, over my future. Not anymore.”

“We’ll see about that-”

“No, we won’t,” Mermista got into his face, ignoring Sea Hawk’s attempt to hold her back. She bared her teeth at him, sharp and feral, eyes boring into his like a predator. “He told me everything, you little whelp. Everything you said to him. I promise you, once this war is over, I’m coming for you next. You sit on that throne because I *let* you, Peekablue. Remember that. You were a deserter, same as my father. Only he had enough self-preservation to not come back. Clearly, your survival instincts aren’t what they should be.” She leaned back. “Watch your back.”

Peekablue was furious, but shaken enough to not respond.

She turned her back on him, pointed, and grabbed Sea Hawk's hand as she led them to the dance floor. They made it just in time to get into the first position, joining the other princesses at the center of the floor. Bow and Glimmer at the center, Perfuma and Adora, Mermista and Sea Hawk, Spinnerella and Netossa around them. United, together. They all shared a smile before the band struck the first note, and they spun off.

Sea Hawk was a masterful dancer, Mermista knew this from the nights they'd spent hiding out at night clubs, dancing reels in taverns, or even swaying alone together in her living quarters (a new, but very loved development). So when he stumbled more than two steps, she fixed him with a look. "There's no way you're drunk yet."

"No, I- ah-" He cleared his throat. "Did you mean that? Would you really remove Peekablue from power? Over…over me?"

"Uh, yeah." She tilted her head, letting him spin her out and then into his chest. "Like, he's a shitty prince anyway, and I've been looking for a reason, but… Sea Hawk, no one gets to talk to you like that. Not anymore."

Maybe she was overdoing it, showing her hand too much, but something about Peekablue had her riled. It could be that she was reflecting on how horribly she had treated him in the past, and compensating. In fact, her tiny inner therapist that sounded like Perfuma assured that that was definitely the case. But it was more than that. He was hers; hers to protect, and love. Peekablue was a threat to him and his well being (both mental and probably physical). She shook off the angry, prickly feeling as best she could, the possession threatening to take her over, and focused on the dance. This would be a bad time to trip.

Sea Hawk looked lost in his own head, cloud-eyed and vaguely worried. She jerked him a bit hard through the next spin and he snapped out of it. “Yes, dearest?”

She rolled her eyes on reflex. “You good?”

“Are you?” He quirked a brow as he replaced his hand on her waist, hips swinging gently in rhythm. There were more people on the dancefloor now, the pressure being alleviated from the monarchs in the center of it all. “I’ve never seen you like this.”

Mermista flushed, and nearly pulled herself out of his grip to get away from the feeling of being perceived in general. But Sea Hawk was a fast learner, and knew the signs of a flighty Mermista. He tightened his grip on her waist, and she groaned. “Ugh, I don’t know. I just don’t like people talking to you like that. I never have, alright? Even when it was, y’know, me.”

Sea Hawk seemed very pleased, and leaned in to brush a kiss to her temple and whisper in her ear. “Well then, for the record, I like this side of you.”

“You…like when I get all, what, possessive?” He nodded against her, and she grinned. “Noted. Now, c’mon, let’s get through this dance and away from that slimy loser. I can feel him staring from here.”

They both glanced cursorily through the crowd, and yes, sure enough, both Peekablue and Sweet Bee were staring at them, disdainful and morbidly curious, respectfully.

“What odd people,” Sea Hawk mused. “Maybe I should challenge him to-”

“Don’t you even dare, Sebastian.”

“Yes, dear.”

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An hour later found them fleeing the scene of the dance, giggling and trying to stay quiet so as to not be noticed by Castaspella. Glimmer led the escape, Adora and Bow just behind her, the blonde taking it as seriously as she had the Fright Zone invasion, hand signals and all. Perfuma trotted alongside Mermista, towing a cackling Frosta behind her, while Netossa and Spinnerella took up the rear, keeping a serene, non-suspicious appearance. Sea Hawk’s hand was clasped in hers, his suit jacket around her bare shoulders. She felt bubbly and light in a way that had nothing to do with the wine she’d been drinking.

They found their usual courtyard balcony, flopping into their seats. This time, she joined Sea Hawk on the couch and let Frosta and Perfuma swing in the basket seat. Shoes were kicked off, more uncomfortable jewelry placed on the table. Each of the princesses tossed their crowns (carefully) onto the center of the low table, where they couldn't be jostled or kicked by propped feet. Mermista reclined into the corner of the couch, sighing in relief. Sea Hawk passed her a glass of wine that she happily accepted before he cuddled up under her arm. Mermista was suddenly very aware of their surroundings, their friends and the potential to be stared at. She forced it away as best she could; she could try this, the whole slight PDA thing, for Sea Hawk. Besides, he was really warm.

Once everyone was settled, Spinnerella rose to her feet and lifted her goblet. "To Angella, our leader, our guide, our queen. May her wisdom and grace inspire us even now, and help us through to the end of this war!"

Everyone raised their glasses together, somber, and drank deeply. They waited for the eldest among them to continue.

"And to Queen Glimmer. Glimmer, we've watched you grow from a hot-headed little girl to a passionate, strong woman. We know you'll lead this Rebellion to victory, and we couldn't be prouder of you." Netossa nodded from beside her wife, eyes wet in the candlelight.

Glimmer sniffled, wiping at her eyes gently. "Today has been...so much. Sad, and exciting, and just...really bittersweet. I don't know what I would have done today without every single one of you." She met each of their eyes in gratitude. "The future is scary, and I won't lie and say that I'm just going to magically know what to do. I'm sure I'm going to mess up, but I know that it'll be okay. Because whatever goes wrong, and whatever goes right, we're all going to do it together." Bow and Adora smiled at her, a private moment passing between the three.

Perfuma was smiling softly. "It can be terrifying, stepping into this role on your own. But that's another thing that all of us have in common." Mermista and Frosta nodded sadly. "We've been...exactly where you are, Glimmer. And we promise it will be okay."

"Seriously," Mermista said. "Don't ever hesitate to reach out; send a letter or hit us up on the datapad. I didn't ask for any help when I took over Salineas. I was...proud, and scared, and I felt like everyone was going to judge me for not knowing what to do. But I know now that that's bullshit, and that life is a lot easier when you just...talk." She ran a subtle hand through Sea Hawk's hair and down his back, and felt him hum in agreement against her.

"And if there's something that can't be solved with words, we can always punch it!" Frosta jumped up, fists encased in ice. She successfully broke the sad atmosphere, sending the group into slightly hysterical giggles. It was nice to laugh, even if it was at something so silly. The conversation turned to happier topics, stories from when the older princesses took the throne and the trials they went through.

"-and so I told the ambassador, 'Oh that's fine, just send him some bush daisies'-" Perfuma was in the middle of one such story.

Netossa barked a laugh. “You didn’t!”

“I did!”

“Dude, isn’t the Ambassador to Thaymore allergic to, like, everything?” Mermista smirked.

“I didn’t know at the time!” Perfuma whined. “Angella actually had to sort it out for me, I was so embarrassed I think I was about to pass out right there in the middle of the gala.”

They all laughed at their usually oh-so-zen friend’s expense.

Adora wiped a tear from her eye. “My first day in the war room, I sat in King Micah’s chair. And the week before that, I was super rude in the throne room where I first met the Queen. And then after that, I got into a fight at the camps…”

“Stars, Adora,” Mermista snorted. “You’re a fucking mess.”

“Well, we all remember Princess Prom, don’t we?” Adora flushed as the whole balcony started cracking up at Netossa’s reminder.

“‘She’s like, *ten* ’,” Mermista mimicked Adora’s yell from the night that brought the Rebellion together. Adora chucked a throw pillow at her, which she let hit Sea Hawk in the face. “Dude, I hope She-Ra has better aim than you do and we haven’t just been getting lucky.”

Glimmer snorted into her wine glass, spraying red all over Bow.

“Meeaaaan!” Adora pouted, sticking her tongue out at Mermista. One glass in and the warrior woman was definitely starting to feel it. “I can aim!”

“Yeah, Mermista,” Perfuma giggled. “She’s just drunk.”

“I’m not drunk!”

“Adora, honey,” Spinnerella soothed. “You’re halfway to shitfaced.”

Frosta gasped. “Oh! Oh! Bad word! Give me money!”

“Oh, fuck,” Netossa laughed, then clapped a hand over her mouth. “Uuughhhh, dam- *darn* it.”

Mermista chuckled as she watched the matriarchs of the alliance fork over some gold pieces to the youngest. She knew Frosta swore all the time, but she respected the hustle. Sea Hawk shifted against her, adjusting to lay his head in her lap. When he settled, which was always an event for him, she let her hand drop back to his head. She looked up to see several pairs of eyes staring at her, running the full gauntlet from smug to enamored.

“Can I...help you?” She sipped her wine, affecting a casual air. She had nothing to hide, nothing to be ashamed of. This was normal, and fine. She was fine.

Bow and Perfuma’s matching faces, with wobbly, adoring smiles, were particularly grating. “You’re just cute!” The archer grinned at her.

Mermista was not dumb enough to miss the tinge of shit-eating menace that colored his smile. She reached out to the water in his glass, and flicked two fingers sharply upward.

Bow shrieked as he was doused hair-to-chest with cold water, wiping at his eyes futilely. Glimmer and Adora found this uproariously hilarious, and ruffled Bow’s hair to add salt to a wound.

Sea Hawk snorted, shaking his head at her as he made to get up. She stopped him with a hand to his forehead. He stared up at her in confusion, and she shrugged. “I didn’t say get up.”

His smile was worth the microdose in public humiliation. Adora, bless her, turned to her and abruptly changed the subject with a charm that only drunk girls (and Sea Hawk on any given day) possessed. “Hey, Mista, what are the thingys on your arms? The gold. The bands. Big bands. Not now but usually.”

“Uhhhh…” She was really struggling not to laugh right now. “My vambraces?”

“Vambraces!” Adora slapped her knees and pointed. “That’s the bitches! I want it.”

Mermista blinked. “I can have some...made? For you? I guess?”

“No, no.” She shook her head almost violently, and Mermista glanced around for help. Glimmer just shrugged, amused. “I’m gonna make my own. Here! Watch!” She staggered to her feet, whipping out the Sword of Power at a vicious speed. Bow ducked and yelled.

“Sword safety!!! How many times-!”

“For the Honor of Grayskull!” In a flash, She-Ra stood before them, looking confused. “Wait, no. I didn’t want...no. Hang on!” She-Ra vanished, replaced by Adora. “Sword! Do the thing!”

To everyone’s alarm, and Sea Hawk’s incredulous, wide-awake amusement, she slapped her forearm *hard* with the flat of the sword. Nothing happened, save for a mighty *CRACK* that probably would have broken an ordinary person’s spine.

Adora, however, just whined. “Owwwww- *uh* , No! Sword! Work with me here!”

Mermista couldn’t hold it in anymore, her confusion winning out over her prerogative of being calm, cool, and aloof always. “Girl! What in the *fuck* are you doing?!”

“Vambracing!”

Perfuma’s eye twitched. “What.”

Netossa was convulsing violently into Spinnerella’s shoulder, snorting occasionally. “Oh my god this is it- she’s finally lost it.”

“Honestly, took longer than I thought.” Frosta frowned.

Sea Hawk, for his part, was too busy laughing into Mermista’s lap to have an opinion. She forced herself to tune it out- his real laugh was absurdly contagious and she needed to preserve some dignity tonight.

At last, Adora managed to flip the blade around and touch the gold pommel and runestone to her skin. There was a flash of brilliant light, and then the sword was gone. In its place, an asymmetrical gold vambrace wrapped Adora's left wrist. She beamed at them all, flushed from wine and exertion. "See! Vambracing!"

Netossa had flopped onto her back in an attempt to breathe, but clapped feebly for the girl. She missed her hands a few times, but the message was clear. Bow, with a face that fondly said 'why are you like this', tried to tug Adora into her seat, but the wall of muscle that was their savior would not be moved.

"Sea Hawk!"

"Adora!"

"Arm wrestle!"

"Oh, hell yes!" Sea Hawk vaulted himself out of her lap and onto the floor in one smooth tumble of long limbs. Adora threw herself onto the ground with more force, and far less grace. Their elbows hit the table with enough force that she feared for its integrity. She, and everyone else gathered, groaned.

"No-"

“Again?”

“Adora, you’re plastered.”

“Let’s go!” Frosta crowed, scooting over to the table to get up close on the action. “Send each other to the infirmary.”

Adora looked at Mermista, as if for permission. She shook her head incredulously. “Please don’t kill him. It would be wildly inconvenient for me.” A disgusting ‘aawwwwwww’ ricocheted the balcony from each mouth, Sea Hawk’s loudest of all, and she grimaced. “Yeah, okay, never mind, break his arm.”

“Mista!”

Netossa, mostly recovered, knelt down to slap her hand on the table. “You know the rules! Elbows on the table, other hand in sight at all times! Don’t kill, maim, or permanently disable. Three, two, one, GO!”

Adora and Sea Hawk had a combined brain power of, like, 2.5 at best, but their musculature made up the difference and it showed. Neither was a new hat at this, both pulling toward instead of pushing against, grunting deep in their throats and staring into their opponent’s eyes in an attempt to psych them out. Mermista was feigning boredom, almost annoyance, but in her head she was absolutely losing it. Adora’s biceps were on full display in her sleeveless red dress, and, like, not to be a creep to one of her best friends, but *boy* was Mermista looking (respectfully). And Sea Hawk, well-

She wasn’t just in love with his emotional intellect, that’s for sure.

His broad shoulders strained against the tight dress shirt, his biceps fighting the same battle, both stronger than they’d been a year ago. Between the work for Bright Moon’s navy, and his own year in emotional exile doing god knows what (setting a loooot of shit on fire, they still had to talk about that), and his flighty appetite on the best of days, the man was politely shredded. His jaw, clenched in concentration and effort, cut a mouth-watering line, and she noticed with a flush that the concealer she’d smeared on his neck to hide the hickies was coming off now that the hour was late.

She needed to wrap this up fast.

To everyone’s shock, his own included, Sea Hawk did indeed win the first round. He whooped, Bow jostling his shoulders in manly camaraderie, turning to her as if to ask ‘did you see that?!’. She rolled her eyes, but let herself smile a little, softening her face enough that he knew she wasn’t annoyed in any way.

Adora shook off the loss, slamming her elbow back on the table. “Best three out of two.”

“Adora, no-“

"Bring it on!" Sea Hawk grinned. He promptly lost the next two, but the last match going to Adora maaaay have had something to do with Mermista's bare foot on Sea Hawk's thigh, rubbing gentle, teasing circles. He accepted defeat fairly graciously, and shortly after the party began breaking up. Everyone stopped to thank Glimmer and hug her tightly, even Mermista, who's touch-tolerance was firmly exceeded for the day.

"Seriously," she murmured in the shorter girl's ear. "Anything you need, just call. It doesn't have to be big, or even, like, serious. Kay?"

"Kay." Glimmer nodded, smiling sadly. "Thanks Mermista. And Sea Hawk...my mother never got to tell you before she...before the portal, but- she was so grateful for what you did for the Rebellion. The intel you brought us was invaluable, and saved us a lot of time, and a lot of people. Thank you."

"It was an honor to serve your noble kingdom in this way, Your Majesty." Sea Hawk bowed deeply. Coming from anyone else, it would have seemed cheesy. "I am truly and deeply sorry for your loss. May brighter days be ahead."

Glimmer bowed her head to both of them, bidding them good night.

Mermista slipped her hand into Sea Hawk's as they walked and leaned her head on his shoulder. She was tired of speaking, after a day of diplomacy and chatting and laughing. Her head was buzzing and ringing, and she craved silence more than a man in the desert craved water. Sea Hawk, thankfully, seemed to understand this without her telling him.

She thought that over as they reached the room and began undressing in contemplative silence. Since she had started opening herself up to him, letting him past the walls she'd carefully built (slowly, one at a time, but still past them), he'd become a certified Mermista Whisperer. He knew when to bring her tea while she worked, when she needed a break, when silence was necessary and when she needed him to speak and drown out her anxiety. He did things without her having to tell him, could make himself scarce or make himself available. It was like he'd just been waiting for this, like this was where he was meant to be all along; at her side, shoulder to shoulder and walking together. She just wanted to be that person for him now, too.

Baby steps.

They crawled into bed, and he immediately snuggled into her, resting his head on her chest and humming happily. She smiled openly, now that no one, not even Sea Hawk, could see. "Sebastian?"

"Yes, love?" he murmured.

She wondered if he could hear her heart thump a little harder when he said that. Maybe that's why he did it. "How are you feeling? After today?” Checking in was something they’d agreed to start doing nightly. It was rare when she prompted it.

“Good,” he said. “Bow putting me to task all morning really helped. It’s easier when I have a physical outlet for the...” He fumbled for words, instead making a vague spinning motion with his hand around his head. Mermista understood, the gesture pantomiming a whirlpool, what his mother had always called his anxiety. “You know. By the time the ceremony started, I was too worn out to be stressed.” He yawned against her, jaw bones cracking audibly.

She sighed, carding her fingers through his thick, soft hair. “I’m glad. And I didn’t make you feel...bad? Today?”

“You made me feel wonderful.” He stretched to smile at her, all soft eyes and dimples. “And you? Your day went well?”

“Yeah.” She caught his yawn, pressing a hand to her mouth. “I mean, there was that whole flower arrangement thing Perfuma and I got into, which was, like, suuuuper childish, but other than that it was just fighting a waterfall and standing around.”

Sea Hawk was chuckling into her breast. “I caught the tail end of that whole situation. I mean absolutely no offense, my darling, but…”

“If you say my sculpture was ugly I’m sending you to Bow’s room.”

He kept his mouth shut, but his body shook with silent laughter, and eventually she couldn’t contain her own. A very impolite and loud snort broke through her defenses, and after that all bets were off.

Sea Hawk rolled away from her, laughing uncontrollably even as she swatted him with pillows. “No, really, Mermista, it was beautiful-“

“Shut uuuup!” she cackled, and boy was it a harsh sound, but this was Sea Hawk, and she knew he found even her ugliest laugh. “You’re such an- *sngk!-* asshole!”

“Your asshole,” he sang at her. “To have and to hold, for rich or for poor, in sickness and health-“

Mermista slapped him with a pillow to drown out his words, and to give herself a chance to catch her breath. His head popped up a second later, eyes bright and smile infectious. He tugged her closer by the waist, capturing her lips with his once she was in reach. They kissed slowly, lazily, without a care in the world and all the time to spend together. Here, in his arms, the night felt endless and euphoric.

He stared deeply into her eyes when they parted, and Mermista felt her breath hitch. “I can’t wait to call you my wife.”

She blushed scarlet, brain short circuiting at the word *wife* . Sebastian’s wife. Sea Hawk’s wife. Something deep within her was moved at the thought, the hopeless romantic she kept buried under lock, key, rubble, apathy, stress, and murder mystery novels, leaping like a dolphin. At a loss for words, but needing to share the feeling taking firm root in her chest, she pulled his lips back to hers, cupping his cheeks tenderly. “Husband,” she murmured into his mouth, sharing his breath and feeling it catch. “My husband.”

“Just one condition.” He tugged at her bottom lip with his teeth, gentle and teasing.

She sighed. “Anything.”

He pulled back just enough for her to see his smirk. “We hire someone else to do the flower arrangements?”

The whole castle must have heard the pillow slamming into Sea Hawk’s chest, his yelp as he hit the floor laughing, and the following groan of ‘ *You’re always ruining iiiiiiit!’*

Neither could truly bring themselves to care.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading!! As always, comments kudos and bookmarks are wildly appreciated and I work on replying to each one. Also feel free to check out my CM AU, chapter 2 coming this week!

i’m in paradise whenever i’m with you

Chapter Summary

> The Alliance takes a breath in the wake of their loss, and gather themselves for the next step. Meanwhile, Sea Hawk experiences some growing pains.

Chapter Notes

> Just some sweet meanderings while we wait for the other shoe to drop. I just wanted them to be in love and happy for a little bit

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Their return to Salineas was uneventful, and soon they were swept back into the chaos of daily life as a royal (and royal-to-be). Endless meetings, endless paperwork, endless elbow rubbing and brown nosing. Mermista’s days started at exactly sunup, and therefore so did Sea Hawk’s; they were lucky if they fell into bed by ten. The young queen was privately impressed with her fiancée, since she’d essentially tossed him into the deep end of her court with one hand tied and he was already capable of doing a backstroke. Her court, for their part, were much slower to accept the former-pirate as their future king. And, really, Mermista could hardly blame them.

But Sea Hawk was a grown man, who now had several important jobs she needed done, like, yesterday, and so he was kiiiiinda on his own. He still crashed into her office about three times a day for advice, an ear to complain to, or, on bad days, a hiding spot. Mermista allowed all of these things graciously because apparently she loved him or whatever.

It was getting easier to remember that, now that he had quietly taken up living with her. They'd never spoken about it, but since the portal he had yet to leave her side for more than a day. They also did not speak about how she had yet to complain about this. Mermista was no stranger to anxiety in its many forms, but separation anxiety was new, and a total bitch. But she digressed. Yes, it was much easier to remember she loved Sea Hawk when he woke her up with soft kisses on her bare shoulder, had breakfast waiting for her when she swanned out of the shower, brought her tea and coffee and water throughout the day; he may have had more jobs, but no one in Salineas was as busy as their Queen, who had begun truly wading into building up her nation. What her father had left her had been functional, but she wanted it to be great. Mermista wanted Salineas to shine like its pearl, and wanted all of Etheria to see it.

Now, she just had to read about a thousand years of trade agreements, infrastructure policies, and international maritime law so she could start untangling years of stagnation. Fun, y'know?

Most days were good now. She had a routine, a kingdom she adored (inwardly and stoically, as was her bent), and a partner at her side that was typically the ballast to her sails. Typically.

Today was not such a day.

"-And *then* , he asked me, oh Lieutenant, I don't mean to interrupt but that's just not how it's done in these waters. *Not how it's done?! Lieutenant?!?* I mean really, who does he think he is-"

“My international trade advisor?”

“... *still!* ”

Mermista tossed her pen onto the desk and brought her fingers up to massage her temples while her “better half” (ha) tore off on another tangent about respect, or nuance in law, or something. If she was being honest, she’d tuned him out about five soliloquies ago. Sea Hawk had swanned in here in full-tilt Diva Mode, and was now, somehow, being even more dramatic. It was like it increased exponentially. Renewable, continual energy. Maybe he could power the Sea Gate in an emergency.

And, yeah, while Mermista had gotten much better at weathering Sea Hawk’s more obnoxious moments, she was still human (kind of) and, more importantly, still her.

“Dude! Please, for the stars’ grace, can you stop talking for like two minutes!” she snapped, eyes squeezed shut against a growing headache.

Sea Hawk did fall silent, but it wasn’t his normal ‘oh shit my bad Mermista I didn’t mean to piss you off, love of my life and light in my eyes’ silence. It was more...contemptuous. “Oh, I’m so sorry.” She could hear his eyes roll, which was ironic since that was her move. “I didn’t mean to interrupt you writing your signature for the four hundredth time today.”

Bitch. “Apology accepted,” she snarked back, finally opening her eyes. Why the hell was it so bright in her office all the time? Didn’t the day moon, like, orbit? “Are you done or would you like to keep screaming at a level that seagulls envy?”

Sea Hawk scoffed, and glowered at her. “Is my rough adjustment period to the obnoxious bureaucrats that yell at me all day for coughing wrong annoying you?”

“Uh, yeah.” She picked up her pen again. “It is. So go blow off some steam or suck it up, buttercup.”

She didn’t see him turn away, but she did look up in time to see him yank his long leather sailing coat off the peg by the door and whisk out of the room, slamming the door shut behind him. Mermista groaned openly, understanding that, yeah, she had definitely not handled that properly. But contrary to Sea Hawk’s belief, this was not just scribbling her long-ass name and title on documents in triplicate and tossing them out; she had to read every single page of this new proposal for an agency, or committee, on...something to do with the docks, she didn’t know, Sea Hawk usually-

Ah. Well, shit.

A rational queen would have said ‘hey, that sounds really horrible, and I’m sorry. Why don’t we switch for today since I’m having a hard time understanding this, too?’ And then kissed her stupid, cute fiancée on his stupid, cute, mustached mouth, and then been happy.

But nooooooo, not her. She much preferred shooting herself in the foot for sport.

Mermista tossed her pen to the desk again, defeated and now annoyed and kind of sad (ugh, lame). She wandered over to the window, tracking Sea Hawk with her eyes as he left the castle and made his way around to the private dock she let him use. Everything about his body language screamed Huffy and Emo. Thinking quickly, Mermista grabbed some paper, scribbled a recipe she knew by heart onto it, and made her way out of the room to gesture to one of her ladies-in-waiting. “Hey, can you, like, ask the chef to make this for dinner if he hasn’t started already? If he has, it’s seriously no big deal, don’t let him stop what he’s doing to make this. But if he can’t tonight, just come back and let me know, Kay?”

The young girl scurried off, and Mermista made her way to her (their?) private wing of the castle. Her brain was off of work for the evening, but she could focus on other things.

When Sea Hawk returned for dinner, which she knew he would, he was noticeably calmer when he walked out onto the balcony she’d had Maevik lead him to. In fact, as she came around the corner in a plain navy and gold kurta and worn leggings, she would almost say he was...sad? Her feet were soundless as she came up beside him, and he startled comically when she touched his elbow.

“Mermista!”

“You good? You’re all jumpy- whoa!”

Sea Hawk lifted her off her feet into a hug, which she could barely return before he was placing her down and staring into her eyes with watery, puppy-dog sadness of his own. “I’m sorry I annoyed you today!” he practically wailed. “I didn’t mean to, and then I insulted your job because I was feeling petty, and then I just *left* - will you ever forgive me?”

“Sea Hawk!” She couldn’t help but laugh, just a little. “Chill. Seriously, it’s alright. I, um, actually, uh…” Why was it so hard for her to say the things he could seemingly spout non-stop? She grappled with her words for a bit before giving up, and gesturing for him to follow her around the corner of the balcony. His theatrical gasp when he saw dinner laid out was annoyingly, infuriatingly cute. Slightly.

“Dearest…” Oh stars, was he actually gonna cry? “You did this for...me?”

“Ugh, yes! Don’t make a thing out of it, alright? I just wanted to, like, apologize, or whatever. I was rude, earlier, and dismissive, and that wasn’t cool of me. Of course you’re gonna get wound up and complain, you’ve never done this before. And it was way too ‘dad’ of me to invalidate you, and I’m sorry, okay?” Mermista scuffed her bare feet on the brushed stone, staring at the chipped polish (she needed a pedi, maybe tomorrow?) and definitely not his eyes. At least, not until he lifted her chin with a gentle finger and pressed a soft kiss to her lips.

“You’re nothing like your father, my love.” His voice, deep and genuine, devoid of his melodrama from a second ago, sent tiny trails of lightning down her back. “Don’t even think on it for a moment.”

“Kay.” She brushed another kiss to his lips. “Still sorry.”

“So am I.”

“Cool. Can we stop apologizing and eat now?”

He flashed a grin at her, bounding for the table like a switch had been flipped. He was already humming under his breath, the promise of a shanty carried in the back of his throat. She hid her smile between bites of salmon meunière, but she knew he saw it anyway.

—- - — — - - -

Some days were dangerous, in a fun and exhilarating way.

“Horde ship spotted beyond the reef! Horde ship at the reef!”

The call rang through the castle, jolting Sea Hawk out of the mind-numbing haze that was reading this dock space allotment review. Why did they even need paperwork for this? First come first serve, people! Keep politics out of parking spaces. Bam, new slogan. Maybe he'd make a banner…

"HORDE SHIP!"

Right! *Adventure!*

Sea Hawk cleared his desk in one leap, grabbing his sword and lashing it to his belt as he tore out of his office. It was by the throne room that he nearly collided with Mermista, who was running from a very harried-looking courtier. She nodded to him, as if they were doing laps in the training yard and not sprinting headlong into a skirmish. "Hey."

"M'lady!" He winked at her, delighting in her eye roll. He was getting better at which ones meant 'I hate this' and which ones meant 'I'm not allowed to find this endearing, but keep going'. "Just the one ship? Hardly seems worthy of a Princess."

"I'm bored, alright? I need to knock some skulls together before my brain turns to mush."

"Of course! After all, I would hate to 'stifle your creativity'."

“Ugh! Will you let the stupid flower arrangement thing go!”

“Never, dearest.”

They tore down the steps to the private docks, and Sea Hawk had his cruiser out on the open sea in two minutes flat. Mermista helped him untether from the docks, but after that she was racing along the pier, diving headlong into the ocean. He caught up with her about a third of a mile off the shore, halfway to the Horde tank. Her braid flew behind her as she flipped up, shifting from her mermaid form to ride the waves like a surfer instead. She had to yell to be heard above the surf. “Are we making this interesting?”

“Of course!”

“Majority wins?”

“Seems fair.” Sea Hawk stroked his mustache with one hand while the other gripped the wheel. “If I win, I get half the vanity.”

“Fine. If I win you have to let me pluck your eyebrows.”

“No! It hurts!”

“They’re shaggy! You look like an ancient boar!”

Sea Hawk grumbled, but nodded in the end. They were approaching the ship, and it was time to focus in. Mermista slipped soundlessly below the surface of the ocean, only a flash of magic giving away her brief position. She moved too fast with her tail for him to keep track of. He cranked the ship into a drifting glide, lining her up with the cruiser. He had them grappled to his vessel in the blink of an eye, swinging over on a rat line with his sword between his teeth. He landed on his feet (very debonair, very cool, he hoped Mermista saw that) and brandished his blade at the first opponent he saw: the small scrawny kid he’d tossed away from Bow in the Fright Zone. Karp, or Karl, or maybe Kevin? Definitely a K. Probably Karp.

Karp shrieked, fumbling his stun baton and leaving Sea Hawk the perfect opening to disarm him. Poor kid, he really wasn’t cut out for this war stuff. Luckily, well, for him, not for Sea Hawk, he wasn’t alone. Reptilian arms the size of his head grappled him from behind and sent him soaring. He hit the deck hard, but rolled to his feet and turned, blade forward. The reptilian (Ronald? He knew his name, too.) charged him, but never made it within five feet. Ronald was pushed overboard by a jet of water, and Sea Hawk whistled his thanks to his savior. The last soldier on the bridge (Laurie...Lettie...Letta? No…) abandoned the canon, charging him fast and with deadly accuracy. Blade met baton as they fought, almost evenly matched. However, Sea Hawk had sea legs (ha!), and this lass did not.

He whistled a frantic note, hoping Mermista remembered what it meant. Not a second later, the ship was rocking violently, like a sudden hurricane had befallen them. Lettie/Laurie yelped, stumbling, and Sea Hawk pressed his advantage. He disarmed her with a parry, and sliced her across the outer thigh with enough force and heat to knock her down. Water rushed around them, pushing her overboard and bringing Mermista up to the deck. His Princess wasn't even winded.

"That was, like, way too easy."

"It was, wasn't it?"

"Bravo, bravo!" They spun in tandem to see...Scorpia? Definitely Scorpia. She strolled toward them leisurely, at a sauntering pace that Sea Hawk didn't know a woman of her powerful stature was capable of. It didn't look quite right. "Just testing out a new patrol pattern, thought I'd swing by to see your beautiful little island."

Sea Hawk frowned. Scorpia had been here before, so why-? His thoughts were cut off, violently, as his opponent swung around faster than a blink, her long tail smashing into him and sending him flying. His back hit the wall of the ship with a *clang!* and a rather concerning crunch. He had no time to catch his breath, as it was immediately knocked from his lungs by Mermista crashing into his front.

"Ow, fuck," Mermista groaned, clutching her hip. "Your sword just bruised my ass so bad-"

"Duck!"

It came out as a gasp, but she heard him anyway, hitting the deck quickly as a metal crate flew over them and into the sea. They both scrambled to their feet, Sea Hawk taking a sliver of a second to check over Mermista, and feeling a little giddy when he saw her return the favor. Focus, old boy! Battle!

Scorpia looked like she was opening her mouth to taunt them more, but they'd had enough. He glanced at Mermista, catching her eye, then the ocean, and then his sword. She nodded. Full frontal melee it was! Adventure!

Sea Hawk rushed the arachnid woman before she could finish her sentence, taking her off guard with a harsh, wide swing. It missed her chest but clipped her shoulder pauldron-armor-exoskeleton-thing; she flinched, hissing in pain, but had no time to assess the damage. A long, thin tendril of water whipped her around the ankles, pulling tight and sending her falling to the deck, while another reached out and wrapped her wrists. Mermista tried to haul her overboard, but the larger woman broke free after a moment of struggle, staggering to her feet and lunging for Sea Hawk. He had no time to dodge, and braced for spine-bruising impact, but it never came-

He cracked an eye open to see Scorpia suspended in front of him, encased in a bubble of water. She thrashed and swung her tail and attempted to pince her (ha! Pince her, pincer- right, focusing) a way out, but to no avail. Mermista, breathing only somewhat heavily, moved her arms and *threw* , sending the bubble flying wide and far. Scorpia hit the water some many, many meters out, while Mermista shook out her shoulders and turned to him. "Alright?"

Sea Hawk nodded. “Bruised, but none the worse for wear. Shall we sink it?”

“Hmmmmm, I was thinking something a little more...explosive.”

If it hadn’t been a scummy Horde ship, Sea Hawk would have made love to her right there on the deck. And her smirk said Mermista knew it, too. He settled for a deep, passionate kiss, the kind that they stuck at the end of fairy tales, and pressed his nicest lighter into her hand.

“Untether your boat, goober, before I burn that, too.”

“Is that a threat or a promise?” He growled in her ear, nipping at her lobe. She chuckled, low and breathy and oh, how it shot right to his core.

“Sea Hawk, seriously, get your boat off and grab the prisoners.”

“Fine,” he sighed. “But we’re continuing this later.”

“More than alright by me.” She swatted his ass as he walked back to his ship and cast off from the Horde vessel. When he swung around to grab their prisoners, though, they were nowhere to be found. He checked the sonar panel, but there were no bodies under the water so they couldn’t have drowned. What the devil was this?

He was momentarily distracted by the tanker going up in flames in front of him, and the rush of adrenaline it sent flying through his body, but not distracted enough to not tell Mermista as soon as she touched down on his deck.

“The fuck?” She glowered. “How could they just...vanish?”

“I wish I could tell you, dearest, but I’ve never seen anything like it.”

They called it a victory anyway, Mermista resolving to bring it up at the next Alliance meeting, and made their way back to shore with their heads held high, albeit confused.

— - — - —

Schlepping over to Bright Moon was never exactly enjoyable, but seeing their friends and allies was always worth the stressful journey. At least, that’s what Mermista reminded herself as she dusted soot and ash off of Sea Hawk’s jacket.

“I told you to move left or we were going to hit the black smoker eel, and what did you do? Go right.”

Sea Hawk was in as fine a mood as ever, his tarnished long coat not bothering him in the slightest, not even when he slid it off his shoulders and an arm fell away as the stitching disintegrated. Mermista groaned.

“Easy, dearest, it was old anyway. I’ll pick up a new one at the markets tomorrow before we cast off.”

“Can’t we cast off tonight?” she whined. “It’s always fucking frigid in Bright Moon and we just got the new comforter in from Snows.”

“You know how I feel about sailing the Serpent’s Tail in the dark…”

“Fine.” She rolled her eyes. “Can we at least sleep on the ship, though?”

Sea Hawk cast her a bemused glance as he finished with the mooring lines, jumping from the ship first before turning to give her a hand. She didn’t need it, really, but she knew he liked to feel helpful. “What’s with your sudden, visceral aversion to sleeping in Bright Moon?”

“Okay, one, the beds are made of, like, pudding or jellyfish goo or something, and my spine is still all kinked from the coronation. Two…” She tucked her hair behind her ear and looked...elsewhere. “The walls are, like, thin, okay? Or entirely non-existent. And

Glimmer has her guards crawling everywhere now that Shadow Bitch is around, and I feel like we're always under watch."

"Well!" He slung an arm around her waist as they walked the path to the castle. "Two excellent points that I would be a fool to argue against. Ship it is!"

Mermista rewarded his adaptability with a kiss to the cheek, the soft and sweet kind that still made him blush. He was cute when he blushed, she thought to herself (before catching the thought and shoving it back in its little box labeled 'later').

They were the last to arrive in the war room, which was to be expected as they had the most arduous commute. Pleasantries, hugs, back-claps were exchanged before Mermista settled into her throne-away-from-home, Sea Hawk standing to her side like always. She cast him a glance. "Do you, like, want a chair?"

He shook his head. "No thank you, dearest, I'm feeling too jumpy." Sea Hawk had the empathic habit of feeding off of other's energy, and with so many people in a room, he was probably trying not to bounce off the walls or start singing or whatever. She nodded and let him be. Glimmer cleared her throat, and began with reading the minutes and notes from their last meeting, and the relevant correspondences from around Etheria.

"-Perfuma has reported no new pulse bots, so we feel good in saying that the issue has been handled. Special thanks to Bow, Adora, Spinnerella, and Netossa for meeting this challenge head on."

The four nodded, Bow a bit stiffly from where he sat, ribs bound tightly. The summons to the meeting had filled the others in on Bright Moon’s recent bot struggles. Glimmer moved on to her correspondence and Mermista grimaced at the memory of the missing Horde Soldiers.

“Wait.” Adora frowned. “They were just...gone?”

“Yup,” Mermista drawled. “They couldn’t have been in the water for more than a minute, but by the time we sent Scorpia over, they were literally nowhere to be found. Sea Hawk swept the area with his sonar, and we did a visual sweep before we went back in. Nothing.”

“It was strange!” Sea Hawk was stroking his mustache. “I’ve only met Scorpia once before, granted, but she seemed...different on the ship. She moved oddly.”

“The portal has left the Horde scrambling, and off their game.” Glimmer dismissed him. “I’m sure that the Force Captain’s all have Catra’s and Hordak’s whips at their backs. And you're sure the ship didn’t look any different?”

They both shook their heads. “Standard Horde tanker- ugly, bulky, and green grey like sewage.” Mermista felt bile claw up her throat at the thought of Horde sewage, and Sea hawk patted her shoulder plate in comfort. Glimmer sighed, as if disappointed, but she nodded and they moved on through the memos. Once they were done, she stood from her chair and activated the Holo-table.

“The main reason I’ve asked you all here today, is because it’s time to stop playing defense.” The Princesses looked at one another with varying degrees of agreement and shifted forward in their seats. “I think it’s time we talk about reclaiming Dryl.”

A gasp and murmur rippled around the table. Reclaim Dryl? Look, Mermista was no wallflower- she loved throwing down and scrapping with the best of them, and yeah, she’d definitely been spoiling for a good brawl lately. But this had the potential to go really, really bad. Perfuma’s eyes reflected that same concern.

Frosta did not have the same reservations. “Cool! So everyone here is in on the plan?”

“Almost everyone.” Glimmer gestured to the door guard. “Let Flutterina in.”

Fucking whomst? Mermista shared confused looks with Perfuma, Sea Hawk, and Frosta. The doors opened, and a young Elberonian girl of about 13, maybe 14 if she was pressed, flounced in like a- well, like a princess. Wide doe eyes scanned the room lingering on...Sea Hawk? Weird. Flutterina pranced into the open seat at Mermista’s left, between her and Perfuma. “Uh, Glimmer, who’s the kid?”

Frosta was staring at them all warily, somewhere between nervous and excited. Mermista could relate; social anxiety as a preteen royal was a plague. Glimmer swept in, graceful as ever, for introduction and to smooth ruffling feathers. “Flutterina is an emissary from Elberon, and, for now, an honorary princess. Her help has saved us on multiple occasions, and her intel has proven to be reliable.”

“Cool.” Mermista picked at a nail. “So why is she sitting in on a war meeting for a territory thirty miles from Elberon?”

Perfuma cleared her throat. “It’s not that we aren’t open to help from all quarters, but Mermista has a point. This is a sensitive discussion, and I don’t know how...prudent it is to open it up to outsiders so soon.”

“I’m with Glimmer on this one!” Frosta shrugged. Mermista rolled her eyes, not surprised even slightly. “We need all the help we can get.”

“Help with what, though?” Adora frowned. “We don’t even have a plan yet.”

Glimmer rapped her staff on the ground. “If you’d all stop talking, we could start making one. Flutterina stays. She’s an ally, and she’s here to help.”

Mermista narrowed her eyes, bristling at the dismissal, but a hand on her shoulder stopped her from opening her mouth. She met Sea Hawk's eyes and caught the subtle shake of his head. For a moment, she debated plowing ahead anyway, but her ire cooled, and she let herself relax back into the chair. In fact, she let herself relax so much she propped her high-tops up on the Holo-table, daring Glimmer to challenge her on it.

The Queen of Bright Moon did cast her a baleful glance, but moved on. "Dryl is producing almost all of the metal, alloys, and technology that the Horde is using to build these robots. We need to take back Dryl, and repossess the resources. Or, at the very least, keep them away from the Horde. I propose a stealth mission, covert and small."

"Soooo we're leaving Sea Hawk, Frosta, and Adora here?" Mermista smirked.

The goons in question frowned at her.

"Excuse you!" Adora sniffed. "I'll have you know I can be very stealthy-"

"Frosta and Sea Hawk are in," Glimmer cut her off. "But, Adora...you're going to need to be the distraction again, you know that."

“Wait, what?” Perfuma frowned. “Leaving She-Ra behind on a mission to reclaim the capitol of an entire territory doesn’t exactly seem...smart.”

Sea Hawk nodded. “Indeed. Adora here is one of our best tactical minds. It’s a waste to use her as mere bait.”

“See! They get it!” Adora crowed.

Glimmer only shook her head. “No, it’s too risky. We have reason to believe the Horde is tracking Adora, or She-Ra, somehow.”

Flutterina cleared her throat, petite. “It was really suspicious how the pulse bots just kept showing up wherever Adora went. And how the Horde always knew when we were going to cut off their supply runs, or weapons drops. The only time we actually succeeded was when Adora was, well, here.”

Adora scowled, sinking into her chair. “Still! What if we found a way to use that to our advantage! What if we could somehow get the Horde to think I was elsewhere, lull them into comfort, and then BAM! She-Ra time!”

Bow looked like he was considering it, but Glimmer just rolled her eyes. “We don’t have time to figure all that out. We have reason to believe that the Horde is gearing up for something...catastrophic. If we waste anymore time, it could cost us everything.” Flutterina shifted nervously next to her, and

Mermista scowled. The war room was no place for squeamish preteens. Frosta was already on thin ice (ugh, Sea Hawk’s puns were contagious…).

“Fine,” Adora muttered. “What do you propose then?”

“I’ve done a lot of planning, with help from Juliette, but this plan isn’t final. I want to hammer out the details with everyone here. So, obviously phase one is getting the Horde to take the Adora bait. We set her up somewhere in the mountains around Dryl, and lure out the bulk of the guards. Then, we move in Teams. Team A- Bow, Frosta, Sea Hawk. You guys will scout ahead while Team B- Mermista and Perfuma- guards the exit and keeps an eye out for the Horde. Once Team A gives the all clear, my team- Juliette, myself, and Flutterina will converge on the signal. Then we rendezvous with Team A and Team B and we all make for the forges, the mines, any material source we can get to.”

“And once we’re there?”

Glimmer grinned, almost manic. “Fuck it up.”

“We’re good at that one.” Sea Hawk bounced a bit on his feet.

Flutterina, however, didn’t look convinced.

“I’m sorry, Queen Glimmer, but I think the teams need...tweaking.” She wrung dainty pink fingers together. “It would make more sense to put me on the scouting team. I’m small, and fast, I’ll be able to help more out in the field.”

“Flutterina...are you sure?” Glimmer looked apprehensive. “This is really no small mission. You could be seriously injured, or even killed.”

“I know what I signed up for.” Flutterina was entirely unbothered by the prospect of death. Brownie point for her.

“While we’re tweaking the teams...” Perfuma cleared her throat. “I think it would be best for me to replace Flutterina on your team, Glimmer. I’m not good in open spaces...and I’ve never been stellar at recon.”

“Wait, hello, you’re just gonna ditch me to guard the doors alone?” Mermista scowled at her friend. “Lame.”

Bow cleared his throat. “Right now, with the shifting, that leaves four people on Team A and only one on Team B. Team A, we need someone to volunteer to guard the doors with Mermista.”

It was like every eye in the room was a magnet and Sea Hawk had pockets full of scrap metal. He actually *blushed* , the goober, and scratched his head. “I-I didn’t want to- heh- presume, I figured I would go where you needed me-“

“Mermista, that work for you?” Glimmer’s look was far, far too smug, and Mermista clenched her jaw.

“Listen, I’m apparently just a pawn right now soooo you move people where you see fit.”

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “Oh please, we all know you have the most tactical experience here besides Adora. Salineas has been fighting the Horde openly for as long as Bright Moon, and you’ve been commander in chief for like, almost four more years than I have. Help a bitch out.” Flutterina looked appropriately scandalized at the foul language, as did Perfuma.

“Ugh! Fine!” Mermista got to her feet, scanning the Holo-table with benign interest. “Flutterina’s right, actually. She and Frosta are your best scouts. And Bow is lithe and light enough on his feet to pull it off, not to mention he’ll be in charge of tech for the mission.”

“I’m not that lithe,” Bow grumbled, flexing his arms to himself. “I’m making gains on gains! I’m strapping!”

“Right.” Mermista smirked at him. “You’re very handsome and ripped. Happy?”

“Yes, continue.”

“Sea Hawk or Perfuma would be fine with me, so yeah, I can take Sea Hawk since Perfuma obviously, totally hates me-“

“I do not!”

“What I don’t understand is why you’re sitting back up.” She glanced at Glimmer. “You make more sense on the scouting team, while Bow stands by and monitors the technology and keeps his eyes on us. You can literally teleport, and cover the most ground and fastest.”

“No!” Bow and Adora chorused. Adora cleared her throat and continued. “She’s the queen now, she can’t just go running off into the middle of every battle.”

“Buuuuut Perfuma and I can?” Mermista threw up a brow.

Bow had the decency to flush. “W-well, it’s just...it’s different?”

She snorted. “It’s not, but whatever. That’s my primary issue with this...oh wait, no, one more thing. How exactly are we reclaiming Dryl if we’re just there to fuck them up?”

Glimmer flushed. “I haven’t gotten there yet.”

"Noted." Mermista sat back in her chair, reclining again and putting her boots through the holograms of Dryl's bordering mountains. Sea Hawk, tired of standing, perched himself lightly on her arm rest. She debated pushing him off, but he wasn't bothering her, and she wasn't mad at *him* . Glimmer had her riled, and she wasn't going to take it out on him anymore.

"The main issue with reclaiming Dryl," Glimmer sighed, "is that we don't know who in the Horde is currently occupying it. Scorpia hasn't been seen out of the Fright Zone in months, not since the northern reach mission, technically. Entrapta isn't there, and Catra hasn't been to Dryl since they took it."

Mermista didn't miss how Adora tensed and flushed at the mention of her ex-bestie. Interesting. She filed that away to ponder later, preferably in bed and gossiping with Sea Hawk (a shared favorite pastime for both of them). Adora opened her mouth to say something, but Mermista's mind was now stuck on the topics of 'bed' and 'Sea Hawk'. Then, it was just 'Sea Hawk'. Although, right now, he was surprising her and being far more 'Sebastian'. Her system wasn't stringent or official, but she'd started referring to the man everyone else saw- pyromaniac pirate, adventure-obsessed, loud, energetic, obtuse- as Sea Hawk, while the man she usually got all to herself- passionate, intelligent, funny, and still loud and energetic but in a way that made her actually want to enjoy life- Sebastian.

Nowadays, the line between them was blurring. People changed, she supposed. He certainly had. She wouldn't mind sharing Sebastian with everyone else, he was a wonderful man. But then again, she would hate to see Sea Hawk leave permanently. Maybe his over-the-top side was a big front for his insecurities, sure, but he also made her life interesting, and fun. Ugh, how sappy.

"Mermista?"

Oh shit, they were talking to her.

"Uh, sorry, what?" She forced herself not to blush; no one could have known what she was thinking about, right? Right. Probably. "I was, like, totally spacing."

Glimmer groaned. "I said, have you gotten any intel recently?"

Her usually kind friend's perpetual annoyance was beginning to grate on Mermista. "Uh, have I intercepted any hot Horde info on my island kingdom in the middle of the ocean? Lemme think real quick- uhhhh nope."

The tension in the room was growing, and Bow and Adora were cutting furtive glances at one another, then her, then Glimmer, then each other.

Mermista exhaled through her nose, trying to center herself. Glimmer was still grieving, she reminded herself. Of course she wasn't going to be sunshine and rainbows and optimism. "I'm sorry, Glimmer. If we do hear anything we'll tell you immediately, but most of the folks coming through the ports now aren't affiliated with the Horde."

"Indeed!" Sea Hawk backed her up. "The pubs, the taverns, the offices- all clear of any morally misaligned marauders. We'd say sorry but… the people are safer, and happier this way."

"What he said."

Glimmer sighed, defeated. "No, no, it is a good thing. Just not particularly advantageous right now. Although…" She paused and glanced up at them, almost nervous. "There was another option."

"Glimmer, no-" Bow sat up straight, wincing and grabbing for his ribs. "We agreed it wasn't worth it."

"We could at least ask him."

"Me?" Sea Hawk sat up straighter. "Ask me what?"

Glimmer, Bow, and Adora shared an uneasy glance, but they seemed more nervous about...Mermista's reaction- oh.

"Hell, no," she practically snarled. "Not in a million years."

“Told you.” Bow shrugged.

Glimmer was never so easily deterred. “It would be invaluable to us, especially now-“

“He almost died last time-“

“Excuse me!” Sea Hawk rarely shouted, and this really wasn’t even a shout, but his booming voice did silence the bickering very effectively. “Ask me what. Mermista? I have the right to know, and give my own answer.”

“Fine,” she snapped, busying herself with her cuticles. “Ask him.”

“Sea Hawk!” Glimmer turned to the captain. “Would you consider going back undercover and gathering Horde intel? Intercepting it and sending it to us?”

“Oh!” He nodded in understanding. “Absolutely not, but thank you for letting me answer myself.”

“May I ask why?”

“You may ask.” He shrugged. “The answer is simply that I’m needed elsewhere right now. I have obligations to fulfill in Salineas, and if I left now, they would all fall to Mermista. And while I do firmly believe she is capable...” He smiled at her, and she rolled her eyes. “It wouldn’t be right.”

Glimmer’s look was unfathomable, and Mermista felt her hackles rising with the need to defend herself and Sebastian.

“The ports still need work, Glim.” She shrugged. “Like, a complete overhaul. And we’re constantly altering trade routes to avoid the Horde and get shipments moving on time. I really do...need him here.” Ugh, even in a professional capacity, it was nauseatingly sweet.

“Plus!” Sea Hawk perked up. “My cover is pretty much blown thanks to Peekablue. So, no dice.”

“Wait, the far-sight Princess?” Adora tilted her head. “What did he do?”

“Assaulted me!” Sea Hawk supplied helpfully. “Both verbally and physically. We had a brawl in a thieves’ den, where he shouldn’t have been, he insulted me viciously, I choked him out, then the portal came and that was that. Not my wildest night at the Grotto…”

As he stroked his mustache, lost in memories of brawls and gambling and stars-knows what else, Mermista laughed internally at the varying looks of impressed horror and concern around the table. It was wildly entertaining when people forgot Sea Hawk was, like, a real pirate. Gods knew she did.

“Alright, let’s take a lunch break!” Glimmer flopped into her chair. “Two hours? One hour? What are we feeling?”

“Two,” was the unanimous answer.

“Right, see you all in a bit.”

Mermista practically dragged Sea Hawk out of the castle, feeling like a volcano ready to burst. Her fiancé wisely kept his mouth shut, letting himself be led back to the ship. Once they were safely on board, and tucked below deck, Mermista exploded.

“UuuUUUUUUGGGGGHHHHHHH! Like seriously what the hell was *that* ?!” She started pacing, fuming.

“I know, dearest.”

“What is happening to Glimmer? I know grief is an insane, warping thing, but she’s turning into a completely different person! Do this, do that, and Adora- oh my god, what was that!”

“That was very strange-“

“And who the fuck is this Flutterina kid? We’re just letting anyone into the Alliance now? Cool! I’ll let the little urchins from the charter school know, they’ll be thrilled.”

“You love Eliza.”

“I do, and that’s not the point!” Mermista’s pacing was starting to make her dizzy at the speed she was going. “The point is that there’s clearly some *bullshit* happening in Bright Moon, and it’s, like, actually going to start impacting our ability to do our jobs soon. Sidelining Adora is a mistake. Holding herself off the battlefield is a mistake. Not looking into this weird ‘Horde knows all, sees all’ thing is a *massive, stupid, fuck-you mistake!* ”

“You have such a way with words.” Sea Hawk hid his grin behind the hand stroking his mustache.

She whirled on him, and she must have looked every inch as angry as she felt, because Sea Hawk immediately held both hands up in surrender. Mermista slumped onto the v-berth, and after she flopped onto her back, he joined her.

“This is all very odd. There’s a tension in the war room that wasn’t there before, but we are still only a month out from losing our leader. Perhaps these are just...growing pains.”

“Ugh, I’m sure you’re right.” Mermista pressed her hands to her eyes, feeling a headache start to build. “But this is really stressing me out. I don’t like this. And I don’t like how she looked at us after we said no. That wasn’t cool.”

“Also true!” Sea Hawk rolled onto his side, lifting a hand to play with her braid where it lay on the bed. “But again, none of them have ever seen you, or, us really, like this. You know, working together. They’re probably not sure if this is a long-term joke, or if you’ve finally gone round the bend.”

“Little do they know it’s both,” she snarked, and was rewarded with a flick to her ear. “Ow, mean.”

“I’m terrible, yes.”

“C’mere.” Mermista held her arms out, and Sea Hawk rolled to settle on top of her. They’d invested in the finest weighted blanket they could find after learning Mermista felt safe when he rested the full weight on his body on hers. She exhaled deeply, letting her lingering annoyance from the meeting leave with all the air in her legs, and inhaled the scent of woodsmoke, white birch shampoo, and spiced incense. Sweat, salt, that weird but pleasant smell he could never get out of the blue jacket, like varnish. The many comforting smells of Sebastian. Against her will, sleep began pulling at her almost immediately; early mornings, no time for coffee, peace and quiet, and of course, sleep being her go-to stress avoidance mechanism, made this an irresistible napping moment.

Sometimes it was like Sea Hawk could read her mind. He adjusted to tug off his jacket and boots, and her armor plating, and drew shut the blackout curtains before rolling slightly and tucking her against her body. “Sleep, dearest. I’ll wake you up when it’s time to go back.”

“What about lunch?” she mumbled into his chest, already almost completely asleep.

He chuckled. “I’ll message Perfuma to bring back extras of whatever she’s getting.”

“Kay,” she sighed, going slack against him. “Love you.”

If he answered, she didn’t hear.

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Sea Hawk did wake her up in time for the second half of the meeting, which was an absolute drag for the next four hours. Perfuma brought them some very delicious cashew lettuce wraps, but Mermista’s nap had left her overly warm, kind of nauseous, and very cranky, much to her ‘better half’s’ amusement. Rat bastard. She held off eating hers until they took a short break around dinner time.

She was working on not puking up her lettuce wrap while Sea Hawk finished all of his, and the remaining half of hers (and he would still be hungry for a late night snack, because he was a living battery) when Flutterina flounced down into her seat next to them. “So! Sea Hawk, you’re a pirate, huh?”

He took the time to chew, swallow, and wipe his mustache off before answering. Etiquette classes were going well, good to know. “I am- well, was. I’m more of a freelance pirate now? Maybe that’s just a sailor. I was definitely a pirate for about 10 years before I retired.”

“That’s so cool!” Mermista hid a snort in her hand. This was just what he needed, some teenage girl feeding his ego. “Did you, what’s the word, swashbuckle?”

“Certainly, lass! Or, I think I did. You know, I never actually learned what that word means? But it’s safe to say that if a pirate does it, then Sea Hawk’s done it!”

Bow had made his way gingerly around the table, and perched on one the edge of it. “Sea Hawk’s had some really crazy adventures, right bud?”

“Like you wouldn’t believe!”

"Oh, no, you certainly wouldn't," Mermista muttered to herself.

"Have you ever fought the Horde? Taken a ship over? Sang a shanty? Hung around the ports like the pirates in books do? Seen a, uh, what's the word...wench?"

Mermista was *not* able to keep her amusement to herself that time, and barked a harsh laugh that made Sea Hawk elbow her. He was blushing, but trying to remain composed. "Yes, yes, I know enough shanties to out sing a siren, yes, and, ahem, yes."

"Wenches, port boys, tyrosaurs..." Mermista ticked her fingers off. "Sirens, nymphs, dryads, naiads- that was rough for you, right?- *mmph!* " Sea Hawk had shoved his remaining cashew role into her mouth to shut her up.

Flutterina looked far too amused.

"I've been around, yes," he scowled. "Any reason you're asking?"

"No." The girl shrugged. "I've just lived in Elberon my whole life. We don't see many pirates there. Or mermaids!"

Now she was in Mermista's face, bouncing on her toes. She swallowed the remainder of the wrap and grabbed her water to buy herself some time. “Uh, and?”

“What’s it like? Having a tail and breathing underwater?”

She flushed.

Bow cleared his throat. “Uh, Flutterina, there’s a much politer way to ask those things. You wouldn’t ask a Reptilian what it feels like to be green or purple, right? Or to have scales?”

“Oh gosh, no! I’m sorry, I didn’t mean to make you feel like that!”

“Chill, kid, I don’t.” Mermista flipped her braid over her shoulder. “Being a mermaid is awesome, and I’m awesome sooo. No harm done.”

“Can all mermaids walk?”

“No, just my family and a few others.” She played with the water in her goblet. “It had something to do with the Pearl, but that’s not where the ability comes from. It’s, like, biology or whatever. Most merfolk still live deep, deep underwater, out at sea. They don’t bother with people, and it’s probably for the best. They’re total assholes.”

“What?” Bow frowned. “Really?”

“Yeah, they have natural magic. It’s ancient, and not tied to a runestone, kind of like Netossa and Spinnerella. But they see all humans as beneath them, and we cut ties with them a looooong time ago, like my great-great-great-great-great-great- you get the picture- grandmother’s day. They said we sullied our bloodline by choosing legs. Even though we still also had tails? I dunno, it’s stupid.”

“So, mermaids aren’t sirens?” Flutterina tilted her head.

“No, sirens have legs, and they live on land or water, and they’re...wild. They have their own set of societal rules that don’t really apply to others. That’s why they act so strange. Their singing can bewitch you, though, that’s not a fable.”

“Oh yes it can.” Sea Hawk rubbed his head. “And you’ll wake up hungover like never before.”

“Facts.” She nodded. “But yeah. Merfolk, sirens, not the same. Having a tail rocks, except when you don’t want to have a tail and the transformation is involuntary. That blows. Breathing underwater is always helpful. The rest of it is kind of annoying.”

“Rest of it? Involuntary?” Bow was looking curious now, too. “Sorry, it’s just, my dads’ library never had anything on merfolk.”

“We keep to ourselves,” she said, heavy handed in the implication that this was starting to annoy her. “And yeah. It’s not just a tail.”

“You’ve said the teeth are the most cumbersome.” Sea Hawk nudged her, and she gave him her water.

“Ugh, yeah, you try having your mouth rearrange itself every time you wanna take a dip in the ocean. Sucks ass. And all the special lotion I have to buy just so my scales don’t dry out? It’s really not what it’s cracked up to be, kid.”

Flutterina was eyeing her almost...hungrily when she turned back, startling Mermista. “Sorry, I don’t mean to pry. I get the whole annoying appendage thing, though. My wings get stuck a lot. Is it annoying, transforming when you don’t want to? Does it happen a lot?”

“Mhmmm,” Mermista drawled, suddenly feeling very recalcitrant. “It’s not nearly as sexy as the tavern tales make it seem.”

“Beg to differ- ow!” Sea Hawk rubbed his hip where she’d pinched him, and she stuck her tongue out. Glimmer swept into the room with Juliette at her side, and they all moved back to their seats. Except Sea Hawk, who leaned against hers.

“Are you sure you don’t want a chair?”

“No, I’m good here. I’ll use your arm rest if I need to.”

“Suit yourself.”

Flutterina’s dogged questioning perturbed Mermista, to the point she found it almost difficult to focus on the meeting. She offered what she could in the way of strategic help, but Glimmer wasn’t incredibly open to suggestions. So she entertained herself with Sea Hawk’s ridiculous utility belt, surreptitiously pulling out the various contents of its pocket. He tried swatting her hand away, but gave up when they came too close to laughing out loud. Mermista felt like she was a child again, in lessons with Peekablue and Sweet Bee and the Star Sisters and occasionally the children of duke’s and earl’s, being a nuisance to her tutors on purpose.

Glimmer dismissed them around nine, and they took their time leaving. Perfuma walked with them most of the way to the docks, the two women chatting in low tones about Glimmer and Flutterina and Adora’s worsening mood as the meeting went on.

“She’s never been very centered, but this was something else,” Perfuma mused. “I’ve been assuming it’s the grief, but her aura is...darker.”

“She’s desperate for this war to end, ‘Fuma.” Mermista shrugged. “We all are.”

“But she wants more than that, I think.”

“What do you mean?”

“I think Perfuma means,” Sea Hawk chimed in from a few steps behind them. “That Glimmer is becoming vengeful. And that can be a dangerous thing in a leader.”

The words sank in, wreathing them in concern for their friend, themselves, and their future. Perfuma shook herself out of it abruptly. “I have to meditate with the heart blossom. I feel very off-balance. Mermista, Sea Hawk, it was wonderful to see you.” She swept them both in bone-crushing hugs, before letting her vines carry her away into the forest.

“She’s good people.” Sea Hawk smiled.

“Yeah, she is.” Mermista let her fondness for the plant princess creep into her voice. A yawn broke the spell. “Wow, I’m beat.”

“You just slept! For two hours!”

“What can I say? It’s a lot of work to look this good and be this smart all the time.”

“And yet you make it seem effortless.”

“Ugh.” She blushed and rolled her eyes away from him, even as he wrapped an arm around her bare midriff. “Why are you like this.”

“Because I love you, dearest.”

“Yeah, whatever.” *Love you, too.*

Chapter End Notes

Next: and ADVENTCHA!

need a love like ours

Chapter Summary

> An adventure, some sparring, and preparations for the reclamation of Dryl…

Chapter Notes

> Some sex in here bracketed by the cut. I’ve been dragging my feet bc I don’t want salineas to fall :((I have it a culture and personality to heighten the loss and made myself love it lmao. Catch 22

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next week, on the first day of the weekend, the mythical stars themselves must have aligned for them because they each had a clear schedule. Sea Hawk nearly sprang out of bed when he realized, his brain kicking into overdrive, but he took the time to carefully untangle his limb’s from his fiancée’s (and wasn’t that still a thrill?) and clamber out of bed without waking her. Once she was asleep, it was very hard to wake Mermista, but he was always careful anyway. He padded across the room, snatching his robe off the ground as he went and cinching it tight around his waist before he poked his head out of the room.

“Psst! Maevik!”

Mermista’s head guard turned to him, alert as ever. “Captain Sea Hawk, how can I help you?”

“Can you tell the butler to have our breakfast brought to the room this morning?”

“Do you have time for that?” Maevik was blunt, like Mermista. He appreciated it.

“As luck would have it, we both have clear schedules today.”

“Ah!” The guard’s eyes lit up with understanding. “Breakfast in bed, then, excellent choice. I’ll send word immediately, as I’m switching off now. Enjoy your day, Sea Hawk.”

“Thank you, Maevik, you as well.”

Sea Hawk popped back into the room, shutting the door softly. He rocked on his heels, deep in thought. Ideas came to him in bits and pieces, snatches of inspiration, until a plan was fully formulated in his head. Fighting to keep from singing or squealing in glee, he settled for punching the air in silent, passionate victory. But first, a gentle, easy wake up. If he let Mermista sleep in too long, her schedule would be wrecked for the week, and he’d never hear the end of it.

That was alright, though; he liked the sound of her voice.

He meandered around the room, lighting refreshing incense and cleaning as he went. His love was an organized chaos sort of person- piles of belongings and clothes and books in odd places and things left haphazardly around the room mid-thought, and yet Mermista knew where every single thing she owned was at all times. It was impressive and concerning. He tidied her massive vanity, arranging bottles and containers and tubes and pallets, sweeping jewelry into its respective drawers and boxes. He gently shook out the knitted throw blanket she kept thrown over the couch of her reading area- handmade by her mother, and one of Mermista's most treasured possessions. He gently drew back the dark curtains that kept Salineas' early day-moon rise out of his princess' eyes, and then set about getting dressed. He forewent his usual tight pants, opting for airy cotton breeches and one of his cut out shirts. He grabbed a book off her shelf and settled back into bed, chuckling when Mermista rolled back into him and latched on like a limpet. No one would believe that between the two of them, she was the cuddler.

After about half an hour, the room was warm with incense and sunlight, and the butler was knocking on the door. Sea Hawk called out an entrance, making sure Mermista's bare form was covered entirely by the blanket. She shifted a bit, close to waking up. The butler left the trays on the table by the door, bowed and exited. Sea Hawk sunk deeper into bed, peppering gentle kisses on every available inch of Mermista's sepia skin, warm and soft with sleep. "It's morning, love, time to wake up."

She groaned, and tried to turn over but he held her tight in his arms. "Nooooo…"

"Yes, dearest." He nosed along her collarbone, rubbing broad hands down her back. "I had breakfast brought to the room. All you need to do is sit up."

“Too much work,” she grumbled. “Sleep.”

“If we sleep the day away, we won’t get to enjoy our mutually free day.”

That got her to crack an eye open. Sea Hawk sighed blissfully, she had the most stunning eyes.

“What? We both have off today?”

“Mhm.” Her hand came up to scratch at his stubble, and he hummed blissfully as he kissed the inside of her wrist. “Come on, breakfast time.”

“Fiiiiiiine,” she groaned, pushing herself up to sit against the headboard. “What’s breakfast.”

“Lox and burrata on toasted baguettes, a side of strawberries and cream, eggs, and very dark coffee.”

“I love you.” Mermista grinned. “Marry me?”

“I think I might.”

“Hell yeah.”

They chatted idly over breakfast, scrolling the updates from the Alliance on their data pads. Bow had set up two shared communication servers, one for formal and official business, and the other for general bullshitting. Mermista had the latter muted, it was more distracting than helpful. This morning, though, they were perusing the pictures Perfuma had sent in of the summer foliage. It never snowed, or really ‘wintered’ in Plumeria, thanks to the Heart Blossom, but the flowers and plants there still lived and died on a staggered timeline. Perfuma had explained it to her once, something about the natural cycle of life and death, the beauty in both, but she’d been young. Maybe she would ask her about it again soon. Right now, the flowers in Plumeria were in full radiance, the peak of their life cycles.

Sea Hawk cleared their plates, dropping them on the reception table and holding out a hand. Mermista groaned. “We’re off! Can’t we just go back to bed.”

“We could, buuuuut then you’d miss the wonderful adventure I have planned.”

Okay, she was somewhat intrigued. “Tell me about it.”

“I will after you get dressed.”

“Lame.” She pushed herself up and over to her closet. “What should I wear?”

“Nothing fancy, but your armor probably won’t be necessary. Something you can transform in”

“Kay.” Mermista bit her lip, considering her options. She settled for a pair of dark blue leggings, enchanted like her usual armored ones, and snatched one of Sea Hawk’s boob-window shirts off the ground before disappearing into the bathroom. She emerged with her hair in a loose braid, Sea Hawk’s shirt tied in a knot just under her chest, leaving her toned stomach bare. Sea Hawk eyed her with interest; she always looked damn good in his clothes.

Alas, he had to focus or they’d never leave. Which was probably the exact reason she’d done this. While she sat at her vanity to apply her lotions, he ducked into the bathroom to tend to necessities. They were ready at the same time, and he offered her his arm gallantly. She nodded to her guard as they left, waving him away when he moved to escort her. “Let Maevik know I’m going out for the day with Sea Hawk, no guard requested.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

It was only once they were out in the open sea, no land in sight, that Mermista realized-

“Hey, wait, where are we going?”

Sea Hawk flicked the controls out of manual, hopping down to the main deck and pulling a map out of his jacket’s lining. He joined her on the crate she was relaxing on, enjoying the gentle whip of the wind on her face. “On an adventure! Quite literally. We’re headed here!” He pointed at a spot he had circled on the map. “About another thirty miles off shore, there’s an old network of submarine caves, with a legendary treasure allegedly somewhere inside.”

Mermista looked reservedly intrigued. “Uh huh. And why do we need treasure? We’re, like, royal.”

“It’s the principal of the matter, dear!” He bopped her lightly on the head with his map. “Plus, this treasure may be personal. The legend says it once belonged to a great King of the Merfolk, lost in a war that led to their withdrawal from Etherian society.”

Now Mermista looked interested, eyes shining at the story. “What? Seriously? What’s the treasure?”

“No one knows,” he said with a shrug. “No one is even sure if it's real or if it’s a mistranslation that led to a fable. That’s just how these things go.”

“Have you ever actually found buried treasure?”

“Twice!” Sea Hawk smiled proudly. “Although one of those was a complete accident. So, once on purpose. Which, in a pirate’s lifetime, is a pretty impressive number.”

“Whatever you say, dork.” Mermista rolled her eyes, even as she moved to lean her head on his shoulder. Sea Hawk enjoyed the moment, the tranquil sea, the wind in his face, the sun warming his skin, and the way his heart fluttered at having Mermista here with him. His legs still fidgeted, burning with the suppressed thought that he needed to do something grand to impress her. The overall day was grand, he reminded himself. No need to jump the shark.

She followed him back up to the wheel, wrapping her arms around his waist and hooking her chin over his shoulder while he steered. “So, like, was it hard? Learning to sail?”

“I...can’t recall.” Sea Hawk frowned. “I was raised on boats. Some of my earliest memories are views from crow’s nests, or the prows of ships. Instead of being put in time-out as a boy, I swabbed decks and cleaned fish and restrung lines. It was constructive, especially when I was angry. I learned to sail bigger vessels after the raid, and I remember being excited. I think I was just too foolish and young to be nervous.”

Mermista was silent against his back for a long while, probably contemplating whatever she wanted to say next. “Have you thought about…”

When she didn’t finish the thought, he nudged. “About what, love?”

Her mouth was pressed firm into his shoulder blade, muffling much of her question but not so much that he couldn’t make it out. “Would you teach our kids to sail?”

Sea Hawk fought to keep his voice steady, not wanting to spook Mermista during a clearly vulnerable moment. It reminded him of the bet he’d lost that resulted in him having to corner a woodland boar. “Would you want that?”

“...yeah,” Mermista whispered. “I...I want them to love the ocean like we do. And sailing is important to you, so they should.”

“They’d be royalty. They’d never need to sail themselves.”

“I don’t want them to be, like, brats. Hard work isn’t a bad thing to learn. And I really like the thing you said about swabbing decks. It beats writing lines, or extra training hours.”

“Is that what you did?”

Mermista’s cheek was resting against his back now. “Yeah, my dad made me run laps, or swim miles, or write lines over and over again when I screwed up. Didn’t teach me anything except how to get better at hiding my bad choices from him.I don't want that for our kids.”

Sea Hawk squeezed the arm wrapped around his waist. “You'll be five hundred times the parent your father was, Mermista.”

“...I hope you’re right.”

“I know I am.” He sensed the need for a shift in topic, and went for lighthearted. “So...kids? Plural?”

Mermista groaned, hiding her face in his back even though he couldn’t see her anyway. “Shut up.”

“You want my babiessss,” he sang at her, laughing. “You want mini-Sea Hawks-“

“Don’t even fucking joke about that.”

“I don’t need to, you admitted it-“

“I will drown you.”

“But then how will you have my- *argrrargsplbphtbt!”* Sea water down the gullet was always a sure fire way to get someone to shut up. Sea Hawk coughed and sputtered until Mermista took pity and dragged the water out of his lungs. Which was an equally horrid experience; it was like being drowned in reverse.

“Are you done?”

He wiped his mouth. “I am until we aren’t in the ocean anymore.”

“I’ll take it.”

“Good, because we’re pretty much here.” He gestured out past the prow, to the smattering of tiny, rocky islands jutting out of the water. Sea Hawk dropped anchor a good bit away from the rocks, taking note of the ship debris scattered around them. There were probably many boats sitting on the sea floor below them. Mermista scanned the water, concentrating.

“I don’t sense any life near here at all. Not even dolphins, and they love wreckyards. This place is spooky.” She gave him a genuine smile. “Nice pick.”

“I aim to please!” He mock-bowed. “Shall we?”

“Wait, how are you going to breathe in there?”

“Oh, I-ah…” He rubbed his neck sheepishly. “You can push air into my lungs, can’t you?”

Mermista smirked at him. “What would you have done if I said no?”

“Probably tried anyway because I’m stubborn like that.”

She laughed softly, and yanked off her crop-tied top. Underneath, she wore a blue bikini top, embellished with gold thread and well made, and he only choked a little bit. “Ready?”

She didn’t wait for an answer, instead diving off the boat, flipping mid air and hitting the water with nary a splash. Sea Hawk stripped down to his trunks and a tight tee, double checked his anchors, and followed suit. He kept his sword belt on; they would need the light in the dark caves.

When he hit the water, he looked around and frowned. He was alone...where had Mermista- *eep!*

Hands wrapped around his ankles and pulled, hard, dragging him away from the surface just enough for him to start worrying, before letting him go. He kicked out hard, and had barely swallowed a breath of air before he was dragged down again. This time, amber eyes met onyx and smiled, sticking a tongue out at him and gliding away. Mermista was radiant, in her element and clearly enjoying it. She glided through the water, turning over herself in the sunbeams, flipping lazily, blue hair floating behind her elegantly. It had come loose from its braid, probably when she hit the water, and spun away from her like streamers.

Sea Hawk could taste his love for her, seeing as his heart was practically in his throat, choking him with emotion and gratitude. Mermista swam closer, tail rolling minutely, until she was in his arms. She pressed her lips to his, softly, until he needed air. She let him swim to the surface this time, joining him.

“So, where do we start?”

“From what I could tell, the largest of these caves is the entrance, and from there it's a bit of a maze. Are you claustrophobic?”

“Guess we’ll find out.” She wrapped her arms around him and began swimming for the largest cave. Sea Hawk’s stomach flipped, swimming this fast was a novel experience and he was having a blast. When they approached the cave’s mouth, half submerged in water, they swam in carefully.

“See anything?”

“Hang on.” Mermista dove under, leaving Sea Hawk to scan the interior of the reasonably large cave. It went back a ways, and the sound of rushing water was faint but present, letting him know there was some sort of current nearby. It sounded strong, he'd hate to get caught in its undertow, in the dark.

He gulped, vowing to stay close to Mermista. The cave was unremarkable, and he was about to start making his way to the back when Mermista popped back up. "So, there's a ton of tunnels spanning out of this one cave, but there's this one that's marked with pearls. If it is a merfolk treasure, that's probably the one to take."

"Pearls are a merfolk thing?"

"Yeah it's our most prized gem or whatever." Mermista shrugged. "Hence the giant runestone hanging above our throne."

"Huh. I always assumed it was one of those circumstantial coincidences!" He stroked his wet mustache. "No matter. Lead the way my dear!"

"Deep breath," she warned him, before taking his hand and leading him down.

He could see the marked hole, yawning and large, tunneling off into the back of the cave. They swam through the mouth of it, and it stayed straight for a while, occasionally tilting up, moving often and angling downward. Mermista turned every few minutes to breathe air into his lungs, sometimes lingering for longer than was strictly necessary. Not that he was complaining in the slightest.

Eventually, it became too dark for him to see, and he cranked his sun-saber up to about a sixth of its power. The glow illuminated the way for them both, and it was about fifteen minutes before the tunnel angled up sharply, turning from rough rock to soft sand in a matter of minutes. They emerged into a pocket of air, a small sandy dune rising out of the water for them to relax on. Sea Hawk lowered the blade's brightness down to two. Mermista's tail kept her from climbing out fully, so she reclined low on the bank, chin in hand.

"We keep following this then? Any more clues?"

"There were weird inscriptions on the map." He shook his head like a dog. "One said something about the mother's daughter's treasure leading you onward-"

"That's the pearl path." Mermista nodded. "Mother of pearl, pearls are the merfolk treasure. So that's good, we're heading the right way."

"Brilliant!" He pressed a kiss to her cheek, feeling scales under his lips in lieu of smooth skin. "The next said something about darkness lighting the way. I didn't understand that." Mermista shrugged so he continued. "And the last was, when up is down, look around, see the treasure run aground."

“Oooh, that one rhymed.” The Princess rolled her eyes. “Fancy.”

“Such a critic of the pirate treasure code,” he chided. “Shall we push on?”

“I’m ready when you are.”

Sea Hawk dove back into the water so quickly that Mermista had to scramble to find him in the dark water. It was easier said than done, even with her enhanced vision; she could see underwater better than any human, but it wasn’t crystal clear. More like the light when the sun was first rising- hazy and fuzzy at the edges, details hard to register. When she found him, she seized his upper arm in a vice and made sure he could see her scowl. He merely laughed, wasting air.

“This is how people drown, you know that right?” Mermista chided after she breathed more air into him. Sea Hawk just shrugged, and tugged her onward.

They followed the pearls, weakly reflecting the light off Sea Hawk’s sword. Eventually they came to a fork, both ways studded with pearls. Mermista strained her ears, but heard nothing. She tasted the water as it flowed over her gills, but it was the same in all directions. No currents, no difference in salinity, no signs of life. A complete impasse.

“I have an idea,” Sea Hawk signed at her; a helpful talent she wasn’t aware he knew until a few months ago. “Stay close.”

She wound herself around him, tail brushing his legs, as he shut off his blade. At first, there was nothing but darkness, and she coiled tighter around her fiancé, illogically nervous to lose him in the dark. Then, pinpricks of light began to poke through the abyss, so faint that for a second Mermista thought she was imagining it. Sea Hawk squeezed her shoulder, and she shook herself from her daze to breathe into him. When she pulled back, there were hundreds upon thousands of illuminated shells, rocks, and gems, glowing a haunting bluish green in the dark. As if in a trance, Mermista swam closer, running her fingers over them gently. The ocean never ceased to amaze.

Sea Hawk yanked on her arm, hard, and she whirled on him in annoyance. He pointed excitedly down at her tail, and when she glanced at it, she forgot how to breathe for a moment. Where the tips of her scales usually shone gold in the sun, now they glowed with that same luminescence that shimmered in the water around them. She whirled, trying to get a better look, and ended up chasing her own tail for a moment like a guppy. Even the scales on her human half were glowing gently, and she stared at her arm for a good few moments with her mouth agape, until Sea Hawk gestured for her to breathe into him again. He gathered her close this time, sharing more than just air, running his hands along her waist where skin became scale. Mermista shivered and bit down a moan; it was one of the most sensitive parts of her body, which he damn well knew.

She motioned for them to follow the illuminated path, and Sea Hawk nodded, placing his hand in hers and kicking along next to her, half swimming, half being dragged. The cavern widened enough for them to swim side by side, and then wider yet, the blues and greens of the luminous shells dancing in the water like the borealis did over Snows in the winter. Mermista felt giddy, suddenly, lighter than she had in years, and tugged her hand out of Sebastian's so she could swim around him, looping his body with her longer one, dancing like a ribbon in the water, He would reach out to touch her, and she would flit away, challenging him with heated eyes and wide, sharp mouth to come and play.

He now understood how sailors drowned chasing mermaids.

They chased one another through the water, joining to share air before darting apart to lead each other deeper, deeper into the caves. Mermista's laughter was clear as a bell, her magic making her voice ring out clearly, echoing off the stones. Soon, the cavern started sloping upwards a bit, opening into a large, round cave. Sunlight must have been coming in from somewhere, some hole above them, because it brightened considerably. Not enough for the bioluminescence to fade from Mermista's tail and body, but it dimmed. She motioned him closer, pushing more air into his lungs without him needing to ask. She motioned upwards, and darted away to the top of the cave, Sea Hawk busied himself with looking around, swimming down deeper toward the sandy floor. He brushed his hands lazily through the soft, white sand, waiting for something to catch his finger. He startled, then chuckled, when Mermista's hand wrapped around his ankle, tugging harshly. He kicked at her playfully, trying to swim on, but her hand wouldn't budge. He tugged at his ankle, and she tugged back aggressively. He turned to question her, and promptly lost all the air out of his lungs in a scream.

The thing holding his ankle was *not* Mermista.

Mermista didn’t smile at him coldly, hungrily, like he was prey (well, not outside the bedroom, and not like this), Mermista didn’t threaten to crush his ankle bone in a clawed, webbed hand. This mermaid was lithe, streamlined purple tail and purple armored bodice, black hair, green eyes narrowed into slits. Her mouth was sharper than sharp, needled teeth bared as she hissed. The long sword she had leveled at his neck was more of a large metal toothpick than a blade. She pressed in with it, and Sea Hawk felt it nick his throat, watched the blood float upwards, a crimson ribbon. The mermaid opened her mouth, inching closer, and Sea Hawk braced himself for his jugular to be someone’s lunch-

SHRIEK!

His eyes flew open, hands going automatically to his throat, which was still miraculously intact. He scrambled for his sword, but found that it was essentially unnecessary; Mermista had come tearing down the surface, and slammed into the other mermaid with enough force to send her into the cave wall. She turned, quickly pushing more air into his lungs, which he drank in greedily. She was torn from his lips when the other mermaid rallied, and grabbed Mermista by the hair to rip her away into a brawl. However, watching them tussle, it was obvious that Mermista had at least a foot on the other woman. Unsure what to do, Sea Hawk hovered just outside of the scrap, watching with open curiosity.

The other mermaid had caught Mermista by the throat, but let go when the princess raked sharpened nails- claws, really- down her forearms, drawing no small amount of blood. She shrieked again and released, and they circled each other for a moment, Mermista never leaving Sea Hawk unguarded. Purple (he didn’t know what else to call her, so Purple it was for now) opened her mouth and started...clicking? Definitely clicking. Shocking him even more, Mermista responded in kind, but with some hissing in there as well. Fascinating. For a moment, Sea Hawk forgot to be scared, and found himself inching closer.

Mermista circled back, wrapping her elongated body around Sea Hawk, hissing more. He clocked unnaturally sharp teeth in his peripheral, and swallowed hard. Briefly, he reflected on how he wound up in this situation, the choices he'd made in life. It would be a hell of a way to die, at the least. The shanties they'd sing…

Without preamble, Purple lunged again, seizing Mermista by the shoulders and attempting to bite her. Sea Hawk was pushed away by his Princess' tailfin, thrown clear of the brawl. Mermista slammed a fist into her face, flipping out of the grapple and racing away, around the rock pile jutting out from the sandy floor. While Purple struggled to regain her bearing, Mermista snuck in from behind, grabbing her in a headlock with her arms paralyzed, jerking harshly until the sword clattered to the ground. With one hand, she fisted the woman's hair, and yanked until she snarled. Mermista made more clicking sounds, throat working almost unnaturally to produce the inhuman sounds. At length, the other mermaid clicked back, and Mermista shoved her away roughly. She let Purple gather her sword, and then circled her arms through the water. A current picked up around them, pushing a shocked Purple out of the cavern via a small tunnel that Sea Hawk hadn't clocked. Even after she left, Mermista didn't relax, body tense and alert. It was only when he tugged on her for air that she broke focus, and turned on him.

She gave him a hasty once over, before helping him to the top of the cave. They broke the surface, Sea Hawk breathing for himself for the first time in about half an hour. Mermista circled him as he caught his breath, ducking below the surface frequently, popping up only to make sure he was still breathing, it seemed. Eventually he reached out and grabbed her elbow. “Mermista…” It felt strange to talk. “What the hell was that?”

“Another mermaid.”

“Yes, thank you.” He rolled his eyes. He was picking up too many of her habits. “I mean, why was she here? Why did she attack me?”

“Because you were right.” She flicked her gaze at him. “The treasure is in here. And apparently it's a rite of passage, or challenge, I’m not sure about the translation, for just-of-age warriors to come and try to find it.”

“And so she was going to eat me over some gold?”

“Gold is priceless to mermaids. They covet it almost as much as pearls. And she wasn’t going to eat you.”

“It felt like she was going to eat me.”

“Don’t be stupid, merfolk don’t eat people. She was going to claim you.”

“Claim me?” Sea Hawk was more than alarmed. “As a...what, as a prize?”

“Uh, yeah.” Mermista was starting to look amused now. “Something like that.”

“Mermistaaaaa,” he whined. “Tell me.”

“She wanted to fuck you, Sebastian.”

“ *What?!* ” His yell ricocheted off the ceiling. “What! She...how? *What?* Is that why you beat her up?”

“Uh, yeah, duh.” She tightened her circling. “Mermaids are possessive, to put it lightly. Territorial is a better word. And they can get violent. She was just being, y’know, normal for her. Don’t make a thing out of it.”

“Mermaids are possessive?”

Mermista ducked back under the water in lieu of answering, but Sea Hawk wasn’t letting her get away that easily. He thrashed around until she came back up, or, the upper half of her face came back up. Her cheeks downward were submerged, hiding any possible blush. “What?”

Sea Hawk swam closer, until his skin brushed hers. “When were you going to tell me that you're the jealous type?”

“Oh, please.” Mermista rolled her eyes. “I am not.”

“You just gouged out another woman’s forearms for me.”

“It was for me!” She splashed him. “Get over yourself!”

“For you, huh? Then what were you clicking about?”

“I was not- it’s not important.”

“Mermistaaaaaa, communication is the cornerstone of a healthy-“

“Y’know what, let me call her back-”

“You would never!” He smirked. “Not after you just fought for little ol’ me.”

“Regretting it.”

“Mermista!”

“Ugh! Fine! Gods!” she groaned, and maneuvered to float on her back, tail dragging in the water. “She wanted you as a prize, because mermaids like keeping people as prizes for as long as they remember to keep them alive. It’s a sport to them, because mortal lives aren’t worth what theirs are. Like, keeping a caterpillar in a jar on your windowsill. But, mermaids, like I said, are territorial, and they have an urge to dominate. That’s what my mom said. So they’ll try to hurt you, claim you in other ways, as a mark of their, I dunno, abilities? They’re freaks, dude.”

“So she was going to keep me in a jar after she…” He shuddered, unable to finish the thought.

“Yeah. She wanted you, I told her to fuck off, she said on what grounds, I said you were mine-“

“I like the sound of that,” Sea Hawk purred, swimming up alongside her.

Mermista snorted. “Shut *up* , goober. Anyway, she didn’t like my answer and so she wanted me out of the way.”

“She wanted to kill you?”

Mermista just shrugged. “Yeah I guess.”

“What if...she hadn’t yielded?”

She stared at him, long and deep, and for the first time in ever knowing her, Sea Hawk felt the full effect of Mermista not being completely...human. “Then I would have killed her first. Simple.”

“Is it?”

She seemed to consider that for a moment. “It is for me. But the rules I was born into, the rules of the ocean, are different. I would have tried everything in my power to incapacitate her first, believe me, but if she wouldn’t stop, and it was your life on the line…” She shrugged. “What would you have done if the positions were reversed?”

Sea Hawk thought of that, of the scum of the earth people he’d been dealing with since he left Snows, the thought of how they operated, their codes of conducts. Faces like Scurvy and Falcon flashed into his mind, the knowledge of what they would do to Mermista if they had the chance. He nodded. “I understand.”

“I know you do.” She leaned in and kissed him deeply, her tongue caressing his as she traced still-sharp nails along his jaw. He shivered as she pulled away. “Still want your treasure?”

He thought about it. “I’d like to at least know where it is, and what it is. Then we can see if it's worth taking.”

“A logical pirate. How cute.”

Mermista scanned the floor of the cave while he searched the surface, sword in hand at all times. He ran the rest of the riddle over in his mind, back and forth, up and down-

“Hey!” Mermista’s yell broke his train of thought as she glided over to him. “So, the rocks on the bottom, they’re not normal sea floor rocks. I think they’re stalactites.”

His eyes widened. “Which would mean-“

“-the cave is upside down!” they chorused.

Sea Hawk looked upwards again, scanning for- “There!”

He pointed, guiding Mermista to a clump of what he had assumed were stalactites, but which he now saw were corroded metals and woods, welded to the ‘roof’ of the cave by hundreds of years of weathering. A ship had crashed here a long, long time ago, and then something had somehow turned this entire cave upside down. That seemed a much greater mystery than the treasure, but they could ponder that one back home. He glanced at Mermista, who smiled back, summoning a funnel of water to push them up the twenty feet to the pile of deadwood. She sliced at it with sharp jets of water, until a large chest tumbled loose. She caught that, too, in a bubble and drew it level with them. Sea Hawk jimmied his sword into the mouth, crowbarring it open when the old, rusted lock disintegrated. They pried it open, gasping at the contents.

Mountains of gold, rubies, sapphires, piled as high as they could go. Pearls and locked boxes sat nestled in the gold, along with…

“Is that First Ones tech?” Mermista reached in gingerly, and pulled out some geometric runes. She frowned. “No, not tech. But artifacts. This is invaluable, Sea Hawk, we can’t leave this here.”

“Agreed.”

They shut the lid, and Sea Hawk slid his blade into the lock hole to keep it from opening. Mermista glanced around. “The day-moon is setting, and we can tell because there’s lighting coming in from somewhere...there!” Above them, there were fine fissured cracks in the cave ceiling. With one strong upward thrust of her arm, Mermista summoned a strong wave to smash through the weakened ceiling. She propelled them out on a water funnel, into the bright light of the ending day. Sweeping her arms, she pushed them away from the caves on a wave, until his ship was in view. She boosted him up to the deck first, following close behind.

He abandoned the chest to kneel at her side, letting her lean back against him to catch her breath. He pressed a kiss to her hair. “Dearest, you were *amazing!* I’ve never had so much fun on an adventure. You’re...you’re the perfect partner!” He scooped her hand up, still scaled and clawed, and pressed a kiss to her knuckles. “In every way.”

She flushed and turned away, but didn’t hide her smile. “Yeah? Even when I have a giant tail and I make weird clicking noises and I get possessive? Some people would call those all, like, major turn-offs.”

He knew she was joking, but he still hugged her close. “Especially when you do all of those beautiful things.”

“You’re so much.” She buried her head in his shoulder. “I’m changing back now.”

“Okay, love.” Sea Hawk never got tired of her magic, watching it wash over her in beautiful, sparkling light. Her tail split and shrank, replaced by leggings that Mermista immediately shucked off, leaving her in just her bikini. He squeezed her tight, giving her a moment until she was ready to stand. She had told him once that when she had a tail for long hours, switching back to legs could be jarring.

She didn’t stumble, but she did lean heavily on him as he brought her below deck and got her settled in the v-berth. “I’ll have us home in about an hour.”

“'Kay.” She yawned wide, giving him a glimpse of razored teeth. “Wake me when we’re about a mile out?”

“Always.”

“Love you,” she mumbled into the pillow, and he brought the blanket up around her shoulders. “Today was fun.”

“Adventure?” He grinned giddily at her, and she smiled.

“Yeah,” she snorted. “Adventure.”

“Woo!”

He left her to doze, grabbing a towel as he made his way back up to the wheel. Hauling anchor, setting the course, and adjusting the sails took a matter of minutes, and soon they were flying back to Salineas. He was racing the night; while he could sail in the dark, and had many times, he preferred not to, especially around Salineas. The entire island chain was surrounded by whirlpools, rip currents, hidden sandbars and stretches of rough rock, and of course pirates, marauders, Horde vessels. And now he had mermaids to tack onto that list. He shook off the memory of those cold eyes, the teeth near his throat. Instead, he thought of Mermista, beautiful, strong, protective. It was hard to know from how aloof and distant she made herself, but he’d never known anyone as fiercely defensive of those she loved as she was. She was protective of her kingdom, her people, her culture, her mother’s legacy. And now he was on that list. It was the highest honor he’d ever received.

Sea Hawk didn’t have much in his life worth protecting. He’d never really understood the emotion, rooted in pride and love, until he met Mermista. Now, he knew what it felt like to be willing to do anything for someone. He’d heard someone say once that being willing to die for another was the greatest love; he disagreed. He felt that it was much harder, and much more fulfilling, to live for someone instead. He’d lived for himself all his life, chasing his own pleasure in the form of adventure, illegality, defying death and living on the edge. That was a cakewalk compared to being the man worthy of Mermista’s love and protection. But he’d never felt so fulfilled. Never felt so loved, so capable of creation, instead of destruction.

Creation...his mind floated to his fiancée’s earlier question. After the portal, he’d been careful to keep his subconscious thoughts of the future, his hopes for it, close to his sleeve. Mermista was already wearing his ring, it was enough of a dream come true. But now, she’d said the K word. She wanted his kids. Logically, he knew that marrying her would involve children, but they’d never sat down to talk about it. Whether she wanted them, or saw them as a necessary duty, another transactional obligation that came with the crown. (In his deepest nightmares, he had worried if she saw marrying him like that as well.) Now, he knew. And it terrified and exhilarated him. And she’d said kids! Kids, plural! More than one! He’d always wanted a large family, knew the pangs of growing up alone when all the other kids had built in playmates, confidants, mentors, friends. And, sure, maybe he was romanticizing it. Kids were hard work. But he wanted them. As many as she wanted, he would give her.

Sea Haw could see them, in his mind's eye, playing on the deck of his ship, climbing ropes and sitting in the crow’s nest (with him or Mermista, at least until they could see over the edge on their own). He would teach them to tie knots, read sonars and radars, when to put it in autopilot and when to stand by the wheel. How to read the winds, the birds, the moonrises and moonsets. How to read maps, use compasses, the best way to get barnacles off the hull in a pinch. Whatever they wanted to learn. And if he taught them the basics and they didn’t want to sail, that would be okay, too. They could lounge on or below deck with their mother, reading books or playing on their datapad, asking him ‘ugh, dad, are we there yet?’.

He wanted it so badly he could feel it, feel his love for these people he hadn’t even met yet, building inside of him almost painfully. Against his will, the little girl from the portal flashed into his eye, looking so like Mermista he ached. He saw her smile, his smile, heard her giggle, and felt the phantom weight of her in his arms. *Soon* , he told himself, entirely uncertain if it was true.

The cry of a gull broke him from reverie. He peered out into the gloom, and saw the bright lights of Port Salineas. He lowered the main sail, leaving the lesser ones up, and checked their heading before jumping below deck to shake Mermista awake.

“Wake up, dearest. We’re home.”

— —. — - — — - - -

A month later, Mermista was able to return the favor of Sea Hawk's lazy morning gift. She'd quietly had the schedule for his birthday cleared of any meetings, paperwork, or assignments. She'd let Maevik know the night before to have breakfast in the room by eight, as Sea Hawk was incapable of sleeping past eight thirty in the morning. She had also made sure they got to bed early the night before so she wouldn't be a cranky, sleep-deprived monster that morning.

By some miracle, she woke up first, stretching languidly and rolling over in Sea Hawk's arms. He snored on, warm breath puffing over her face with each exhale. In the quiet of the morning, she let her hands roam as they pleased, feeling every inch of skin, some areas soft, some calloused, much of it scarred. Sebastian's torso was a mixing pot of scar tissue, ink, and muscle. His broad shoulders supported a near-barrel chest, dusted with hair that Mermista ran her fingers through. His tattoos were many, scrawling over his chest, his shoulders, his back, even some down his left bicep. Geometric patterns native to Snows, waves and ships and sea monsters. On each pec, a small seagull that he'd had done when he lost a bet. Over his heart, a compass, and diving on his back was a sea hawk. Some he'd gotten for fun, or from boredom, or because he was drunk. But she knew that most of them meant something to him. There were dates hidden in the pictures, and she'd always meant to ask him about each, but the timing never seemed right.

She brushed her hands over the electric burn-scar on his ribs from the battle of Bright Moon, memories of that night, of that time in their lives, flashing into her mind. She pushed them away, and ducked to press a kiss to the expanse of paler skin. Freckles made constellations across his skin, and she followed them back up to his lips. She smiled to herself, noting how chapped they were and feeling a particular lack of remorse for it. Hers were in the same shape, she imagined. Mermista smoothed gentle fingers over his mustache, naturally shiny and unruly from sleep. It was the most well-maintained part of his face, compared to his unruly eyebrows, wind-and-sun burned cheeks. His nose was crooked, though you'd never know unless you were looking for it; he'd broken it as a kid, running on the icy docks after his mother told him not to, and the healer hadn't fully set it. It had mostly fixed itself as he grew, but there was a tiny kink in it that Mermista loved kissing. So she did. His brow crinkled under her lips, and she smiled. She pressed kisses along his cheek to his ear, where she whispered, "Sebastian, its time to get up."

One bleary eye peeled open, already looking far more awake than she felt, even half-asleep. "'Mist?"

"Morning, birthday boy." She kissed him softly. "Happy 25th."

His eyes blinked open wide now. "Is it…am I really that old?"

Mermista nodded, smirking. "Yep. I'm turning 24 this Autumn, so you're old now. Old, old man."

"Feels like only last year I was 20, meeting the princess of Salineas…" He ran his hands through her hair, brushing errant strands behind her ear. "It's been a wild few years."

She just nodded, leaning in to kiss him softly. He returned it wholeheartedly, ghosting his fingers down her body to squeeze her thigh and tug her closer. She sighed happily into his lips, losing herself in the feeling of kissing him. She knew breakfast would be here soon, but she wanted…oh, she wanted. And so did he, by the feel of him under her thigh. Sleeping bare had its benefits, she was learning.

They broke apart, panting gently. He pressed his forehead to hers, sharing her air. "'Mista…"

"I know." She ran her open mouth softly along his jaw, teeth grazing his stubble. She drank in the scent of him, his warmth, almost drunk off his presence. "I'm having breakfast sent up here at eight."

"Darling." His chuckle was rolling thunder in his chest, hands skimming her thighs like storm wind. "You've got me half undone just laying here."

Couldn't argue with logic that infallible. Mermista rolled them over, hooking her legs over his hips, reveling in the feel of his weight settling between her hips. He draped himself over her, elbows resting near her head so she was covered by him, but not crushed. She wrapped an arm around his shoulders, drawing him as close as she could. His teeth grazed her neck, just enough to light her nerve endings on fire and pull a breathy moan from her throat.

— – EXPLICIT — —

Sea Hawk’s fingers, calloused but gentle, skimmed the length of her body and came to rest at her entrance. He dipped first one, then two fingers between her lips, and she inhaled sharply at the contact.

“Stars, Mista, you’re so wet,” he groaned into her neck. She grinned, and rolled her hips against his fingers.

“Do something about it.”

Pulling his fingers back, he shifted and lined himself up with her sex. She hitched her legs higher, spreading herself wide for him. She groaned low as he entered her, stretching her exquisitely. In two thrusts he was buried to the hilt, sheathed in her velvet heat. For a moment, neither moved, just breathed against each other and reveled in the moment. Sea Hawk pulled back from her neck to press a soft kiss to her lips, surprisingly chaste since he was currently inside of her. She wasn’t protesting, though. The easy, slow morning didn’t call for their typical brand of passion, but rather a quieter, earthier love.

Sea Hawk rocked into her, and Mermista gasped. He was deep, as deep as he could be, but she wanted more; more of him, more of this feeling, more of this connection. She grabbed the small hairs at the back of his neck, dragging his eyes to meet hers while she rolled her hips to meet his shallow thrusts. The air between them was electric, and she was forced to break eye contact when he gently twisted her nipple. She half-moaned, half-sighed when he ducked to take the same nipple in his mouth, laving his tongue over it in time with his thrusts.

Mermista was starting to float, nerve ends tingling as her blood rushed south to her clit. Sea Hawk was working magic all over her body, mouth on her nipples, fingers on one hand tracing patters on her sides and abdomen, tugging gently at her hair with the other. “Sebastian…” she gasped. “I- I need…I…”

Words were failing her, but Sea Hawk understood anyway. He reached between them, rolling and pinching her clit between clever fingers. She whimpered, an embarrassingly needy noise that only he would ever hear her make, and he bit gently at the soft skin below her ear. “You’re so beautiful, Mermista, you drive me- *ah* - insane,” he whispered into her ear. “I love you so much.”

“Se-Sebastian,” she choked out. “Please.”

The heat that had been racing up and down her body, aimless, was now gathering at the base of her spine, melting her from the inside out. Her legs began shaking as her ability to restrain herself fell away, leaving her a trembling, moaning mess. Sea Hawk thrust on, unhurried as she felt apart on his cock, muttering sweet nothings into her ears. He was starting to make a series of needy noises that let her know he was getting close, and she raked her nails down to his nipple to tweak the bud. He cried out, hips bucking harder into her. “Mermista- *haa* - I won’t last-”

“Come with me,” she moaned, taking her ear lobe into her mouth and biting gently. His hips stuttered their rhythm. “Sebastian- *ah!* ”

Her orgasm had snuck up on her, taking her over like high tide; strong but gentle all at once, washing over her in unrelenting waves. Mermista pressed her forehead back to Sea Hawk’s, the burning look in his eyes only heightening her pleasure when she found herself unable to look away. Her hips were jerking of their own accord, chasing her seemingly endless high. One orgasm gave way to another, smaller one, that was Sea Hawk’s undoing, and he cried out as he emptied himself deep inside her. He crushed his lips to hers, teeth and tongue and impossibly soft lips, and she let herself float while she kissed him back. Her entire body was tingling, and light; she felt like she’d been swimming in a deep current, and was now unhurriedly making her way to the surface. When Sea Hawk shifted and pulled out of her, the emptiness left her shivering.

He rolled her into his chest, running his fingers through her hair. She felt him heaving for air under her, and pressed lazy kisses to the ink on his chest just above his heart. Mermista propped herself up on one elbow to look at him with far too happy a grin. “So, what do you want to do today?”

– – - —- - - - - Explicit over – - – - -

They spent the day goofing off, essentially, until their dinner reservations. Sea Hawk took her to the markets, where they proceeded to spoil each other rotten. His main birthday gift was sitting in her clutch for the evening, but she liked buying him things as much as he enjoyed buying her things. Sea Hawk had grown up without much, even before the Horde took his home, so the ability to buy her things, and the novel act of receiving presents back, still cowed him.

He bought her new dresses, shoes, bindis and other jewelry. She bought him books he hadn't read but always wanted to, fine soaps, a sun-blade upkeep kit, new sailing gloves. They bought each other candles, incense, new stationary sets for their respective desks. Mermista pointed out matching sets of earrings, and Sea Hawk grabbed them without another word.

"I like when we match," he told her as they walked away. "It makes me feel like we're a team!"

"We are a team, dork." She'd laughed and kissed his cheek.

They ended up being accosted in the town square by the same gaggle of sailing students that Mermista had met at the school, and then after bringing Sea Hawk home. Eliza rushed up to Mermista, sneaking past her guards, and threw her arms around the Queen's legs. "Thankyouthankyouthankyou *thankyou!* "

"Uh, you're welcome?" Mermista pried the young girl's arms off her legs, waving away her sheepish guard. "For what? Eliza, right?"

"Yes!" Her deep emerald hair was braided into pigtails that bounced as she jumped. Mermista knelt down to her level. "My mommy, you brought her home for my birthday!"

"Oh, that." She blushed, fully aware of how Sea Hawk was looking at her. "It was no big deal, kid, don't even sweat it."

"It was the biggest deal! At least, to me!" Eliza grinned, and threw her arms around Mermista's neck this time. "Thank you, your maj'sty."

"You're welcome" sShe let herself hug the small girl back for a second, before standing. "Now, like, go play or whatever it is you kids do that isn't ever school."

"Yes, Your Majesty!" they all chorused, running away giggling and pushing and yelling. Sea Hawk sidled up next to her, wrapping a smug arm around her waist.

"Don't."

"I didn't say anything, dearest."

"You didn't need to, it's all over your everything."

"Oh, I see."

"Ugh! It was one little thing! Her ship was coming in for resupply the next week anyway, I just shifted some things around and had them dock a week early. They're already back out at sea, on patrol. No big thing."

“No, not at all.”

“Then *stop looking at me like that* !”

“I’m looking at you how I always look at you!”

“You- ugh! Whatever. Let’s go to the tea shop.”

“Yes, dearest.”

After their arms were laden with bags, which they gratefully handed off to her butlers once they arrived back at the castle, it was about time to get ready for dinner. They shared the shower, which Mermista was not typically one to allow as she was extremely particular about her routines. Sea Hawk still wasn’t quite over the scale of Mermista’s bathroom. It was bigger than most people’s houses, dominated by the large lagoon she bathed her tail in. Her shower was massive as well, enough room for them to stand well apart and not touch (not that that ever happened on the rare occasions they bathed together), a waterfalling shower head with excellent pressure raining down on them. The entire room was tiled in white, light teal, and gold. It should have been too massive to be homey, but the clear evidence of *Mermista* everywhere made that impossible. Mer-Mystery books left by the tub (notably separate from the lagoon and the shower, thank you), the vast array of face washes by the sink, the dozens of vials of soaps in the shower, the lingering scent of her perfume. It was all so her.

They dressed quickly, he in a formal kurta suit like he'd worn to Princess Prom, in a deep navy this time. Gold embroidery down the fitted bodice made it fit for a king, and she watched as he openly ogled himself in the mirror. He'd slicked his hair back, trimmed up his mustache, and even let her pluck his eyebrows a bit.

Mermista wore a lehenga choli in the same colors. She agreed with his feelings on matching, even if she would rather be caught in a fishing net than share the sentiment. It made her feel connected to him in a silly, public way, let the world know they were a package deal. Her hair was braided and bunned, and she was clipping in her set of the matching earrings when Sea Hawk came up behind her. He nudged around the pots and pallets and bottles on her vanity until he found what he was looking for; her favorite eyeshadow pallet and her pot of body shimmer. She met his eyes in the mirror. "You want me in those tonight?"

"You, yes." He rocked on his heels, almost shy. "Or maybe both of us?"

She grinned; he knew she loved doing his makeup. "Pull up the other seat."

Primer went on first; his skin was still in pretty rough shape after his months of non-stop sailing, despite the many face masks he let her put on him. She didn't have any concealer to match his skin tone for his eyelids, so she made do. He sat surprisingly still for her as she swiped on a blue ombre shadow, smoking it out at the edges. A soft cadet blue to navy with gold liner on each eye, and she pulled it together with some swipes of mascara. She put the same on her eyelids with practiced ease, before turning to the body shimmer.

“This stuff is like, super sticky, so sit very still.”

“I can do that!”

Mermista snorted, watching his legs bounce. “Uh huh. Let me go first.”

She dipped a finger into the iridescent goo, rubbing it over her hands before swiping it onto her neck, her cheekbones, the shells of her ears, her midriff, the backs of her hands. It was practically invisible in most lights, but when she turned the right way, it sparkled like her scales in the water. Satisfied, she turned to Sea Hawk. He jolted when the cold goo touched his skin, and giggled and squirmed when she got to his neck. “Mermista- ah!- it’s- *sngk* - stop tickling me!”

“I’m not trying to tickle you!” She was trying to maintain her scowl, but it wasn’t working out for her. “Stop squirming and it’ll be over!”

“That’s what she sai- *stop!* ”

She laughed as he wiggled away from her fingers. Eventually, she was content with what she got on him; his cheekbones, temples, jawline, and the deep v-cut in the fabric that showed off his toned chest, all shimmered like she did. They put on their shoes and she grabbed her clutch, and they made their way out of the palace. Maevik was escorting them, along with two other guards. He gave them both an approving once over and a subtle bow, before turning and leading the party.

The restaurant Mermista picked was an upscale restaurant on the roof of one of the coastal buildings, with a beautiful view of the ocean. There was a dance floor, a live band playing jazz all night long, and excellent drinks. One of their visiting diplomats had recommended it, and she hoped Sea Hawk liked it. It wasn't his usual vibe, really more hers, but he seemed open to new things.

They were seated immediately, in a private section tucked away from the main restaurant. Mermista tried to be as accessible as possible to her citizens, but tonight was about Sea Hawk, who was still adjusting to royal life. Speaking of…

"So…" Mermista crossed one leg over the other and leaned back in her chair. "How do you like being king so far?"

Sea Hawk spluttered, brushing off her comment. "I'm not king yet, dearest. I'm just helping with paperwork, and buffing up on history. And politics. And taking some etiquette classes. Oh, and getting fitted for new outfits almost constantly."

"Yep." Mermista smirked. "So, again, how do you like being king?"

He blinked owlishly. “Is that really what it’s like?”

“Pretty much. After you’re crowned, you’ll have to hold court with me, but that’s about it. Oh, and you’ll get your own seal.”

“Do…do the people know? That you're marrying me?”

“I’ve asked some of my courtiers and some of the staff who go into town to start spreading the rumor, softening the ground. The overall reception has been very positive.” She sipped her cocktail slowly. “You seem to have already built quite the relationship with Salineas, at least in the towns around the castle and ports.”

“Heh, well...” he shrugged modestly, mostly for show. “When one is as talented and lauded a sea captain as I-”

“Here we go-”

“...It’s rather impossible to not garner lavish praise and attention and dare I say a shanty or two-”

“I’d rather you didn’t dare.”

“-wherever I go. Besides, the people of Salineas clearly have excellent taste in supported royalty.” He nudged her foot with his. “Your people adore you, Mermista. And you them.”

“And you?” She neatly dodged the praise that made her flush. “Do you like the people of Salineas?”

Sea Hawk leaned back in his chair, watching the horizon. “Your people…our people, I suppose…are the most incredible nation I’ve seen in my travels. Helping one another seems to be everyone’s priority, and the sense of community here astounds me. I’ve never been anywhere else where people would invite you into their home and give you the clothes off their back if they felt you needed it. Maybe Plumeria. And the pride your people have for their home, their culture. Your navy is a testament to that; entirely volunteered, paid handsomely for their bravery, simply to defend their home, their family, from threat. It’s beautiful. Salineas is beautiful, and strong, and I’m honored to be their king. I’m honored to be given a chance to serve them in this way.”

Mermista was definitely *not* getting choked up, okay? She wasn’t. The sea breeze was just, like, super salty today, and totally getting right in her eyes. That’s why she was tearing up. She covered Sea Hawk’s hand with her own, joining him in looking at the horizon. “Good answer.”

He squeezed her hand, and they sat in comfortable, contemplative silence until their appetizers arrived. They shared small plates, Mermista indulging Sea Hawk and letting him feed her bites of whatever he wanted her to try. He let her feed him some of the odder Salinean dishes, raw octopus legs that were still moving, eel skin, sushi that one couldn’t find anywhere else on Etheria. Most of it he ended up liking, even if he was sweating bullets when she pressed the fork to his mouth. By dessert, her cheeks were starting to hurt from smiling, a natural consequence of spending an evening with Sea Hawk.

“So…” Sea Hawk thanked the waiter for his third whiskey, settling into his chair. “How come I get the king title, but if, say, Bow were to marry Glimmer-”

“Yeah, okay, ‘if’-”

“I know right? But, okay, when he marries Glimmer, he’ll be Royal Consort?”

“I’m not sure about Bright Moon’s laws,” she hummed, swirling her straw. “I studied them, but those aren’t, like, international or trade laws so, not really my area- but I think it has to do with, like, status prior to marriage and land ownership. You served in a royal navy, and you hold the title of Captain- technically Admiral, even though you deferred it- so you, like, have a status you are also bringing to the marriage? I think? Whereas Bow is Master Archer, which isn’t a position of service as much as a merit of honor. It's like… okay, so, in Salineas, the crown is viewed as the ultimate service to the people. You also gave the people your service, so we’re in the same ocean, if not the same boat. As for the land ownership, that varies in importance by nation.”

“I think I get it.” He nodded. “And why are Bright Moon and Salineas the only places with kings and queens?”

“Oh that’s, like, technical stuff.” She shrugged. “We’re all Princesses, but Frosta is an Empress, and Perfuma is a Chieftan, and Entrapta was, like, a Queen but also a president of city-states? Dryl confuses me, to be honest.”

“Ah, yes, Dryl,” Sea Hawk swirled his whiskey around. “Are you nervous for the…plan?”

“Nervous? No. Apprehensive about the overall cohesion? Yeah.”

“How is that different?”

“It just is.” She waved him off, and he chuckled. “So, lookout team, huh?”

“You and me, darling.” He toasted her with his glass before taking a sip.

“What do you think about that Flutterina kid?”

“Too young for the Alliance, that’s for sure.”

“Right! She was also, like, suuuuuper over-personal about the mermaid thing, what was up with that?”

“I hear you.” He nodded sympathetically. “I trust Glimmer knows what she’s doing, but this will be quite the trick.”

“Yeah…”

The horizon was growing dark as the day-moon set and the night-moon rose. The buildings and shops below them began turning on lanterns and lights, fountains glowing in the moonlight. In the distance, the Sea Gate glittered and glowed, blue light bathing the castle. Mermista sighed, content. Her kingdom was thriving in spite of the war raging on their doorstep, her people were happy and strong.

The band struck up a slow, crooning song, and Sea Hawk lifted her hand to his lips. “Dance with me?”

“...sure, why not.”

He led her onto the floor, the other patrons parting for their Princess and her rumored husband-to-be. It wasn’t a song that required much more than swaying, and holding your partner close, which Mermista was grateful for as the three strong drinks she’d had settled in her system. Sea Hawk pulled her close, one arm snaking around her waist and up her back, the other cupping her hand to his heart. She laid her head to rest on his shoulder, her heels bringing them to about the same height, her other arm around him. He swayed them to the rhythm, humming along in her ear.

She didn’t care that this was all but confirming the rumors she’d started among the people, didn’t care that by the next day, everyone would know she was with Sea Hawk. The eyes obviously on them faded to her subconscious, replaced by beautiful music and a warm embrace.

“I love you, Mermista.”

“I love you,” she murmured back. “Happy birthday.”

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Two weeks later, they were four days from Dryl’s siege. They’d all arrived at Bright Moon the night before so they could begin prep and training. Mermista had left her head advisor in charge, with Maevik supervising. She hated leaving her kingdom at such a volatile time, but when she had explained the situation to her advisors, they’d agreed that Dryl was too valuable a resource to not attempt to regain.

Nonetheless, she was feeling uneasy. Sea Hawk had tried to soothe her anxiety, but there was nothing for it. Maybe this afternoon sparring session would help. Glimmer had ordered it for the entire Alliance, claiming they needed to work on moving as a unit.

“We haven’t fought together as a whole in months,” she’d said. “It’s time to shake off the rust.”

So, in her usual armor, trident holstered to her back, Mermista stood in Bright Moon’s largest courtyard, leaning against a wall and waiting for Glimmer and Adora to show up. Sea Hawk was stretching beside her, in his usual attire as well. His sword was sharpened and shined, hanging loosely at his hip. “Wanna make it interesting?”

“Ooh, I do like a good gamble,” he groaned as his vertebrae popped concerningly. “What do you have in mind?”

“You really need to see a chiropractor,” she muttered. “Uh, how about… loser takes half the winner's stack of documents that are waiting to be signed.”

“Ugh, that would suck. You’re on.”

“And winner gets?”

“Hmmmm.." He stroked his mustache, thinking deeply. Mermista started stretching out her quads. “Winner gets taken out to a nice dinner and then they get to choose how the rest of the evening is spent?”

His heavy-lidded look was full of enough implication that Mermista couldn’t help but laugh. “Yeah, okay, whatever. You’re a dork.”

“So I’ve been told.” He shrugged, smiling. “Oh, here come Glimmer and Adora.”

The two came down the steps from the palance, body language tense and closed off. Perfuma made her way over to Mermista, and they shared a glance of concern.

Glimmer’s smile was brittle, strained. “Good to see you all. Let’s get started. Pair off into teams, start warming up with stretches and small bits of magic. Sea Hawk, Bow, can you two start stretching and sparring? I want you both pairing up with Princesses later.”

“Sounds good!” Bow yanked Sea Hawk away to a far corner of the courtyard. Mermista bet the two of them would have a lot of fun, while she was here.

“Where are Spinnerella and Netossa?” Perfuma piped up.

“They won’t be joining us for the siege, they’re staying to guard Bright Moon as my Seconds, and keep an eye on Horde movement across the Woods,” Glimmer said. “Now, Frosta and Flutterina, Adora and Mermista, Perfuma, you’re with me. Sound good for now?”

They broke off into their pairs, Mermista and Adora heading over to the large fountain in the center of the courtyard. “So, what counts as warm-ups in the Horde?”

“Well…" Adora rolled her neck. “We usually started with ten minutes of suicide runs, then another ten of endurance training, then half an hour of weight lifting, then sparring for however long the drill sergeants said.”

“Holy shit,” Mermista blanched. “Yeah, uh, no offense but I’m not doing that.”

“Well how do you warm up?”

“Honestly? I usually swim, like, a mile, and then just jump right in. I stretch, too.”

“Well, we can’t swim a mile here.” Adora frowned. “How about calisthenics and cardio?”

“Works for me.”

They chatted idly when they had the breath for it, in between sets of crunches, push ups, planks. They jogged around the courtyard, lapping Bow and Sea Hawk, who had decided to do the same, to much protest. They finished with stretching, which Adora proved to be less than stellar at.

“Seriously, how are you this stiff? It’s like you’re made of wrought iron.”

“I don’t know!” Adora wailed from her failed butterfly pose. “How are you so…floppy?”

“Half fish, I guess,” she snarked, pulling herself out of her folded position to stand and pull her leg up toward her head. “Swimming limbers you, and I’ve always been naturally flexible. Not like Perfuma, though, she’s, like, triple jointed.”

Mermista pointed to where Perfuma sat serenely in a complex knot, alongside Glimmer, who was looking very not zen.

Adora groaned. “Have I stretched enough yet?”

“I’m not your drill sergeant, dude.” She smirked. “I don’t care when you stop.”

“Okay, good, I’m stopping.”

Adora stood and brushed herself off before scanning her. “So, should we start hand-to-hand? Sword to trident? Water to She-Ra?”

“Whatever works for you. I’m gonna kick your ass either way.”

“Ha! Not likely.” Adora smirked.

“Guess we’ll just have to see, then,” Mermista yawned.

“Let’s start with trident and sword. Blade-to-blade combat is an area I’m rusty in, which is the point of all this.”

“Same here.” Mermista unsheathed her trident, tossing it from hand to hand and letting its weight settle in her hands, familiar. They took up starting stances. “Ready when you are.”

Adora was not a subtle woman, and she began without preamble, throwing herself at Mermista with a yell. Mermista dodged neatly, side stepping Adora’s lunge and hooking her trident’s hilt around her ankles and pulling hard. Adora tripped, but tucked and rolled out of it fluidly, bounding up and lunging again. Her sword came swinging down in a cleave, and Mermista brought her trident up to block it. The resounding *CLANG!* rang through the courtyard like a temple bell, sending her ears ringing. They grappled for a moment, a test of wills, until Mermista slammed both weapons down into the dirt, lashing out with her foot to kick Adora away. The ex-Horde soldier was faster than that, though, and seized her ankle, tossing her back and away. She landed roughly, but sprung up immediately, trident coming up on instinct. Sure enough, it met the sword mid-air as she parried it away, creating an opening. She wasn't going to actually stab Adora with the serrated prongs, but she feigned the hit, calling out "chest!".

Adora growled and brought the sword up to disarm her. Mermista barely spun out of the way, but Adora clipped her shoulder pauldron anyway, calling "shoulder!".

They stood, panting, assessing each other. "Care to add magic yet?"

Adora smirked, and raised her sword. "For the Honor of Grayskull!"

Mermista pulled the water out of the fountain, moving it around her in orbiting rings, like she'd seen in drawings of fabled other planets, acting as both defensive barrier and ammunition. Adora was moving before the glow faded, charging her again. Mermista grinned, finally feeling like she was on equal footing with her element surrounding her. She lunged out of the way of Adora's attack, lashing out a tendril of water to wrap around her ankle, yanking her leg out from under her and sending her flying into Glimmer and Perfuma's match. She winced. "My bad!"

"All good!"

“Please don’t maimm the She-Ra!”

Adora was none the worse for wear, up and shaking off the dust. “Nice hit, Mermista!”

Mermista was *not* going to blush at the compliment from the literal goddess warrior. “Thanks. You're a tough opponent.”

“That’s the idea!” She-Ra grinned, and then lunged forward. “Hyah!”

In one jump, she cleared the courtyard and knocked Mermista wide. She yelped, just barely getting enough water under her to soften her landing. Her hip still took the ground hard, and she winced. That was going to bruise, for sure. She grit her teeth and shook it off. Alright, no more kid gloves.

Adora was charging again, but Mermista stood her ground in her path. When Adora leapt, Mermista pushed all the water around her into Adora, knocking her back and down into the ground. She kept the deluge up for a second, and then released, pulling the water back to idle behind her. Adora sat up, coughing and spluttering, soaked to the bone. “Shit, dude.”

“I know, right?”

Adora shook herself off, and got back to her feet. This time she didn’t charge her, but circled, considering. She feinted Mermista a couple of times, trying to goad her into attack. Eventually, Mermista got bored of whatever strategy this was, and brought the water back to rush around her in rings. She began punching hard, sending bursts of water out at Adora, who scrambled to dodge. She nailed the goddess a couple of times, knocking her back but not stopping her.

Adora growled, annoyed, and turned the sword into a shield so she could rush Mermista without being hit. When she got close, Mermista swung out with her trident, metal crashing into metal. Adora parried her with the shield, kicking out through the opening she’d made. Mermista tried to block her with the water, but Adora slammed through it, nailing her in the ribs.

Winded, grounded, Mermista held a hand up. Adora trotted over and slapped it. “I think that’s a good warm-up spar, don’t you?”

Mermista just coughed, waiting for her lungs to take in air again. When they did, she groaned. “My god, dude, I don’t know how we haven’t won this war with you packing that much heat.”

“Aw, thanks, ‘Mista!” In a flash, She-Ra was gone, replaced by Adora, who rubbed her neck sheepishly. She leaned down and hoisted the other princess to her feet. “That means a lot.”

“Nicely done, you two.” Glimmer’s voice made them both turn. The queen was crossing the courtyard, covered in pollen and petals yet still effortlessly regal. “But, Mermista, you were holding back.”

“Uh, yeah, this is a spar, not battle.” She flicked her damp braid over her shoulder. “I’m not gonna drown She-Ra, we kinda need her.”

“Still." Glimmer frowned. “Go harder. If anyone can take it, it’s Adora.”

Adora scowled down at the grass, but said nothing. Mermista watching the tense moment pass with benign, curious interest. “Riiiiight, got it. Are we switching now?”

“Yes. Whoever you’d like to spar with next, go for it.”

Unbidden, her eyes slid over to Sea Hawk, who had since shucked his jacket and was using his red bandana to mop sweat from his brow. Bow stood panting next to him, both glistening with sweat and laughing. “Yeah, sure, sounds good.”

“Another hour and then we’ll break into doubles, okay?”

“Yep.”

“Uh-huh.”

“Sounds good.”

Frosta accosted Glimmer, while Perfuma and Adora headed off together. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Flutterina making her way over to Sea Hawk. *Oh, hell no* . She picked up her trident and whistled, low and cooing, like a dove. The pirate turned at once, eyes searching for her, and wasn’t that a fun little power trip. She tossed her head in a ‘c’mere’ motion, and he lit up like a beacon, snatching his sword and trotting over to her. He brushed past Flutterina, who watched him go with a pout.

“You called, m’lady?” He swept into a goofy bow, snatching her hand up.

She yanked it back, face burning. “Ugh, don’t be weird,” she was definitely blushing, but whatever. “Wanna spar?”

“Of course!” He bounced up, unbothered. “Should I have worn my trunks?”

“Nah, you get so whiny when I try to drown you. Weapons only.”

“As my Princess commands.” He winked.

“I did not command!”

“Ah, my mistake.” He smoothed his hand over his mustache, hiding a smile. Was he making fun of her? Jackass. “Shall we?”

They took up ready stances. Sea Hawk had learned informal, but effective swordsmanship from his grandfather, and then from pirates, so while he’d never pass for a royal knight, he knew how to get the job done. Sword held loosely in a sturdy hand, legs planted but on his toes, ready to jump. Mermista preferred a wider, more grounded beginning stance, letting her weapon’s weight speak for itself. Both metaphorically and literally, the trident was heavy, with sharp bladed teeth and a bludgeoning hilt. Sea Hawk still had the starburst scar on his left temple to prove it.

They sized each other up, shifting, settling, honing focus. Sea Hawk’s fingers twitched first, and Mermista sidestepped his sudden swing, parrying his blade away with the front of her trident. With the back, she aimed for his sternum, but he was too quick, spinning away from her and disengaging their blades in one. She pursued, following his footwork with sure steps until she could drop and kick out at his ankles. She clipped one, bringing him crashing down. She stood quickly, planting one foot firmly on his chest, kicking his sword out of his hand with the other and bringing her trident to his neck. “My point.”

He panted gently, barely winded under her. “Well done, my love.”

“Shut up.”

She hauled him to his feet, not letting go of his hand yet. She tugged him closer to whisper in his ear. "New rules; winner of this match gets whatever they want later."

His breath hitched. "You mean…?"

"I do." She ghosted her lips down his chin, making sure no one was watching too close.

Sea Hawk's eyes were dark, roaming her body with renewed interest. "Well, then. Shall we?"

"Loser takes point."

They reset, this time circling one another. They were familiar with each other in this way. They sparred regularly, for various trophies or just for sport. It got Sea Hawk's energy out, and focused her mind when everything was just too much thinking and not enough doing. Fighting came naturally to both of them, having been raised at war. Sea Hawk fought like he danced, fluid, with rhythm and passion and a certain fire that was so distinctly *him* . Mermista fought like the ocean; sure, steady movement, grounded and yet never still. She could take hits that most couldn't, and deal back blows twice as hard.

But Glimmer was right, she tended to hold back. Maybe it was because she knew the power her element had, had seen ships dashed on rocks, watched hurricanes tear apart the coast, seen tidals waves taller than mountains. Her gifts were a fine line between beauty and destruction; water gave life as easily as it took it, her mother had taught her, and it was never to be disrespected or misused. The ocean was the most powerful force in the world, and she was lucky enough to be granted a fraction of its power. That wasn't something to be taken lightly.

Sea Hawk feinted, and Mermista fell for it, lost in her head. She staggered her footing for only a second, but it was enough for Sea Hawk to beat her trident out of the way and hook a heel around her ankle, knocking her off her feet. When she hit the ground, his foot was on her wrist, pressing until she dropped her weapon, and his blade was at her neck, just tracing her jaw.

"My point, dearest."

"Ugh." She flopped against the cobbles. "I was distracted."

"And so you lost!" He chirped, offering her a hand up. She took it and dusted herself off, kicking her trident back into her hands. He was staring at her with mild concern. "Alright there?"

"Yeah, I dunno, just head stuff." She waved vaguely at her brain, shrugging. "I'm fine. I just gotta focus." He nodded, letting it go and resuming his start. She mirrored him.

She began again, on purpose this time. She struck at his feet harshly with a yell. Sea Hawk startled violently, jumping backwards and landing oddly. He stumbled, but caught himself too quickly for her to press the advantage. She thrust for his chest, and he barely blocked it with his sword, grunting as his forearms flexed, straining to hold back her attack. She had the advantage, pressing in with two hands and her full strength, which was comparable if not greater than his. He held her off for two more seconds, faces so close in the grapple that she could see the flecks of hazel in his onyx eyes, watching his aggravated breath move the hairs of his mustache. He snarled, and gods was *that* a sound that went straight to her core, and circled her blade down and out of the way.

The force knocked both their weapons aside, but Mermista was ready. She kicked high, hitting him hard in the shoulder. He went sprawling to the ground, but was up in a flash, flipping out of a handstand and swinging back at her, hard. She ducked the punch, grabbing his arm as it went by to flip him over her shoulder, but he planted his feet and threw his weight in the opposite direction, throwing them both to the ground. Mermista grunted as Sea Hawk tossed her over, attempting to get her in a headlock. She wrapped one leg around his, pushing back with her ass to break his grip. She succeeded, and he attempted to get to his feet.

Oh no you don't! Mermista pushed out of her half squat, throwing herself headlong into Sea Hawk's abdomen and taking him down *hard* . Hands grabbed her wrists, steel covered in calloused skin, while she dug her knee into his thigh. He shouted in pain, and twisted her wrist outward until she cried out, and released the pressure to his leg. With his grip, he flipped them over, on top of her and trying to apply pressure to her neck. Playing dirty, she snapped at his nose with unnaturally sharp teeth, grinning when he yelped and reeled back. She flipped them over, yanking her hands from his and pinning his above his head. One knee on his thigh, the other digging into his side, she leaned down, barely an inch from his face.

“My point?”

He struggled for a few more seconds, before sighing and going all but limp. “Your point.”

She smiled, and pressed a fast kiss, blink-and-you-miss-it, to his nose. “Sorry about that.”

“You play dirty.” He pouted. “Shark teeth is cheating.”

“You like it,” she taunted. “Admit it.”

“No.”

“Baby.”

“Cheater.”

“Loser.”

“Sore winner.”

“Whipping boy.”

“Oh, dearest, not in public.”

Someone cleared their throat, and they froze before Mermista scrambled off of him, getting to her feet in record time. Their friends stood a few yards away, expressions ranging from amused, to grossed out (Frosta), to impressed. Mermista felt herself blush to the roots of her hair, while Sea Hawk brushed himself off. “Mermista won.”

“Oh we could see that.” Glimmer smirked. Behind her, Adora coughed into her hand.

“I’m going to throw myself off this balcony.” Mermista groaned.

“Nope, you have to do doubles first!” Perfuma smiled serenely. “Then you can throw yourself off.”

“Square deal.”

“Alright!” Bow clapped, thankfully taking the attention off of them. “Doubles time! Perfuma, you and I are up first. Who wants to take us on?”

“We will!” Frosta and Flutterina cheered, high fiving and running into position. Bow and Perfuma followed suit.

“Who wants to ref?”

“On it!” Glimmer teleported onto a floating stone just above the courtyard. “Begin on my command.”

Mermista sat on the fountain, replenished from the aqueducts, to watch, face still burning. Sea Hawk sat a bit away from her, sensing she needed the space. She couldn’t believe she let herself get so carried away like that. And in public! Yeah, sure, they were sparring, but not at the end…

“Hey." Adora broke her train of thought, sitting down beside her. “You guys were really impressive! I’ve never seen two people fight like that, it was like watching a dance. Are you gonna partner for doubles?”

“Uh,” Mermista stammered. So they had all been watching the fight? And not just the end? “I- I guess, yeah.”

“Cool! Glimmer and I will take you on next!”

She turned to Sea Hawk, who was failing at pretending not to listen. “That cool with you?”

“Hm? Oh, sure! I mean, if that’s cool with you?” His eyes searched hers, looking for any signs of ire or overwhelming anxiety.

“Yeah…” She tapped his hand with her finger, the most she could do at the moment. “Yeah it’s fine.”

They turned back to the match, which was becoming a melee brawl. Much of the ground was frozen, and where it wasn’t was being corroded by ferns and vines secreting a noxious acid. Flutterina was pinned by two vines, while Bow’s feet were frozen to the ground. For every volley of ice bombs that Frosta launched, Perfuma raised another layer of flora shielding. The plant princess didn’t have a scratch on her.

“She’d be unstoppable if she’d just attack once in a while.” Mermista sighed to herself. Adora nodded next to her.

“Perfuma’s a beast,” she agreed. “She just fears her own strength.”

“She saved my ass in the Fright Zone,” Sea Hawk added. “When push comes to shove, she’ll attack.”

“Only for her loved ones.”

“Then let’s be grateful we’re all on such a prestigious list.”

Adora nodded, fingers drumming nervously on the stone. Her sword was back on her wrist, a golden vambrace shining in the sun. Mermista thought she seemed tenser than usual, more on edge. She wondered if it would impact her fighting.

A shout on the battlefield grabbed her attention away. Perfuma had Frosta constricted in a nest of vines, twisting tighter and tighter until the young girl yielded. She was placed soundly back on her feet, unharmed save for her ego. Bow was thawed out, and Flutterina freed. Glimmer hopped off the rock. “Match goes to Perfuma and Bow. Next?”

The three of them stood from the bench, stretching and cracking bones. The four on the field high fived them as they swapped, going to take their place on the designated bench. Glimmer materialized her staff, and Mermista whipped her trident out of its holster. Sea Hawk pushed his sun-blade to half power, giving it a few test swings. Adora took a breath, and summoned the Sword of Power. “For the Honor of Grayskull!”

Bow took over as ref from his spot on the sidelines, counting them off. “Ready, set…BEGIN!”

Mermista, feeling maybe slightly petty, immediately slammed Adora with a jetstream of water that blew her clear across the courtyard. Glimmer blinked away, and she felt the crackling of the atmosphere behind her that meant *magic* . She spun away, whistling sharply, and Sea Hawk jumped in, swinging directly into the spot Glimmer teleported to. Taken off guard, she only half-blocked the blow, gliding away a few feet from the force. Metal met metal as sword and staff parried, thrusted, and traded off blocks and attacks. Mermista refocused on She-Ra, now rushing her with the force of a stampede. Gathering water underneath her feet, she propelled herself into the air, flipping over the charging bull that was She-Ra. She whistled again, warbling, and Sea Hawk back-flipped away from the queen. Like she'd planned, Glimmer and Adora collided, sending each other sprawling.

As the two younger women recovered, Mermista pushed water under Sea Hawk's feet and brought him closer to her. "Not bad for a first improvisation. What now?" He panted

"They're not working together well," she murmured. "We need to exploit that, keep them separate."

"Well, I'm no match for Adora, but I'm fast enough to at least keep up with Glimmer. Kind of."

"Let's do that. Draw Glimmer's fire, I'll exhaust She-Ra. Then, we switch to finish."

"You have such a beautiful mind." He sighed, lovestruck.

"Thanks, now *duck* !" She pushed Sea Hawk's head down and moved out of the way of the sparkle-bomb that was aimed at their heads.

Bow whistled from the side. "Hey! No head shots!"

"Sorry!" Glimmer did not in fact sound sorry. She sounded rather mad.

"You know what to do. Go."

Adora, with her head made of literal stardust and concrete, was back on her feet like nothing happened, bouncing on her toes and swinging her sword in delicate arcs. "Nice play!"

"Focus, Adora!" Glimmer snapped before teleporting away.

Mermista smirked, pulling the new batch of water in its totality out of the fountain. "Thanks, 'Dora. Let's see what you've got." With a grunt of effort, she hurled the water overhead and down before sweeping up like a strong wave. Adora planted her feet and sliced the water with her sword, parting it around her body. Not a bad strategy, but water wasn't so easily knocked off path. With a flick of her wrist, Mermista reconnected the twin streams behind She-Ra, boxing her in. Surrounded by fast moving water that hit like a sack of bricks, Adora paused, frowning. Mermista tightened the circle, pinning her arms.

“Give in?”

“When have I ever? HAH!” With one solid punch, Adora broke through the current, charging her. Mermista attempted to dodge, but the warrior clipped her hip with an elbow, sending her flying. She cushioned her blow, landing in a bubble of water and hitting the ground unphased, save for her pinging hip bone. This time, when Adora charged her, Mermista threw the bubble at her, lifting the eight-foot woman off her feet and into the air. With a toss of her arm, she sent Adora flying again.

She turned to check on Sea Hawk. He was holding his own against Glimmer, but not with nearly as much success as she was having with Adora. He fended off bludgeoning attacks with his blade, and dodged spells that were flung his way. He jumped, rolled, and spun with the grace of a bird, but she could see he was wearing out. They had to wrap this.

Adora was tiring, too. She wasn’t charging Mermista anymore, instead staying away from her and sending out energy pulses with her blade. She deflected them all, catching them in water and redirecting them out. With another flick, the water rushed Adora again, knocking her to her knees. She was slow enough to get back up this time that Mermista knew they could switch off. Two sharp whistles in succession, and Sea Hawk’s back was to hers. “Ready?”

"As ever!"

They traded sides, Glimmer's and Mermista's magic colliding mid air, sparkles dissolving in water, water burning at the touch of white-hot moon magic. Trident met staff, sparks flying off the weapons. Mermista pressed in, using her height to her advantage, but almost falling on her face when Glimmer teleported away. She caught herself, throwing water behind her to cover her back while she corrected, and heard a grunt as it made contact. She continued to hurl jet after jet of water at the queen, giving her no time to do anything other than teleport away to dodge. Two whistles caught her attention, and she made her way over to Sea Hawk, backs together.

"Switch again?"

"Yes, please, Adora's got a second wind."

It continued like this for moments more, Sea Hawk and Mermista trading off opponents, keeping them separated and wearing them down until Mermista could finish it. The final blow came when Adora swung with all her momentum, sending her and Sea Hawk crashing to the now muddy ground. His blade was knocked wide while Adora held hers tight, and raised it above her head to deliver the final faux-blow. She never got the chance, as Mermista caught her in the abdomen with a whip of water, grabbing her and hauling her off Sea Hawk. She flipped She-Ra head over heels above her, and sent her crashing into Glimmer. The two women went skidding in the mud, and didn't get up until Glimmer called out their yield.

Mermista dashed over to Sea Hawk, helping him to his feet. They were both well bruised, and singed with magic in places, but they high-fived and shared a smile that made their eyes crinkle with pride. Beating She-Ra and the Queen of Bright Moon was no easy feat. They shook hands with Glimmer and Adora, who were staunchly not looking at one another. "Good match. You guys were no joke."

"That win was clean!" Adora smiled. "Impressive stuff. You two work well together, you'll have to teach me that whistling thing."

"Pirate's code! Very useful to know." Sea Hawk winked. "Any time you want to learn, come find me."

Glimmer just smiled tightly and walked off to Bow, who glanced between her and Adora with unease. Mermista narrowed her eyes; interesting. She and Sea Hawk moved to take their seats as the teams mixed and matched. Glimmer and Adora went up again after a short rest, facing off against Bow and Perfuma. Mermista busied herself with drying out the ground to an acceptable level, turning mud back to damp soil and siphoning clean water into the fountain. Sea Hawk was cleaning his blade next to her, humming a shanty to himself. Mermista scowled at her shoes, they were caked in mud.

The afternoon dragged into night; Bow and Perfuma emerged victorious among them all, beating Sea Hawk and Mermista by a slim margin. An impressive maneuver with a shock arrow used Mermista's water against her, and she grudgingly had to admit it was a genius move. They all retired to a quiet, exhausted dinner, and then to their rooms. Mermista scrubbed the day's sweat and grime away, and was practically asleep by the time Sea Hawk joined her. He fell into bed, both of them clad in sweats and tank tops; they typically slept bare in Salineas, the humidity and familiarity of home making most sleep clothes excessive. Here, the air was cold and the room was strange, so they picked matching pajamas for the trip. “Good day, dearest?”

“I’m bone tired,” she yawned, backing up so her black was flush to his front. His arms curled around her, drawing her even closer as he spooned up to her. “You were great out there.”

“Thank you,” he murmured. “You said winner gets what they want tonight, and that’s you.”

Mermista snorted. “This winner wants a night of dreamless sleep and a lazy morning.”

“I think that can be arranged,” he brushed a kiss to her shoulder. “Good night, love.”

“Good night, Sebastian.”

Chapter End Notes

Next: the fall :(

if your world falls apart (i’d start a riot)

Chapter Summary

> /For your love, all you are
> I’d start a riot/
>
> The Fall of Salineas

Chapter Notes

> Well. Here we are. I had. So much fun writing this chapter in the worst way. I am so happy with it. But so sad we’re here. Enjoy, in a weird sort of way.
>
> Song for the chapt: Start a Riot by Banners

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The sky was beautiful. The bright fuschias and blues of the day-moons was being eaten up by the incumbent night, the ombre to navy a watercolor tapestry in the sky. Most nights, in Salineas, there wasn’t much pink in the sky at the turning of the hours, the changing of tides. The pink moon that hung full and swollen over Bright Moon and Plumeria didn’t reach their skies in the late summer. But tonight, the sky was bleeding. Angry, burning red; choking the night sky until it screamed for help. And it was screaming…

Wait, no, that was her.

Mermista stood from her knees and ran for the edge of the platform, but her legs gave out before she could make it. Arms around her waist…Sebastian? No, these were less sure. She thrashed against them, screaming until her throat was raw and all she could do was sob.

Her home…her kingdom… *her people* -

“Please, no, *please* -”

“Mermista!” Someone was calling her name, but they sounded so far away… “Mermista! We have to go, they’ve seen us!” A Horde ship had turned around in the debris-riddled water below them, raising a canon to aim at the rock they stood on. “Glimmer!”

“No!” She tried once again to wrench herself from Bow’s grasp. “Please, they need me, I have to-”

“Mermista!” Adora’s hands were on her shoulders, straining to hold her back. “There’s nothing you can do! If you go down there, you die.”

“Then let me!” she sobbed.

Adora’s grip slipped in her wide-eyed shock. Glimmer grabbed them all around the shoulders, and in a blink, the smoking wreckage of what was left of her kingdom was gone. They materialized back in Bright Moon’s war room, surrounded by friends and-

“Sebastian-”

Bow let her go as Sea Hawk surged forward to grab her. She collapsed into his arms, shaking soundlessly with rage, grief so potent that she could feel the ocean miles away tossing furiously in its bed.

“Well, well, looks like all went according to the plan-”

She wasn’t thinking, she didn’t need to. Not for this. She’d never been surer of anything in her life. Mermista reached for the knife Sea Hawk always kept on his lower back, for emergencies, sliding it out of its sheath and ripping out of his arms. She threw it overhead, a perfect graceful arc and watched with perverse glee as it sailed through Glimmer’s barrier and into Double Trouble’s shoulder. They cried out and fell forward, hand ripping the blade out and trying to staunch the blood flow.

“Mermista!” Glimmer and Perfuma ran to the prisoner. “They’re our only lead.”

“I don’t care!” she roared, ready to pull the sea out of the bay and send it pouring down their throat. “ *I’ll kill you, you slimy, sadistic fuck* !”

Hands were back around her waist, struggling to hold her back from the carnage she promised. She reached out with her magic, trying to grab onto whatever water she could but the room was bereft of it. She could only feel the blood coursing in her friends’ veins, and that was too far for her, even in her desperate state.

“Mermista, love, please.” Sea Hawk sounded as angry, as broken, as she felt, but it wasn’t enough. She needed Double Trouble to hurt like she was. “They’re not worth it, I beg you.”

“I don’t care, I don’t care, I’ll kill them, I don’t care-” Her vision was starting to tunnel, tears of grief and rage blocking what little vision she had left. Faintly, she heard Sebastian call out for Perfuma. Then, there were hands on her neck, the smell of something fragrant and sweet like the blooming orchids in the gardens of her home. Finally, darkness, and dreamless sleep hit her like a courier ship, and all was blessedly silent..

– - – - — - - -

Sea Hawk felt Mermista go limp in his arms, whatever sedative Perfuma had conjured going straight to work. He adjusted his grip, hoisting her dead weight into his arms. He didn’t dare let go, not even for a second. He had seen Mermista in many dark moods, been the cause and recipient of more than half of them, but nothing like this- this blind anguish, a bottomless grief that howled and hungered for revenge.

He looked up at the room, now silent, all avoiding eye contact. “Is it true? Is…Is Salineas…?” The thought was too terrible to finish.

Bow nodded, tears in his own eyes.

“It’s gone,” he whispered hoarsely. “Rubble, all of it. All that we could see at least, along the coast by the castle. The ports, the- the market, the castle… Sea Hawk, I’m so sorry.”

He couldn’t pass out, not now, not holding Mermistsa, but it was a damn near thing. He fell to his knees instead, burying his face in his Princess’ shoulder. Tears had been leaking out of his eyes since they teleported back, but now his shoulders shook with force. He felt Bow hit the ground next to him, dragging him into a hug. Perfuma wrapped her arms around him and Mermista, crying just as hard as he was.

Glimmer finished patching up Double Trouble, turning to the huddle. “We won’t let this stand. We *will* take back Salineas, we *will* defeat the Horde. I swear it.”

“There’s nothing to take back,” he spat bitterly, daring to lift his eyes and glare at the queen. “It’s gone.”

“Then we’ll rebuild.”

“People? You’ll rebuild people?” He barked a harsh laugh. “You can’t rebuild the dead, you- you can’t take back lives that have been lost because they dared to exist during a war they had no choice in!”

Glimmer was resolute. “We will make a new world, so that their losses aren’t in vain.”

“It’s not enough.”

“It’s all we have.”

He knew he was right, but he was sick, sick with grief, with anger, with another loss so vast and absolute it left him adrift. He couldn’t wrap his brain around it…Salineas couldn’t be gone. “I need to lay her down.”

Glimmer nodded, wiping her eyes. Bow helped him stand, and Perfuma followed them out. Frosta trailed behind, looking like she wanted to help but didn’t know how. Sea Hawk knew she looked up to every single princess as an older sister, and he was touched that she wanted to help Mermista. Mermista…

His love slept on in his arms, utterly limp. His heart broke for her, his warrior of a queen. She had already been through so much. There wasn’t anything the war hadn’t taken from her; her mother, her childhood, her confidence, her father’s loyalty and love, and now, her home. Her kingdom, her lifeblood. She’d put so much into Salineas; her love for her people was resolute, obvious in everything she did.

She still has you. Don't let her down.

They arrived at the room they'd been staying in for the past few days, and Sea Hawk placed her down gently on the bed. Mermista frowned in her sleep, briefly, before her features smoothed out once again. He hoped she wasn't having nightmares. There was a hand on his shoulder, and he turned and saw Perfuma.

"We should get her into something more comfortable."

He nodded, and set about taking off her armor plating. The shoulder guards came off first, then the metal belt, then her vambraces. Her nail polish was chipped, he noted to himself. She hated that. Bow was untying her shoes, while Perfuma rummaged through Mermista's bag for sleepwear. Frosta hovered by the door, looking smaller than he'd ever seen her. He nodded to Mermista's bag.

"Frosta, could you get me her hairbrush?"

The girl jumped to action immediately, the task seeming to ground her. Bow stood from the bed, letting Frosta take his seat.

"I'm going to check on Glimmer and Adora," he said. "I'm sorry Sea Hawk, but with Mermista out of commission for the moment, we'll need you in the War Room as soon as possible."

“Me?” He blinked dumbly. “I’m not Mermista’s second.”

Bow’s eyes were full of sympathy. “I think, as of right now, you kind of are. If Mermista’s second hasn’t made contact by now…we have to assume the worst.”

“Right.” Sea Hawk blinked back tears, thinking of Maevik, the advisors and handmaids and diplomats who had grown to be so kind to him over the years. “On the outside chance…has anyone heard from Mercia?”

Perfuma scoffed under her breath. Bow winced. “I’ll let you know if we do.”

“Alright. I’ll be along in a minute.”

Frosta had started brushing out Mermista’s braid, focused on her hands so resolutely she wasn’t blinking. Perfuma patted the girl on the shoulder. “I think you’re good, Frosta.”

“What is she going to do?” Frosta looked up at Perfuma, eyes wide and…scared. “What are any of us going to do? This is the nightmare, *the* doomsday scenario. One of us losing our kingdoms. What happens now?”

Perfuma swallowed. “I- I don’t-”

“Is she still a Princess? What happened to the Pearl? What if they destroy it?”

Frosta’s fear was contagious, and Sea Hawk felt what little grip he had of his emotions slipping. He looked to Perfuma as well, begging her to have answers.

“I- I don’t know, Frosta- I’m sorry-”

“Of course she’s still a Princess,” All three turned to Adora, standing in the doorway. She looked impossibly tired, fatigued in a way Sea Hawk struggled to comprehend. “No Princess left behind, remember? Mermista is one of us. And we’re going to help her however we can, in whatever way she needs.”

Frosta nodded, and Sea Hawk felt his own hackles lowering. They weren’t alone. “Thanks, Adora.”

“Uh, I kind of need to talk to Sea Hawk and Perfuma alone, now. Boring grown up medical stuff, privacy, all that.”

It was a testament to her fragile state that Frosta didn’t even huff, merely nodding and hopping off the bed, handing the brush to Sea Hawk as she left. Adora sat down on the bed, taking one of Mermista’s hands. Perfuma frowned. “Adora?”

“She, um. When we were up on the platform, and- and we saw the Sea Gate…it was bad, guys. Really, really bad. The water was full of debris. Wrecked ships, I think maybe even bodies…it was dark, and hard to tell. But something in Mermista snapped. She… she…”

Sea Hawk felt bile climbing up his throat, and he rearranged himself so Mermista’s head laid in his lap. He watched the rise and fall of her chest, counting the breaths. “She what?”

“She wanted to jump. And I told her that if she did, she would die. They’d spotted us, they saw Mermista. They were aiming right at us, and she- she told us to let her. Die, i mean. She wanted to die.”

He shut his eyes as Perfuma choked on a gasp. He wasn’t surprised, not really. Maybe that was worse; he should be horrified. But he’d suspected for a long time that Mermista’s opinion of her own life wasn’t very high. He’d never have considered her suicidal, and he wasn’t sure if he did now, either, but he knew that she had always been oddly resigned to the idea of a coup. Oh, love…

Perfuma had her hand in an iron grip, tears streaking her face. “No…no she wouldn’t…”

“It was a bad situation,” Adora muttered. “The worst, really. It… happened sometimes. In the Horde. When a siege would fail, or someone screwed up, and the idea of being banished to Beast Island or facing Hordak was too much…”

“I’m going to be sick,” Perfuma bowed her head and swallowed thickly. “Mermista would never-”

“She might,” he spoke, finally. Perfuma’s head snapped up. “Mermista’s been fighting an uphill battle with herself since she lost her mother. Salineas was everything to her…I think in the moment, she felt it was an equal punishment to her perceived failure. At least, that’s how she was raised to think.”

Perfuma was incensed. “If I ever see Mercia again-”

“That’s a long line you’re going to be waiting in.” He smiled without humor. “I have first dibs after, well, Mermista. For now, we need to let her rest while she can.”

Adora nodded. “You get her changed, and then I’ll sit with her while you’re in the War Room.”

“No, I’ll stay,” Perfuma said. “You’re needed more than I am right now.”

“I don’t think Glimmer feels that way.” Adora’s eyes were downcast, staring at the hand that held Mermista’s.

“Tough shit.” Sea Hawk shrugged. “We need a strategist if we’re going to figure out evacuations.”

Adora nodded again, and the two women made their brief exit. When the door shut, Sea Hawk let himself crumble. He slid down to lay next to Mermista, pulling her tightly to his chest. She was so limp, and so still, it felt like-

No. Don’t think that, don’t you ever even think that .

He muffled his sobs in her neck, her hair, pressing teary kisses to every available inch of skin. “I love you so much, so, so much, Mermista. Please, don’t you ever think this was your fault. We need you here… *I* need you here.”

There was, of course, no response. She slept on, momentarily unaware of the nightmare waiting for her to wake. He nuzzled his cheek to hers, holding her as close as humanly possible for one more second. Then, he pulled back, dried his eyes, and set about getting her comfortable. He carefully pulled off her top, her neck guard, her leggings, her panties. He left her bra on, unsure if she’d feel comfortable without it when she woke up. Next, he snapped off her ear cuffs, placing them gently on the bedside table. He rolled thick, warm socks onto her feet, kissing each calf and knee. Next, the oversized flannel pants she loved to sleep in when they visited Bright Moon. Lastly, he grabbed a long, oversized tunic, threadbare and soft, from his own bag, and slid it over her head. It had been her favorite since one of their first sleepovers; she’d stolen it out of his rucksack because it smelled like him. He left her hair loose, she said sleeping with it tied back gave her a headache, and tucked her under the blankets. Sea

Hawk leaned over, pressing light kisses to her forehead, her eyelids, her nose, the corner of her mouth, and finally her lips.

“I love you endlessly,” he murmured. “I’ll come back when you wake up.”

He shed his blue jacket, and left it next to her. As an afterthought, he yanked his red bandana from his neck, and left it on the nightstand. In case she needed something for her tears. He was sure there would be more. He left the room before he could change his mind, resolutely not looking back at her. Perfuma and Adora were talking in hushed, furious tones when he opened the door, and stopped abruptly at his appearance. Perfuma nodded to Adora, then him, and then went inside, shutting the door behind her. Adora gestured wordlessly with her head, and they set off.

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“The Horde focused their attacks along the coast of the main island. As far as we can tell, the smaller city-states in the archipelago of Salineas haven’t been hit…yet. Attempts to contact Prince Peekablue of Sunset View and Princess Sweet Bee of Cobalt Bay have been unsuccessful.”

Sea Hawk rubbed a hand over his brow. “What’s the level of casualties we’re dealing with?”

Glimmer grimaced. “Right now, civilian casualties have actually been minimal. Reported, only about twenty, somehow. The naval forces however… I think we’re looking at nearly one hundred.”

“Stars,” he breathed, sitting down heavily. “How. How could this have happened? The navy has been on red alert for almost two months! They were ready for this.”

“From what we’ve managed to get out of Double Trouble, Hordak and Entrapta have put together some sort of photon cannon,” Bow said, looking over the reports. “It’s like nothing we’ve seen before. A sustained beam, instead of the bursts we see from bots, that can cut through anything in seconds? If the navy had seen them coming, which I’m not sure they did because it was sundown, they didn’t stand a chance, Sea Hawk. They would have been sunk before they could even turn and fight.”

Sea Hawk dropped his head into his hands. “The coast is lost, then. What about the inland cities and villages?”

“Untouched, so far. We’ve dispatched troops there, on skiff and ship, to sound the evacuation alarms. With luck, we’ll beat the Horde there.”

Adora frowned. “We have to assume they’re already moving inland to raid and…recruit.”

“Recruit?” Frosta frowned. “No one will go willingly to the Horde.”

“Children,” Glimmer sighed. “Babies, infants, orphans. The Horde will take them, just like they took Adora.”

“And Catra, Lonnie, Rogelio, Kyle…” Adora looked defeated. “Until there’s no one left to stand against them.”

Sea Hawk cleared his throat. “I’d like to talk about evacuating those trapped in the rubble, along the coast. They won’t be able to escape without us, and if they can’t run, they’ll die. With Netossa and Spinnerella, and She-Ra, we could do it. Get the majority of them out.”

Bow frowned. “That’s risky. But I agree, we have to try.”

“I want to go.” Glimmer stood.

“No!” Adora and Bow shouted together. Adora took the lead. “You’re too valuable to the Horde. Seeing you there will only further endanger the people, because Hordak will stop at nothing to get you.”

“But with my teleportation, we can move twice as fast!”

Sea Hawk let them bicker back and forth while he studied the map in front of him. He could get his ship out, move it up the coast and come in from behind. The estuaries and currents that connected mainland Etheria to the ocean provided a natural defense system, not to mention the rip currents and whirlpools that cropped up almost daily. That’s why the Sea Gate only defended the south. Still…he had to try.

For Salineas. For Mermista.

He nodded Bow over, and showed him the route. Bow jotted it down, following along closely. “Sea Hawk…I don’t know if you should go.”

“What? Bow, I have to go.”

“You’re only one man. Let the princesses handle this. Mermista needs you here.”

He grimaced. “How about we leave it to Mermista? This is still her kingdom, she’ll have final say in the rescue party.”

“That’s agreeable.”Bow sighed. “I’m just…worried we’re spreading ourselves too thin here. I can’t keep everyone safe.”

“Bow, like you said...” He clapped the younger man on the shoulder. “They’re princesses. Let them keep themselves safe.”

“I don’t roll like that.”

“I know,” he chuckled. “That’s why you’re such a good leader.”

Bow blushed, and opened his mouth to reply, but was interrupted by the opening door. Perfuma stood in the entryway, Spinnerella and Netossa behind her. The wives sprinted into the room, dressed in their usual armor instead of their earlier formal wear. “We came as soon as we heard. Is Mermista alright?”

No one answered, looking down at the floor. Sea Hawk glanced to Perfuma, who waved him out of the room anxiously. He jogged to her. “What is it?”

“The draught wore off. She’s awake, and…she’s not doing well. I’ve done everything I can, Sea Hawk. Anti-nausea herbs; she vomited when she woke up and it all…hit her. Sedatives, but they haven’t done a thing to her, the adrenaline is too high. I’ve tried muscle relaxants, cooling herbs, everything, but she’s blocking my magic with her own. She needs you.”

“Stand in for me here, aye?” He gave Perfuma a brief, strong hug, eternally grateful for this woman who loved Mermista as much as he did, in her own motherly way, and took off at a sprint. When he reached the room, two guards were stationed outside, on alert. He waved them off, waiting until they were down the hall to open the door.

The room was completely destroyed. His boots splashed through an inch of water covering the tile, his shirt quickly soaked by the bubbles suspended in the air, like the room was holding its breath. The bed was dry and empty, his jacket missing, too. Glass and wood chips from the shattered mirror, armoire, and light sconces crunched quietly underfoot, muffled by their watery grave. He checked the balcony first, and, against his wishes, the ground below it. Both blessedly empty. The bathroom held more broken glass, and porcelain, where the tub had taken a massive blow; half of one side had been smashed into bits, the rest of the tub following bit by bit under gravity's order. Sea Hawk swallowed. He'd known Mermista was powerful, but between this and the sparring match, he was starting to reevaluate just *how* powerful.

"Mermista? Dearest, it's me."

Nothing. He stopped, listening intently. When Mermista was panicking, she made herself small. Water soothed her, and muffled her sobs, and she fled to it when she was distraught. He turned to the waterfall shower, and slid the glass door back, suspiciously still intact. Water flew out at him immediately, knocking him back to the bathroom door. Found her.

He coughed and spluttered, heaving himself upright. "Sorry to disappoint, love, but you're not getting rid of me that easily."

She kept the deluge up, a steady stream of water from the overhead fall pouring out of the shower door, obscuring and blocking the entrance to her hiding place. He took a deep breath, and walked directly into the stream. It was like swimming up river in a rainstorm, but eventually he was able to grab the reinforced glass and pull himself through. The river stopped, doubling back until it bubbled around the curled up form of Mermista, huddled in the corner of the shower.

She was in the fetal position, head tucked into her knees with her hands clasped over her head. He could see her nails digging into her scalp from where he stood. She was rocking, whether manually to self-soothe or from the weight of her heaving sobs, he didn't know. He stepped closer, kneeling down and reaching into the bubble. He felt the water grow almost unbearably cold around him, just before the point of freezing (which she told him she couldn't do, despite having tried for years), but he pressed on until he could touch her arm. She tried to throw herself away from him, but there was nowhere to go as she was already pressed into the corner. Sea Hawk decided that maybe tough love was the only way to go, and wrapped his hand firmly around her forearm to tug.

"Mermista, c'mon, love, it's just me. You don't need to hide from me. Perfuma's gone, they're all gone. It's just me. Just me." He repeated it like a mantra until she relaxed enough that the water dropped out of the bubble. She looked smaller without the water, shivering in the cold air. He could hear her choked sobs, almost like heaving, and if Perfuma hadn't reassured him she had dosed her with anti-nausea meds, he would have assumed she was going to be sick.

Sea Hawk hauled her into his lap, still curled in her ball, and tucked her head under his chin. He didn't dare move, he knew she wouldn't leave the shower until she was ready, so he couldn't bring her to the bed. So, he resigned himself to sit there with her. He stroked her loose, wet hair, rubbed her bare arms where he could feel goosebumps rising. After a few long, silent minutes, he began to hum, and then sing softly, slowly.

" *I wish I was on yonder hill*

'Tis there I'd sit and cry my fill

Till every tear would turn a mill

Is go dte tu mo mhuirnin slan

I'll sell my rock, I'll sell my reel

I'll sell my only spinning wheel

To buy my love a sword of steel

Is go dte tu mo mhuirnin slan"

He repeated the only two verses he could remember of the old Snows' lullaby. Eventually, maybe half an hour later, Mermista uncurled enough to tuck her face into the side of his neck. She released the vice grip she had on her calves, folding her shaking hands against his chest. Warm tears trailed down his collarbone, but her sobs were subsiding into something more manageable.

She could take in air now, if only to cry harder, louder. Occasionally, he felt her teeth against his skin when she couldn’t help but scream her anguish into his neck, unadulterated rage so pure he could almost taste it. The water around them thrashed, tiny whirlpools and cyclones forming and dissipating with each breath. He let himself cry with her, chest shaking with muffled sobs. Their tears rolled off her jaw, falling to the water below as one.

After what felt like an hour, and maybe it was, Mermista had run out of tears and energy. She was limp against him, uncurled and boneless. He stroked her hair back from her damp cheeks, daring to pull her head away from his neck. Her face, beautiful and regal but utterly shattered, broke him.

“Hello, love.”

“Sebastian…” Her voice was raw, scratched to hell and back. Her golden eyes were glazed over, far away. “We lost Salineas.”

“I know.” He tucked more hair behind her ear. “I know.”

“I…I tried to-”

“I know.”

“I’m sorry.”

“It’s alright.”

“Is it?”

“It is..”

“I…” She searched for words, vacant eyes darting around the room like they would materialize. “I lost…we lost…everything.”

“Not everything.”

She didn’t acknowledge his assurance. “How…how do I go on.”

“I…don’t really know. One bit at a time, I suppose. Together” He adjusted his numb legs. “You’re still a Princess, still queen. When you’re ready, we go back, and we rebuild. Reclaim. Make new. All of us together.”

She picked at the fraying hem of his shirt, listless. He gave her time to collect her thoughts. “I want to kill them.”

“Double Trouble?”

“Yeah.”

“I do, too.” His voice, deep and angry, made her raise her gaze. “You got a head start, though.”

“Oh, right,” she mumbled. “That was…yeah.”

“Vengeance is…slippery. We’ve seen what it’s done to Glimmer, to her and Adora. But you’ve lost so much, my love. I would think you mad if you didn’t want blood.”

“I keep thinking about my dad.” She changed the subject suddenly. “Whether this would have happened if he was still around.”

“I think...” He picked through his words carefully, “that with Mercia on the throne, such a travesty would have been a sooner inevitability, rather than the blinding shock this is to all of us. You are a wonderful queen, Mermista. You did everything you could have, and then some. We were betrayed.”

“It’s still my fault.”

“It’s not.”

“I wasn’t there.” Her ire was rising, and it was almost refreshing to see in place of that vacant melancholy. “I wasn’t there to help them. I was here, playing a *stupid, childish game* .” She clawed at her hair, tugging it so harshly in self-loathing that he feared for her scalp.

He tugged her hands away from her hair, trying to speak over her hateful stream of consciousness. “You were trying to help. And, in the end, you were right about the traitor, too-”

“I wasn’t there, *I should have been there* -!”

“Mermista, if you had been there, you would be dead!” he all but shouted. His voice bounced loudly off the walls, and she flinched. He cursed himself; he hadn’t raised his voice at her in so long, and he had never meant to again. “You would be dead. And…I can’t think about that. You’re all I have, and maybe it’s selfish of me, but I’m glad you were here with me.”

Her head was tucked back against his chest, but he heard her sniffle. “I’m sorry.”

“You have nothing to be sorry for, and I’ll tell you that for as long as I need to.”

“It’ll be forever, because I don’t think I’ll ever stop blaming myself.”

“Forever with you? Sounds like paradise to me.”

“Ugh.” Some of her old self crept back in. “Sap.”

“Always. Now, please, let me bring you to bed.”

“I need to clean up first. I kind of wrecked the place.”

“I noticed. Here, c’mon.” He helped her to her feet, wrapping an arm around her waist when her legs buckled. With a flick of her hand, the water from the floor of the bedroom and shower went cycling down the drain. She used a bit of it to collect the glass, wood, and porcelain shards and put them in the ruined bathtub. With another wave, they were dry. He helped her climb into bed, getting in next to her.

“Are they meeting in the War Room?”

“Yes, and they will be for a while. We have to plan the evacuations.”

“I should be there.”

“Right now, you need to rest. Do you want me to get Perfuma? She can knock you out again.”

“No, that’s alright,” she yawned, shaky with lingering tears. “I’m exhausted from that humiliating display of emotion.”

“Mermista-”

“Chill, I’m mostly kidding.” She burrowed into him, hands creeping under his shirt to leech his warmth, legs tangling with his. “I’m glad that you’re here, too. I couldn’t…If you’d…”

He knew what she meant. He tilted her lips up to his, kissing her softly. “I love you, dearest. We will get through this. Somehow.”

“I don’t see how,” she sighed, shutting her eyes. “But I trust you, or whatever.”

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When Mermista woke up, she almost couldn’t open her eyes. They were swollen and sore, reminders of what had transpired. She sat up, glancing around when she realized she was alone in the bed. There was a note on the nightstand next to Sea Hawk’s bandana.

Mermista,

Got called back to War Room. Perfuma should be with you.

Love

She looked around in confusion. Perfuma? She was alone-

Humming from the balcony interrupted her thoughts. She pushed herself out of bed and followed the sound to find Perfuma growing flowers, vines, ferns, whatever she could conjure, along the railing and trellises. She stopped when Mermista stepped into view.

“Mista! You’re awake!” She crossed over, but stopped short of giving her the usual bone-crushing hug. “How do you feel?”

“Like shit.” She winced; her throat was raw. “I need to go to the War Room.”

“You need to shower and change first, then get some food in you. Maybe tea. Can you… is it safe for me to step out and get food while you dress?”

Perfuma had this way of looking at people that said she knew everything, but wasn’t going to throw it in your face. It was sympathetic, but laced with steel. It was impossible to lie to. “Yeah. I’ll be fine. I’m…sorry for scaring everyone.”

“Absolutely no one blames you, honey.” Perfuma did hug her now, cradling her like she was something precious. It made her want to vomit again. “We’re here for you.”

Where were you before Salineas fell? Where was your aid then? Her mind screamed. She pushed those thoughts away. They weren’t constructive, or fair. It was the grief speaking. “Thanks, ‘Fuma. I’m gonna shower now.”

She didn’t linger in the shower, scrubbing herself down efficiently and using her magic to rinse. The memories of last night, of Sebastian holding her close, were too strong. Sebastian… the fear in his eyes when they teleported back, the grief in his own tears. Even when she pushed him away, he found a way to get to her. Stupid, loveable, selfless idiot.

Mermista had never been prone to separation anxiety. In fact, she preferred being alone most of the time. But now, without Sea Hawk at her side, she felt oddly exposed. Incomplete. Open to attack. She dressed quickly in her armor. She was snapping the vambraces on when Perfuma reappeared with a tray.

“Oatmeal, and chamomile tea with honey for your throat. I don’t want to give you eggs or meat with your system so off balance.”

“Thanks.”

They were quiet as she ate. Perfuma braided her hair in a fishtail, the warm tingling behind her telling Mermista that she was weaving flowers into the design. She didn’t have the energy to fight her off, so she let it happen. She ate about half the oatmeal before her stomach protested, and she pushed the rest away. The tea went down easier, soothing her throat.

“There!” Perfuma tied off the braid. “Nothing too flashy. I know you don’t like bright flowers, so I put some baby’s breath and apple blossoms. They blend nicely. I just…wanted you to have them.”

Mermista said nothing, but turned and pulled her best friend into a tight hug. “Love you, ‘Fuma.”

“Love you too, ‘Mista.”

They walked to the War Room together, her trident in hand. It wasn’t necessary, but it gave her strength in an intangible way, like the adamant that formed the hilt was seeping into her bones, holding her up. The room was packed when they got there, generals and the princesses and Sea Hawk and Bow all huddled around the table. She gasped when she saw-

"Maevik!"

"Mermista!" Her captain of the guard stood so quickly that his chair toppled over with a bang, but he paid it no heed as he sprinted to her. He grabbed her in a crushing embrace, one she dropped her trident to return, decorum be damned. His eyes were wet when he pulled back. "Thank the stars, you're alright."

"You got out- how did you survive?"

Maevik dabbed his eyes with his sleeve, stooping to grab her trident and hand it to her. "Forgive my theatrics, Your Majesty," he tried to apologize, but she waved his words away. "Right. Come, sit, and we'll tell you."

"We?"

She noticed, then, that many of the generals and advisors in the room wore Salinean blue and gold. At her notice, they bowed deeply. One stepped forward. "We made for Bright Moon as soon as we could, your highness."

"Please, sit." She waved off their formalities. "I'm just glad you're all alive."

Sea Hawk stood from his chair as she approached, and she touched his shoulder gratefully. He stood to her side, as near as the chair allowed, and she relaxed a bit. She noted that most of the generals and advisors here were not the ones she usually met with, rather their seconds or thirds. Her heart sank at the implications. They took their seats, and Maevik began the debrief.

“We were able to evacuate the capitol on extremely short notice, perhaps an hour at most before the attack. The primary defense line, the *Calypso’s* fleet, were able to get out an SOS flair and radio before they were sunk. We saw the flair, and began evacuation. By the time we got the transcript, we had the markets and ports as clear as possible. Most of the ships were able to cast off and get out of the warpath. They took whoever they could; women, children, mostly. The militias fled inland to get to the more rural towns, and, ideally, get them over the mountain and to the mainland. We haven’t heard from them in twelve hours. At eight PM SST last night, the Sea Gate was breached, and the Horde took Castle Salineas. Per your orders, the sorcerers sealed off the throne room during the evacuation.”

“Thank gods,” Glimmer breathed, slumping in relief. “Good thinking, Mermista.”

She nodded. “I just wish it hadn’t come to that. Continue.”

“We sent deep sea messengers to the other city-states, and to the mainland territories to brace them for refugee impact. We have yet to hear back from the messengers, or the city-states. However, our latest intel reports that Prince Peekablue has been AWOL since five pm SST two nights ago.”

“That little fucking coward,” she snarled. “He knew.”

“That…is the current assumption, yes.”

“I want him found, and I want him arrested. Whatever two individuals you can spare, send them immediately.”

“Yes, Your Highness.”

“Is that really a priority right now, Mermista?” Adora frowned. “Vengeance-”

“I want his farsight,” she interrupted. “And I want answers. Two invaluable resources at the moment.”

“Fair enough.” Adora sighed.

“So,” Maevik sighed. “That’s the rub of it. Salineas is currently fully occupied by the Horde. We have to work on evacuation, and getting the last of the civilians away from the Horde.”

“Right.” She nodded. “Who’s volunteering?”

All of her generals, and Maevik, stood. Bow, Spinnerella, and Netossa raised their hands, and Sea Hawk cleared his throat beside her. “I’d like to accompany them, dearest, if that’s alright with you.”

It’s not . “Fine, but don’t be a moron.”

“No promises!” He winked. She rolled her eyes.

Her (now head?) general stepped forward. “We’re going to take several personal vessels up the straits and estuaries, and evacuate the towns left along the water. After that, we move inland.”

Mermista nodded. “I want bi-hourly reports, and diversified body counts. Grab what resources you can as well, for the refugee camps.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

She dismissed them to the docks, and they bowed and exited.

Maevik stopped by her chair, leaning down to murmur in her ear. “I’ll keep an eye on our would-be King.”

“See that you do. And Sea Hawk, keep an eye on our head guard in return.”

“Yes, dearest.”

Maevik spared her a smile, and followed the Salinean forces out. Spinnerella and Netossa stood as well, and she rose to thank them. “I’d go if I could-”

“Hell no, girl!” Spinnerella frowned. “Stay here, recover your strength. We heard you did a number on the guest room.”

Mermista flushed while Netossa slung an arm around her. “Besides, they need you to do all that official queen shit, resources and all that. Let us handle the leg work.”

“Thank you both, so much.”

“It’s no problem.”

They left, and Mermista took the chance to walk Sea Hawk out the door.

“Dearest?”

“I swear to the gods above...” She leaned in, speaking through gritted teeth, “if I hear of any heroics, any swashbuckling, any adventure or derring-do, I will divorce you the *second* we get married. Understand?”

Sea Hawk swallowed, hard. “Yes, Your Majesty.”

“Correct.” She grabbed him by the lapels of his jacket, and hauled his mouth to hers for a searing kiss that left her mind blissfully blank.

His hands found her hips, pulling her body into his while she ran her tongue along his lower lip. He groaned softly, letting her in, and she reveled in the taste of him; strong coffee, mint, and something earthy that was just pure Sea Hawk. His mustache tickled her cupid’s bow, and she would rather die than admit she loved it. They broke apart, panting ever so slightly, staring into each other’s eyes.

“Don’t you dare leave me.”

“Never.”

“Good.” She kissed him again, just because she could. When they separated, she quickly tied his bandana back around his neck. His good luck charm. “Now go.”

He hugged her one last time, almost lifting her clear off her feet, before he took off down the hall. Maevik had been waiting for him in the archway, back turned to give them privacy. Together, they made for the docks.

She took a steadying breath, and made her way back into the War Room. “Alright, talk to me about collaterals.”

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It was only after about five hours of arguing semantics about refugee camp setups, resource allocation, and retaliation theories (because without a headcount on the navy, they couldn’t organize a retake of the country), that they noticed Glimmer was gone. And an hour after that, she reappeared.

Along with Sea Hawk, Netossa, and Spinnerella.

Adora hit the ceiling. “Is that where you went!”

“Yes! I told you they needed me.”

“They didn’t need you, they had it under control!”

“Oh yeah?” Behind her, Sea Hawk suddenly looked very panicked. “Without me, we’d be down a pirate. So, suck it, Adora.”

“What.” Mermista swiveled to glare at Sea Hawk.

It was Glimmer who answered. “Yeah, he almost got blown up by a tank in the name of adventure. The usual. More importantly, we saw Hordak. And that ray gun is no joke, it’s attached to his arm-!”

Whatever else Glimmer was saying faded away, as she and Sea Hawk stared each other down across the room. Finally, she pushed away from the table. “Alright, I’m going to go rest for a bit. I have a headache coming on.”

She turned and left the room without waiting for a response. The clicking of heeled boots behind her told her she was being followed. “Mermista-”

“Not now, Sebastian.” She turned a corner.

“Mermista, wait-”

“I said not now!”

He had longer legs than her, and caught up to her at the end of the hallway. “Mermista, please let me explain.”

“You have sixty seconds, and let *go* of me.” She ripped her arm from his hands, feeling only a little bad at the kicked-puppy face.

“I was trying to save these two kids, and they looked so scared, so, yes, I was hamming it up, and I got carried away, and then we were surrounded and that’s really not on me, and then I got a little blown up-”

“I could kill you.”

“-and then Glimmer got us out! That’s it. I’m sorry I let you down.”

“You didn’t- ugh!” she groaned. He looked so fucking sad, it was unfair. “You didn’t let me down, alright? You saved Salinean citizens, and kids, and you deserve a commendation that you will get after this stupid war. I am furious with you for being a goof during an evacuation, though, as is my stars-given right.”

“That’s fair.”

“When will you learn, dude?” she sighed, leaning against the wall behind her. “You have so much potential to be this amazing guy, this amazing leader, and every time I think you're getting it, you go and goof off and almost get yourself killed."

"I'm sorry."

"I know you're sorry." She took his hands. "But right now, everything is a little bit too much, and I need some alone time."

"I understand."

"I'll talk to you later."

"Alright." He watched her go, calling out before he could stop himself. "I love you."

"I love you, too." She glanced back. "I'm still pissed at you, though."

Sea Hawk nodded, and she turned the corner. He sighed, scrubbing a hand through his hair and resisting the urge to punch a wall. Nothing for it, he thought. He'd let her cool off. Not that that would break her out of this haunted funk she was in, plagued by shock. Gears in his head were working overtime as he rolled the thought around in his head. How could he help her snap out of this? By the time he made his way back to the War Room, he had a half-formed plan in his head, and most of a note to Bill ready to be written.

Chapter End Notes

:(

(Sea Hawk’s song is Siúil a Rún. The Ella Roberts version is gorg)

whenever this world is cruel to me

Chapter Summary

> Post BNO shenanigans and conversations

Chapter Notes

> Smut in this chapter that I entirely forgot to highlight and can’t go back and edit bc my phone is throwing a BF. So be warned.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“You know, when I said I needed alone time, I meant, like, give me an hour for a bath. Not get yourself kidnapped by the Horde.”

They were back on his ship, sitting on crates and barrels of recovered Salinian resources from the evacuations. Sea Hawk had the good graces to look abashed, rubbing the back of his head with his hand. “I’m sorry, I know you said no grand gestures, but I didn’t know what else to do-”

“Relax, I’m not that mad,” she chuckled. “You were actually, like, right.”

“I was?”

“Don’t get used to it.” She smirked, ruffling his hair. “But, yeah. I needed to get out of my head, and be reminded of what this is all about. Rescuing people *is* my jam, and I’m tired of moping around.”

“You weren’t moping, dearest-”

“Regardless, I’m done with it. It’s time to take action.”

Sea Hawk smiled at her, thrilled to see her fighting spirit back in force. “What do you have in mind, dearest?”

“Always with the pet names.” She rolled her eyes. “I want to join the refugees, and take back what we can. I can’t abide just sitting around Bright Moon anymore while they’re out there struggling. I’m their queen, and if my people are homeless then so am I. I’ve never asked them to do anything I wouldn’t before, and I’m not going to start now.”

Sea Hawk didn’t think his admiration for her could grow anymore, but here he was. Awestruck yet again by a new facet of Mermista. “Then we’ll find them. I think Maevik and the other generals are with them, so we can track his location to find where the majority of the people are holed up.”

“Sounds good. We’ll stop at Bright Moon to let the others know, organize contacts and the paperwork, collect provisions.”

“I’ll work on tracking down Maevik.” Sea Hawk went to stand, but Mermista reached out and grabbed his arm. “Dearest?”

“Ugh, just…” She was blushing, and avoiding eye contact. “Thank you, for today. You were great out there. You punched, like, ten Horde soldiers.”

“You mean ten *hundred* Horde soldiers!”

“Don’t push it.”

He decided to push it anyway, ducking down to give her a kiss. She smiled into his lips, hands coming up to caress his jaw. He could feel Bow’s eyes on them, so he pulled back a bit. “Love you,” he murmured.

“You, too.”

He took his leave of her to go to the wheel, where he’d left his datapad. Bow followed him up, looking a bit…lost.

“Hey, um, can I ask you a question?”

Sea Hawk looked at him briefly. “Always, lad!”

“How do you…do it?”

“Um, what?” He quirked a brow at the archer. “Bit personal, eh?”

“Wha- NO! Not- not that!” Bow’s voice cracked in panic, and Sea Hawk laughed. “You and Mermista are, like, always fighting or arguing. But you’re still always together. And you just kissed her.”

“Hm, yes, I did, didn’t I?” He smoothed a hand over his mustache and winked at Bow. “We communicate, Bow. Sure, sometimes that comes in the form of arguing, but that’s just because we both tend to care a good bit about making the other see our own point of view.”

“Yeah, I was afraid you’d say that,” Bow sighed, leaning against the wheel housing and crossing his arms. “Adora and Glimmer are fighting. And they won’t talk.”

“Ah. That’s difficult, I’m sorry to hear it.”

“I don’t know how to fix it.”

“Oh, that’s easy. You can’t.”

Bow whipped around to look at him. “W- what?”

“You can’t fix other people.” Sea Hawk shrugged. “If they won’t talk, or work to resolution, then there’s almost nothing you can do. You can be there for them, if they want to talk. But you can’t fix their issues for them.”

“But…” The younger boy frowned. “That’s what I do. I fix things. I help people, and- and I’m a great friend!”

“Being a great friend doesn’t mean taking on everyone else’s burden’s because they refuse to carry them.”

Bow huffed, and looked away. Sea Hawk’s eyes drifted to Mermista, unbidden. She was leaning against the railing of the prow, staring into the waves they were cutting through. He could stare at her all day and never grow bored, he had decided long ago. Like she could feel his eyes, she looked up and met his gaze. She didn’t smile like she did when they sailed alone, but her eyes crinkled at the edges and she winked. He grinned back.

“Get married already!” Bow snorted next to him, shaking him out of his daze.

Sea Hawk smiled, sheepish at being caught. “Working on it, lad.”

“Wait- really?”

“Uh…” Oh fuck, he wasn’t supposed to- okay, he could figure this out. “I mean, in the abstract, sure? Isn’t that where relationships end up? Or they break up, and we did that already-”

“What!”

“Hm, this isn’t…going as planned.” Sea Hawk frowned, eyes fixed on the horizon. “Don’t worry about it, Bow. It’s personal, and all that, you understand how Mermista is.”

Bow looked like the last thing he wanted to do was drop it, but he did because he was cool like that. “So what’s next for you guys? With Salineas and all.”

It still felt like his chest had been ripped open and pillaged for spare parts at the mention of their once beautiful nation. “We’re going to join the refugees, and help however we can. Neither of us were built to sit around when there’s hard labor to be done.”

“That sounds like Mermista’s whole M.O., to be honest.”

Sea Hawk chuckled. “Make no mistake, it usually is. But not when it comes to her people.”

“Glimmer’s the same way.” Bow smiled. “She always preferred to get her hands dirty, boots on the ground with the rest of the Rebellion.”

“Incredible women we’re blessed to know, eh?”

“Yeah…”

They lapsed into a comfortable silence, and it wasn’t long before Sea Hawk was maneuvering into Bright Moon’s harbor. Adora and Glimmer were off the ship before it even docked, Glimmer teleporting away as soon as they were near land, Adora hopping off the second she could hit wood and not water. Bow groaned, and shrugged helplessly. “Go on, lad, I’ll be fine here.”

“Are you sure?”

“Off with you.” He shooed Bow down the gangplank, kicking the anchor housing as he did to drop it. Mermista was tossing the mooring lines down to the dock hands, so he busied himself with lowering and securing the sails. There were clouds lingering in the distance, and while he loved a good risk, he didn’t feel like buying new sails at the moment. Or a mast. They tended to be on the pricier side.

“Ready?” Mermista was leaning against the door to the cabin, waiting for him. “We have one more night in a real bed for who knows how long, and I intend to take full advantage.”

“A good night’s sleep is always important, yes.” He smiled at her, and she quirked a brow at him. Her smirk was sultry, her eyes half lidded- *oh* . “Ah, ahem. And so are, ah, extracurriculars-”

“Oh my gods, shut up,” she snorted, breaking eye contact to roll her eyes. “You’re such a dork.”

“I aim to please, dearest.”

They made their way to the castle, discussing supplies, provisions, the route they’d take. “Sea Hawk, I’m telling you the Siren’s Blood current is going to be so much faster-”

“Absolutely not,” he scoffed. “Grotto’s Gateway is the best route-”

“If you want to get us shot.”

“Oh, please, what are you scared of? Pirates?”

“I’m sorry, did you hit your head and forget what we literally just finished saving your ass from-”

“Scurvy and Mila and Humbert are going to be stuck out there for at least three more days, so unless we run into Falcon-”

“Okay, who didn’t you hit, quit, and commit arson against? Because my list is now, like, two pages long-”

“Sea Hawk! Mermista!” Adora was jogging toward them. “You’re leaving?”

“Uh, yeah, sorry.” Mermista shrugged. “There’s more we could be doing out there, so…”

“I understand, just, can you stay one more night? I’m going to find Madame Razz and ask about the superweapon and we may need to call a meeting and if you’re out in the wilderness we won’t be able to get to you-”

“Yes, okay, sure,” Mermista cut her off. “Uh, travel safely?”

“Thanks!” Adora took off again, heading for the Whispering Woods.

“Did that make any sense to you?” Sea Hawk tilted his head.

Mermista groaned. “Absolutely not, and way less than usual with her. I’m too tired for this, c’mon.”

She led him back up to their room, firmly pushing all thoughts of Adora, and crazy old ladies who she'd never actually met, and super weapons out of her head. At one point they passed Glimmer and Shadow Weaver, and Mermista firmly did not make eye contact. She didn't approve of this whole Dark Magic thing Glimmer was trying out, but that wasn't her business. Glimmer was an adult, and Mermista was no mage, so who was she to be vocal about it (you know…outside her private conversations with Sea Hawk and Perfuma).

They locked the door behind them, letting the door guards know they were in for the night. Mermista flopped onto the bed, feet hanging over the edge. "You know what I miss?"

"What's that, dearest?" Sea Hawk was sitting at the vanity to unlace his thigh highs.

"The lamb marsala kebabs from the bazaar. The ones that Miriam would sell every other Sunday?"

Sea Hawk moaned at the thought of them. "You're making me so hungry."

"Think we'll ever get to have them again?" Mermista's voice was quiet, tinged with palpable sadness.

"I do." When she turned to look at him, he nodded firmly. "I really do. Your people are strong, Mermista. This war *will* end, and they *will* rebuild. And it will be beautiful, and grand, and better than before.” He came to lay next to her, feet bare, and she tangled her fingers with his.

“Our people.”

“Hm?”

“You always say ‘your people’. You’re gonna have to shake that eventually.”

“Oh, heh, right.” He smiled sheepishly. “I just…forget. A lot. It still doesn’t feel real. Maybe it never will.”

“Being king?”

“And getting to marry you.”

“Ugh!” She rolled over. “I’m gonna get cavities.”

Sea Hawk chuckled, kissing the back of her head before standing. “Well, I’m covered in bar scum, salt, sweat, and horse smell thanks to Adora’s giant friend there, so I’m going to shower.”

“Without me?” Mermista rolled back over, stretching provocatively.

Sea Hawk swallowed. “Uh, I didn’t- didn’t say that, w-would you like to?”

“What would you do if I said no?” she quipped, standing and kicking her shoes off.

“Cry, I guess.”

She laughed, and he pulled her close, kissing along her jaw and down her neck. He ran his tongue flat over her sensitive gills, and she shivered, inhaling sharply. Her fingers came up to fist in his hair, and he busied himself unclipping her armor plating. It fell to the ground loudly, but he was too focused on pressing bruising kisses to her throat to care. Her other hand fell to the laces of his pants, loosening them with one hand- a well practiced move. She didn’t wait to push them down all the way, instead shoving her hand into his underwear and stroking him. He jolted, startled, and she chuckled low in her throat.

“Dearest-”

“Sshhh…” She kissed him hungrily, biting at his lower lip and pushing her tongue into him when he moaned. She pulled away quickly, leaving him dazed. “Allow me.”

She dropped to her knees, bringing his trousers and underwear down to his ankles with her. He stepped out of them shakily, and kicked them away. Mermista was pressing kisses along the fronts of his thighs, trailing her tongue along the softer skin around his groin. One hand stroked him, the other coming up to cup his balls, rolling them gently. He groaned, one hand falling to grab the back of her hair. “Fuck, darling-”

Mermista looked up at him, copper eyes smoldering. She held his gaze as she took him into her mouth, swallowing around him until he was fully in her, touching the back of her throat. Her eyes watered, but she moaned around him in pleasure. The vibrations cut right to his cock, and he thrust slightly against her, prompting another moan. Together, they moved, Mermista working him in and out of her throat while he gripped the back of her head and thrust in tandem, fucking into her mouth. Her nails dug into his ass, pulling him deeper, and it wasn’t long before Sea Hawk was cursing and grunting, fingers twisting harshly in Mermista’s hair. “Dearest, I- I’m-”

She just nodded as much as she could, ready for him. Not a second later, his hips were jerking into her mouth of their own accord, deeper, deeper until he came down her throat. Mermista swallowed around him, the sensation heightening his orgasm until he had to pull out, oversensitized. Mermista coughed and gasped, and he helped her to her feet. He crushed her mouth to his, moaning when he could taste himself on her tongue. “You’re the most incredible woman.”

Mermista just smiled, kissing him again. He picked her up, not breaking the kiss, and carried her to the bathroom with her thighs around his waist. She flicked the shower on with her hydrokinesis, and he set her down to finish stripping. They undressed each other with fast, practiced ease, stumbling into the shower where Sea Hawk pressed her against the wall. Kissing his way down her body, he pressed her breasts together, sucking and biting the soft skin there until she was moaning. He loved leaving hickies on her wherever he could, as many as he could get away with. There was something about it, marking her and claiming her, that brought him endless pleasure and satisfaction. Maybe it was that she was an ethereal, magical being that should have been entirely unattainable, a borderline goddess, and here he was, making her moan and scream and beg for more. And he knew Mermista enjoyed it even more, if that was possible, even if she did have to restrict where he could leave them.

Mermista pushed at his head, moving him down, and he placed one more kiss to her nipple before dropping to his knees. He lifted one of her legs over his shoulder, and steadied the other with a firm hand on her ass. Sea Hawk pressed kisses to her center before running his tongue up the length of her sex, drawing a deep moan from her. He gently sucked her clit into his mouth, and she cried out, fisting a hand in his hair and rocking her hips against his. Sea Hawk set a fast, unforgiving rhythm, exactly how she liked it. Mermista tended to prefer sex on the rougher side, and he was never opposed to indulging her. He moved his hand off her ass, and eased first one, then two fingers into her sex, curling them forward into her g-spot and pumping. She moved to cover her mouth with a hand, but he grabbed it with his own. He pulled away briefly to look at her. “No, I want to hear you.”

“Sebastian-”

“No one can hear, not with the water on.” He had paused his hand to speak to her, but moved it again now, cutting off whatever protest she had with a cry. He worked his fingers in and never-fully-out of her, rubbing against the soft spot deep inside her that made her legs shake. He held her gaze until she nodded, and then moved his mouth back to her clit.

“Ah! Fuck!”

He grinned against her, tongue working overtime to keep up with his fingers. He could feel her walls tightening, and worked a third finger into her heat. She sobbed, groaning openly into the air and yanking his hair hard.

“So close- I’m so close, please, *please, don’t stop- don’t stop- yes, yes, right there!* - *AH!* ”

She came hard around his fingers, warm fluid running down this throat and wrist, but he didn’t let up as she rode him through it. Her hips rocked against him, chasing her high with violent abandon. When she stopped pulsing around him, he knew she was at the end and slowed his pace until she tugged his hair twice in rapid succession. He stood, pulling his fingers out of her gently and sucking them into his mouth to clean them off. Mermista was slumped against the shower wall, eyes half-shut as the water resumed its regular action. “How are you so damn good at that?”

“I’m damn good at *you* ,” he grinned, leaning in to kiss her softly. She smiled against his lips, hand reaching down to lazily stroke his reinvigorated cock. He groaned, pressing his forehead to hers. “We still haven’t actually washed, dearest.”

“Ugh, fine.” Mermista let go, reaching for the soap. “But then I want you to bend me over.”

She said it so casually he almost didn’t register what she said. “I-I- uh, yea-yeah! Yes, absolutely, dearest-”

She laughed at his expense, and he reveled in the sound. After tonight, who knew when she’d laugh again so freely? There was a world of stress and anger and fear waiting for them outside this room, waiting to rip into them with vicious abandon, leave them broken and unwhole.

“Hey, get my back?” Mermista looked at him with an almost bored expression, and he relaxed. They’d be fine, he mused as he scrubbed her down. They had one another, and if they didn’t have anyone else, Sea Hawk had come to learn that the two of them were more than enough. Mermista made him feel invincible just by being the unstoppable force of nature that she was, and he knew she was learning to draw strength from his presence, knew that he provided the unconditional support and love that she craved. Her confidence was no lie, but he liked to think she held her head a little higher when he stood at her side.

“I love you,” he murmured against the back of her neck, hugging her close. “Just, so much.”

“You’re a sap,” she snorted, hugging him back. “But I, like, love you, too. Duh.”

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They were fast asleep, sated and bare, when Adora kicked in the doors to their room at around one in the morning. “Mermista! Emergency meeting!”

She had been asleep on Sea Hawk’s chest, her cheek pressed to his pectoral and like, lowkey drooling. She jolted awake with a start, reaching out for the water on the nightstand instinctively. Sea Hawk’s arm had been draped over her shoulders, and tightened inhumanly fast as he woke up, reaching for his sword before he realized what was happening. The blanket snugged tight around them both shifted as he pushed her off of and behind him, leveling his sword at the door before he saw who it was and relaxed. Mermista pressed his torso back down to the bed so she could level a glare at Adora that would reduce a lesser person to a puddle of tears in seconds. “Adora. What the fuck.”

Adora had the good grace to blush and look away. “Uh, sorry, but c’mon! Emergency Alliance meeting NOW.”

“Ugh, alright, I’ll be there in two seconds-”

“We have to go now-”

“I’m fucking naked, dude! Give me a goddamn minute!” Mermista snapped. Adora glanced at her, then Sea Hawk, then down at them, and then *firmly* at the ceiling, scarlet in the face.

“Sorry! Right! Two minutes!” She bolted from the room, and Mermista slammed the doors shut with her hydrokinesis.

“I’m gonna kill myself,” she groaned. “That makes, like, top ten most embarrassing moments of my life easy.”

“Why?” Sea Hawk yawned, already rolling over. “She was the one who burst in here, we have every right to be naked in bed.”

“Shut up. This is why I wear pajamas in Bright Moon,” Mermista grumbled, kicking the blankets off her body and grabbing a fresh set of armor from her bag. Sea Hawk watched her dress with a pout, and she rolled her eyes. “Show’s over, dork. C’mon, get up, we should get moving after this meeting anyway. Can you pack and get the supplies ready while I go handle whatever bullshit Adora brought back this time?”

“Yeah,” Sea Hawk yawned. “Leave it to me, dearest. Go be a badass.”

Mermista blushed and rolled her eyes, swatting Sea Hawk firmly on the ass as she walked by. He yelped, and she laughed at the afronted look he gave her as she walked out. “Bye, handsome.”

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Mermista watched the simulation run, conflicted. On one hand, the whole ‘unstable mass’ bit was, like, horrendously terrifying. On the other hand…with power like that, she could take back Salineas in an hour…two, tops. And that was a pro that really couldn’t be conned. Adora’s hesitation wasn’t comforting, though, and neither was Glimmer’s zeal, even if she did agree. Mermista glanced at the other two princesses. Perfuma looked more conflicted than she was, sprouting thorns along her arms that she scratched at anxiously. Frosta was frowning, and that was weird- she never disagreed with Glimmer.

She turned her attention back to the shouting match, eyes volleying between the two (former?) best friends. It wasn’t like she wanted to agree with Shadow Bitch, but…the idea of using the power was too tempting. Images of drowning the Horde fleets that sat on her kingdom’s doorstep danced in her brain, and she felt her heart pound faster, even as guilt at the idea settled in.

Stars, she was so tired.

Mermista moved over to the simulator settings on the table, and began punching in different inputs and outputs, turning the dial as she went. Maybe they could regulate how much magic they took out of the Heart? Like bleeding a thermal vent before it blew up and took out an entire coral reef; release a bit at a time, let it settle back down. Except nothing she put in resulted in anything other than a catastrophic explosion…

Mermista frowned; she knew that that would be them. That with that much magic coursing through them like lightning rods, their bodies would never survive. They were just conduits for the runestone's power, and conduits could be burnt out. That was okay, she mused. At least they'd have Salineas back…

"-Thaymoor! Alwyn! *Salineas!* We've lost almost everything!" Glimmer was pleading with Bow to understand.

Mermista bristled a bit; *she* had lost Salineas, not that anyone seemed to care too much about that on a personal level anymore. Whatever. Perfuma's hand landed on the back of hers, sympathy shining in her big brown eyes. Alright, almost everyone. She spared the other woman a smile.

"This magic is the only thing that can help save everyone."

Perfuma withdrew her hand to conjure a large flower. She plucked petals off with shaking hands and voice. "Use the scary magical energy, don't use the scary magical energy-"

Frosta's head hit the table, waking her up from her doze. "Ah! Uh, maybe we should continue this in the morning?" She paused, then flushed. "N-not that I'm up past my bedtime. I don't have a bedtime. I can go to bed whenever I want," she huffed.

Mermista had reached her limit, and turned the holotable off. “Or we can just decide right now.” She slumped to her elbows, sagging with the weight of her choice. “I’ll do whatever it takes to get my kingdom back. I say we use the magic.”

Next to her, Adora’s shoulders sagged, and Mermista felt like she’d let her down.

Perfuma, visibly stressed and panicking, began picking petals harder. “Oh, it’s so dangerous! What if it goes off in the process?” she moaned. “I don’t know, just come back to me!”

Swiftwind tossed his mane. “How come I still don’t have a chair even though the new person does?”

Scorpia smiled. “Oh, no, I’m sitting on Emily.”

Mermista was watching Perfuma shred the poor flower to pieces while she started to hyperventilate while Adora rolled her eyes at her unfortunately stupid horse. “Swiftwind is this really the ti-ime…to…”

Wait. Scorpia?

The room froze, Glimmer making a noise of confusion while Frosta rubbed her eyes again for good measure. As one, their heads turned to the arachnid woman at the far end of the table, who smiled at them. "Hey everybody! How are you? Gosh, I am so sorry for popping in unannounced. I didn't want to interrupt, y'all seemed *really* busy, so I snuck past the guards and was just waiting for you guys to notice I was here-"

"HORDE SOLDIER!"

"For the HONOR *OFGRAYSKULL* -"

Scorpia leapt to her feet, pincers up in defense. "Hol-Hold on! I don't want to fight you-!

"SHE'S GOT A BOT!"

"FOR SALINEAS!" Mermista snapped out of her shock, pulling every bit of water she could feel into the room and hurling it at Scorpia. The Force Captain went flying into the hall, recovering admirably and landing in a slide. Frosta threw herself after the intruder, a tiny ball of frozen fury.

" *You ruined Princess Prom!* "

Scorpia dodged again, and Mermista found herself mildly impressed with the large woman's combat agility. Frosta froze the hallway, sending the bot crashing into Scorpia and rolling them both out into the training courtyard. Adora, Glimmer, Bow, and Frosta resumed a frontal attack, while Mermista and Perfuma rushed around the Horde soldier to cage her in.

When the bot began attacking, Perfuma paused, frowning at her. "Something's wrong here."

"Besides the obvious?"

Perfuma approached the fight as Scorpia yelled. "Please! I don't want to hurt you!"

"I think she's telling the tru-u-uh-ugh-!" Like a sack of bricks, Perfuma dropped to the ground, paralyzed, while Scorpia grabbed her tail, yanking it close.

Mermista gasped along with everyone else.

"I am so sorry, I did not mean to do that i-it's instinct-!" Adora was done listening, and rushed her former ally, sword raised to deliver a devastating blow. Scorpia raised her claws in submission, squeezing her eyes shut. "Please! I need your help to save Entrapta!"

Adora stopped short, and they all reeled back. Geek Princess…?

Glimmer stepped forward to take over. “Alright, that’s enough. Scorpia, we will hear you out. But first, we’re restraining you…as soon as Perfuma, uh, shakes it off.”

The downed princess was already recovering, trying to get to her feet. Mermista rushed forward to help her up, lifting her from under the arms until she was back upright. Even then, she leaned heavily on Mermista. “Water…please…”

Mermista yanked some out of the fountain, holding the bubble to Perfuma’s mouth as she drank. With the water coursing through her, Perfuma’s body started pushing the toxin out of her, and they all watched as the venom bubbled on her skin before sliding harmlessly to the ground. Scorpia was in awe. “How…how did you do that?”

Perfuma patted Mermista’s shoulder in thanks before taking a steadying breath. “When I connected with the Heart-Blossom, my cardiovascular system became stronger, more like a plant’s. With the right ingredients and focus, I can push just about anything through my system. Water always helps.” She spared Mermista a smile, who rolled her eyes at the sap (ha, sap- gods she was becoming her fiance, what-).

“That’s amazing,” Scorpia breathed, and seemed to mean it. Perfuma blushed and hummed, busying herself with growing strong enough vines to restrain Scorpia.

Mermista quirked a brow; okay, that was a new…thing from the queen of zen vibes. She bent down to "relace her shoes" so she could listen in.

"Listen, your majesty, I am so, *so* sorry about that, I really didn't mean to I swear I came here in peace."

"I believe you."

"And when you snuck up I couldn't control it and I just- wait, what?"

"I said I believe you," Perfuma giggled, beginning to move the vines to wrap around Scorpia. "Higher on your knees, please. Anyway, most Horde soldiers don't walk into a meeting of Princesses and just wait to be noticed. Especially with one of them falling asleep."

Frosta, who had moved off with the others, turned around to stick her tongue out at Perfuma. Mermista coughed to hide her laugh.

Scorpia frowned. "I couldn't think of another way…I just, I really need to help Entrapta. I screwed up."

Perfuma was quiet for a while, braiding vines into thick ropes along the other woman's body. When they reached her armored elbows, Perfuma sighed. "I think that, in life, we all screw up. It takes a very big person to admit it, and an even bigger person to walk away from a system that protected them from accountability so that they can try to fix it. What you're doing is brave. I just hope it's for the benefit of all involved."

Scorpia's eyes were wide, a blush rising on her cheeks. Mermista retied her left shoe for the fifth time, utterly invested in whatever the fuck was happening here. She gave the intruder a once over; take away the Horde uniform, and Scorpia was a very attractive woman. Tall, broad with muscle, beautiful hair that was effortlessly styled. Mermista choked down another laugh; she was *exactly* Perfuma's type.

Speaking of Perfuma, she was tying off the vines while the others approached again. Scorpia leaned toward her. "Seriously, again, I am so sorry."

Perfuma just smiled and walked off, but she did reach back and sprout a blossoming flower right at the tip of Scorpia's restrained tail. She came over to Mermista. "I'm so sorry to see that, at twenty-four, you've completely forgotten how to tie your shoes."

Mermista hid a smile in her knee. "Yeah, it's, like, really tragic."

"Get up, you nosy thing."

She let Perfuma tug her to her feet and walk them a few feet away. "Sooooo, she's cute- ow! Don't pinch me, fucking five year old.”

“Then act your age!” Perfuma tossed her hair to hide her blush, nodding with her chin to the interrogation. “And pay attention.”

“-anyway, the thing is, you all seem really good at friendship.”

Perfuma clasped her hands under her chin. “You’re here to learn how to be a good friend?”

Mermista glared at her out of the corner of her eye. Ew.

“Yes! That’s it! See, I thought I was being a good friend to Catra, but it turns out Catra wasn’t being a good friend to me, and also that I have no idea what friendship is.” Gods, these two morons were made for each other huh? Mermista blinked while Perfuma wiped an eye, trying to figure out what Scorpia was talking about and more importantly, why she should give a fuck. “Man, I think… Entrapta’s the only real friend I’ve ever had. Oh, and Emily.”

“Uuuuughh!” Mermista slapped her forehead, utterly annoyed by the trajectory of this interrogation. “Say things that make sense!” She ignored Perfuma’s glare.

“Right! Entrapta tried to warn Hordak about the whole portal… weirdness…thing..? And so Catra sent her to Beast Island and I…I let it happen. Now, I have to save her.” She looked down ashamed, while they all shared glances of concern. Wait, Entrapta wasn't helping the Horde anymore?

Mermista frowned. That meant that she hadn't been a direct part of Salineas' downfall. Feelings of relief, bitter resentment, and deep confusion churned inside her, and she started chewing on the dead skin around her thumbnail as her thoughts raced. So where did that leave her? The reports said there was a new weapon, and it sounded like First One's tech. After all, what else could have taken down the Sea Gate so easily other than a weapon of equal make? It was literally built to deflect all magical attacks.

"-Great. Then it's decided," Adora was saying.

Mermista snapped back. What was decided? Shit, how long had she been spacing out?

"We'll leave-"

" *Will everyone just stop for one second?!"* Glimmer shouted, bringing whatever plan they were formulating to a grinding halt. Mermista and Perfuma stepped back a bit, not wanting to be involved with whatever new drama this was. " *You* aren't going anywhere. You're our prisoner!" She jabbed a finger at Scorpia.

Mermista shrugged. That was, like, fair, in her opinion.

“And you!” She whirled on Adora and Bow. “We need to talk.”

In a flash of sparkles, they were gone. Mermista groaned. “Is anyone else getting tired of that?”

“A bit, yes-”

“Extremely!” Frosta huffed. The remaining princesses turned to Mermista, who faltered.

“Uh, what?”

“What now?” Perfuma asked.

“How the fuck would I know?” She scowled. “Glimmer said Scorpia was our prisoner, so, like, take her to the last spare bedroom, I guess? I’m going to find Sea Hawk.”

“Come find us before you leave!” Perfuma called after her.

She waved a vague assent, trotting up the stairs. Anxiety was churning in her, thoughts about the Heart, the turncoat, Entrapta, all tearing holes in her mind. She walked blindly, turning corners in the maze-like, too-enclosed halls of Bright Moon. She realized her feet were carrying her back to their bedroom, and figured it was as good a place as any to start searching for her lawless spouse-to-be.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you for reading, and thank you for every single comment and kudo. I really do read every single one, they make my day, and I’m working on responding, so feel free to drop me some feedback!

i got you to help me forgive

Chapter Summary

FORGOTTEN CHAPTER OOPS

Chapter Notes

This is the chapter that I forgot to add :)

She found Sea Hawk in their rooms, two traveling packs sitting ready on the bed while he sharpened and cleaned his sword. He looked up when she walked in, eyes lighting up at the sight of her. "Dearest!"

"Hey," she sighed, flopping back onto the bed. "How'd packing go?"

"We're set!" He grinned, clearly proud of himself. "Clothes and armor, provisions for up to five weeks should we have issue finding the camp, datapads and replacement power crystals, fresh water in reusable canteens, sleeping rolls and a tent, a hammock just in case, books on the off chance we have down time, Sea-Ra-"

"What?" Mermista's eyes flew open.

"Yeah, I found her at the bottom of your bag, and figured you wouldn't mind the luck." Sea Hawk had had Sea-Ra made eons ago as a joke at a bazaar, just after they'd met Adora and Mermista's crush had been painfully obvious. He'd been jealous, but not so jealous that he was above teasing her. She’d never told him how touched she’d been at the silly doll, that she took it with her everywhere she traveled outside of Salineas for luck. Apparently he’d known anyway.

She climbed off the bed and into his lap, straddling him with her thighs and kissing him deeply. “I love you,” she breathed against him. “And all the stupid, dorky shit you do.”

“I had a feeling.” He grinned, nipping at her lower lip. His hand came up to cradle the back of her head, tilting her into another kiss. She moaned softly against his lips, her tongue moving against his in a gentle caress.

“How was the meeting?” he asked between kisses.

Mermista was entirely blissed out, lost in the haze of endorphins and oxytocin racing through her at his attention. “Bad. Apocalypse is near.” She sucked on his lower lip. “The Horde princess defected and showed up…” His calloused fingers were rubbing circles into her lower back and she groaned in bliss. “Perfuma’s got a giant crush.”

“We should talk about all of that.”

“Probably.”

Sea Hawk got to his feet, lifting her with him without breaking their kiss. Blindly, he pushed the packs off the bed and sat back down, reclining with her on top of him.

She moved down to his jaw, working her teeth and tongue gently along his stubble. “You need to shave.”

“Yes, dear,” he sighed absently, utterly relaxed under her ministrations. Mermista placed a last kiss on his lips before sitting up. He whined. “Why?”

“Because we don’t have time to take this further, as much as I want to.” She patted his chest softly. “We need to meet up with the others before we go, see what’s happening with Scorpia.”

Sea Hawk sat bolt upright at the name, excitement replacing his glaze of arousal and contentment. “Scorpia?! She’s the defector?”

“Uh, yeah- whoa!” Sea Hawk was on his feet, tossing her to the bed and scrambling to get his shoes on. “Where’s the fire?”

“Scorpia was the friend I made in the Northern Reach! The one I told you about who I said was a brave and kind soul trapped in the wrong place. She defected! This is wonderful!”

“The one who told you to dump me?” Mermista quirked a brow.

Sea Hawk froze, one leg in the air with his boot half on. “I feel as though I should tread carefully here.”

“Nah,” Mermista snorted. “I’m just messing with you. We both needed the wake up call, and it’s water sooo far under the bridge.” Sea Hawk tugged her to her feet, kissing her softly before wrapping her in a bear hug. She smiled to herself. Sea Hawk gave, like, the best hugs.

“I love you.”

“I know. I love you, too. Now, c’mon, we gotta go be, like, responsible monarchs.”

“Lead on, dearest.”

They shouldered their packs, trident and sword fastened tight, and left the room. They nodded to guards as they passed, who bowed in return. At some point, Sea Hawk slipped his hand into Mermista’s and she let it be, tangling their fingers together. They reached the spare room and strode in, walking in on-

“Are you seriously having a sleepover with the prisoner?”

Pillows, blankets, and snacks were scattered around the room. Frosta and Perfuma were smiling about something while Scorpia still looked pretty shell-shocked at how she was being treated. At the sight of Mermista, she froze, before her eyes drifted to-

"Pirate Guy?!"

"Scorpia!"

They grinned at each other, Sea Hawk leaving her side to bound over and give the broad woman a hug. Scorpia's bonds were long gone, and she picked up Sea Hawk as she hugged him back. He was a tall man, but even he was at least a head shorter than the arachnid princess. Sea Hawk flopped into a bean bag as the two began chatting, and it was like Scorpia had been given permission to be herself. Their energy was almost identical, excitable and loud and undeniably goofy.

Mermista smiled to herself the sight of Sea Hawk's usual, old self. She'd just have to keep an eye on the very flammable drapery. She came to sit by Perfuma and Frosta. "How's it going?"

Frosta smiled. "She's nice, Mermista. Really nice. She's one of us, underneath the Horde armor."

"Mhm!" Perfuma nodded. "It's like, we just connected. Like she was always supposed to be here. She's genuine, and even now, one of the happiest people I’ve met. Her aura is simply incandescent.” She sighed dreamily, eyes drifting back to Scorpia.

Mermista smirked. “You’ve got it so bad.”

“Says you.” Perfuma huffed.

“You’re both gross,” Frosta groaned. “Love is gross.”

Mermista flopped over into the younger girl’s lap, making sure her elbow was lodged in her ribs. “Aw but Frosta! We love youuuuu-’”

Perfuma giggled, following suit and landing on top of Mermista so she could boop Frosta’s nose. “Yeah! You’re like our little, tiny, cute, *baby* sister-”

“Get off of me!” the younger princess snarled, slapping at their backs to no avail. “Gross! Ew!”

Perfuma leaned over and kissed her head, which resulted in more thrashing and shrieking. Mermista laughed, until a booted foot caught her in the stomach. “Ow! You little shit-!” She grappled Frosta in a headlock, rubbing her knuckles into fine blue hair until Frosta licked her arm. “EW!”

“Nyeh, nyeh- hey!” Perfuma blew a fistful of flower petals onto her tongue that she was sticking out, so she and Mermista could scramble away back to the safety of their own bean bags. “No fair! You ganged up on me!”

“Duh.” Mermista settled herself between Sea Hawk’s thighs, her back to his front. Frosta hurled a snowball at her, which she flicked out of the air with the water in the flakes.

Scorpia was watching this all, mystified. “Is this what you guys are…really like?”

Mermista spared her a side eye. To be frank, she had yet to form an opinion on Scorpia, but she certainly knew where she stood on Horde soldiers. “What the fuck is that supposed mean?”

Perfuma elbowed her, glaring.

“I dunno.” Scorpia flushed, looking down. “Every time I’ve seen you all before, you’re so focused and punchy and intense. Now you’re…not.”

Perfuma smiled. “Well, yeah, silly. We’ve only met in battle. No one can walk around like that all the time, combat ready and always on edge. It’s not healthy.”

Scorpia just stared at her, confused. “I- I don’t understand.”

Sea Hawk cleared his throat. “Is that what it was like for you? In the Horde? People were soldiers, instead of, well, people?”

“Yeah.” Scorpia nodded like this was normal. “It was. I didn’t know you could be anything other than who you were on the field, in training. You’re a soldier from sun up to sun down, and when you’re not, you’re asleep. We don’t…do *that* .”

“Have friends? Or fun?” Frosta tilted her head.

“...yeah.”

Alright well that was…sad. Really sad. Fucking heartbreaking, actually. Perfuma looked ready to cry. “So you weren’t, what, allowed to be happy?”

Scorpia shrugged. “I mean, you could be whatever. But if you weren’t going to be like everyone else, you had to be ready to face those consequences. I was the weird one there, and I knew that, even if everyone else didn’t think I did. I mean, ha, how could you not, you know? When you’re the only one getting told to shut up, get back in line, talk softer, be angrier, be tougher on the cadets, be seen and not heard, it’s kinda obvious, ya know?”

Mermista did know. Memories of feeling very small, standing before a throne that seemed bigger than life so she could be yelled at for speaking out of turn, for being loud, for crying in training-

“That sucks. I’m sorry.” The other princesses seemed taken aback she was speaking at all, let alone in sympathy. Scorpia, especially.

“Oh, I mean, it wasn’t all bad. At least… I didn’t think it was.”

“Yeah,” she snorted mirthlessly. “You never do until you’re out.”

Scorpia pondered that, and then nodded morosely. The group lapsed into silence and Mermista busied herself with pushing Sea Hawk’s cuticles back. He whined and tried to jerk his hands away, but she held tight. He was always such a drama queen. His chin was on her head, digging into her scalp. “Can you move your bony-ass head?”

“Certainly! If you release my cuticles.”

“Bitch.”

Frosta glared at them. “Stop being gross.”

Mermista just stretched her legs out so they were resting in Frosta’s lap. “No.”

Perfuma, ever the mediator, came over to sit in front of Mermista with her back to the mermaid. She shook her hair into Mermista's face. "Braid this? So, Scorpia, what do you like to do for fun?"

"Fun?"

"Like, recreation? What do you do when you're not training or fighting?"

"Oh!" Scorpia relaxed. "I like to doodle, or sing, or make up stories. Sometimes Catra and I would go on trips- usually they were for work but it was still fun to travel and see Etheria."

Mermista could feel Sea Hawk vibrating against her. Oh no. "You like to sing! What do you like to sing?"

Scorpia rubbed the back of her neck with a pincer. "Oh, heh, just stuff I make up, or tunes I'd hear at Noman's Land if I ever had enough down time to go. Not a lot of music in the Fright Zone, ya know?"

"Noman's Land! I go there!"

"Yeah?" Scorpia sat up grinning. "I loved their karaoke nights! Well, until they had to stop because that guy got stabbed with the mic stand.”

“That was me!”

“What!”

“What.” Mermista whipped around to glare at him.

Sea Hawk cleared his throat, smile faltering. “It wasn’t that bad, there was just a lot of blood. It wasn’t even a stabbing, they hit my head. And- And head wounds, heh, bleed..a lot?” He was shrinking under the weight of Mermista’s glare. “Anyway.”

“I was there that night!” Scorpia smiled. “I mean, sorry you got stabbed, or hit, but it made for a very cool story at the mess hall.”

“Always happy to have my stories told across Etheria!” Sea Hawk winked and stroked his mustache. “Where have you traveled, Scorpia? Tell us in vivid detail so we might move on from this life-threatening topic.”

“Is that what the weird bump on your head is that you said was because your stupid bird attacked you-”

“Scorpia! Travels!”

“Well…” She tapped a pincer to her chin in thought. “We’ve been almost everywhere thanks to Entrapta and her First Ones’ tech obsession. The Northern Reach, the Crimson Waste, Mount Candila, Dryl, Salineas-”

The temperature in the room dropped about a thousand degrees, probably because Frosta was suddenly much sadder. Mermista kept her eyes focused on Perfuma’s hair, even as her hands began shaking and Sea Hawk’s grip on her waist tightened. Scorpia stopped, looking around. “Did…did I say something?”

Mermista scoffed. “Like you don’t know.”

“I- I don’t- wait…” Scorpia looked around them, the grief and devastation clear on their faces. “Did the plan already happen?”

“Yeah,” Mermista bit out. “And it was a rousing success, you’ll be happy to know.”

“No,” Scorpia whispered, staring at her pincers. “I thought- when I left there was still time, I thought I could reach you in time, and Entrapta would know how to… I’m so sorry.”

Mermista kept her face turned away, bitterly cursing the tears pressing at her lids. How could she still have tears?

Perfuma took over. “Your apology is…acknowledged, Scorpia. But, I don’t think it carries much weight here.”

“Of- of course not,” she mumbled. “I just- I’m sorry. I am. For all of it.”

“Let’s move on.” Mermista tied off the one braid and moved to the next. “Scorpia, why did you stay with the Horde? Did you not know you were a princess?”

“No, I- I did.” She scratched her head again. Mermista noticed it was a regular nervous habit. “I went to my first Princess Prom and…I just, didn’t fit in. And then Shadow Weaver capitalized on that, and told me I would never fit in with them, that no one liked our family even before the Horde. I don’t even know if that’s true, but I never had a reason to think otherwise. So. I stayed there, because that was where I fit in.”

“Except you didn’t fit in there.” Frosta frowned.

“No.”

“Wait, when was your first Princess Prom?” Perfuma frowned at Mermista as they did the math. “Because the last one should have been your third.”

“Third?” Frosta gaped. “How old are you people?”

“Well…” Perfuma counted off on her fingers. “Our first All Princess Ball was about, what, twenty one years ago?”

“Yeah, I was, like, three or four?” Mermista shrugged. Sea Hawk made a soft noise behind her. “What?”

“Baby Mermista…”

“She was so cute!” Perfuma gushed, while she groaned. “I was about six, that was the first time we met. And she had on the cutest little lehenga choli! And your tiny little sari! It was so cute.”

Mermista rolled her eyes, tugging harder on her friend’s hair. “What about you! You looked like a little cloud! Your puffy, floaty white dress, with the pink embroidery. And you kicked off your shoes under the buffet table so you were running around barefoot.”

“Shoes constrain my aura,” Perfuma said. “And so did you!”

She chuckled. “Yeah, because I was following you! I got in so much trouble for losing my sandals.”

“My first prom was your second then?” Frosta frowned, trying to do the math.

"Yes, that was the one in Plumeria! I was about sixteen. And Mermista didn't go."

"How come?"

"Oh, I was super grounded." She shrugged. "My rebellious early teen phase, I guess. I snuck out to the markets without my escort and then kiiiiinda snuck onto a party boat and got, like, wasted. No one recognized me because I hadn't left the castle for fun in years, so they all thought I was someone's niece or cousin and gave me alcohol."

Perfuma was rolling her eyes, while the other three just looked impressed. Frosta looked borderline awestruck. "WHAT!"

"Yeah, not my best moment. Wasn't worth it, since I missed out on Prom."

"Frosta was so cute as a baby. I got to hold you!"

"You did?" Frosta tilted her head. "I don't remember that."

"Of course not, you were a baby. Scorpia, why didn't you go to the second ball?"

"Oh, because my first one was no fun."

"Yeah, wait, back up." Mermista frowned. "How old were you at the first one?"

"About seven? Maybe eight?"

"So why was it such a bust?"

"Oh, none of the monarchs wanted me there, I think. They kept looking at me strangely, and- and I didn't have as nice a dress as you guys did, and the older princesses were more concerned with my chaperone, and it was just, I dunno."

Perfuma frowned. "I'm sorry you were made to feel that way."

"That's okay. Some of them were really nice! Two older girls showed me where the bathroom was, the one had really pretty pink hair. And when I couldn't reach the food this suuuuper tall woman got me a plate. And the other lady with her, she wore a lot of gold, she fixed my ponytail and told me I had a nice dress, which made me feel better."

Perfuma was smiling at Mermista. "That was probably Spinnerella and Netossa, you'll meet them soon. And do you think…?"

“Sounds like them.” Mermista smiled softly. “Those were our moms.”

Scorpia blinked. “Whoa…”

“Fate is a beautiful and strange thing,” Perfuma hummed enigmatically.

Mermista tied off her braid and leaned back into Sea Hawk, who pressed a subtle kiss to the top of her head. They all sat in an odd, contemplative silence for a while. Mermista found herself occupied by thoughts of what young Sea Hawk, maybe five or six at the time, was doing while she was at her first Princess Prom. Maybe he was at home, sleeping in front of a warm fire while his mother whittled, or made dinner. Maybe he was out on a boat, night fishing with the other sailors of the village. Maybe he was having snowball fights or sledding with friends. It was a bizarre, out of body feeling to think about him so far away, no knowledge of who she was, or what they’d be one day. How could a fisherman’s apprentice ever predict that one day he’d be marrying a queen, fighting in a war so much bigger than any of them? She tucked herself a bit closer into his arms, silently thanking fate, or whoever, for giving her such a gift. A loud, dramatic, chaotic, unpredictable gift that, yeah, she wouldn’t trade for anything.

Eventually, Frosta dozed off, head in Perfuma’s lap. The plant princess gently removed her tiara and set it aside, doing the same to her own circlet. Mermista grimaced, thinking of her own crown. It was probably, like, super destroyed. Whatever. There were bigger issues.

Sea Hawk leaned back into the bean bag, and she turned to glance at him. He pouted. “Just a few minutes, dearest, then we’ll get moving.”

“Uh-huuuuuh, sure.”

“Pirate’s promise.”

“Oh, good, that’s reassuring.” Despite her snark, she was already moving to her own bean bag, curling up tightly in the plush fabric. She shivered; even with all the people in this room it was still fucking arctic. Sleeveless armor made sense in Salineas, okay? It was tropical year round, no one wore sleeves.

A familiar weight and warmth settled over her shoulders- Sea Hawk’s jacket. She smiled softly, face buried where no one could see, and grunted her thanks as she tugged it around her upper body. Mermista cracked an eye open to see Sea Hawk leaned back in his cushion, chest already rising with the familiar rhythm of his sleep. Perfuma was in lotus position, face lax in deep meditation while Frosta was sprawled like a starfish next to her, mouth open and snoring. Scorpia sat looking unsure of herself, glancing around like she wasn’t really sure what had just happened. Gradually, she relaxed, tail coming up to curl around her body while she tucked her head to her knees. Mermisa thought she looked an awful lot like one of those armored desert animals she’d seen in a book once, just pointier.

At some point, she'd fallen asleep *hard* , because the next thing she knew, the door was banging open, and Glimmer was there- yelling and seething. They'd all startled awake; Sea Hawk was on his feet above her with his blade drawn- yeah, okay, they really needed to talk about this throwing himself in front of her at the slightest hint of danger nonsense- Scorpia's tail was rattling dangerously as she bolted upright militaristically, and Frosta and Perfuma were already summoning their magic before they realized what was happening.

Jeez, this war was turning them into a bunch of hairpin-trigger nervous wrecks. She tried to relax, letting the water she'd seized fall back into the fountain outside.

"-they took off! So now we have to do this on our own. The worst is *here* , it's now or never-" Glimmer was pacing frantically.

Perfuma got to her feet to comfort her. "Glimmer, what are you talking about? Bring us up to speed."

The queen worked on soothing herself enough to get a sentence out. "I got Double Trouble to talk."

They all tensed, looking at one another. Scorpia frowned. "Wait- *you* have DT- oh gods, she's going to go absolutely ballistic-"

"We know the Horde's grand plan, *spy* ." Glimmer spat.

“That’s great!” Scorpia cheered. “What is it?”

“What? You…you don’t know? You were Catra’s right hand.”

“Uh, well, the thing about that is, Catra doesn’t really *have* a right hand. It’s her, and sometimes Hordak, and I guess Double Trouble, too…” Scorpia looked crestfallen. “So, I guess she does, actually. It’s just… not me. Sorry.”

Sea Hawk placed a careful hand on her shoulder in sympathy, and there was a heavy moment of understanding there.

Glimmer scowled. “Whatever, it doesn’t matter now. We know.” She turned to them. “The Horde wanted to open a portal to bring forth the rest of their army. Double Trouble has it on good authority that a message got through when they opened the last portal, and that the rest of the Horde will be here any day.”

“Wait, wait.” Perfuma frowned. “T-the rest of the Horde? What does that mean?”

“I don’t know everything. I can’t figure out a lot of it. But from what I’ve pieced together, the Horde, and Hordak, are an alien race hellbent on conquering Etheria. There’s more than just the army we’ve been fighting.”

“How much more?” Frosta asked.

Glimmer closed her eyes, looking almost defeated. “Thousands. Hundreds of thousands of soldiers, with technology we’ve never even seen. We won’t stand a chance.”

Mermista felt like she was falling, though her face remained impassive. “So what now? What do we do- where’s Adora? Shouldn’t she be, like, in on this? Being a First One and all.”

Glimmer sneered. “Adora and Bow are gone. They went to Beast Island. We’re on our own.”

Well, fuck.

“What now, your majesty?” Sea Hawk stood just behind her, sounding downright terrified. She really didn’t blame him.

“Now, we defend our home.” Glimmer’s resolve was back, and seemed to breathe life back into the room. “I’m going to Light Hope, and I’m going to demand she tell me how to access the Heart. We’re officially out of options.”

This time, there was no debate. They nodded as one. Frosta stepped forward. “Snows remains well defended, and inaccessible to the Horde at this time. I’m going to stay here, and defend Plumeria and the Woods with Perfuma.”

Glimmer nodded, and turned to them. Mermista picked up her trident and holster from where she'd dropped it by her pack. "We're going back to Salineas, or what's left of it. I need to find my people, and help however they can. Thank you, for your hospitality and support, Glimmer. All of you, really. I-I don't know where I'd be without you guys."

The princesses came together in a hug, drawing strength from one another. Glimmer sniffled a bit. "We've got this. We're the Princesses of Power, and we won't go down without a fight."

"Who knows," Mermista drawled. "Maybe we can win this shit."

She, Sea Hawk, Perfuma, and Frosta took their leave, bowing to Glimmer, tossing a myriad of goodbyes at Scorpia. Sea Hawk and Frosta went in for a hug, while Perfuma settled for summoning an orchid into Scorpia's hair and smiling gently. Mermista just nodded at her. She had a long way to go before anyone trusted her fully, but so far she'd been nothing but surprises.

The morning was young when they left the castle, dawn just peeking over the horizon. Perfuma turned and hugged them both one more time. "Please, be safe. Send word when you find the refugees, or if you need help."

"Only if you promise to do the same," Mermista hummed into her oldest friend's shoulder. "Love you, or whatever. Don't die."

Perfuma giggled. “Love you, too, Merms. Be well, both of you. Sea Hawk, keep her safe.”

“Yeah that’s usually how that goes.” Mermista rolled her eyes as Sea Hawk nodded.

“I will.”

They both hugged Frosta goodbye, Mermista maybe a bit tighter than she’d willingly admit- she was just perfectly sized for it, alright? “Give ‘em hell, tiny.”

“You, too, fish stick.”

And as one, they all turned and went their separate ways.

til the rivers flood and the ocean dries (i will love you)

Chapter Summary

> Finding Salineas, reconnection, and new beginnings that have been a long time coming

Chapter Notes

> This is a monster of a chapter but I’m tired of chunking up Google docs so here you go! This chapter is chock full of Salinean lore that I conjured for this fic, so I hope y’all enjoy!
>
> Song: Star of the County Down! There are many versions but the Irish Rovers is my personal fav

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They waved goodbye again before setting off for the harbor. The sun was just making its appearance as they cast off, headed up the coast toward Dryl and Snows to sneak around the back of the archipelago that was Salineas. They used only one sail to avoid being spotted, so the journey was slow, taking about 2 days on the whole. Not only did Mermista not mind, she relished the time alone with Sea Hawk, and the time to think.

Glimmer had told them to stand by for orders, so there was nothing much to do until then. They plotted courses together, through coastal island towns, up along citadels and villages and outposts. They trained, sparring on the deck while the sun beat down on them. Sea Hawk told her stories of his adventures, some new, some old, all ridiculously embellished. She worried, sometimes, that he was still trying to impress her, but decided to take it at face value as Sea Hawk just being Sea Hawk.

Deciding to save the rations for whatever refugees they found, Mermista dove into the water to fish for the meals. She brought back massive tuna and salmon, leaving Sea Hawk to clean and gut them.

He laughed at her repulsed face while he began stripping scales into an empty barrel. “So, let me get this straight,” he chortled. “You will *hunt and kill fish with your teeth*, but you won’t watch me debone them?”

Mermista gagged at the wet noise the fish made. “Uh, yeah.”

“And you say I’m the weird one!” He shook his head. “It’s strange, when I first met you, I almost didn’t believe what you said about being merfolk because you were nothing like the legends. Now, I’m convinced you started all of those rumors yourself.”

Mermista sniffed haughtily as she hopped up to sit on a crate with all the regal poise she could muster, tossing her hair. “No idea what you’re talking about.”

Sea Hawk just shook his head and went back to cleaning. He’d set up a *very controlled* makeshift firepit on the deck, both of them confident that her magic would prevent anything unseemly, so that he could cook the fish. Mermista could eat it raw, and often preferred to, but Sea Hawk only ate sushi prepared by “professionals”, the coward.

Whistling under his breath turned to humming, which turned to song, but he sounded nice when he wasn't being a clown so she let it be.

In an old Port Town in Salineas Bay

One morning last July,

From a boreen green came a sweet fair Queen

And she scowled as she passed me by.

Mermista turned to glare at him, and he purposefully ignored her, working on sliding the fish skeleton into the barrel. She could hear the smile in his voice; they both damn well knew those were *not* the words to this song.

She looked so sweet from her two bare feet

To the sheen of her storm blue hair.

Such a winsome elf, sure I shook myself

For to see I was really there.

Mermista smiled against her will, shaking her head at him. Sea Hawk was many things, charming included when he wanted to be. And he loved charming her more than he loved sailing. He was still bent over his fish, but his voice carried louder and surer, rich and deep and playful.

From Bright Moon Bay up to Coral Town and

From Snows down to Dryl’s old Quay ,

No maid I've seen like the Deep Sea Queen

That I met in Salineas Bay.

Mermista was blushing against her will, and turned stubbornly to the horizon. Sea Hawk abandoned his fish and washed his hands and bare forearms off in the cleaning water barrel she’d fashioned. He strode over to Mermista, placing calloused hands firmly on her hips and tugging her toward him. She rolled her eyes like she was annoyed, but jumped down readily so he knew it was all her usual facade. He tugged her into his chest so he could sing in her ear.

As she onward sped, sure I scratched my head,

And I looked with a feelin' rare,

And I say's, say's I, to a passer-by,

"Whose the maid with the storm blue hair"?

He ran his fingers lovingly through her hair- loose for once around her shoulders- and buried his nose in it, inhaling deeply into his lungs. Mermista smelled like the ocean, but like cardamom and lavender and old paper, too, and something that was solely hers. Her scent soothed him more than any drug or draught ever could, grounded him. He swayed gently with her in his arms, smiling when her own came up to hold him loosely about the hips.

He smiled at me and he says, say's he,

"That's the gem of Salineas' crown.

The Queen of the Pearl, the sea's own girl,

Mermista of Salineas' …town".

Mermista snorted at his weak rhyme. "Aw, you were so close, too."

"It's one of my better ones!" he protested, nuzzling his nose into the ticklish spot behind her ear until she leaned away laughing.

"Yeah, it didn't totally suck."

"So meaaaan," he whined, pouting. Mermista leaned back into him and pecked his lips. "Well, maybe only a little mean."

"Don't go telling people." She rolled her eyes.

He kissed her forehead and let go of her waist to finish deboning dinner. In seconds, both fish were staked and roasting over the fire. He'd left the salmon's skin on at Mermista's request; she liked the smoky, salty crisp skin. The idea intrigued him, and he vowed to steal a bite. The sun was fully set, and Sea Hawk wasn't going to risk sailing through the night with precious cargo, so he left Mermista to tend dinner while he set about lowering the mainsail, dropping the anchor, and lowering the boat into the water so he could turn off the anti-grav fin's mechanics. The boat didn't so much as rock when it hit the water, which he suspected had everything to do with Mermista.

He ducked below deck to grab lanterns and warmer clothes for his fiancee. Mermista thanked him with a smile when he handed over the sweat pants and thick jacket. She shimmied out of her leggings, and he didn't bother to hide his staring while he hung and lit the lanterns (carefully, more carefully than usual). He came up behind her when she discarded her panties and bent over to pull up the sweats, strolling past her casually while he reached over to smack her ass. She yelped, and he ran off cackling toward the wheel. The thumps behind him told her she was absolutely not taking that lying down, and he sped up until they were both tearing along the deck. He lost, of course, when a tendril of water reached out of the ocean and snaked his ankle, sending him sprawling before lifting him into the air. From here, Mermista was walking on the ceiling, the sky below his feet. She was scowling, but barely. Her eyes were laughing.

"Hey, dearest."

"Asshole." She lifted him higher, until they were face to face- well, sort of. Her hand hovered at chest level and oh- she'd taken her shirt off, left in her plain black sports bra. Her finger crooked ever so slightly, and he swung closer to her.

He grinned. "Couldn't help myself."

“Suuuuure.” She crossed one arm under her chest, lifting her boobs in a purposely distracting manner, smirking at him. “If dinner wasn’t about to burn, you’d be overboard.”

“I’m aware.” His smile was roguish now. “Any other way I could make it up to you after dinner?”

Her eyes smoldered in the firelight. “I’m sure you’ll think of something.”

“I always do.”

She stepped into his space, cupping his cheeks and bringing their lips together. He wasn’t sure if his world was reeling from the blood rushing to his head or Mermista’s kiss, but he didn’t really care. His own hands came up (down?) to cup the back of her head, scratching lightly at her scalp. She hummed, blissful, and he swiped his tongue along her lips. She opened for him, and he ran his tongue carefully along sharp, inhuman molars. He stroked her soft tongue with his own, tasting the coffee he’d made her around midday. She pulled back gently, rotating her wrist casually and dropping him back on his feet. He shook his head briefly, and grinned.

She smiled back, soft and gentle.

Sea Hawk went back to dinner while Mermista slid the old jacket over her bra, leaving it open. He swallowed, eyeing her figure where she sat reclined on her elbows. In the years he'd known her, she'd only grown more beautiful as she matured into a woman. Her curves were devastating, the hills and valleys of her body that belied incredible strength. Mermista had once utterly destroyed him in an arm wrestling contest he was actually trying to win, which, despite the Alliance's opinion, didn't really happen that often. He was no string bean- well, not anymore. He'd been a lanky lad. But Mermista? Her biceps and thighs were thick with muscle that had proven lethal. Her ass was plump, accentuated by long, strong legs. Her stomach, soft when she was relaxed and perfect for taking a nap on, or trailing kisses or hickies over, was toned from years of swimming- as a mermaid, she'd told him, her maneuverability was completely dependent on her abdomen. Her tail was the propeller, but her core was its rudder. When she flexed it, Sea Hawk was almost certain he could break plate glass over it with nary a scar.

Even now, after unending months, years, of stress, a poor eating and sleep schedule, too much fighting and not enough rest, she had retained her strength and her softness alike. She would never cease amazing him.

He pulled the fish off the fire, perfectly smoked and cooked, handing the skewer with the salmon on it to Mermista. He leaned against a crate, and she flopped over to recline with her head in his lap. He smiled. "You shouldn't eat laying down, dearest."

"Bite me," she drawled, tearing a piece of fish off and chewing.

He left it, eating his blackened tuna in contented silence. He fed her pieces of his own every now and again, smiling when she would grab his wrist to better eat the food out of his fingers. She returned the favor, offering him pieces of skin and fish (she was right, the fish's skin was to die for), giggling when his mustache tickled her fingertips.

"Are you nervous?" he murmured.

Mermista was silent for a while, and he almost thought she hadn't heard him. Eventually, though, she shrugged."I think so," she sighed. "I'm scared to know what…what they think of me. What if they blame me? Not that they shouldn't-"

"They shouldn't."

"-What if they hate me? What if they…" Mermista trailed off, unable to finish the thought.

Sea Hawk tossed aside his skewer, reaching down to take her hand. "You know I won't let that happen, my love."

"I know you'll try to keep me safe," she whispered. "But some things are out of our hands."

Sea Hawk had no reply to that, so he tugged her upright until he could pull her into his lap. She let him hug her close to his chest, tucking her face against his neck. "You know I love you so much, right?"

“I do.”

“Then trust me?”

She sighed. “I’m trying.”

“Alright.” He rubbed her back. “Alright.”

It was a while before she spoke again, so long that he assumed she’d nodded off.

“What if they don’t want me to be their queen anymore?”

“Then they’re fools.”

“Sebastian, I’m serious-”

“So am I, Mermista,” he said. “You love your kingdom, and your people. You built them a kingdom to be proud of, made a beautiful paradise out of the scraps your father left you. You didn’t tear it down.”

“But it’s gone anyway,” she whispered.

“Yeah.” He swallowed. “It is. But, it will be rebuilt. By all of us, together. And you’ll lead them through that, too.”

Mermista said nothing, just snuggled closer. “Can we talk about something else?”

Sea Hawk hummed, casting about for a topic. “Where is our wedding gonna be?”

She laughed, startled. “What?”

“Our wedding, will it be in the castle? On the beach? In a temple?”

“Uhhhh, I gotta be honest I don’t really know,” she sighed. “I was never one of those girls who sat around and thought about their wedding, the colors and the flowers and the dresses.”

“Ah,” he chuckled. “Wanna know something?”

“What’s that?”

“I was.” He grinned when she laughed, pulling back to look at him. “I used to think about it, like, all the time, especially on the sea. Who I would marry, what they’d be like, what our wedding would look like, if we’d travel after, where we’d go, what our-”

He cut off abruptly, and Mermista poked him in the chest, playfully. “C’mon Mr. Romantic, our what?”

“Nothing, it’s nothing,” he laughed unconvincingly. “Wow, that ocean sure is…dark. Hey, do you think it’s still blue even when we can’t see it?”

“Seeebaaaastiaaaaan,” Mermista needled. “C’mon, tell me. Tell your wiiiiiife.”

“Not my wife yet.”

She pouted. “Technicalities.”

He groaned, rolling his eyes skyward. “Odds you’ll let it go?”

“Big fat zero. It’ll keep up. All night. And then I’ll be bored. And I’ll press my ice cold feet to your ass for entertainment.”

“Cruel, cruel woman.”

“C’mon Sebastian…” She kissed the side of his neck softly. “Our what?”

He sighed, knowing he had lost, like he usually always did in these little tete-a-tetes. “Our kids.”

“What, really?” Mermista furrowed her brow.

“Not like, ours ours, but yeah. I dunno.” He ducked his head and scratched his nose. “It’s silly. I’ve never thought I wouldn’t have kids, just always assumed I would. So I would think about them when I was bored, or pining; what they’d look like, who they’d sound like, if they’d laugh like me, or my spouse. Now I think about whether they'll like shanties, or prefer dramatic rock power ballads.” He nudged her and she blushed, rolling her eyes.

“Shut up.” She played with his fingers where they rested on her thigh, one of her preferred ways to fidget while she thought. “I always knew I’d have kids. As an heir to a runestone, you don’t have a crazy amount of choice. For a long time, I had convinced myself I didn’t want them. And then, I dunno, the thought became…bearable. Then it was kind of nice, the idea of a mini-me running around. Maybe they’d like to dress up with me, wear makeup. I could teach them to surf, teach them hydrokinesis…”

“And now?”

Mermista shook her thoughts away. “Now what?”

“You said it was bearable, then it was nice…and now?”

Mermista looked away as casually as she could manage. “Are we really having this talk right now?”

“Sure seems like we are.” Sea Hawk was trying to tread carefully. Kids had been brought up in the abstract before, as an inevitability. But this felt…real. There was intent in their words, and it made his heart race.

Mermista shifted in his lap, clearly struggling to voice whatever she was feeling.

He ducked his lips to the soft skin where her neck met her jaw, just above her nearly-invisible gills. Fine scales ticked his lips, and he decided to take a risk while he peppered kisses along her neck. “You know, I still think about them. Now, it’s just easier. I think about how they’ll roll their eyes, or groan when they’re annoyed. I think about how their noses will wrinkle when they laugh. I think about little saris, and lehenga, and kurtas, embellished in gold, at Princess Prom. I think about tails, the colors of their scales, or if they’ll have them. I think about what shade of blue their hair will be, if it’ll have finn in it. If their eyes will be amber, or blue, or brown.”

“I…” Mermista had relaxed under his ministrations. “I think about missing teeth, and bruises, and broken bones from going on adventures. Or about little bandanas holding back messy finn curls.” She ran her hands through his hair, scratching his scalp. “I think about how much they’ll love music, and singing. I think about days at the beach, surfing and playing and making sure they don’t drown their dad.” His breath hitched, the word ‘dad’ hitting him hard in the chest. “It was nice. And now, sometimes, when I see you it’s all I can think about. I want it so bad sometimes, especially after the portal, that it hurts. And now…I don’t know when, or even if, I can give us that.”

Sea Hawk brought her lips to his, eyes burning slightly. “ *We* will meet her or him or them whenever we’re meant to. You’re under so much pressure right now, love, don’t add this to the pile.”

“I get that, like, logically and practically. But…” Mermista groaned, and blinked up at the sky. “Fucking hell, I’m sick of crying.”

“But what?” He kissed her cheek softly. She mumbled something he couldn’t understand, her face scarlet and burning under his lips. “What was that?”

“...But, I want a baby.”

The yearning in her voice, plain and simple, or what should have been simple, broke his heart. “I do, too.”

“Are we stupid?” she chuckled wetly. “We’re in the middle of a war, we can’t have a baby.”

“No,” he sighed, scratching at the damp corners of his eyes. “But I think it’s only natural to want to create in the face of so much destruction.”

Mermista sighed, curling against him. “It’s weird, to want something so normal, but so insanely incredible, something we could do, like, whenever, technically.” He smirked at her implication. “But then not be able to do it.”

“I understand, uh, I think.” Sea Hawk sometimes couldn’t follow her more abstract tangents, but he tried. “Can I help? In any way?”

“Other than knocking me up?”

He coughed, harshly, making her chuckle. “Um, yes, dearest, other than that.”

“...can we go to bed? And read the Mer-Mystery I know you packed?”

“Nothing gets past you, huh?”

“I don’t know why you try.” Mermista climbed to her feet, helping him up and calling some water out of the sea to bank the fire and flick off the lanterns. Sea Hawk grabbed her discarded clothes off the deck and gave them to her before dumping the fish remains overboard along with the charred wood. Then he took her hand and let her lead him to bed. Later, after she’d fallen asleep on his chest to the vibrations of his voice as he read to her, he laid awake, pondering abstract thoughts himself. Of course they couldn’t have a baby right now, not when they could die any day and leave them as alone as they’d been left. He knew that would tear Mermista apart, in whatever place they went to after this.

Mermista’s love was strong, and selfless, even if it was bruised and hidden away, too. He was lucky enough to receive it regularly now, in a myriad of capacities, and he knew how deeply it ran for those she deemed her own. The unconditionality of it amazed him. She would be an incredible mother, he mused as he banked the lantern in the v-berth, and he would be the luckiest man alive to share a child with someone as strong and loving as her.

Someday.

– - - - - - - - - - - -

They found the refugee camp on an abandoned, ravaged islet town called Lua Pele. The sand on the shores was black, and the soil was rich and dark with nutrients. The ground when they came ashore was warm to the touch, even through their shoes. Where the natural structures of Salineas’ main island were built of sandstone, coral, and the precious gems and minerals mined from the sea floor, here the buildings (what remained of them) were fashioned out of rhyolite and andesite bases, soft pinks mingling with ashy greys, on a bedrock of long-cooled lava. The temple in the distance looked to be carved entirely from obsidian, sparkling in the morning sun. It was one of the most beautiful islands Sea Hawk had ever seen, even half-destroyed.

“Maevik pinged us from this island,” Mermista glanced at his datapad. “It’s a residential village, there are no resources or weapons or anything like that to pillage, so the Horde shouldn’t be returning here. And if they do…”

“They’ll live just long enough to sorely regret it.” He finished.

“Word. Let’s go.”

They moved inland carefully, trident and sword brandished, footsteps careful. The Horde may not be active here anymore, but if the refugees were here and Hordak had found out… not to mention the possibility of traps, or just idle occupation by enemy forces. Mermista grit her teeth, eyes scanning the streets they walked. It was painfully quiet, like the entire island was holding its breath.

The hair on the back of her neck prickled, and she spun to javelin her trident at whoever was behind her. Maevik hit the ground with a yelp, just barely avoiding the trident that embedded itself in a wall behind him. The man wheezed from his prone sprawl. “Greetings, your majesty.”

“Shit! Maevik, I’m sorry!” She rushed over to him, hauling him to his feet by the elbow. “Are you alright?”

“My, you’ve gotten good at that,” he turned to admire the trident, still vibrating from impact. “I remember when you couldn’t hit the front side of a barn running full speed.”

“Yeah, well, war.”

“War, indeed.” He retrieved her trident for her, tossing it to her casually. He bowed to them both, but accepted Sea Hawk’s handshake with a slight smile. Sea Hawk would never not treat the staff as his equals, insisting they not defer to him. It made the staff uncomfortable, which she found amusing as the inverse was just as true. They’d find a rhythm someday.

“How many…where is everyone?” Mermista settled for.

“Come, my Queen,” he gestured for them to follow him. “They wait for you more inland. Horde drones have been scanning the outer banks, as that’s where most of the residencies were. They’re crude, though. The children have been using them for target practice.”

They hiked inland, up stairs carved from cooled lava, along pathways lined with beautiful stones, down slopes bordered by lush, tall grass. “This island is beautiful.” Sea Hawk murmured.

“Do you think so?” Maevik grinned. “Lua Pele is my home island. I am glad to see it still standing. Well, sort of.”

“I never knew that,” Mermista said. “Do you have family here? Are they alright?”

“The only island to suffer casualties was the capital. So, silver linings I suppose. Everyone is eagerly awaiting your arrival.”

Mermista wrung her braid in her hair. “So they’re not…”

Maevik seemed to understand her unfinished thought, turning to her with sympathy in his deep blue eyes. “No one blames you, my Queen. They were all on board with the idea to reclaim Dryl. They know that if you had been here, nothing would be different, save for the fact that you may well be dead.”

Sea Hawk swallowed the bile that rose in his throat at the idea. “Your people love you, dearest.”

“They truly do, your majesty.” Maevik smiled, a rare and genuine one. Mermista smiled back, but it didn’t reach her eyes. They all knew the guilt would be present for years to come, and all they could do was regularly reassure her of what they knew to be true. Maevik’s eyes met Sea Hawk’s over Mermista’s slightly bowed head, and A Look passed between them, one of mutual determination to not let this consume her.

Maevik led them down a smaller path, into a grove of koa trees that knotted thick over their heads. The forest floor was open, the trunks narrower at the base and leaving plenty of room to walk. The path turned to paver stone and shining rocks embedded in lava, and soon the path led them through the thick fronds of a bush and into a bustling town.

The buildings here were mostly intact, and what wasn't was covered in tarp and eucalyptus trunks, knotted with thick and sturdy ropes and overlaid with canvas. Repair teams were clearly already hard at work, buckets of spackle and rhyolite concrete mixtures sitting around. Tents dotted the streets, marked for food, medical supplies, spiritual services, the various military corps., child care centers, and more. No one was milling about, not even the children, running from tent to building to congregations of adults with scrolls, papers, datapads, supplies, schematics.

The first to notice them was a broad shouldered Octarian man in a hardhat, long tentacles hanging from his chin to his knees. He shouted, dropping his clipboard and bucket on the tail of a ginger magicat in sorcerer's robes. She yowled, whirling to rake claws across scaled flesh, but freezing on the spot at the sight of Mermista. She quickly dropped to one knee, elbowing the larger man into a bow. "Hail, Queen Mermista!"

That caught fire quickly, groups of refugees turning to her, stopping what they were doing to stare. Children elbowed their way to the front, clearing the way for an elderly looking Swami in sorcerer robes and a rich sea green turban, fastened with a pearl at the front. His mustache was groomed to a point, his beard perfectly quaffed despite the destruction he'd no doubt been through. His eyes were a striking purple, and wise beyond measure. Mermista bowed to *him* , startling a few people in the crowd.

"Shastri Dhang." Mermista addressed the man.

He assessed her with a glance before gesturing her forward. "Come, *priy* , I must check your connection to the Pearl."

" *Jee, shreemaan* ," she murmured. She gestured for Sea Hawk to follow her, taking his hand when he came closer. "I would like Sebastian to accompany me."

The man's eyes raked over Sea Hawk, stripping him down to his soul with his gaze while the pirate tried his very hardest not to fidget. At length, he nodded slowly. "That is amenable. Meet me in the temple. I trust your people will want to speak with you on the way."

He disappeared into the crowd and Sea Hawk leaned into her ear. "Who was that?"

"That's the Swami in charge of protecting the Pearl when I'm not here. It's the highest spiritual position in our nation, as he's the only other person who can even remotely access the Pearl's magic," she murmured back. "He delivered me, too, and gave me one of my titles. He’s like…a godfather? In a way? For the royal family.”

“Whoa,” Sea Hawk murmured, swallowing hard. “So, like, no pressure.” Mermista just snorted, making her way toward the crowd. She gripped his hand tightly before letting go to fold her arms in front of her like she’d been taught to when addressing people as nobility.

“Hey,” she started simply, prompting some smiles. “There is…so much I want to say to all of you, and just not enough time, or words, to say it all. So I will keep it as simple and genuine as possible.

“I’m sorry, first of all, for not being with you at our darkest hour. I understand that I couldn’t have changed anything, but I’m sorry nonetheless. As your queen, your Princess, it’s my duty, and my honor and joy, to be in your service. To defend you, and protect you. And I couldn’t do that for you, and I am sorry. I will always be sorry.

“Second, I am unspeakably proud of and grateful for every single one of you, those present…and those not. We have suffered an immense, and painful loss. Now, with the destruction of our home, and for many, many years prior at the hands of those who didn’t value us as they should have,” some people bowed their heads, others spat on the ground. “But they were wrong to ever doubt us. I can say with all authority that we are the strongest people on Etheria.

We are a people who were raised by the laws of the ocean, by its magnitude and beauty, and taught to respect its power. *We* are that power," she gripped her trident tightly, meeting as many eyes as she could. "We are the spirit of the sea, its indomitable force, and we never stop. The Horde may have won this battle, through lies, deceit, and slimy, disgusting sneak attacks like the cowards we've always known they are," cheers went up, curses upon the Horde following suit. Sea Hawk watched in amazement as the crowd's energy shifted from tired, to hesitantly hopeful, to something hot, burning with fervor and pride. "They may have won this battle, yes, but *we* will win this war! With our courage, and our strength, we will make them regret ever even looking at our kingdom and thinking they could take it."

Shouts and yells of 'yeah!', 'to the queen!', and 'make them pay!' were growing louder and louder as Mermista continued.

"We *will* rebuild Salineas, better than it has ever been, and we'll do it together. We will build in the name of peace, and in unity, the jewel we have always known our kingdom to be," Mermista took a breath to steady herself, and Sea Hawk squeezed her hand. He was so proud of her, in awe of her grace, and he was certain it was all over his face. And probably the number one reason Mermista was absolutely *not* looking at him. "When I was a little girl, I thought that being a queen meant sitting in boring meetings all day, and signing papers full of words I had to read twice to understand. I thought that being a Princess meant I got a cool power, that I was, like, automatically the best surfer ever, and that I'd never have to refill my own teacup ever again," a murmur of laughter ran through the crowd as Mermista smiled self-deprecatingly. "And it doesn't *not* mean those things. But that's only a fraction of what the crown has come to mean to me. The greatest gift I have ever received as my birthright is the chance to serve you all to the best of my ability. Every day of my whole life, I have been inspired by your brilliance, the capacity of Salineas to adapt, to overcome everything this war has thrown at our people.

I'm going to wrap this up now, because as I'm sure you all know, this is not exactly within my comfort zone," chuckles and murmurs of amusement buzzed through the assembled. "But I would like to remind all of us, myself included, that Salineas is not just a place. It's not a castle, or a harbor, or a bazaar, or a big shiny gate. It's us, all of us standing here, and those who aren't anymore; it's our culture, our memories, our beliefs and values and our community. It's the dreams of the generations that came before us, and the hopes we'll inspire in all who come after. And that's something that the Horde can *never* take away, can *never* destroy. And it's what I promise to continue to fight for, every day."

The cheers grew to a dull roar, and the stamping of feet and tridents and whatever else shook the very ground beneath their feet. Mermista turned to him then, looking utterly worn out and overwhelmed, but also stronger than she'd been before. Per usual, she had been right; she needed to be here, with her people, where she could make a physical difference. The very presence of their queen had clearly bolstered the people, and when the crowd parted for them to pass through, there was a new life humming among them all.

Sea Hawk grinned, at first shy and then with his usual relish, as he received nods and small bows and claps on the shoulder from the people they passed. A few sailors and former pirates who'd taken up residence in Salineas whistled good naturedly as he walked by, publicly hand-in-hand with the queen. Mermista hadn't brought him up to stand next to her, he hadn't expected her to, but this was her way of telling the people her choice.

They broke through the crowd and began down a quieter side street, lined with untouched houses. The tree cover high above them was thick, but not so thick that light couldn’t seep through. The dull roar of the ocean was far off, but omnipresent and comforting. The entire island seemed to be a tucked away paradise. The homes’ doors were open, warmth and good smells spilling onto the streets. The porches and front yards were full of cookouts, or campfires surrounded by the eldery, most of whom sat in sprawling chairs or reclining on lawns. Mothers with young children strapped to their backs, or babies in slings against their chests, were moving debris, running materials and ingredients between homes, or tending to the injured soldiers and civilians who had been laid here. In many camps, those who weren’t hurt enough for the tents but still too injured to resume activity were cared for by the locals, and Salineas was no different.

Many stopped and stared as they walked by, bowing or curtseying as they walked by. The elderly and injured made an odd hand gesture, and Mermista returned it. He frowned in confusion, and she copied the gesture again. “It’s a sign of respect in Salinean culture. Many of our citizens can’t bow, y’know, fins, tentacles, so on, or they won’t for spiritual reasons, so they do this instead. My father hated it.”

“All the more reason to do it.”

They were approaching a battered, obsidian carved temple like the one they’d seen on the way in. It was beautiful, the runes carved in it a mixture of First Ones’ writing and native Salinean. Sea Hawk could only make out a few words; he’d have to start brushing up on that if he was going to be king. A shout interrupted them.

“Queen Mermista!”

They turned, Sea Hawk’s hand flying to his sword, and saw a young sea elf, or maybe a nymph, running toward them. Mermista relaxed, gesturing for him and Maevik to stand down as she crouched to meet the young girl. “Eliza, you’re okay!”

Ah, yes. The young sailor who’d taken a shine to his dearest. The girl, despite the mortified yelp of the woman running after her, ran straight into Mermista, arms latching around her neck desperately. Mermista stood with her, adjusting the slight girl on her hip so she could hook bruised knees around her waist.

The nanny caught up with them. “Your majesty, a thousand pardons, I am so sorry for her. Eliza has been having some… difficulty adjusting.”

“Duh,” Mermista deadpanned. “I’m sure she’s, like, traumatized.”

“Yes, well, decorum is what it is- Eliza, let go.”

“No!” The girl gripped Mermista tighter, tiny clawed hands digging into the scaled mail of her tank. Mermista waved the nanny off.

“Seriously, it’s fine. I’ll bring her back in a bit.”

The woman warred with herself for a minute, but the crying of another young child took her attention away from them. Eliza had buried her head in Mermista’s braid, fanned ears fluttering slightly at the noise around them but otherwise still.

Sea Hawk and Mermista frowned at one another. He leaned in, careful not to touch her. “Hello, lass. What seems to be the problem?”

No answer, just a jerky shrug and sniffle.

“Hey, c’mon, kid,” Mermista jostled her gently, stroking her hair. “Can we talk about it?”

“Not s’posed to.” Eliza hiccuped. Mermista frowned.

“Why not?”

“I dunno,” Eliza pulled back a little to wipe her face, which they could now see was damp with tears. Her hiccups wracked her body, holding back sobs. “Pop-pop said not to. Said it wasn’t done. Said…said it would just make it hurt longer. I don’t want it to hurt longer.”

“Don’t want what to hurt?” Mermista brushed damp strands of forest green hair off wet cheeks. “Eliza, you can tell me. I promise you won’t be in trouble.”

She coughed, heaving for air. Sea Hawk took his red bandana off his neck and offered it to her. Eliza took it gently, wiping her face. “Pinky promise?”

Sea Hawk took the proffered pinky, as Mermista’s hands were full. “Absolutely.” He swore solemnly. Eliza inhaled shakily, clearly trying to compose herself enough to speak. Sea Hawk admired the young girl’s poise. He rarely spoke coherently, and he was an adult.

“When the bad guys- the Horde- attacked Salineas,” her small, webbed hands playing with Mermista’s braid. To his shock, Mermista let her; his dearest was incredibly particular about her hair. “My Mommy…she ran to the docks to help, to go out with her fleet. They were on shore leave, on- on preserve?”

“Reserve,” Mermista murmured, not unkindly. “She ran to help.”

“Yeah,” Eliza hiccoughed. She was quiet for a moment, and then all at once her face crumpled. “She didn’t come back. A-and my Pop Pop says she- she’s never coming back…ever again…”

Whatever she said next was unintelligible through her tears, but it didn't matter. They'd heard more than enough to piece together what had happened. Mermista said nothing, just tucked the small girl's head back into her neck and let her cry. Sea Hawk tried to catch her eyes, but they were glazed over, distant. To anyone else, she would look incredibly indifferent, even bored, right now, but Sea Hawk knew her too well. He knew she was hurting something awful right now, guilt manifesting in a near-total emotional shutdown.

The only way he knew she was still with them and not completely walled off was the way her hand ran over Eliza's back in soothing circles, nails scraping lightly through gauzy cotton. Sea Hawk hovered, uncertain; he wasn't much better than Mermista at big feelings. Sure, he talked a great game, but where Mermista clammed up, he ran. He'd sort of run during the whole Boys' Night Scheme, and even if she hadn't brought it up, they both knew his flight instincts had played a role. He was determined not to bolt now, no matter how much he wanted to. Instead, he took the handkerchief out of Eliza's hand and held it out for Mermista to wet.

He dabbed Eliza's face with the freshly soaked fabric. "Of course you need to talk about this, Eliza," he murmured. She lifted her face enough for him to wipe tears and snot and dirt- the primary ingredients of children- from her cheeks. She heaved a shaking breath, lips wobbling as she regarded him with wary curiosity. "I lost my mother to the Horde, too, you know. And so did Mermista. And it hurt so bad, then, I thought I'd never stop crying."

"Didja?"

“Well, I’m not crying now, hm?” Eliza nodded slowly, following his logic. “The only way to stop hurting so much, and someday, start healing, is to talk.”

Mermista hummed in agreement, pulling Eliza back a bit so she could look her in the eye. “It hurts at first, talking about people who are gone. But, it’s how we keep them with us. When memories become all we have, it’s important to share them, and keep their spirit alive.”

“I…I had a question.” Eliza fiddled with the hem of her top, frayed and a bit dirty.

“Shoot, kid.”

“Last time, you- you brought her back,” her tiny voice quivered, and he heard Mermista’s sharp intake of breath. “When I missed her, you brought her back, and you said that you could do anything because you were a Princess. Could you…bring her back now? Please?”

Mermista sighed, closing her eyes. Sea Hawk placed a hand on her lower back, feeling otherwise helpless. “ *Beta* , if I could, I would in a heartbeat. I swear to you, I would. But I’m not a goddess. I wish I could bring back all of our mothers, and fathers, and brothers and sisters, but I- I can’t. I’m sorry.”

Eliza slumped against her again. "That's okay. I didn't really think it worked like that, but I had to ask."

They stayed for a while, Mermista just holding the small girl, swaying gently until her tears turned to sniffles, then to hiccups, then the rattling breaths that always came like a gentle breeze after a storm. "Will you be alright, Eliza?"

She shrugged. "I guess. Pop-pop's lungs are getting tired…but I've got the other kids, I guess. I can help run things to people around the camp. No boats to sail here."

Sea Hawk shared a sad smile with her. "I'm afraid carefree days on the open sea will have to take a break for a while, lass."

"Yeah," she sighed, sounding wistful beyond her years. "I don't like waiting. It feels like all the grown-ups are just…sitting around and waiting for the Horde."

Mermista smiled sadly. "Sometimes, there's not much else to do."

"We could fight!"

"Not everyone is built to fight, *chutki* ."

“I could,” the little nymph pouted, green scales on her pale cheeks winked as she puffed them. “I’m strong from sailing. And I’m fast, I got out of Salineas before all the other kids! I could fight.”

Sea Hawk chuckled, but Mermista looked thoughtful. “How old are you now?”

“I just turned eight.”

“Hmmm,” she craned her neck to glance at Maevik, who had remained a few yards away. “Hey, royal fork-bearer, how old was I when I started training with you?”

“Six, Your Majesty.” Maevik looked like he was just barely holding back a deeply beleaguered sigh.

“Right,” she smirked at Eliza. “Tell you what, kid. I’ll come collect you from the creche tomorrow morning after breakfast. And we’ll start you out with some basic self-defense forms.”

“I can fight?” Eliza’s eyes were bright with excitement, with purpose.

“You can train,” Mermista corrected firmly. “Being good at anything takes lots of practice, and fighting is more than just punching and stabbing, kay?”

“Kay!” She chirped, legs swinging by Mermista’s hips. “Thanks, your majesty!”

“You can call me Mermista, kid.”

“Thanks, Mermista. Thanks, mustache man.”

“Sea Hawk, Eliza,” he sighed. “My name is Sea Hawk.”

“Mustache King?”

“That’s a terrible compromise. But! I accept.”

Eliza giggled, reaching out to hug Mermista one more time. “I’ll see you tomorrow, kid.”

“Tomorrow!” Mermista placed her gently on her feet, waving goodbye as she ran off. Sea Hawk wrapped his arm around her waist, and it was a testament to her fragile emotional state that she leaned in without hesitation.

“I feel like I just got punched in the heart by She-Ra. In a bad way.”

“No one blames you, love.”

“I do,” her voice cracked slightly, and rolled her eyes at herself. “Eliza’s mom is gone because of-”

“The Horde.”

“Because I couldn’t stop them.”

“You know that’s not true.”

“But it feels true!” she snapped. “It feels true, and I don’t know how to make it stop.”

“By listening to me, and Maevik, and your people,” he moved to grip her jaw lightly but firmly, making sure her eyes were on his. “I love you, Mermista. Remember? I’m not here to lie to you, and you need to trust me.”

“I’m trying.” She closed her eyes, tears slipping out silently.

“I know you are,” he murmured. “But everyone gets tired of swimming against their own current. And that’s when you come find me, right?”

“Yeah, I guess,” she sighed, aiming for dismissive and aloof but landing somewhere sad and despondent. “I feel like I’m drowning, which is, like, pathetically ironic.”

“Just keep your head above water, Mermista, and let me help with the rest?” He brushed her tears away with his thumb. “Please?”

“Okay,” she sighed. “Okay. Let’s go check on the Pearl, and then we need to check in with Glimmer.”

“Lead the way, dearest.”

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The temple was vacant, and they followed an acolyte dressed in light blue and shimmering white toward the center of the building. There sat Swami Dhang, eyes closed in meditation, below a massive collection of stones, pearls, sea glass, and other precious materials. They were fastened together by ethereal rope, not unlike the webbing Netossa controlled, displayed like a large suncatcher. Light from the setting day-moons cast nebulas of light around them, shades of blue, green, gold, purple, and everything in between. It felt like they were sitting on the horizon line at the end of a clear day, floating in the space between the sky and the mural it cast on the ocean, just before night came.

Mermista guided him to sit in a lotus position on two cushions. He held his back straight like she was doing, and tried not to fidget. When his fingers began tapping of their own accord, she linked them with her own, and wordlessly bade him to mimic her slow and deep breaths. He shut his eyes, focusing only on his breathing, and how his body felt, just like Perfuma had shown him at Princess Prom. It was years ago, now, but it felt like just yesterday, and also three lifetimes ago.

After what could have been one minute or one hour, Swami Dhang spoke. “How have you been feeling, my queen? Has the Pearl been speaking to you?”

“Not super clearly, no,” Mermista murmured. “My hydrokinesis is fine, but I feel…disconnected.”

“From the Pearl?”

“No, more from the sea itself. I could always feel it, even when I was deep inland. Now, it feels far. I can’t hear the waves in my dreams anymore.”

“Have you been able to speak with the life in the waves?”

“Not well, no.”

Sea Hawk frowned in confusion. “You can talk to animals?”

Mermista shot him a look that very clearly said *really bold move to interrupt right now, buddy* . “Yeah, it’s not just seagulls.”

He nodded, blushing. “Sorry, forgive my interruption.”

Dhang’s face was unchanged, but his eyes sparkled a bit. “Your chosen’s spirit is bright, and impatient, like fire and lightning.”

Mermista just nodded. “He gets that a lot.”

Sea Hawk opened his mouth to apologize again for his…spirit? But Dhang cut him off. “I did not say that was a bad thing. Mermista was born to a rainstorm,” he began setting out incense, raw cut pearls, gold totems that looked older than Etheria itself. “And she has carried this in her aura ever since. Lightning seems random, chaotic, even destructive to those who do not understand the purpose it serves. When storms become too strong, and get caught up in themselves, lightning strikes to relieve the pressure, to break the tension, so that the hurricane can roll on as it’s meant to.”

Dhang fixed them both with a level stare. Mermista wasn’t looking at him, but Sea Hawk could feel her anyway, feel her presence beside him in a way that couldn’t be quantified. He felt like he was holding his breath. “And what else do you see, Shastri?”

The older man smiled, just barely. "That is for you to spend the rest of your lives finding out, *beta* . Now, come, and let me feel your connection."

Mermista moved forward so Dhang could take her hands. He picked up a long, thin stick that looked like charcoal, and began drawing on Mermista's hands. Instead of soot, lines of pearlescent ink followed his hand, glowing in the low light. Sea Hawk couldn't help himself, scooting forward to get a better look. For as long as he'd been with Mermista, she remained pretty tight-lipped about the arcane magic that bound her to the Pearl, and the extent of its power. He felt like he was witnessing something very few ever saw.

Dhang stopped drawing, and picked up a lit incense stick, weaving the smoke through Mermista's fingers, up her arms, around her head. He touched the burning end of it to the center of her brow, and Sea Hawk winced. Mermista didn't flinch, and Dhang moved the fire off of her. He placed a bowl underneath her hands, and crushed a rock that shone like the legendary stars in his first, dusting the powder onto her inked hands. Lastly, he drew forth a jewel-encrusted blade.

Sea Hawk couldn't help himself. "What's that for?"

Dhang merely glanced at him. "I need a bit of Mermista's blood to check her body's connection to the pearl."

“Relax, Sebastian,” Mermista murmured, eyes still shut. “It doesn’t hurt me.”

He grit his teeth and nodded, not that he really needed to give permission in this situation. Nonetheless, the swami nodded back, and quickly sliced the blade of the knife across Mermista’s left palm, turning her hand over so the blood dripped, darker and… bluer than Sea Hawk thought blood should be, but maybe that was just the lowlight. True to her word, Mermista’s eyelids didn’t even flutter.

When her blood hit the bowl, the contents began smoking and swirling. Dhang stood, and moved one of the hanging mirrored stones so the light bouncing around the temple hit the bowl. Blue fire erupted, but it looked…heavy. Like water, almost. Sea Hawk was overcome by the urge to touch it, but Mermista snatched his hand out of the air with a glare. He smiled sheepishly.

Dhang sat back down, pushing and prodding the flames. His thick brows were knit, the teal bindi on his forehead displaced by the movement. “This is very strange.”

“What’s wrong?” Mermista examined her cut, as though unaffected, but Sea Hawk could hear her voice trembling.

“Your connection is strong, but it’s almost being…filtered. Or siphoned somewhere. There’s another presence, barely there, tampering with the power of the connection, but not the connection itself. I’ve never seen anything like it.”

“So how can we fix it?”

Dhang frowned heavily, leveling Mermista with a deep stare. “You’ll have to reconnect to the Pearl manually, refresh your bond.”

“Refresh?”

Dhang smiled with his eyes. “The Pearl is alive, *beta* . It knows you. It misses you. Like saying hello to an old friend, it wants to check in with you. You have a symbiotic relationship. The Pearl grants you the blessing of the sea, a chance to communicate with the waves that tie us together, give us life. And you give it that chance in return, to connect with its element. You are a conduit, it’s avatar, just as all Princesses are. You must be in harmony to fully understand one another.”

Mermista sighed. “I remember some of this, from my first connection. I guess with the war, I may have, kind of, sort of, forgotten a lot of it.”

“You have had quite a bit on your plate,” he waved off. “No one can remember everything all the time. Now, come, we need to figure out your reconnection.”

“What- now?” Mermista’s eyebrow touched her hairline. “Salineas is, like, extremely hostile and very occupied. There’s no chance in hell of getting to the Pearl.”

“Only a fool’s chance,” Dhang glanced at Sea Hawk then Mermista. “Have faith in the capabilities of your chosen, *beta* . He’s lived this long.”

“Hey,” Sea Hawk frowned, but he was already thinking. “We could…use the old catacombs?”

“The underwater ones that are almost completely stopped up with rocks and sea monsters?”

“Yes, obviously, what other catacombs would I mean? A small team, Maevik, you, and me-”

“Absolutely not. You can’t breathe underwater, and I can’t…check on you down there,” she avoided Dhang’s shrewd gaze. “I can maybe sneak in with Maevik but if the Horde gets me-”

“They won’t, because I’m coming with you, and I’ll die before I let that happen.”

“I won’t let you die.”

“Then we can’t lose,” he grinned. “Mermista, I go where you go. Nothing changes that. If this needs to get done, then we’ll do it together.”

She held her glare for a few more seconds, but he saw her resolve give way. “Ugh, you’re so stubborn.”

“If I may interrupt,” the Swami’s eyes swam with mirth. “I may have a solution for our king-to-be here.” He rummaged through a bag, withdrawing a vial, a plant, and a book. He pushed the bowl aside, and began drawing a rune on the floor. He followed the pattern he drew with the vial, and placed the plant in the middle. “Sebastian-”

“Uh, Sea Hawk, please,” Sea Hawk blurted before he could stop himself. Dhang raised an eyebrow. “It’s- I just-”

Mermista swooped in. “Sebastian is…personal. Sea Hawk is his given name. You understand, I’m sure.”

“Of course,” Dhang nodded. “Apologies, Sea Hawk.”

“It’s really fine,” he hastened to assure. “Please, go on.”

“Place your hand over the plant, palm to the fronds,” he did as Dhang instructed, and felt tiny sparks lance up his hand and down his arm where he touched the plant. He shuddered, and watched as an otherworldly glow creeped up his arm. “You will feel a slight burning, in your neck and chest, but it is normal, and you’re in no trouble.”

“What is this doing?” The burning was taking root, and he fought to not jerk away from the rune circle.

“You’re growing temporary gills and an altered respiratory system.”

“Oh- WHAT?!” Sea Hawk *did* jerk his hand away this time, but the glow followed him. It was on his neck and chest now, growing brighter and brighter. He doubled over at the waist, groaning and coughing- it felt like his sun blade was slicing little bits out of his neck, one at a time. His chest was imploding, air being compressed out of his lungs and choking him. Hands were on his shoulder, strong and reassuring. Mermista. He reached out blindly and grabbed one.

And then, like it had never happened, it was over. He drew in great lungfuls of breath, coughing through the lingering burn. Dhang nodded approvingly. “Excellent, he still has his ears.”

“That was a possibility-!”

“We have no time,” Dhang rose to his feet, and thrust the book at Mermista along with a satchel of iridescent powder. “I am too old to make this journey with you, Princess. But when you get there, draw the teleportation rune I’ve bookmarked and I will come through to help you.”

“Uh, I’m not a sorceress-”

“Your father was, and it’s genetic enough that you should be able to pull at least this off.”

“Reassuring.” Mermista grimaced. Sea Hawk patted her shoulder comfortingly.

“The gills will last six hours. Go, now, so you make it back.”

They nodded, both bowing deeply to the Swami before making a hasty exit. They found Maevik waiting outside, picking crud and dirt off his trident. They sped past him so quickly he did a double take, and nearly tripped over himself trying to catch up.

“Your Majesties, please!”

“No time!” Mermista called over her shoulder. “We have to get to the Pearl, like, *now!* ”

Maevik sprinted ahead of them. “I’ll ask on the way. Follow me!”

He led them through the camp town and down a hidden path that plunged them deep into the jungle. It was mid afternoon now, and the sun blazed through the gaps in the trees in blinding splotches. They leapt over roots and ducked under branching tendrils ripe with blossoms and fruit until they reached a rocky, steep shore. Maevik and Mermista cast aside their footwear, and Sea Hawk followed suit.

“It’s deep here, and the current strong. He’ll need your help.”

“On it.” Mermista yanked her hair out of it’s loose braid and tightened it up with quick fingers. She turned to him as she worked. “Don’t let go of me. Just because you can breathe underwater doesn’t mean you’re gonna grow a tail.”

“Is there a spell for that?”

“Focus, Sebastian.”

“Right, sorry.”

Mermista and Maevik strapped their tridents to their backs with their holsters, and Sea Hawk rechecked his scabbard’s ties. He nodded when he was set, and tried to keep the trepidation he was feeling off of his face. Maevik hopped in first, leaving Mermista and him on the shore.

“Sebastian,” she tugged him close with firm hands on his hips. “If I tell you to let go, let go. If I tell you to swim away, you do. The legends about Salinean waters exist for a reason, and you’re not going to be as equipped as you normally are to face anything head on. So listen to me, without question. Please.”

He nodded, reached up to cup her cheek. “You know I’ll follow wherever you lead me, dearest.”

“Ugh, sap.” Still, she leaned forward to leave a lingering kiss on his lips. Without further warning, she hooked a strong arm around him, and fell into the rushing surf below.

Sea Hawk had held his breath on instinct, but it was knocking from his lungs quickly; the current was impossibly strong here, almost like it had a mind of its own. He opened his eyes in a panic as he gasped, inhaling seawater-

Only to feel his lungs fill with air- salty, heavy air, but still oxygen. He kicked out hard to get away from the jagged rocks of the steep shoreline, and saw movement in his peripheral. A long, green tail, tinted with yellow, slid around him, circling. It was thinner than Mermista’s, lithe with muscle. Where her tail had sleek, subtle fins like the back of a blue whale, or a dolphin, this tail was studded with tall, jagged fins, sharp and jutting like a shark. He jumped, instinctively pushing away from it, and collided with something warm and solid.

“Sea Hawk, while I’m fond of you, this is a bit *too* close, hm?” Ah, it was Maevik’s toned chest that he’d thrown himself into. He allowed the man to push him away, just in time for Mermista to swim into view, taking him by the waist. He spun, and saw that the tail did in fact belong to Maevik.

He gaped a bit. “But…I thought that Mermista’s bloodline were the only merfolk in Salineas.”

“When the Queen’s ancestors left the undersea kingdom, some loyal followers made the journey into exile with them. My family has served the monarchy for centuries, even before we walked on sand. We keep it quiet, though. Land-dwelling merfolk are still rare.”

“Come on,” Mermista tugged at his waist, and he moved to hold onto her back. “We have a ways to go, and not much time to get there and back before Sea Hawk starts, like, dying.”

Sea Hawk had obviously swam with Mermista in her mermaid form before, but it was usually leisurely, diving or goofing around or whatever. This was completely different; Sea Hawk had ridden skiffs slower than Mermista and Maevik were moving now. It was all he could do to hold on. He could feel the tingle of magic around them, and realized Mermista was also using her abilities to propel them faster.

“Your majesty, there’s something up ahead.” Maevik took the lead, whipping his trident off his back. They rounded a bend in the rocky trench they were racing through, and stopped abruptly.

“Land mines,” Mermista groaned. “Awesome.”

Bulbous, round floaters filled with who knows what were dropped into the sea, bobbing at varying heights. Above them, ships sat in wait. Sea Hawk frowned.

“Why are they sitting above explosives?”

“It’s a blockade,” Maevik murmured. “So if anyone tries to dive to pass, they’ll be blown up.”

“That would kill the Horde, too.”

“Either they don’t care, or they’re ghost ships. Either way, we’re going to have to be careful.”

“Sebastian, hang on tight.” Mermista squeezed his hand where it was hugging her diaphragm. He nodded, digging his fingers into her scaled skin and curving himself to her body. Maevik took the lead, tail moving like a dancing ribbon through the water as he bobbed and weaved between heavy chains. Sea Hawk wanted to squeeze his eyes shut, but he was too paralyzed by anxiety.

Mermista craned her neck, and a low, humming sound, somewhere between a whistle and a groan, floated through the water. A responding hum came back, and suddenly they were diving. It felt like the water got one degree colder for every foot they dove, and it wasn't long before Sea Hawk couldn't see. He hugged Mermista closer, and she patted his hand.

At one point, Mermista's tail brushed a chain, and they all held their breath while they continued to swim, albeit a bit faster. Maevik would click at times, and Mermista would click back, or they'd hum at one another. It was disorienting, and eventually he shut his eyes and let his head rest against Mermista's back while she swam on. Before long, they were ascending, and light was filtering back in.

Sea Hawk opened his eyes to see they were out of the trench, and in the open sea. He loosened his grip on Mermista and she turned to glance at him. "Alright?"

"Never better." He grinned, and she rolled her eyes.

"Hang on, doofus. We're gonna gun it."

No sooner had he adjusted his arms before Mermista took off like a laser cannon round, Maevik falling a bit behind. They careened through the open sea, tearing through schools of fish, pods of dolphins. At one point, they passed under massive shadows, and Sea Hawk looked up to behold the largest whales he'd ever seen. Sharks darted out of their way, and even the usually-vicious sea serpents gave the merfolk a wide berth. "Damn, you all must have quite the rep."

Maevik snorted to his right. “Razor sharp teeth, human intelligence, and opposable thumbs? We’re the total package.”

“They hate us ‘cause they ain’t us,” Mermista deadpanned, suddenly turning headlong into a dive. “We’re here. The caverns into the castle are just below us.”

The seafloor wasn’t far, and nestled between two large rocks there was a small hole. Holes usually meant eels, or poisonous crabs, or dead bodies in Sea Hawk’s experience, so he winced when Mermista sailed through the hole without pause. It was just large enough for the two of them to get through, and he fought off the claustrophobia pressing at his mind. The cramped passage opened quickly, and he was reminded of their treasure hunt in the caves off the coast of Salineas; maybe the tunnels were connected.

The passage was disorienting, up and right and left and down and right and left and up, up, *up* before they broke the surface. Maevik sprung out the water, tail turning into feet as he landed on the cave floor. Well, cave wasn’t very fair. The chamber was tiled with stones and fine metals like the rest of Salineas castle, but it was still bedrock with a pool in the middle. The bodyguard turned and helped them up. “Princess, the rest is on you.”

“Yup,” Mermista pulled the water off them and dumped it back in the pool before she walked up to the far wall. It was unmarked, no seams or cracks or indents, and yet when she pushed a hand to it, a door appeared in a flash of teal. “Shall we?”

They drew their weapons, and made their way carefully through the door. It led them down a short hall, and dumped them out directly into the throne room. The door that swung shut behind them was now practically invisible, blended with the murals of the room. In fact, even knowing it was a door, Sea Hawk was already hard pressed to find the seam.

The throne room was ever the same, just…with cracks. Like a battered tea cup. The throne was intact, but the walls and windows facing the bay were broken through. Glass littered the floor and shone in the fathomless pools around the edge of the room, and the crumbled architecture prevented about half the waterfalls from flowing. Mermista approached the seat, gently brushing stone dust off. Sea Hawk could see her jaw working as she fought back tears; it was one thing to hear it, and another to see it from afar, but to be here, in the middle of it…

She sighed, and turned to Maevik. She spoke briefly in Salinean, and he replied, and they seemed to argue for a bit before Maevik spun and began to head for the door. Mermista frowned. "I'm serious, Maevik. Do not risk your life for this."

"I can handle myself, you majesty," he waved her off. "I'll be back before you've reconnected."

Sea Hawk frowned. "Where is he going?"

"To check something for me," Mermista was avoiding eye contact. "Come on, we need to get the rune set up."

Together, they drew a passable teleportation rune on the ground, adding the appropriate geographic notations to the sketch that would bind it to the rune Dhang was no doubt waiting by. Sure enough, not even a second after they'd finished, the rune flared to life, glowing softly. One second, it was empty, and the next Dhang was before them. His pagri was wrapped tight, his greying facial hair immaculate, and his robes were pristine. He nodded to them.

"Your majesties. I am glad to see you made it safely."

Sea Hawk nodded his gratitude. "Thank you for the gills."

"It was no problem," he demurred. Dhang turned to Mermista. "Are you ready?"

"Totally," she shook her shoulders out, and handed her trident to Sea Hawk. Dhang stepped forward, and pulled a small glass pot from his robes. He dipped his thumb in, and it came out covered in a pearlescent teal powder. He pressed it to Mermista's forehead softly, murmuring something under his breath. "Thank you."

"You need never to thank me, *beta* ."

“I know.”

Mermista turned to face the Pearl, glancing at him nervously. He winked, giving her a surreptitious thumbs up. The corners of her mouth twitched, and that was that. She raised her arms, pulling water out of the bottomless pools to swirl around her and under her feet. It lifted her up, and Sea Hawk stepped back to watch. He’d never actually *seen* a runestone being interacted with, and he was more than a bit curious. Once she was level with the runestone, Mermista pressed both palms against it, eyes closing in concentration. At first, nothing happened. And then, the Pearl began glowing; first, it was just a pinprick of light deep inside the stone, but its intensity grew quickly. Soon, the whole stone was glowing with teal light that should have been blinding, but was just…comforting. Warm, somehow, and refreshing all at once. The glow moved from the Pearl to Mermista, swirling around her like water before engulfing her. Her body was swallowed by light, which grew to take the shape of a mermaid with a long, serpentine tail that swallowed the water under her and ghosted the floor, and a flowing waterfall of hair. The light faded slowly, leaving Mermista behind, back on the floor with them.

She was glowing, resplendent in the light of her runestone, like she did when the Princesses united together under She-Ra’s power. Mermista opened her eyes, the usual copper-amber replaced by a striking teal. It all faded quickly, until the only trace of the Pearl’s power was the slight light that seemed to sink into Mermista’s skin, highlighting patches of usually invisible scales. She sighed, and stretched. “That felt wonderful.”

Dhang smiled serenely. “As it should. Was the Pearl happy to see you?”

“Yeah,” Mermista murmured, blushing slightly. “Felt a bit like coming home after curfew.”

That got the swami to laugh. “I suspect it would, yes. Ah, no matter. Are you ready to leave now?”

“Actually,” Mermista was suddenly *much* redder. “I had one more favor to ask you, *shreemaan.”*

“Anything, child.”

Just then, Maevik came back into the room looking none the worse for wear. In his hand he clutched a small wooden box, which he passed over to Mermista. She opened it, and nodded before closing the lid and glancing at Sea Hawk. He frowned. “Yes, dearest?”

“Just- ugh, okay- hang on, one sec.” She brought the box over to Dhang, who opened it and lifted an eyebrow.

“Are you sure, my queen.”

“I’ve never been more sure of anything in my life,” Mermista’s voice didn’t shake, but her cheeks were only getting redder. Was she feeling alright? “If not now, when? I can’t…I won’t wait for a perfect time that might never come.”

Dhang nodded. “You know I can only perform a binding ceremony, in the light and magic of the Pearl right? It won’t be a full ceremony.”

“That’s enough for now. It has to be. I still get to call him…?”

“Yes, child.”

“Right, then. J-just give me a second with him, okay?”

Maevik yawned. “Castle is deserted. They probably looted it and then went for the bars and market stalls. We have time.”

Mermista grabbed Sea Hawk’s wrist and pulled him away from the other two so they could speak privately. Except, she wouldn’t look at him, and she was biting at her nail beds viciously. Gently, he pried her hands away from her lips and held them in his. “Hey.”

“Hey.” She whispered.

“Wanna tell me what’s going on?”

Mermista grimaced, rolling her eyes, but her heart wasn’t in it. “I’m…rushing into something headfirst for once, because it feels right, and I’m trying not to overthink it because I know it’s just nerves.”

“Alright,” he was somehow even more confused. “What are you rushing into?”

Instead of replying, she pulled the box back out of her pocket and shoved it into his hands. He opened it and his breath caught for a full minute. It was a velvet-lined jewelry box, with three rings snugged tight in the fold. Mermista’s engagement ring, and two wedding bands, one slimmer and more curved to fit the engagement ring. They were each made with a white gold base, and inlaid with rich brown bands of wood. Splitting the wood was a strip of a shining, blue oceanic metal that he couldn’t make out, but he didn’t have to.

“I-I had them made after, um, after the treasure hunt. Gold from the treasure we found. Wood from the ship we reunited on after the portal. And the center is abalone, pearl, and glowstone- the bioluminescent stone we found in the caves. Apparently that’s the working title because no one actually knows what it is, which is, like, kind of lame, but-”

Sea Hawk couldn’t take not kissing her anymore, so he remedied the situation by grabbing her hips and pulling her to him. She gasped a bit, but kissed him back just as hard as he kissed her. The box snapped shut between them, and her hand came up to rest on his chest. Sea Hawk pulled back faster than he'd have preferred. "You mean…right now? You want to do this right now?"

"Is it totally insane that I do?" Mermista chuckled weakly. "I- I can't stand not being married to you, and not knowing what could happen next. I know this is morbid, but if something were to happen to either of us, I'd rather we be husband and wife than just…whatever. You know?"

Sea Hawk nodded, eyes wet. "I do know. But that's not the only reason, right?"

"Of course it's not," Mermista rolled her eyes. "C'mon, Sebastian, how long have we been ignoring this inevitability? To be honest, half the time I forget we're *not* married, because it makes more sense that way. We make more sense together than we do apart. At least, to me. Whatever happens next, if it's good or bad or catastrophic, I want to do it with my husband next to me." Her voice faded shyly, but her eyes held a resolve stronger than steel.

"You're saying so many things." He kissed her cheek.

"Are you sufficiently wooed?"

"Absolutely."

"So," Mermista smiled, small but genuine. "Will you marry me?"

Sea Hawk kissed her again. “Hell yes, I will.”

They broke apart, and Mermista took his hand to lead him to the dais. Dhang stepped forward, a strip of cloth in his hands. “Mermista, if you please?” She pulled some water forward to soak the cloth through, and Dhang wrapped it around their joined hands, taking the box from her and handing it to Maevik. “As I was telling the queen, this is not a universally legal Etherian marriage, which has become the standard. This is an ancient Salinean tradition known as Confluence. Your essences, souls, auras, what have you, will be unified together under the Pearl, and this marriage will be recognized in Salineas by all. We can get into legalities later, but it is, essentially, a wedding without legally binding vows. Those vows are necessary to be coronated, Sea Hawk, but not wed. This will name you Consort. When you become bound in legal matrimony, you will be permitted to be coronated and named King.”

“However,” Maevik murmured. “Salineas has never been particularly reverent. Socially, this will still name you King, and next in line for the throne until you bear children.”

Sea Hawk nodded, working hard to commit everything to memory. “Consort now, king later, husband now, kids take the throne. Got it.”

Dhang patted him on the shoulder. “One last thing. For both of you,” he made sure Mermista and Sea Hawk’s eyes were fixed on him. “The Runestones are the avatars, the channels, the raw power of the arcane magic of Etheria. It is known that their power recognizes the spouses of the Princesses, and extends its abilities to accommodate them."

"What?" Sea Hawk tilted his head.

Dhang smiled. "In short, the Pearl will bind you in ways that others would not experience. Your mother described it as a sort of…extra awareness. She always knew when those who shared the Pearl's favor were in trouble, or distress. Nerida claimed she knew when you were near, and when you were farther than the Pearl could reach. It is a complex, varied magic that manifests differently for every Princess and their partner. Now, are you ready?"

Their eyes met, and they shared an exhilarated smile. It felt like the moments before he had set his first ship on fire, the pause before the cliff-jump, the inhale of breath before a war cry. "Ready."

Mermista took deep breaths, focusing on the feel of Sea Hawk's calluses under her fingertips; familiarly rough, reassuring. A sash, teal and worn and soft was wrapped around their hands, over the damp cloth, braided and knotted with intricate purpose. The fabric was smooth like silk, but heavy like leather, and shimmered as it moved. It was as if someone had plucked it right out of a stream, the physical embodiment of water. Dhang began to speak as he wove.

"Since the days of the sunken Kingdom, deep in the ancient waters of our home, we have revered the Pearl and all it stands for. We have bathed in its glow, following where its essence led us. Our mothers, their mothers, and all our bearers since time immemorial have understood the sacred ways, and passed them on to us. From water we emerged, and one day, to water we will return, so said Oceana, first of the Pearl, settler of Salineas, highest mother.

In her name, in the Pearl's name, and in the name of our culture, I bind thee to one another until the end of your days and beyond; this union will not fade with time, with your bodies' age. It will grow stronger, it will runneth over and back like the rivers that feed the great basin. Like those that have come before it, this union will honor you both as you honor it; like the flowers of Plumeria, it will grow and bloom and bear fruit with the same passion and devotion with which you nurture it.

Love is the ultimate magic of life, and all that comes after it. Love will be your light in the dark, your strength in times of weakness, your balm when you are ill or hurting. Love has the greatest powers of all; the powers of creation, or destruction. Take strength from one another, be each other's confidants, guides, counsel, friend, and partner, and there is no limit to what you will be able to do. You are equals now, in the eyes of the Pearl. Treat one another as such, and never know loneliness, or emptiness, again. This is the promise the Runestone gives us, the promise that we as Salineans hold most dear to our hearts. This is the promise you make to one another, here, now, and forever."

Mermista, despite the tears that had long since gathered and fell and kept falling, couldn't look away from Sea Hawk's eyes, wet like her own. In that moment, none of it mattered; her father's desertion, her kingdom's fall, the fights, the breakup, the storms they'd weathered. None of it. Despite the war literally raging on around them , she was at peace in the eye of this hurricane, and it was all because of *him.* What Dhang said resonated in her like the striking of a bell. Her strength, her guide, her friend, her counsel. Sebastian had been all of that and more for longer than she could really quantify. It was comforting to know that, in reality, this binding wouldn't change anything about them, that they'd been on the right path this whole time.

Sea Hawk smiled at her, elated, and in his eyes she saw her entire future more clearly than ever. She wondered if he saw the same.

The knot was tied off atop their joined hands, and Dhang raised his arms to the Pearl. Mermista felt the familiar liquid-cool tingle of its magic surrounding her, but watched in amazement as it stretched to cover Sea Hawk. He turned his head this way and that, trying to clock how the blue glow swirled up his legs and around his body with childlike amazement that left Mermista smiling helplessly.

Dhang nodded. "The Pearl will handle the rest."

The magic washed over them both, and then they were… elsewhere. But also nowhere. One second, they'd been on their feet with their hands joined under the Pearl in her throne room. Now, they were semi-floating in a blue ether, light filtering in from all directions. It was like being underwater, far from the surface. Sea Hawk spun around.

"What is…what's happening?"

"I don't know," she frowned. Mermista reached out. "Here, give me your hands again."

They wound their hands together like they had in the throne room, and watched as a pinprick of light appeared between them. It grew and grew until it was swirling around them, taking shape- the shape of a mermaid. The manifestation of the Pearl's magic.

Mermista, Queen of Tides, Calmer of Storms, Sea Dancer, Daughter of Salineas Born to the Hurricane. You seek union to Sebastian Hawkins of Snows, first of his name, first of his title.

"I do."

Sebastian. You seek Kingship of Salineas.

"I…I seek marriage to Mermista, and all that comes with it."

You do not seek Kingship?

He swallowed, and Mermista squeezed his hand. He was speaking to the Pearl, but looking into her eyes. "I would be honored, humbled, to serve Salineas and the Pearl as King. But those titles were never my prerogative, so much as being Mermista's husband has been."

The mermaid, now larger than life and hovering in the ether with them, bearing down on them without eyes but seeing all, paused and regarded them.

You have a noble heart, Sebastian. You have proven yourself to be brave, kind, and loyal. Your heart burns like fire, and it searches for the rest of itself ceaselessly. You are a restless soul, but in Mermista you find peace. In her, you have found home.

Mermista, I have known your heart for longer than you've walked this earth, my child. The voice rushed through her like a warm breeze off the ocean, and she smelled orchids in bloom mixing with the salt of the sea. Tears pricked at her eyes, but she didn't know why. *Your heart has been bruised many times over, and so you have closed it off and sealed it away like the stone you stand beneath. And yet, despite all you've endured, it heals every day that you stand beside Sebastian. To each other, you are solace.*

I have seen, and beheld your auras, your essences, the very fabric of your souls, and I find your Confluence entirely approved. I welcome thee to the Pearl's favor, Sebastian, and I happily bless your union to Mermista. Go now, and see what your future holds.

The mermaid- the Pearl- circled them, getting closer and closer until all was white, and warm, and full of invigorating energy. Like magnetics set free, Sea Hawk and Mermista crashed into one another, their non-physical selves that had been floating in the ether now blending together, becoming one, and whole.

It was like she had crashed back into her body as the light faded away. Sea Hawk practically stumbled, gripping her hands for balance, both of them gasping. Dhang and Maevik stood a bit off to the side, eyes on the Pearl which was engulfed in teal light, pulsating and sparkling like a contained firework display. Mermista didn't even spare it a glance, though, as she was more preoccupied with yanking Sea Hawk as close as humanly possible.

"Are we-"

Mermista cut him off as she pressed her lips to his. "I'll ask in a sec, just, please, kiss me."

And he did. The kind of kiss that you read about at the end of fairy tales, not in history tomes in the middle of a war. The kind that made your heart palpitate, your head spin, and your toes curl for how sweet and burning it was. A once-in-a-lifetime sort of kiss that you would dream about in your darkest moments, remember on your happiest days, revisit when your heart ached just a little bit more than you could bear. Sea Hawk's rough, sure hands gripped her waist and pulled her flush against him, before he moved one arm to her shoulders and one to the small of her back. His mustache was brushing her upper lip, her cheeks, the very bottom of her nose- which rubbed ever so slightly against his as they moved together in their favorite dance of all. It was so familiar to kiss him, practically instinct now to open her lips to the soft brush of his tongue along her bottom lip. One hand moved up to tangle in his hair and yank him impossibly closer, the other resting over his heart.

It was familiar, yes, until it suddenly *wasn't* . From nowhere, or maybe everywhere, Mermista's head was assailed by a lack of sensation, and then a split-second of an overwhelming amount of it, and then nothing- back to normal. Save for the tiny, blink-and-you-miss-it tingling in the back of her head- no, wait, the…front-ish side? It was hard to pinpoint. But it was there. Whatever it was. She pulled away from Sea Hawk's lips, not far, never far again, to try and poke at it with her mind. As she did, Sea Hawk winced, a hand flying up to his temple. Mermista gaped.

"Is that…you?"

"Is what me, dearest?" Sea Hawk looked concussed, the way his eyes were glazed over. Mermista snoted.

"This," she reached into her subconscious again, trying almost to *not* focus on the little spot that was fading from a tingle to a soft, comforting warmth. She poked it again, and watched Sea Hawk's brows furrow. "There's a- a thing. In my head. Dhang said…"

"Is it?" His mustache twitched as he concentrated, and Mermista was almost overwhelmed by the urge to kiss him again. Suddenly, her head pinged, like someone had tapped her from inside her own brain. She reached up to swat at nothing, and Sea Hawk smiled. "That's you? That little…thing?"

"Yeah," she felt out of breath, and knew she sounded as winded as he did. Whatever. Sebastian was allowed to see her little weaknesses. He was her… "That's us."

A throat cleared behind them, and they stepped back (barely) from one another as Dhang approached. "You should exchange your rings. I assume you will be waiting to exchange tokens until the royal wedding?"

Mermista nodded, and Sea Hawk just smiled, happy to go along with whatever pleased her. "Seems a bit too much like painting targets on our backs to exchange anything larger than these right now." They slid their respective rings onto one another's hands carefully, pressing kisses to knuckles as they went.

Dhang just nodded. "Then, by the power vested in me by the Pearl, the Queen, and the united governments of Salineas, with Maevik as your witness, I happily pronounce you husband and wife," he smiled softly, before it warped to something shrewd and sharp. "I would tell you to kiss your spouse, but you handled that already."

They had the good grace to blush, but, like, just barely. Maevik snorted and bowed to them both. "It's about time, your majesties."

Sea Hawk twitched next to her, and Mermista hid a smile at the formal joint titles. "Not all of us marry our childhood sweethearts at eighteen, Maevik."

"Different strokes, I suppose," he winked. "Now, I do hate to cut a beautiful and life changing moment short, but your datapad has been vibrating against my back for ten minutes.”

Mermista slipped back into the comfortable role of queen and commander as she took the pad from her guard and flicked it on, scrolling through the missed transmissions and video chat feeds. She clicked the open one and waited for it to connect while Sea Hawk wrapped his arms around her waist from behind, hooking his head on her shoulder. The feed connected with a hum, and Glimmer’s face popped into view. Mermista frowned at the background.

“Are you in the Fright Zone?”

“Yes, long story,” Glimmer panted. “Right now, you need to get to Salineas Harbor and out to sea. We’ve redirected a Horde fleet your way, they have no idea you’re going to meet them.”

Sea Hawk stood abruptly. “Double Trouble’s faulty intel feed worked then?”

Glimmer smiled triumphantly. “They don’t suspect a thing. We’ll work on freeing up some of the magic trapped at the heart. In the meantime, give ‘em hell.”

Mermista flicked off the pad, crossing to what used to be a window and peering into the darkness of the Bay. Once, there had been lights along the piers and harbor, the markets and bazaar, the homes in the city. Now, it was pitch black. Above them, the moons sat high and far, shedding what little light they could. Not that it mattered to Mermista; she could see just fine. And what she saw was a battalion of Horde ships with no idea they were heading toward Salineas at full speed. The ocean called to her, screaming righteous fury as it tossed in its bed, begging her to let it help, to let it take revenge for the atrocities it saw here. It pulled at her, clawing through her veins with howling, unbridled power. No- *hunger* . Gnawing hunger, whispering promises of revenge and redemption, if she would just set the magic *free-*

“Mermista?” Sea Hawk’s hand was on her shoulder, and she shook herself. She saw him staring at her with thinly veiled concern, and no small amount of eagerness. Mermista could feel him, in the back of her mind, thrumming with energy like a string pulled taut, waiting to be given the go ahead. She pressed a fast kiss to his lips.

“Let’s go,” she nodded to Maevik to retrieve her trident, and then to her husband. “We have a fleet to sink.”

Chapter End Notes

> Would love to hear what you thought after reading, liked disliked loved etc. Thank you for reading, always. Comments are nice to receive to know I’m not shouting into a void, but if I am then that’s okay, too.
>
> Either way, I hope you enjoyed reading! Til next time.

angel down

Chapter Summary

> The Heart of Etheria goes off

Chapter Notes

> Sorry for the delay! I realized something. Big. Lmao. So ANNOUNCEMENT: I am retroactively adding a chapter two before this one, because I… completely forgot to publish the chapter that goes there :) bc I'm a silly little goose
>
> So! It doesn't rlly change anything it's just some fluff with Scorpia. So feel free to read, or press on as is.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Maybe it was a bad thing, how much Sea Hawk loved a good fight. Maybe he should have been concerned with the level of catharsis he achieved when he swung his sword and felt it connect with dingy metal armor or a stun baton. Maybe it wasn't a good thing that he threw punches as often as he could, slide tackled Horde scum to the dirt and loved every bloody moment. Maybe it meant he had more than just a few screws loose. However, none of that mattered right now.

What mattered was that he was actually living out his elaborate tall-tales; he had taken down at least twenty Horde soldiers in the last half hour, and he wasn't even somewhat fatigued. If anything, he was growing more energized with each punch he landed.

What mattered was that as batshit crazy as he was in the heat of battle, Mermista, his *wife* , was at least ten times crazier. He saw her dancing in and out of his line of sight, bobbing and weaving between foot soldiers, amphibious tanks that rolled out of the sea and onto bedrock, and the battle cruisers hovering off in the deeper water- and taking them all out with ease. He'd always known Mermista was a beast, but this was otherworldly. For every soldier he dispatched, she was taking out three.

What mattered was that the little spot in his mind, the little spot that was Mermista, and the Pearl, and a tiny touch of magic- more than any mere man should possess- was spreading like wildfire through his veins, and Sea Hawk felt like he could fly if he really put his mind to it. He settled for throwing his whole arm into his next swing, nearly cleaving the helmet of an approaching soldier clean in half. He spun, feet sloshing through the few inches of water they were fighting in on this shelf.

In a lull, he felt his back collide with something warm and strong, and his link sang with joy. *Mermista.* "Hello, dearest!"

"Hey!"

He turned to give her a quick once over, looking for any massive injuries. "Alright there?"

Mermista turned and grinned at him, and it was bloody and raw and defiant and *beautiful* . "I'm having the time of my life. You?"

"Is this what you feel like all the time when you fight?" He gestured vaguely at his head. "It's exhilarating."

“Nah, this is different. There’s…more, I guess?” She shrugged, flicking her trident in a lazy, deadly spin. “Maybe Glimmer’s freed up some magic. Incoming!”

Sea Hawk whirled in time to see a flaming hulking mass of broken tank come flying at them. In a flash, Mermista had a wall of water up, catching the projectile mid-arc. Using the momentum, she swung around in a graceful spin, flinging the tank back out to sea with her magic. It collided with another vessel, and within seconds the ship was up in flames.

Sea Hawk grinned. “Nice touch.”

“Thanks.” She smirked. “Watch my six? I’m going to sweep these amphibian things back out to sea so we can handle the last of the foot soldiers.”

“I’ve got you. Go.”

They leapt into action, their familiar and lethal dance coming easier than ever with the boost from the Pearl. Sea Hawk kept any and all soldiers from getting near Mermista while she conjured up a massive tide, pushing and pulling relentlessly until all the amphibian tanks had been thoroughly dashed upon the rocks of the shore. They sparked and sputtered, crumpled, smoking wrecks bleeding Horde scum that fled from the vehicles, only to get knocked far inland by the waves Mermista brought up.

Vaguely, further inland, Sea Hawk could hear brawling, and he wondered who else could possibly be on the island with them besides the Horde.

"TO THE QUEEN!"

Well, he didn't have to wonder for long. Crashing through the jungle was Maevik and the royal guards, the remainder of the navy, and droves of average citizens with spears and knives and even just rocks in hand. Mermista spun to face the roar her people brought with her, eyes growing wide when she saw them rushing out.

"Maevik! I said keep them safe-"

"Sorry, your Majesty!" Her guard slammed the hilt of his trident into a wayward soldier, smiling grimly when he crumpled. "But your people are as stubborn as you are, and would not be persuaded from assisting."

"But-"

"Mermista!" Sea Hawk's eyes widened as he saw a stun baton arcing high above his wife's head, wielded by a hulking, blue furred man. Without thought, he flung his sword as hard as he could. "DUCK!"

She did, hitting the ground just as his sun saber sailed overhead and sank hilt-deep in the chest of the man. The stun baton dropped to the water, quiet and useless without a hand on the trigger. The soldier stumbled briefly, scrabbling at the blade but ultimately unable to do anything about it as he fell limp to first his knees, then his back. Sea Hawk searched for an ounce of remorse, but the image of the baton ready to send thousands of volts right to Mermista's head was stronger than any guilt. Without flourish, he ripped the blade from the chest of the soldier, and spun to yank Mermista to her feet. "Are you alright?"

She nodded, eyeing the body behind them with vague concern. "Are *you* ?"

"As long as you're safe, I'm fine." Sea Hawk's jaw was tight. Mermista just nodded again, eyes softening briefly.

"Then let's keep going."

Sea Hawk lost track of the minutes spent hacking and dodging and spinning and punching, sometimes dancing, other times pummeling away without rhythm or flair. Sometimes Mermista was there, back to back with him or circling around him like a shark, keeping the onslaught from overwhelming him. He would swap out with Maevik in covering Mermista so she could cut down swaths of soldiers, or push ships back out to sea. His energy had yet to flag, so he rode the high with abandon.

Soon, the soldiers were attempting to fall back, but the Salineans kept after them, chasing them inland or along the coast. Mermista had ordered them to take quarter when they could, but to show as much mercy as they were offered; which was to say, not a whole lot. There was an air of…finality to this battle, and Sea Hawk wondered if this was it, if this was the climax of all their hard work. Would this be the end of the war? Of the Horde?

He was being circled again, Horde soldiers boxing him in on every side. His palms were slick with sweat and blood and grimy, muddy water as they gripped the hilt of his saber, and he swallowed, praying the Pearl, or his uncanny luck, would continue to hold out over the next few minutes. He backed up, ready to leap back into the fray-

A torrent of water thrashed around his feet, spiraling up and slamming three soldiers into the deep water of the bay, one even skipping like a stone in his flat armor. Mermista slid into view with a snarl, skating on the water as she whipped around in a vicious dance, trident in hand. He backed up to her, keeping his body between the soldiers and his love.

Then- a blinding flash of light, and white-hot flames licking at his back. He spun around, and saw Mermista engulfed in teal flames of magical energy. She was lifted off her heels with the force of it surging through her, her eyes whiting out entirely with pearlescent light. Briefly, her body went slack like a marionette being pulled up by its strings, before she snapped back to herself, somehow… more. Her eyes returned, blue and burning, and met his.

Sea Hawk’s jaw was slack, and, really, this was no place to be staring but…how could he not? Mermista was radiant, power coursing through her like a storm on the open waters. Like the hurricane she'd said she was born in. The water around him thrashed in its bed, ready and willing to leap to her smallest command. He could feel her, bright and hot, arcane and deadly, and oh so beautiful, dancing through his mind. She grinned at him, her expressive eyes saying 'check this out', before leaping into action.

With one skyward swing of her trident, the surrounding fifty feet of water was swept from its resting spot along the shelf, gathering momentum and speed until it met the water in the bay and pushed outward in a hill of sea water, knocking cruisers and ships off course. One even started listing towards capsize, and soldiers began jumping clear.

Mermista picked up the rest of the water on the shelf and sent it rushing inland, commanding it as it went to leave the Salineans be. When she recalled it, there were about fifty Horde soldiers trapped in a bubble of brackish water. They thrashed, running out of oxygen, and briefly Sea Hawk worried she would simply drown them all. But she didn't- despite the way he saw her fingers twitch as she threw the lot to the ground *hard* , like she hadn't wanted to stop. When she spoke to Maevik, her voice was deeper, rushing, and echoing, like several Mermistas were speaking at once. If the ocean had a voice, it would be this.

"Bind them and take them prisoner. I'll handle the rest."

Maevik nodded, eyes wide with awe. Mermista turned to Sea Hawk, and held out a hand. Wordlessly, he took it, brushing a kiss over impossibly warm knuckles. Mermista smiled at him, and took off for the bay. While she leapt into the water, he charged along the coast, doing his best to keep pace with her- the water was deeper here, up to his mid-shin, and she was, y'know, a mermaid. But she was fighting as she moved, so he made good time.

Tidal waves, massive bubbles of sea water weighing metric tons, tsunamis, and more were sent hurtling toward the Horde ships. When they reached a natural jetty of rocks and sand jutting out far into the sea, they raced down it to get nearer to the ships. Sea Hawk picked off the few Horde soldiers who had made landfall and were still trying to fight, knocking them out with punches and kicks as he jogged to catch up to his queen. Mermista, meanwhile, had her eyes on larger prizes. Feet now planted on the jetty, she centered herself with a deep breath, and reached both arms out toward the sea, her palms facing the sky as she curled them into loose fists. Massive tentacles of water, like the fabled krakens of old, shot from the surf to wrap around the nearest three ships, and the sound of metal being rent apart screeched across the bay. Mermista waited until all the soldiers had jumped clear of the ships before closing her fists; the tendrils seized, crushing the cruisers with the pressure of the deep sea, dragging the wrecks into the abyss.

Only two ships remained a float, and they were readying laser cannons- fast. Sea Hawk frowned. "Dearest-"

"I have an idea." Mermista turned to him breathlessly. "But I need you to cover me from down here. I won't be able to focus on anything else while I do this."

"Whatever you need, love." They had precious few seconds, but he snagged her by the waist and kissed her anyway. Their bond hummed with life, and Sea Hawk felt a whisper of the exhilarating power coursing through Mermista. “I’ve got you. Go.”

She nodded, and leapt into the water. Not a second later, a whirlpool began swirling lazily where she’d vanished, picking up speed and form with every breath he took until it was a maelstrom, sending up sprays of water and heat with its velocity. Just as he was growing concerned, the whirlpool imploded, collapsing in on itself briefly before exploding upwards. The water spout that emerged was the largest Sea Hawk had ever seen, fast and deadly and-

Mermista stood atop it, arms spread as she controlled the tornado beneath her. Her glow had faded, channeled into the water. She reached outward, and a massive whirlpool began drifting to life in the center of Salineas Bay. Sea Hawk was frozen in awe as he watched it take shape and gather speed until it was spinning almost impossibly fast. A noise behind him broke his focus, and he spun to see a small group of Horde soldiers charging up the jetty. He raced to meet them; they had stun batons, and if they got near Mermista’s water platform they would surely kill her.

The first one was easily dispatched, Sea Hawk barely had to swing before the young soldier went sailing headlong into the bay, knocking his helmet on some rocks as he went. The next two attacked as one. The shorter swung a stun baton with deadly precision while the massive reptilian feinted and tackled and swung with a heavy tail. Sea Hawk managed to maneuver them off the jetty and down the rocky shore, keeping Mermista in the corner of his eye. She was moving down the coast with him, but her focus was on the two ships now caught in her waves.

It was a stroke of luck that he managed to get the reptilian down. The soldier went in for a tackle, and Sea Hawk dropped and rolled along with his attacker's momentum. As his back hit the ground, he kicked up as hard as he could into the armored stomach and threw the lizard wide. Like his companion, he went sailing into the bay, falling down the rocky slope with vicious clangs and grunts. The last soldier was easily the most skilled, and it wasn't long before Sea Hawk was covered in new burns and bruises. He gave as good as he got, but she had armor where he only had reinforced leather and thick canvas cotton.

His luck held out and saved him, in the end. Maevik came charging down the coast to help, and it was only the threat of a two-on-one brawl that made his attacker fall back. Well, maybe lucky was an overstatement- she got in one hell of a shot before she left; Sea Hawk had parried her baton away from his neck, but she used the momentum to swing around, under his blade, and lash out with the baton as she charged past. The ends were apparently serrated, a vicious design that he almost admired for its tactility, and it tore the skin of his right flank open as it shocked him. Sea Hawk stumbled, gasping for air- there wasn't enough in his lungs to scream. It was Maevik who charged after them, giving chase to the three Horde scum, while he moved to support himself against a rocky cliff.

It felt like every nerve was on fire, colored spots dancing in his eyes while a bell rang in his ears. His side, his back, his head- wait, he hadn't been hit in the head. And those weren't colored spots; all around him, rainbows of…energy? were erupting from the very crust of the planet, running up toward the heavens like waterfalls in reverse. It was frighteningly beautiful. A shout of pain disrupted his thoughts, and he watched in horror as Mermista faltered on top of her waterspout. Like a puppet whose strings had been cut, she crumpled into the dispersing waves, her beloved element barely helping her land on the shore before receding to its natural place. She fell to her knees, but she was wavering. Sea Hawk shook off his pain with a grunt, running for her as fast as his tired feet could carry him. He felt it now, the exhaustion, bone deep and life sucking. Like he'd never actually had any energy in his life. As he ran, the sky went supernova, temporarily whiting out his vision in a haze of electric purple; was this the Portal again? Were they back in that superficial hell?

No, they were still…somewhere. Here? He assumed so, but Here didn't have stars. Shining, dazzling stars that sprawled across the sky like they belonged there. Maybe they did. That was far above his pay grade to wonder about.

He reached Mermista as the rainbows began to roll off her body in waves, before turning into steady streams of upward motion, like the earth around them. He didn't know how he knew, maybe it was this fledgling bond in their minds- souls- whatever- or maybe it was just instinct, but he knew with every fiber of his being that she was dying. That he was watching her very life be ripped away. Siphoned. It was the Heart, it had to be; Adora had been right all along.

Sea Hawk fell to his knees in a skid, tearing them up as he went and not caring even slightly. Mermista had collapsed onto her front, unable to support herself even enough to keep her head from the wet rock. Gently, he hauled her into his arms by the shoulder, turning her over as carefully as he could. He choked down a sob at the electronic, circuitous calligraphy that was crawling all over her skin. First Ones' writing, he recognized vaguely. It danced and flickered like Bow's datapad, and made him sick; this was not a piece of machinery, this was not a weapon, this was not a *tool.* This was Mermista, his beloved, the woman who rolled her eyes at every little thing he did because she loved him so much it scared her, who danced and sang with him when they were alone, who devoured mystery novels and political theorems with equal fervor, who cared so much it hurt her. The woman who made him smile, made him laugh, who frustrated him, who comforted and supported him, who challenged him and dared him to be better, his equal in every way. His partner. His wife. The love of his life, in this one and the next, and probably all the previous ones; it felt that way from how his heart sang when she was near. His other half, his *better* half. They- the First Ones- couldn't just take her from him, from her people whom she loved so much. Not when they had so much left to do, so many adventures left to go on together…

She was frighteningly limp, not even her facial muscles twitching in pain. And he knew she was in agony. The field of energy being sucked out of her burned against him, like he was standing just too close to a bonfire, but he didn't dare let her go. Her head flopped listlessly against his upper arm, and he adjusted to support her neck as he cradled her.

"Mermista, love, please wake up," he begged, uselessly. "Please, darling, I'm right here. I promise I'm right here."

Nothing. Just the roar and hum of magical energy around him. Unbidden, tears welled up in his eyes, dripping down his cheeks and chin to fall on her. Where they met skin, they evaporated almost instantly, and he realized belatedly that she was burning up where the runes were etched into her, and deathly cold everywhere else. Sea Hawk choked on a sob, and gathered her as close as he could, praying to the Pearl, to Adora, to Oceana, to any other gods who might be listening, to please, *please* not take her. Not like this. Not now.

"I love you," he murmured wetly into her hair. "I love you so much, and I have always loved you. Always, I promise. Even when we were mad, and not communicating. I'm sorry I left you, and I'm sorry I let you hurt me. I'm sorry for not being stronger, for not- not giving us more time. I thought, even with the war, we'd have all the time in the world. Because I'm stupid, Mermista. Without you, I'm an absolute fool who doesn't know up from down or left from right, so you can't leave me. I can't be me without you, because there is no Sea Hawk without Mermista. No sailor without his mermaid. No King without his Queen." He babbled on, not wanting to stop even for a second. If he stopped, the universe might see it as him giving up, and interrupt him to take her away. So he kept talking, barely pausing to breathe, because surely the universe understood conversational decorum.

"If you wake up, dearest…" He shuddered through another choked-down sob. "You can see the stars in the sky. They're real, and they're beautiful, and I just know you'll love them. They say sailors used to use them to navigate, and that there was this one star- Polaris. It always pointed north, an absolute, so they would use it to steer their ships by. They said it was the brightest, most radiant star in the whole sky, so they could never lose her, or her them. I think it's a lovely sentiment, but I'll tell you a secret; I already have my north star." He pressed damp kisses to her hot-cold skin, hugging her tightly. At some point, he had started swaying gently, tiny rocking motions like the waves around them. "Please. I love you, dearest. *Please* -"

Sea Hawk intended to press on and talk for as long as it took, but suddenly, like somewhere a switch had been flicked off, it all just… stopped. The waterfalls of energy petered out, dispersing into the atmosphere. The sky settled from its purple haze, leaving behind deep, deep blue and a freckled sky. The runes faded from

Mermista’s skin, and a blink of teal magic flickered over her body. When she groaned, and her eyebrows twitched, Sea Hawk wasn’t sure if he cheered or sobbed as he pulled her into his arms, crushing her against his body as it was wracked with relieved tears. He knew he should pull back, let her reorient herself and check her over for damage, but the idea of not holding her filled him with agony and anxiety.

“Mermista, Mermista, my love, my life,” he chanted under his breath as he held her. “You’re alright!”

“I wouldn’t go that far.” Her voice was husky, like she’d been gargling with sand and gravel. He belatedly remembered her agonized screams of pain before he reached her, having blocked out the sound so he could focus on getting to her. Now, they flooded back, and he knew he’d be having nightmares about it for ages. “But I’m alive. What happened?”

“The Heart, I think.” He had yet to pull his face from her hair. “It erupted, like Adora said, and almost took the whole planet with it. Or at least, Salineas and the entire ocean.”

Mermista pushed gently against his shoulder, and he relaxed his arms enough for her to draw away. She didn’t go far though, and they sat nose to nose, faces not even an inch away from each other. Her eyes were bright, despite the way she sat slumped against him. He couldn’t be certain, but he thought he saw them flicker into a sea blue once or twice. The magic of the Heart seemed to be lingering.

“Are you…” Mermista bit her lip, eyes scanning his face. “Are you alright?”

“Am I-?” He laughed incredulously. “Dearest, you’re the one who nearly had her life siphoned out of her.”

“Yeah, but I’m a Princess.” She rolled her eyes. “And I’m already feeling better. You look pale, and sweaty, and you’re…”

“Human?”

“Yeah,” she whispered. The only thing betraying her cool mask of indifference was the worry in her copper eyes. “Reckless, foolish, and human.”

“I’m fine, ‘Mista.” He brushed a kiss against her forehead. “I promise.”

“Okay. Can we get off the ground now?”

He wiped the last of his tears dry, chuckling as he moved to stand with her. She stopped him with a gasp and a hand clamping like a vice around his bicep. He hissed. “Ow, what-?”

“Sea Hawk!” She was staring at his shirt. He frowned and glanced down- oh, right. The stun baton. “What the hell!”

“I- heh- I may have completely forgotten about that-”

“How do you forget-”

“My wife was dying! Excuse me for being slightly preoccupied-”

“Do *not* try to charm your way out of this,” she snarled, yanking him back to the ground. “Just sit there and let me see-”

“We need to get back to base-”

“Sebastian, I swear to the gods themselves-”

Movement behind Mermista’s beautiful yet infuriated face caught his eyes, and he turned his gaze skyward only to freeze in abject horror. “Mermista.”

“Seriously, how do you always lose so much blood-”

“Mermista.”

“It’s right next to the old one, too, so that’s not gonna heal nicely-”

“Mermista!” He grabbed her wrist, stopping her definitely-not-fretting, and forced her to look up with him. “Look.”

Overhead, fleets of…ships, if one could call them that, slid soundlessly beneath the stars. They didn’t move like anything he’d ever seen before. It was like gravity didn’t apply to them, or even exist. Long, dark green metal, laser cannons on either side of the main body. Mermista exhaled shakily. “It’s them. The rest of the Horde.”

Stars preserve them.

Mermista snapped back to herself in record time, scrambling to her feet. “C’mon, up, we gotta go, like, *now* . We’re too exposed here.”

He let her pull him to his feet and wrap one of his arms around her shoulder. Now that the adrenaline and magic were fading, the pain was setting in and it felt like hellfire. He hissed, stumbling slightly. Mermista just kept him moving until they were under tree cover, deep in a mangrove forest where thick roots and branches and bushy tree tops would keep them hidden. Sea Hawk grunted as she set him down against a trunk. “Maevik, he was running down the coast- we have to find him-”

“I have to patch you up before you lose any more blood, Sebastian.” Mermista’s voice wavered, but her hands didn’t shake even slightly. “Then we can worry about Maevik. He’s an amazing soldier, one of the best fighters in Salineas. He’ll be alright.”

Sea Hawk nodded, and let Mermista work. She wasn’t a healer like Perfuma, but she got by well enough. She pulled freshwater from the dirt beneath them, ignoring how a few trees withered as she did, and held it gently over his still clothed wound. He tilted his head. “Shouldn’t you lift my shirt?”

“Not yet. The blood’s already drying in spots which means your shirt is going to stick to the wound. I don’t want to pull any skin away with it, so I’m going to wait til everything is wet. .”

“Lovely.”

He let her work in silence, well aware that she was working through the last hour or so in her head (or was it only minutes? Who could know…), as well as the ships in the sky, his injuries, her dear friend and guard’s absence. He traced her face with his eyes, a welcome and gorgeous distraction from the pain in his abdomen- the shirt had indeed stuck when she removed it, even with the water, and it was because most of his side was a bloody, singed mess. She cleaned his wound with her water, the tingle of magic dancing along his skin, and he counted the bruises on her temple, assessed the small trickle of blood that had dried on her forehead where it crept out of her hair line. Her lip was split and raw, and she was favoring her left side. He vaguely recalled that when she’d fallen out of the water spout, she’d landed harder on her right side.

At length, she pulled away and reached for his discarded, ruined shirt. “Mind if I rip this up?”

“Go for it.”

She tore his shirt into large strips, and fashioned a bandage out of them that she wrapped tightly around his torso. “That should hold you together until we can make it back to the village. It’s gonna be a long, slow swim.”

He was cut off by the sound of something crashing through the brush toward them. They reached for their weapons, and Mermista placed herself somewhat in front of Sea Hawk where he sat. She was winding up to javelin her trident when-

“It’s me! Maevik! Please, don’t attack.”

They relaxed, and her guard came through the forest. Mermista stood to meet him in a hug, even if he did bow anyway afterwards. His gaze flit to Sea Hawk with concern.

“You alright, Maevik?”

“I’m fine, my Queen. Is he…?”

“He’ll be alright once we get him some salves. Can you swim ahead to the healers and let them know what we’ll need?”

“At once, my liege. I’d also like to report that every civilian who came to our aid today is whole and hale.” He spared them both another bow before taking off. Mermista released a massive breath.

“Thank the stars,” she murmured, before turning to offer Sea Hawk a hand. “Come on, goober. Let’s get you healed up.”

He slipped his hand into hers. “Lead on, Princess.”

Chapter End Notes

Hope you enjoyed!!! Thank you for the feedback and love!

promise i'm worthy (to hold in your arms)

Chapter Summary

A brief moment of celebration

Chapter Notes

This chapter is really just sap and their wedding night. Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next few hours were a blur to Mermista. She got Sea Hawk back in one piece, and gave him over to the healers who met them at the cliff-like shoreline. Dhang and Maevik escorted her back to the temple, where her connection was once again assessed. Dhang made a series of disconcerted faces, but ultimately assured her that not only was the connection in full effect, but the blockage had been completely removed and the energy flowing to her was stronger than ever. That made sense. Despite nearly dying in Sea Hawk's arms earlier that evening, she felt like she could surf from here to Snows and back before maybe considering a nap.

Sea Hawk was still being tended to when she emerged from the temple, so she allowed Maevik to lead her to their quarters- a house that had been in his family for generations that he was all too happy to give them. She protested, of course, completely fine with a tent, but her guard insisted.

“This location is ideal, my Queen. Inland, off the main paths, easily guarded and yet well-accessible in the event of an emergency. Plus, it's relatively private.” When Mermista just quirked a brow in confusion, Maevik chuckled. “Might I remind you that it is, technically, your wedding night?”

Oh.

Oh.

Right.

She waved him off with a dismissive eye roll, and he went on his way, still chuckling. Mermista pushed any thoughts of ‘later’ away with a huff. Who knew what state Sea Hawk would be in when he left the tent? It was best to assume a poor one, and move on accordingly. She made rounds about the town, chatting with citizens as she went. She sat and conversed with some elders who had a few questions and far more opinions to give her, which she listened to with grace. A group of young mothers all about her age, which knocked her for quite the loop, came up to ask about the safety of the village, what the machines flying over them earlier were, and if they needed to be worried. They clutched their children to them, eyes wide, and Mermista assured them she was doing all she could to keep them safe and get ahead of the situation. Which was the truth. She would have a lot more success, though, if Glimmer would pick up the damn datapad.

For now, she nodded to the mothers, waved to their babies, and pressed on. She joined the engineers briefly, who were overlooking blueprints and schematics for new weapons and other, more abstract sketches on ways to fortify the city and keep it hidden. Mermista offered what support she could, nodding along to the techno-babble, and wished them luck. After about an hour of these rounds, she was no less keyed up, and was in fact restless without Sea Hawk by her side.

She brushed through the flap of the tent the head healer had brought her to. "He's resting, we haven't allowed anyone in for the past hour or so."

"Why?" she'd asked.

The healer gave her an assessing glance. "It's etiquette," she murmured. "To not let anyone see the King in such a state."

Mermista just blinked. "Does everyone know?"

"The rumors began when Swami Dhang announced he would be departing to the Pearl for a bit. When he returned, he confirmed them himself."

"Good," She'd nodded. "I was going to have him announce it tomorrow anyway. You know he isn't really the king yet, right?"

The healer had merely flapped a hand at her. "If the difference for him lay in whether or not he had a nice piece of gold on his head, we wouldn't be calling him king already. He should be awake within the next half hour, dear."

Mermista smiled to herself, replaying the healer's words as she refastened the tent's opening. She turned to Sea Hawk, and her smile faded. His torso was wrapped in blue bindings, and the smell of salve lingered in the air. His face was slack in rest, his hair falling into his eyes without the bandana to hold it back. Mermista had seen sorcerers going to the healing tents, so she could only imagine what spells or enchantments the wraps around his body held. She could see more wrappings on his calf, creeping toward his thigh, and saw his clothes folded neatly on a chair.

Ah, so that’s what the healer meant.

Mermista snapped her armor off and kicked her shoes away. The magic of the heart still thrummed through her, but it had become easier as soon as she entered the tent. Even asleep, in a magically-induced healing coma, he soothed her. The healing beds were just large enough for her to lay alongside him, curled into his ever-present warmth. His face twitched slightly, and she propped herself up on an elbow to just…look. He was, like, nice to look at.

A shadow of stubble had grown across his jaw, and Mermista ran her fingertips along the prickles. She smoothed a thumb over his mustache, enjoying its softness. His eyelashes, full and dark, fluttered against his cheekbones in sleep. She wondered what he dreamed about, if he remembered when he woke up. His finn hair, almost indigo in the lowlight, covered his forehead and made him look disheveled. She shifted closer, pressing a feather-light kiss to his full lips, and then another to his bruised bottom lip. Her hand caressed his jaw, and she trailed barely-there kisses from the corner of his mouth to his temple. Sea Hawk was good with words; she’d heard him earlier, talking to her, begging her to stay, while her magic and life were being drained from her. Mermista did better with actions, gestures, little things like this. But for him, she would try.

"I love you," she breathed against his ear, kissing its shell softly. "I know I don't say it a lot. And I know that you don't really care because you, like, understand me. But I do. A lot. Well, obviously, I totally just married you." She smirked to herself, and traced his softly parted lips with a careful thumb, smiling at the warm puff of air that brushed her finger. "You scare me, you know. You never know when to quit, when to stay down. You just keep going and going. You never stop, Sebastian. Relentless. Determined. Reckless, honestly. But I don't know who you'd be if you weren't a total hardheaded dumbass, so I guess this is what they mean when they say compromise is good for the long run. Ugh, I'm not even making sense now. Maybe I'm concussed."

Mermista laid down, tucking her head into her…husband's… shoulder. Husband. Fucking hell. *Husband.* Her heart was racing, and she wasn't sure if it was panic or adrenaline racing through her. Both, probably. Had she really impulse-married Sea Hawk, like, a handful of hours ago?

Yeah. She had.

And despite the nervous and giddy feelings fighting for dominance in her stomach, neither of them carried even a hint of regret. No matter how much she looked for regret, she found none. Because she hadn't *really* impulse-married Sea Hawk. She'd made good on an unspoken promise, years in the making, one they'd fought (each other, the world, whoever) tooth and nail for. They'd wrenched free what little happiness they were due in the middle of a vicious war that had just taken a turn for the worse, and Mermista would die to keep it, she knew. She'd married her best friend, Sebastian.

She kissed him again, just because she could, and smiled against her will when he twitched underneath her, and feebly, groggily, kissed her back. He groaned when she pulled away. “Mr’missa?”

“Hey.”

“Wha’ happ’n?” He stretched, and Mermista winced at the chain of clicks of pops that radiated from head to tailbone along his spine. “We win? We won, right?”

“For now, yeah,” she sighed, reaching up to scratch his scalp softly. He hummed and leaned into her hand. “I’ve been waiting to hear from Glimmer, but there’s nothing yet. I’m getting worried. If there’s still nothing by mid-morning I’ll call Perfuma. Or Adora.”

Sea Hawk nodded, coherency returning in steady waves as the seconds ticked by. “How are you doing, dearest?”

“Honestly, fine. Too fine, actually.” She flopped down onto her side. “I’ve got, like, energy to burn and no way to burn it. I can’t even swim laps thanks to all the fucking mines, and stars-know-what that’s probably leaking out of the sunken ships. Ugh.”

“I’m sure we can find other ways to burn off your steam,” he murmured, voice husky and deep and sending shivers down her spine. His arm wrapped around her, fingers stroking lightly down her spine in a motion that absolutely should not be doing what it was to her. But- here they were. She cast a slightly baleful glance at him before pointedly sweeping her gaze down his body.

“I don’t know if you noticed, but you’re not exactly wearing anything and if the nurses come in here to check on you, they’re not gonna love what they find if you keep this up.”

His eyes opened at that, finally, and Mermista’s heart thumped disgustingly hard at the familiar warmth of them. Sea Hawk winked. “I’ll show you what I can keep-”

“I’ll smother you right now.”

“Dearest…” He pouted. “You wouldn’t.”

“I absolutely would.”

“On our wedding night?”

“On any night.”

He smiled despite himself. “Well then, help me into my clothes and let’s get to our tent.”

“Maevik did us one better.” Mermista smiled. “C’mon, let’s get you dressed.”

They managed to keep their hands to themselves- mostly- while Sea Hawk dressed. The sorcerers’ wraps came away clean, and Sea Hawk was left stitched up and healed with minimal soreness. He had several new scars, though, a few of them exceedingly gnarly. Mermista kissed away his grimace of displeasure when he saw them. “Well, they can’t all be sexy and mysterious.”

“Mysterious, no,” Mermista hummed as she traced the mangled, faded skin where he’d been electrocuted twice and nearly gutted like a fish, the spots so close they had turned into one large scar. “But undoubtedly sexy.”

He snorted, and she knew he didn’t believe her. That was fine. She’d just have to show him. They exited the tent to little fanfare, which Mermista deeply preferred. Sea Hawk didn’t lean on her, but she stayed close, just in case he, like, fell or whatever. It was the polite thing to do. The village was settling down, finally, late in the night. Or morning. It was definitely past midnight. Elders and children had been brought inside, working tents were closed up, doors were being shut for the few hours of sleep they’d all get.

Mermista intended to get as little sleep as she could.

She dismissed her guard to a more relaxed position as they made their way up the walk, grateful when they fell back to a wider radius. Sea Hawk let her in first, locking the door behind them. Mermista glanced around the small house, relaxing as best she could. It smelled like home, like her private wing of the castle; spiced with incense, invigorated with sea air, all overlaid by the flowers in bloom this time of year. She ached with the loss, but it was less now, and she was able to let the pain go for the moment. It had no purpose here.

She turned, and saw Sea Hawk watching her from where he leaned against the door. For a man who was usually a blur of motion, uncontainable energy, he was oddly, tantalizingly still. His eyes tracked her slight movement, and in the low light, she saw how they burned. Their bond, faded into the background now, pulsed with something hot and hungry, stoking a fire low in her belly.

EXPLICIT

Mermista held his gaze, and watched his eyes dilate when her tongue darted out to wet her lips. She grinned and reached up to her bodice, undoing the hidden fasteners with practiced ease. She could hear it, the way his breathing shallowed and sped. With a flick of her wrist and a natural flourish, her top was a heap on the floor and she was walking backwards, slow and teasing. Mermista liked games- well, no. She liked winning, and anything that gave her the potential to win. And this game? She always won. The game where she pushed, and teased, and drew Sebastian to the edge over and over, seeing how long it took him to break.

That was the thing about people like Sebastian- the nice, genial, somewhat unhinged people who everyone assumed were incapable of anything even akin to the darker side of the emotional coin. People thought they saw it all, that they knew; thought that he was incapable of covetous jealousy, of possession, of claiming, the rougher sides of love. They thought it was all a show, that he was the nicest pirate you'd ever meet. And maybe he was.

But none of those people had ever seen Sea Hawk pushed to the brink of control, driven mad with desire.

She had.

And she loved it. Loved the way his calloused hands were capable of both unspeakable gentility and impassioned grasps that left her bruised in her favorite ways. She loved the way his teeth felt when he left marks all over her body that screamed *mine, mine, mine* . She ached for his voice, low and growling, in her ear, sweet nothings replaced by tantalizing promise. Mermista loved being queen, loved the power she held and the abilities she had. But the other side of that was the occasional need to let go, to have someone else take over. The trust it required was breathtaking.

And she needed that now.

Sea Hawk's eyes were oscillating between her eyes, lips, and exposed breasts. She was already pebbling in the night air, and was privately desperate to get under some blankets for the rest of the night. But she could be, like, somewhat patient. She winked at him when he met her eyes again next, turning her back to him to head toward the bedroom and take off her leggings in the same step. She had just stepped out of them and her panties when she heard Sea Hawk push off the door, crossing the room in a few quick strides. In a flash she was pressed against the wall, Sea Hawk's hands in her hair, yanking her head back to expose her neck, hand on her hip in a bruising grip as he rolled his clothed erection against her ass. She moaned, but it was cut short by his mouth on her neck, sucking and biting and pressing open mouth kisses wherever he could reach. Her gills fluttered from stimulation, and he pressed reverent kisses to them. Her back arched against him, ass grinding against his cock, one arm lifting to tangle fingers in his thick hair. He groaned and spun her around harshly.

He crushed his lips to hers and she sighed in his mouth. She tore at his jacket, and he cast it off. His shirt had been destroyed so he'd gone without, and his bare chest to hers, the dusting of coarse hair against her nipples, was driving her insane. He hiked one of her legs over his hip and ducked his head to suck a dusky nipple into his mouth, leaving her moaning and writhing against him. His other hand trailed down her body to reach between her legs, and Mermista cried out as he traced careful circles around her clit, down to her entrance, and back; a heady figure eight that left her floating.

"You always look so good for me like this." He released her nipple to whisper in her ear, tongue tracing the shell of her ear so slightly she wondered if she was imagining it. "Wet for me. Open for me."

"For you." She turned her head to brush her mouth along his jawline and down his neck. She wondered… "You and only you. My husband."

He groaned, pressing his head into her collarbone as his fingers fumbled their rhythm. Mermista grinned to herself; it was always nice to know that she could still have the upperhand if she wanted it. Sea Hawk looked up to meet her eyes as he nudged her leg further open, slipping the first knuckle of his forefinger into her. She whined, trying to buck against him, to take him deeper, but he used his legs to keep her in place. "Not yet, dearest."

"Sea Hawk." She let her head hit the wall, frustrated and increasingly, impossibly aroused.

"Mermista," he breathed against her skin, a prayer and an oath, and she shuddered. "You are everything I've ever wanted."

Well that- no, that wasn't how this went. This was rough and- and hard and- "Yeah?" She hated how vulnerable, how small she sounded in the moment; the inevitable surrender.

"Yes, love." He kissed her, softer than before but with no less heat, and she *melted* . "Everything and more…" He pulled back to grin roguishly at her. "And I'm going to show you just how much I want you."

He withdrew his hand from her sex, and lifted her effortlessly into his arms. She attacked his lips with her own, and it was rough, messy in the best way. Sea Hawk groaned into the air as she drew his lower lip between her teeth, soothing the harsh treatment with strokes of her tongue that led her past his lips and deep into his mouth. Her hands came up to cup his jaw, and she kissed him breathlessly until he made it through the door of the bedroom and tossed her onto the bed.

Mermista ogled shamelessly as Sea Hawk finally kicked off his trousers and underwear. He hissed as his boxers slid over the head of his erection, and Mermista wet her lips as she felt herself grow wetter.

Sea Hawk climbed over her, resuming his task of painting her body in watercolor. She groaned as he buried his mouth in the juncture of her neck and shoulder, biting and sucking and licking, a starving man at table. Mermista whined, hooking her legs over his hips and thrusting up to brush the head of his cock. Instead of grabbing her hips and taking her as roughly as she wanted him to, Sea Hawk pressed her hips down into the mattress with his own, making sure she couldn't move them.

"Sea Hawk." She frowned. "C'mon."

"Patience, darling." He bit a particularly vicious half-moon into the soft skin next to her breast, over her ribs, and she cried out as her hips spasmed. "Always in such a rush."

She huffed a sigh, but was fairly quickly distracted by Sea Hawk shifting to take her nipple back into his mouth, sucking it into a sensitive peak at a speed that left her moaning. Never one to take anything lying down (proverbially, at least), Mermista snuck a hand between them to run light circles over her clit, sighing at the slight, momentary relief. Momentary because Sea Hawk allowed roughly two seconds of that before he yanked her hand away from her sex and pinned it above her head. His eyes were impossibly dark as they bored into hers. “No.”

She smirked. “Yes.”

He narrowed his eyes, and she raised her eyebrows. She wanted to *play* , and Sea Hawk was stopping her fun. Whatever, Mermista mused. She always got what she wanted in the end. He shook his head at her, not actually annoyed even slightly, and moved to kiss her. She allowed it for a while, but as soon as she felt him start to lose himself in the motion, she acted, wrapping one leg around his, flipping the position of his wrist, and- with a push here and pull there- flipping them over expertly.

Sea Hawk didn’t have much time to be surprised before Mermista was licking a stripe up his neck, teeth scraping his jaw. He groaned, and she took the moment to line herself up with his erection. Graceful as ever, she sank down onto him, raising and lowering herself until he was hilt-deep and she was fully seated. The heat that had been burning just under her skin since the Pearl went supernova was back, a torrent in her blood that had her riding Sea Hawk rough and hard even by her standards. Their bond sang in her mind, a clear stream in a rocky bed, cool like mountain runoff after a long winter.

Sea Hawk recovered from his shock magnificently, sitting up and bending his knees so she was surrounded by him on all sides, senses overwhelmed with woodsmoke and ocean air and something uniquely Sea Hawk. His thrusts shallowed out, restricted by the new position, even as he pressed deeper, somehow. She groaned, head falling forward to press against his own forehead, and she looked into his beautiful eyes. “Sebastian…”

“I love you.”

“Yeah.” She smiled, and the arcane heat within her built higher. “I love you, too. Now…” She nipped at his ear. “For the love of all the runestones left, will you please fuck me?”

Sea Hawk chuckled, nipping at her jaw in turn. “Gladly.”

He looped one strong arm around her waist and tipped her backwards, head at the foot of the bed, so he could loom over her again, still inside her. She lifted her legs to hook around his hips, and this time he let her thrust against him. He met each one, starting with gentle pushes like an even tide, until he was pounding into her as hard as he could. Mermista cried out with each thrust, and she felt the fire that was her magic being stoked higher and higher by the moment.

“More,” she panted, hands roaming over his jaw, chest, biceps, wherever she could touch. “I need more, deeper- *ah!* ”

He kissed her, and barely broke rhythm as he lifted one of her legs off his hips and bent it back until it could rest on his shoulder, doing the same with the other. The change in angle had Mermista biting the flesh of her palm, knowing that if she lost control her guards would come running. She couldn’t help it, though, and she meant that truly; every thrust stroked her g-spot, the coarse hair above his cock was rubbing her clit, and he was at the perfect level to grab her breast in his calloused palm to flick her nipple in rhythm. She was being entirely overwhelmed, by him, by the magic surging through her, getting hotter and hotter and-

They both startled violently when the blue glow of the Pearl flooded over her body, starting as a soft haze, then a glow, before the flames of the Heart were back, swirling around them both. Sea Hawk looked ready to stop, concerned, obviously, for her safety. She fisted a hand in his hair and brought his eyes to hers, electric teal in place of amber. "If you stop now, so help you gods, Sebastian, I swear it-"

He kissed her in lieu of an answer, and resumed thrusting into her heat. A low whine turned into a prolonged moan, which became a gentle wail, which led to her screaming into Sea Hawk's mouth. He muffled most of it, but at this point, she was well and truly beyond caring. The heat had finally caught in her lower belly, and was now figure skating between her spine, her clit, her g-spot, and, in a detached way, their bond.

"Please, please, Sea Hawk," she sobbed against his mouth nonsensically. "Please-"

"I've got you, dearest." He was panting like he'd run a marathon, and despite how much she wanted to close her eyes, she couldn't look away from him if she tried. "You're so wonderful, so good for me. You're almost there, it's alright-"

"I can't-" She tried to buck, to push back, but she was completely immobilized in this position, which gave her a headrush that she didn't have time to dwell on right now. "Please, Sebastian."

"Keep going." He was fighting his own uphill battle, she could see it in his eyes and feel it along their bond, that he couldn't last much more. "That's my girl- *ah* - my love, my life. My wife. Fuck, darling, you're so good-"

It was all becoming too much, and Mermista felt a sense of violent anticipation and relief wash over her together. She was there, she was right *there.* Sea Hawk was singing praises in her ear, and her entire body was pulsing in a steady rhythm that was bringing actual tears to her eyes. She opened her mouth, and for a moment she was terrified that she was about to scream bloody murder, but no sound came out of her. At last, she was forced to close her eyes, look away from her husband, because she was finally at her peak and- and-

" *Fuck!* " Mermista wondered if this was how glass felt when it shattered, how flowers felt when they bloomed, how the ocean felt when it broke on the shore; this ultimate release of energy, flooding out of her in every sense. Sea Hawk had the presence of mind to keep a hand over her mouth, which was excellent foresight as she was too busy sobbing broken screams into his palm as she shuddered through an earth-shattering orgasm. She felt delicious relief spread outward from her clit, over her hips to her toes, and up her spine to her brain. She felt it dance along their bond, and knew it had reached Sea Hawk when he stiffened, thrusts faltering before turning animalistic as he chased her high and his at once.

It was her turn to murmur in his ear as he grunted into her neck. “You’re almost there, Sebastian. Give it to me, give it all to me. I want to feel you, darling-”

“Mermista- *ah!* ” Like he’d been struck by lightning, he seized so harshly she worried for his back muscles, before his hips jerked once, twice, and he was spilling inside her. Warmth flooded her, and Sea Hawk continued to thrust into her as he rode out his orgasm. Mermista was taken entirely by surprise when her own legs started shaking again, and she felt herself crest another small peak. She cried out softly, hot liquid gushing onto Sea Hawk’s lower abdomen.

EXPLICIT OVER

They lay there, unwilling to move from their position but unable to stay in it much longer. At length, Sea Hawk pulled out of her gently, and Mermista groaned at the empty feeling. Gently, he lowered her legs to the bed, and she opened her arms to him, beckoning him to lay with her. He curled against her eagerly, pillowing his head on her breast.

“You make the best pillow,” he sighed.

Mermista grinned where no one could see it, and ran her fingers through his hair. “You’re not too uncomfy yourself. You okay?”

“That was…wow.”

“Yeah.”

“I’m alright. More than alright. What was that?”

Mermista shrugged. “Leftover magic from the Heart, a fresh union through the Pearl, post-battle-holy-shit-somehow-we’re-alive adrenaline? Sounds like the perfect storm to me.”

Sea Hawk yawned. “I’m very glad we’re alive. Wouldn’t have enjoyed dying before I could have sex with my wife.”

Her face burned. “Ugh, you’re such a sap.”

“Why?” He propped his chin up to look at her. “Because I get to call you my wife now? ‘Oh have you met Mermista, *my wife* ? May I introduce you to *my wife* ? That’s *my wife!* ’ It packs such a punch! Plus, it makes you blush.”

“Stooooop,” she groaned, pressing her hands to her burning cheeks, willing them to cool and to also, like, stop smiling. “You’re so annoying.”

He just smiled guilelessly. “And yet, here you stand, married to me, your annoying husband.”

Mermista was losing the battle against her own joy, and really, it was just them here. So she gave up the ghost and sank down so they could lay on their sides eye to eye. “It’s, like, kind of surreal, huh? On one hand, I still feel like a stupid teenager who just took a game of dress-up and make-believe way too far. On the other, I feel like an old hag who should’ve been married years ago.”

Sea Hawk snorted. “Luckily, you are neither of those things. You are a capable, strong leader, and the most beautiful woman in Etheria.” He laced his fingers through hers, drawing her knuckles to his lips. “And someday, you’ll be a beautiful old hag.”

“Jerk!” Laughter bubbled out of her, surprising them both, as she slapped his chest. “So mean. Why did I marry you.”

“Because you love me, dearest.” He smirked. “And I am absurdly attractive. And an accomplished sailor. And a dashing pirate. And a rebel soldier. Really, I’m the perfect catch.”

“You certainly smell like the perfect catch.”

“Thank y- hey!” He stuck his tongue out at her as she laughed. “I built up this sweat trying to keep your ass from being shot, stabbed, and then spirited away by long-dead gods, thank you very much.”

Mermista smiled gently, placating him with a soft kiss on the corner of his mouth. He rolled onto his back, and she scooched closer to lay her head on his chest. Absently, she traced the constellations of scars across his skin; long clean slices from swords (one of which was far, far too close to his jugular), tiny raised bumps from acid or scalding water, clean burns from lasers, less clean burns from his favorite hobby, and, of course, the crater that was now taking up most of his lower left side. She ran her fingers over it, noting how he stiffened.

She tsked. “It’s not that bad.”

“It’s hideous,” he sneered. “I’ll look into cosmetic removal after the war-”

“Why?” Mermista frowned. “You always said your scars told a story, or painted a picture, or whatever. Why does this one’s aesthetic bug you?”

Sea Hawk’s jaw worked for a while. “It’s not…that. It’s just that today is a day I’d rather not remember every time I look at myself in the mirror. Holding you on that beach, Mermista…that was the scariest moment of my life. I don’t…I can’t-”

“I know.” She cut him off, trailing her hand up to his heart, feeling it beat against her palm. “I’m sorry.”

“You have nothing to be sorry for.”

“I don’t like scaring you,” she whispered. “It’s horrible.”

“There was nothing you could have done, dearest.”

“And isn’t that the worst part?” She looked up at him with wide, terrified eyes. “I have more questions than ever. About the Pearl, about myself, about the Heart and what it all means. What it could mean for my successors, and theirs, and-”

“Mermista, darling.” He soothed her, rubbing circles into her shoulder. “You can’t worry about these things right now. There’s nothing to solve, no problem we can address, and you’ll just make yourself sick over it. You need rest, my love.”

Slowly, she settled against him, though it took a good few minutes. “It’s weird when you’re the smart one.”

“I know, I much prefer this the other way around. Feels more organic.”

“Goober,” she snorted, and he smiled. “We should rest now. At least for a few hours.”

“Sounds lovely to me.” The shifted to lay the right way on the bed. He rolled over, tucking her against his chest to trade lazy goodnight kisses until they were yawning more than kissing. They fell asleep within minutes, in one another's arms, at peace for just this moment despite the war howling at the doorstep.

Chapter End Notes

> Next, a period of transition between seasons four to five. I only have like maybe three chapters left of this to write, and lemme tell y'all. It is SURREAL. I have plans for a sequel of sorts, because I'm really excited to throw my hat in the ring of post-canon narrative and play with the other couples more. So! Bittersweet as we come down the final lap here.
>
> Thank you, as always, for the comments and kudos. I'm working on getting back to them all bc you're all SO nice like omg.

to the ends of the earth (would you follow me?)

Chapter Summary

> Part one of three of the time between seasons 4 and 5: The New Normal

Chapter Notes

> This chapter is 50 pages long in my computer so we're chunking it up into more chewable pieces! Part one!

Life found a new normal in the weeks and months that followed after the Horde's simultaneous defeat and renewed invasion. Etheria grew accustomed to stars in the sky, to drones overhead, to legions of robots and clones marching on exposed villages and towns. Mermista received word every day of territories lost to the Horde's rapidly widening scope, word of casualties and the New Horde's frightening competency and organization. It was all woefully depressing.

But in Lua Pele, their oasis, life was shockingly…fine. The thick forests around them shielded the paths and entrances to the village, and the branch cover high overhead stopped drones from finding them. They made sure to keep the population centered away from the larger gaps, especially the children, but that still left plenty of room. Engineers worked around the clock to fortify the entrances in the event of a successful invasion, and to create escape tunnels off the island. Mermista spent her days oscillating between assisting with the tunnel construction, running drills with her guard and the remainder of her forces for those citizens interested in self defense, and helping with supply runs to the mainland. Sea Hawk worked with the guards on drills as well, in the food preparation and healing tents, or with the creche system that had been set up for the kids and orphans.

They fell into routine here. Rise with the sun, eat the breakfast Maevik brought them, the only meal they ate alone together, and then depart for their morning chores. Sea Hawk would gather up dirty linens and textiles with the other handmaids and bring them down to the freshwater stream for laundry. Mermista would train Eliza and a few of the other children for an hour or so with Maevik, sticking mainly to self defense with a sword, a trident, or with just their bare hands. Eliza was a bright girl, Mermista had learned, and a quick study, picking up the forms as fast as she and her guard could teach them. Maevik had gifted her her own training trident after just a week, with a promise to work with her even when the queen was busy.

In the afternoon, she kept the ocean at bay so the engineers could dig and fortify and, more than not, argue viciously about the tunnel system. Mermista didn't love this part of her day, as it mostly consisted of standing around, holding her arms in the air, and waiting for progress to be made. Sometimes a dolphin swam by, or an osprey circled overhead, and she would chat with them for a bit. Turns out the wildlife of Etheria? Remarkably *not* thrilled about the alien invaders pumping toxic sludge into the ground to siphon out the good shit like nutrients and magic.

Idly, she wondered how Perfuma was holding up.

While she did that, Sea Hawk worked with the kitchens or with the children, depending on who needed an extra hand more. The kids in Lua Pele were, shocking no one, rabid for Sea Hawk and his ridiculous stories and stupid songs, and he was equally happy to have a willing audience. Or, he would take them into the mangrove and willow jungles to climb trees and run around in the safest place they had to burn off energy. He was becoming fast friends with the parents and families of Salineas, and there weren't many in the village who shied away from addressing him personally, much to his happiness. Mermista didn't mind the space people gave her as Queen and Princess; she'd grown up with it, and she was a private person who enjoyed her own company. Sea Hawk was like the dogs one could find hanging around the ports, content on his own but happier when people paid him friendly attention. Mermista knew that if people had started giving him space after their confluence, he'd have gone crazy. Well, crazier.

That was where she found him today at sundown, in the jungle with the children and a few other parents. He was seated against a tree trunk, cradled in its roots with an Angler child in his lap, and a Salinean toddler balancing on his shoulder. She saw Eliza a few yards away, sitting with a Mer-Mystery book in her lap. Mermista had loaned it to her one evening after she overheard the little girl asking Maevik if he had anything other than training manuals to read. It was a little advanced for her age, but Mermista had started reading them at her age and she had high hopes for her little…apprentice? Shadow? Whatever.

"Hey, dork." She sauntered up to her husband, reeking of mud and brackish water.

"Evening, dearest," Sea Hawk grinned at her, even as the child on his shoulder began trying to climb on top of his head. "Finished with the tunnels? Ow- Helena-"

"Yep," Mermista plucked the kid off Sea Hawk, ignoring her short-lived whine. She plopped down next to him, settling the young girl in her lap and idly braiding her thick hair as she spoke. "For today, anyway. I swear, all they do all day is argue, and then in the last two hours, work like they've been possessed. It's fffff- freakin' ridiculous."

Sea Hawk chuckled at her save in front of the young kids. The angler child in his lap was occupied, batting at his own lure and watching it glow, but the Salinean girl was eyeing her shrewdly- well, as shrewd as a maybe-four-year-old could be. Which was still, apparently, very shrewd. "Well, at least it's getting done. Are your arms sore?"

"Yea, kinda," she shrugged. "It's fine. How was your day? Hear from the others?"

If Sea Hawk noticed her deflection, and he always did, he didn't press her this time. "It was lovely! After morning training, Eliza and I went on patrol with Maevik and two other guards, and then I returned her to the creche and stuck around to help out. Been here since," he tapped the now dozing child in his lap on the nasal ridge, and they twitched a bit. Mermista bit back a grin. "I did hear from Bow. Which we can talk about after dinner."

That didn't sound good. "Right. When is it time for everyone to head in?"

Sea Hawk glanced skyward. "Probably soon-"

" *HELP! Someone, please!* "

They were on their feet before they really knew what was happening, but the sound of something- no, several somethings- crashing through the underbrush was easy. Sea Hawk lifted two fingers to his mouth and whistled sharply- short, short, long. The children, who had frozen in their play, immediately leapt into action, running for the village entrance. “Go! Just like we practiced, get to your Safety Zones. Hurry!”

They handed the toddlers off to two older kids, and Mermista reached for the trident she was never, ever without these days. Eliza bounded up to them, weaving through the last of the kids. “Queen Mermista-”

“No.”

“But-!”

“Absolutely not, Eliza.”

The little girl huffed, stamping her foot. “But this is what I’m training for.”

“No, you’re learning self-defense, in case we fail and can’t hold the Horde back. We aren’t training you to throw yourself headlong into danger.”

“Please-!”

“Eliza,” Mermista sighed, and placed a hand on her shoulder. “Please, kid, I’m begging you, just head back to the village and send Maevik. Get your trident, and follow the other kids. You may need to fight anyway, alright?”

“Dearest, we have to go, now.” Sea Hawk was glancing anxiously at the sky.

“Eliza, you have an order. Follow it or hand in your trident. Now, go!” Mermista gave the girl a little push, and despite the mutiny in her eyes, she took off for the village. She groaned “I’ll deal with that later.”

“Still want kids?” Sea Hawk snorted as they started toward the open shoreline and decimated town toward the front of the island.

“Ask me again after we win. I’m sure I’ll be giddy enough to agree to all sorts of self-destructive behavior.”

“Aw, heartwarming!” Mermista feigned a punch at his arm, smiling despite herself. They took off at a light jog toward the scream, doing their best to stay silent as they moved off the path and into the underbrush. She took the lead, crossing over small streams and winding through thick tree cover until they could see the rocky shore. Horde bots, bipedal and one-eyed with long, sharp arms, laser cannons mounted on them, were scanning the shore. A Salinean woman Mermista vaguely recognized was crouching behind an outcrop of rocks. Sea Hawk swore.

"Tilda. She came down to do some of the laundry, I thought she said she was coming with…oh gods-"

He cut himself off, and pointed shakily at the slumped form of a young man, crumpled at an unnatural angle a ways off. It looked like he'd been running for the shelter of the rocks, but hadn't quite made it. Mermista grit her teeth. "I can handle this. Cover my back, and get them both out."

"Be safe."

"Always, duh."

Mermista waited until the bots were scanning the rubble of what was once a nice house, before sprinting out from under cover and charging the Horde bots. With a yell, she pulled forth a tidal wave, slamming it into the intruders without mercy. Two of them crumpled like paper on impact, crushed under the weight of the sea. The other two sputtered and sparked, but otherwise remained upright. She snarled. Using the water, she lifted them off the ground and sent them flying.

Sea Hawk was helping the woman, who was clearly in shock, to her feet. "Go now, get back to the village. We've got it covered here.”

“But, what about Noa-”

“We’ll get him, I swear. Go!” Sea Hawk pushed her firmly toward the well hidden path that would take Tilda to the village, and help. He turned to the prone man, sliding onto his knees and immediately checking for a pulse. Mermista watched him with bated breath, only releasing it when Sea Hawk gave her a thumbs up. She looked at the returning two bots, and then Sea Hawk, making her decision.

“I can handle this here. Take him back to the village.”

Sea Hawk glared. “I’m not leaving you, Mermista.”

“Either you take him now, or he dies,” she shot back. “Salineas first, like we agreed, right?”

He grit his teeth, and she could see him trying to argue the point in his head, but he gave in with jerky nod, and hoisted the younger man into his arms. “Don’t play around, dearest. Finish it and fall back.”

She rolled her eyes. “Yeah, no shit. I’ll only be a few.” She watched him vanish into the tree cover, and turned back to the bots. They were charging her, their legs sounding like pistons and steam engines as they ran. She pulled more water out of the ocean and grabbed them up in it again, slamming them into a pile of rocks and debris. One went down, the other got to its feet, sans an arm.

“Man, even when they’re from space the Horde can’t make a quality bot.” She jeered. The cyclopic eye whirred and clicked, like the camera on a datapad, and Mermista felt…watched. Freaky. She wasted no more time, pulling water off of the ground in thin tendrils and snaking it into the cracks in the bot’s shell so she could pull it apart from the inside out. It’s freakish head popped off its body with a satisfying *clank!* while the rest of its body just sort of fell apart. Satisfied, Mermista turned to leave.

She never saw the laser blast coming.

– – —- – - –

“...too dangerous here….exposed….Bow said….camp in the Woods…”

“It would…move them all…we would… room and…elderly… you two should…”

“She won’t agree…abandon…trauma…”

“Only hope….have…”

Mermista peeled her eyes open and groaned at the harsh light above her. As her senses returned in small waves, so did the pain radiating over her back and hip. She gasped, but her lungs felt like they were being pressed into her shoulders, so it came out as a mangled cough. The light died down, and she could see she was in their bedroom, Sea Hawk on one side of her, Maevik standing guard on the other. Neither of them look thrilled with her.

“What?” She snapped, or tried to. It was more of a grumble.

“Your Majesty-”

“Mermista-”

The two men glanced at each other, but Sea Hawk motioned for Maevik to take the lead. Mermista clocked the muscle jumping in her husband’s jaw, the vein pulsing at his temple. He was decidedly *not happy* . In fact, she would even be so bold as to say he was angry. True anger was a rare emotion in Sea Hawk, and it set her teeth on edge.

“Your Majesty, we need to discuss the immediate future of Lua Pele. This is the third potential raid in two weeks, and they’re getting closer to the entrance path each time. The builders cannot reinforce the walls fast enough, but if we put all the manpower into the tunnels, they could be done by the week’s end, and we can move the populace onto the main land.”

“Where would we go from there?” Mermista’s head was foggy, and throbbing. She definitely had a concussion.

“The King mentioned your friend, Bow, sent correspondence of a joint Rebel Camp, an Alliance between the refugees of all Etheria’s kingdoms. Perhaps-”

Mermista pushed herself upright; if they were going to have this talk, she wasn’t going to do it lying down. “Wouldn’t that just create a larger, more concentrated target for the Horde?”

Maevik sighed. “We can’t really say for sure-”

“I think we can assume,” she sighed. Her temples ached, and nausea was climbing up her throat. “Lua Pele is well protected and highly defensible. If we try to move everyone, even with the tunnels, we run the risk of a total loss.”

Sea Hawk spoke, at last. “Then we leave the people here, and go to the Camp ourselves.”

Mermista blinked at him, wondering if she was hallucinating. How hard was she hit? “Why the hell would we do that?”

“Bow’s requested-”

“Oh well then of course we should just up and go-”

“Please let me finish-”

“Start saying things that make sense and I’ll seriously consider it.” Mermista rolled her eyes. Sea Hawk closed his, and took a deep breath. Maevik was shifting uneasily from foot to foot.

“The camp needs us.”

“Salineas needs us more.”

“If we link back with the Alliance, we can talk about strategies to end this, and that’s the absolute best shot we can give the people.” Mermista clenched her jaw, saying nothing. He made an excellent point. “Mermista, we’re bailing water out of a sinking ship. If we lighten the weight, get off, and get help, we can save them all, and not just the lucky ones.”

“No.”

“Mermista-”

“I said no.”

“You’re not letting yourself think straight-”

“Oh, because you’re always so reasonable and logical,” Mermista scoffed and swung her legs out of bed. “Maevik, you’re dismissed.”

Her guard all but fled the growing tension in the room. Mermista pushed herself to her feet, but had to steady herself on the dresser when hot, sharp pain lanced up her left side and buckled her knee. Sea Hawk was suddenly in her field of view, palms turned upwards and ready to support her. Mermista, however, was feeling particularly petty, so she batted them away, keeping herself upright by sheer force of will.

“Fine, be that way,” Sea Hawk rolled his eyes, and Mermista pushed away the gnawing regret that always followed outbursts like that. “Mermista, you know I’m right.”

“Do I?” She rolled her eyes. “Please, mansplain to me more what I do and don’t know.”

Sea Hawk threw his hands up. “You know that’s not what I’m saying! Mermista- you- *fine* . Be that way.” He stomped out of the room, and Mermista gaped.

“Where are you going?”

“To get some air.”

Something ugly and angry was prying her mouth open, seizing control of her brain and voice. She couldn’t have stopped it if she wanted to, calling after him. “Yeah, run away, Sebastian! Just like you always do when things don’t go the way you want them to.”

The front door slammed, but the sound of steps was not retreating away from the house. In fact, they were coming back towards the bedroom, angrily. Sea Hawk was suddenly there in the doorway, taking up a lot more space than usual, the slouchy bastard. She opened her mouth, either to dig herself deeper or start climbing out, but it didn’t matter because Sea Hawk had crossed the room and was in her face now. She didn’t give him the satisfaction of backing down, and so their noses brushed as he snarled at her. “You are the most stubborn, self-satisfied, *petty* woman I have ever met, and you know what? You can be *mean* , Mermista. Mean when *you* don’t get what *you* want, and mean when you do half the time. I don’t know how I forgot, but I did, and now I’m paying for it.”

“Shut up,” she snapped, pushing away the hurt. “You don’t get to sit here and point fingers when you just run ahead without me half the time and expect me to be ready to race and catch up without a moment of thought for myself.”

“It’s called trust-”

“Oh get over yourself,” she rolled her eyes. “It’s called egomania, Sebastian. Do you seriously think I don’t trust you?”

“Somedays I seriously doubt it.” He huffed.

She scoffed. “Look me in the eyes and say that like you mean it, and maybe then I’ll be hurt.”

He did look her in the eyes, but he didn’t open his mouth to hurt her. “Why won’t you just have this discussion with me, Mermista? We need to have it.”

“No, we don’t.”

“Yes, we really do!” He shouted, and she realized they were still nose to nose. “We need to rejoin the Alliance, and end this. The people will be safer without us here.”

“Says who?”

“Entrapta thinks Horde Prime is tracking down Princesses, and I think she might be right.”

“That’s- what? No, that can't be it. What would he even need us for?”

“I don’t know, Mermista, but we can’t take chances” Sea Hawk’s eyes were pleading. “Please, we have to go, and you know we do, so why won’t you just-”

“ *Because I won’t abandon them again!* ” She shouted back, finally. There was a small flicker of satisfaction at Sea Hawk’s shock. “I won’t do it, Sebastian, and you can’t…you can’t ask me to do that. I can’t leave my people alone in the middle of this war. I can’t leave them to die, and you can’t make me.”

“Mermista,” Sea Hawk sighed, the fire in his eyes finally banking into something softer, more familiar. “I’m not asking you to abandon them. I know you’re scared- don’t roll your eyes at me, you are- but we can’t let fear paralyze us, and doom them.”

Mermista shook her head. “I can’t leave them alone, Sebastian.”

He looked at her for a long moment, then nodded. “Fine. Then you go to the Camp, and I’ll stay here with them.”

“ *What-?* Absolutely not.”

“That is the only logical solution here, Mermista.”

“N-no! I refuse. I won’t leave you.”

“What other choices do we have?” He begged her. “I need to keep you safe, dearest. Help me keep you safe.”

“No,” her eyes burned, and she willed away the tears. “You- you can’t ask me to be okay with this.”

“I’m not,” he smiled sadly. “I’m just asking you to do it.”

She squeezed her eyes shut, the fight leaving her body like a sigh. Her knee buckled again, and this time she let Sea Hawk pull her against him. “I can’t, and I mean that. I can’t just leave you.”

“We have the bond,” he stroked her hair, and she heard him sniffle. “And, sooner or later, this war is going to end.”

The idea of it ending badly came unbidden into her brain, and she thought of him, alone as he fell, surrounded by enemies without her at his back- “No. Alright? No. I will go to the camp, if you really think that’s the best move here. But I won’t go without you. We can leave Maevik in charge.”

He eyes her warily. “Are you sure, dearest?”

“Not even a little,” she sighed. “But you seem to feel strongly about this, and maybe I’m not thinking very objectively so. I’m trusting you. Because I do. Trust you, I mean. I always do.”

“I know you do,” he kissed her temple. “...I’m sorry for calling you mean.”

“Yeah, well…I’m sorry for being so nasty about you taking a minute. That wasn’t fair.”

“It’s alright,” he pulled her away just enough to kiss her. “I love you, Mermista.”

“How embarrassing for you” she smiled a bit, but it didn’t fully reach her eyes. “I love you, too. Can I lay down again now?”

Sea Hawk helped her back into bed, and climbed in on the other side. She rolled over and snuggled against him as soon as his head hit the pillow, and he wrapped an arm around her to pull her close. “I have to call Bow back.”

“Go for it, just leave the picture off. I look like shit.”

“Fun fact, that’s an actual impossibility.”

“Uh, the Fright Zone sewers?”

“...improbability?”

Mermista snorted, tucking her face into Sea Hawk’s shoulder. “You’re dumb.”

“You like me that way.”

“Yeah,” she yawned. “It’s cute.”

“Stars, you are concussed aren’t you?”

“Oh, yeah, big time.”

“Just lay there and rest. But don’t fall asleep.”

“I know what to do,” she sighed, and listened to him tap away on his datapad. The outgoing call chimes filled the room, and soon Bow picked up. Mermista glanced up to see him, and felt her heart pang a bit at just how dog-tired their friend looked. “Sea Hawk! Glad to hear from you.”

“Hey, Bow. We’ve thought it over, and we’re going to leave here in a few days, as soon as the tunnels are done. It’ll take us a bit to get to you since we’ll have to travel on foot after we find somewhere to hide the ship.”

“Take all time you want!” Bow’s face had lit up, and he leaned off screen. “Guys, Sea Hawk and Mermista are gonna come.”

There was a rustling the sound of footsteps before Perfuma and Frosta’s faces filled the screen. “Is that them? Hey guys!”

“Why can’t we see them?” Frosta frowned. “Turn the picture on.”

“They have it off, not me.”

“Oh,” she rolled her eyes. “Are they being gross?”

Mermista snorted. “No, we are not being gross. Hi guys.”

“Mista!” Perfuma sounded and looked very choked up, and wow, that was absolutely not going to make Mermista cry, no sir, not here, not now. Not ever. “I’m so glad you’re both okay.”

“Mostly okay,” she sighed. “I’m sliiiiiightly concussed. Just a teensy bit.”

“It’s a large bit.” Sea Hawk corrected.

“Still, a bit.”

“How’d you get hurt?” Frosta and Perfuma had commandeered the pad from an annoyed looking Bow. “Was it cool?”

“Uh, duh, it’s me,” Mermista smirked. “I took down some bots and apparently some of them have a delayed cannon fire thing going on, so I took a laser right to the hip. And back. And I guess I hit the ground really hard.”

Sea Hawk hugged her tighter. “Luckily, all her hair broke the fall so her huge head- ow! Hey! Stop pinching!”

Mermista stuck her tongue out, but relented. “Anyway, yeah. So, recovery, finish the tunnels, then we’ll set out.”

“Adora will be happy to have you guys around,” Perfuma smiled, but it was strained. “She feels better with everyone in one spot.”

“Still no sign of Glimmer?” The silence spoke volumes. “Right yeah. We’ll call again when we head out.”

"Can't wait to see you both," Bow smiled. "Travel safely. Feel better!"

They ended the call, and Mermista swiped gently at her eyes. "I didn't know how much I missed them."

"We've been focused on everything else," Sea Hawk soothed. "And now, we can focus on ending this whole thing."

"After we sleep?"

"No sleep," he frowned. "Not until your head stops throbbing."

"Fine," she sighed, feigning a put-upon eye roll even as she grabbed for the lapels of Sea Hawk's shirt. She tugged him closer, smiling at the *meep!* he made as she manhandled him. "I guess I can think of some other ways to kill time."

Sea Hawk chuckled, moving over her. "As my wife commands."

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The tunnels ended up taking three more days thanks to a massive, concentrated effort by the entire community. Three days of almost non-stop work, sun up to sun down, holding back the ocean or filtering water into the clay mixtures they used to lay bricks and build. Their insured contingency plan was ready to go, and they left that very night after wishing Maevik, Dhang, and Eliza goodbye. Sea Hawk politely didn't mention how long Mermista held on to each of them, or the tears she brushed from her eyes the whole way to the shore line.

Settling into life in the Rebellion Camp was depressingly easy. Bow had given them their own tent with a double cot, so there were still small mercies in the universe. Routines were big here; wake up at dawn, patrol the border of the magical barrier and also the protected territory outside of it. Mid-morning was break for food, then inventory, training, daily group meetings. Then, at noon, watch parties were sent out, sorcerers had shift change, and the Princess' were deployed to kick Insert Bad Guy of the Day's ass. Most of the time, it was clones. Sometimes it was smugglers and other dickheads who were taking advantage of the chaos to create- well, more chaos. Either way, it was a never ending stream of kicking ass.

The best days were the quiet ones, where they spent the afternoon sparring, or strategizing. When they weren't doing that, they were helping the camp stay running. Much to Mermista's personal discomfort, there were families at this camp, too, which meant more non-combatants to protect and stress over. But it also meant breaks from warfare.

On days like today, where she and Perfuma were escorting the kids and their parents down to the river to bathe, it was easy to forget just how much danger they were all in. They were going in sets, so they could keep an eye on everyone and protect them all should they need to. Right now, they were perched on a sunny rock in the middle of the river, and Mermista had swapped her legs for her tail, which several of the children were goggling over, clearly wanting to touch the fins and scales she was trailing through the water.

Mermista sighed, reclining in the sun. “So, how’s Plumeria holding up?”

“As well as can be expected,” Perfuma sighed. “They’ve closed all borders, hidden the paths, and completely covered up the village and all the surrounding territories. Most of the people have retreated to the treehouses.”

“Defensible.”

“Exactly,” she hummed. “How was Lua Pele?”

“Wonderful, in a sort of way,” Mermista shrugged. “It was nice to have everyone so close, in one place and easily protected. But I just want to rebuild, y’know? I want to give everyone their homes back, get my home back, find a new normal.”

“I know exactly what you mean,” Perfuma stretched her willowy arms to the sky. “You didn’t hear this from me, but Frosta lost the harbor towns a week ago.”

“What!” Mermista gaped. “She didn’t say anything.”

“You know how she is. She has to appear strong, and unflappable, or else she thinks we see her as just some kid ruler.”

“She’ll grow out of that.”

“Please,” Perfuma snorted kindly. “With role models like you and Glimmer, she’s going to be *the* Ice Queen.”

“If Glimmer ever comes back…”

“Well, yes…that.”

Mermista glanced up at the sky, the day moons floating alongside the new, distant, non-artificial sun. “I just wish we knew where she was. That she was even, y’know, still alive.”

Perfuma said nothing, and they let the silence stretch on until it was time to head back.

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Mermista's back hit the ground so hard it felt like she'd been re-shot with the laser cannon. She was still trying to catch her breath when Bow loomed over her. "You good?"

With a snarl, she kicked out viciously and clipped his ankles, sending the archer sprawling. In a flash she was on her feet, one foot on his chest and her trident level with his throat. Water hung behind her in ominous bubbles. Adora sighed off to the side. "Mermista's match. Bow, what the hell?"

"What?!" Bow wheezed as she took her foot off his chest and offered him an arm. "She looked like she was in pain."

"You don't stop to check on your opponent's wellbeing."

"She's not an opponent, she's my friend."

Mermista rolled her eyes and moved back to the sidelines with Sea Hawk. He bumped her hip with his. "Nice shot with the legs, dearest."

"Thanks," she yawned, rubbing at her hip. "God, do these cannon wounds ever get better?"

"Give it another month."

“Uuughhhh.” She groaned.

Adora cleared her throat. “Alright, Bow and Sea Hawk can sit this one out. Mermista and Frosta versus Scorpia and Perfuma. Five minute melee brawl, winner determined by me. Ready?”

Frosta nodded at her as they took center across from a worried-looking Scorpia and a determined Perfuma. “Let’s take them down.”

“Do we really have to fight? C’mon, we all know how good we are.” Scorpia’s tail twitched nervously.

“It’s not about being good, Scorpia,” Adora frowned. “It’s about being better. Go!”

Mermista yanked more water out of the stream she could feel about a half mile away, and brought it rushing forward with a concerning level of force. She hurled half of it at Scorpia, who was knocked flying, and tossed the other half to Frosta as bubbles. She turned them into jagged chunks of ice and sent them crashing at Perfuma, who blocked it effortlessly with a wall of vines. They rushed her as she lowered the wall, and sent her sprawling to the ground. Frosta froze her to the earth, and Mermista yanked Scorpia back with tendrils of water that left her suspended and immobilized.

Adora called it. “That wasn’t even two minutes. Mermista and Frosta, excellent teamwork. Scorpia, Perfuma…that sucked.”

“We know,” Perfuma groaned. “We haven’t had time to train.”

“Take tomorrow morning off and work on sparring together for next time. Being able to work together could literally save your life.”

“Hey, where’s Entrapta?” Bow glanced around. “I told her we were doing Princess training.”

“Who gives a fuck?” Mermista rolled her eyes. “She’s fine with her tech.”

“Mermista,” Bow frowned. “She’s still a Princess.”

“In title, sure,” Bow sighed angrily at her belligerence. They’d been bickering about this a lot. “Look, it’s whatever. I’m glad she’s alive, or whatever. But her technology razed my home to the ground and killed a lot of my people. Not to mention the bots she was *actively sending to harm us* ? With a Princess like that, who needs enemies. Oh wait-!”

“Enough,” Adora barked, massaging her temples. “Please, leave it alone for tonight, you two. It’s getting dark, and we have to do night patrol after dinner.”

“When is dinner?” Frosta piped up from next to Scorpia.

“An hour. Get cleaned up.” Adora dismissed them, and Mermista immediately turned for the river. She needed to clear her head, and to do that, she needed water. She heard footsteps behind her, heard the creak of leather and the sound of metal tapping the rocks, and let Sea Hawk follow. They didn’t speak until she was ankle deep in the clear water, shoes left on the overgrown bank next to her trident and vambraces and shoulder armor. Sea Hawk waded in after her. “Dearest?”

“I don’t understand how they can just be okay with her being here,” she kept her eyes on the water, now up to her waist. “I don’t know how they can trust her, or even tolerate her, after everything she’s done to us.”

“I know, dearest.”

“She hasn’t even apologized,” Mermista squeezed her eyes shut as her voice tapered into a hoarse whisper. “She made the weapon that killed my people, Eliza’s mother and my soldiers and my citizens, *children* , and she hasn’t apologized.”

Sea Hawk had leapt from the bank along some rocks, and now sat on the boulder that she and Perfuma had occupied just the other day. Mermista ducked under the water before he could speak, wetting her hair and letting her legs turn into her tail. She let the noise and stress of the world above fade into calm silence, giving her time to reign in her emotions. When she broke the surface, Sea Hawk was leaning back on his elbows, staring up at the stars.

“Hey.”

“Hello there,” he smiled at her, and she looked away. “Feeling better?”

“Nope.” Mermista sighed, leaning back to float face up. Her deep melancholy sigh was cut off by water sloshing into her mouth. She coughed and spluttered, sitting up to see Sea Hawk looking away again, whistling obnoxiously. She slapped her tail on the water at an angle that left him soaked through, and he gasped at her theatrically.

“Mer *mista!* Now I’m all wet.”

“Wet? In a river? Groundbreaking.” She rolled her eyes, not even cracking a smile. Sea Hawk frowned, and kicked more water at her. “Dude. Stop.”

He stuck his tongue out at her, and kicked again. She growled, and flung more water at him. He merely spat out what got in his mouth, and kicked yet again. With a snarl of frustration, she grabbed him by the foot and pulled hard. She winced slightly when his head knocked against the rock on his way down into the river, but not much. He was absurdly hard headed, literally, and she wasn't feeling very empathetic tonight.

Sea Hawk came to the surface, coughing out some water. "Rude."

"You're the one who wouldn't fucking stop."

"Ah, yes," he nodded in mock agreement, stroking his mustache lazily. "Spousal abuse is always the answer to annoyance."

"Prick." Mermista glowered at him and dove under, making sure to slap him with her tail. To her shock, though, he grabbed the trailing, gauzy tailfin as it swung, stopping her short and yanking her to him. "Sebastian!"

"Mermista!" He mimicked her, looking far too amused with himself. Mermista suddenly felt twenty-one again, prepared to murder her obnoxious, bothersome partner.

She pushed at his chest as he reeled her in. "Let go of me!"

"Nope," he hummed, wrapping his arms around her. "You're crankier than usual lately, and it's long past time we had a talk."

He was right. For the past week, she'd just been getting angrier and angrier, shorter on patience than usual, all her energy focused on not erupting on her friends, the refugees, the soldiers, her husband. Most nights she fell into bed and was asleep before she hit the pillow. Not that it was particularly restful…not when-

"I've been having nightmares," she muttered at the water, refusing to look up. "Or, night…fits? I dunno, whatever."

"It's not whatever."

"I know, okay?!" She snapped, and then felt the sharp and familiar tang of regret. "I know. I just- Every time I try to sleep, I hear *them* in my head. 'Salineas is gone'. And then I relive it all over again. Every night, I try to save my kingdom, and my people, and I fail, and then I wake up, and it's all just *right there.* At the surface. And *then* , I walk outside and I see Entrapta, and Scorpia, sitting around with my friends and being all buddy-buddy and I-"

She was heaving for air now, rage turning her vision hazy at the edges while water sloshed around them. Sea Hawk's eyes were more than concerned when she snapped her head up to him, but he held on tight. She swallowed.

"I want to hurt them," she whispered, hating herself for it. "I want to hurt them and it's wrong. It's so wrong, and I hate myself for it. I look at them, and all I can think about are all the new orphans in Lua Pele, the people who lost homes, and family, and limbs, and I…I…"

"I understand," Sea Hawk murmured. "I do. I really, and truly, do. Because some days I wake up, and I feel the same thing."

And that was enough. Like she'd suddenly found her footing in deep water, Sea Hawk's assurances rolled over her like a blanket. She slumped against him, perverse relief that she wasn't alone with these horrid emotions rolling through her. "You aren't a terrible person, or friend. You're grieving, and traumatized, and this war is still far from over, my dear. I don't blame you for feeling this way, and you shouldn't blame yourself."

"I just want to know *why* ," Mermista tipped her head forward to rest on Sea Hawk's clavicle. "Why did Entrapta try to kill us? What the hell did we ever do to her to warrant *that?* "

"That's a question only she can answer."

Mermista hummed, and pushed away from Sea Hawk. She leaned back again to look at the stars, tail trawling lazily behind her. Sea Hawk knew well enough that she needed space, and he hesitantly gave it to her, all the while keeping an eye on her for any signs of a spiral.

She had been so strong, his love. In Lua Pele, she'd been every inch the queen he knew she always could be, and was, under all the stress and patriarchal resentment and detestation of bureaucracy in all its forms. Because at the end of the day, Mermista loved her people, and it showed every day in Salineas.

Here, it was like watching someone hide a lamp under a basket. She was withdrawing again, back into her old, grumpy, emotionally stunted self. Sea Hawk knew it was self defense, that she was just trying to survive in the face of total uncertainty, but it hurt.

“Dearest?” He called.

“Hm?”

“I love you.”

“...I love you, too.”

She swam back over to him, circling him lazily like a shark. He smiled. “Feeling better?”

“I always feel better when we’re alone,” she shrugged, like this was a fact. He supposed it was. “It’s like being home.”

Sea Hawk smiled, and he knew it was his biggest, dopiest, teariest grin because it made Mermista roll her eyes almost immediately. “I feel the same.”

“Yeah, yeah.” She flicked him with her tail, but dipped closer to him. He leaned against the rock and opened his arms, letting her float into his chest and rest her back against him. It was properly dark now, and Sea Hawk couldn’t see a thing in front of him.They laid there until he was well past pruning, staring at the stars. Sea Hawk talked, stories and old sailor’s lore and little songs, while Mermista stayed quiet. Eventually, she turned in his arms, and shut him up with soft lips on his chapped ones. He sighed into her mouth, and she ran her tongue lazily along his bottom lip. Gently, like he was scared to shatter this heady, hidden moment, he met her tongue with his, small little caresses meant to tease without a goal in mind. Kissing just to kiss, to hear her sigh and feel her smile against his lips.

“I love you,” she breathed against his mouth, and he smiled. For now, this was enough.

stolen moments

Chapter Summary

Crushes abound, and emotions run high

Chapter Notes

More fluff and filler. The next chap is also filler but it's like. Fun and dramatic

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Dinner that night was a quiet, thoughtful affair. Mermista chatted idly with Frosta, but stayed as close to Sea Hawk as she could without being overly clingy, something she'd found herself reluctantly grappling with lately. She had *never* been a clingy person, never needed to be around anyone, and, in fact, often and happily eschewed social interaction for time alone. But now, maybe with everything being so dire all the damn time, she found herself more and more anxious the longer she was without Sea Hawk. Stupid marital bond. Stupid anxiety.

Said bond sat warm and innocuous in the back of her mind. If she didn't look for it on purpose, it was invisible, but when she prodded it, it was like running her finger quickly through a flame. Sometimes, it nudged her, the mental equivalent of something brushing her elbow. As she pondered it, the connection tapped at her, and she turned her head just enough to catch Sea Hawk's eye where he was chatting with Bow. His gaze slid over to her, and his eyes crinkled a bit in the corners, smiling without his mouth. She turned back to Frosta, but sent a wave of contention over the link. Something else they were getting good at; in close proximity, they could vaguely feel what the other was feeling if they pushed it along the path. It made sex otherwordly, when they could steal away long enough to indulge. Which was essentially never.

She heard Sea Hawk choke on his water, and realized that she'd probably shared that particular wave of frustration with him by accident. Whoops. Like she said, they were still practicing.

"Alright," Adora stood from her log around the fire. "Let's get moving for night patrol. I'll take Entrapta. Scorpia and Frosta, head to the southern border. Mermista, Perfuma, check the north. Bow, Sea Hawk, to the east. And we'll do the west. Good?" At their nods, she nodded. "Good. Meet back in an hour."

She didn't so much as acknowledge Sea Hawk as they split up, but she made sure to bump against him and brush his fingers with hers before leaving the camp and heading north with Perfuma. Her zen friend was quieter than normal, which Mermista was fine with.

"Hey Mermista?"

Nevermind. "Yeah?"

"How do- I mean, how did you…" Perfuma trailed off, and when Mermista glanced over she could see Perfuma running her hands through her hair. "I don't know how to ask this."

"Girl, what?" Mermista snorted. "I, like, made you teach me how to use a tampon. How could this possibly be worse?"

Perfuma giggled at that. “Okay, yeah. That’s fair. Um…Okay, just, can we keep this between us? Like, really, extremely secret-”

“Oh my gooooods,” Mermista groaned, swatting a branch out of her way. “Yes, yes, whatever, just talk.”

“How did you know you liked Sea Hawk?” Perfuma all but whispered. Mermista rolled her eyes.

“I don’t like Sea Hawk-”

“Mermista, I’m serious!”

“So am I!”

“You- ugh!” Perfuma huffed and just barely refrained from stamping her foot, and Mermista smothered a chuckle. It was too easy to wind her up.

“Alright, alright, chill. You have a crush?”

“...maybe?”

“Gonna tell me who?” Perfuma’s silence was deafening. “That’s fine, I’ll just guess. Can’t be Bow, can’t be Frosta, you better pray to every god you know that it’s not Sea Hawk because while I can, like, swing that way for a good time, I’m not big on long-term sharing-”

“ *Mermista!* ”

“So, it’s either Scorpia, Entrapta, or Adora. And, being honest with ourselves, Adora’s so emotionally unavailable thanks to Catra, our literal fucking enemy, that it would be self-deprecating at best. Aaaaand since I’ve seen you ready to chew glass after talking with Entrapta, gonna go with the safest bet we’ve got. So, pincers, huh?”

Mermista glanced sidelong at Perfuma and grinned at just how beet red the usually collected woman was. “I- That- Y-you read too many Mer-Mysteries!”

“Tell me something I don’t know- oh, wait, you can’t.” She stuck her tongue out as she smiled, and Perfuma rolled her eyes.

“She’s just…really, really kind, and gentle, and funny when she’s comfortable, and-” The soft grin that had overtaken her friend faltered. “She’s been badly hurt, though. In love. And I don’t know what to do with that.”

“She has?” Mermista blinked. “I didn’t think they’d have time, or, like, capacity, for love in the Horde.”

“They- She didn’t. Not really. But she tried, it seems. And suffered for it.”

“Who?”

“...this can’t get around.”

“I swear, I swear. Just tell me.”

“...Catra.”

Mermista’s mouth fell open slightly. That made a lot of sense, actually, as she pieced together snippets of one-sided conversations, interactions in battle; the retaking of the river Keep with Sea-Ra came to mind. She didn’t have a great deal of love for Scorpia- Princess or not she had still fought for the Horde- but even she couldn’t deny the kindness at the arachnid woman’s core. It was just a shame it had taken her this long to act on it. In the meantime, it seemed the Horde had zero issues with taking advantage of her misplaced loyalty, both professionally and personally.

Perfuma swallowed and wrung her hands. “She said that Catra used her affection against her, used it to manipulate her-”

“She is, like, very malleable, you know that, right?”

“Yes, I do,” Perfuma sighed. “Hence a good deal of my hesitancy. She’s never just had a friend for friendship’s sake, you know. Could you imagine that?”

All too easily, Mermista mused. Still…where would she be now if she hadn’t let the Alliance into her heart? More than Perfuma, anyway. Memories of breakfasts, sleepovers, stolen moments of joy in the middle of the darkness, came unbidden into her mind, and against her will, she felt a good deal of sadness and pity for Scorpia. “I see your point.”

“She told me that before the portal went off…before we lost Angella…Entrapta tried to stop Catra. She told her that they needed to stop the portal, to shut it down and Catra-” Perfuma paused to take a breath. “Catra attacked her. Took her out with a baton, and had Scorpia put her on the transport to Beast Island, because when Scorpia tried to step in, she turned on her, threatened her.”

Mermista turned to her. She’d known the basics of Entrapta’s banishment but that was…yikes. “Wasn’t that, like, the entirety of the inner Horde circle?”

“Uh-huh.”

Once again, against her will, the hard ground she'd stood on regarding Entrapta and Scorpia softened that much more. "I know this is a massive understatement, but, my gods, the Horde is fucked up."

"You said it."

— – —- - - - –

Bow was rarely this…quiet. Sure, he was a thoughtful young man, always reading or on his data pad, but it was odd when he wasn't actively engaging in conversation when he was with friends. The silence between him and Sea Hawk as they meandered around the eastern perimeter was disconcerting. He had tried to start a conversation a few times, only to be stonewalled with one word answers or stony silences. Luckily, Sea Hawk had more experience than the average person with this type of emotion.

Small talk was a failure. Current events was a failure. Gentle prying was a failure. What did Sea Hawk do when he failed? Went bigger and harder with all guns blazing, logically.

"So Bow, what the hell is up with you lately?" Nailed it.

"Nothing," the archer bit out, swatting more viciously than necessary at a hanging bough of greenery. "I'm just tired."

“We’re all tired,” he snorted. “This isn’t that. C’mon, lad, wouldn’t talking about it help?”

“Never has before. In fact, it made everything worse. So, no, we can’t talk.”

Sea Hawk rolled his eyes in the darkness. “Fine. Keep being a noticeable grouch. Always good for camp morale.”

“Mermista makes it work.” He muttered.

Sea Hawk narrowed his eyes but kept his tone light. “What was that?”

Bow stopped walking, staring at the ground between his feet. His shoulders were a taught line, hunched up by his ears, and his arms were crossed. His body language had never been more closed off, but he sounded more like himself when he spoke after a prolonged silence. “Nothing. I’m sorry, that was rude of me.”

“Think nothing of it. But, really, what’s wrong, Bow?” He placed a hand on the younger man’s bicep.

The younger man scuffed his shoes at the sod beneath him, before he sighed and leaned against a tree. “I’m…angry.”

Sea Hawk nodded. “Okay. About what?”

“Everything, I guess,” Bow shrugged. “But, I’m mostly angry about Glimmer. Or, I guess…I’m angry at Glimmer. And isn’t that, like, incredibly fucked up? We don’t even know where she is, or if she’s- she’s,” he tilted his head back and Sea Hawk saw tears gathering in his eyes. He stepped closer to rest a hand on his shoulder, heart cracking open for his dear friend. “The last thing I ever said to her was that she was wrong, and I couldn’t trust her. If that’s the last thing she ever heard from me, I- I-” Bow dropped his chin to his chest as sobs wracked his frame, and Sea Hawk did the only thing he could think of, and tugged him into a tight hug.

“It’ll be alright, Bow.”

“You can’t possibly know that,” he sniffed. “Glimmer might be dead, and she’ll have died thinking I hate her.”

“Bullshit,” Sea Hawk tugged Bow back enough to meet his eyes. “Listen to me. There is no possible way that Glimmer, wherever she is, could ever believe you hate her. You’re thick as thieves, the best of friends. That doesn’t change overnight.”

“It got bad, at the end,” Bow hiccoughed and wiped at his eyes. They resumed a slower, more leisurely pace, one of Sea Hawk’s arms slung over the archer’s shoulders. “We had a lot of arguments, and then a really big fight before Adora and I ran off to get Entrapta. Which didn’t even help in the end.”

“You still saved an…ally.” Sea Hawk, despite his open and ever-bleeding heart, could not bring himself to call Entrapta a friend. Not yet, not after what she had put the Princesses through, witting or not.

“I guess,” Bow shrugged. “Wasn’t worth losing Glimmer, though.”

They lapsed into silence for a bit. Sea Hawk walked a bit ahead, nudging at foliage and roots with the tip of his sword, while Bow consulted his datapad every few feet. They made note of footprints, drones spotted and where they were going, and any and all clones or bots they saw. Eventually, out of boredom and his neverending curiosity, Sea Hawk spoke. “So, were you and Glimmer…?”

“What?” Bow tilted his head at Sea Hawk, who mimed a vague motion with his hands that could have been a bird in flight, or part of an interpretive dance on giving the heimlich underwater.

“You know?”

“I really don’t. What is that? What are you doing with your hands?”

“I’m pantomiming!”

“In what universe-”

“Were you dating, Bow!” Sea Hawk groaned, giving up his ill-fated hand dance.

“OH! What?! Me and Glimmer- psh- what? No!” Bow began his own interpretive dance, but his style involved more forearm swinging and less finger wiggling. “Don’t be ridiculous-”

“I’m not being ridiculous! I know love when I see it and goodness me, have I seen it in Bright Moon.” He bounced his eyebrows suggestively.

It was dark, but Bow’s cheeks glowed bright enough to light the forest. “We were not and are not dating.”

“But you’d like to be?”

“I didn’t say that!”

“You really didn’t have to.”

“Dude!”

“What are you hiding from?” Sea Hawk spread his arms wide, gesturing to the empty forest, or perhaps, to the shit storm just outside the barrier behind them. “Bow. Look me in the eyes and tell me I’m wrong, and I’ll drop it forever.”

Bow did in fact meet his eyes, but his jaw worked uselessly, producing an odd squeaking groan that ended in a very tired sigh. “Please don’t tell anyone.”

“Bow, my lad,” Sea Hawk clapped his friend on the shoulder. “I shan’t say a word. Pirate’s honor.”

“Is that…good?”

Sea Hawk shrugged gamely. “Depends. But at the end of the day, sometimes it’s all I have.”

“Square deal.” Bow snorted and jostled him with his shoulder, and Sea Hawk jostled back.

“Really, Bow. If you ever need to talk about any of this, you know where I sleep.”

“Yeah,” Bow *smirked* , and it was razor-sharp, an unsettling look in general. “In Mermista’s tent.”

“What was that about Mermista?”

They swung around in tandem, sword drawn and arrow nocked before registering who spoke. When Perfuma pushed through the dense foliage like it wasn’t there, they lowered their weapons. Sea Hawk frowned. “Where’s-”

“Perfuma- *fuck*- would it kill you to hold a branch for once? You keep swinging them back into my damn eyes,” Mermista stumbled out of the forest behind Perfuma, nearly face-planting over a root. She caught sight of him and Bow as she brushed pollen and petals off her body. “Oh. Hey.”

“Dearest.”

“Hey, Mermista!” Bow smiled happily, turning to walk alongside Perfuma. “You guys wrap up?”

“All quiet by us. How about you?” Perfuma smiled serenely.

“Well, there was this one clone…”

Their voices faded as Sea Hawk and Mermista let them walk ahead, falling into an easy and ambling step with one another. When he moved to tangle his fingers with Mermista’s, she met him halfway. “Hey.”

He checked the trees around them, and how far ahead Bow and Perfuma were. He tugged at Mermista's hand. "C'mere."

"What? Sea Hawk-"

"Please?" He turned ridiculous puppy-dog eyes on her, and she groaned.

"If it makes you stop making that awful face, then sure."

"Yay!" He pulled her into a thick copse of trees and frondy plants, deep and dark with a center that was practically invisible to any who walked by. Mermista was frowning as he led her as far in as he could.

"If I get another tick I swear on every g- *ah! Mmph!* "

It would have been gentlemanly to let his queen finish her thought, but Sea Hawk was a pirate, after all. He backed Mermista into the trunk of a thick tree, covering her lips with his to muffle her gasp. She recovered impressively, one hand flying to fist in his hair while the other grasped the lapel of his jacket. He hiked one of her legs over his hips and moved his hand back to squeeze her ass. In between kisses, he spoke. "I have- *mm-* something interesting to- *ah-* tell you."

“So do I,” Mermista sighed against his lips, grabbing his bottom one between her teeth and tugging until he groaned. “But it can wait until we’re in bed.”

“Right.” He ducked his head to rake teeth along her neck and she brought a hand up to stifle her moan. It had been so long, too long, since their last tryst. Between patrols and camp duty and Princess stuff and training, Mermista was almost too exhausted to function, and he was too concerned with keeping her healthy to think of much else. But right now he wanted- he *needed* - this, to feel close to her in a way only they knew. “I love you, Mermista.”

He couldn’t see her smile, but he could hear it in her voice. The smile she saved just for him, for them, that he had fought tooth and nail for. He felt it reverberate in his chest, and along the bond, like a warm summer breeze. “Love you, too.”

When they caught up with Bow and Perfuma an impressive ten minutes later, their friends were smart enough, or maybe just merciful enough, not to comment on their slightly mussed hair and clothes. They sat around the fire for the evening brief, led by an exhausted and stony-faced Adora, before retiring to their tent. Scorpia and Bow had watch tonight. They set about preparing for bed, another new routine they’d learned early on here.

The unspoken fact that the risk of a night-attack was too large to justify not sleeping in half-armor. Sea Hawk left his sword and belt on the nightstand, Mermista’s trident on the floor beside her, and she slept in softer but still reinforced leggings and a loose top. His jacket rested on the floor next to him. If they had to stand and fight as they were, they’d be fine. If they had to run, well, their bags were always packed and ready. Mermista sat cross legged on the bed unbraiding her hair while he did his nightly stretches on the small patch of ground. Despite her insistence that it was dorky and grandfatherly, she watched him every night.

“So, what’s up? What did you want to tell me?”

“Oh, yes!” Sea Hawk pushed up into a cobra pose, applying pressure as his vertebrae clicked. “So, I’m not supposed to tell anyone anything, obviously, so this stays in this tent. Between us. As spouses. Right?”

“You just love finding any excuse to remind me I’m saddled with you forever, huh?” Mermista sighed, but it was fond and her eyes were smiling. “Yes, I promise. Now spill.”

She nudged his ribs with her toe, and he yelped. “Dearest, please.”

“Alright, alright,” she chuckled and waved him on. “Tell me.”

“Bow had a small breakdown tonight, no big deal, because I, Sea Hawk, best friend extraordinaire, brilliant emotionalist, empathic to a fault-”

“-many faults-”

“-Was there to comfort him,” he gave her a hairy side eye that she deliberately ignored. “But that’s not the news. He told me…he’s in love with Glimmer!”

“Yawwwwwn,” Mermista smiled and rolled her eyes, even as she moved to sit cross legged next to him. “I totally saw that coming-”

“-oh, suuure,” Sea Hawk rolled his eyes. “Such a brilliant detective-”

“-I am, and jealousy isn’t pretty on you, babe,” Mermista was in very fine humor tonight, teasing and poking at him like the Before Days. He thrilled internally at her jabs, her quips, even if they were at his expense.

“Fine then,” he shifted his weight onto his forearms, moving to lift his knees to his elbows and hover in a crow pose. “What’s your big news?”

“Hm?” Mermista was openly eyeing his straining biceps, and his balance faltered as a breath of laughter punched out of his chest. “What?”

“My eyes are up here, love.”

“That’s nice, good for them,” she smirked. “Right, so, Perfuma asked me how I knew I was in love, blah blah, super weird for her, and then she got really cagey when I asked her why she wanted to know, and long story short, she's got a thing for Scorpia."

"What-!" His balance did give way at that, but he landed properly and rolled to his knees to catch his breath. "Really!"

"I *know* , right?"

He got to his feet and gave her a hand up, turning to recheck the fastening on the tent door flap and bank the lanterns inside. When he moved toward the bed, Mermista held the blankets open for him, and he all but dove into her arms. They shifted and got comfortable, ending up with her almost on top of him, her face pressed into his neck and their legs slotted together. Sea Hawk's nose was in her hair, and he inhaled deep lungfuls of spiced incense, sandalwood, sea salt, and something undefinable that he just called *Mermista* . Home.

"Are you alright with that?"

"With what?" Mermista's voice was already rough with sleep.

"Your closest friend and an ex-Horde Captain?"

"I'm…trying. Scorpia isn't like the rest of them, even I can see that. She was an accomplice, and a facilitator, but I really don't think that woman has even an ounce of malice in her. Just blind, misused, abused loyalty. I don’t personally understand but…”

“I do,” he murmured, humming as Mermista’s hand came up to trace the patterns of his scars and tattoos across his bicep.

“I know. And that’s why I’m trying to be open. For you, and Perfuma, and Scorpia.”

“Thank you, love.”

“Don’t thank me yet,” she hummed, nuzzling deeper into him. “We haven’t even had a test run yet.”

“I have full faith in you, love.”

“...Thanks,” she pressed a small kiss to his neck. “Get some sleep. We have the first watch tomorrow.”

“Yes, dearest,” he yawned, returning the kiss to her forehead. “Good night.”

“Night, love.”

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Netossa and Spinnerella arrived at camp within the following week, leading a battered but healthy group of refugees from their own regions. With their arrival, the tension lessened a good bit; they'd been fighting this war longer than any other Princess, and their insight was invaluable to the Rebellion. Strategy meetings became more productive and less argumentative… somewhat.

"I'm telling you, liberating Alwyn is our top priority! They're the breadbasket, and without them the refugees starve."

"And I don't disagree! But Thaymoor's been under siege the longest, and they have the best metals available for weaponry-"

"Weaponry we don't really need!"

"Without it, the Princesses will have to keep doing the heavy lifting-"

"And what's wrong with that?"

"Uh, we're exhausted?"

Mermista was reclined in a beanbag cushion thing from Bright Moon castle, watching the heated argument between Netossa and Adora. The two tended to butt heads most often, and lost no love or respect for it. It was just their way. Frosta was leaning back against Mermista's knees, half asleep despite the rising volume in the tent. Next to her, head against his chest, Sea Hawk *was* asleep against a table leg. They'd had a night watch and then immediately been brought in for this first thing. It sucked major ass.

"If you ask me, the Heart of Etheria-"

Mermista scowled. "Well, thankfully, not one single fucking person in here asked you shit, freaky lady."

Shadow Weaver sneered at her, it was obvious from the voice that echoed out of her terrifying mask. "Insolent child-"

"Not even remotely a child-"

"I ought to-"

"ENOUGH!" Spinnerella, usually so soft, sent a gust of frigid wind through the tent, shocking them all into silence. "We're getting nowhere but angry. Shadow Weaver, we appreciate your…well, no, we don't. Please leave us to discuss this among the Alliance."

“Adora asked me-”

“No,” Adora scowled. “I just didn’t have the energy to stop you from coming in here. Big difference. Get out.”

The sorceress left in a huff, leaving the Princesses to stare after her, and then at one another. Netossa, after a brief and wordless conversation with her wife, sighed heavily. “Adora, I really do see where you’re coming from. But food has to be our first priority. We can’t feed the noncombatants Bot parts, at least not yet.”

Entrapta hummed idly to herself, tapping away at her datapad with new interest. She’d actually come to sit in on the meeting, but had lowered her mask and hunkered down with her notes when the shouting had started. “Note to self: research possibilities of using Horde scrap for foodstuff usage, either preparation or creation…”

“We have enough food for the next three weeks, though,” Adora’s eyes were hard but pleading. “If we don’t send help to Thaymoor soon, we don’t know how much longer there will *be* a Thaymoor.”

Netossa nodded. “I hear you. Let’s run some more simulations, see what each outcome will look like. Mermista?”

She nodded, shifting Frosta, who had fallen asleep entirely, into her vacated bean bag. Without her shoulder, Sea Hawk listed to the side and came to rest against the side of the seat. The two snored on, undisturbed. She crossed over to the map on the wall and sighed. “Let’s get this done. If I’m not asleep by noon I’m going to start biting people.”

Chapter End Notes

> Enjoy! Next chapter is going to be long and up very fast bc I’m tired of posting filler. Drop a comment!

out of the silence that songs come to be

Chapter Summary

> A dance, a new beginning, and the exhale

Chapter Notes

> Last of the last filler ever!! Nothing but actual content here on out until the end

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They liberated Thaymoor in record time, and instead of bringing the refugees in, they assigned sorcerers to the town and relocated some of the more dire refugees- mothers with young children, the ill or disabled, the elderly- to the safety and stability of the town that was all too happy to help the Rebellion.

Many families, though, elected to stay near the Princesses, feeling safer with them than in stone walls, and the Alliance didn't protest. It was nice to have regular people to speak with about things that weren't war, strategy, death, decay, chances of survival…the usual. Which was how Mermista found herself sitting around a bonfire with Bow and Perfuma, chatting about tea parties of all things, while children wove flowers and stars-knew-what-else into their hair, braiding and knotting haphazardly as they went.

"- those little like, you know, they're like tarts but they're small and fluffy-"

"Oh, oh, yes! Like a not-scone with filling-"

"Yes!"

"What in the he-eck are you two even saying?" Mermista was not wonderful at the whole kid-friendly language thing. The children in the encampment had probably learned more swears from her (and Sea Hawk, and Netossa) than they would in a prison. But hey, not her kids.

"The tart things!"

"Yeah that doesn't help- ow, hey, careful kiddo."

"Th'orry," the cervitaur kid behind her chirped, patting her head in a vague *'there there'* motion. "Pretty hair."

"Thanks," she chuckled. "You, too."

Adora joined them then, plopping to the ground and letting herself be swarmed by toddlers and children. "Hey, guys! What's going on over here?"

"Only the finest salon in Etheria!" Bow smiled. The flowers in his hair were garish and orange, entirely uncomplimentary and very cute. "Want in?"

“You know how much I love to be pampered…”

The kids set about messing up Adora’s hair and smearing her nails with berry juices for ‘polish’. She turned to the others as they worked. “Thaymoor gave us a ton of gifts for liberation, and it’s taken us all day to sort them.”

“Ohhh,” Perfuma hummed around a handful of hickory bark, a snack she adored that made Mermista’s stomach churn just looking at it. At least one of them wouldn’t starve. “Anything fun?”

“Uhhh some like, lawn games? The kids will like those. Seasoning, so yay. A couple of instruments-”

“Please, no,” Mermista groaned. “Anything loud?”

“There was an old…geeter? Gutter?” Adora frowned over the word, so many things still alien to her thanks to her Horde rearing. “Whatever. Big thing with strings. And a fiddle. And a lute thingy. No- lyre?”

Mermista exhaled in relief. “Okay, those are fine. He can’t torture me with those.”

“Who-?”

“Mista!” Sea Hawk came bounding out of nowhere, sliding to his knees in an impressive skid that brought him to rest next to her. “Look!”

Mermista gave Adora a look that said ‘this is what I was referring to, how ironic’ and turned to her husband. “What?”

“Thaymoor gave us a fiddle!”

She hummed noncommittally, reaching up to test the braid what's-their-face just put in her hair. It was fairly neat, so she let it be. “Do you even remember how?”

“Remember how-” he scoffed, feigning offense. “I learned how to fiddle before I learned how to count-”

“Explains a lot.”

“On the knees of my grandfather. Of course I remember how.”

“Uh-huuuuuuuh.” She was goading him, quite obviously, into playing something that wouldn’t bruise her eardrums. “Like, screeching and fast-paced shanties. Not, like, real fiddling.”

He scowled. “You’re not as subtle as you think, my Queen.”

She refused to blush at that in front of their friends, who had been watching the conversation with no small amount of interest.

“Allow me to show you that fast does not have to mean bawdy, or loud, or talentless.”

She winked. “Promises, promises.”

Sea Hawk opened the case he’d brought with him, settling against the log next to her a bit away.

She pushed fondness, amusement, and affection along their bond, and met his eyes when he looked up at her to make sure he knew she was teasing. A pulse of warmth and happiness came back to her. He knew.

They turned back to their tea-party chatter, filling Adora in on the outlandish foods, weird etiquette, and just how much fun it was despite the bizarre nature of it, while Sea Hawk set about tuning the old fiddle. Bow watched with some interest, and Mermista remembered that he said his dads had put him in music lessons as a kid.

Quite suddenly, and with no preamble other than the discordant whine of the tuning fiddle, a bracing, sizzling hum of music shot through the night air. Heads whipped around, searching for the source and landing on Sea Hawk, who had the fiddle tucked under his chin, bow held just so in his fingers. His feet tapped a steady and quick four count, and then he began to play. It was a playful, tricky song, running up and down stairs of notes jack-rabbit fast. It shifted from swimming low notes to skybird high peels of laughter-like runs. It wasn't long before the entire camp had come out of their tents to find the source of-

" *Music* ," a sorcerer murmured in wonder, before whooping laughter and turning to grab her partner. They began an impromptu slapdash reel of complex footwork, and just like that, the camp was scrambling to act, life being forcibly breathed back into the rebels.

Tables and crates were cleared away to make a dance floor, and the other instruments were fetched from the pile of gifts- another fiddle, a banjo, a large canvas drum that Perfuma grabbed immediately. She grinned wildly at Mermista and wheeled it over to a low crate where she could perch with the drum between her knees.

Bow grabbed the lyre, and an older woman snatched up the banjo. A young child hesitantly picked up the other fiddle, but his form was perfect as he moved beside Sea Hawk, who had risen to stand without missing one fingering. At the pirate's nod, the boy began to play an undercurrent to the song, a low harmony that made Sea Hawk's melody soar.

On the next downswing, Perfuma bopped her head with purpose, and jumped in. The result was a foot-stomping reel with a beat that was irresistible to the refugees.

Mermista shook her hair out, dislodging the flowers and sticks and messy braids with ease, standing to find someone to dance with-

“Hey,” she called to Adora, who was standing frozen amid the sudden action like a deer in headlights. “Wanna dance?”

“M-me?” Etheria’s mighty champion stuttered. “Oh I- I don’t know-”

“C’mon, it’s easy.” Mermista held a hand out, and slowly Adora took it. Mermista brought her to stand beside her, and showed her the basic four-step tavern dance Sea Hawk had shown her before he brought her to Sea Worthy for the first time. “Out step, cross, kick, in step. See?”

“Oh, hey…” Adora copied the movements stiffly until she was weaving fairly fluidly. “Okay, yeah! I got it!”

“Yeah, just like that!” Mermista smiled. “Now, try bending your knees for a little bounce in the middle- yeah! Awesome, dude!”

Adora’s smile was a sight for sore eyes. It had been months since any of them had seen it. “Let’s do this!”

Mermista showed her how to link elbows and turn and spin, and then they were off. Others around them had been watching, and soon the whole camp was tavern-dancing with an energy Mermista had never felt. They were all aching for joy, and laughter, that they seized this moment with almost hysterical fervor.

Even she couldn’t keep a smile off her face, or stop the laughter that built up every time Adora whooped as she spun. It soon became a king’s dance, and they were spinning from partner to partner as the songs shifted from one to the next with seamless interludes.

Spinnerella was easily her most adept partner, and the two of them cut an impressive rug, drawing eyes and shouts and whistles as they dipped and spun and even flipped. She was going to be paying dearly for it tomorrow, she knew, but right now the adrenaline was working its magic.

She ended up in King Micah’s arms, and he spun her out with a laugh. “Fancy meeting you here!”

“Gods, you’re nothing but dad jokes, huh?” She laughed and rolled her eyes.

“Gotta make up for lost time!” He smiled without the sadness that had been lingering around him lately, and Mermista smiled back. As they danced, his smile grew softer but no less genuine. “How old are you now?”

“Twenty four now, Your Majesty.”

“Please, Mermista, call me Micah!” The man smiled, and it was one of the warmest smiles she had ever seen. “I hope you don’t mind my saying, but you look just like Nerida. We met when she was about your age, you know.”

“Really?” Mermista’s eyes were wide. “How?”

Micah spoke with surprising breath control, even as they danced on. “I was studying abroad in Salineas, working on transmogrifying magicks, shapeshifting and the like. I stumbled into the town square one day, and through circumstances that were *in no way* my fault, found myself engaged in some sort of tavern brawl. They must have spilled out onto the street and caught me up. I was a sorcerer, not any sort of brawler, so I was really having it handed to me when it all just…stopped.” He spun her out and they leapt a few more steps of the jig. “Turns out, Nerida had been headed to the docks to meet a friend, saw the visiting sorcerer from Mystacor having his ass handed to him, and stepped in to finish the fight herself.”

Mermista laughed brightly. “Yeah, that sounds like Mom.”

“Oh, absolutely,” Micah laughed back. “She picked me up, dusted me off, and brought me along with her to the docks. We talked the entire time, about what I can’t recall now, but I remember she was whip-smart, with the sharpest tongue I’d ever met in royalty.

We became very dear friends.” The look in his eyes grew far away. “She introduced me to Angella, and I introduced her to Mercia. One of us got the far better end of that deal…”

She patted his hand as they slowed their steps, the interlude letting them know the song would be changing. “For all his many, many faults as a father, and a King, my Ama loved my dad. And I think he loved her, too.”

“When I heard what he’d done, Mermista…” Micah shut his eyes. “When this war is over, I intend to have words with Mercia.”

“Let me know where you find him.” She shrugged, affecting disinterest. “I have quite a bit I’d like to say as well.”

Micah didn’t hesitate to wrap her in a bear hug, one she slowly, but very surely, returned. “She would be so proud of you, Mermista. I’m sure she’s got an eye on you, even now.” He pulled back, giving her a fatherly smile. “Twenty four…I still remember the first day they brought you to our court. You were the first baby I had ever really met, you know. Perfuma was a toddler when her parents joined the Alliance. I pestered Angie incessantly after you left.” He chuckled to himself. “Clearly, we reached an agreement.”

The smile in his eyes faded at the thought of his lost daughter, and Mermista reached up to clasp his shoulder. “Micah…I know Glimmer. Very well, actually. She’s one of the strongest people I know, and an incredible queen. Wherever she is, she’s giving them hell, I promise. And when we bring her home, you’ll get to see for yourself the amazing person your daughter has grown up to be."

"For someone who allegedly hates speaking, you're very good at it," the King chuckled, and patted her shoulders as the strings began anew, sounding…shakier? "Now, I think we ought to switch off. There's a strapping young man who's just dying to dance with you."

Ugh, creep. "Well, I guess one dance never hurt anyone."

Micah winked at her, and spun her out, into the arms of-

"Sebastian?" Mermista grinned, despite herself. "What about-"

Sea Hawk leaned in to kiss her, sweaty and smiling and thrumming with passionate life. "My fingers are ready to bleed, so I begged off the next round. Bow's taking over, all for the best really, he's quite shit at the lyre."

She laughed, and thought *fuck it* , and leaned in to kiss him deeply, twining fingers in sweaty hair and running her tongue along his mouth. He had barely a second to reciprocate before the music was swelling again, and they pulled apart to dance. Of all her dance partners, the skilled and unskilled and everyone in between, Sea Hawk would always be her favorite.

He didn’t have the innate fluidity Spinnerella did, or the same level of sheer and boundless enthusiasm as Adora, but he did have a natural rhythm that matched her own, and quite a lot of skill. The first time they met, they’d danced all night and if she were being sappy, which she totally wasn’t, she’d known he was different right then, that very first night.

Being a sailor, Sea Hawk knew far more complicated footwork than the little she’d taught Adora, dances they’d been doing for years now and it was with ease and excitement that they fell into their favorite. Bow had picked a good piece too, fast with a heavy beat. The dance area they’d cleared was a bit more open now, many people taking a breather or heading to bed, so they had plenty of room.

Sea Hawk tugged her close with a hand at her waist, grabbing her right with his left and lifting it.

She placed her hand on his shoulder, and together they counted off four beats before beginning.

They spun in a wide circle, rapid footwork carrying them to the rhythm. Sea Hawk took lead, stepping and bouncing to the jig in a way that forced her to keep up just as enthusiastically. Her reputation was going to be absolutely *shot* by the end of the night, between her broad grin and her clear knowledge of tavern dancing that left very little room for imagining just where she learned it.

And, of course, the fact that no matter how she tried, she couldn’t look away from Sebastian’s eyes. She knew it was all over her face, her happiness and love for him, but that was…fine.

Actually, totally fine.

He rocked her to and fro, leading her in wide and spinning swaths of complex footwork. A few others had joined in with the same dance, but most of the rest were keeping up with the simpler steps, Adora and her new partner, Frosta, included. Someone near the band whistled, and Mermista laughed when she saw Perfuma lower her fingers from her mouth. She jokingly flipped her off, and the other Princess blew her a kiss. She was being spun away again before she could do more than roll her eyes.

Her hand slid from Sea Hawk’s shoulder to clutch his shoulder blade through his thin white shirt. He’d lost his jacket when he was fiddling, and without it, he looked more like a pirate than a sea captain, let alone royalty.

He grinned at her, a live-wire smile that set her nerves on fire, and whooped as he spun her even faster.

She laughed, helpless and happy and for once, just letting herself enjoy this.

“Wanna show them how it's done in Sea Worthy?” He had to speak against her ear to be heard over the music. She considered his words; they were loose and non-leading, truly letting her choose.

“Let’s do it.”

Sea Hawk grinned broadly and dragged her to the center of the dance area where wooden crate lids had been laid down into a makeshift floor. People were step dancing there, the clatter of shoes and hooves, the thumping of bare or sock feet, were a heartbeat to the rhythm of the night.

Sea Hawk swung her so they were face to face, letting go to stuff his hands in his trouser pockets, affecting a casual air. He grinned at her, and after a few hops, his feet found the familiar steps of the jig. The gold toes of his boots clacked pleasantly against the wood as he stepped from heel to toe, crossing his feet over one another, behind either leg. With a kick, a heel-toe shift, and a flourishing stamp, he came to a rest, tossing his head at her to say *‘your move, Princess’.*

She’d discarded her shoes a while ago, so instead of clicks and clacks, her feet thumped against the wood as bass notes, booming and steady. She copied his footwork step for step, not missing one tap or heel or crossover.

Sea Hawk watched her as she added spins and her own flair to the rhythms, something like awe in his eyes, even after all their many dances together.

A gust of wind drew her attention, and she turned to see Spinnerella and Netossa weaving around one another in their own dance, their magic dancing along with them in ribbons of glittering purple air and thin glowing tendrils. As they wove in and out of one another, so did their elements. It gave Mermista an idea.

When Sea Hawk drew close again, and they took up the second part of the jig together, she reached out for the river a mile away, pulling some water out and calling it to her. Sea Hawk caught her eye, playful and teasing, and stepped apart to launch into a complex set of footwork that lasted only a few beats before stopping, and nodding at her. A challenge to copy him.

She did, spinning just as he did, stamping each step and then nodding back.

They went back and forth like this, trading footwork back and forth until Mermista felt her water race into the camp, streaming through the air and splitting into dazzling currents that drew gasps and cries of delight as they reached her at last. She spun into them, letting the water whirl and arc around her as she hit her next steps, fingers twitching and fluttering. Cheers rose up, and Mermista closed her eyes as she danced, focusing on the feel of her magic as it coursed through her and the water, binding them. A warm hum thrummed through her body, and she cracked an eye to see Sea Hawk stepping back up to her. She held out her arm, and they linked elbows to spin round and round through the last steps of the dance.

Their friends whirled by, all laughing and smiling and looking more alive than any of them have been in months.

The music was reaching a fever pitch, fervor and speed taking the crowd’s adrenaline to a new high. The music rambled to a rolling, humming stop, and Sea Hawk tripped on the last step. Before he could eat shit, she grabbed him around the waist and swung him into a low dip just as the final note sang out of Bow’s fiddle.

Chests heaving, eyes locked, the rest of the camp faded away and it was only the two of them on the entire planet. Sea Hawk’s eyes flicked down to her lips, and she was on the edge of giving in, giving up and just kissing him for all to see if they hadn’t already, but at the last second she paused, and pulled him back onto his feet instead.

He recovered well, bowing deeply to her like he would have before they married, and pressed a chaste kiss to her knuckles. “Thank you for the dance, Princess.”

“The pleasure was entirely mine, Captain.” She smirked.

His eyes widened ever so slightly, and she chuckled low.

Stepping up to murmur in his ear, she felt a shiver run through his body. “Where are you staying tonight, sailor?”

He played along with her little game, and tugged her close by the waist to whisper in her ear. “Wherever my lady wife will permit me.”

Hmmm, that had such a pleasant ring to it. Sea Hawk’s bizarre, arcane way of speaking was plain odd ninety-nine percent of the time, but that one percent where it worked, *worked* . She turned her lips to his own ear, ghosting over the soft shell. “I can’t imagine she’ll turn you away after a display like that.”

He smiled against her hair. “Well, that is good news.”

Frosta came barrelling into them then, breaking the hazy spell they’d fallen under, and the slowly building heat between their bodies and along the bond. “That was so fun!”

Adora caught up to them, out of breath but smiling, really smiling, for the first time in months. “That was amazing! Sea Hawk, I didn’t know you could play, you were great!”

“Thank you, Adora!” He smiled, and it was only slightly egocentric. “When one is as great a sailor as I-”

“Don’t ruin it,” Mermista scowled, before something slammed into her back and knocked most of the air from her lungs.

“Mista!” Perfuma, of course. “You danced beautifully! You all did, that was so wonderful to watch! I’m sorry I didn’t join in, I was communing with the drum.”

“Is that what you call it?” Netossa wandered into the circle, slapping hands and shoulders. “Because I would have called it ‘beating the ever living shit out of’ the drum.”

“We all express emotions in unique, equally valid ways,” Perfuma demurred.

“Spinn, you were incredible.” Mermista held her hand out for a fist bump. “Where’d you learn to dance like that?”

“My sisters were all dancers, back in the day!” The older Princess smiled. “They taught me everything I know. And you?” She smirked at Mermista. “Those were definitely not proper Salinean moves, young lady. Where’d you learn to tavern dance?”

The Princesses all ooh’d and jostled her (and Sea Hawk) even as she tried to shrug it off. “Oh, y’know, here, there, wherever.”

“Uh-huh.” Netossa smirked, then turned to the rest. “Y’all, once we help Mermista rebuild her kingdom, she’s throwing us a real, true-blue Salinean rager. The drinks, the dances, the outfits- except you Frosta.”

“Hey!”

“Don’t worry kid.” Mermista ruffled her hair. “By the time we get Salineas party-ready again, you’ll be plenty old enough.”

Frosta groaned, but leaned against her side. Scorpia finally joined them again, out of breath and flushed. “What are we talking about?”

“Parties!”

“Ah!” Scorpia nodded, despite looking a bit lost. “And?”

Spinnerella chuckled. “‘Tossa and I have been to all the kingdom’s parties, the highest balls and the more relaxed feasts. Elberon has the market cornered on parties, hands down, sorry y’all.”

“No way!” Netossa tossed her hair. “Salineas has belly dancing, and Bright Moon ball gowns? Puh-lease. No contest.”

“Yes, but those are balls, darling.” Spinnerella smiled at her wife, like she’d already won. “Parties are different.”

“Not to brag, but Snows has a Yule Hunt, and nothing compares to the twelve nights of feasting, partying, and gift giving we have.” Frosta sniffed.

Adora’s eyes were wide. “Hunt? Like…animals?”

“Duh? After all this, if Snows stays as untouched as it has been, gods willing, you’re all invited to Yule. Whole twelve days, Princess’ orders.”

“I won’t say no to a twelve day vacation after all this.” Bow finally joined them, handing Sea Hawk back the fiddle. “But did I hear belly-dancing?”

“Yeah, it’s right up your alley, Shirtless.” Mermista smirked. “You’re all invited to the next big Salinean ball, whenever that happens, but you’re gonna need some serious lessons first.”

“I can dance!” Adora pouted, and then pouted harder when everyone, even Scorpia, burst out laughing.

“Loooots of lessons.”

They talked the rest of the night away, lounging around a massive campfire with some of the other refugees. Frosta passed out a little after midnight, splayed across Scorpia’s lap with her booted feet on Sea Hawk’s lap.

Mermista kept a watchful eye on Scorpia, seeing as she had their youngest and Mermista’s best friend snuggled up to her; she was definitely going to corner Perfuma tomorrow to talk about her little crush some more, if only to see her blush. Sea Hawk tipped over at some point as well while she was laughing over something with Bow, and she tangled her fingers in his hair as he laid with his head in her lap.

“You have a huge head, dude.” She flicked his ear, and he whined.

“Go bully someone else, woman,” he mumbled, snuggling in deeper. “I’m tired.”

“Oh, okay, I guess you’re just here now, huh?”

Bow was making the most ridiculous face over them, but she was letting it slide.

Sea Hawk just smiled and hummed, and in the next second, he was asleep.

“So *cute* !” Bow whispered, and she flipped him off half-heartedly.

At some point in the evening (morning?) she realized they were technically one short. Casually, she leaned back and glanced around the camp until she found her quarry.

Entrapta was seated on top of one of the sturdier tents, supported by her hair. Her mask was down and she was tapping away at her datapad.

In that moment, despite…everything she had done to them, cost them, Mermista’s heart clenched a bit. She nudged Bow with her foot and gestured with her head.

“Why?”

Bow shrugged sadly. “She’s not as unaware as she seems. Well, most of the time. I think she’s scared to join us, scared of the rejection.”

“Well, that’s a bit fucking redundant,” Mermista muttered. At Bow’s look, she sighed. “Isn’t her whole bone to pick with us that we made her feel excluded? That she never fit in with us or whatever? Well, not for nothing, but it's not like she really tried, then or now. If she’s that aware, then surely she understands that to progress forward, she’s gotta like, try, right? And, hey, an apology wouldn’t suck, but baby steps,” she huffed. “Rejection is scary, but if you don’t try, you can’t complain about exclusion. Y’know?”

Bow studied her, then nodded at length. “That…makes sense. Should I…?”

And then Mermista realized something else; that Bow would have invited her over here earlier if Mermista hadn't been here. And that was also a pretty crummy feeling, no matter how justified (which she was, like, extremely). She nodded. "Yeah. But she's gotta keep it down a bit for Frosta and Sea Hawk."

"She'll understand." Bow stood, and Mermista watched as he crossed over to Entrapta, talking with his hands and pointing over. He nodded emphatically, and Entrapta clambered down from the tent and followed him over to the campfire. Adora, Perfuma, and Scorpia's conversation lapsed as she sat down with them all, and waved jerkily.

"Uh…hi?"

Scorpia beamed at her. "Hey buddy! Welcome to the party."

"This is soooo not a party," Mermista snorted, but nodded at Entrapta in what she hoped was a non-threatening way. "Hey, Geek Princess."

Entrapta's eyes shone, and for a second she worried that she'd just offended the older woman, but then she smiled, and Mermista realized it was the first time she'd acknowledged her (still legal, somehow) status since she'd come to the camp. Bow swept in gracefully. "We were just remembering Princess Prom, and how much fun it was before Adora went apeshit!"

“I did not-!”

“Totally did.”

“Your vibes were extremely hostile.”

“I detected increased adrenaline levels that would indeed correlate with the state of mind that is ‘apeshit’.”

There was a pause, and Entrapta suddenly looked apprehensive again, but then Bow snorted, and Mermista cracked a smile, and they were all laughing at Adora’s dejected face.

“I can’t dance, I go apeshit, I eat like, and I quote, a starving octopus-”

“And we love you for it.” Perfuma smiled, and everyone ‘awww’d’ at Adora’s soft face.

By the time they dragged themselves to bed (literally, she’d had to carry Sea Hawk) it was almost dawn.

Entrapta had cracked two more jokes, and had retreated behind her mask several times, but they’d passed the night with no injuries, physical or otherwise, so that was a win.

Scorpia, who seemed to never be tired, agreed to take first shift with Frosta, who had woken up raring to go, so Mermista felt perfectly fine to tumble into bed with her husband and wake up in time for dinner.

It almost felt just like the lazy summer days from Before, and the thought comforted her as she dozed off with her head on Sea Hawk’s chest.

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It was a month later, in the lazy breeze of a late autumn night, that Perfuma exploded into Mermista and Sea Hawk’s tent, scaring her violently out of a deep sleep. “Mermista!”

“ *Fuck!* ” She jolted, pushing herself upright with gasp and nailing Sea Hawk in the ribs as she did. He wheezed, startling awake as well. “Perfuma- what- ?”

“The pregnant woman from Bright Moon is in labor!” Perfuma was next to her now, tugging her out of bed, while Mermista’s brain struggled to boot up and process anything she was saying. “I need your help.”

“You- what- labor?” Mermista pulled her arm free and scrubbed at her eyes. “What are you talking about? What time is it?”

“Mermista!” Perfuma grabbed her by the shoulders, and the raw apprehension there was like a bucket of cold water. “We have a woman in labor, in a refugee camp, and limited magical medical resources available. She’s three weeks early. I need you to get up, get dressed, and *help me* .”

Mermista shook herself out of it and vaulted out of bed. The only people there were Perfuma and Sea Hawk, so she didn’t think twice about stripping out of her pajamas to toss on her armor. In her head, she was racing through everything she had learned from her mother and the palace healers; every woman in Salineas had helped deliver a baby at some point, practically.

Her kingdom shared the opinion that it took a village to birth and raise a baby, and labor was a community assisted, and celebrated, event. Even among noble women, who typically turned their noses up at such open displays of emotion, it was a unifying moment in one’s life, and Mermista had helped the palace healers on more than one occasion. Her abilities were a unique asset, especially in a kingdom that preferred water births. Perfuma, however, was a regular doula and midwife for her people, so to see her shaken left Mermista reeling.

Sea Hawk was sitting up now, too, yanking on pants and a loose cotton shirt. “She’s having a baby? Now?”

“How dilated?” Mermista grabbed for her trident, then reconsidered.

“She’s at about six centimeters, but the contractions are coming fast and strong!” Perfuma wrung her hands as she paced. “She’s early, too early, and for a first baby-”

“Relax, ‘Fuma.” Mermista yanked on her shoes. “Three weeks isn’t premature, technically. It’s not ideal but she’ll be okay. You’ve delivered babies way earlier than that.”

“You’re right, I know, I just…”

“Yeah. Middle of a war camp isn’t ideal. Do we have any sorcerers available?”

“Just Micah. The rest are working on the hole in the shield.”

“Okay.” Mermista turned to Sea Hawk, who was openly trying not to let their panic affect him. “Sebastian, listen to me. I need you to take one of the basins, and Bow or Adora, and bring back as much freshwater as you can. When you get back, have Frosta freeze half of it, and chip it up.”

“Yes, okay, on it.”

They all pushed out of the tent into the night air- morning air? Sea Hawk grabbed Adora, who was also looking suitably freaked out, and the two of them took off toward the river. Mermista followed Perfuma toward a tent where Micah and Bow were lingering outside.

“Perfuma.” Micah grabbed their attention. “The mother won’t allow any men into the tent, so I can’t help you here.”

Perfuma just nodded. “That’s fine. If there’s an emergency, I’ll ask her to reconsider, but I think we’ll be okay.”

Mermista was impressed at how quickly Perfuma had reined in her panic. And then she was distracted by the other Princesses, and Shadow Weaver, coming over. The sorceress addressed them first. “I presume you have this under control?”

“Not even acknowledging you,” Mermista muttered, turning to Spinerella and Netossa. The taller woman had a bundle of sheets and towels, while Netossa carried a large box. “Herbs?”

“All the best stuff we could find. Does she want pain killers?”

“Let’s go find out.”

Perfuma led them in, and was followed by a massive orb of light that floated to the ceiling and stuck there, illuminating the tent perfectly. The mother was on a low cot, propped up by pillows and covered in a loose sheet. A sheen of sweat covered her brow, and her wife mopped at her forehead gently with the edge of a blanket.

She turned to them as they spread out in the limited space, setting up what they needed. "Thank the stars. Emmi, see, the Princesses are here, you'll both be fine-"

She was cut off by her wife's groan as another contraction hit. Perfuma knelt by Emmi's head. "Hey, Emmi, my name is Perfuma. I've delivered more babies than I can even count, so I promise you're in good hands. Now, did you want painkilling herbs?"

"No, thank you," Emmi grunted. "I want to do this as naturally as I possibly can, as long as I'm safe."

"Then that's what we'll do. Mermista, check her dilation?"

Mermista knelt down between the woman's legs, keeping her voice and face soft and open. "Hey, Emmi. I'm Mermista. Pardon my reach real quick." She knew that most women, despite the circumstances, weren't fans of random people, Princess or not, feeling up their most intimate areas, so she tried to walk the line of friendly and professional. "Alright, you're at seven centimeters."

Netossa and Spinerella finished setting up the herbs and towels, and Netossa bowed out of the tent to give them space. Perfuma nodded at the wind Princess. “I think Emmi might appreciate a cool breeze along her neck, Spinnerella.”

“Oh, could you?” Emmi panted. “I’m sweating my ass off.”

Mermista chuckled. She liked this woman. “Emmi, I’m bringing some fresh water here from the river. That will give you ice to chew on, and I can help alleviate some of the pressure on your body. It’ll also help your circulation, and contractions. Is that alright?”

“Sounds perfect from where I’m standing- laying, I guess.”

Mermista nodded, and patted Perfuma on the shoulder. “I’m going to go wait for the water.”

She pushed out of the tent, sighing in relief at the cold air. She was already sweating, and she hadn’t even used her hydrokinesis yet.

Micah and Entrapta came over as she was yanking her hair out of its sleep-messy braid to pile it up in a bun, off her neck. “How is she?”

“Honestly, she’s in great spirits. You’d never know it’s her first kid.”

“Does that have an impact on the birthing experience?” Entrapta’s mask was up, but she looked utterly out of her depth, which was an odd look on Geek Princess.

“Typically, yeah. First time mothers are almost always more nervous, because, y’know, new experience.”

“Oh, just the emotional side.”

Her tone rankled Mermista a bit. “Yeah, well, when it comes to, you know, pushing a whole entire new human out of your vagina, the emotional aspect of labor has a major impact on the physical.”

“Really?” Entrapta raised herself up on her hair. “How so?”

Micah took over diplomatically. “Well, you know how panic and anxiety begin in the mind, but can have physical manifestations? It’s exactly like that, but the circumstances are even more dire. If the mother is panicking, it can be harder to communicate with her, which could put the baby at risk. In some births, even a second can make a difference.”

Entrapta nodded thoughtfully. “I’d love to take some notes-”

“Absolutely not.” Mermista stepped in front of her. “This is a really personal, private experience, Entrapta. Not to mention physically draining. We need her focused entirely on her own wellbeing right now.”

Entrapta deflated, but only slightly. “Well, alright. That makes sense. Can I assist in any way?”

Mermista blinked in surprise. “Uhhh, I’m not sure. If anything comes up, I will let you know.”

“Excellent.” Geek Princess returned to her data pad and recording device, moving away to speak into them.

Micah sighed. “Her heart’s in the right place, she just…”

“Yeah, I know. I’m working on not being such a…well, me.”

Adora and Sea Hawk chose that moment to come tearing back into camp, the lidded container of fresh water between them. They dropped it at her feet without spilling, leaning over to catch their breaths.

“Is she…okay? Does she…need…She-Ra?” Adora panted.

“No, right now everything is fine.”

Adora nodded, and walked off a bit toward Bow, Micah in tow.

Mermista patted Sea Hawk gently on the shoulder. “Thanks, Hawk.”

“Wait.” He righted himself. “Do you need anything else? Does she? Are you okay?”

“Relax,” she chuckled, lifting the basin by the water within. “So far, it’s totally routine-”

She was cut off by a scream, and Perfuma’s shout. “Mermista! We need you and the water, *now* !”

“Yep!” She turned back to Sea Hawk. “Go find Frosta and send her in. Hurry.”

He tore off as she moved back inside the tent, bringing the water with her.

Perfuma was helping the woman out of her soaked nightshirt and into a loose, open kimono-esque shift. “Start alleviating some of that pressure on her uterus. These contractions aren’t as productive as I’d like them to be.”

“On it.” Mermista had Emmi’s wife move the blanket off her legs and stomach, and bent the water around her pelvic region and lower abdomen. Gently she encased the stomach in water, letting its natural buoyancy handle the rest.

Emmi sighed, even as another contraction hit; Mermista felt its ripple through the water, and was briefly awed. Frosta popped her head in a few moments later.

“Hey, Sea Hawk said you needed me?”

“Can you freeze and chip up some of this water?” Perfuma motioned to the basin. “I don’t want Emmi getting dehydrated.”

Frosta did so, while steadfastly averting her eyes from the bed. Mermista smothered a chuckle. The ice Princess’ general distaste for all things baby-related was arguably hilarious to her. Whether or not she grew out of it was her personal hill to climb, but for now, Mermista thought it was kind of cute. She nodded and bowed once she finished, beating a hasty retreat.

“I always forget how little she is.” Spinnerella chuckled.

“She’s nearly fourteen now, can you believe it?”

“God, that makes me feel old,” Mermista groaned. “She was eleven when we met.”

“Actually, she was eleven and three-quarters,” Spinerella quipped, sending the tent into a fit of giggles.

Emmi’s broke off with a groan as another contraction hit.

“They’re getting closer.” Perfuma moved down to check her dilation again. “Alright, you’re nearly at nine centimeters. Not long now.”

It took another hour and a half of cool breezes, mini water baths, and soothing encouragement, but soon Emmi was wailing through clenched teeth against the pain of her contractions.

Perfuma ducked to check her. “We’re just about ready. Mermista, does Sea Hawk have any strips or bits of leather on him? I don’t want Emmi cracking her teeth.”

She replaced the water in the basin and sprinted out to check. Sea Hawk patted down his pockets and belt pouches until he decided to just cut some of the extra leather off his belt. “Is she…?”

“Yeah, it’s time.”

The assembled Alliance outside lit up with excitement, turning to one another. She ducked back inside with a wave, and handed off the leather to Perfuma, who gave it to Emmi’s wife.

Perfuma was kneeling at the end of the bed, checking one last time.

“Alright, Emmi, when you feel the next contraction hit its peak, I want you to start pushing as hard as you can. Lui, get that leather between her teeth.” She looked at Mermista next. “Do you have sterile water?”

“Yep, saved just for this.”

“Okay, when the baby is out, I’m handing them over to you for cleaning. You’ve done this before right?”

“Yes, don’t worry. I’ve got this.” Mermista kept the apprehension racing through her out of her voice. She had done it before, but it was a while ago, and every time was a new dose of anxiety. New babies were slippery.

That thought was pushed from her head, though, when Emmi screamed through the leather in her teeth, pushing hard. Her wife, Lui, was holding her hand, but also staring down at her body with raw wonder.

Perfuma looked up.

“They’re crowning!” Emmi pushed again not a minute later, sobbing and screaming, and Perfuma grinned. “Head and shoulders are free, one more push Emmi, that’s it!”

She pushed again, screaming for all she was worth, and a second later a new, fragile sound filled the tent. Perfuma cheered as she scooped something up from between her legs- oh. It was the baby, squalling and waving its tiny limbs in the cool night air.

Mermista moved closer, and Perfuma placed the newborn carefully in her arms before bringing Lui down to cut the cord. She knew this part. She moved up Emmi’s body, checking briefly before telling her. “It’s a boy, Emmi.”

Gently, she placed the baby on his mother’s bare chest, and his cries quieted down a bit at the comforting feeling of her skin against his. Perfuma finished her assessment, and gave the new family a minute.

Spinnerella smiled at them both and quietly left, and Mermista moved to leave as well, but Perfuma grabbed her.

“She has some tearing I need to handle, and the afterbirth, so I need you to take the baby and clean him up, and then give us a minute. I think Lui is going to want to stay. Can you send Netossa and Adora in? I’ll need some help with the sutures, and magical healing never hurt anyone.”

Mermista grabbed one of the fresh towels, and gently but bracingly cleaned off the baby where he lay on his mother’s chest. At her reluctant nod, she carefully picked up him, and brought him over to the basin. Using her hydrokinesis, she moved the water over him quickly, washing away any remaining residue or blood, and cleaning his airway a bit better.

He grunted and wailed, eyes still shut, and Mermista shushed him softly, rocking lightly on the balls of her feet like her mother had taught her. That done, she swaddled him tightly, and let the parents know she’d be just outside with the baby.

“Does he have a name?”

“Theo.” Emmi smiled, though exhaustion was taking over. Lui held her wife close, pressing tearful kisses to her hair.

Mermista smiled. “I’ll be right out here with Theo.”

She was accosted the second she pushed the tent open, Bow and Frosta and Entrapta all straining to see. “Is that the baby? Can we see?”

Mermista held the infant tighter to her chest, suddenly protective. “Whoa, okay, back it up. He’s, like, barely five minutes old.” She looked around for Sea Hawk, and found him staring back at her from a few feet away with an indecipherable expression on his face. “Netossa and Adora, Perfuma needs your help in the tent.”

The two nodded, pausing to coo over the baby (Netossa) or stare at it like an alien (Adora) as they passed her. Micah came up to her, passing a broad hand over the little one’s head. The size difference was humbling, and comical. “Hello, little guy. What’s your name?”

“Theo.”

“Hello, Theo. It’s nice to meet you.” He smiled, and it was sad and blissful all at once. “I’m King Micah, and even though it’s a little odd-looking right now, I’m so happy to welcome you to the Kingdom of Bright Moon.”

Mermista swallowed the lump in throat. “Do you want to hold him?”

“Maybe later.” Micah smiled, and she understood.

She knelt down so Frosta could see him, and the younger girl tilted her head in confusion.

“So that’s a baby?”

“Yep.” Mermista smirked. “They’re just little people.”

“Kind of boring.”

“A bit, yeah.” She nodded. “Satisfied?”

“Yeah. I’m gonna go back to bed.”

Entrapta was hovering a few feet away, and the two women approached each other cautiously. This was a strange no-man’s land of emotion for both of them. The tech Princess raised her mask carefully, clicking on her recorder and whispering into it. “The baby is a male humanoid, of Bright Moon heritage; wide eyes, pale skin, ten fingers and toes. His eyes are shut, color unknown. His hair is a deep navy, straight in texture. He is…cute.”

Mermista looked up at the hovering Princess in shock, and saw her eyes glowing. “Would you…like to hold him?”

Entrapta glanced up at her, and nodded, quickly discarding her gloves and rolling up her oil stained sleeves as she lowered herself back to her feet. “How should I…”

“Copy my arms?” Mermista placed the bundle of blanket and baby in her arms, shifting until the head was supported and hesitantly lifted her arms away. “There you go.”

“He feels fragile,” Entrapta blinked in wonder. “And…heavy. Even though he looks to be about six pounds.”

“That’s a baby for you.” Mermista smiled. Theo chose that moment to start wiggling and squeaking, and Entrapta gingerly handed him back.

“Thank you for the opportunity to meet a tiny new person,” she smiled at the baby again, patting him with a tendril of hair. “I just adore tiny things.”

Entrapta wandered off again, murmuring into her recording device and tapping away. Mermista turned, and came face to face with her husband. “Hey, you.”

Sea Hawk, thought, only had eyes for the baby. He looked completely bewildered by such a tiny person. “Hello, dearest. Theo, right?”

“Mhm.”

“Hey, buddy.” He lowered his voice to a cooing whisper, reaching out to stroke a gentle finger from the bridge to the tip of the baby’s nose. “Welcome to Etheria.”

His smile was infectious, and the wonder in his eyes shot straight to her heart.

He looked up at her. “You look beautiful with a baby in your arms.”

Mermista blushed, and denied to herself that she was melting inside. “Yeah, well. I always look beautiful. Do you want to hold him?”

“What? Me?” Sea Hawk stepped back like she’d offered a hot iron poker. “I’ve never held a baby outside of a combat situation before.”

“It’s easy. Come here.”

He did so, warily.

“Hold your arms like- yeah, exactly. Now, support his neck, he can’t do that yet. And then put that- there. See?”

Sea Hawk stared open mouthed at her, then the baby, then her again. “It’s…he’s *so small* .”

“Yeah, dude, he’s like, ten minutes old- are you crying?”

“No-o?” He sniffled.

“Don’t cry on the baby.”

“I can’t help it.” Mermista just chuckled.

Sea Hawk swayed gently, clearly enamored with the baby. A teeny hand had slipped free of the swaddle, and he moved to tuck it back in. As he did, Theo grabbed his fingers, squeezing it as tight as a newborn could, his hand completely dwarfed by Sea Hawk’s calloused finger. The pirate’s mouth had fallen open softly, frozen by the moment of connection.

Mermista swallowed the emotions clogging her throat at the sight, emotions she really didn’t have the time or capacity to deal with.

Her husband turned to her with pleading eyes. “I want one.”

She flushed, looking around quickly. “Sebastian-!”

“What?” He pouted. “He’s so small! And cute! Please, Mista?”

“Yeah, I don’t think getting me pregnant in the middle of a war would really count as helping the Alliance.”

Sea Hawk frowned. “After?”

Mermista just leaned against him, and he carefully extracted his finger from the baby’s grip to wrap an arm around her, making sure Theo was supported. “Yes. We can discuss it after”

“Liiiiikeeee,” he hummed. “Right after?”

She snorted, pecking his stubbly jaw. “Yeah, sure. You can knock me up the second the war ends. That will make rebuilding so easy.”

“I’m sensing some sarcasm.”

“Smarty pants.” Mermista took Theo back, definitely not because she liked how he felt in her arms, and he immediately began rooting against her chest. "Oh, uh, bad news little guy- no-"

Sea Hawk started chuckling, hiding it behind his hand, and she shot him a glare.

Luckily, Perfuma popped her head out of the tent right then. "Mermista? They're all good, ready for him."

She only slightly reluctantly passed Theo back over, ignoring the baby-fevered thoughts now racing through her mind. She'd known she wanted kids for a while, ever since the Portal, really, and knew that she just couldn't have what she wanted right now. And then Salineas had fallen, and the vague timeline she'd had in her head of her future went right out the door. For a while, she wondered if she'd live long enough to have kids. In fact, she still wondered sometimes if Salineas' royal line would end with her; the ultimate failure, lurking in the back of her head.

Sea Hawk wrapped his arms around her waist. "Back to bed?"

Mermista nodded, thoughts racing, and let herself be led back to their tent. She changed out of her sweaty armor, making a note to bring that set to the river for washing later, into pajamas, and curled up against Sea Hawk's chest. "Hey."

"Hm? Yes, dearest?"

“I…Can we…”

Sea Hawk propped himself on an elbow to meet her eyes. “Mermista?”

“It’s nothing.” She suddenly felt shy, and silly. “Let’s go to bed.”

“‘Mista…” His chest was now pressed to her back, and she felt his voice rumbling. “What is it?”

“I just…really want a family with you.” It came out in a whisper, so quiet that she wondered if he’d even hear it. She felt vulnerable for voicing this at all, and squeezed her eyes shut against the feeling. “And I forgot how much I did ‘til, like, right now. With Salineas, and the war, and the constant exhaustion. I just forgot, and now I remember, and it hurts. Okay?”

“Oh, love.” Sea Hawk hugged her tightly, and she gave up her unbothered affectations to turn into his arms. “I know how you feel. I’m right there with you.”

“Yeah?” Mermista swallowed, tracing lines of ink on his chest. “Sometimes I…feel bad. About dragging you into all of this.”

“...what?”

"I dunno," she swallowed. "Before you met me, you were a carefree pirate. You had a, like, semi-regular job, and no war. And now, you're a fucking King, and in a refugee camp, and your life is in danger every day, and if we win this, there will just be *more obstacles* . There will be bureaucracy, and a whole nation to rebuild, and my dad is still out there somewhere, I think, who knows, maybe he's dead. And then we, like, have to have at least one kid, and what if we can't? And then you'll just be chained to Salineas, all the time, by me and a kingdom and a *baby* , and you can't just go sailing-"

" *Mermista!* Breathe, dearest, breathe."

Belatedly, she realized she was hyperventilating, and at some point she had started crying a little bit, and that Sea Hawk had been saying her name for a while.

He rolled her onto her back and draped himself over her, the pressure on her chest alleviating some of the panic coursing through her. She missed her weighted comforter. "It's okay, dearest, just breathe. I'm going to talk, and you're going to listen. And breathe. First of all, I wouldn't trade meeting you for all the gold, or jewels, or adventure in the world. You are the best thing that has ever happened to me, my love."

Mermista sniffled. "Sometimes I feel like I ruined your life."

"Mermista." He pulled back enough to look in her eyes. "The odds are very good that you saved my life. By now, I'd probably be recruited by the Horde, or more likely, dead. Or black out drunk under some table in some tavern waiting to die. With you, I have purpose, and direction. You're my north star, remember?" He brushed a kiss to her forehead, and she felt a few more tears slip out. "I am, admittedly, terrified of being King. But the idea of anyone else in my place fills me with boiling rage, so here I am."

She snorted and he pecked her nose.

"We will figure everything else out, together, one thing at a time, after this war ends."

"It's weird when you're the smart one."

"Oh believe me, I know," He smiled, and eased off her chest. "I have no science to go off of, at all, but I don't think we're going to have an issue with children."

"Yeah?"

He shrugged. "And if we do, we handle it together. In the meantime, though." He pulled back to smirk at her. "There is absolutely no harm in practicing our technique right?"

She groaned and rolled her eyes, brushing the last of the tears away, even as the smile stretching across her lips ruined the effect. "Why are you like this?"

“Because I love you, dearest.” He pecked her nose. “And I’ll always have your back.”

Chapter End Notes

> I hope you enjoyed!! Pls lmk if you did, or didn’t, I love to hear from everyone and I’m working on responding to every comment. Love y’all!!

the beginning of the end

Chapter Summary

Season 5, Episode 1

Chapter Notes

Sorry for the IMMENSE delay, I was in the ER and then on vacation so that's been barrels of fun. We're in the home stretch now!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

What was the old expression? Nothing gold can stay?

Yeah, Mermista was beginning to think that whoever wrote that little nugget was really onto something. She was once again fighting for her life against insurmountable odds, but that had pretty much become the new normal.

The day had started off like any other- bring a new group of refugees to the camp, fight off the drones and bots, and get back in time for lunch and the strategy meeting. Then, Bow and Scorpia and Adora and Swiftwind had run off, and within the hour, all hell had broken loose.

She blocked a barrage of laser blasts with her trident, and the force of it pushed her back to the edge of camp. Careful to keep Frosta in her peripheral, she swung her arm in a wide arc and sent a wave crashing around them. Frosta was well-attuned to her combat strategies now, thanks to Adora's nonstop training regiments, and turned the wave into a slide, bringing herself close enough to take out the bots. Perfuma swung in to assist, and Mermista took the opportunity to run for the camp. They had to get everyone out, and there weren't enough soldiers to move the noncombatants smoothly. In her mind, the thread tying her to Sea Hawk was pinging with worry and stress, but she forced herself to ignore it.

The camp was a complete stampede of people fighting or running. She helped an older gentleman to his feet before he could be trampled by a bot, and handed him off to a young woman. A cry caught her ear, and Mermista whipped around to see a young child, practically a toddler, in a heap on the ground. His foot had been caught up on a root and he'd taken the fall hard to the nose, bloodying his terrified face. A drone was scanning him, a strange whine coming from the machine, and Mermista started running. Between the throngs of people and the other bots that were coming at her from the side, though, she knew she wasn't going to make it to him. The drone deployed a small cannon, like a laser beam, and began charging up as the child's eyes screwed shut. With a yell, Mermista javelined her trident at the drone just as it went off, and she watched in slow motion as the beam flew at the boy-

Who wasn't there anymore. Sea Hawk was, though, tucking and rolling out of the way of the laser with the boy against his chest. He rolled right to his feet and ran headlong at her. "Go! We have to go!"

"You go, I need to hang back!"

Sea Hawk was grabbing at her waist even as she spoke, and he looked at her with naked fear in his eyes. "Mermista, we're not going to be able to hold the camp."

"I know that!" She pushed his hand off her waist, reluctant even if she didn't show it. "But we need to buy all of you more time. Let the Princesses handle this."

"Then I stay with you-"

"No."" She could feel the earth shaking as the the bots marched toward them, and pushed at Sea Hawk's chest. "Take him, take all the other kids without parents looking for them, and get the hell out. Please."

She could feel how much he wanted to fight her, to stay by her side; it would have been obvious even without the bond. But there was nothing for it, and they both knew it.

Sea Hawk nodded, and hiked the boy higher up his hip before sliding his fingers into her hair and crushing his mouth to hers in a bruising, desperate kiss. "You come back to me," he spoke against her lips.

Mermista squeezed his wrist. "And you stay alive. Or else."

"As my Queen commands me."

And then he was gone, tearing off for the tucked away area of camp where they'd set up a creche system for the orphaned children who had been brought to, or found the camp throughout the invasion.

Mermista retrieved her trident from the drone's fried, sparking carcass and turned back to rejoin the fray. Adora, per usual, had thrown herself headlong into a hopeless six-on-one situation, but as Mermista ran to her, a large shadow fell over her and she turned to see a bipedal bot with a white eye in place of a green one. Weird.

She spared it no thought as she pushed a river of water into its face and knocked it flying into the hard ground. When she turned to find Adora, though, she realized she was completely surrounded by bots. Her steps faltered, and panic began to bite at the edge of her focus.

No , she thought. *I won't break my promise.* She looked around quickly, and realized the other Princesses weren't close enough to her for an immediate assist- especially with Adora literally about to be blown to bits. Mermista grit her teeth, and got to work.

Fighting had always been natural to her; her father had forced her to train for hours on end as a child, especially after what happened to her Ama. On the training sands, in the ocean, sometimes even in the Woods or the mountains of other lands. He was relentless, and for most of her life, Mermista had despised him for it. At the present moment, though, she couldn't help but thank the bastard. Combat, especially with her magic, was a lot like dancing; bobbing and weaving and anticipating your partner's next move so you could be ready to meet them where they landed. A bot took a step, and she wrapped its ankle in water and whipped it into the wall of the ravine. Another raised its cannon while yet another charged her, so she flipped over the latter to land in front of the former, slamming her trident into its arm hard enough to disable the weapon. When the one she'd dodged came back around, she moved with it, using its momentum against it to send it crashing into the next bot. While they tried to orient themselves, she slammed them with tendrils of water made into one large battering ram of a wave. And the last one- Scorpia of all people had come to her rescue, and sent it flying to the ground in pieces with one massive, sparking claw.

She nodded to the arachnid woman, who grinned back before jumping to attention at Adora's call. Mermista turned back to the next wave of bots, and decided she was entirely done with finesse; she summoned all the residual water from around the camp and swung it around her in an arc, taking out bots as she went. Bow's arrow pierced a drone that had been flying at her back, and she nodded a thank you.

And just as fast as the invasion had started- it was over. The bots and drones lay in sputtering, seizing heaps, crushed or frozen or corroded or water-logged. Mermista let herself breath as Adora and Bow discussed where to go. Most of the camp was entirely empty, just a few soldiers left.

"I think I know a place," Adora was saying as they walked over. She looked better than she had the past week, but she still seemed hollow, a shell of her former self. "We need to salvage what we can, find the refugees we sent away. We'll leave at dusk- just the Alliance- and see if the place I have in mind will work."

They nodded, and she dismissed them. Mermista was immediately pulled aside by Micah, and she fought down her panicked annoyance; Sea Hawk was fine, he'd gotten out in plenty of time and they'd kept the combat concentrated here. That's what she told herself, anyway, over the hours it took to get the camp packed up and organized and loaded up in wagons.

Swiftwind had assembled some of his liberated, equine brethren to move the supplies and shelters, while the Princesses scouted ahead. Adora's plan was a rousing success, especially for them- the heart of the Woods was brimming with arcane magic that called to each of them, welcoming them with open arms, recharging their strained abilities. Even if Adora did almost immediately collapse, which, like, was absolutely not a shock to any of them once they asserted that she was in fact still alive. The woman was beyond exhausted. They got their own tents set up, and Adora settled into her own with Swiftwind keeping watch, before Mermista could finally take Netossa, Spinnerella, Scorpia, and Perfuma to bring the refugees back. Checkpoints and safety areas had been set up and established weeks ago, so they began checking them all in order of distance.

They found the elderly members of the camp closest to the old camp, and sent them back with Spinnerella to guide them. Next, they found the young noncombatants, parents with young children, healers and sorcerers who had left to protect the people, camped out by the river, ready to swim across it if they had to. Perfuma agreed to take them back, and told them she'd send Spinnerella their way if she saw her.

Mermista was suitably nervous now; how far had he taken the kids? How far had they made it? Did anyone else go with him-

They were cut off by the sound of snapping underbrush, and twigs breaking under rapid footfall. Before they could slip into combat stances, Sea Hawk came stumbling through the underbrush, looking pale but relieved to see them. "Thank the stars. A few of the kids are banged up, they need medical attention-"

"Whoa, dude, slow down." Mermista put her hands up to try and stem the tide of his words, but ended up catching him when he suddenly pitched forward. She grunted as he fell into her. "Hey- Sea Hawk, what-"

He was trying to grip her shoulders for purchase but he…couldn't. His hands kept sliding off her armor, and he was still mumbling under his breath. "They- over the ridge…there…"

"Sea Hawk?" Scorpia approached cautiously, pincers up. Mermista felt his legs giving out, and realized something was very very wrong. "You alright, buddy?"

He pulled away from her slightly, and Mermista's stomach churned when she saw that his eyes were unfocused, and his skin was almost sallow. Sweat lined his brow, his chest heaved like he couldn't suck in enough air, and his voice sounded far away as he spoke. "I- I don't…what?"

Netossa pulled him away from her slightly, and that's when they all saw the massive red stain on his shirt, blossoming and dripping from his shoulder down his entire side. He locked eyes with Mermista again, jaw working like he was trying to speak, before his eyes finally rolled back and he collapsed.

“Sea Hawk!”

“Scorpia, go find the kids. Mermista, can you carry him over to the river?” Netossa stepped into command fluidly. “We gotta get get him cleaned and closed up if we can. Scorpia, when you find the kids, take them back to camp and get Perfuma. If we can move him we’ll be taking Path A there. If not, we’ll be by the river. Go!”

Scorpia took off, and Mermista lifted her husband into her arms. He was heavy, but she’d been carrying his dumb ass out of danger for just about ever. He’d never been this…limp before, though, and it unnerved her. She laid him on the pebbled shore of the freshwater river and began peeling his shirt away from his body carefully. They didn’t know exactly where the wound was, and she didn’t want to injure him further. Netossa helped her work his shirt off, and whistled loudly at the carnage underneath. “Well, hope he saved the receipt on that ink.”

His entire upper right shoulder was covered in blood, still bubbling out of a deep and messy stab wound. It could only have been from the jagged arm of a Horde bot, judging from the size and shape of the exit pattern. Mermista fought down nausea at the thought of Sea Hawk being actually run through with something, and forced her brain not to think about the noise he would’ve made, the pain he was in. She shook her head harshly. Focus.

They worked together to clean the wound in silence. Netossa moved him carefully while Mermista washed away the old blood, and new blood when it bubbled out. It was slowing, thankfully, but they weren't sure how much he'd already lost. Judging from his pallor, it was a good amount. Mermista worked with single-minded focus until Netossa spoke up.

"How long?"

Mermista blinked at her, and realized it had grown almost completely dark. Well, as dark as it could get with the stars, now. "How long what?"

"Have you been married?"

She dropped the water she'd been moving, and felt her hands start to shake. "I-I don't know what you're talking about."

"Uh-huh." Netossa gave her A Look. "Mermista, you realize Spinnerella and I have been married for, like, years, right? I know what the Bonding Magic feels like; you know that Bonds call to one another, right? And more importantly, I'm never wrong. So?"

She hadn't known that. Mermista kept up her skeptic face for all of three more seconds before her shoulders slumped and she sighed. "Almost three months. We got married, like, hours before the Heart went off and Prime invaded."

“Damn,” Netossa whistled. “Rough anniversary.”

She snorted. “Something like that.”

“I understand, though. I asked Spinnerella to marry me when we were seventeen, and marching into the battle that took Micah. I remember being so scared, and feeling like it was then or never. It was like…if she said yes, then I just *had* to live, y’know? I couldn’t go and die if I was engaged, or if I had the most incredible woman waiting to marry me. The universe just didn’t work like that to me. And we got so lucky.” Netossa brushed at her eyes. “We’ve lived our whole lives at war, me and Spinny. And if I hadn’t had her by my side through it all, I don’t think I’d still be here today. She gives me a reason to fight, sure. But more importantly, she gives me a reason to come home.”

Mermista took in a shaking breath, and realized her own eyes were filling with tears. “I-I love him. A lot. And I’ve never told anyone that besides him, and myself, and my guard back home. And I really need someone to know that.” The words were tumbling out of her mouth faster than she could think to stop them. “He’s a total buffoon, and reckless, and loud, and I love him so much that it hurts sometimes.”

Netossa wrapped an arm around her shoulders and squeezed. “Of course you do. He’s Sea Hawk. And you’re Mermista. You guys just…fit.”

“I think that’s a backhanded compliment.”

“Only a little.”

They chuckled, and Mermista picked the water back up. She shifted closer to Sea Hawk, feeling like a small weight had been lifted off her shoulders as she resumed washing the wound. It had finally stopped bleeding, and she made sure to be gentle.

“Does anyone else know?”

“I think Micah, if what you said about the bonds recognizing one another is true. We haven’t told anyone, though.”

“You think he’d be screaming it from the rooftops.”

Mermista chuckled. “I told him to chill about it. He…gets that these things take more time for me to adjust to. Even if it was, like, my idea.”

“Really!” Netossa laughed. “Aren’t you full of surprises. How’s the bond settling in? I know ours kept scaring me for months. I’d be thinking something and she’d answer out loud. Spooky as hell, and she did it on purpose.”

“Ours isn’t quite like that.” She smiled. “We can’t hear words or, like, full thoughts. It’s more of like, the emotion. I can tell when he’s happy, or anxious, or whatever. Right now it’s like a swollen river, moving all over the place and messy.”

“That makes sense.” She squeezed Mermista’s shoulder again. “As soon as you’ve got it clean, I’ll stitch it up, and we’ll get his ass back to camp where you can yell the shit outta him once he’s awake.”

Mermista sniffled against her will. “Yeah. That sounds good.”

They ended up running into Perfuma and Scorpia on the way back, and Mermista let the buff scorpion cart her husband the rest of the way back to camp. Perfuma wrapped an arm around her shoulders, and Mermista let it happen. She really ought to tell her…

“Hey, we’ll meet you guys there.” She stopped in her tracks, bringing Perfuma to a halt with her. “I gotta talk to ‘Fuma, just put him in our tent.”

As soon as they were alone, Perfuma rounded on her. “Are you pregnant?”

“What- NO!” Mermista flushed. “At least, I better fucking not be.”

“Good, okay, good,” her friend sighed, then paused. “So…what’s up?”

“I, uh, did something a while ago, and I didn’t want to tell anyone, but Netossa figured it out, and you’re my best friend so I need to tell you, and I’m sorry I didn’t sooner-”

“Mista, Mista, breathe,” Perfuma soothed. “You can always tell me anything.”

“Okay.”” She inhaled shakily. “Okay, uh. Yes. So. A few hours before the Heart went off and almost killed us all, Sea Hawk and I kinda…sorta…got married?”

Perfuma’s jaw dropped, and her eyes widened comically. “You-what?!”

“Like, a Salinean ceremony, a Confluence, not the big Etherian one, like, obviously, that will be an After sort of thing- oomf!”

Perfuma all but tackled her in a hug, nearly sending them both to the ground.

Mermista only resisted for a second before sinking into it. “You’re not mad I didn’t tell you?”

“Of course not, silly!” The plant Princess was vibrating out of her skin. “I’m just so, so happy for you! Married!”

“You and Netossa are the only ones who know, and I’d like to keep it that way, please.”

“Always, girl!” Perfuma drew back just enough to press a kiss to her forehead. “I’m really, seriously over the moons for you, Mermista.”

“Yeah.” She smiled, a small and genuine one. “Me, too.”

“Now, c’mon, let’s get you back to your husband.”

“Ugh, do not start.”

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The world was flashes of brilliant light and loud sounds. Sea Hawk felt like he was floating in a place that was nowhere and everywhere. Sometimes he was asleep, and in some split seconds, he was awake and very painfully aware. His shoulder burned and throbbed, like someone had somehow injected him with frostbite.

At some point, there was water running over his body and everything was suddenly much more peaceful. His head stopped screaming, briefly, and he became aware of Mermista. He tried to reach for her, but his arms wouldn't move, and soon enough he was slipping back under.

The next time he woke, he was in Scorpia's arms and there was noise everywhere. The camp. Wait, no- the camp wasn't safe, they weren't safe! He tried to tell her, warn her, but all he could do was groan. Scorpia glanced down at him. "I know, buddy, but Perfuma's going to fix you right up once we get you settled. She's really amazing with healing- well, she's really amazing all the time. Did you know that one time she…"

Whatever Scorpia said next, his brain refused to grasp onto it, and he was dragged back under. The next time he woke, Perfuma was leaning over him, and his shoulder wasn't burning so much anymore. The lilac and honeysuckle scent of her magic lingered in the air, and he inhaled deeply. The fog lifted, finally, and he opened his eyes truly for the first time in hours. "'Fuma?"

"Hey, Hawk." She smiled at him. "Feeling better?"

"Like I could take on one hundred bots."

Bow was somewhere off to his left, and he chuckled. "Let's maybe leave that for tomorrow, buddy."

“Mmkay,” he yawned. “Where’s Mermista?”

“She went to wash off in the river.” Perfuma smeared more… something on his shoulder. “She’ll be back- oh, right now.”

He couldn’t lift his head, but the part of him that was tethered to her knew exactly where she was, and he reached out toward her feebly. To his surprise, she gripped his hand tightly for one small second before dropping it.

“Thanks, guys. You can go to bed now.”

The polite dismissal was obvious, and their friends nodded and left. Perfuma dropped a jar of salve into Mermista’s hands with instructions before whisking away to go flirt with Scorpia, probably.

Mermista wouldn’t look at him as she busied herself getting ready for sleep, dimming lanterns and changing into pajamas and stretching sore muscles. It was clear to him that she was avoiding her emotions, and by proxy, him. Sea Hawk sighed. “Mermista…”

“Yeah?” Her voice only shook slightly, and she cleared her throat. “What’s up? Do you need water?”

“No, dearest. I need you to come here.”

With nothing else to distract her, Mermista squared her shoulders and came to sit stiffly beside him on the bed. She still wouldn’t look at him, even when he took her hand in his and squeezed gently.

“Mermista, love, will you look at me? Please?”

Mermista’s hair hid most of her face from few, but he saw her jaw wobble slightly before she grit it. Almost angrily, she whipped her head around to meet his eyes, and he was dismayed to see her walls firmly up. Carefully cultivated apathy sat on her shoulders like a well worn cloak. “What?”

“You tell me.” He wouldn’t be cowed, not now when they both needed each other so much.

She scoffed and snatched her hand back, but it was a sad little sound, more clogged and wet than she intended. She wrapped her arms around her torso, and looked away again.

“I thought- I- I couldn’t feel…” she tried, and then stopped, and then tried again. “Do you know how badly you scared me?”

Wisely, Sea Hawk kept his mouth shut, though he reached out to place a hand on her thigh.

“There was so much blood, Sebastian, all over you. A-and I couldn’t-” She wiped carefully at eyes he still couldn’t see. “I couldn’t make it stop. None of us could, for a while. We just had to wait. And then we stitched you up, and you bled right through them when you got you back here, so we had to try and stop it again and I - !”

She broke off with a strangled sob, and tossed her head back to stare at the ceiling. The remaining lanterns threw her face into sharp relief, and Sea Hawk’s heart broke at the tears carving a steady path down her cheeks, dripping off her chin and down her neck. He grabbed for her hand again, relieved when she squeezed it back this time. “Mermista, I’m so sorry. I tried my best- I didn’t see the bot-”

“I’m not blaming you.” She sniffed. “That would be silly. But I- I’m still angry. I’m angry at myself, at the Horde, at the world and the universe for being so fucked up. I’m angry at Entrapta, still, and I’m angry with Glimmer, even though I miss her way more and I’d give my trident to have her back with us. I’m just so, so angry, all the time!” She was crying in earnest now, shoulders shaking with months of pent-up grief and rage and stress.

Sea Hawk tugged gently and she went with him, lowering herself to the good side of his chest carefully, tucking her head into the cradle his neck and shoulder made as he wrapped his good arm around her.

“A-and now, it’s not enough that I lost my mother, my father, my whole fucking kingdom, but now the universe wants to take my husband away and I- I just- I can’t-”

She was starting to hyperventilate, so Sea Hawk squeezed her as close as he could. “Mermista, please, breathe with me, love. I’m right here. I am alive, and I’m going to be fine. I am so, so sorry for putting you through this. I never want to hurt you-”

“I know that!” She sobbed miserably. “It’s not your fault that life just, like, fucking hates me.”

Sea Hawk chuckled sadly, and waited for Mermista to get her breathing under control. He hadn’t seen her this distraught since Salineas fell, and he felt like an idiot for thinking she was coping as well as she made everyone think she was. He was supposed to see past all that, supposed to understand her better than anyone. Of course she wasn’t fine; every day was tearing at a still-open wound that would be a lifelong scar. Self-loathing welled up in him, and Mermista made a noise.

“No, stop that. We’re not doing that.”

“I can’t always help it.”

“You can’t just…know everything, Sebastian. That was our problem in the first place, remember?” Mermista shifted against him, settling more comfortably against him. The line of her body was warm and soft along his side, and brought him a deep feeling of comfort. “I haven’t been sharing as much as I should. It’s harder, right now. I feel like I have to be a Princess twenty-four-seven, because that’s what everyone needs me to be. So when it’s just us, I forget to turn it off.”

“I could never blame you for that, love.” Sea Hawk brushed a kiss to her head. “You’re so strong, Mermista. Stronger than you even know.”

She sniffled against his shoulder. “Whatever.”

He could sense she was reaching her emotional limit, so he let silence wash over them. He played with her hair, loose about her shoulders, running gentle fingers through wavy curls. He was beginning to think she’d fallen asleep when she suddenly spoke.

“We need a more proactive plan.”

“How so?”

“We can’t keep running and hiding and moving people and supplies like this. Eventually, our luck is going to run out. It’s time to take some sort of offense.”

Sea Hawk hummed, letting her work through her thoughts aloud as she was occasionally prone to doing. “What do you propose?”

"Ugh, I don't know," Mermista groaned. "If I had to, like, come up with something, I would start with getting Glimmer back. From there…" She trailed off, falling into a contemplative silence as she traced the ink on Sea Hawk's chest and far shoulder. He was almost lulled to sleep by her gentle scratching. "I think I would go find Peekablue, actually."

"What?" Sea Hawk's eyes flew open. "Why him?"

"He sucks, but his gift would be invaluable right now. He could probably see Glimmer, and Prime, and everyone else we can't."

"Would he help us?"

Mermista shrugged. "No idea. Probably not. He's the kind of guy who'd rather watch the world burn than be wrong, or humble, or loyal, or respectful."

Sea Hawk nodded along to her words, but the medications were beginning to drag him under. The gentle drone of his wife's voice, her hands soft and soothing on his skin, the security that, at least for tonight, they were alive and in one another's arms, all rolled together into a haze of contention that warmed the bond, made it drip some ambrosiac nectar into his brain that, bit by bit, pulled them both to sleep.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed! Next up is one of my favs, because I finally get to play with Entrapta and Mermista. If you enjoyed or didn’t, drop a comment! I’m trying to get back to everyone now that I’m back in action

Launch

Chapter Summary

Apologies and goodbye to some friends

Chapter Notes

Season 5, episode 2: Launch!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I'm not good at people. But I am good at tech. I thought maybe if I could use tech to help you…you'd like me. But I messed that up, too."

The mission was absolutely not going to plan, even slightly. They were pinned down in a desert, about to be surrounded, and Mermista was feeling a very distracting mixture of anger, and guilt, and something adjacent to pity, but softer. Sympathy? Staring at Entrapta, her rage faltered, and for the first time in a long time, flickered out entirely. They were all right, and she knew they were right. Entrapta had tried to kill them, and she still wanted to know why. But, she had been trying to do better, trying to help them, the one thing they'd asked of her, and they had still rejected her, rebuffed her efforts with contempt. It felt…bad. Bad in a familiar way.

Before she could speak, Geek Princess was up and moving, racing across the desert toward the tower, away from them. The anger came back, but now it was more frustrated, and she leapt up to chase after her. "Entrapta! No!"

She pelted after her, and snatched the first thing she could get a hold of- one of her pigtails. Mermista felt bad when she screamed, but a little hair pain was a small price to pay for bodily safety, and, like, life. "I said we have to leave! Can you listen for once in your life?" she snapped.

To her shock, Entrapta snapped back with an equal amount of sass. "I'm *sorry* I'm bad at listening! *I'm sorry I mess everything up!* But you need this signal and I'm gonna get it for you."

Mermista froze, releasing Entrapta's hair in shock. "You're…still trying to get the signal?"

Entrapta turned to her, and finally, *finally,* Mermista saw she understood. That she understood everything; the pain she'd caused, the remorse she felt, her desperation to prove herself to them, and the same grief they all felt at their hopeless situation.

"Of course. Glimmer *needs* us *.* "

And it was enough, for now. Not for forever. Not for Salineas. But it was enough for her as Mermista, as a person. As a friend. Drones were spilling out of the spire, bots trooping over the edge of the crater toward them. Mermista knew it was now or never. And she made her choice.

"Okay, Geek Princess. Get that signal, we'll cover you."

The rest of the Alliance reached them, panting and heaving, and Entrapta smiled gratefully at them all before taking off for the spire.

“Frosta, Scorpia, on Entrapta. Perfuma, with me, *now!* ”

They leapt into action, and Mermista mentally thanked Adora for all the training drills over the past four months. As annoying as they were at the time, they were more than paying off now. Especially since, y’know, no water in the desert. The first bots reached them and Mermista and Perfuma made short work of them; her trident pried at their limbs, cracking open metal casings and warping the soldering so Perfuma could snake vines into them, tearing them apart quickly and efficiently from the inside. The plant Princess sent waves of roots up into the horde coming their way, slicing the attacking party in half as they were torn apart or wrapped up.

Two more bots were coming her way, and Mermista groaned. She flipped her grip on her trident, and threw it overhead as hard as she could, javelin-style. It pierced the chest of the bot, which buckled in a shower of sparks and crumpled to the ground. She raced forward, snatching her trident out of its chest as she went, and engaged the next bot with her trident to its arm cannon. This one seemed smarter, and instead of raising the cannon right away, thrust out with a knife-sharp appendage. She parried it, but it was much heavier than Sea Hawk’s blade, and she didn’t clear an opening large enough to land a strike. It forced her to retreat, and she leapt backwards to land next to Perfuma. They dodged a cannon blast, and the bot kept on pursuing her.

She landed in a skid, and didn’t recover as quickly as she would have liked. The bot was standing tall over her, and brought its blade arm down in a vicious slice. Her trident flew up and stopped its path, and she parried again, this time catching the blade in the prongs of her weapon. She twisted, and slammed her trident into the earth, trapping the appendage. She allowed herself a smile of victory, but it faded quickly when the bot warped itself, folding to level the cannon at her. Time slowed as the arm charged up, sickly green energy belching heat into her face. She couldn’t dodge in time, and at point-blank range, there was only one way this was going to end.

‘Sea Hawk, I’m sorry,’ she thought as she squeezed her eyes shut, bracing herself for death.

The blast fired off, but a metallic clang next to her ear forced her eyes open, and she watched the shot go high and wide, pushed away from her by a root. She grunted, yanking her trident out of the earth and more vines and roots snaked up the bot, immobilizing it. With a yell, she slammed her trident into its neck, striking the head hard and forcing it into an awkward angle. The sound of snapping wires and the dimming of the light heralded the bot’s death.

Before she could thank Perfuma, another door on the spire opened, revealing another squadron of bots in pristine fighting condition.

Mermista snarled her frustration. “Perfuma, cut off that spire.”

In an impressive display of magic, her friend dug deep into the dirt, pulling up thick, gnarled roots that blocked and trapped the bots.

She grinned. "Nice job."

"Thanks!" Perfuma smiled. "I wish there was water here for you, though."

Mermista took a second, and reached out as far as she could with her magic. She waited for the usual feeling of water in her mind, a cool, calming presence, a soft little *ping* . Sure enough, she felt it, muted and tainted but *there* , right next to the bond, which was taught and humming with apprehension but she had no time for that. She tried to send reassurance across it, but it was all she could do to focus on the water. Drones flew past her, breaking her second-long reverie.

She grinned when she saw the mangled water pipes. "But there is. If there's one thing that I know in the Fright Zone, it's the sewer system."

She dropped her trident, using both hands to pry up the piping with the remaining water inside. There wasn't much in the pipes themselves, but she could feel tanks of waste water just under the earth. She knocked two drones out of the sky with the pipes, before a shout interrupted her. She and Perfuma whirled around to see Scorpia and Frosta being chased by drones, foxed into a trench.

“Scorpia! Frosta!” Perfuma shouted, and they started sprinting.

They were sitting ducks in the trench, and not even Scorpia’s armor could hold out against more than a couple of laser shots. They jumped into the bowl just in time to see Scorpia leap, grab Frosta in her arms, and tuck and roll into a protective shell. Mermista sent a torrent of filthy water flying past them, knocking out the attacking tech.

The two Princesses unfurled, and Mermista felt the last of her apprehension and ice toward Scorpia melt away as she quickly checked over their youngest member for injury. She and Perfuma stepped into their line of sight, and Mermista offered the arachnid woman a true smile, grateful and proud of their team work. Scorpia smiled back briefly- before the stench hit her. “Oh, wow, that’s uh- that’s…”

“That was so gross!” Frosta cheered, pumping her fists in the air. Mermista laughed, helping the young girl to her feet and ruffling her hair with a little more affection than usual.

“Nice shooting, kid.”

“Nice shit water, fishstick.”

“Language!” Perfuma, who had an arm around Scorpia’s pincer to help her up, groaned.

No one was hurt, so they took off back up the bank and across the swath of desert to where Entrapta stood, feverishly tapping away at her datapad. Mermista snatched up her trident on the way.

As they approached, she screamed. “Got it! Okay, good news and bad news. The good news is I successfully triangulated Horde Prime’s flagship.”

“Hooray!” Scorpia cheered.

“Bad news is, I intercepted the last message he sent.” The techie winced, as if nervous for their reaction. “He’s sending reinforcement ships to Etheria. They’ll be here any minute.”

“I take back my hooray.”

Mermista grit her teeth. “We need to get Bow on the ‘pad, like, *now* . It’s do or die if they’re going to go get Glimmer.”

Entrapta set about doing so while they stood guard around her. It was less than a minute before more spire doors were materializing open, troops of bots and swarms of drones spilling out of the tower in a beeline right for them.

“Frosta.” Mermista dragged more shit water out of the tanks below them. “Ice arrows.”

“Got it!”

She flung her hand out, the water flying over the incoming army in a broad, airborne wave that Frosta froze in volleys of arrows and darts. When the projectiles hit the mob, taking out a solid majority of them, she raised her arms, freezing the rest in place. Mermista whooped, and offered Frosta a high-five, which she returned, only panting a little.

Another door slid open much closer, and the bots that came out of this one were sprinting, cannons already booting up.

“Perfuma, Scorpia, go!”

While they send lightning and roots at their attackers, Entrapta shouted again behind them. “I’ve got a signal! Calling Bow now!”

Mermista took out three drones with her water, and ripped the chest out of a bot with her trident before she had the ability to turn to Entrapta and the ‘pad.

“He’s taking the pad to Adora, I’ve informed him of the situation.”

“Nice job.”

Entrapta beamed at the praise, and Mermista wondered idly how much outside encouragement she had ever really received. Before she could hop on the call, another drone attacked, and this one was much harder to pin down.

As she dodged and swung at it, Entrapta shouted. “Mermista! I’ve got Bow and Adora, what did you want to tell her-”

“ *Get to the ship!* ”

“We found her!” Entrapta chimed in. “We found Glimmer!”

Mermista pushed her out of the way of the camera, holding her off with one hand, and manipulating a volley of water with the other. “But also, we found out that Horde Prime is sending more ships to Etheria, *today* . If you guys don’t leave now, you can’t leave, *period* . So, uh, *RUN!* ”

They nodded at her, and the connection shorted out. Entrapta stowed away the antenna and datapad, and, to Mermista’s shock, joined the fray. And the woman was a *beast* . Her hair propelled her around the battlefield like a crab, and she kicked out at any attackers with steel-toed boots. “C’mon! We need to meet them at the ship!”

Mermista nodded at the others when they turned to her for confirmation. She grimaced at the implication, and what it meant. With Bow and Adora leaving Earth, that left her in charge of the Rebellion by the unofficial chain of command they had established. She didn't relish the thought. Maybe Micah would be willing to reconsider his non-leading stance.

They raced across the desert, taking out only the necessary attackers to conserve energy. They hit the treeline running, and didn't falter despite the roots and branches in their way. If anything, Perfuma and Entrapta sped up, aided by their magic and grappling opportunities, respectively. Scorpia scooped up Frosta, who's short legs had left her lagging, to only minimal protest. Mermista kept up by sheer will, and, not for the first time, missed the ocean, and water in general. She always felt she moved too slow on land. They reached the ship's clearing in record time, arriving at the exact same time as Micah, Bow, Adora, and Swift Wind.

Micah stared at the treeline apprehensively. "We're exposed here. We need to make these goodbyes quick."

Adora turned and met Mermista's eyes. They exchanged a look of sadness, anxiety, and fear before Adora wiped her expression, determination replacing everything else. She crossed to Mermista, who looked down at her friend and realized just how much she was going to miss her, and everything her presence brought to the Alliance. Adora had entered her life…strangely, and despite her benign attraction to the blonde girl, she had been nervous to let her in. But Adora was more than an ally now, more than a coworker, another Princess. She was Mermista’s friend, well and truly, and she was leaving.

“We’ll be back as soon as we can.” She wrapped Mermista in a quick, tight hug that she was too shocked to return before it ended. Physical touch was neither of their styles. When she pulled away, she was smiling, pride in her blue eyes. “The rebellion is in good hands.”

Bow smiled and nodded his agreement.

Mermista flushed at the praise and approval, crossing her arms in an effort to preserve her aloofness. “Yeah, turns out I’m an awesome leader, so we’re gonna be fine.” And then, when it wasn’t enough to get the attention off of her, she yanked Entrapta to her side with an arm around the neck.

The older woman stumbled, looking very confused at the contact and what it meant.

“Aaaand, Entrapta helped. You’re still a weirdo, but you did good today. We’ve got your back anytime.”

Despite her tone, and her flippant words, Entrapta seemed to understand exactly what she was trying to say. ‘*You’re one of us, we’ll miss you, come back or else* .’ The other Princesses nodded their unanimous agreement, and Entrapta’s face scrunched up as she fought off tears. She turned her head into Mermista's arm, hugging back in her own Entrapta way.

Bow whimpered, already crying, and grabbed them all in a desperate hug.

And for once, Mermista let herself feel every bit of it. They were losing Adora, Bow, and Entrapta, three of their strongest assets, for who knew how long. A few tears slipped out of her, and she hugged Frosta and Entrapta close to her. They would return.

They had to.

She wouldn't accept anything else.

They broke apart as Adora whispered to her horse, and Mermista grimaced when she overheard Swiftwind would be remaining behind. A flying horse was an undeniable positive in terms of transport and even combat, but that thing was a bad influence on Sea Hawk.

Then again, her husband had grown so serious…it wouldn't be an altogether bad thing to see some (*some*) of the old Sea Hawk again. If only just to know he was still in there, under all the stress and grief. But if he wasn't, well, she certainly couldn't and wouldn't hold it against him. And she'd love him all the same.

“Surveillance bots!”

Mermista whirled at Frosta’s cry. Sure enough, a swarm of drones was cresting the treeline, headed right for them. “If they see the ship, they’ll alert the Armada and stop us.”

“What are we gonna do? Are they gonna have to stay here?” Scorpia’s distress was mutual.

Mermista turned to Adora, still her leader for as long as she had her feet on this planet.

However, it was Micah who spoke. “No. We’re getting this ship off Etheria no matter what. I’ve got an idea.” He gathered them close. “Bow, Adora, Entrapta, get on the ship and wait for my signal. The rest of you, lead the incoming bots toward me. Swiftwind, play along.”

That ended up being no issue, as the bots started opening fire on them as soon as they broke the treeline. Mermista ducked and dodged as she ran, and still caught two blasts to her shoulder plates, and felt a burn scorch her leggings as it grazed her. She grit her teeth and kept on, leading them to the center of the clearing where Micah, glamoured as She-Ra, sat astride Swiftwind. They fell behind him, letting Swiftwind and Frosta knock out the squadron. Mermista, Perfuma and Scorpia skidded to an abrupt halt as another, larger group of bots fanned out of the forest, bracketing them in. That was all of the surrounding enemies, according to the datapad. Mermista smirked as she turned to the King.

“What do you think Micah? Have we wasted enough of their time?”

He let the glamor drop from his face only, and winked as he readied an attacking spell. “Get my good side.”

Between his magic and theirs, it was only moments before the bots were falling apart left and right, ripped open by pincers, corroded by acid, water-logged and frozen beyond function. The bits and pieces of machinery littered the clearing, and they stood panting, but smiling, at yet another victory that night. They waited as Micah sent the signal, a burst of purple fireworks, and seconds later, the ship was bursting out of the forest, rocketing toward the stars beyond their sky.

“Yes!” she cheered, the other Princesses joining in. “Go get our girl!”

“Good luck, and good vibes!”

“Hooray! I reinstate my hooray!”

“Go! Go, go, go and save my best friend!”

The procession back to camp was slow, and as the minutes ticked on, sullen. Knowing She-Ra was off planet, far away and beyond their reach, left them all feeling weirdly exposed.

Spinnerella and Netossa met them at the entrance to the grove, and the two women sagged with relief when they saw who remained, and who was gone. "They did it, then? They're on their way?"

Micah nodded. "The ship just cleared the atmosphere, according to Perfuma's pad. They'll be beyond our signals in just a few minutes."

Netossa blew out a gusty breath. "We're really in it now, huh?"

The group let it sink in, the realization that one way or another, this war would be coming to an end sooner rather than later. The thought followed Mermista's steps as she made her way to the small stream behind the camp, running cool clean water over her sweaty, bruised, and somewhat bloody body. It was there when she hugged Perfuma and Frosta good night, and even placed a gentle hand on Scorpia's shoulder. She had more than proven herself tonight; she was a Princess of Power now, just like the rest of them.

And it was there when she finally pushed into her tent, and was immediately engulfed in broad, strong arms that lifted her clear off her feet. She dropped her trident with a clatter to hug Sea Hawk back just as tightly, just as desperate for the connection as he was. She buried her face in the crook of his neck, and let him swing and rock her idly in his embrace.

“I was so fucking worried, Mermista.”

“I know, I know you were,” she murmured, scraping his scalp gently with her nails. “I could feel you, I tried to let you know I was okay.”

“You almost died.”

She froze. How could he have possibly known…

“I felt this moment of…paralyzing fear. It was what woke me. I’ve felt it before, of course, more than a normal amount- I knew what it was, and I knew it wasn’t mine. I rolled over and-” He choked, stuttering on air and emotion and Mermista hated herself for causing him so much anxiety. “You were gone. I left the tent, and Netossa told me where you’d gone and I…”

“I’m so sorry, Sebastian.” She clung to him, and let him grip her even tighter. Her spine cracked pleasantly under his forearms, tension from the battle being released bit by bit. “I didn’t want to just leave, but you needed to heal, and we needed to go-”

“I know,” he sighed, finally placing her on her feet. “I’m not angry. I was just so, so scared. I thought…I thought I was going to lose you."

"To be honest…" Her voice wavered, and she kept her face buried in his bare chest to avoid his eyes. "For a second there, I thought you were going to lose me, too."

He folded her into his arms again, and for a while they just stood there in each other's arms, swaying together and trying not to think of what had almost come to pass just over an hour ago. Mermista pushed the macabre thoughts out of her head as best she could; thoughts of her body being brought back to camp, of Sea Hawk having to be told she was gone…

She sniffled, and his chest convulsed under her head, and neither mentioned that they were crying until they stopped, wiping tears away. Finally, Mermista pulled back from his chest, and a fresh wave of tears threatened her eyes when she finally saw Sea Hawk's face. He looked exhausted in the way only anxiety and panic can make you look, dark circles and frown lines and puffy eyes. His hair was disheveled, and the wound on his shoulder was leaking a bit, but she ignored it all to tug his lips down to hers.

She kissed him once, softly, then twice, and then she couldn't stop. There wasn't much urgency, no after-battle adrenaline fueled fervor that typically led to them ripping off clothes and fucking up against a wall half-dressed and desperate. There was just reassurance, the need to be reminded that they were alive, and here with one another. Her lips slid along his with languid passion, teasing and nipping until he tilted his head and opened up for her. Her tongue slid into his mouth, and he groaned into her throat. Without breaking the kiss, she led him back to the back, let him lay her down and climb over her, bracketing her in with arms and legs and his larger than life presence, brought down from a blazing fire to a steady simmer just for her.

He needed his wound redressed, and the burn on her leg was starting to hurt now that shock was fading, and she really didn’t have time to dally; plans needed to be made, strategies developed, and to do that she needed rest. But their bond was teeming with love, and life, and Sea Hawk’s lips were warm, and in his arms, she felt untouchable.

And right now, she needed that more than ever.

Chapter End Notes

> Not sure when my next upload will be as I’m dealing with a bit of personal grief at the moment but it shouldn’t be too long. Writing is my happy thing, and I could use a bit of happy
>
> Thank you to everyone for reading and commenting! I love hearing everyone’s thoughts and opinions about the show and the fic!

thunder in our hearts

Chapter Summary

> The alliance, smaller than ever, begins to see the real scope of the threat they're up against.

Chapter Notes

> Hi!! Hello!! I'm so sorry for the delay in this chapter. Work and real life have been kicking my ass unfortunately :/ said goodbye to my dear furry friend two weeks ago and since then time has??? Felt unreal lmfao.
> But! It's here and it's ready! So pls enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After the success of her mission leading the other Princesses to victory at the spire, and getting their friends off-planet, Sea Hawk saw that something had shifted in Mermista. She carried herself differently- more confident, less anxious. She was still stressed all the time, they all were, but she didn't demur or keep her mouth closed in strategy meetings. Leadership of the Rebellion was now squarely on her shoulders, as Micah, Netossa, and Spinnerella had all "officially" passed on the position. Micah felt he wasn't ready to lead again, while the other two preferred to remain as mobile as possible, ready to ship out and fight at a moment's notice. Netossa did still lead plenty of meetings, but she would rather be out leading missions.

Sea Hawk helped where he could, as did the other Princesses. He took over supply route planning and strategy, making sure they could move food and weapons between the territories of the Whispering Woods without interference. Perfuma helped him, pointing out hidden paths and old, overgrown highways the horses and carts could use to circumvent the more active war zones and groups of Horde bots. Scorpia, ever a nurturer, helped

Spinnerella with care of the less abled, the medical supplies, and the makeshift creche they had for the orphans or separated families. Naturally, Micah led the sorcerers, along with a reluctant and usually unhelpful Shadow Weaver.

This left Mermista with the active military campaigns and management of their troops, areas in which he knew his love excelled. She'd been fighting alongside and then leading Salineas' armies and navies for years before the Kingdom's collapse. Once, late at night in their tent, pouring over topographic maps and sheets of resource allocation, she told him that the most common naval strategies from Salineas were proving to be extremely land-battle adaptable, and very difficult for the Horde to predict or subdue.

Two months after the launch, the tide of the war wasn't looking quite as hopeless as it once had. They weren't winning, not by a longshot, but they weren't losing as tragically as they had been before. Sea Hawk could see in her smile, in her bearing, that Mermista was tentatively proud, and carefully, slightly hopeful- even if it was against her will. He knew that the fall of Salineas had absolutely decimated her confidence in herself as a leader, but hopefully this would nudge her back toward the right track, if only mentally.

He slid into the tent after a long and grueling day of hoisting rations into the trees; Perfuma's idea for keeping the Horde and any natural predators away from their camp. It was late Spring now, Summer just around the corner, and despite the perturbations, Etheria's larger fauna were coming out of hibernation all around them. They'd had to severely restrict the childrens' free areas and change some patrol patterns to avoid the Moonian bears, the mega-boars, and the Cackling Howlers (dog-like creatures that laughed instead of barked, and feared no man or god). Sea Hawk missed the ocean, where all the things that could kill you had the decency to stay silent and in the water. Mermista was reclined in their cot, chatting with Maevik on the datapad about Lua Pele. The captain of the guard's voice was comforting in its monotonous drawl, so similar to Mermista's that Sea Hawk couldn't help but smile.

"-training is coming along surprisingly well. I'll be moving her on to a double sided trident, or maybe a dull sun saber, soon. She even took out two drones all on her own, no assistance, when a flock of them swarmed the outer shoreline during a laundry trip."

Mermista hummed. "Well, I'm glad Eliza's progressing so nicely. She'll be a fine soldier one day."

"...something like that."

"What does that mean?" Mermista accepted the glass of water Sea Hawk handed her with minimal eye-rolling. She didn't hydrate enough during the day, and it was prevalent in how she came to bed with her gills more visible than normal.

"After all this is said and done, I'd like to consider her for an apprenticeship."

That drew both of their attention. "Are you sure? You've never wanted an apprentice. In fact, you rejected every single one my father proposed.”

“Yes, well,” Maevik sighed on the other end. “That was then, and him, and this is now, and you.”

“Alright.” Mermista shrugged. “I think that sounds great. Now, tell me more about these drone attacks.”

They chatted while Sea Hawk stretched his sore muscles, alternating between talking shop and shooting the shit. Maevik was Mermista’s oldest and closest confidant, save for Perfuma, and he knew she missed him dearly. He crawled into bed a few moments later, curling up to Mermista and resting his head on her chest. She snorted, but obligingly slid her fingers into his hair.

“Good evening, your Highness.”

Sea Hawk whined. “Please, Maevik, just call me Sea Hawk.”

“As you wish, my liege.”

Mermista chuckled dryly, and so Sea Hawk just sighed and let it go. Mermista’s voice, echoing in her chest, buzzed pleasantly in his ear, and he must have fallen asleep because at one point she was chatting with Maevik, and the next, the lanterns were being banked, and all was silent.

“M’mis’a?” He mumbled.

“I’m here.” She brought the blanket up around their shoulders, and despite the warm spring air, Sea Hawk snuggled in. “Maevik had to go, there’s another skirmish on the border.”

He hummed, and tried to distract her from the stress of being apart from her people. “How was your day?”

“The usual. Arguing with Shadow Bitch, planning our next liberation, moving troops around. You?”

“Fantastically heroic! I punched, like, a hundred bears in the face over some rice.”

Mermista snorted. “Really? Cuz the way Perfuma told it you saw one bear, and almost dropped the entire load out of the tree.”

“Alas, I have been betrayed,” he sighed. “If it had come close, I *would* have punched it. And then I would’ve punched his friend, and then her friend-”

She flicked his ear gently. “Suuuuuure, dude.”

“Always the tone of doubt with you.”

A kiss landed in his hair, and he hummed happily. “Me? Noooo. I’m, like, so realistically proud of you for assaulting one hundred bears today, babe.”

“Thank you. Was that so hard?”

Mermista just chuckled, scratching his scalp gently. “Go to sleep, doofus. Another long day tomorrow.”

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The next day, he ended up on a last-minute supply run with Scorpia while Mermista and Perfuma worked on finding a closer, self-renewing fresh water spring that they could both *feel* but not exactly find. As they were loading up, Netossa, Spinerella, Frosta, Micah, and Swiftwind bounded out of the camp, yelling something about Elberon. Sea Hawk pouted. Elberon always threw the best parties.

He mounted his horse, and Scorpia hopped into the supply cart, carefully grabbing the (now reinforced) reins in her pincers. “Ready, buddy?”

“Lead on, my armored friend!”

Sea Hawk liked Scorpia. He liked her a good bit, and he was glad Mermista had thawed in her opinion of the arachnid woman. He saw so much of his not-so-younger self in her, and felt a strange sort of brotherly fondness, and protectiveness, over her still wide-eyed view of the world. Many at the camp called her naive or stupid, but Sea Hawk knew it was her choice to remain thus, to see the world as a place of beauty and light, even in times as dark as these. He wanted her to hang onto that, to keep it, because they would all be needing it in spades after the war.

He often wondered if his own optimism, enthusiasm, and penchant for adventure would ever be what it was. Sea Hawk used to fill days with dreams and plans of grandiose futures, futures where every day was a new adventure with treasure and fun and song. Now, he just wanted to be able to wake up, and take an unhindered breath. He had no time to mourn his loss of spirit, though, as each day brought with it new and distracting demands. His only constant in all of this was his wife, and Mermista had so much on her plate that he didn't even dare bring up his own struggles to her. He had to manage this on his own.

He was a King, now, and he needed to be strong, like Mermista.

“So!” Scorpia's voice cut through his reverie, and he jolted on his horse. “Why did we need to drop everything and get to Erelandia, like, yesterday?”

He smiled at the vernacular Scorpia was clearly picking up from Mermista and Netossa. “They sent us an urgent correspondence, saying they had too much grain and nowhere to send it.”

Scorpia blinked. “And that’s…urgent?”

He glanced around at the forest. The trees had ears, these days. “It’s a code. They have vital information for the Rebellion.”

“Oh!” Her eyes lit up. “That’s so smart! Oh, wow, gosh, and they put us on it? That’s…wow.”

“Mermista trusts us,” Sea Hawk affirmed. “And Perfuma was adamant you come with me. She seems to be very fond of you, hm?”

Scorpia blushed through to her platinum roots, and Sea Hawk chuckled. “Oh, heh, she’s- yeah, she’s great, y’know? She’s just so nice. And open with her feelings! That’s…it’s new. I like it…her. I like her.”

Sea Hawk smiled. “I have it on good authority that she likes you, too.”

“You do?” Scorpia’s blush got deeper, if such a thing were possible.

He just winked, and whistled to his horse to speed up.

The other horses followed suit, and Scorpia yelped as the cart moved faster. “H-hey! Wait! What do you know? Sea Hawk!”

He laughed, booming, and felt lighter. Maybe days of simple fun weren’t gone just yet.

They arrived in Erelandia around an hour past noon, judging by the sun (he could have just looked at his pad, but Sea Hawk liked to keep his skills sharp, especially this long off a boat). They were met at the gate by a mushroom woman and man; the man was wringing his hands, looking around apprehensively, while the woman was scowling. Sea Hawk slid off his horse and bowed courteously to them. “Greetings, my fungal friends! I am Sea Hawk, and this is Scorpia, and we come with the Reb-”

“Keep your voice down!” the woman hissed, now also looking around frantically. “Get in here, quickly.”

They tethered the horses to trees lining a stream and hustled into the gated village. The man shut the gate behind them, sliding a large wooden bar into place. The town was…empty? Almost completely empty. One or two shopkeeps stood in their stalls, but they looked terrified to do so. No one was out and milling about, and the overall air was incredibly tense. Scorpia’s tail whipped and rattled, betraying her apprehension, and she grabbed it nervously. Sea Hawk subtly nudged his sun saber on, increasing the heat to level three so it would be ready if he needed it. “What’s going on here?”

“Inside, to my shop. I have the shipment.” They followed the woman into a small general store, where she locked the door behind them, slumping against it in relief. “We’ve been having… visitors. Regular visitors. Of the clone variety.”

“How regular?” Scorpia swallowed.

The woman just gestured vaguely out the window, and Sea Hawk moved to check it out. Sure enough, a pair of clones strolled by the window, far too close for comfort. He jumped back, one hand flying to his sword. “How…what do they want? They haven’t attacked?”

“They did at first…” the woman sighed. “But then, after they realized we weren’t exactly a rebel town- no banners, no army- they just stopped. And ever since then, we’ve been occupied. One stepped forward, and assured us nothing would change. But then, the rules started. No music. No celebration. No playing in the streets. No…emotion. Those who dissented, well…”

She didn’t have to say it. This was new, and terrifying. Fighting the Horde was one thing, but this apathetic occupation, this quiet coup of an entire village… “We need to get back to the Rebellion. They’ll know what to do.”

“There’s one other thing.” The woman gestured to the man, and he checked the windows before letting the drapes fall shut. In the low light, the woman dug in a sack of grain and produced… a tick? Sea Hawk frowned. “My sister, she started behaving oddly one night, like one of *them* . We got into a fight, I have an old-

Erelandia temper, you know, and I knocked her against a wall and this fell off her neck. We don't know what it is. But we're hoping one of you will."

Sea Hawk inched closer, staring at the tiny metal disc. It had legs, like a bug, and a green diamond in the middle of it. He flipped it over in her palm to reveal circuitry. He frowned. "Both of our tech masters are presently…occupied. But I'll get this to them as soon as I can." He pulled a handkerchief out of his interior jacket pocket, wrapping up the tick-thing and tucking it away for later. "For now, we had best get that *grain* moving."

"Yes, I quite think you should." The woman gave them a wobbly smile, before loading them up with six bags of grain. Sea Hawk grabbed two, and Scorpia grabbed the other four. The man checked the windows, nodded, and unlocked the door. They had just made it to the gate when-

"Halt!"

Fuck . Sea Hawk plastered a genial, vapid smile on his face. The kind that said 'who, me? I'm just a silly, stupid little man! What could I possibly do?'. He turned to the approaching clones, and watched as Scorpia did the same, suppressing a shudder. Sea Hawk had never been face to face with Hordak, had never even seen him from a distance, but it was clear that Scorpia, as a former officer, had, and was downright terrified of the man, and, by proxy, these clones.

"What can we do for you gentlemen?"

“State your names, purpose, origin, and destination.”

Sea Hawk had always been excellent at thinking on his feet, and the best lies were those with just enough truth. “Sebastian Hawkins, grain delivery, the Province of Sea Worthy, Thaymoor.”

“Uh, Scor..lina. Scorlina. Grain delivery to Thaymoor. Uh, th-the Crimson Waste. Also, Thaymoor, since, y’know, delivering there…”

The clones eyes’ narrowed. One spoke. “According to our collected data, the peninsular province of Sea Worthy and the desert colloquially termed the Crimson Waste, are nowhere near each other. How did you come to live in Thaymoor.”

Sea Hawk felt sweat start beading on his face. “On the run from mercenaries. You know how it is.”

The clone opened his mouth again, but no sound came out as his body suddenly seized, convulsing as if possessed. His spine twisted, straightened, neck cracking oddly, before righting himself. White, glowing pupils materialized in green eyes, and a calm, disturbing smile stretched the alien mouth. “Well, well, if it isn’t Princess Scorpia. And…the pirate King. How charming.”

They froze, eyes sliding to each other. “Uh, excuse us?”

“Oh, come now,” the clone chuckled. Sea Hawk noticed the other was now staring at the ground, averting his eyes. “You can’t honestly expect me to have no knowledge of those who oppose me so staunchly.”

Sea Hawk felt his stomach drop into his knees. “Prime.”

“So astute.”

Scorpia dropped two of the sacks, tail bristling as she stepped back. They were too far from the gate, just slightly too far, to make a run for it. They’d have to buy themselves time. Sea Hawk let his grain fall to the ground as well. “There’s no need for altercation-”

“Oh, how I do agree.” The clone grinned, and snapped his fingers. The other clone rose back up, and two more materialized in the town square, melting out of shadows. “I’m so glad you see this my way, your Majesties. I truly hate when there's a struggle.”

“Sea Hawk…what is he talking about?” Scorpia frowned. He just shook his head.

“I have no idea. Bad intel, your lordship?” He spat the title like a curse, and the clone just grinned blithely.

"I should hope not. Your…Maevik, was it? Would be a terrible captain if he had such wildly wrong information." His heart was pounding. Maevik? What did he have to do with this? He exchanged a look with Scorpia.

Scorpia whimpered. "The chips. The acting strange. You're… you're…"

"I am simply welcoming new brothers and sisters into my flock, Little Sister," the clone- Prime- sighed. "You will see, you will all see, how much easier it is, how simple and peaceful this life can be, when you just give up your worries, and suffering, to me."

Sea Hawk was shaking his head. "No. You're lying. You don't have Maevik. You- you can't." That would mean they had found Lua Pele. That would mean the end of Salineas. "Liar!"

"Such anger. Such grief. And all of it so preventable." Prime stepped closer, but Sea Hawk stood his ground. He was a head shorter than the clone, but it didn't matter to him. "Aren't you tired of the grief? Of the sadness and the fighting? He was- your Maevik. In the end, he was so *tired* ."

"You. Lie."

"What reason do I have to lie, Brother?" he sneered. "I will admit, though, he was more of a challenge than I expected. It took twice the normal amount of clones to hold him down long enough to show him the way. Sadly, the same can't be said for your smaller friend. Tell me, *Sebastian* , how desperate is your Queen, that she would allow children to fight her battles while she hides away?"

Eliza .

Prime grinned as anguish flickered across his face, and something dark and malicious reared its ugly head in Sea Hawk's chest. He moved like lightning, faster than he could register, too fast to think twice, drawing his blade and running the clone through the stomach.

Scorpia yelled, and Prime's eyes widened in shock, before he winked out of the clone, and possessed the next one.

Sea Hawk yanked his blade out. "Paralyze him, quickly!"

Scorpia swung her tail in a graceful arc, catching the clone in the back and dropping him like a sack of potatoes. The other clones were too far off to stop them from racing through the gate, but they were gaining fast. Sea Hawk slashed at the tethering knots on their horses before holstering his blade and mounting up. Scorpia was already on the cart, snatching up the reins.

"Go! Hyah!" He kicked his horse into a gallop, and the draft horses followed suit. Laser cannon fire flew past their heads, but they were too far to be hit. The Rebel camp was a three hour walk, an hour and a half canter. At this pace, they'd be there in under an hour. He willed his steed faster, making sure Scorpia was keeping up.

Forty-five minutes later, they were forced to slow to a loping canter as the forest grew dense. Scorpia caught up with him to keep pace, and at last turned to him. “Hey, uh…why did Prime call you King? And who’s Maevik? And…why did you stab him like that?”

Sea Hawk’s jaw was tense, but he forced himself to breath and answer kindly. “He called me King because Mermista and I wed three hours before the Heart of Etheria erupted. We’ve kept it under wraps for reasons exactly like that. Maevik is the captain of Mermista’s guard, and…a very, *very* dear friend.”

“Oh. Wow. Uh, congrats?” Scorpia smiled, wobbly. “And you stabbed him because of that?”

“Because I’m angry. And scared. And he…he was taunting me. Prime found our people’s oasis, their last stronghold. He attacked them, he took…” Emotion clogged his throat, and he dashed his sleeve against his eyes. “If what he said is true, then the last of Salineas is gone, enslaved to that mad man. I don’t know how I’ll ever tell Mermista about this.”

“We’ll tell her together.” A heavy pincer landed on his leg, and he met Scorpia’s wet eyes. “I’m…I’m so sorry, Sea Hawk. I really am.”

He knew what she meant, and patted her pincer. “Thank you, my friend.”

They sped up as the forest opened back up, and all but flew into camp, Scorpia leaping off the cart and handing the reins over to a soldier. Sea Hawk rode all the way up to the strategy tent, open to let the spring air in, and brought his horse to an abrupt, rearing stop. Mermista and Perfuma came jogging out to meet them, concern all over their faces. “Sea Hawk, Scorpia, what- what happened?”

Sea Hawk slid off the horse, and felt for all the world like a pirate walking to the gallows as he approached Mermista. Brave, strong, beautiful Mermista, who didn’t deserve this. He gripped her by the biceps, meeting her eyes and knowing she could feel his anguish through their bond.

She blinked, confused and upset and not knowing why. “Sebastian…?” she murmured, hands coming to rest on his chest.

He couldn’t help himself, crushing her body to his in a hug, heedless of the watching eyes.

“We need to talk.”

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It was a long and stressful night, filled with arguments, revisions to plans, rearranging what troops they had available to fall back strategically. Mermista and Netossa stood hunched over maps and itineraries, arguing back and forth desperately with one another, talking with Micah about what the sorcerers could do about some sort of chip-detecting spell.

Shadow Weaver was conversing tersely with Scorpia, who looked scared out of her mind. At some point, Perfuma wandered over and stood next to Scorpia with a vaguely threatening aura that eventually had Shadow Weaver making a disgruntled exit.

Sea Hawk, for his part, was slouched on a cushion, tapping listlessly away at his datapad.

Maevik hadn't answered. Neither had Dhang. The others from Salineas whose datapad codes he had weren't reachable either, and eventually, he had no choice but to give up. He scrubbed a hand through his hair and let the pad fall to the dirt with a soft clatter. A soft hand landed on his shoulder, and he looked up to meet Perfuma's eyes.

The Princess sat next to him, cross legged on the dirt. "Scorpia told me what happened, how you found out…how you saw *him* . I'm so sorry, Captain."

Sea Hawk smiled a bit at his old title turned nickname, so foreign and far away to him now, but it faded quickly. "Yes, it's…hard."

Perfuma hummed. “I think that maybe you should take Mermista and yourself to bed. Or at least for a walk. She needs time to process.”

“I agree, but she’s not going to walk away right now.”

“Sometimes, we have to help the people we love, love themselves.” Perfuma patted his knee. “Even when they don’t want to, we have to take care of them. Right?”

Sea Hawk sighed, and let his head fall into his hands. How had this all happened? It was like the fall of Salineas all over again, but without any time to process their losses. With death, or worse, apparently, biting at their heels, taking a second to breathe seemed suicidal. But he had made a vow to Mermista, to take care of her for better or for worse, in times of prosperity and in hardship, sick or healthy. And Sea Hawk didn’t break promises.

He stood, sparing Perfuma a smile, and walked over to his wife. He laid a careful hand on her tense shoulders, practically shaking with stress. “Mermista.”

“What?” she snapped, trying to shrug off his hand. He gripped her tighter.

“Walk with me.”

“Sea Hawk, I don’t have time-”

“Dearest.” He tugged at her, firm but gentle, until she turned and met his eyes. He saw her resolve cracking, the way she wavered. “Please.”

She huffed, and rolled her eyes, but allowed him to tug her out of the tent and into the cool night air. The other Princesses and Micah, and Swiftwind, had returned just after dinner, at sundown, and it was now nearing midnight. He wrapped Mermista’s hand in his, and marveled silently at the difference in size he never really thought about. Her hands were so strong, and capable, but they were also soft, and fine-boned. Supple chestnut skin, flecked with invisible scales that caught on his thumb as he stroked. His own hands were scarred and calloused and broad-knuckled. A sailor’s hands, built to survive long, salty days of hard labor at sea. They dwarfed hers as he curled her fingers into his, cradling them. Mermista wouldn’t meet his eyes, not even when they passed out of the camp and found a small, meandering path winding away into the woods. He stopped them in a small clearing, tugging her to face him.

“Mermista-”

“ *Don’t.* ” She ripped her hand out of his, wrapping her arms around herself. “Don’t, Sebastian. I don’t want to hear it. I don’t want to hear *any* of it. Not one single word.”

Sea Hawk frowned, but he refused to let her lock herself away from him. He gave her space, hands up, but kept his voice steady as he spoke. "Mermista there was *nothing* we could have done."

"We could have stayed, and fought, and protected them-"

"Then we would be gone, too."

" *So be it!* " She whirled on him, and her eyes were manic. He took a step back. "I am their Queen, their leader, and once again, I left them to fight their own battles, and *lose* -"

"You're trying to end this war for them-"

"What good is that if there's no one left!" she cried, pacing around the clearing. Sea Hawk was reminded of a caged predator, dangerous, waiting for an opportunity to attack. "I should have been there-"

"Well, I'm glad you weren't!" He frowned, holding steady even when she turned incredulous eyes on him. "They got *Maevik* , Mermista. You would be dead, or worse, chipped right now, if you had stayed and I…" He shook his head. "I couldn't live with myself. Call me a terrible person, but I'm…glad you're here. With me."

For a brief moment, he was worried she was about to attack him in her grief. But she didn't. Instead, she just scoffed. "You're not a terrible person…but you are a terrible King. Go."

"Mermista…"

" *I said go!* "

Sea Hawk turned, took two steps, and then stopped. Mermista's voice, younger, angrier, echoed in his head. *'Go ahead, run away. You always leave when things get rough.'*

He turned back, and cleared the space between them in quick, loping strides, grabbing her by the biceps and turning her around none-too-gently. "No. Stop pushing me away. Stop hurting me because you hurt. I…I am not a bad King. I am not a bad husband. And I am *not* a bad person because I want you alive, and safe. Mermista, I love you, more than anything else on this planet, in this whole, new *universe* . And I would do anything for you, even when it's not what you want, as long as it keeps you safe. What would you have me do? Let you stay behind to be enslaved by a megalomaniac dictator just so you can prove something to yourself?"

He shook her by the arms, pleased that she was stunned into silence. "Dying won't make you a good queen. It wasn't what made your mother a good queen, was it? No, it was everything she did before, with her *life* . Living to fight another day, for their freedom, is what makes you a leader. And if keeping you alive so you can save them makes me a bad King, well then…I guess you should've married better."

He let go of her, and turned to leave. He'd said his peace, and now he would leave her to cool off. That wasn't running away, he told himself. Besides, he wasn't going to go far, leaving her alone in these woods was a horrific thought. But a hand shot out, fisting in the fabric of his jacket and holding him in place.

"Sebastian…"

He paused, and turned back to Mermista, seemingly collapsing in on herself as she stood there, trying to stay tall.

Her chin wobbled, even though her jaw was so impossibly tight he could see the strain even in the lowlight. "Please don't leave me."

Like a dam breaking, they fell into each other's arms, barely present enough to land softly on the ground. Sea Hawk didn't feel like busting his hip and ass in addition to everything else going on. Mermista was attached to him like a limpet, and he didn't care one bit, clutching her just as tightly around shaking shoulders. Her nails dug into his back, stinging even through the fabric of his jacket. Sobs wracked her body, just as deep and mournful as they had after Salineas, and just as he had then, he cried with her. It felt like hours, running gentle fingers through her hair, rubbing her arms and back. It hurt worse, now, for him; in the months since the Heart, and the invasion, he had come to love the people of Salineas…his people. The thought still gave him anxiety, but now, there was grief, guilt, anger, all of it useless with nowhere to go at the moment, threatening to drown him instead.

He couldn't think about the faces he had come to know and see every day, Maevik and his dry humor, Eliza's young fire, the mothers and fathers and caretakers of the creche system, the remaining guards, all those he had not only fought with, but lived beside.

Gone.

He didn't realize he was trembling with rage and loss until Mermista ran a hand along his cheek, scratching gently at the stubble. She knew the sensation grounded him, helped him take a deep breath. And he did. The haze at the edges of his vision faded, and he turned to press a tear-streaked kiss to her palm. He scooted back until he could lean against a tree, Mermista slumped against him. Her eyes were red-rimmed, still steadily shedding tears even as her breathing evened out. He wiped one away, only for it to be immediately replaced, running over his thumb to continue down her chin.

"I'm sorry."

He opened his mouth, to reassure her, and then closed it. She *had* hurt him in her pain. She knew his insecurities, about his title, about even their marriage, some days, and had turned it against him. At a loss for a response, he just shrugged, leaning his head against the tree and shutting his eyes. "I know."

He felt her head come to rest against his chest, ear above his heart, and traced her jaw with lazy fingers. Her shoulders shook a few more times. “I shouldn’t have said that. I didn’t mean it at all, Sebastian. I swear it.”

He nodded again. “Okay. I believe you.”

“Do you…are we okay?”

“Are we?” He raised his head to look at her, holding her gaze for only a second before breaking it to look back down at the forest floor.

“Sebastian.” She guided his eyes back to hers with a hand along his jaw. She shifted to support herself more so she could cup his jaw in both hands. “I love you. Even when I’m bad at showing it. When I’m mean, or rude, or tired, or…this. I love you.” She blinked, more tears falling as she fought to find words. “I love you more than any single other thing that exists…even my kingdom, and sometimes I feel so guilty about that. But there was a time where they weren’t loyal to me…when you were. And I’ve never forgotten that.” She leaned her forehead against his, and her tears fell onto his own cheeks. “I get it, you know. I’m not the easiest person to love, I understand that. But-”

“No.”

“No?”

“Don’t say that about yourself.” His arms came up to hold her. “Not to me. Mermista, loving you is the most natural thing in the world. It’s part of who I am, part of what makes me *me* . And I’m proud of that. Not because it’s tough, but because it’s easy. I am privileged enough to see and know parts of you that no one else does, and those moments that we share are what make it… simple. How could I not love you, when you’ve trusted me with all that you are? Yourself, your kingdom, your hopes and dreams, all of it. Neither of us are perfect, and, yes, what you said really hurt. But I would rather stand by your side, fighting because we’re alive, than ever entertain the alternatives.”

“Shut up.” Mermista smiled through her tears. They shifted so she was straddling his legs, and he bent his knees up to bracket her against his body. “Stupid, poetic bastard.”

“ *Your* stupid poetic bastard.” He smiled against her neck, pressing light kisses.

“Never doubt that,” she whispered. “No matter what happens, what this war does to us, promise me that you will never forget you’re mine. Mine to me.”

“Never, dearest.” He wrapped his arms around her, cradling her to his body with every inch of him. “Promise me the same. That you’ll never forget I love you. I adore you, every part of you, and I always will.” He smiled at her, and she returned it softly. “You’re still my best friend, you know, after all these years.”

“Yeah, well…” She tried to roll her eyes, but aborted halfway through. “You’re mine, too.”

“I think as long as we remember that, we’ll be okay.”

Chapter End Notes

> We’re coming down the line! I hope y’all stay with me and stay reviewing, they really make my whole day. If you enjoyed or not, drop me a line!
>
> Forewarning: about 80% of the next chapter is just sex so if that’s not your cup of tea I’m going to try to do two fast uploads ! See you then!

hours and hours

Chapter Summary

Mermista and Sea Hawk steal a few hours for themselves before the Underwater Grotto Soirée

Chapter Notes

THIS CHAPTER IS EXPLICIT. FULL STOP.

It's literally pretty much just sex. Monster-fucking, kinky sex. If you like that, read on! If not, I'll have the next chapter out within the next few days, pinky promise.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next few days were a haze of preparations for last-minute troop gathering missions. Sea Hawk, Mermista, Perfuma, and Scorpia would be going undercover to find Peekablue. Mermista was exhausted from planning and leading, and yet, she was one of the only ones still awake the night before their mission. Sea Hawk and Scorpia had both begged off after night patrol, and Perfuma and Mermista had let them. The rest of the camp had followed shortly, until it was only the two of them still awake. Or… so they thought.

"Guys? Aren't you going to bed?" Frosta pushed the tent open, rubbing her eyes and yawning. She was getting taller, almost up to Mermista's chest now, but she was still little to them.

"In a bit, Frosta." Perfuma ghosted a motherly hand over deep blue hair, frowning as she examined another map. "I don't think the tides are going to be shifted like this."

Mermista let herself fall into a plush cushion, narrowly avoiding banging her elbow on the low table. “Whatever. Let Sea Hawk handle that tomorrow, he knows how the Grotto works. What’s up, kid?”

Frosta shrugged, tossing herself into an adjacent cushion. “Dunno. Can’t sleep. Everything feels…weird. Like everyone’s holding their breath.”

“Well, we are, in a way.” Perfuma sat down elegantly in the remaining cushion. “But you do need the rest.”

“I will, it’s just…you know. It’s hard.” Frosta looked down at the table, suddenly shy. “Ever since Scorpia started sleeping over with you, it’s a little bit harder to fall asleep. I guess I got used to having someone there.”

“Hold up, pump the breaks.” Mermista’s head whipped around to Perfuma. “You’re having *sleepovers* ?”

Perfuma spluttered. “Sometimes-”

“All the time.” Frosta’s grin could best be described as ‘shit-eating’.

“Often!” Perfuma huffed, and then blushed. “Things are crazy right now, and I didn’t know if we should wait, or go for it, or what, and now things are just kind of…happening.”

“Huh.” Mermista shrugged. “Never would’ve pegged you for someone to just…let things happen, ‘Fuma.”

“I’m *not* ,” she all but wailed, head dropping to lay on the smooth wood of the table. “That’s why this is all so confusing.”

Mermista chewed her lip, taking in her companions before making a swift decision. “Well, I’m too keyed up to sleep, and Frosta needs buddies, and you definitely need to work through whatever the hell is going on with you, so…Princess sleepover?”

Frosta lit up, and Perfuma smiled. “I’ll get my stuff!”

“Same!”

“Meet back in five.”

Mermista popped over to her tent to grab her pillow, and whatever blanket Sea Hawk was willing to part with. To her surprise, he was still up, tapping away at his pad and scribbling on some paper. He looked up when she came in. “Bed time?”

“Actually, would you mind if I had a little sleepover with Frosta and Perfuma in the strategy tent? We kinda need the vibes, or whatever.”

Sea Hawk stood and stretched, spine cracking into place. He walked over to press a kiss to her forehead. “Of course I don’t mind, my love. I’m going to be up working for a while anyway.”

“On what?”

“I’m trying to decode the latest password for the Grotto through all the chatter on the servers. Despite everything going on, business is still booming.”

“Typical,” she sneered. “I’m shutting it down once we get Salineas back up and running.”

“A wise decision.” He leaned down to kiss her softly, and then helped her bundle up a blanket, and pillow, and grabbed her pajamas. As she changed, he took off his jacket, and he draped it around her shoulders when she was done. “Here.”

“Why?” She frowned at him.

“Because you get cold, and one blanket won’t be enough, and I won’t be there to warm you up. So, jacket!”

She smiled, and rewarded his thoughtful kindness with a gentle peck on his stubbled cheek. “Thanks, babe. You need to shave tomorrow before the soiree.”

“Yes, yes, it’s on my list.” He rapped the datapad’s stylus against his head. “Go, enjoy yourself.”

“Love you.” She smiled over her shoulder, and he winked back.

“Love you, too.”

Mermista did her best to wipe the smile off her face by the time she got back to the tent, but between her lack of success and the jacket around her shoulders, she was a fresh hunk of gossip mill meat to the ravenous Princesses waiting for her. “OOoooooh!”

“Shut up!” she groaned, dumping her pillow and blanket onto her cushion. The other two just laughed. “I thought we were here to talk about Perfuma’s relationship, not mine.”

“We can multitask.”

It was a sign that she was growing up when, instead of rolling her eyes, Frosta propped her chin on her hands and stared between the two of them. “Well, who’s first?”

“Perfuma is.” Mermista fished around in the bag of nuts someone had pillaged from the food stores. “Go ahead, girl. Spill.”

“I-I just…I don’t know.” Perfuma slumped to rest her head on her crossed arms. “Whenever I saw myself getting serious about a relationship, it was at a much slower pace than this. I always told myself I wasn’t going to do the whirlwind war romance because I’m just not built for that stress- no offense, Mermista.”

“None taken.”

“But now it’s happening, and the idea of stopping it makes me…hurt? I feel guilty for even thinking I should? Because who cares about what I thought in theory, when this is happening now, in reality. Am I making sense?”

“Yeah, you are.” Mermista nudged her with her foot. “Not to be, like, a total gross cliche, but you need to listen to your heart right now, not the thoughts of a Perfuma who doesn’t really exist anymore. And, not to get too morbid, but we don’t exactly know how much time we have left. Could be decades. Could be a week. Why would you waste any time on what you *should* do when it doesn’t, like, align with what you *want* to do.”

Perfuma stared at her long and hard, one of those fathomless gazes that made Mermista want to avert her eyes. At length, she nodded. “That…that helps, actually.”

“I don’t know much about this stuff.” Frosta stood, dragging her cushion around the table to sit between them, and sprawled so her head was in Perfuma’s lap, her feet in Mermista’s. “But…I do know you, and now, I know Scorpia. And I think you make each other happy at a time when that’s not very easy to find. So, why would you do anything to stop that, y’know?”

“Do you…really think it’s that simple?” Perfuma sighed, running gentle fingers through Frosta’s fine, thick hair.

Mermista shrugged. “Why shouldn’t it be? It’s your life, girl. You make the rules. Don’t overthink it.”

Perfuma snorted. “That’s a bit ironic coming from you, ‘Mista.”

“Shut up.” Mermista flushed, opting to focus on tying Frosta’s shoelaces together. “We worked it out eventually.”

“Oh, yes, I would certainly say you did.” Perfuma smirked.

Frosta looked between them, frowning. “What are you guys talking about? You’re doing that secret-y, ‘saying things without saying them’ thing.”

What followed was a very intricate non-verbal argument between the two elder Princesses, complete with emphatic eyerolls, pursed lips, and dancing brows. It ended with Mermista groaning, apparently having lost. "Okay, kid, this isn't, like, hot gossip, and it has to stay under wraps for, like, security reasons or whatever. But you're the only Princess currently on this planet who doesn't know, which is lame. So, F.Y.I., Sea Hawk and I got married in a, like, Salinean confluence. So, semi-legal. It's not a big deal at all."

Frosta was staring at her like she'd grown another head. "You're *married?!* "

"Uh, yeah, did I not *just* say-"

"Where's your ring, then?"

Mermista rolled her eyes, but unclipped her armored neckpiece and set it aside on the table so she could pull out the chain with her rings on it. Perfuma all but lunged for it, but Frosta's head digging into her abdomen stopped her, so Mermista took it off entirely. Despite the slight weight of the rings and thin chain, she felt suddenly…vulnerable.

Perfuma took the rings gently, and Frosta, despite her typically tomboyish nature, sat up to eye them with interest. Mermista knew they were gorgeous, and the way they twined together to almost form one, concentric band was reminiscent of her magic at work. The jeweler had done a wonderful job. She hoped he was alright.

“‘Mista, they’re beautiful,” Perfuma breathed. “When did you have them done?”

“Sea Hawk had the jeweler make the engagement ring years ago, I think. And after we were betrothed, I had the same jeweler make the wedding rings.”

“How did he propose?”

“Oh, he didn’t.”

Frosta looked at her, confusion writ across her brow. “Then…how did you get betrothed?”

Mermista took the rings back gratefully, and slipped them onto her right hand. They sparkled beautifully in the lowlight, and she mourned the fact that she couldn’t wear them where they belonged. “After the portal, we were sailing back to Salineas. I was getting cold so he gave me his jacket, and I found the ring in the pocket. So, I put it on, and waited for him to see it.”

Frosta giggled. Perfuma looked delightfully scandalized. “Mer *mista!* When did he notice?”

“Oh, like four hours after the fact. C’mon. It’s Sea Hawk.” The two other Princesses fell onto each other giggling. Mermista allowed herself a few chuckles. “But like, enough about me. Who else can we gossip about?”

“Did you girls notice how much Bow and Adora were pining before they left?”

“Ugh! Tell me about it!”

“Gross.”

Hours later, too many hours later, Mermista was stumbling back to her tent, the rosy, hazy light of dawn just barely enough to see by. They had all passed out for a while on the tent’s cushions, but she’d woken up freezing cold, and alone, which was a novel feeling for her these days. She hadn’t slept a night without Sea Hawk at her side in a bit over a year. The thought brought her up short as she pushed open the flap of their tent.

Sea Hawk was sound asleep, but she moved carefully. He’d always been a light sleeper, having been raised with the mindset of needing to be out of bed and ready to run, fight, or work at a moment’s notice. The war had only made it worse. He slept between her and the entrance to the tent always, and kept a vice grip on her waist. Part of her was annoyed by it- she was more than capable of defending herself- but mostly, she knew he needed to do it more for himself than her, so she allowed it.

She slipped into bed carefully, and he woke up just like she knew he would. “Mermista? What’s wrong, are you-?”

“Sshhhh…” She pressed her fingertips gently to his mouth, smiling when he relaxed enough to kiss them. “We went back to our tents. Too old to sleep on beanbags, I guess. And I like, missed you, or whatever.”

Sea Hawk grinned, and pulled her into his chest. “Little old me?”

“Don’t make a big deal out of it.” Mermista rolled her eyes, and settled deeper into his arms. “Nervous for later?”

“A bit. I think I’m more excited to sail again, though.”

They would have to take his ship to the Grotto, as Sea Worthy was too far to walk in finery, and riding horses would ruin the clothes they so painstakingly acquired. So, they would sail, and hope the darkness of night would keep them shielded from any Horde bots. Sea Hawk would be readying the ship with full sails, so they could keep the engine off. “Do you need any help getting the ship ready?”

“Can you spare the time?” Sea Hawk pressed idle kisses to her forehead, temple, nose as he spoke, and she basked in his affection here in the privacy of their tent. “I know you’ve got things to do here.”

“Netossa can handle it.” Mermista ran her lips along his jaw, not quite kissing. “Besides, no one else here can help you, so it’ll just be the two of us. For the whole day. On your ship.”

Sea Hawk’s eyes flew open, realization hitting him like a sack of bricks. “Yes. Yes, I desperately need your help. Without your nautical expertise, we definitely won’t be able to sail tonight.” He punctuated each sentence with deeper and deeper kisses until Mermista was panting needily into his mouth.

“How awake are you right now?” she breathed.

Sea Hawk grinned, and tossed the covers off of them. He threw her usual armor at her, hopping into his pants and shirt. Mermista smothered a laugh in her hand and got dressed herself, tossing his jacket to him. He grabbed their weapons, and they shoved their feet into their shoes and all but ran out of the tent.

Mermista found Netossa, already awake and sitting by the fire.

“Hey, we’ve got to get the ship ready to sail for tonight, and it’s gonna be sort of an all day situation soooo…” Mermista shrugged. “Don’t need me, I guess?”

Netossa nodded, but her smirk was knowing. “Good luck, you two. With the, uh, *preparations* .”

“Thanks.” Mermista tossed over her shoulder, sauntering out of camp with Sea Hawk at her side.

As soon as they knew the forest was shielding them, they took off for the river at a sprint, whooping and hollering, pushing and teasing and laughing like little kids. Anticipation, hot and needy, was sweeping through Mermista’s body in waves. The river, freezing as it was, did little to cool it. She transformed as soon as she was shoulder deep, turning to offer Sea Hawk an arm.

“Just like the treasure hunt, yeah?” Sea Hawk nodded, and took a deep breath. Mermista took his hand and dove down, resisting the urge to swim as fast as she could- she really didn’t want to dislocate her husband’s shoulder right before a huge mission. But the water rushing around her felt wonderful on her scales, and her heart ached with how much she had missed this feeling. Fish swam by her, and her stomach growled. Camp food was sustainable, non-perishable, and kept them all fueled, but it wasn’t anywhere near good. Sushi, however, was a delicacy. She felt the teeth in her mouth changing, elongating and sharpening and thickening. Her gills were working overtime, and with each “breath” she could smell more and more fish. Sea Hawk tugging on her hand distracted her, and she pushed fresh air into his lungs after he exhaled. She tried not to let him see or feel her mouth, but it was somewhat inevitable.

He pulled back, concern radiating from him. He gestured to his mouth, and signed. *Sharp teeth?*

Mermista shrugged as nonchalantly as possible. “The fish smell good. I, like, haven’t eaten anything but camp protein shit in weeks.”

Sea Hawk nodded, and gestured. *You should eat, then.*

She wrinkled her nose. “I’m not hunting in front of you, or eating. In case you didn’t catch my drift, I really want to fuck you on the ship.”

He grinned. *So?*

“It’s gross. And disturbing.”

You could never be anything less than beautiful to me, dearest.

“Shut uuuuup,” she groaned. “It’s fine. I’ll be alright.”

He grabbed her wrist again, onyx eyes boring holes in her defenses as his voice echoed in her head. *Mermista. Eat. I want you to.*

Her stomach growled again just as a massive school of salmon came into view. They were near the estuary that the ship was hidden in. Her mouth was salivating, jaw practically aching to sink her teeth into the soft, pliant scales. Her vision was sharpening, and she knew her pupils were swallowing up her irises. “Fine. But, like, don’t say I didn’t warn you.”

She turned, and pushed one last breath into him before darting away. Circling wide, she disappeared into the slightly turbid water around them, her blue-green scales and top camouflaging her. The school of salmon was none the wiser, pivoting and darting around as they swam steadily toward him. Sea Hawk watched them, mesmerized by the way their scales glittered and shone in the watery sunlight.

The salmon seemed to sense the danger gradually, the exterior of the school suddenly turning or diving and speeding away. The interior wasn’t so lucky, turning about as if confused, agitation obvious. They weren’t stressed for very long. Mermista shot into the school from the vague left, and Sea Hawk caught a glimpse of too-many, too-sharp teeth. They didn’t push out like a shark’s jaw, nor did her eyes roll back, but her jaw did seem to be open wider than it should be able to. He swallowed- not in fear or disgust, that was for certain- and licked his lips. He never got tired of seeing this side of Mermista, especially after such a long time out of the water for both of them.

She sank her teeth into the salmon’s gill area, and blood pooled around them, obscuring her face. The fish’s tail, jerking and flopping in the throes of death, was the only thing visible through the cloud, and eventually even that fell still. Seconds later, a thoroughly picked clean fish carcass was drifting to the ocean floor, and the dirty water was magically moved deeper into the river.

Mermista floated back over, avoiding eye contact and picking scales out of her teeth. Once satisfied, she pushed more air into his lungs. It just tasted like she'd eaten extremely fresh sushi, so he pulled her closer, turning the exchange into a kiss. She sighed against him, relaxing.

Sea Hawk had experienced many exhilarating things in his adventurous life. He had ridden sea serpents, found buried treasure, blown up ships and harbors and even people, had had sword fights on masts of ships- he could fill book after book with his tales, even without exaggeration. But nothing was half so mind-blowing as kissing Mermista.

From their first kiss, he'd known no one would ever compare again. Everything, from the way she grabbed his jaw, or scratched his stubble in the mornings, to how she teased him with her lips and tongue, drove him wild. Even the softest of kisses could leave him aching for her, for more. Mermista loathed words, but she more than made up for it in her actions; everything she struggled to vocalize he heard loud and clear when she kissed him.

They broke apart, and Mermista groaned, rolling her scaled hips against his pelvis. "C'mon, let's get to the ship so I can get my legs back."

Sea Hawk bit his lip, and gestured toward the surface. She pushed a bit more air into him, before nodding and going to scan the surface. The early morning sunlight was warm and watery as it filtered through the trees and onto the water. Mermista scanned the area around them, remaining submerged up to her eyes; she couldn't see or hear any signs of Horde activity, even after staying still for a few seconds. Gently, she pulled Sea Hawk to the surface with her hydrokinesis, and let him breathe on his own while she circled lazily around him.

Typically, resisting her more primal Merfolk urges was easy, but lately it had become a challenge. She figured it was the stress of the war, her life and her husband's being in near-constant danger. Or maybe her biochemistry was shifting as she grew further into adulthood; by Mer standards, she was barely out of her adolescent phase, despite being well into adulthood by human standards. Whatever the reason, she found herself, even on land, circling Sea Hawk, especially in group settings. On the rare occasions they could be intimate, she couldn't stop herself from leaving an absurd amount of hickies, scratch marks, bruises, or from running her tongue up his throat until it looked raw. He didn't know that she could smell herself on him for days, from no small distance away. It reassured her, settled some frenzied part of her.

Sea Hawk reached out and grabbed her arm, stopping her circling to tug her to him. Years of sailing- and jumping off burning ships- had given him plenty of experience treading water for hours on end, so he had no issue lingering above the water with her. And if he did, he knew she could hold him up. He wrapped strong arms around her, and brought their lips together for a heated kiss. Her tongue moved against his as they teased each other into a fervor. One of his hands trailed down her waist to caress the place where her skin met scale. The area was bracketed off by her gold belt, but he scraped her skin with one nail, and her scales with another, and she moaned brokenly against his mouth. "Yes… *more* .."

Sea Hawk smiled as he trailed kisses down her jaw, past her raised gill ridges, and along her collarbone. Her top felt heavy and cumbersome- this was exactly why she swam topless. Well, that and other reasons that had everything to do with Sea Hawk. His fingertips were snaking up under her tank, brushing against her breasts, tweaking her nipple. She whined against his mouth, shifting to run her tongue over his stubble- he'd have to shave on the ship. He gasped as she sucked his earlobe- earrings and all- into her mouth, and his hand flew to cup her ass. Well, where her ass would technically be. He ground his hips against her and she groaned at how hard he clearly was, despite his tight pants and the cold water. "Mermista, it's been too long, please-"

"Ship," she panted, even as her hands betrayed her, flying to struggle with the laces of his pants. "Gotta get to the ship."

"No," he growled in her ear, nipping at it. "Here."

"Sebastian," she groaned, rolling her scaled hips. "It's…that's a bit more complicated. The ship is just there-"

"I need you, Mermista." He pulled away to look at her, and she was taken aback by the naked desperation in his eyes, the pure, unfiltered *want* . "I- I need to be in you again, it's been weeks-"

"Shhh…" She pressed a slightly softer kiss to his lips, stemming the flow of his words. He was right, it *had* been weeks since they'd had time for anything other than fast handjobs or maybe, if they were lucky, oral. Her body missed him, the shape of him, how he felt buried in her heat. More than anything, she missed the level of connectivity it created. Their marital bond cried out, and whether it was from her or just echoing his own desire, she felt it sweep through her and knew she would cave to it. "Alright. But you need to, like, let me guide you, kay?"

Sea Hawk scanned her face carefully. "Can you…legs?"

"I can't, it'll hurt too much in water this salty." She trailed kisses down his throat, and *finally* got his soaked laces untied and dipped her hand below his waistband. They moaned together when she got one hand around his rigid shaft. "My gods, this shit's like my trident."

"Like I- ahh- said, I've really missed you." Sea Hawk hissed as she worked her hand up and down his length. Mermista took a breath, taking in his scent, feeling his lust echo her own across the bond. Carefully, keeping eyes on his face for any signs of discomfort or disturbance, she pulled him free of his pants, and brought the head to rest against her pelvic region. His own eyes opened and met hers, and they held the charged connection as she shuddered, scales rippling as they started to part underneath his most sensitive skin. His mouth fell open softly, pleasure clouding his eyes. "What…are you-?"

"Yeah," she breathed, somewhat bashful. "Is this…okay?"

Sea Hawk chuckled softly, twitching in her hand. "You have no idea how long I've wanted to ask about this. Since I first saw you, actually."

She flushed, but kept her focus on their bodies. "Do you…you can touch me, if you want. Just, careful?"

He ducked to kiss her, chaste considering their position. "Always, dearest." His hand left her chest, trailing a path down her body to where she held him against her. Her scales were still shifting minutely, and he pressed against the softest, most sensitive part of her tail, typically shielded by a paper thin, nearly invisible curtain of harder scales. They were pulled apart now, leaving the much softer hind scales exposed. Sea Hawk ran gentle knuckles along the slick patch of scales, and she cried out, shutting her eyes against the electric sensation.

Mermista had certainly fooled around on her own in her mermaid form, but had never, ever taken a partner. Fantasized? Sure. But the list of people who wanted to be intimate with what they perceived to be a fish with tits? Not long. The legends told about her kind had never painted them in a favorable light- sirenic, evil, rough, wanton, cold, on and on. Outside her own kingdom, and even then, outside the capital, prejudice still lived in the stories and tall tales told in taverns and ports, on ships at sea. She had made her peace with that perception a very long time ago, and at times, even leaned into it. People left her alone when she did.

Well, most people. The man carefully parting her slit and stroking her to a heady orgasm had long since been in a league of his own.

Mermista was fighting to keep her voice down, but it was becoming difficult. Sea Hawk had no idea how crazy he was driving her; the softer scales were almost as sensitive as her clit was when she had legs, and he had yet to actually delve into her.

Her grip on his length had slackened, but she pushed herself to rally and come back to her body. Gently, she tugged his shaft closer, until once against his head was pushing against her slit. He looked at her, and she nodded, and he pushed gently, shallow thrusts to ease her open. Slowly, her scales split under him, welcoming him into her heat. She stilled him with a hand on his inked, scarred shoulder. "Okay, this next part is…it can be jarring."

"Alright." Sea Hawk nodded, sweat dotting his brow. "What's up?"

"It's not, like, my usual…set up?" Mermista buried her head in her hand. "Gods, this is so embarrassing to try and say."

"Dearest…" He drew her into a soft kiss. "No part of you is disturbing, or off-putting, or scary to me. I swear it, and I'll prove it, too."

Mermista took a deep breath. "Okay. Alright. I…it's not unlike a sort of…vice? It's like, designed to grab, and hold the, uh, male. And, like, do all the work."

Sea Hawk nodded gamely. "Does it hurt?"

"It, uh, didn't hurt me whenever I, y'know…played around," Mermista didn't know if she was more red from embarrassment or arousal. Her body was *throbbing* , especially with the tip of Sea Hawk's cock nestled in her. "But if it starts hurting, like, at all, you have to tell me."

"Safe word is still anchor?"

"Always."

"Alright." Sea Hawk kissed her again, and thrust gently further into her. "Let's try this."

Mermista nodded, and took him all the way into her. He stretched her more in this form than her human one, and she groaned at the sensation of being so full. Within seconds, her walls had clamped around him, drawing him in to the hilt, leaving them flush against one another. He couldn't tread water like this, so she kept their heads and shoulders above water with small flicks of her tail and her hydrokinesis. Mermista let her head fall forward to rest against his shoulder, and waited for him to nod. "Ready."

"'Kay." What little hold she had left over her most primal of urges fell away, and her body took over. Her walls squeezed Sea Hawk hard, and he cried out in pleasure. She moved her hands down to cup his ass and tug him impossibly further into her, and in that moment, their eyes locked and their bond practically exploded with pleasure.

The magic of their marriage wreathed them in its arcane grasp, and Mermista could feel both her own pleasure, and Sea Hawk's as her own. She was penetrating and being penetrated, sheathed in her own warmth, being pumped by her walls. Sea Hawk was feeling the same, she knew. It was as if their bodies had fallen away, and the physical walls keeping their essences separated dissipated with them. They were one, running together and merging just like the estuary around them. She undulated against him with each pump of her body, and it was only seconds before it was too much- the bond, her sensitive scales rubbing against his rough trousers, how full she was. “Sea Hawk- I can’t- I’m going to- *!* ”

“I’m with you,” he grunted, hanging on to her. “I can’t last, ‘Mista.”

“Then don’t.” Her tail coiled itself around one of his legs, immobilizing him entirely, while her body took what it wanted from him, working him in and out of her in thrusts. He lasted two more seconds before he was smothering cries in her shoulder, spilling deep into her body. His orgasm rushed along the bond to her, and one last thrust brought his leather-clad hips slamming back into her overstimulated scales. She came hard, squeezing his cock so tightly inside her that she momentarily feared for it and him. But she sensed only pleasure from his body, and let herself keep on. Orgasming was different without legs, her tail instead vibrating and thrashing below them, having released Sea Hawk’s leg. After the waves abated, she slumped further into the water, panting hard.

Sea Hawk was stroking her hair, moving his legs slightly to keep them up while she recovered. Her body released him slowly, and the cold water against her soft scales made her shiver with aftershocks of pleasure.

She pulled away from his shoulder to glance at him carefully. “Good?”

“Try absolutely mind-blowing,” he chuckled, pressing kisses to her shoulder.

Her tail twitched back to life, propelling her upright on her own. She was still shuddering minutely, draped languidly over Sea Hawk now.

“Are you still…?”

“...kinda, yeah,” she mumbled into his wet clothes. “But we seriously need to get to the ship.”

“Hmmm, I suppose we do.” Sea Hawk’s nose nuzzled her temple and Mermista felt for a moment like she could purr. “I intend to fuck you on or against every available surface, and we still need to prep her to sail, so...”

“Someone’s thinking with the wrong head,” Mermista snorted, but made no other protest. Small aftershocks were still rippling her body, but her scales were back in place and she was becoming too aware of their exposure. “Ready to dive again?”

He nodded, this time shifting to cling to her shoulders from behind, streamlining them more efficiently. Once his lungs were full, she dove down a good ten or so feet and took off toward the cove where they’d docked the ship. The fish and river fauna gave them a wide berth, save for some young otters. They swam alongside them, curious and squeaking, and it took everything in her body for Mermista not to stop and play with them. They were, like, stupid cute. As it were, she gave the bravest and closest one a few pets before gliding on. They surfaced every five minutes for Sea Hawk to breathe, and it was maybe half an hour before the river was opening up into the larger estuary.

The currents here were a mess, ocean meeting river in a confusing dance, and Mermista held onto Sea Hawk with both her hands as she twisted and turned, until they reached the small cave they'd used to get in and out of the hidden cove. The ship could sail out a back channel, but this kept them from being seen, and giving away the position to any watching eyes.

Once they were on the deck, and Mermista had pulled the water off of them both, it was a fervid race to see who could strip the other first. The ship was hidden by weeping willow branches, thick foliage blossoming with flowers in the mid-summer heat. The cove was just large enough for the ship, giving maybe twenty feet of excess room on all sides, and covered in lily pads and small flowers. Mermista thought it was beautiful, as far as non-oceanic views went. Maybe after the soiree they could come back and have a midnight picnic, sleep under the stars. Among other activities, of course; Mermista knew the outfits she picked out for them for tonight were going to drive Sea Hawk wild. He loved when they matched, and he loved her in a suit.

That was, if she could still walk tonight; the rough intensity with which her pirate's hands were tearing at her clothes gave her pause. His mouth was hot and fervent against hers, and she moaned louder than she meant to when he sucked her bottom lip between his teeth.

“So fucking hot- missed you- need you, need to feel you-” he babbled against her mouth.

“Sebastian, please-”

“Fuck yeah, say my name,” he growled, moving down to bite at her shoulder. Her knees wobbled, and he backed her up against the mast. Her back hit the wood hard, but the pain mingled with the pleasure headily. “Say my name, baby, it’s been so long-”

“Sebastian,” she moaned into his ear, hand dropping to his pelvis, where she found him already hard again. “Gods, I love you-”

He groaned, and she grinned against his hair; all the lingerie, posturing, ropes, and fantasies in the world couldn’t compare to how he came undone when she spoke her love openly to him. He bucked against her hand, and she decided they didn’t have the time, patience, or need for more foreplay. She nipped the shell of his earth and dropped to her knees unceremoniously, ripping at the laces of his pants until they were loose enough to drag his ridiculously tight and sexy leather pants down enough to free his cock.

Mermista salivated at the sight of it, grabbing it gently to run her tongue over the head again and again until it was leaking precum, and Sea Hawk had to brace himself against the mast behind her with one hand. The other rested on the back of her head, fisting in her thick hair. She looked up at him, and held eye contact as she swallowed the length of him down, barely even tearing with all of him settled deep in her throat.

He was iron in her mouth, twitching furiously in a search for friction she wouldn't give him yet. He broke first, as he always did, shutting his eyes with a groan. "Mermista, love, *please* …"

She wrapped her hands around the backs of his thighs, cupping his ass, and slapped him hard. He yelped, bucking forward in surprise and shoving himself down her throat. She moaned, tears springing to her eyes at the sweet burn, and he understood what she wanted. Gently at first, and then harder and harder, he slammed into her, fucking her throat. Mermista had never imagined herself not only enjoying the sensation of her husband's cock pressing against the walls of her throat, but missing it so much it had become a craving in the past few weeks. She'd always enjoyed sucking him off, but this was something else. It clicked when the bond suddenly pulsed with pleasure; *he* had been craving this, missing her mouth around him, making obscene, lewd noises that one rarely heard outside of the highest end brothels. And his want had become so strong it had bled into her.

She pushed her own enjoyment along the bond, and his hips stuttered their rhythm. She moved a hand from his ass to his balls, cupping them, scraping lightly with her nails, rolling them around.

Sea Hawk's mouth fell open, and his grip in her hair tightened. "Mermista- I-I'm gonna- *hah* -"

It was at this point the planets aligned most stupidly, and several poorly-timed unfortunate events happened at once; Mermista was thoroughly out of air, and Sea Hawk was at the end of his control. She tapped his leg hard twice, but he didn't feel it through the orgasm creeping up on him, so she grabbed his hand in hers and yanked it off her head.

She pulled back quickly- too quickly, apparently, as the sensation proved to be Sea Hawk's undoing. He shouted, ripping his hand out of hers to grab his shaft, but it was too late. Mermista barely got one breath in before he was coming directly in her face. She shut her eyes on instinct, yelping as ropes of come landed on her face, her hair, her chest. No small amount got in her mouth, but that was where she had intended it to end up anyway, so she didn't care much about that.

A few seconds later, she opened her eyes to glare viciously up at him. " *Dude.* "

"I am *so* sorry, dearest." His eyes were wide, cheeks flushed with orgasm, embarrassment, and…arousal.

"Don't tell me this is doing something for you," she deadpanned.

He just swallowed, looking elsewhere.

She snorted. "Seriously?"

“It’s not like I meant for this to happen!” he wailed, clearly feeling pretty awful.

Mermista, despite her frustration (come was so hard to get out of her hair, it wasn’t funny at all), found amusement bubbling up in her chest at the frankly ridiculous situation. Maybe she could have some fun at his expense.

When he looked back down, getting nervous that her silence meant certain doom for him, she held his gaze and licked her bottom lip lewdly. His eyes dilated, tracking her tongue.

With a smirk, she cupped her bare breasts, pushing them together lifting them up to her mouth; she licked another few drops off her chest, slowly, lazily. Her tongue ran over her wedding rings, resting in the valley of her breasts.

Sea Hawk groaned, the hand still on his semi-hard cock pumping it softly. Arousal shot straight to her sex at the situation, and they both paused.

As one, they broke and dissolved into slightly hysterical giggles. Mermista dropped her tits to brace herself on Sea Hawk’s hips as she pitched forward from the force of her snorts. Sea Hawk’s knees hit the deck a second later, and he wrapped her in his arms as they fell over in a heap.

“This is the stupidest fucking way to figure out a new kink,” she cackled, burying the sound in his chest.

Sea Hawk’s laughter boomed across the deck and into her body. “But so fun, dearest!”

“Speak for yourself! I am so fucking sticky, you asshole!” She smacked his pec, but he only laughed harder, rolling away slightly. She pulled some water out of the cove, washing off her face and chest before setting to work on her hair. She sat up and leaned her back against the mast as she worked, so focused on the drying mess in her hair that Sea Hawk tugging her leggings down shocked her enough to kick out.

He neatly dodged her foot, only raising an eyebrow to check that she was okay. She grinned and nodded, settling back against the mast while he tossed her leggings toward the door to the captain’s quarters. She was entirely bare now, save for her rings. Sea Hawk was shirtless, but he’d dragged his pants back up to sit loosely around his hips. His cock, hard again thanks to his legendarily short recovery period, hung out of it, and he worked it lazily as he settled between her legs. Mermista gasped as his lips connected with her sensitive skin, trailing toward her lips. He chuckled as he reached her sex.

“What?”

“You still have scales down here.” His head popped up, resting against her thigh. His eyes were so full of love and adoration, it was almost nauseating. “It’s cute.”

She rolled her eyes. "Whatever, dork- *ah!* " Sea Hawk had ducked back down, and ran his tongue flat against those scales. They were incredibly sensitive, and the sensation cut straight to her throbbing clit. "Sea Hawk- Sebastian, baby- please-"

She could feel him smiling against her sex, but he said nothing, instead licking a slow strip from her entrace to her clit. She groaned, just barely hanging onto the water she was using to clean her hair still. It became a sort of game, then; he tried to undo her focus, she fought to hang onto it and get clean. Neither was really losing. Sea Hawk had a talented tongue in all regards; he could charm the pants of any dignitary (case in point), compose poetry and song, sing with actual talent when he chose to, kiss her mind blank, and, of course, this.

He alternated between light strokes on her clit, fast side-to-side flicks, gentle sucking, kisses. It was only minutes before she was moaning brokenly into the open air, unable to cover her mouth thanks to the task at hand. After one particularly rough bout of sucking, she decided *fuck it* , and tossed the water back in the direction of the cove. Hands free, she fisted both in Sea Hawk's hair, tugging him impossibly closer against her sex, grinding into him. The friction of his mustache, his stubble burning her thighs, was all ratcheting her higher and higher. With one hard tug, he pulled them both backwards so her back hit the deck, laying her flat out. He tossed her legs over his shoulders and got to his knees, lifting her hips and lower back off the deck. She wailed, losing her grip on his hair and any sense of grounded direction. Her mind and body were starting to float beyond her.

His tongue left her clit briefly, and she whined, but it found her entrance and she moaned. He tongue fucked her relentlessly, his nose nudging into her clit, and her legs began shaking.

“S-Sebastian- I’m gonna-”

He hummed some affirmation, and she cried out as she came, shattering underneath his talented mouth. He kept his mouth on her, softly guiding her through her orgasm until her legs stopped shaking. He lowered her hips back down to the deck, both of them panting. Mermista didn’t know if it was the bond, or the fact that they were taking turns, but her arousal wasn’t abating, instead burning hotter with each tryst. Shakily, she got to her feet, tugging him up and crushing their mouths together. She hiked a leg over his hip, and he got the hint, lifting her into his arms. His cock bumped against her and she cried out softly. “In me,” she panted. “I need you in me.”

“I need to be in you,” he gasped against her mouth. “Bed?”

“Don’t care,” she grunted, already moving to suck hickies into his shoulder. “Just fuck me.”

“Yes, ma’am.”

They slammed the door to the captain’s quarters shut behind them, uncaring of the dust and darkness of the room. The first available surface was Sea Hawk’s desk; he haphazardly swept papers and datapads to the floor and laid her down. His pants were shoved off along with his boots, tossed who knows where. He took his length in hand, staring down at her as he worked it, calculating.

She flushed. “What?”

“You,” he answered simply, eyes tracing a path from her face to her chest down to her sex. “I dream about this more than you know; you, spread and waiting for me, begging me to fuck you, to tied you up, to come in you-” He cut himself off, and Mermista felt his sudden burst of apprehension and embarrassment in her mind, though his face gave nothing away.

She quirked a brow. “What?”

He said nothing, busying himself with peppering her chest with kisses and hickies. She let herself get lost in the feelings before she reoriented herself.

“Sea Haaawk,” she whined, wiggling her hips enticingly. “C’mon, tell me more. Tell me what you dream about me.”

He looked away, but kept a hand on himself, rubbing gently.

She pouted more, lifting a leg to tug his head back in her direction. “I’m your wife, remember? You can tell me anything.”

It was a dirty trick, pulling the wife card, because they both knew it was his permanent undoing, the hopeless romantic. He sighed, leaning down to brace his arms on either side of her. The air, their bond, shifted from something hot and needy to something a bit more tender. “I just don’t want to hurt you.”

“With your dream fantasies?” she chuckled.

He shrugged.

“Babe, it’ll be fine. C’mon, don’t you want me to know?” She leaned up enough to whisper in his ear, soft and sensual. “Then I can make your dream a reality.” He was almost there, but still hesitating. She wrapped her legs around his hips, lining up his cock with her dripping cunt. “Tell me what I’m saying. What am I begging you to do?”

She trailed her open mouth, her lips, the tip of her tongue, along the shell of his ear, his neck, his lobe, and he shuddered. Suddenly, she heard his voice, clear as a bell in her mind, the bond overflowing with an intimate closeness she hadn't felt from it before.

You’re begging me to fuck a baby into you. To fuck you hard and deep and fill you over and over again. Begging me to mark you up, claim you, to not stop until you’re pregnant with my child.

Mermista’s vaguely aware that she’s moaning, that the tip of Sea Hawk’s cock has slipped into her entrance, that he was barely holding back from slamming into her. She pulled back enough to meet his eyes, and nodded once at the question there. He adjusted to sit up, grabbing her hips and without further warning, pushing into her in one smooth thrust. They both gasped, feeling the other’s pleasure alongside their own, a positive feedback loop of arousal.

Sea Hawk checked once more with her before pulling almost fully out, and then slamming back in. He set a slow, tortuous pace at first, dragging himself in and out of her with all the control and time in the world. Mermista snarled; he knew she liked it fast, hard. He knew she liked to be *fucked* . She pushed her impatience along the bond, but he just chuckled. He grabbed her legs, lifting them over his shoulder and leaning down, immobilizing her. She whined, and he stopped for a long moment, fully seated inside her, and it wasn’t long before she was all but sobbing, begging him to keep going. Sea Hawk, not that she ever planned on stroking his ego, was not only stupidly hung but fairly thick, and when he did this the stretch was almost too much. Judging from the smug satisfaction on his face and in her mind, though, he already knew.

“Please, Sea Hawk- *ah!* ”

Keeping her legs folded to her own chest with his hands, he leaned back a bit to get the best possible angle to set a decidedly brutal pace. Gone was the slow, sensual burn, the dragging pleasure. He slammed into her over and over again, nearly animalistic. Mermista was grateful for the empty ship in the hidden cove, because she was moaning higher, louder, longer; her inhales became sobs, and she knew she was screaming by the carnal satisfaction radiating from him. Sea Hawk loved making her lose control, and tried to make her scream whenever they had the time and privacy to build her up like this.

Her orgasm hit hard and fast, her back bowing off the desk with the force, nearly pushing him out of her body as her walls contracted. Sea Hawk bit his tongue hard enough to draw blood so he could hang on through it. As she came down, he wrapped her arms around him, lifting her limp form against his body, cock still sheathed in her. He brought her over to the bed, dropping her onto the plush mattress gently and climbing over her. Her eyes were glazed over, but bright with need. He could feel her desire for more through the bond, and set her legs back over his shoulder, leaning down to press his lips to hers. The position forced a shallow angle, but the stretch made up for it.

One hand snuck down, rolling her swollen clit between his fingers. Mermista's mouth fell open, and she groaned. He set a somewhat softer pace, not by much, thrusting into her and rubbing her off. This orgasm came on fast, and she felt herself immobilized as it gripped her. This time, when she came back down, she pushed her legs back down, off his shoulders and around his hips where she gripped him tight and flipped them over, his cock still iron inside her.

He groaned. "Dearest, please…"

She smirked, and set a painfully slow pace, grinding herself down on his cock, taking him as deep as her body would allow, not letting up enough for any helpful friction. Sea Hawk pushed his head back into the pillow, clearly biting the inside of his cheek to maintain control. Mermista tsked; she didn't want him to keep any control. Despite his batshit approach to every other aspect of life in general, Sea Hawk was an attentive, careful man in bed, always making sure her pleasure came first, that she was satisfied. He was an amazing lover for it, too, but Mermista relished the rare occasions where he lost control.

She could count on one hand the number of times he'd really *fucked* her, bruising her body with his iron grip, leaving bite marks and hickies all over her body, taking his pleasure from her body with an almost animalistic abandon. She loved it, she missed it, and she wanted it, like, yesterday.

So she teased and taunted, winding him up impossibly high, watching the cords in his neck and the veins at his temples grow more pronounced. He licked his lips, and she saw blood on his tongue from biting his cheek. The grip he had on her ass was just shy of painful, but his fingers were wrought steel, restraining themselves from digging in. Mermista huffed, and leaned forward, running her tongue over his nipples, flicking and nibbling until he was moaning brokenly into the air. Her tongue ran up his neck, and her heightened sense of smell brought the scent of herself on his body back into her nose, making her moan and spasm, gripping his cock that much tighter.

"Mermista, I'm begging you-" Sea Hawk practically snarled. She only grinned, nipping his neck, his earlobe, his jaw.

"If you want to come, then come." She shrugged.

He whined; they both knew he couldn’t, not like this, with her slow and steady but frictionless rocking. He was throbbing inside her, desperate for a release she wouldn’t give him yet.

“Mermista-”

“What?”

Their lips weren’t even an inch apart, and she could feel his breath ghosting her lips. She smiled, not unkindly, and traced his jaw with her nail. “Want something?”

She leaned in, as if to kiss him, but when he moved his lips to reciprocate, she pulled back just enough for him to miss. He glared at her, and she moved in, before darting back again. She did this a few more times, watching his patience fray, until he finally snapped, moving one hand to grab the back of her head, holding her in place long enough to crush his mouth to hers. It was messy, more teeth and tongue than lips, and it stoked the fire in Mermista that much higher. With the hand now fisted in her hair, he ripped her away and back, sitting up with her to push her off his cock. She whimpered at the sudden loss, the chill between her legs, but he pushed her down onto her stomach and moved to straddle her ass so quickly it was no longer a concern.

His mouth was suddenly by her ear, voice lower than ever and sending shivers down her spine. “Think you’re so cute, huh?”

"Uh, duh. I'm fucking adorable- *ah!* " she cried out as he smacked her ass, hard enough to leave a handprint, she was sure. She moaned after, and he yanked her head up by her hair to kiss her again. When he let her drop, she was panting. "What are you gonna do about it?" Teeth sank into her neck, and she yelped. "H-hey! My outfit tonight isn't high necked, c'mon!"

He stopped right away, soothing the spot with lips and tongue in wordless apology. Just as she relaxed, he pulled back, repositioning himself between her legs and pulling her hips off the bed to press against his. She groaned as his cock bumped her entrance, and he nudged the tip in. He grunted, legs flexing against hers, and she realized he was trying to be gentler. She frowned, and pushed her ass back, impaling herself on his cock in one thrust. They both cried out, and she was rewarded for her impatience with another smack on the opposite asscheek.

"So that's how you want it?"

"Obviously," she snarled, patience having officially run out. Luckily, he was right there with her. She had no warning before he gripped both her hips and held her still while he pulled almost fully out before snapping his hips back into hers harshly. She cried out, in pain and pleasure alike, but he paid her no heed, setting a brutal pace that she knew was going to leave her very sore. She could feel his satisfaction, his need, coating their bond, drowning out any discomfort she had and replacing it with more pleasure. Her mouth fell open, and she tried to get her hands under her to push herself into a better angle.

Sea Hawk growled, and pushed her face back into the pillow with a hand splayed between her shoulder blades. "I didn't say you could move," he bit out.

She whined, and settled for using what little leverage she had to tease him further. She wanted more, impossibly more; she wanted that hunger lurking just under his need to break free. She could feel it there, in his mind, tightly reined and locked away. That just wouldn't do. So, on the next thrust, she stopped bracing, letting his hips push her own away from him, so that he slid out and lost his rhythm. She feigned confusion, but she knew he could feel her amusement. He pinched one of her nipples this time, hard enough that she winced, and resumed his pace.

The next time, she pulled herself away from him in small increments, until he wasn't getting nearly enough friction to satisfy. This time, she was barely smothering chuckles. Annoyance, fondness, and love mixed together in her mind, and she relented before he got snitty enough to pinch her other nipple. The final straw came when she purposely threw her hips out of rhythm, ruining the pace he had set. He groaned and sighed, clearly aggravated, and she smothered her laughter in the pillow though it did nothing thanks to the bond. Laughter turned to confusion when she felt Sea Hawk lean over and loop his arms under hers, linking them at the elbow. His core tightened, and he leaned back, lifting her torso off the bed flush with his.

She yelped, but couldn't flail or move or anything. Her lower half was immobilized, too busy keeping her balanced to do anything else. He repositioned them so they were facing out into his quarters, directly in view of the full length mirror hung on the far wall. They looked completely wrecked, debauched and filthy, and she moaned as he kissed her shoulder and spoke in her ear.

“This is what you get since you can’t behave.”

Her cunt twitched as his voice dripped right to her core, the darkest honey in her ear. She tried to close her eyes, and those lips turned to teeth.

“Ah-ah, I didn’t say you could look away.”

She whimpered, opening her eyes and meeting his in the mirror. He smirked, and she watched his hips flex, watched his cock glide deep into her and back out. His knees were between hers, keeping them as far apart as he could while still letting her balance. With no warning, he dropped her down, so her tits hung away from her body and her neck strained to hold her head up. She looked like one of the mermaids sailors used to carve into the prows of their ships in this position. Without breaking eye contact, Sea Hawk reset the pace, bypassing any gentility. He slammed back into her, and she wailed, unable to shut her eyes against the vulnerability of the image. Her gaze moved as he thrusted, oscillating between his cock, pounding her sore sex, glistening with her juices, their biceps, both flexing hard to maintain the position, her own tits, bouncing with each slam, and his own eyes.

His moved too, lingering for a very long time on her chest, she noticed, but stayed mostly on her eyes. Sweat was dripping down his face, his chest, and she tracked the drops hungrily. All the while, their bond grew blisteringly hot with the intensity of their connection.

Mermista was shocked by how long they both held on before she felt her orgasm creeping up on her. She was sure Sea Hawk could feel it too, both in her mind and around his cock, by how he was groaning. Their eyes met in the mirror as he slammed into her with a single minded, animalistic focus, and she couldn't have kept quiet if she wanted to.

"Sea Hawk- *Sebastian- baby- ah!* Fuck me, *fuck me, I want you to- ah!- fuck me- shit!- yeah- ah AH!"*

Her entire body was shaking as she came, sobbing openly. She didn't know if tears or sweat were running down her face, probably both. She had never known pleasure as all consuming as this, gusting through her body like a wildfire. Her mind was wiped blank, swallowed by the orgasm that hit her, a tsunami that overtook her; she wasn't aware of anything but the waves racking her form, pulling her muscles taught, paralyzing her in bliss. Distantly, she was aware of the liquid gushing out of her, of Sea Hawk crying out as he was finally pushed over the edge. His orgasm mixed with her own in their minds, and she was acutely aware of his hips rocking into her, spilling deep inside of her just like he'd wanted.

When she came back to herself, her ears were ringing, and everything looked bleary, like she'd just woken up after an impromptu nap. Sea Hawk was leant back, arms around her waist and holding her back to his front, both of their chests heaving. He was still inside her, twitching, the last of his orgasm finding its way into her. She groaned, letting her head drop against his shoulder.

He kissed her exposed throat. "Alright, dearest?"

“Yeah.” Her voice was sandpaper. “That was…holy *fuck* .”

“I quite agree.” He huffed a laugh, the best he could offer. Their bond was humming like a live wire, still, but Mermista knew that she was sated at last. “I really needed that.”

“Yeah, you did.” She grinned. “No one can be a gentleman all the time.”

“Are you alright?” He hooked his chin over her shoulder, running gentle hands down her body. “I didn’t hurt you, did I?”

“Nah, I’m alright. More than alright.” She turned and kissed him softly. “That was, like, exactly what I needed, too.”

“And you claim to be a Princess.” He tsk’d at her, mocking.

Carefully, they separated, Mermista groaning and then laughing at the mess that followed his cock’s retreat. “The unsexy part the romance novels never talk about- the cleanup,” she sighed, and went to get up, but found herself gently pushed back down.

“Allow me, please.” Sea Hawk’s puppy dog eyes begged her to let him take care of her, so she shrugged and reclined. A day she didn't have to do more work than was deemed necessary was a good day. He kissed her again before climbing off the bed and making his way to the head attached to his main quarters to take care of himself and get some supplies.

Mermista took the time to glance lazily around his study. He hadn't been here in months, but it was like time had frozen inside his cabin. Maps detailing possible leads on treasures, or sea monsters, or previously unproven routes cluttering the desk (the floor, now). His usual knick knacks and books filled the shelves on the far wall. Shoelace's cage stood empty by the windows- Sea Hawk had set the bird free when Prime arrived, hoping to give him the best possible chance at survival. Mermista found herself wondering where the obnoxious yet charming thing had gone off to, and hoped he was alive. For Sea Hawk's sake, of course.

Pictures in frames had joined the bric a brac between volumes and tomes on ship care, sailing history, lore and mythos. They all had her in them, which made her want to roll her eyes, but really was very touching. The largest was them on the rooftop of the restaurant they'd gone to for his last birthday; they were smiling and laughing as they danced, some quip he'd made having caught her off guard enough to laugh freely in public, the rarest of scenarios. There were smaller ones scattered around the shelves; a candid of her reading on her balcony, one of her getting ready for some event before they joined the Alliance, one that looked like a natural shot of a hidden cove, but she could see her tail just cresting the surface. Other pictures, of ships and people he'd had before he ever met her, joined them, and there was one very old, very carefully kept picture of a small Sea Hawk and his mom. She'd spent long minutes just staring at it when Sea Hawk had first shown her, and knew how precious it was to him.

He emerged from the head then, bearing a damp towel, a glass of water, and lotion. He stopped at the dresser and grabbed a bundle of fabric out of it. Mermista couldn't see what; her eyes were starting to droop where she lay stretched out, feeling luxuriously untethered in the way only good sex could ellicit.

"Hey."

"Hello, gorgeous." He sat alongside her and handed her the towel.

She was too tired to bother with her magic, so she went about cleaning her mess up the lame, uncool way. "Long-term relationships, huh?" she snorted as she handed him back the dirtied towel.

He chuckled as he tossed it into a laundry bin. "Marriage, even."

"Yeah, that too." She let him rub the lotion- a special tincture from Mystacore that soothed aches and healed bruises- into her hips, her shoulder blades, her ribs and abdomen, her legs, her knees. Her whole body ended up benefiting from it, and she hummed happily as he finished. "Let me do you?"

"Drink your water first."

“Ugh, fine.” She rolled her eyes as she sat up slowly, pleased to find it much easier than it had been when she first tried. She downed the glass and handed it back before gesturing Sea Hawk closer.

“What do you think tonight will bring?” he murmured as she rubbed lotion into his joints.

“I don’t know,” she sighed gustily. “Answers, I hope, but I’m not optimistic. At worst, I hope I’ll get to punch Peekablue for his desertion and treason. At best, we get a real answer on where our friends are. It’s been too long.”

“Whatever happens, we’ll do it together.” He grabbed her hand in his, squeezing briefly. “I’ll be right next to you.”

“You always are.” She had meant that to sound so much more annoyed than it came out. She pushed on before he gave her The Look. “Just stick to the plan, and we’ll all be okay.”

He hummed his assent, and she returned to soothing his aches away. An hour later, they were curled up in the bed, having agreed on a short nap before they got to work on the ship. Sea Hawk had dropped off almost immediately, but Mermista laid awake, stroking his hair and holding him close. She knew it was just her anxiety giving her a bad feeling about tonight, but she couldn’t stop herself from going over every plan, every contingency, strategy, exit, excuse, and lie they had come up with over and over again. It would all be okay, she tried to soothe herself. She had thought of everything there was to think of, so either they were ready for whatever came next…or they never stood a chance in the first place.

Chapter End Notes

> Hope y’all enjoyed! If you did pls leave a comment, I love feedback! And if you didn’t also feel free! See y’all next time!

angel down

Chapter Summary

> Their mission at the underwater grotto doesn't go exactly to plan.

Chapter Notes

> One of my most fav chaps to write

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It hadn't exactly been their most successful recon mission. Between her and Sea Hawk's slew of exes, Scorpia's social anxiety, and Perfuma's big fat crush, they hadn't been able to accomplish much. Mermista had been ready to toss in the towel and call it a night, happy to spend the rest of the evening in bed with Sea Hawk, when Perfuma had raced up to them behind the bar and told them the quasi-good news: Scorpia had found 'Peekablue'. Sort of.

Turns out she'd really found Double Trouble.

At this point, Mermista would take what she could get. And if what she got was the slimy low-life mercenary who helped destroy her homeland? She could work with that.

Everyone else must have seen the murder in her eyes, though, because they quickly voted she guard the door while they interrogated Double Trouble. Sea Hawk walked with her over to the dressing room entrance, and pressed a soothing kiss to her cheek.

“Don’t worry dearest, I’ll make sure you get some time alone with them.”

“You better,” she grumbled. She let her eyes roam over his body; he cut a very fine figure in his suit. It showed off his broad shoulders and tapered waist perfectly, and his slicked-back hair was just begging to be mussed up. *Later* , she told herself. Later, they’d have the whole night to undo each other. For now, she tugged his lips down to hers, letting him wrap strong arms around her waist. “Be safe, or whatever, alright? They’re a slippery bastard, and I need you, like, in one piece.”

“I’ll be alright, love.” He brushed another kiss to her lips, and then nipped them gently. “Soon we’ll be back on the boat, in our cabin, and you can wipe that lipstick off on my-”

“ *Go* , doofus.” She rolled her eyes, smiling and blushing. “Give me a shout when you’re ready.”

Sea Hawk lingered another moment, and then impulsively tugged her into a hug. “You know I love you, right? Despite my comical mountain of exes.”

“Duh,” she snorted. “We’re married and there's a big fucking mental bridge between us. I think I’d know by now if you weren’t obsessed with me.”

“Good.” He breathed in deeply, hands rubbing gentle circles into her back. “Because I am. Obsessed. In a healthy way.”

“I know, Sebastian. Now, go on, go be a badass, live out your interrogation fantasies.” She swatted his ass gently, and he pulled away. She tugged him just close enough to kiss his cheek before pushing him off. “And I, y’know, love you, too.”

He spared her another soft kiss and sappy, love-struck smile before disappearing around the corner. Mermista settled herself against the curtained doorway, eyes scanning back and forth. The only people back here were stage hands. Everyone who could have identified her as Queen and Princess was unconscious or tied up behind the bar. She watched them mill about, unaware that the show had been on intermission for far longer than was appropriate.

Being here tonight, it was like the war was all a fever dream or a mass hallucination; after this, she and Sea Hawk would go home to the castle, take off their fancy clothes and makeup and curl up in their massive bed facing the beach and the stars and talk until they fell asleep. There was no refugee camp, no strategy meetings, no rations running low, no units to mobilize. Salineas was still standing, and flourishing.

It was a nice fantasy.

Mermista grabbed for her rings on their chain, like she always did when she was stressed, only to come up empty. *Oh, right. Low neckline means great cleavage and no rings* . It had been a fair trade at the time, watching Sea Hawk's eyes follow her chest all night. Now, she had some regrets. She missed the comforting, slight weight of them against her clavicle, a constant reminder she wasn't alone.

A couple of the stagehands had paused in the entry of the alcove she was in, a tiny dead-end hallway in which the entrance to backstage was tucked. They gave her a once over and moved on, but there were…a lot of them checking on her. At first alone, then in pairs, then groups would pause and look. She probed the bond, and relaxed when Sea Hawk pushed back. She was just being paranoid. This whole chip thing had her on edge like never before; she was losing sleep and like, hair, over it.

Another group stopped. A hammerhead woman, a large pufferfish man, and two smaller angler individuals. She nodded casually and went back to staring at nothing. They didn't move on. She looked again, and a siren had joined them. She hissed, sibilant, and the hairs and scales on the back of Mermista's neck stood on end. She could feel the responding hiss in the back of her throat, but bit down on it with all she had; there were very few land-dwelling merfolk. Response would give her away. The group still didn't move on. In fact, the shark woman took a step closer, and then paused, scenting the air quite obviously. Mermista forced herself to remain aloof, leaned against the door jamb.

"Excuse me," one of the anglers said, in a strangely calm, emotionless voice. "Could you help us? We're looking for someone."

"Uh…" Mermista shrugged. "Depends, I guess. Who are you looking for?"

"The Princess of Salineas."

Her heart started to beat faster. "Why would the Princess be hanging out in a dive like this?"

"We have good intel she's here."

"Good for you, I guess." Mermista tried to keep her voice light, airy. Her deadpan drawl was well known throughout the kingdom. The siren woman was staring right at her, and she forced herself not to look away. "No, I can't help you."

But they didn't move. As a whole, they stepped closer, eyeing her with undisguised hunger. The pufferfish man grinned, rows of needle-sharp teeth glinting in the lowlight. When he spoke, it was with a strange, formal cadence, an alien-deep voice that shook her very core. "Actually, Princess…I think you can."

They were fast, but she was faster. The shark lunged for her, and she rolled to the side. There were puddles of dirty water back here, and she grabbed what little she could, using it like a whip to defend herself. The two anglers were knocked out easily, but they got a few good shots in with their viciously clawed hands. The puffer man wasn't even phased by her attack, lunging for her with massive fists topped with exoskeletal spikes. As she dodged him, she slammed a knee into the sternum of the shark, winding her and giving Mermista a chance to get around her…

And see the chip on her neck.

Panic, hot and tight and disorienting, crashed through her, and she tried to send a warning to Sea Hawk. He didn't answer, and her panic grew. *Sea Hawk, I have to get to Sea Hawk-*

She never saw the two octavarians who grabbed her, grappling her in their many suctioned limbs. She kicked, and thrashed, and opened her mouth to scream but a tentacle slid over her mouth. Snarling, Mermista let her teeth shift and sharpen to merfolk teeth, and bit down until inky blood slid down her throat, and the man holding her was screaming. There were more people behind her, a hand on her neck- no, *no, nonononono-*

Something pricked the back of her neck, and in seconds the fight was bleeding from her. Her limbs twitched as she tried to fight back, but found herself no longer in control of them. Fight or flight was taking over, but only internally, and only for a bit, because soon, any urge to get away was just…gone. Everything was gone. Her fear, her worry, her omnipresent stress for the war, for her people, for her husband and friends- no, her *family* - all gone.

It wasn't unpleasant.

'There… ,' the voice in her brain, so unlike the voice she normally heard there, cooed. *'Isn't that better?'*

No. Yes? *No!* …Yes.

Now let's see…what do we have in here .

Another tentacle slid over Mermista's mouth, muffling the agonized scream that was ripped from her throat as ghostly needles pawed through her mind. She had the sensation of her thoughts, her memories, her feelings, being pried open with force and peered inside, before being discarded.

Useless , the voice hissed.

No, they weren't, the part of her being pushed into the corner screamed and sobbed.

Her mother teaching her to swim with her tail. Her father reading her a bedtime story, illustrated by magical illusions that he made dance through her bedroom. Meeting Perfuma. The tiny whale calf that had been stuck in the bay that she'd helped home, the first time she knew rescuing people was, like, her *jam* . Meeting Sea Hawk, their first dance and kiss, that feeling of falling. Prom. The breakup.

Some of the memories were carefully examined. Her first connection with the Pearl. Her lessons with Shastri Dhang, learning the basics of Rune Magic. Her marriage.

How sentimental

Leave that alone. It’s mine.

Oh, my child, the voice tutted, a disappointed parent. *Nothing is yours anymore. And isn’t that freeing? No more worrying. No more stress.*

No, this fucking blows.

Vulgar as ever, it appears, he sneered. *Look, and see, of all I’ve liberated you from* .

More memories pried open, shoved into her mind’s eye. Her father’s cold, disappointed gaze after another less-than-adequate political exam score. Being told to leave his presence until she was worthy to stand there, worthy to lead her kingdom. The fights upon fights as she got older, his growing distance, the hollow words, the occasional but hot ire. The grief of losing her mother, fresh in this moment, waking up and being told she was gone by a governess, not even her Baba. Waking up the same way over a decade later, to learn her father had left, too. Every nasty moment she and Sea Hawk had put each other through. The pitying looks from the Alliance. Glimmer’s aloof judgment of her ruling style, her choice in partner, everything about her.

Is this not easier?

Yes, Lord Prime. What? NO!

Yes, my child-

I am *not* your child.

Then whose are you? he asked with false softness. *A mother long dead? A father who felt you had outgrown her novelty, her use, before you could walk? Who's, Princess?*

Tears slid down her cheeks. She had no answer. She knew she should, knew she did once. But now…it was too hard to find, to sort through the jumbled memories. Slowly, the places they had been, and the emotions that were tied to them, were filled with a green light- warm, all-encompassing. Like being too near a fire but knowing that if you scooted away, you'd freeze to death.

Yours, Lord Prime.

Yes. Mine. Now, let us liberate your friends.

Yes, Lord Prime.

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“They’ll never make it.”

Double Trouble’s smug, slippery voice sent shivers of fear and anger down Sea Hawk’s spine. He turned to the two Princesses, each looking more concerned by the minute.

Perfuma wrung shaky hands together. “We…we need to warn them. Get a signal out, somehow. Wait for them to be in range…”

“How will we even know when that is?” Scorpia asked. She was looking incredibly shaken, unsteady on her feet.

“We leave a channel open, round the clock, and hope for the best. I guess.”

Double Trouble butted in, rolling their eyes. “Are we done here-”

Plop .

A drop of water landed on the shapeshifter’s forehead, and they craned their neck up at the ceiling. Sea Hawk looked as well, his heart dropping as he saw cracks, pressure fractures, crawling through the reinforced glass. This bubble was carefully designed to never, ever break from ocean pressure, which, as far as he knew, was a constant- well, without…magic…

Oh, gods.

They turned as one, to see Mermista stood across the room, silhouetted by shadows and velvet curtains. Slowly, deliberately, one finely manicured hand raised, and the cracks worsened. Her head was down, her eyes shut in focus. Like she was relatively unsure of her actions. Sea Hawk probed the bond, and found it unresponsive, as if asleep. She finished her movement, and the cracks burst, steady waterfalls shooting into the room around them. In seconds, the water was ankle deep.

"Mermista, what are you *doing?* " Perfuma demanded, angry and confused.

Her eyes opened, and Sea Hawk felt the floor drop out from under him, nausea clawing up his throat. Her beautiful amber eyes were gone. In their place, green whites and sclera, a glowing white pupil that he knew signified Prime's presence in the host.

" *Step out of the darkness, and into the light of Prime,* " she said, and two spoke as one. He was here, in her, in his wife's body-

“Mermista,” he choked. Her eyes met his, and he saw her face flicker, but the green became stronger, wiping away whatever he thought he saw. Her hands were moving, clumsy and unsure, before he finished. “ *Mermista, NO!* ”

A wave, hasty but strong, came flying at them, and it was only Perfuma’s vines that kept them all from being thrown into the glass walls. Scorpia roared, and sent a blast of lightning at Mermista that was absolutely *not* a pulled punch. Part of him, a large part, wanted to stop her, scream what are you doing, that’s *Mermista* . But the rest of him knew that while it was certainly her body, whatever was attacking him was not his wife. His best friend. The love of his life-

Mermista was knocked into the supporting beam of the stage, and he choked down a cry as she landed harshly in the water. Red electricity continued to wreath her body for a moment, and she whimpered in pain, a purely autonomous response that the actual Mermista would never have allowed. It seemed to hit the Princesses, then, that this was their dear friend, and they both faltered.

Double Trouble, still bound in a sailor-knotted feather boa that Sea Hawk had delighted in tying painfully tight, spoke up. “Uh, we are in a delicate underwater bubble, so can you *please stop HITTING ONE ANOTHER?!* ”

Scorpia scooped the changeling up, and from there it was all a bit of a blur. Perfuma grabbed his arm, tugging gently at first, then harder when she realized he was frozen in place, staring at Mermista. “We need to get out of here!” He let himself be led away, stumbling through the water which had momentarily stopped flowing in.

Later, Sea Hawk would remember running into the chipped crowd. Making a break for the stage, being given charge of Double Trouble, the elevator descending. He knew he should have felt hope, and relief, but he just felt the early stages of survivors' guilt. How was he supposed to leave here, leave *her* , alone, in Prime’s grasp. He had failed. As a soldier, as a rebel, as a husband. He hadn’t been able to keep her safe- he’d left her alone. *He’d left her alone* .

“That's your cue, Hot Stuff! Let’s go!” Gods, but Sea Hawk wanted to let this irreverent creature drown. Not the time, though.

Mermista burst through the curtains on a whirlpool of water, landing harshly and sending more water toward them. She cried out, not in battle-hunger but almost…in pain. Prime didn’t know how to use the Pearl, how to work with it. Sea Hawk figured he was forcing the magic, just doing whatever he could to move the water, damn whatever it did to Mermista.

“With her in his hive…” Double Trouble shook against him, a theatrical but genuine shiver. “No pun intended, but the tide of this war may have just changed permanently.”

Sea Hawk was helpless to agree. Mermista was incomprehensibly strong; she held herself in check, even in battle, but he’d seen glimpses of it, her true potential. It was devastating. Hopefully, Prime was too much a zealous fool to think he had to learn the proper way to move water. Without mastery of the specific, ancient combat style, Mermista would be powerful, but not deadly.

Gods, how could he be thinking like this, analyzing her like this? Like an enemy? *Because from now on, she is. At some point, you may have to fight, really fight, and even…take out…your own wife.*

Sea Hawk was going to be sick.

Perfuma ran toward the elevator, but it wasn't enough, they didn't have time. Mermista was increasing pressure on the glass, water flowing through faster and faster. It was already ankle deep on the stage, which meant the rest of the Grotto was chest-high. And Scorpia…wasn't moving.

Please, gods, no.

"Scorpia, c'mon!" Perfuma cried, halfway between them.

"There's too many of them. And this place is coming down unless someone stops it!" Scorpia was resolute, even though her voice shook on each word. "You have to get out and protect the others! *Go, NOW!* "

“Wait-” Vines shot toward Scorpia, wrapping her arms and waist while Perfuma pulled with all she had.

Sea Hawk stood frozen, watching in dismay as yet another relationship was ripped apart by the Horde. This was shock, he knew. Shock at how much they had lost in just minutes.

“You’re coming, too!” Perfuma sobbed.

“Nah.” Scorpia shook her head. “This is why I’m here; I’m the muscle, remember?” She turned, and smiled at them, utterly certain and yet so very sad. “ *I can do this.* ” She snipped the vine clean, sending Perfuma crashing into Sea Hawk’s chest.

He caught one arm, Double Trouble the other, and together they watched the door shut. The tube wobbled, and Sea Hawk watched in dismay as it began to shake loose. With a mighty yell, Scorpia unleashed her full power, momentarily pushing back the water falling into the grotto and keeping the tube together long enough for them to escape. They watched as, inch by inch, their loves slid out of view.

The secret elevator let them out in an alley between some buildings, near the docks. Sea Hawk stood utterly frozen, not even daring to breathe.

It was Double Trouble who prodded him with their tail, humming to themselves. “I mean, at least you’re not dead, right?”

Something in him snapped, and before he knew what he was doing, his fist was slamming into the shapeshifter's jaw. Double Trouble hissed, and stumbled back into Perfuma, who caught them numbly. The nausea he'd been fighting ever since he'd looked into Mermista's glowing green eyes, became too much, and he stumbled a few feet away to expel the minimal contents of his stomach.

He coughed, choking on the last of it. A green-gloved hand bearing a pale yellow flower slid into his peripheral. "Eat this. It'll help with the shock, give you enough energy to get us out." He righted himself, taking the flower and shoving some petals into his mouth. The cool menthol and honey flavor slid down his throat, soothing the burn and invigorating him. He nodded his thanks, and turned to Double Trouble.

"I- ahem- am sorry for that. Somewhat."

DT gave him a once over, and then snorted. "It's fine, it's fine. What's a little drama to one such as moi? And I suppose that was a bit gauche of me. She was your girlfriend, right? Paramore? Secret lover? The Princess and the Pauper, oh, how roman-"

"Wife," he corrected gruffly, pushing past them. "She *is* my wife."

"Oh, yikes," the lizard hissed. "That's gotta sting. So, what now?"

“Now, we get the hell out of here.” Perfuma was already pulling her datapad out of her clutch. “But first, I’m going to try to get through to the ship.”

“Better hurry.” Sea Hawk grimaced, reaching for his fully extinguished blade. “We have company.”

There were at least a dozen chipped sea-folk streaming out of the buildings, looking for them. Double Trouble sighed theatrically, like this was all just a massive inconvenience to them, and shifted into a minotaur, easily tearing through the last of the feather boa.

“Our ship is docked at Pier 26, Spot 14. And don’t get any ideas,” he warned DT. “The controls are bio-coded to me, and me alone. So unless you know how to steer it manually, it won’t do you any good.”

“Ugh, you do-gooders are *so* boring.”

“C’mon, Perfuma, it’s time to go.” Sea Hawk grabbed the Princess’ elbow. “We can call them on the-”

A melodic ring interrupted them. Perfuma froze, then answered the pad. “Adora?”

Yes, there on the screen was Adora. Along with Entrapta, Bow, and…Catra? “Perfuma! What’s going on?”

“I…I…” She broke off with a choked sob.

“We’re on our way back, just hold on a little longer! We’re almost there!”

“No! Don’t come back! Horde Prime knows your coming. There’s a trap, a blockade- you’ll never make it through. You need to *stay away* .” She took a breath, looking at Sea Hawk, and he watched tears gather in her eyes. “The Rebellion’s been compromised. Horde Prime has them. We lost, I-I’m so sorry.” The signal began cutting out. “We lost them.”

A laser cannon shot flew overhead, and they both turned to see the Horde was nearly on them. They’d been found. Perfuma gathered her vines as the signal cut out, and abandoned the pad. They had no time to grab it, nowhere to put it…Sea Hawk made the split second decision to turn around and slam the heel of his shoe into the housing, once, twice, three times, until there was no way to salvage the information on it, before turning and throwing himself into the fray.

He parried, swung, blocked, sliced- over and over until he was on autopilot. Whenever he felt something on his neck, he dropped and rolled and sprinted. Somehow, by some miracle, they all three made it aboard the ship. “Hold them off! I need just two minutes!”

Double Trouble had snagged someone's laser gun and was wielding it with relish, firing shot after shot- to injure, not kill, they had been warned- into the fray. Sea Hawk vaulted up to the wheel, turning on the engine in the belly of the ship and not even waiting for it to reach optimal heat before he threw it in reverse. He hadn't unmoored the ship, and as they turned, the lines pulled taught for a brief second. They were no match for the engine, though, and soon the dock was groaning, splintering, pulling apart until they were free. He flicked a couple of switches and pushed the central lever up two notches, and he had the main sails up, catching the frigid night wind of Sea Worthy and pushing them out to sea. He didn't let off the throttle, though. "Perfuma, DT, get those lines cut off! They're dragging too much."

He felt when they fell away, and watched the speedometer rocket up. The wheel evened out, and he set it to cruise control. They were going far, far too fast for night sailing, but they had to get away from Sea Worthy. It was only a matter of time before Prime learned what Mermista was, what she could do. She'd caught him before at top speed, and had trounced him soundly in many a race. His only hope was to outmaneuver her before they realized the game he was playing.

"Sea Hawk." Perfuma climbed the steps gently. "Where are we going? This isn't the way we came."

"Our camp is compromised. We don't know who's chipped and who's not. We have to assume the worst, and that means we can't go back."

Perfuma sighed shakily. "Right. Yes, of course. Where else…could we go?"

"I…might have an answer to that." DT joined them, once again their true form, or as close to it as they'd ever see, probably. "There's a hideaway deep in the Whispering Woods, an old abandoned Horde storage unit. The only people who knew about its location were Kitten and myself. Not even Snips back there would know."

"Is it near…water?" Perfuma whispered.

"No. Pretty much land locked."

"Right. Give me the coordinates."

DT tutted. "Not so fast. First, I want some things in return."

"Like…?"

"I want shelter, sanctuary, whatever. I'll help your stupid little Rebellion but in return, I want protection. Scratch mine, I'll scratch yours, right?" They had the gall to give Sea Hawk a little once over, smiling flirtatiously.

He fixed his eyes back on the moonlit sea.

"Ugh, no fun. And, if we do win this, and we all come out with our skins still intact…I want a lighter sentence. I know Kitten, and if she's going down then so am I. She knows my tells, and I'll only be able to run for so long. So, if and when you do catch me, I'd rather not be, y'know, put to death."

"Bright Moon doesn't believe in the death penalty." Perfuma murmured.

"Salineas does," DT and Sea Hawk spoke together.

"Or, it has in the past, on some certain occasions. I get the feeling his leading lady won't be feeling very merciful."

"Fine. How's this." Sea Hawk tapped on autopilot, and then grabbed the front of DT's shirt. He marched down the steps with them in tow, until he could kick the plank out into place. He walked to the end of it, and swung DT to dangle over the edge. "No chasing. No games. You help us through this, and come forward after the war, and by whatever power is vested in me by the Kingdom of Salineas, you will not be put to death. You *will* serve a hefty community service sentence."

"Or what?" they sneered.

Sea Hawk smiled without humor, and loosened his grip on the mesh and leather. "Or you go nightswimming with the blood-eels.

We’re in their waters, and not even a mermaid can outswim them.”

Below them, the water slithered and roiled, and he watched as DT realized that it wasn’t the roar of the ocean they were hearing. They snarled, but deflated. “ *Fine* . Ugh. This is what I get for getting mixed up with that fucking furball.”

He tossed DT back onto the deck, pulling in the plank. “Make yourself useful, grab some of the ranged weapons out of the storage closet in the hall. Red door.”

Perfuma was waiting for him, quiet disapproval on her brow. “That was a bit harsh.”

“I truly don’t think I have it in me to care, Perfuma.”

There was a beat of silence. “You know…I really don’t either.”

Perfuma slumped against the stern railing, and slid down to the floor. Sea Hawk checked the controls, the readouts, and scanned the horizon and water for any ripples before joining her. She had taken off her gloves, her hat long lost, and covered her face with her hands. Muffled sobs shook her shoulders, and Sea Hawk wound an arm around them as he sat there.

“They’re gone.”

"...They are."

She tilted her head back, staring at the stars as tears soaked her face. "How do we… how do we go on? I feel like I have nothing left to fight for."

"We have to believe we can save them." Except Sea Hawk didn't even believe that himself. He felt hollow, drained, utterly bereft. An unmoored ship caught in an easterly. His anchor was gone, and he was completely alone. Once again, for the first time in so many years, Sea Hawk was alone, and the thought scared him straight down to his marrow. Without Mermista, what did he have? Their friends were more hers than his, she was the Queen he was wed to, with claim to the kingdom- oh gods, the kingdom. If she was…They didn't… Without a legal universal marriage, he couldn't be crowned. They had no heirs. There was no succession to the throne, *or* the Pearl. What did this mean for Salineas?

Then again, most of Salineas' people were dead or mentally enslaved. What did it matter in the end? His beloved, and her beloved kingdom…gone. He hadn't noticed the tears until Perfuma pressed one of her discarded gloves into his hand. He took it gratefully and dabbed his eyes, not that it stopped his spiralling thoughts.

"Can you feel her?"

"What?"

Perfuma gestured to his head. “Your bond. Can you feel her?”

“Let me see.” Sea Hawk closed his eyes, and tried to envision the bond as he saw it; a small, soft teal spot, fuzzy and hazy that, when he pushed at it, gave way to a bridge like running water, winding off into the starry ether of his consciousness. He had always known that at the other end of that bridge was Mermista’s own mind. Now, the bridge was dim, flickering instead of glowing, and spun out not into stars, but into a harsh, oppressive darkness that only swallowed what he gave it.

He didn’t know how long he sat there, walking along that path and knowing that with every step he was getting nowhere, but unable to stop trying because *what if he did find her on this next step* . Eventually, though, he did get…somewhere? Maybe? The darkness was all around him, straining to touch him but completely unable. It clawed and hissed and snapped shadowy jaws, and he thought he glimpsed flickers of predatory green eyes watching him, but he remained unharmed. It was as he was mired in this darkness that he stumbled, and found himself ankle deep in a pool of water. He looked down, and wondered how he was only ankle-deep when he saw the pool was unfathomably deep, crystal clear water extended for what would have been hundreds of feet. He stepped out, and kneeled down, peering in. He knew this was what he had been looking for, but didn’t know *how* he knew that. As he watched, a large fish darted from one end of the pool to the other. The shadows hissing above him dove then, streaming toward the pool, but bounced harmlessly off the same barrier than had followed him from his own mind. He kept his eyes fixed on the pool, and sure enough, the fish darted again, and he got a better look. It wasn’t a fish at all, but a mermaid, deep, deep down in the pool. Mermista.

He cried out, and tried to reach into the pool, but got nowhere. She was scared- no, *terrified* - he could see, darting around, eyes wide and chest heaving as she hyperventilated. She looked up, and saw him, and her eyes widened further. He tried to reach again, offer a smile, but she shook her head. He frowned in confusion, and watched her raise a hand. She mouthed *I'm sorry* and pushed up with an open palm; water shot out of the pool, slamming into his chest and knocking him clear out of the bond-space and back into his own mind. He broke from his reverie with a loud groan, clutching at his head.

There was a waft of something sweet smelling, and the headache abated quickly. Perfuma was on her knees next to him, looking frightened. "Did you feel her?"

"I *saw* her," he gasped, the tears coming back, faster and harder. "She was right there, but I couldn't touch her. Couldn't get to her."

"What did you see?"

Like a dream, it was already fading, so he struggled to get it out. "A- a pool. On the bridge, on her side, there was a pool. It was deep but I could stand in it. Shadows- everywhere. Prime. Watching her, watching *me* . But he couldn't get to me. And when I was there with her, he couldn't get to her. She was…frightened. Horribly frightened. And alone."

Perfuma pulled him into a hug. “That’s good, though. If she’s scared, she can still feel. And if he can’t reach her in the pool because of your bond, then you’re still protecting her.”

Sea Hawk leaned his head against hers and nodded.

“I’m…I’m so sorry, Sea Hawk. You two don’t deserve this, any of this, after everything this war has put you through.”

“Neither do you,” he rasped, patting her arm. “Young, budding love is as tragic to lose as a well-aged romance.”

Perfuma shuddered. “I’m so scared for her. She’s so…open, sometimes. Malleable. And she’s so strong, but her heart is so kind. I’m so scared that even if we get her back, I’ll have lost her. And I only- *I only just found her* .”

It was Sea Hawk’s turn to wrap her in a hug as the Princess sobbed into his vest. “They’re so strong, our loves. They will be okay, but we can’t lose hope. They need us to help them, to save them from this. So…” He tugged her away as her tears ebbed, and got to his feet, offering her a hand up. “It’s time to dry our eyes, dust ourselves off, and get back up. If not for us, then for them.”

Perfuma took a centering breath, and when she opened her eyes, the usual steel was back in them. “Right.” She took his hand, and got to her feet. “Let’s do this. First things first, we need to go see what’s left.”

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Mermista was trapped in her own mind. Or, at least, that was the best way she could describe it. Sometimes, she was asleep for a long time, and everything was green, and her body was moving and speaking but she wasn’t telling it to. Other times, she was awake, sort of, and everything was still green but less so, and she was moving in a fog, completing simple tasks.

When she’d first fallen asleep, she was in the grotto, and her friends had been there, fighting her, begging her to stop. But that didn’t make sense? She was doing what she was supposed to be doing… Wasn’t she? When she tried to follow that train of thought, the exhaustion got worse, and she lost minutes, maybe hours. The next time she awoke, she was submerged in water, and Scorpia was floating in front of her, unconscious. It was pure instinct that led her to swap legs for tail, ripping through her slacks, and grab Scorpia and get her above water, onto land. There was a perversely curious glee running through her as she examined her legs.

Ah, so this is how .

What’s how? This is how it’s always been.

Silence.

Yes, Lord Prime.

Inhuman, both of them. Innate magic, so many questions.

Mermista didn’t answer that. She wasn’t supposed to. But she did feel fear drip down her spine before she was floating again, not-asleep not-awake. At some point, there was someone else there… she didn’t know who, just that they were in danger, so she pushed them out, away, until it was just her again.

The next time she could wrest some control of her mind back, tiny little scraps of perception, she was in Salineas, back in her castle. Pure joy managed to break free at the familiar decor, the smells of home underneath the choking dust of the rubble. The main entry and receiving hall, with its murals and open-water aquarium walls, was completely wrecked. The walls were empty, the fish either gone or dead on the ground, sitting in still-water. The scent was overwhelming. The further in she went, the less destroyed it was, besides being almost completely looted. Her mother’s live coral statues, the ancient vases, her great-grandmother’s paintings, and the ornaments of her kingdom- gone. No more Salinean gold was left in the halls.

Prime all but left her mind at this point, leaving her with a simple order. *Change* . She glanced down and realized her suit was in tatters, and only the gauzy magical sarong that manifested when she shifted back without her leggings covered her legs and ass. She grimaced. Lovely. It was strange; she almost felt like her old self. Sarcastic, dry, annoyed. But she was missing…a lot. Vague recollection of her memories and emotions being ripped out of place, dumped and jumbled around, flashes into her mind, but it was gone just as quickly. She was here to change, nothing else. The 'why' didn't matter right now.

She came to the waterfall that sealed off the private apartments of the castle and raised her hand to part the water. Her magic resisted. Mermista frowned, tugging harder, and feeling more resistance. It took several tries before the blockage gave way, and it felt…reluctant. Or would have, if magic could give off an emotion. Once through, she made for her bedroom, bypassing her study, her private kitchen, the solarium, the den area. Each room tugged at her heart, but she didn't know why. She pushed open the double doors to her room and a wall of familiarity hit her. Cardamom, lavender, sea salt, and honey all wafted through the air. Fresh laundry, too, and she noticed a pile of it left on an end table in the small entry hall. A white linen shirt on top called to her, and she held it up. It wasn't hers, that was clear. Then why did she want it? She brought it to her nose, and inhaled. There was something…someone…right there. She let the shirt fall, and continued on.

Her room was messy, she noticed benignly. Like she'd left here in a hurry. Both sides of the bed were unmade. On one nightstand was a stack of books, file folders, a small pile of documents, and a glass of water. Her side. On the other was a half-dismantled compass, a small pile of hardware, some maps, a pen, and a coffee mug. His- no, the other- side.

Mermista shook her head, clearing the thoughts and going to her closet. She quickly changed into her usual armor; reinforced, enchanted leggings, reinforced top, gold belt, pauldrons, vambraces, neck plate, shoes. She braided her hair in its usual fashion. She was done. It was time to leave. Once again, her body would not comply. She wanted to…stay. She wanted to sleep in her bed, bathe in her pool, eat on her balcony- *No.*

He was back. She was slipping under. She tried to stay but the hazy green glow was getting stronger, more inviting. It would be so easy to just…

She woke up again somewhere else. It was white, sterile, empty. The wasp-hive halls echoed with her footsteps. Sentient bot guards and clones flanked her and Scorpia, just beside her, bringing them to a chamber. The doors opened to reveal two medical beds. And Horde Prime. They each fell to a knee, heads bent to expose their necks.

"Well, well…" His voice dripped in their ears like honey, echoing two-fold in their heads. "If it isn't Queen Mermista, Princess of the Pearl, and Force Captain- ah! My apologies. *Princess* Scorpia of… well. Of nowhere really, hm? Of the Black Garnet, if that suits you." He smiled cruelly, but not without some warped kindness.

Scorpia just nodded. Mermista did nothing.

"And, look! Your friends are here as well! Isn't that nice?"

Mermista turned, and the barely-there part of her that was still really, truly *her* , wanted to cry. Micah and Spinnerella entered and kneeled as well. That just left…Perfuma, Netossa, and Frosta. Adora and Glimmer were lost in space.

The Rebellion was done.

“Yes, it is, child.” A cold, metal-tipped hand cupped her jaw, and she shivered. “But do not fret, for I am a merciful and benevolent savior. You will all be brought to the light, as will your loved ones, to bask in the glow of my kingdom. But first, we must win. And in order to win, I must understand you. Scorpia, if you please…”

Mermista went back under, into more darkness this time, so much she couldn’t see anything, do anything. It was just her, alone. When she woke, she was on the table, and it was a blur of vague awareness. Hands opened her jaw, prodded her teeth. Her gills were spread, and she wanted to cry out at the burn, but couldn’t. Scales were picked off her body and placed into dishes. Her legs shifted to tail at some point, which was poked and prodded. Clones took notes on pads, apathetic to her discomfort. It was a blur of almost painful touch, scales being taken, transforming back and forth until she was exhausted. Eventually, she went back to sleep, and woke up again in a…pool. A green pool.

“This is a symbolic moment of cleansing, as we welcome our new sisters and brother!” Prime’s voice was everywhere. Cheers, sobs, warbling cries rang out. “Let us rejoice, as they purge themselves of all taint, and join us as the Purest Among All!”

Mermista was dunked into the pool, and the liquid filled her nose and mouth and lungs without having to inhale much at all. Even her respiratory system was having a hard time breathing through the viscous matter. She became aware, then, floating in the ether, of several things. Prime had let go of her for a second entirely, letting the liquid do its thing. And in that moment the bond slammed into her like a cargo ship. Whoever was on the other side (someone important, but *who?*) must have been *screaming* for her to hear them this loudly, from wherever she was. The bond was closed, cloaked in shadow, separating them almost completely, but what could leak through from the other end was acting as a barrier from the worst of Prime’s control, even now. She knew it wouldn’t save her completely, not right now, but it was something. With the last seconds of control she had, she sent a burst of love, fear, and what little else she had back, feeling it tear through the shadows and into the dark matter of her partner’s mind. And then, all was Prime, and whoever she had just been thinking about was long gone.

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Chapter End Notes

Hope you enjoyed!! Leave a comment if you did !

out on the edge and i’m screaming my name

Chapter Summary

Sea Hawk sets off to find Mermista

Chapter Notes

This chap was honestly one of my most favorites to write. I got to play with so many different characters and concepts. Hope you enjoy!

Warning: depression and suicidal thoughts discussed in abstract.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It took them two weeks to get the new camp fully hidden and set up, and only then could they start re-evaluating their mission. The goal remained the same: stay alive, defeat Prime, liberate Etheria. Now, though, there were several caveats; unchip their friends, get back in contact with Adora, Bow, Entrapta, and Glimmer if they have her. They had to set up food supply runs, water sources, and escape routes. They had to establish stricter security measures, stricter watches, and a tighter safe zone. Sea Hawk had never been so exhausted, and that was truly saying something. Everyone was lucky to get four, maybe five hours of sleep on their designated rest shift.

Netossa and Perfuma were splitting the role of leader. Netossa handled battle and planning strategy, coming up with ideas to free their friends and how to best fight back with their limited numbers. Perfuma took on resources and supplies, watch shifts, and healing, of course. Occasionally they would ask Sea Hawk to weigh in with one thing or another, supply routes, this area and its layout, but other than that they mercifully left him alone.

It was rote motion, the predictability of routine and the needs of others, that kept him moving. He and Swift Wind patrolled the border almost constantly, or went out scouting for whatever they needed. Occasionally, he fished when they needed it. His life was monochromatic, a constantly turning wheel of apathy. He ate, he bathed, he slept, but only out of some thin thread of obligation to…something. An idea of someone who wasn't there.

Double Trouble popped in occasionally with updates from the frontlines, keeping up their end of the bargain. When they were around, they gravitated to Sea Hawk, either from morbid curiosity at such "potent emotion", or attraction. Both ideas nauseated him, and he made sure to never be caught alone with the shapeshifter. It was one of these moments, though, that brought them the first scraps of news of their chipped loved ones in weeks.

They were sitting around the bonfire, himself, Perfuma, Frosta, Netossa, not exactly talking but not silent either, when the flap over the entrance rippled and a cloaked figure slipped in. Instantly, they were on their feet, sword drawn and magic ready, only relaxing when the figure slips the hood down. "Relax, divas. It's me."

"Neck."

DT sighed theatrically but turned, exposing their neck. Frosta checked, then nodded once. "Clear."

“Come, sit,” Perfuma gestured. “Hungry?”

“No, but I thought you all might be,” from within their cloak, DT produced a burlap sack, and tossed it to Sea Hawk. “Rations and fishing are only so much. And some for the veggie girl.”

The sack was full of fresh meat, rolls, cheeses, all magically preserved. Sea Hawk stopped Frosta’s eager hand. “Where did you get this, how long ago, and what spells?”

DT scoffed, offended. “I bring you food and this is how you treat me? Rude.” Netossa took a step forward, and they must have been genuinely a bit scared of her because they relented. “Tetchy, tetchy. Relax, your highnesses, it’s from Alwyn. From the small rebel group holed up just outside. Some plucky young things, real spunky. They stopped me, asked me where I was going, I told them, and they sent this along. Said to enjoy the bread, as it was handmade.”

Perfuma paused, and turned to the bag. “Check the rolls. Thoroughly. Have Swift Wind sniff them, too.”

Frosta nodded and carted off the bag for examination. DT stretched their legs out, leaning back on the log like this was a nice vacation spot and not a foxhole. “I come bearing news as well.” They fixed Perfuma, Sea Hawk, and Netossa with A Look. “About the chipped Princesses.”

Immediately, they were huddled around the shapeshifter, who leaned in, dead serious for once. “From what I could tell, both from listening in and from my own experience, Prime has stationed each Princess in a strategic position, slowly closing in on the remaining rebels. And, he seems to have figured out some Rune lore. Scorpia doesn’t stray far from the Fright Zone, or her Garnet. Mermista has control of…well, just about the entire eastern seaboard, including Salineas. Spinnerella is tricky to pin down. She comes and goes on Prime’s whim, and he knows he can move her the fastest so she’s all over the mainland territories.”

Netossa’s breath hitched. “So she never stops moving?”

“None of them do. If they stop, it’s because…” They glanced away. “Prime recalls them, sometimes. I saw Mermista and Scorpia, once, from a distance. Snips was leaving the communication spire. Mermaid was entering it. I think he takes them back to his flagship.”

Frosta padded back over. “There are messages baked into the rolls. I set them aside. Swift Wind says they’re fine to eat.” She sat down. “What about King Micah?”

“I heard a rumor that he’s in Mystacor.”

Netossa slapped the ground, standing. “That’s it. I’m going to look for her. I can’t sit by anymore.”

Perfuma scrambled to her feet. “Netossa, wait, please! We’re stronger together, we need you-”

“ *And I need my wife!* ” Netossa shouted, her voice bouncing off the carved rock.

Sea Hawk stood. “Let me go first. I’ll track them, and report back.”

“No. I appreciate it, but no.” Netossa shook her head. “We need Spinny back. She’s…I’m not strong enough on my own. Prime took our powerhouses, and he knows it. We have to start doing something about it, and I’m sorry, Perfuma, but we can’t do anything hiding here.”

“But-”

Frosta sighed. “They’re right. Let them go. You and I can hold things down here.”

“I’ll stay, too.” Swift Wind trotted over, munching on a roll. “Adora’s going to come back, and I need to be here when she does.” He nudged Sea Hawk with his nose, snorting. “Sorry, but this adventure isn’t for me.”

“Rest easy, noble steed.” Sea Hawk patted his neck. “I think this is going to be a solo event.”

DT stood, stretching. “I’ll hang around for a while, too. This last trip really took it out of me.”

Netossa nodded. “Right. You all get some rest, I’m going to ready supplies and take a look at strategy. Sea Hawk, we have to leave within the week. We should stagger our departures. I’ll leave a few days before you.”

He patted her shoulder, and wordlessly left for his sleeping mat. Footsteps were following him- light, soft, tentative. “Perfuma.”

“Sea Hawk…”

He dropped down to his mat, and began unlacing his shoes.

“What’s your plan?”

“Make for the coast and figure it out from there.” He turned to her sorrowfully. “Perfuma, a brave and intrepid man I may be…but not even I would brave Scorpia’s domain alone. I’m sorry.”

She hung her head. “I know,” she whispered. “I just…if what DT said is true, that they’re always *on* , I can’t imagine how tired they are.” She shifted to sit next to him. “Using magic for long periods of time is draining, that's why we all learned other ways to fight, too. If he's keeping them so close to their Runestones, then…"

"He's using too much to keep them away," Sea Hawk finished. "Like machines kept on a charging dock."

Perfuma nodded, jaw tight. "They're people. *Our* people. How could anyone do this?"

"He's a monster." Sea Hawk scrubbed a hand through his hair. This was the same conversation he'd been having with himself for weeks. "Perfuma, I… It's getting harder to feel her."

"What?" Perfuma snapped her head up. "The bond?"

Tears crowded his eyes, and he set his jaw in hopes they wouldn't fall as he nodded. "It's fading. I used to feel it when I fell asleep, or catch glimpses of her in my dreams. Now, it's like whispers. I…I think we're losing her. She's trapped in a small corner of her mind, and he's closing in on her."

"Oh, gods," Perfuma whimpered into her hand. "What…what do we do?"

It killed Sea Hawk, absolutely destroyed him, to answer. "I don't know."

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Mermista's mind had finally settled. Granted, it had settled in two pieces, but at least she was stable. There was *her* , the real her, sitting here in a corner of her mind, protected by some strange barrier that Prime couldn't quite breach yet. And not for lack of trying. She'd been dunked in his slime pool at least four times, laid out on exam tables so often she'd lost track, subjected to solitary, combat training, on and on. But he couldn't break that barrier.

It sure was weakening, though.

And then there was the her that had been hijacked by Prime. Which was still, like, her. She could feel it, witnessed it in first person, her arms raising, her voice speaking, water jumping to her command. But it was like watching a video on her datapad, if the glass was her own eyes. Her emotions weren't her own; perverse glee and satisfaction at a job well done as people fled, screaming. Annoyance at rebels, hatred for magic, even as she used it. It was a horrific first-person play she was the star of, a marionette on green strings.

Mermista didn't know how much time was passing. She didn't sleep, and ate sparingly- only enough to keep her body functioning- so there was no way to mark time like that. Sometimes, Scorpia was there, and she could feel the arachnid woman curled up in her own mind thanks to the hive connection. The darkness had nearly swallowed her as well. A few times, Mermista tried calling out, but no response ever came. She gave up after a while. Sometimes, Prime would leave her body for another's, or his own, and the shadows abated a bit more, enough for her to relax and breathe. Sometimes, in those moments, another presence, a familiar presence would flicker into her space, both around her and next to her. Like someone was holding her. Sometimes, she would just sit there and enjoy the feelings. Other times, she would try to grab it, only for it to slip away. It was only as her two selves grew more pronounced that she could start to see the other presence.

It was a human, she could tell. Another Etherian. A man, she was pretty sure. His presence would flicker, sometimes taking shape and form, other times just a hazy glow. When he was there, the shattered memories scattered around her feet would glow, some starting to knit together. When he left, they fell still.

Mermista was frustrated, helpless. She couldn't *do* anything, trapped here in her mind. It was a waiting game, only broken by the man who came and went, who she *knew* she was supposed to know. He was someone important, but she couldn't remember who. So she rested in limbo until one day, the presence did something.

He was strong that day. Prime was gone, occupying Spinnerella, so the shadows had stopped their assault on the barrier around her. The man flickered into view, and Mermista could make out distinct features. Thick facial hair, a sharp jaw, a starburst scar on his temple, gold in his ears, and something red around his neck. The man looked around, and as if seeing them for the first time, prodded on of the shattered remnants of a memory.

Mermista opened her mouth like she always did, trying to speak despite the futility. “Hey, can you, like, not?”

The man’s head snapped around dangerously fast, eyes widening. “M…Mermista?”

“Uh, duh? Who else?”

The man surged forward, and grabbed her. She yelped, even more so when he actually made ghostly contact with her skin and tugged her into him. He wasn’t quite corporeal, but he was solid enough. She collided with his chest, and warmth exploded through her. She didn’t realize how cold she’d been.

“I…I know you,” she murmured, staring up into onyx eyes. “Or, I’m supposed to.”

The man nodded, very sad. He turned to the fragments. “Are these…oh, dearest, are these your memories?”

“Yeah. At least, I think so.”

“Can I…?” He gestured to them, and she nodded. She trusted this man, even if she didn’t know why. He picked up one of the amber shards, and looking about, grabbed one of a matching shade. He snapped them back together, and sharp pain flooded Mermista’s head.

"Okay, we're gonna stand in one-two- up!"

Waves rushing below her, and hard waxed wood against her feet. Her arms around a toned calf, letting go slowly- carefully-

"That's it, ishu! You're surfing!"

Surfing. Yes, surfing. She loved surfing. Or, she had, when she still had time to enjoy things. Her mother had taught her-

"Ma! Look!"

Warm green eyes, like the ocean on a sunny day, not like- Him.

Mermista rocketed back to her body, to her corner of her mind. In her hands was the precious memory. Her mother, teaching her to surf. How could she have forgotten her own mother…?

"Little sister."

She hid the memory, sliding it behind her, behind the barrier. "Lord Prime."

The man was gone.

“Submit yourself for examination.”

She did, she always did, and he saw what he always saw- her, the barrier, the memory fragments. Prime scoffed. “Go, now, to the examination room.”

“Yes, Lord Prime.”

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Sea Hawk woke violently, with a gasp, and a burning headache. He had seen her- touched her- She was still in there, trapped. And he’d, they’d…

Mermista, no older than four, on a surfboard with her mother, Nerida. Standing, wobbling, letting go and finding her balance. Laughing. He had put one of her memories back together. Scrambling to his feet, he raced to find Perfuma and Netossa. Quickly, over fresh bacon and rolls, he filled them in.

Disbelief and concern gave way to realization. Hope. Netossa looked at Perfuma. “Take the next watch. I have to see if I can reach Spinny through our bond." She wrapped Sea Hawk in a brief, crushing hug. "Thank you."

Perfuma squeezed his hand. "This is good. This is…a chance."

While Netossa slept, she filled him in on the reports from Alwyn. The second largest (well, now the first largest, but least equipped) rebel force was holed up in some abandoned tree forts with the Plumerian peace force, who had been using the trees to get around and liberate whoever they could. There weren't many, and they weren't armed, but they were going to try and make it to them. She and DT were working on a plan to move them from the trees to the foxhole. Sea Hawk chimed in where he could, offering what little knowledge he had of the area.

Eventually, Perfuma dismissed him back to his mat with a cup of sleeping draught tea. "Try to sleep more, see if you can find her again."

Sea Hawk didn't hesitate to follow orders. He downed the scalding tea far too quickly and was asleep again in minutes.

He followed the path back the way he always did, until he reached the pool he'd first seen Mermista in. He dove without hesitation, and emerged in the closed off space of Mermista's mind. She was there, but she was…listless. Suspended between waking and sleep. Occasionally she would twitch, or grimace, but other than that, she was still.

He didn’t know how much time had passed- seconds, minutes, hours- but eventually she snapped back. Immediately, she doubled over in pain, clutching the back of her neck, and her legs. Muffled sobs reached his ears, and he wrapped her in his arms. Usually, when she was like this, she never even knew he was there. Still, he spoke.

“I’m here, dearest. I’m going to help you. I don’t know how, exactly, but I am.”

She didn’t respond, so he turned his attention back to the memories. He matched colors, snapping them back together, watching them flicker out of existence once he did. Mermista twitched with each joining, so he assumed they were absorbing back into their proper places in her actual mind. He hoped so, at least.

Eventually, he could feel himself fading. Mermista was still listless, unresponsive to his presence, but she looked more settled, at peace. More like herself. There were still more broken, scattered memories than there were healed ones, by far.

But that was okay, he thought. He wasn’t going anywhere.

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Mermista was back in the exam room. This time, in a tank of water. Her powerful tail flicked lazily, and she circled the tank in disinterest. In the room before her, Scorpia was sliding off the table. The clones in the room had collected skin samples, hair, flakes from her chiton, and more. Scorpia spared her a short, emotionless, green glance, before turning and leaving the room. In the corner, Prime stood, observing. He nodded in her direction, and his presence in her mind grew stronger, pushing her further into the corner until she was only observing again, at a complete loss of control.

She sighed, alone in her mind. All around her were glass fragments, but…less. With Prime occupied controlling her body and magic- he still couldn't figure out how to move her tail efficiently, which brought her a small amount of satisfaction- she had wiggle room to think, to feel, to take stock of what she had left. The shield didn't extend far beyond the fragments, and seemed to be shrinking more every day. She stood, and walked over to the shield, touching its rippling blue surface- not unlike water.

A pulse of emotion- strong, heady, and warm- shot through her, knocking her soul-self back onto her ass. She gasped for breath, and struggled onto her elbows. She couldn't place the feeling, but it was *strong* . And familiar. Steeling herself, she stood, and touched the barrier again. This time, she was ready for the shock, and when it hit her body, she let it run through her like an electric current. It burned, hotter than anything she'd ever felt, but was soothing and cool all at once. A desert oasis. She opened her eyes, and saw the glass shards hovering, sparking back to life. Her memories. Her emotions. A glance outside the bubble showed her Prime was well distracted, and the vague pain in her throat told her it was because they were prying her gills apart again. She'd have preferred they take more scales.

Carefully, but quickly, she pushed out with the energy in her, and watched as memories began knitting themselves back together. She wouldn't be able to get them all today, or for who knew how long, but she could do this. A flicker of hope, a candle's worth, took root in her heart.

When the man appeared again, she had exhausted herself. The energy was fading fast, and the pain from Prime's experimentation was becoming too much, so she was curled up again, waiting for it all to end. He might have said something, but it sounded like she was underwater. Something warm- his arms, maybe- wrapped around her, and she leaned into his embrace. The warm feeling from the barrier was back, but softer. Kinder. She let it lull her back into the limbo her consciousness rested in when she was neither here, nor there.

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Sea Hawk had left the camp three days ago, with only his rucksack, datapad, and sword. He had vowed to keep in touch with Perfuma, check in daily, and keep his eyes peeled for other rebels. He had just reached the coast, and had seen no sign of life other than himself. Etheria was eerily silent, like the planet itself was holding its breath.

Now, his camp was set up on the beach, just over the dunes. His boots and socks were propped near his tent, his jacket with them, warming next to the fire. Sea Hawk was ankle deep in the waves, just letting the ocean lap at him. He'd been on this beach before, years ago with Mermista.

Before her father left, before she was queen, before the Alliance- when it was just them, two kids falling headfirst in love with no idea what they were doing, but achingly happy anyway. They had been heading to some festival on another island in the archipelago, taking the long way and hopping from island to island on foot. They'd camped out here at night, and when the music from the festival just a mile away reached them, Mermista had taken his hands and they'd danced in the waves. He smiled at the memory, even though the salt on his lips wasn't from the ocean.

Sea Hawk's heart *ached* more than ever these days because he had been given back his hope. The sleeping tea was sitting in his bag, but he didn't think he'd need it tonight; getting from the Whispering Woods to the Salinean coast in just three days was no small feat, and he was completely exhausted. Plus, he needed his cunning wits out here, and a drugged sleep wouldn't be any help if he had to run. So, with his heavy heart, he left the waves, shoved some protein gunk in his mouth, and dropped off to sleep in his tent. He always dreamed before he reached the shared bond space, and tonight was no different. Memories of their last time at this beach played on a mocking loop in his head.

Mermista in a beautiful sarong and jeweled choli, her face still young and carefree. She was laughing at him, and he was telling some ridiculous story they both knew was false. When he took a deep breath to start singing, a wave bowled him off his feet and knocked him into the surf. When he came up, she was laughing, her real, beautiful laugh that she felt was too loud, too raucous for others to hear. He loved her laugh. Especially when she snorted, and covered her face with her hands because it made her laugh that much harder. She offered him a hand, and pulled him to his feet. As she dragged him down to her height to press his lips to hers, the scene shifted.

They were tangled in sheets in their tent, and he couldn't tell if it was their tent from the festival or the rebel camp. But that didn't matter, not when he was underneath her and she was rocking against him, a tide moving to a rhythm only they knew. He knew this couldn't be just a memory, this was too sensual and earthy, completely unlike how they'd been with one another in those first years. The kind of rhythm borne from years of practice, of knowing your partner better than you knew yourself.

Her rich bronze skin was impossibly smooth under his hands, and he gripped her thigh and lower back so hard he knew he would bruise if he could. It didn't matter, as long as she stayed. Her bare chest pressed against his was driving him mad, and the wild look in her amber-gold eyes wasn't helping. He refused to blink. If he did, this might end, and he'd be alone again. Instead, he surged up and kissed her hard, and felt her moan reverberate in his chest like his own. When he pulled away, they were both crying.

"I know you," she gasped out, almost confused. "I know I do. I know you're important, but I don't- *ah!* - know why. I can't remember." She sobbed against his mouth, rocking harder. "Please, I want to remember. *Help me remember* ."

"Anything," he gasped, nearing his peak, desperate to get her to hers. "Anything, my love. I'd climb one hundred mountains, sail one thousand oceans, if it brought you back to me. I'd pluck every star out of the night sky, and box them up one by one for you if it made you happy."

Mermista laughed, sadly, and shook her head, even as her thighs began shaking. "W-why are you like this?" It was half-rhetorical, half-curious, but the answer was always the same.

As they both tipped over the edge, he leaned up again to kiss her, breathless, desperate, needing. "Because I love you, dearest."

Sea Hawk woke with a violent start, gasping for air like he'd run a marathon. Tears on his cheeks, and heart heavier than ever, he rolled over into his pillow and sobbed for all he was worth. Sobbed in the way he hadn't let himself this whole time, and desperately needed to.

Mermista was gone. Taken from him by an evil entity thousands of miles away in space, and he had no real way of knowing how to get her back. Everything that made her who she was, that made her strong, brave, smart, sarcastic, caring- gone. He…he might never hear her laugh again, watch her eyes crinkle up even as she's rolling them. Might never hold her hand again, might never kiss those beautiful, pouting lips ever again. Never help her dress for an event, amusing and distracting her because she doesn't really want to go in the first place, not when they could curl up by the fire, or on the balcony, and read Mer-Mysteries and drink wine. They'd never sing together again, or dance, or make love.

She could well and truly be gone, in every way that mattered.

Sea Hawk staggered to his feet, suddenly overcome by nausea, and pushed his way out of his tent to sprint for the shoreline and vomit. The grief was choking him, even after his stomach was well empty. He washed his mouth out with salt water, tears still falling, and made his way back to camp. He changed his clothing, tossing his underwear- deemed unsalvageable after his dream- in the fire, and walked back out to the waves, sitting in the sand just shy of their reach. At a complete and total loss for the first time, well, ever, he flopped onto his back and watched the stars.

An hour later, he was being woken from a fitful doze by the sound of splashing, like someone was walking…toward…him-

Sea Hawk was on his feet in a flash, moving away from the splashing on instinct. He was a fool, leaving his sword back by his camp, but he could do okay in a brawl with a couple of clones, and could probably outrun a bot- All these thoughts, however, came to a screeching halt when he got a good look at the figure walking…out of the ocean? He blinked, and rubbed his eyes- and then swore under his breath when that got him an eyeful of sand. This was no mirage though; Former-King Mercia was walking out of the ocean, and he'd just seen Sea Hawk.

The older man's lip curled in disdain. "Oh good. It's *you* ."

Sea Hawk shuddered, the cadence of his voice so very like Mermista's that it shook him to the core. He had nothing pithy to say, so he stood and brushed his pants off. "Yes, it's me." He turned and stalked back to his camp.

Of course, Mercia followed, the hilt of his trident- less grand than the one Mermista now wielded, but no less deadly- brushing sand up as it hit the ground.

Sea Hawk walked to the far side of the fire, daring the man to come any closer while he grabbed for his sun blade.

Mercia stood across from him. “So, *boy,* ” he snorted contemptuously. “What have you been up to? Contracted by the Horde like all your pirate friends? Moving goods and people that have destroyed thousands?”

Sea Hawk set his jaw. “For your information, not that it’s really any of your business, I joined the Rebellion, and I work with the Princess Alliance. More than you’ve been doing, clearly.”

“Watch your tone, pirate.” Mercia glared at him. Sea Hawk glared back, and eventually Mercia tossed his head, redirecting his eyes to the fire. “So. You’re still clinging to my daughter like the scraggly barnacle you are?”

“Something like that.” Sea Hawk smirked. Mercia leveled a look at him, shrewd and disbelieving and fairly annoyed, a look that said ‘you know something I don’t and I’m not sure if I care yet’, and Sea Hawk’s heart ached again. He’d never realized how similar Mermista and her father looked. She was a dead-ringer for her mother physically, but her facial expressions seemed to be all Mercia. He recalled his wife saying that they’d been close when she was young, very young.

“Wonderful to know my daughter is still goofing off when she has responsibilities to tend to-”

He wasn’t even aware he was moving until he was directly in front of Mercia, face to face. The man had always seemed so tall, so intimidating, larger than life. In reality, they were about the same build, and although Mercia was more filled out, Sea Hawk had an inch on the man. “Listen here, you fucking *coward* . Your daughter, the love of my *life* , has been through hell itself. Not that you would know, seeing as you fucked off to gods-know-where and left her *alone* . She made Salineas into more than you ever could, despite everyone and everything saying she couldn’t. When it fell, she almost killed herself in grief. And *now* , she’s in Prime’s hands.” Grim satisfaction curled low in Sea Hawk’s chest at the horror dawning slowly in Mercia’s eyes. “He’s chipped her, and she’s gone.” His voice broke, but he refused to look away. Let Mercia see his tears. Stars knew the man hadn’t shed a single one for his only child yet. “So you can fuck right off, *your majesty* . You abandoned your kingdom, your people, your *daughter* to the world. In my mind, that washes you of all ability to pass judgment on what’s transpired in your self-imposed absence.”

Mercia looked away at last, staring into the fire, silent for many minutes. His pagri was fine silk, befitting a nobleman, the jewel in the center glowing faintly. His mustache and beard were a deep navy, shot through generously with silver. His eyes were amber, just like Mermista, and their noses had the same proud profile as well. Mercia’s eyes were tired, and bore dark circles and lines that his daughter’s didn’t. Where Mermista had laugh lines that crinkled when she smiled, Mercia had frown lines. Sea Hawk was so intent on studying the man he’d only really met once- and he had the scar on his temple to remember the occasion- that when he spoke, he nearly jumped.

“There’s nothing I can say, no platitudes or reassurances, that would be honest. I wanted to leave. I was scared. I didn’t…care… about the burden it would put on my daughter’s shoulders. Let me explain.” He held up a hand when Sea Hawk opened his mouth.

“After we lost Nerida…surely you can understand the all-consuming pain.” He said it almost like a challenge, like Sea Hawk’s love for his wife was less than Mercia’s own.

“I still wouldn’t have done what you did.”

“No?” Mercia laughed humorlessly. “Picture it, Captain. Say you had a child, right now, with Mermista. And that child was all you would ever have left of her. That child who looks exactly like her mother, walks and talks and laughs like her mother- until she doesn’t.” Mercia inhaled shakily. “All I had left of my beautiful wife, my love, was Mermista. And she drew away from me, more and more as the years went on. And one day I looked, and all that was left of my wife was gone from her, too. Somedays, it was like I was living with a stranger. A foundling child, not my daughter. Not my *chottu* . I had lost Nerida, and then, I had lost Mermista. The grief…”

“You didn’t *lose* her.” Sea Hawk frowned. “You pushed her away, locked her out of your life. Mermista told me how you never included her in your day-to-day, how you both went weeks without seeing one another. That getting any scrap of affection from you was harder than taking away a shark’s dinner- her very words.”

Mercia glared. “I was hard on her, yes. But the world is a hard place, Captain. You know this, I know this. She needed to be ready. I had to protect her however I could, and prepare her.”

“Children don’t need their parents to toughen them up,” Sea Hawk growled. “They know the world is scary, and hard. They’ll learn that on their own as they grow. Children need a safe, kind place to land, someone to turn to, when the world doesn’t stop. And you never let her have that.”

Mercia looked away. “I did my best. I was a single father and the ruler of a kingdom I was never supposed to inherit.”

Sea Hawk scoffed, and they lapsed into silence once again.

When Mercia spoke again, his voice was barely above a whisper. “I left her because my grief was killing me. And seeing her every day, growing to look just like her mother…call me as cruel as you wish, but I couldn’t have her knowing she was driving me to sealonging just by existence.”

“Sealonging?” The term was vaguely familiar.

Mercia sighed, heavily. “It’s an ailment of the soul, the heart, and the mind. It can stem from grief, or can creep up suddenly for no certain reason. It’s…somewhat of an old merfolk myth these days.”

“What is it?”

“It’s a baseless longing that takes root in your very being, and makes peace and contention impossible for as long as you live once it’s begun. It can take years to develop, and severity can vary by individual.” Mercia sighed. “The only thing that calms it is returning to the sea, to submit yourself back to the waters you came from. Even now, just being out of the ocean for this long, the waves in my ears are almost deafening.”

Sea Hawk stared at him in horror. “There’s no cure?”

“No.”

“Does she…”

“ *No* ,” Mercia whirled on him, glaring. “And she never can. Our family is more liable to be afflicted by this for reasons unknown; if she knows I’ve been cursed…you know my daughter, Captain. She becomes…paranoid.” Mercia sighed angrily. “It may be hard to believe. But despite everything, all the harm I’ve done her, on purpose and by accident, I love Mermista.” He stared into the fire. “It’s terrifying, you know. To feel such overwhelming love for something so…fragile.” Mercia almost smiled then, lost in memories. “And yet, so very strong. She was so loud, when she was born. Ironic, now, hm? She wailed and wailed, and I remember holding her, and thinking it ridiculous that something so tiny could make such a sound. So tiny her head didn’t even fill my palm, but loud enough to deafen me. *Meri chand ke tukra* .”

Sea Hawk swallowed the lump in his throat. “What’s that?”

“My piece of the moon.” Mercia murmured.

They fell silent again for a while.

“I don’t like you,” Sea Hawk said at last. Blunt, like Mermista would want him to be. “And I probably never will. And I know you feel the same. But we both love Mermista more than life itself, or so you claim. So, I think she’d want you to know- *AHH!* ”

Sea Hawk was suddenly airborne, the stars whirling around him before he smashed into the sand hard. He groaned, struggling to get to his elbows. His vision was spotty and his head was aching a fair bit, and- yep- there was blood in his mouth. He blinked, and barely had enough wherewithal to get to his knees and dive out of the way of an oncoming stream of ocean water.

Well, he had finally found Mermista.

“Hello, sailor.” Her voice, her beautiful voice, was robotic and flat.

As he staggered to his feet, he got his first good look at her in weeks, and felt his stomach drop. She was as gorgeous as ever, but covered in bruises and cuts and scrapes. Her skin was sallow, dark circles around her eyes, and she had clearly lost muscle and weight. Her hair was braided tightly, but caked with sea salt and dust. There was blood spattered along her throat, chin, up to her face, and he couldn't tell if it was her own or…

"Mermista!" he gasped, taking a staggered step toward her.

Her lip pulled back in a sneer. "Not anymore." She swung her arm wide, and another wave of ice cold sea water bowled him over. He got to his feet just in time to be hit again, this time going sprawling down the beach. He coughed up lungfuls of sea water as he heard her approach.

"This vessel may have once had that name, but in my light, there are no names. There is only Prime."

"Freak." Sea Hawk coughed, only to choke when Mermista's foot connected with his ribs. He groaned, trying to scramble away, and received another blow to the jaw for his struggle. "Mermista, stop! Please, dearest, it's me!"

" *Dearest* ," she drawled, so alien and cold. "Ah, yes. This vessel once held a great deal of affection for you. Love, as you would so falsely call it on this planet." Her face fell vacant, like Prime was shuffling through notes. "She felt it made her weak. Hmph…" She almost chuckled. "Well, she had enough awareness to realize that, at least."

"You're wrong." Sea Hawk struggled to his feet, holding his blade in a vice grip. "Love is strength. It lights the fires of our souls, gives us reason to *fight-* "

"My, she also felt a good deal of annoyance for your prattle." Mermista's lip curled again. One hand trailed almost sensually up her arms to hold herself in a loose embrace. "It seems that this vessel and I share many an opinion-"

Sea Hawk surged forward, ripping her hands off her arms. " *Don't you dare touch her-* "

"Jealousy," she purred. "Anger, sorrow, hate…come now, captain. Aren't you tired of these negative, petty emotions? The bitter taste they leave in your mouth." She yanked one of her hands free, and cupped his jaw gently.

Sea Hawk's breath stuttered, and he treacherously leaned into her palm. It wasn't her, he *knew* it wasn't her. But oh *gods* did he want it to be. Need it to be.

"Join me, *her* , in my light. Reunite with her in my glory, and never be parted again."

He was leaning in, watching the green fade from her eyes just enough to see her pupils. She leaned forward as if to kiss him, her hand snaked around…his…neck-

Sea Hawk jerked back, grabbing her arms and throwing her away from him as hard as he could. The chip she'd been holding fell to the ground, and he smashed it with his heel. Mentally, he berated himself viciously. How could he have been so foolish? Just because it was Mermista's face, her body-

It was Prime. And that wasn't going to change without him.

Mermista snarled, and lunged for him. He caught her, rolling back and kicking up into her ribs to send her flying. He grabbed his sword and took off running. Mercia…where was Mercia? Out of the corner of his eye, he saw the old king slinking through the shadows, spell circles around his hands keeping him out of Mermista's sight.

Or so he thought; Mermista spun around, nailing her father in the chest with a jet of water. The spell broke, and he landed harshly a bit away from Sea Hawk.

"Fool. Prime sees all. Even your paltry parlor tricks are no match for my sight," she sneered. Then, a look of contemplation. "This vessel…she knows you. Oh, dear." A sick grin pulled her lips apart. "Such a wealth of horrid emotions. Anger, so dark I would almost think it hatred. Except for that large swath of pain. Hurt…and *fear* . Fascinating. Hurt, fear, anger…and yet. There remains love. A yearning for it to be returned. And a gaping pit of loss." She tapped her chin with one torn up nail. "You must be her father. King Mercia?"

Mercia glared. "What is it to you, tyrant?"

“It is absolutely nothing to *me* .” She grinned. “But to her… Mermista…it was once everything. Oh, yes, it’s all here. The desperation to prove herself to you in exchange for your approval, your attention. Your love, she thought.”

“My daughter knew-”

“She didn’t.” Mermista shrugged, as if this was some bit of trivia and not the greatest source of emotional pain she had ever endured. “But that’s irrelevant now. All of it, the long nights she sat up studying, or training, or just *weeping* , wondering why she wasn’t enough for you, the days she wished she’d never been born into your line, the long and lonely years of knowing she would never ever be enough…all irrelevant now. *I* have healed her pain, cured her of her suffering. All of the harm you’ve done, offered up to me and burned away.” Mermista grinned, even as a tear slid down her cheek. “Is this not better? Simpler? Is this not happiness in its purest form?”

Mercia was trembling, with rage and pain, and Sea Hawk felt a large amount of satisfaction at the understanding that was *finally* dawning on him. Too bad it was fucking *Prime* who had made him seen the light. Sea Hawk took the opportunity to stand, and attempted to back away silently. Maybe if he could sneak around behind her-

A tendril of water lashed his ankle and he fell sprawling to the sand. He spat granules out of his mouth, keeping his sword up as he got back to his feet. Mermista had turned from Mercia, and was nearly on top of him. Sea Hawk was out of ideas. Except-

"Mermista! Dearest, I know you're in there," he yelled with all his chest. "It's me! It's Sea Hawk. You've known me for years, my love. You know who I am!"

"She does not," Prime snarled in his beloved's voice.

"Oh, yes she does!" Sea Hawk smirked. Mermista began sending waves at him, and he did his best to slice through and dodge the waves as he tried to shout down the demon in her head. "We met almost seven years ago- you were eighteen, almost nineteen and I was twenty. You taught me how to eat kelp and sushi, and we danced all night. We spent three years together before your father left, and you sent me away so you could focus on the throne."

She faltered a wave.

"You were the most beautiful girl I'd ever met, and *are* the most gorgeous, brilliant woman I'll ever know. We've fought side by side for nearly four years, and every single day I love you more."

She stumbled, her face contorting as she grabbed her head.

He held his breath. Out of the corner of his eye, he saw movement, and realized Mercia was making his way back up the shore, trident in hand, fear and grief in his eyes visible even from here. He knew he had to lay out all the cards now or never. He took a deep breath, praying that she’d forgive him for this when he had her back. “Mermista, one year ago *to the day* , we married, connected forever by the magic of Etheria.”

Both Mermista and Mercia froze, staring at him. Did the green in her eyes flicker?

“You’re my wife, and I love you.” His voice cracked treacherously. “And no chip on your neck, or dictator in your brain can ever change that. I promise.”

Mercia was now in Mermista’s line of sight, and the sight of him shocked her back a few feet, even while he continued to grip her head. With a pained groan, she fell to her knees, and when she opened her eyes, they were normal.

Sea Hawk choked on a sob. “Wha…”

“Mermista,” Mercia’s voice trembled, and his trident fell from his fingers as he reached out toward her. “My beautiful Mimi…my *chotta* …”

Tears welled in her eyes, and she looked so painfully young as she reached back for her father. “ *Baba…* ” Her eyes slid past him, connecting with Sea Hawk, and widened. She struggled to her feet, still clutching her head. “Sebastian… *Sebastian!* ”

She tried to run for him, lunge for him, but both men were frozen in horror as she jerked to a stop, a puppet whose strings had just been tightened. Her body seized, contorting unnaturally as they heard bones and pop and crack. Her spine bent harshly back, and it was only Mercia's iron grip on his bicep that kept Sea Hawk from running to her. When she relaxed, her eyes were green and furious once again. She pulled her arm back, ready to deliver a devastating blow.

Sea Hawk shut his eyes, bracing himself-

Only to be grabbed and *yanked* out of the way. He opened his eyes to see a wall of water crash into the ground where he had been standing, leaving a crater the size of Emily. Sea Hawk himself was about ten feet in the air…hovering. Below him, Mercia had thrown up a hasty shield spell, and lowered him down behind it. Sea Hawk stared in shock. "Thank…you."

"Really don't mention it." Mercia frowned. "Ever. Do not mention this, ever."

"Done."

Mermista snarled at the barrier, not even attempting to get closer. "Clearly, this vessel is not nearly as attuned as it should be. *Useless* ," she muttered to herself. Water surged out of the sea, swirling around her, and when it receded back to the basin, she was gone.

Sea Hawk fell to his knees, slamming his fist against the sand over and over. " *Fuck!* She was right there, we had her-!"

"You had nothing, my boy," Mercia sighed tiredly. "She barely broke free for ten seconds. There was nothing we alone could have done."

"Coward," he spat.

Mercia remained silent.

Tears were sliding down Sea Hawk's cheeks, clumping the sand below him where they fell. He righted himself, wiping his face. "Where will you go now?"

"I cannot leave the sea. But, I will try to follow my daughter." Mercia's mask was back in place, eyes vacant and bored and annoyed. "That monster is taking her back to one of his spires, I imagine. She will be even more dangerous in the water. But who knows? I may get lucky." He turned to Sea Hawk as he climbed to his feet. "Married?"

"Confluence. The night of the invasion."

"Ah." Mercia nodded. For a long time he was silent. "It is not my place to approve or disapprove anymore. Had it been up to me, my daughter would have married a merfolk noble. Or perhaps

Peekablue, though I do believe they'd have murdered one another in some elaborate, theatrical fashion."

Sea Hawk almost smiled at that.

"But, as it stands…you clearly mean more to her than I ever realized, if you could break through Prime's hold like that. I maintain you are a lazy, fanciful pirate, who suffers from deep seated delusions of grandeur, and had it been between you and a walrus, I would have needed to sit in deep consideration for many days. However…I have wounded my daughter far more than I realized, been wrong in many places I had known myself to be right. Maybe this…is one of those places."

"I maintain you are a coward, and treated your daughter horribly in the years before you left. But…I understand that grief is…that each of us can only do our very best in the moment. I still don't think you even did that, but maybe you can going forward."

Mercia stared at the waves, as if in a trance. "Do you really think you can win this? Get her back and be the hero?"

Sea Hawk sighed. "I have no idea. But I have to try."

"Why?"

"Because it's the only path left."

Mercia said nothing, and after a long moment, he turned to the sea as if he hadn’t even heard Sea Hawk. It wouldn’t have shocked the sailor. The ocean swallowed him in inky darkness, and the last he saw of the former king was a shimmering navy tailfin cresting the waves.

Chapter End Notes

Mercia will be making a reappearance before the end of this fic.

Credit for the concept of sealonging as depression/suicidal ideation goes to my very dear friend deheerkonijn. If you like lord of the rings, ABSOLUTELY check out her incredible writing and art.

missing you

Chapter Summary

> Reunions abound as emotions run high. Three u likely friends have a chat.

Chapter Notes

> Sorry this took forever!! I'm like. Sick af lmao. But in other news
>
> THIS STORY IS DONE. The main chapters are written. And all that remains is the epilogue(s). Ngl very emotional about it. We're in the very tip top of the home stretch now!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Sea Hawk didn't remember the walk back to camp, lost in thought as he was. Mercia was alive, and was inflicted with 'sea-longing' as he called it. Mermista was one of Prime's favored playthings, if her appearance was anything to go off of. Just the thought of his stolen love, battered and bruised and clearly so exhausted was enough to ignite a fire in his blood. Her beautiful mind and her body, in the clutches of a psychotic tyrant who clearly didn't care for her wellbeing or basest sense of survival, if that, made him burn with rage.

It was this rage that kept him from focus as he stumbled back into range of camp, ignorant of the magical barrier he passed through until he was well beyond it. He paused, looking back at the invisible line. When did that-

"SEA HAWK! "

He spun around, hope filling his heart, just in time to see Bow charging toward him. “BOW!” The younger man crashed into him, and Sea Hawk caught him around the middle, barely staying on his feet. “You’re back!”

They stayed hugging for a while, Sea Hawk all but collapsing into the familiar comfort of a friend he wasn’t sure he’d ever see again. Tears sprung to his eyes, and he let them- there was no shame in reunion. When he pulled back, he saw Bow was crying a bit, too, grief and joy mingling. “Sea Hawk, we-”

“Hawk!”

“Sea Hawk!”

Adora and Glimmer came sprinting out of the base, grinning madly. He smiled back, pleased to know they’d missed him even a bit. Somedays, he still felt these were all Mermista’s friends who just sort of tolerated him. But as the Princesses wrapped him in strong hugs, he felt the warmth of friendship burning away the all-consuming storm of grief until it was a mere cloud.

“Sea Hawk, we’re so glad you’re okay!”

“Of course! I’m Sea Hawk, I am!” But his usual motto rang hollow, even to him, and they pulled back to give him twin- triplet, counting Bow- looks of sympathy.

“We…heard. About Mermista.” Glimmer’s lip trembled. “We’re so sorry we weren’t here to help.”

“There’s no one to blame but Prime.” He shook his head. “Even with you here, an attack was inevitable. At least now, we have She-Ra again.”

Adora stood a bit straighter, nodding with purpose. “We’ll get Mermista back. In fact, we have some news about that. C’mon, Netossa was waiting for you to debrief.”

The girls turned back inside, but Bow hung back, wrapping an arm around his shoulders. “Really, though…how are you?”

“Terrible.” Sea Hawk shrugged, seeing no point in lying. Not now. “I feel like…I’ve lost my purpose. I am my own man, make no mistake, but Mermista…without her, there’s no sunrise, no beauty, no- no *passion* in my life. My fire is gone.”

Bow hugged him tighter. “We’ll get her back.”

“Or all die trying,” he muttered.

“Yeah, that seems about where we’re all at.” Bow frowned suddenly. “I feel like I wanted to tell you something, but I can’t remember what.”

“I guess that means it wasn’t important.”

Inside, he hugged Perfuma, Frosta, and Netossa in greeting. Entrapta patted his arm in greeting and sympathy, mask down, wrapping one of her hair tendrils loosely about his shoulders. Double Trouble was long gone, shocking no one. Swift Wind was napping against a wall, along with a strange…half-bot, half-mammalian, water-maned cat…thing? And Catra was leaning against one of the supply crates. Business as-

Catra?

Sea Hawk froze, staring at the feline conqueror, and felt his fingers itch for his blade. She turned, lazily, and made eye contact with him. She froze, apprehension taking her over until her fur was standing on end. Next to Swift Wind, the cat was waking up, its mane shifting from blue to a burning yellow.

“What is *she* doing here?” he snarled, and Catra’s ears flattened.

Bow rubbed his chin. “Oh yeah, that’s what it was.”

Adora was suddenly in front of him. “It’s a lot to explain, but she’s on our side now.”

“I have time.” He saw Adora swallow nervously, and wondered if she’d ever seen him so serious. If she even knew he was capable of the malice stirring in his heart. “Adora, she was *there* . She stood over the burning wreckage of my home, *Mermista’s home* , and laughed. So you better have a damn good explanation.”

“She was with Glimmer, on Prime’s ship.” Adora gripped his shoulders, eyes boring into his, begging him to understand. “He had them, and she…she saved Glimmer. She got her out, sent us the coordinates, and transported her right to us at- at her own expense. He chipped her for it, took her away from herself and then, when I went back for her…”

Adora’s eyes filled with tears, and against his will, Sea Hawk’s heart began to bend.

“We fought. He made her fight me. And I - I promised, okay? I promised I’d bring her home. And I promised so many things over so many years, I just *had* to see this one through. But then he- he threw her off this ledge and she…” Tears slipped down her cheeks. “She died. I couldn’t get to her in time. I failed. She was gone. And that’s when She-Ra came back, *because of her* . So, I know she has a lot to apologize for, a lot to help rebuild. But give her that chance. The chance to- to atone.”

Sea Hawk sighed, shutting his eyes, and when he realized they were surrounded by people, tugged Adora over to a secluded corner, out of most's earshot. He wasn't so sure about Catra. "Adora," he murmured. "Do you…is this love?"

Blue eyes widened, before she sighed and hung her head. She nodded. "Yeah. I know, okay? I know she did horrible things to us, to *me* personally. I know she's not alright yet, and it's going to take a long time. I know. But I can't-"

"Help it." He smiled sadly. "Believe me when I say I understand. The heart is illogical, and fickle, and very rarely do we get to choose who we love. Adora, I trust you completely. You're our champion, and more than that." He placed a hand on her shoulder. "I consider you my friend. So, if this is your choice, then I respect it. And you."

Adora smiled, eyes wet with unshed tears. "Thank you, Sea Hawk."

"However…" His smile faded. "If- *when* - Mermista returns, I cannot promise even a fraction of the understanding I'm extending here. Not personally, not politically, and not on behalf of Salineas." He fixed her with a grave look. "We lost people, Adora. Many, many people. And that will haunt Mermista until she dies."

"I know." Adora sighed, pressing the heels of her hands into her eyes.

“An apology will be a start. But it can’t be forced, or prompted. Adora, she *has* to mean it.”

“...I know.”

“Alright.” Sea Hawk tugged her into a hug then. “She is very cute, though.”

Adora snorted loudly, drawing more attention, so they patted each other’s backs and let go. They rejoined the group, and while his mood didn’t immediately sour, it certainly faded to something more…cautious around Catra. She refused to make eye contact with him, and that suited Sea Hawk just fine. He noticed Perfuma next to him was even tenser than he was, and it brought him some comfort.

Netossa came to the head of the table they stood around. “Alright, is everyone good? Here’s the deal.”

She, Adora, and Glimmer- with occasional interjections from Bow, and even a few from Catra- told them about Prime’s ship, their time in space, Erelandia, how they found Spinnerella, and how they got through to her eventually. For the first time in weeks, Sea Hawk felt real hope spark in his heart. *He could save her* . His palms grew sweaty as he began to connect the dots- the dreams, the moments of connections he was having with Mermista in their shared Bond space- and knew he had to speak up.

He cleared his throat. "That would make sense, Netossa. With the Bond space? If you were able to contact her, help her-"

The Princess' eyes widened. "That's right. I haven't checked since before- alright, Perfuma, can you make me some tea?"

"Right away." The willowy woman rushed off toward the firepit, Netossa in tow, leaving Sea Hawk with a very confused Best Friend Squad.

"Bond space?"

"As in…?"

"What's that?" Adora looked bewildered, while Bow and Glimmer were more…assessing. Catra was side-eyeing him, but her cat-thing was staring in rapt attention.

"A 'Bond Space' is a shared, intangible mental space between two magically linked individuals," Bow recited from memory. "It's the home of their, well, Bond- capital B- which is the forged magical link itself. There are different types of Bonds, forged in different ways and between different people. Siblings can have them, or battle-companions, shield-brothers, whatever, but the most common Bond in our age is forged by marriage, between two magical beings, or one very powerful magical being, and a mortal."

“Powerful like…a Princess?” Adora whirled on him, wide-eyed.

Glimmer smirked, slowly. “ *Exactly* like a Princess. Sea Hawk…”

“Are you and Mermista…” Giddiness was overtaking Bow.

“ *Married?!”* Adora finished, jaw dropping. Even Catra had spun around, a look of astonishment taking over.

Sea Hawk cleared his throat, loosening his neckerchief with a finger. “Whooo boy, is it warm in here? Just me? No?”

“ *SEA HAWK!* ”

“Yes, yes, alright, yes!” He threw his hands up. “We’re married, yes!”

“When?”

“Where?”

“Why?” That one was Catra.

“How?”

“ *WHAT?* ”

“Please.” He held his hands up. “I’ll explain, I promise. It was after Salineas fell, hours before the Heart went off. Mermista knew… something could happen, something bad, and so when we snuck back into the palace to retune her connection to the Pearl, we had a Confluence. It’s an ancient Salinean marriage, only legal there. It’s not a coronation, and it’s not universally recognized. But…”

“She’s your wife?” Adora’s eyes shone with emotion. He nodded, choked up.

“The Heart…” Glimmer frowned. “That was- you’ve been married a little over a *year?!* ”

Sea Hawk frowned, counting on his fingers. “No that’s…oh my stars.” Realization dawned on him, and he whistled. “Yes, *wow* . A little over a year. She’s been chipped since August 2nd, I hadn’t realized.”

“Since your birthday practically.” Glimmer frowned.

“Oh, yeah.” Sea Hawk tilted his head, considering. “I forgot about that. I guess I’m twenty six.”

“Happy belated.” Bow nudged him. He chuckled a bit, and then sombered.

“We didn’t keep it from you in specific. It was just safer to play it down, be as covert as possible. I’m not technically King, so there’s no political change or anything-”

“Sea Hawk, we don’t care about that!” Glimmer exclaimed. “We’re just glad to know. We’re happy for you- both of you.” They sobered briefly, before she smirked. “Sooooo it was Mermista’s idea?”

“Yeah.” He couldn’t stop the grin tugging at his lips. “She said she’d rather die husband and wife than ‘whatever the fuck we’ve been doing for years’. And though I may be a fool, I’m no idiot. It was…my dream come true. Being her husband is as natural as sailing for me. It’s where I’m meant to be- at her side.” He sighed, smile slipping away. “I’d give anything to have her back here.”

“You will.” Catra startled all of them from their bubble. “I’ve…been where she is. Not for as long, sure. But…yeah. She’s going to be okay. Eventually. ” A clawed hand crept up to clutch the back of her neck. “You guys seem… you’re gonna get through this.”

“Thank you,” he said sincerely, shocking her enough to raise her eyes to his. “I don’t know you as a person, Catra. But you don’t seem one for platitudes, so that means a lot.”

“I…” She swallowed. “Yeah. Sure. You’re, uh, welcome.”

“Well, I’m off to sleep.” He yawned, jaw clicking. “I’ve been on foot for two days, and before that, my darling wife used me as a beach-side rag doll, so I’d like to rest my bruised spine.”

“Wait.” Netossa and Perfuma meandered back over. “You found her?”

“I did! Well, she found me. I also happened to find Former King Mercia.”

“ *What!* ” Perfuma and Glimmer gasped.

“Yes, he was as pleasant as always. Sadly, I have nothing to report other than what you discovered.” He sighed. “We broke the connection, briefly. But Prime grabbed her back almost immediately.”

“We’re so close,” Netossa groaned, downing the rest of her tea in one go. “Alright, Hawk. We’re on wife duty. Everyone else- start working on the Fright Zone plan, but getting rest is most important.”

Sea Hawk saw Glimmer bristle a bit at being ordered around so casually, but a soft, lingering touch from Bow soothed any ruffled feathers. Hmmm…Sea Hawk wondered what had changed in space. As his back hit his bedroll, though, any such ponderings slipped away from him as quickly as they came, until sleep was pulling him under like a gentle wave.

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Mermista came to with a shuddering gasp of pain, alone in her mind for the first time in days. Her physical body ached, *badly* . She was in a cell of some sort, on Prime's flagship. The green haze was still there, but it had receded enough for her to see with her own eyes. Prime had dunked her in the gunk-tank again, raged when it still didn't breach her mental barriers, subjected her to more exams, and then depleted her magical reserves down to almost nothing in some combat "training". Really, he just beat the shit out of some clones, and then vice versa.

She tried to roll over, she was in a decently soft bed, but only succeeded in aggravating the bruising along her ribs. She bit down on a cry, but couldn't stop the tears that sprung to her eyes. She missed…she missed… *why couldn't she remember?* It was like her brain had the hiccups. With a huff, she let her eyes slide shut, and found herself back in that weird dreamscape, behind a barrier, her scattered memories around her. She took a shallow breath, peering into the shadows beyond the bubble. She couldn't feel Scorpia, or Spinnerella, very closely. Only the clones (' *Brothers-' NO*) and, very distantly, Prime. He was distracted, busy with something. She turned back to the mess that had once been her mind. It was now or never.

Hastily, but as calmly as she could, she began connecting the fragments, not giving herself even a moment to bask in the emotions, the powerful *feelings* , each elicited. Her first connection to the Pearl. Her mother's death. Her sixteenth birthday- coming of age to rule. Her eighteenth birthday. Her coronation. The ball… *him* .

Sea Hawk.

Sebastian.

The memories were flying to her fingers now- joining the Alliance, the battle for Bright Moon. The fight. The break up. Her months of solitude. The Portal. Their reunion. Betrothal. The Fall of Salineas. *Their marriage* . Yes- he was her husband. Sea Hawk was her husband. Her best friend. Her sailor, her ride-or-die, her other half. Her person.

"Mermista?"

She whirled around, and saw him. Felt him. She staggered to her feet. There were tears on her cheeks, but she didn't care. "Sea Hawk?"

He paused, like he scarcely dared to breathe. "Do you…know who I am?"

Everything he was to her flooded her mind, and therefore, the space they shared. The atmosphere around them pulsed with her emotions, and it was all she could do to nod before they were colliding. He lifted her into his arms, shaking with sobs, and it felt so *real* , so tangible, that she nearly forgot they weren't physically embracing.

"Sea Hawk…" She wrapped her arms around his neck, holding onto him with all she had. " *Sebastian* …"

"I'm here, dearest." His lips were pressing against every available inch of her, shoulder, neck, collar, hair. "I'm here, I'm with you."

"I remember." She sobbed. "All of it. You're not…we're not really here."

"We are." He pulled back, and she saw the tears streaking down his face. "As real as it can be, it is. This is really *us* , our Bond, our souls, essences, what have you. This is really my love for you all around us." His forehead came to rest against hers, and her knees felt weak. "I miss you, Mermista."

"I miss you." She sniffed. "I miss *me* , and being me, and feeling like myself. When he's here, I can't feel anything. And when he's away, it's getting harder and harder to remember how to feel at all." Even as she spoke, a wave of exhaustion overtook her, and she slumped against him. "I'm getting…tired, Sebastian. Too tired to keep-"

" *No* ." He gripped her shoulders harshly, and if she'd had a physical form it would have been bruised. "Mermista, I know you're tired of fighting, but I need you to hold on just a little longer. Please, dearest. For me."

"...I'll try." She sighed. "I'll try as hard as I can. But I'm hurt, and if my physical body can't…I don't know what will happen."

"It won't come to that," he swore. "I promise you, it won't."

"Alright. Can we sit a while? Until he comes for me?"

"For as long as we have."

They sat in silence, at first side by side, until Mermista felt even the micrometers between them was too far, and curled into his lap, head tucked under his chin and against his shoulder. Sea Hawk ran ethereal fingers through her hair, humming idly. She'd missed his singing, even if she'd rather gnaw on a fishbone than admit it, even now. Missed the shanties, the pyromania, the adventure that was every minute by his side.

"Will we ever have another adventure?" She didn't even realize she was speaking until the words were out, hanging between them. He held her tighter.

“We will,” he vowed. “I promise, after this is over, we’ll have all the adventures you want.”

“...okay.” She closed her eyes, resting against him, letting his warmth lull her into a reverie. When she woke from it, she was back in her cell, and he was gone. The tears slipped out of her eyes much easier this time, and she didn’t bother to stop them.

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Sea Hawk understood why the Princesses left him at the camp, it made logistical sense. What he didn’t appreciate was Bow and Glimmer running off without warning, and the feeling of being left behind. He knew he was just cranky, and grieving, but still!

He sighed, idly examining the maps of trade routes and the postings of their remaining allies across the Whispering Woods. Swift Wind trotted to and fro, also grumbling.

“Stupid cat. She gets to go on adventures but I’m stuck here. I’m Adora’s loyal animal companion! Don’t I get to go on adventures?”

Sea Hawk opened his mouth to respond, but was cut off by the sound of Glimmer’s magic. One by one, the Alliance materialized in the stronghold, starting with Catra. She was utterly waterlogged, coughing up lungfuls of foul-smelling liquid. Melog was similarly drenched, and the faint tang of sharp, cold ozone lingering around them confirmed his suspicions. This was Mermista's work- the scent of magic tied to the water was unmistakable. He had little time to dwell on it, as Netossa materialized next, Spinnerella bound in her arms. Entrapta sprinted into the space from her tiny alcove, mask down as she rushed to help.

Together, he and Entrapta got Spinnerella and Netossa up to the med bay Entrapta had erected literally overnight. He left them to it once she was settled, sparing a hug of congratulations for Netossa, even as his heart bottomed out once again.

He wasn't blind, he'd seen that Mermista wasn't with them, but he still made a beeline for Perfuma, who was chatting with a hopeful-looking Catra. "Fuma-?"

She spun to face him, smiling shakily. "We saw them. Both of them- Scorpia and Mermista. They were…we got through to Scorpia. She *saved* us!"

"That's wonderful news!" He hugged her close. "And the chips?"

"They're getting worse," Catra interjected softly. "The network is- it's spreading. Starting to fuse with the nervous system according to Entrapta."

His heart was plummeting. "How do we know that?"

“Well, they were chipped at the same time, Scorp and Fish- *Mermista* ,” she corrected hastily. “And when I saw Mermista’s chip, it was starting to web across her neck-”

“Wait.” Sea Hawk’s ears were ringing, and he suddenly felt far away. “You…saw her chip?”

“Uh, yeah?” Catra scowled. “She was raining hellfire- or, hellwater, I guess- down on me in the observation bay, trying to drown me. Melog grabbed me, turned me invisible, we fought, and I ended up…behind…her… *what* ?”

“How close were you?” His teeth were clenched together, near to cracking. “How. Close. Were you. *To her neck* .”

Catra, realizing her error, flattened her ears as Perfuma gasped softly, turning to her with wide eyes. “Catra…”

“I- I didn’t- it’s not like that, okay? I didn’t think-” She half-crouched, tail swishing in agitation, and for the first time since coming face to face with Prime in Erelandia, Sea Hawk felt the dark, blackened tendril of *hate* curling in his chest.

“You could have freed her.” It wasn’t a question. Sea Hawk’s hand was drifting toward his blade, Adora be damned. “You could have *freed* my *WIFE* - *!* ”

He lunged for her, and found himself being restrained by several sets of hands and plants. Still, he thrashed, throwing himself at Catra to no avail. “I- I’m sorry!” The feline woman stammered. “I didn’t … *I’m sorry* !”

“Not yet you’re not,” he snarled.

“Sea Hawk, *please* !” Adora’s voice near his ear. “There was so much happening, we barely made it out alive. We got Spinnerella, and we learned, okay? We learned how to free them! We can find her, we can free her, I swear it! Please don’t make me call She-Ra -”

Gradually, the anger was joined by fresh waves of grief, but the fight in Sea Hawk only doubled as tears sprang to his eyes. With renewed strength, he strained against his friends. Perfuma was trying to reason with him, but he had no mind for it. “Sea Hawk, please- I’m sorry about this but you need to stop- *sleep!* ”

Something pricked his neck, and an itchy, hot feeling spread over his body like fire. The last thing he saw before collapsing was Catra, still mouthing “I’m sorry”.

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Sea Hawk woke up in the dark with a throbbing head. He shifted, grunting at the grogginess in his limbs, the fog wreathed around his brain. The camp was fairly empty, he noted as he looked around. Catra and Adora were gone, Bow was dozing by the fire, Glimmer and Netossa were bent over a map. Next to him, Frosta was snoozing in her bed roll, crown askew and blankets tangled. He gently lifted the ice tiara from her hair, placing it on top of her pack. Perfuma and Entrapta walked through the entrance just then, and immediately saw him sitting upright. They hustled over to check on him.

"I'm sorry, Hawk," she murmured. "I just…"

"Yeah, I know," he muttered, not going to pretend he wasn't a bit stung. "I'm…fine. It's fine."

"It's not." Entrapta stated factually, shining a light in his eyes. "But it is the reality we occupy. Perfuma suggested that fresh air would help wake you."

Her hair lifted him to his feet, and the three of them meandered out into the night. They walked sedately, each lost in thought, clearly waiting for someone else to break the fragile silence. Shockingly, it was none of them that cut through the tension- Catra and Adora stumbled out of the underbrush, both with red-rimmed eyes and twin scowls.

Catra froze at the sight of the three of them, while Adora just nodded. "Hey guys."

“Hello, friends.”

“Adora, Catra.”

Sea Hawk just nodded, uncharacteristically quiet. The two began walking away when Catra stopped, and turned on heel.

“Hey, um, S-Sea Hawk?”

He took a breath and turned to meet her wide, somewhat defiant, mostly scared gaze. “Yes?”

“I-I feel that I owe you an explanation, and an apology, if you’ll hear me.”

He blinked, surprised. “Uh. Sure?”

“When we were fighting- me and Mermista- I got her down at one point, and I…I was there. I had it. But, when I saw the chip…it was different. It was spreading. The green from the chip, his, uh, essence, or neurons or tendrils, *whatever* . It was webbing all over her, covering her neck, and I froze. Because I had never seen it that bad. And I know this isn’t believable, and you don’t have to believe me, that’s okay, but…I didn’t want to hurt her. I didn’t know if ripping it out would…kill her.”

Entrapta cleared her throat, showing Sea Hawk her datapad. “From what I’ve been able to extrapolate from Spinnerella’s chip and her body’s response to its removal…it may have.”

Catra’s eyes widened. “R-really?”

“Yes,” the tech master sighed. “The chips are fusing to their nervous systems, taking over their bodies, yes, but…Prime picked the back of the neck for a reason. It’s only a short distance until the network fuses with their brains. And when that happens…” She looked away, and yanked her mask down. “I had a hard enough time removing a juvenile chip from Catra. Not even the best healers at Mystacore will be able to untangle them at that stage. Everything they ever were, or ever thought… their entire selves will be gone.”

“H-how?” Adora’s voice shook, and Sea Hawk felt his own eyes growing wet.

“In simple terms,” Entrapta tapped a few times on her pad’s screen, pulling up some images. “The chip contains a biomechanical virus. What it’s doing is electrifying their neurons in short, harsh bursts, wiping clean what was there, the paths of thought, pain, and so on, and replacing them with whatever Prime wants. When it reaches their brain, it will spread like wildfire along the neuropaths into their very synapses until…”

“They’re burned away?” Perfuma’s lip wobbled, tears gathering in her eyes.

“Purified in the light of Prime,” Catra snarled. One hand gripped the back of her own neck.

“We won’t let it happen,” Adora swore. “Some of us are setting out for Mystacore. There’s a- a thing there. A failsafe for the Heart. We can use it to stop Prime. We can *do this* …we have to.”

“Or die trying.” Sea Hawk stared back at her, utterly resolved.

Adora nodded, even as Catra’s ears flattened and she looked away.

“Thank you, Catra. For telling me. I apologize for attacking you.”

“Wouldn’t be the first time.” Catra rubbed her jaw idly. “Definitely won’t be the last.”

“Keep your chin up.” He nodded at her, turning to resume his walk. To his surprise, Entrapta and Perfuma stayed with him.

“How are you feeling?” Perfuma murmured.

“Groggy. Empty,” Sea Hawk sighed. They reached a small ledge at the edge of this part of the forest, overlooking more of the words. Far, far in the distance, was the ocean, just kissing the horizon. To their right, large, craggy mountains rose against the night sky, opaque and purple. They all sat down and heaved heavy sighs.

“I miss home.” Perfuma sniffed. “I miss the smells and the sounds of a night in Plumeria. I miss drum circles and group meditations and bedtime yoga.”

“I miss the sea, and Salineas.” Sea Hawk nodded. “The gulls crying, the crashing waves, the smell of salt and freedom…”

Entrapta was silent beside them for a while. But tentatively, she spoke. “I miss…the feeling of home. I don’t know where that is anymore, but I know that I miss it. I miss the familiarity of my lab. I miss not having to stick to a routine. I miss my-” She broke off suddenly, and yanked her mask down again.

Perfuma and Sea Hawk frowned at each other. “Entrapta? You miss your what?”

“Nothing. Irrelevant data.”

“If you care about this thing enough to miss it, then it can’t be irrelevant.” Sea Hawk tilted his head.

Entrapta’s mask stared at him. “Explain.”

“Well…” Perfuma stepped in. “You’re our friend. If you care about something, we care about that something, too. Because it’s important to you, and therefore, relevant to us.”

“I…see.” Entrapta lifted the mask with a tendril of hair. “So…even if this were to be a…say, a taboo thing. If I cared about…it… enough to miss it, then you would…be okay?”

They frowned at one another again. “Well…” Sea Hawk said. “You could explain it to us, and we won’t judge, and then we could… discuss it?”

Perfuma nodded. “Yes, that would be alright. If you want to talk about it.”

“Alright…” Entrapta took a breath. “When I was…in the Fright Zone, I…had a lab partner. And I miss that lab partner very much.”

“Oh…” Perfuma smiled shakily. “Entrapta, that's wonderful. Were they kind?”

“Not always.” Entrapta shrugged. “They were in a great deal of pain, you see, emotional and physical, at all times. I tried to help them, and I succeeded…even when that help was used against people I care about. But that’s a bigger issue.”

She hugged herself with her hair, and for the first time, Sea Hawk saw Entrapta’s age on her face. The scientist looked *tired* .

“But he understood me. Really understood me, like no one else ever has. And right now, I- I really miss that?” Her voice stumbled over a small sob. “I miss him. He could be volatile, and mean. But deep down, he *wanted* to be kind. He wanted kindness. He wanted love, and acceptance, but he didn’t understand it, and didn’t…feel he deserved it. And so he was angry. Constantly angry. At himself, and the world, and his…overseer. But never at me. Not really. He’d lash out but…” She smiled through the tears tracking down her face. “He once told me that I wasn’t flawed, and any who said so were ‘utter fools’. It was…sweet.”

“Oh, Entrapta…” Perfuma got up and crossed to Entrapta’s other side, putting the older woman between the two of them. “I’d like to give you a hug?”

She lowered her eyes. “Rain check?”

“Of course.” Perfuma smiled. “I’m sorry you’re separated from this person. He sounds like he cares about you immensely.”

"He does." Entrapta nodded. "Even if he can't remember that right now."

"Is he chipped?" Sea Hawk frowned.

"Sort of, yes."

Perfuma frowned. "What else was he like? Besides hurting."

Entrapta smiled, and it was a very soft thing. "He was… emotionally constipated, to put it colloquially. He cared very much about appearances, especially to those under his command. Looking strong was everything to him. He loved science, and tinkering, and I could listen to him talk about astronomy and history for hours and hours. He had very little patience for things that annoyed him, and most things did annoy him. He was… mercurial. But he was also quick-witted, and funny if you knew what he was saying. He didn't sleep enough, and pushed himself too hard. But he was…my friend. I…loved him. Love him." She sighed. "And I never had the chance to tell him, outside of etching it on some First One's tech."

Sea Hawk smoothed a hand over his mustache. "He sounds incredibly like my Mermista."

Entrapta blinked at him. "Huh. You know, that data *does* correlate."

“Maybe they could be friends after the war?” Perfuma smiled.

“Ahhhh, proooobably not?” Entrapta winced, looking down. “They have bad blood.”

The Plant Princess frowned. “How would Mermista have personal issues with any Horde soldier besides, say, Catra. Except for, say…”

“No.” He blanched.

Perfuma’s eyes widened. “Entrapta…?”

“Oh, gods no.” Sea Hawk plunked his head into his head. “Entrapta, you cannot mean-”

“Is your lab partner…”

“Hordak.” Entrapta dropped her mask down. “Yep.”

“You Princesses sure know how to pick partners.” Sea Hawk couldn’t help but laugh, slightly hysterically. “A pirate, a dictator, said dictator’s top general, said dictator’s general’s right hand…”

“A master archer?” Perfuma amended.

“Potentially, as we still don’t know the status of Bow and Glimmer’s romantic relationship,” Entrapta corrected, mask still firmly down as she wrung her hands. “Likely. But still only potentially.”

Sea Hawk made a considering noise in his throat. “One out of five isn’t horrendous.”

“Statistically speaking-”

“Entrapta!” Perfuma sighed heavily. “I just…how?”

“I already told you all the relevant data.”

“But-!”

“Perfuma,” Sea Hawk cut her off. “We have enough strife in our lives right now without adding the personal choices of our friends to the mix. For some reason, her own reasons, Entrapta’s heart has chosen Hordak. And Adora’s has chosen Catra. And yours…”

"Chose Scorpia, I know." The blonde relaxed. "Entrapta, I apologize for my…less than favorable reaction. It just- well, it's a pretty staggering pill to swallow."

"I…comprehend your analogy. And understand your intent. And…I don't blame you."

Sea Hawk scrubbed a hand through his hair. He needed to dunk in the river, it was getting a smidge grody. "Entrapta, having heard it from your mouth, and being, well, incredibly sympathetic to the emotional aspect of loving who you do, I will try to support you through whatever is next. But…like I told Adora…"

"Should all of this work out, should we beat all statistical odds and survive this war…" Entrapta was nodding. "The other Princesses will not be accepting, or understanding. And I will likely become an outcast again-"

"Well, hey now!" Perfuma frowned. "I understand. In theory. It will take me some time to come around to it, sure, but living through what we are now…understanding that, from what Catra has said, Hordak is as much a pawn as our friends right now? You do have my sympathy. He will need much therapy, and emotional healing." She opened her palms, and conjured a blooming orchid blossom, white with deep blue interior and red stigma, and placed it in Entrapta's gloved hands. "Remember what Mermista said? Before you left?"

"'We have your back. Anytime,'" Entrapta quoted. "But…"

“Mermista doesn’t parse words, or say anything she doesn’t mean.” Sea Hawk nudged her gently. “This will be…a difficult concept for her. She may never accept him, will likely never forgive him, and maybe, by the time we all die, will tolerate being in the same room as him. But, she will try not to let those feelings impact her relationship with you.”

“But…” Entrapta lifted her mask once again. “My feelings for Hordak are a part of me. He’s a part of me. Is that not what love means?”

Sea Hawk smiled. “It can be, yes. Well, in that case, have faith that your friendship with Mermista and the other Princess’, and your mutual respect for one another, be the olive branch. Hordak will need you to go to bat for him, and they’ll need you to understand their pain. It will be quite the balancing act, I imagine.”

“But you won’t be alone.” Perfuma patted her arm gently. “You won’t ever be alone again. We promised, remember?”

Entrapta’s eyes welled with tears, but this time she left her mask up. She gently placed the flower aside, before yanking them both close to her with her hair, and wrapping her arms around them. “Thank you both. And I’m sorry that our partners are in this mess that I helped create.”

“You’re helping now.” Sea Hawk hugged her back. “You’re helping them heal, helping us fight back. You have a steep hill to climb, but like Perfuma said, you’re not alone. We won’t forget all you’ve done to help after this. In my humble opinion, it already outweighs the bad.”

“Good always does.” Perfuma rested her head on Entrapta’s hair.

“Thank you. I…I think I needed this- to talk. It was…nice.”

“It was!” Perfuma stood, stretching, and as she did, the trees around them blossomed spontaneously and vibrantly, like it was midday and not the wee hours of the night. “Healing is a winding path, filled with many surprise stops, and this felt like an important one.”

The other two stood as well, Entrapta gathering her blossom in reverent hands. As he began walking, Perfuma shoved another flower into his hands. It was turquoise, veins of gold running through, with tips of amber. His eyes filled with tears, and he nodded his thanks. “It’s getting harder to believe I’ll ever see her again.”

“I understand.” Perfuma wiped her eyes. “Seeing Scorpia, the lack of warmth in her…it was horrific.”

“Did you see her? Mermista?”

“Only briefly, as we escaped. She was…angry.”

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Mermista gasped for air in the Bond Space. Prime had been using her more than ever, pushing her to extremes that she’d never known before. When he was in her body, or even just commanding her, it was like falling asleep and lucid dreaming. She wasn’t in control, but she was. She was aware, but she wasn’t. It was her body, her magic, her will…but not. Coming back to “her” mind, what little was left of it, was agony. She could take a breath of fresh air, but it was laced with acrid smoke and blisteringly cold and it tore her lungs to bits.

It was getting harder to deny that her…self? Her soul? Whatever part of her was in here- was throbbing in miserable pain. It came and went in waves that mirrored the pulsating of the sickly green vines creeping up the barrier between her and the darkness. Her thoughts, despite her memories being healed, were tattered, running through her fingers in ribbons. It was all she could do to stay anchored to this small haven her marriage had granted her. At the very least, she knew that those vines would kill her if they got to her.

Mermista curled up, knees to her chest, on the floor of this odd little bubble, and summoned a memory to her hands. She didn’t care which, she just needed *him* .

The now whole memory materialized in her shaking hands. It was like a picture frame of smooth amber glass, translucent and not all…there. Like everything else here. As she tilted it, it shifted between moments of recollection. Mermista pressed her forehead to it and let herself be lost in the past.

Father had once again pushed her beyond function in training with Maevik. Her magic reserves were depleted, her body was bruised, and she had a cut along her tricep that stung as she walked with her trident. Staff leapt out of her way as she stormed to her rooms, terrified of the thunderous expression their princess wore. Too exhausted to feel even slightly guilty, she opened and slammed shut the door to her bedroom, throwing her trident viciously to the ground.

'Hope it breaks,' she thought mutinously.

She should shower. She had somewhere to be tonight, with Sea Hawk. They were going to hop islands to Maluhia and grab dinner from her favorite little hole-in-the-wall, one of the places that wouldn't snitch on her to Father for being out without an escort. Probably because she tipped double the bill's worth. So, yes, shower.

Instead, she kicked off her shoes and collapsed into her bed. She was filthy with sweat and sand from the training pit, her sheets would need to be cleaned…but that was a problem for future Mermista. Sleep was already pulling her under.

When she woke up, it was late sunset. She blinked groggily, frowning at the vista outside her open balcony doors. Why was it so dark? Wasn't she supposed to…?

SHIT!

She rocketed upright, definitely twisting something in her back, and lunged for her pad. Ten missed calls from Sea Hawk. Fuck, fuck, fuck! She had totally blown it! Groaning, she thumbed open the device, reading through his texts briefly before tapping the call button. It rang…

In her room?

She turned to her living area, where Sea Hawk was lounging on her couch, a book in his hand that had him utterly entranced. His boots and socks were by the doors, his jacket draped over a chair. On the table was a bag of takeout, placed under a warming dome to stay fresh. She blinked, and blushed.

"Sea Hawk?"

He jumped to life like he'd been shocked. "Princess!"

"Uh, hey. What are you doing here?"

"Well, when you wouldn't answer my calls, I feared the utter worst!" He gently placed the book aside before swanning to his feet, dramatically waving his hands around in punctuation. "Ruffians! Thugs! A siege! A deranged seagull! Anything could have happened! So, I asked the kitchen to take the food to go, and made haste to the castle, ready to save my Princess from whatever evil had befallen her!"

"You are so loud, it's like, killing me. I need you at a two," she groaned, rubbing her temples. "Wait. You were worried about a siege and still got the food to go?"

"Uhhh, well, ahem..." Sea Hawk shrugged sheepishly. "I may have also suspected that you either fell asleep or forgot. So, I figured I'd cover my bases for all possibilities."

Mermista couldn't help her snort. "Whatever, goober. Did you remember my sauce?"

"But of course!"

They sat down to eat, and Mermista let the memory play in slower time. She was leaning into Sea Hawk's side, still groggy, but happy that he was here. More than happy. She felt warm and fuzzy deep in her chest, almost in her stomach. She could smell his cologne, his natural scent. He fed her bites of his food off his fork, and she let him. She offered him the same, but kept pulling the fork further and further away until she could kiss him softly.

In that moment, she'd never known such peace, suffused with a quiet happiness and comfort that couldn't be found anywhere else, from anyone else.

In that moment, she was in love. And for the first time, she'd known it, even if she couldn't admit it.

Mermista came to, tears rolling down her cheeks. The memory evaporated just as the tugging at the back of her neck dragged her upright. She hung there for a moment, a marionette, a ragdoll waiting for directions, before she felt the *burning* course through her body, possessing her limbs and whiting out her ability to think. She screamed, shutting her eyes, and when she opened them again, everything was green.

Yes, Lord Prime.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you for reading and pls lmk what you thought! I'm still working on responding to some comments but I'll get to all of them pinky promise

you’ll be the one who saves me

Chapter Summary

> The End (sort of)

Chapter Notes

> This is the last chapter of canon…. Yall. What a RIDE this has been. I cannot thank all of you enough. I hope you enjoy this as much as I enjoyed writing it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When they returned to camp, everyone was in a massive tizzy. The ‘BFS’ and Catra (was she part of the BFS? Was she Adora’s girlfriend? Did anyone know?) were running about, grabbing supplies and slipping into light armor. Bow was fletching and adjusting arrows, and Entrapta ran to help him.

Sea Hawk and Perfuma wandered over to Glimmer, bent with Shadow Weaver and her aunt over a map of what looked to be Mystacor.

“Going somewhere?” Perfuma asked politely. Her body language screamed anxious, but he wasn’t sure if it was from the proximity to Shadow Weaver or the uncertainty.

Castaspella looked up, sparing Perfuma a glance before fixing her eyes on him. Sea Hawk grimaced internally; Mermista had never thought highly of Mystacor’s matriarch after the coronation, and he was beginning to get the full scope of *why* . Any time they were in camp together, she found a way to talk to him, get close to him, leaving lingering touches heavy with innuendo. Not only was he a married man (not that she knew that- but was it not *obvious* that he was off the market?), but he was clearly grieving the loss of Mermista. So either she wasn't that bright, or she didn't care. Neither were wonderful options. He glanced away casually as she spoke.

"We've found a failsafe for the Heart of Etheria! We could not only stop Prime from using it, but release the magic stored there safely."

"Which would give us the final upper hand against Prime," Glimmer sighed.

Sea Hawk was pleased to see that she wasn't looking excited at all by the idea, just wary and tired. She'd grown, out in space. Bow had said she understood that she was wrong every step of the way with the Heart, even if her intentions hadn't been.

"This is our last shot, guys. If we can't do this…he'll get the heart. And it'll all be over."

"What can we do?" Perfuma asked.

"With She-Ra and the Queen leaving camp, you'll need to remain behind and defend it as best you can." Shadow Weaver sniffed, dismissive as ever of those who weren't her pupils. "Try not to get yourselves blown up."

Sea Hawk sneered at the witch. “Thank you for your wonderful advice.”

“Oh, I’m sure Sebastian is more than capable-” Castaspella began.

Something angry and ugly crept up his throat, and he was unable to stop himself from snapping. “Sea Hawk, if you please.”

The sorceress looked taken aback. “Oh! Well, I just heard Mermista-”

“Mermista can call me what she wishes,” he bit out. “You may call me Sea Hawk. Or Captain.”

Castaspella seemed vaguely insulted, but Sea Hawk was well past caring.

Perfuma placed a hand on his shoulder. “Let’s go see what the others need.”

As they walked away, Glimmer appeared next to them in a shower of sparkles, looking rather apologetic. “I’m sorry for them. I wish…I wish it didn’t have to be this way. I wish I could tell

Shadow Weaver to fuck off, and tell my aunt not to be such a weird cougar. But for now…"

"Hey, it's okay, Glim." Perfuma smiled. "We don't blame *you* !"

"Certainly not!" Sea Hawk clapped the short queen on her shoulder. "You're doing what you must for the good of the many. We shall adapt!"

Glimmer smiled gratefully. "Thanks, you guys." She wrapped them in a tight hug. "I don't get to tell you both enough, but I'm so glad you're both here with us. You've been great helps, and great friends."

Sea Hawk, utterly unused to hearing praise from the other Princesses, smiled genuinely. "That means a lot to ol' Sea Hawk, Your Majesty."

"We're glad you're here, too, Glimmer." Perfuma leaned her head on the other woman's. "We missed you so much when you were lost in space."

"Indeed! It's wonderful to have you home." Sea Hawk fired off a casual salute.

Glimmer returned it happily. "Wonderful to be home, Captain." Her smile faded a bit, tinged by sadness. "Maybe after all of this is over…we could go sailing again? I never thought I'd miss your brand of adventure, but right now, punching a sea serpent seems like some seriously solid therapy."

"Adventure is the best therapy." He winked.

Perfuma frowned. "That's a bit of a stretch."

"I suppose you'll just have to come see for yourself, then!" Sea Hawk threw an arm around the willowy woman's frame.

Glimmer grinned. "It's settled then. After this is all over, we'll go on a sea serpent hunt!"

"Scorpia would love that," Perfuma sighed wistfully.

Sea Hawk snorted. "Mermista would *not* . But she wouldn't mind the excursion, I think, after all of this…"

"I guess we'll just have to ask them later." Glimmer nodded, almost defiantly, as if daring the universe to try to contradict her.

"I guess we will."

They parted ways, and shortly after, the Away Team of Adora, Glimmer, Bow, Catra, Weaver, and Castaspella teleported away, grim faced and nervous.

Frosta woke up and found them, and after a brief debate, all three decided to check on Spinnerella and Netossa. They climbed the stairs and pushed aside the heavy drape shielding the small medbay from the rest of the camp's hustle and bustle. Spinnerella was hooked up to several monitors that Entrapta had rigged up, Netossa tucked into her side on the cot, snoring softly. Spinnerella, though, was awake and sitting up, and waved at them as they entered.

“Hey, guys.” She smiled tiredly. “How have you been?”

“We’ve been…alright.” Perfuma tried to smile. “Not great but alright.”

The older woman nodded sadly. “Tossa has been filling me in on what’s been going on since…everything. I’m so sorry, you two.”

“Quite alright.” Sea Hawk flashed her a smile that didn’t reach his eyes. “The better question is, how have *you* been?”

“Oh, y’know…” She gestured vaguely. “My mind is pudding and my body is completely wrecked. My manual breathing keeps kicking in…Entrapta says my body is relearning how to function on its own. Which is, uh, horrific.” Her chin trembled, but no tears fell.

Sea Hawk marveled at her strength. “I was with them, you know. For long stretches. Both physically and mentally.”

The three of them froze up. “Really?” Frosta whispered.

“Yeah.” Spinnerella swallowed. “We uh…Prime didn’t know what to make of us. Especially Mermista and Scorpia. He said he’d never seen ‘their kind’, and wanted to know what made us all so different. So he…”

“He what?” Sea Hawk didn’t want to know, but he *needed* to know.

“We had to submit ourselves for testing.” Spinnerella’s voice was sliding into a monotone as she spoke, her mind elsewhere. At some point, Entrapta had scurried in, and was listening raptly, tapping away at her pad. “It was simple for me. Hair samples, some skin samples, blood. That was it. But for them…” She hesitated, turning. “You might not want to hear this.”

“No, we might not.” Perfuma frowned. “But we need to.”

They pulled up chairs, Entrapta sitting on her hair, and settled in. Sea Hawk untied his bandana to wring between his hands. Spinnerella nodded, and pressed on while Netossa slept at her side, utterly exhausted.

"For Scorpia…it started with flakes off her chiton. Then chunks. Then the softer tissue under the exoskeleton. Hair samples, blood samples, saliva were next. And then he started extracting her venom. He wanted to know what made it so potent, and try to weaponize it. Last I knew, he wasn't successful. But he's got a bottomless supply."

Perfuma and Frosta looked nauseous, both crying silently. Sea Hawk swallowed the bile in his throat. "That poor woman."

"And for Mermista…it was worse." Spinnerella shut her eyes. "She could *transform* . That was an invaluable novelty to Prime. And despite his claims to us otherwise…I think it amused him to make her change." Sea Hawk's ears were starting to ring as rage and despair clawed through his body. "He started with the usual. Hair and blood. But then he saw the scales on her body, and needed to compare them with the scales he took off her tail-"

"He took scales off her tail?" Sea Hawk seethed.

Spinnerella nodded. "Yeah. It…she was in pain. And it only got worse. The more he forced the transformation, the more he wanted to know. He noticed her teeth changing-"

"No." Perfuma gasped.

"-so he took one. And then when he saw it grow back within a day, he took two. Her ears- he took samples off the fins. Her nails…her gills.”

Sea Hawk dropped his head into his hands, trying to control his breathing. “Gods, please no…”

“I can’t remember everything. I remember flashes…Scorpia lashing out with her tail, even under his control. I think Mermista took a bite out of one of the clones. That’s why the experiments stopped. Even under his control, they were too ‘wild’, he said. So, he aborted those plans. I don’t know what he did with the samples, not much from what I can tell. But it’s also why he plans on using them to the point of destruction. Even chipped and brainwashed, he can’t purge away physical biology. They are, at their core, imperfect to him. Just like Catra was. He’ll have them killed in the final battle, letting them die with the rest of Etheria.”

Sea Hawk stumbled to his feet, fleeing the medbay. He crashed through the camp, and just barely made it out to the grass before throwing up everything he’d eaten in the last few hours. Images flashed in his mind, Mermista being held down, forced to transform, her autonomy and magic being violated… He doubled over again, retching more. Tears dripped down his face, choking him with sobs, but he didn’t care. It wasn’t anything compared to what Mermista had been through- why shouldn’t he suffer alongside her?

Gods, Mermista…his beautiful, strong Mermista. He prayed Spinnerella was right. Prayed she didn’t remember any of it. He screamed out to every deity there may have been that she would be alright, after everything. She was so strong, strong in every way, he just didn’t want her to have to be.

‘Of course she won’t be alright.’ He chastised himself as he began walking for the river. ‘She’s been brutally abused by an intergalactic madman. She’s going to be in pieces, just like Spinnerella and Catra, if not worse. It could take years for her to be okay again, if ever.’

That was *fine* . As long as he had her back, it didn’t matter the capacity. He had vowed before the Pearl, and Oceana, and Mermista herself that he was never, ever leaving. Not again. Things were going to be hard. They were going to have more bad days than good days, at least for a while. She was going to shut him out, wall off, snap and scream at him, because she would be hurting in ways he couldn’t fathom. He didn’t care. At least she’d be alive to do all of it. As long as she was breathing, he’d be by her side. In whatever capacity she needed.

If she needed him to never sail again, he would. If she needed him to only be around once a week, that was fine. If she didn’t want the throne, and elected to abdicate after this, he would still be her husband. If this permanently changed her stance on starting a family, then he would support her endlessly.

He loved her unconditionally, and he was going to make sure she knew that.

As he rinsed off in the river, he let his mind wander. He’d had so many visions for the future, visions that had been his life raft through this nightmare both before and after he lost his wife. Back before the mass chipping, they had lain awake in camp, whispering in the quiet, still hours of the morning about everything and anything.

What kind of color scheme did they want for the big wedding?

What did they think their child’s first word would be?

What would they rebuild first?

How did Sea Hawk want the new harbor to look?

At what age would he teach their kid to sail? At what age would their child connect to the Pearl?

Were they going to have a tail? They’d only be half-merfolk, after all.

Would she let him adopt that stray dock cat who liked to sleep on his ship if the poor thing had survived invasion?

What did he want for a ‘real’ wedding gift?

Where did he want to honeymoon (even if it was cut short)?

What color would they paint the nursery?

Sea Hawk sobbed into his sleeve, knowing that it was time to finally let his dreams go. They had to be set free down the river, so he could move forward into whatever the future might hold without expectation. Mermista didn’t need to be tied back down to a past that didn’t exist; he had to bring her ashore to a new, uncertain future. And from there…they’d just have to figure it out together.

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Sea Hawk’s head hit his pillow at the end of his watch, still swimming with everything. Everything left unsaid and undone between him and Mermista. All they’d wanted to do, all they’d done together. He couldn’t have explained it if he wanted to, but tonight felt final. Waiting on the Mystacor group, Entrapta making one last ditch effort to get Prime’s transmission pattern down to shut off the chips, the deafening silence sitting over them all; they were in between night and dawn, a no-man’s land where time seemed to halt and spin on its head. Whether or not they were ready, come morning, it would be time for the next step, and whatever it brought.

Sleep overtook him almost forcefully, and he woke up next to Mermista in the Bond space. She was in the fetal position, tucked as small as she could make herself. The area behind the barrier was smaller than ever, the darkness outside howling, although it made no sound he could hear. The green webbing was inching closer to Mermista, creeping under the fading barrier once made strong by their love, their connection.

He was losing her.

Tears filled his eyes as he shook her, and watched her uncurl lethargically. Her eyes were unfocused, their beautiful copper hue dull and fogged. The whites of her eyes were flecked with green. It took her a few seconds to blink herself out of whatever trance she'd been in, and another few for her to recognize him. It seemed all their work with her memories had been for little after all.

Her voice was rough when she spoke, but her hands on his cheeks were as soft as ever, stroking away tears with her thumb. "Don't cry."

"I can't help it," he whispered, covering her hand with his. "I love you so much, Mermista. And I'm so scared this is the end."

She blinked, and he watched her focus fade in and out as the green crept closer. Tears filled her own eyes, even as she smiled shakily. This felt *wrong* . He was the one who smiled. He was the one who cheered her up with blind hope. *He* was the one who… who…

"Tell me how we first met?" she asked, voice cracking around a cry.

He drew her in close, tucking their heads together. “We met at a gala your father threw to celebrate a good trade season. He hired my crew of pirates to test the castle’s defenses, but that’s not important. We met by the kelp bar, and you pointed out the food that wouldn’t kill me, and then we sat and talked for a while. I’d never enjoyed just talking to someone that much. And then we danced. We danced for hours, and it was the most fun I had ever had in my life ‘til right then.”

“That sounds nice.” Her shoulders shook.

“It was perfect.” He pressed a tear-stained kiss to her head. “But you wanna know something?”

“Sure, Sebastian.”

“I don’t think that was the first time we met. I think we met eons ago.” He closed his eyes tightly, fighting off the sobs that threatened to take over. “I think we’ve met over and over, in every lifetime, dancing and laughing and fighting together. I think I’ve been driving you crazy since the universe blinked into existence, and I think you’ve been calling me home for just as long.”

He wasn’t sure who was holding who tighter, but he didn’t dare soften his grip. If he did, she could float away and be gone forever. She was crying in earnest, shaking sobs he’d only heard a handful of times. She looked up into his eyes, her own impossibly tired, and sad. “Tell me, do you think we’ll meet again?”

They both knew she didn’t mean in this life, but he was Sea Hawk. And he could be a stubborn fool for her if she needed him to be. “I do. In this life, and every one that comes next.”

Maybe it was his conviction, or her own stubborn streak, but suddenly, she was aware again. Like he’d watched her rouse herself from a wakeful sleep, her countenance shifted, becoming more alert as her eyes focused fully on him.

“Sebastian…” She gripped his arms with desperate conviction as her voice broke. “I know I don’t say everything I should, and I haven’t said even half of what I’ve wanted to all these years. But I swear, I *feel* it. I feel all of it, like, so much, and I’ve felt it this whole damn time.” She tugged him into a bruising hug, one he returned with equal force. “I love you, Sebastian Hawkins. I’ve loved you for as long as I’ve known you. In this life, and in all the other ones. I love your spirit, your fire, *everything,* even when I’m giving you hell for it. I love how you sing, and yes, that includes your dumb, amazing shanties. I love how you *listen* to me. I love how you’re kind to every person you meet, no matter who they are. I love so much about you. Hell, I love everything about you, and there’s not enough time, like, in existence to say it all, so just *know* that I do, ‘kay?”

Now he was the one shaking, sobbing into her shoulder. “Mermista, please, *please* come back to me. There’s no me without you! I-I don’t like who I am when I’m alone- who I become. And even if I did, there’s no reason to be him if you’re not going to be next to me.”

“Yes, there is.” Mermista spoke with single minded focus. “The world needs people like you, Sea Hawk.”

“No, the world needs *you* , Mermista. *I* need you.” He bent his head, tears dripping down his chin and vanishing into the ether, before he could look her in the eye again. “I love you so much, dearest.”

“I know you do.” She smiled, and it was beautiful- pain-free and blissful, even if just for a moment- before she sobered. Her eyes burned with resolve, pulling him in and igniting something hopeful and flickering in his chest. “Which is why I know that you’re going to save me.”

He scanned her face. “You do?”

“I do.” She wiped his cheeks again, kissing each one softly. “So, like, don’t cry, okay? You’ll be the one who saves me. I know it like I know when the tide is coming in.” She leaned her forehead against his. “It’s a part of me. *You* are a part of me. The best part of me. I’m going to hang on, and fight, for as long as I absolutely can.” She took a shuddering breath, and he took his turn to wipe away her tears. “And you’re going to save me.”

“I am.” It wasn’t a question now, and he held her as tightly as he could until he started to fade away. “I promise.”

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Three days later, Sea Hawk was roused from an unproductive, Mermista-less sleep by Bow, who politely ignored the tears on the sea captain's cheeks. It was time to go. As he joined the others, he felt his mood lifting bit by bit at the sight of everyone gathered around the fire. Bow sat down, leaning against Swift Wind, to pluck the lute he'd kept from the night they all danced in their old camp, and Sea Hawk hid a smile as Glimmer leaned her head against him. They were quite sweet.

Frosta sat laughing with Perfuma on a crate, demonstrating some idea she had for their long-hiatused tabletop roleplaying game. Netossa and Spinnerella- who was looking much better and more recovered- were curled up under a blanket, whispering and giggling like the teenagers they never got to be. Wrong Hordak, who was now trying out the name Kadroh, was leaning over Entrapta's datapad along with the Tech Princess, pointing at something while Emily beeped contentedly behind them. Off to the side, in a darkened corner, Shadow Weaver sat sulking while Castaspella whisper-yelled at her.

In his mind, he took a picture. This may well be the last time they'd all be together for one reason or another.

He sat on the last available crate, as close to Perfuma and Frosta as he could. A thud alerted him to someone sitting next to him, and he turned to see Castaspella smiling at him. Wonderful. He spared her a polite smile and attempted to tune into whatever Frosta was saying.

"Captain!"

Life had other plans, it seemed.

“Glimmer was telling me at Mystacor about how you all met- the sea serpent, saving the Gate. It seemed so heroic!”

“It was!” He puffed out his chest, deciding that, for now, his usual brash bravado would do as a facade for the anxiety gnawing away at him. It had never failed before. “A harrowing *adventure* unlike any I had faced before, as it was my first mission for the Rebellion! There I was, at Seaworthy’s Tavern-”

He let himself get lost in the story, jumping up to narrate and amuse the Head Sorceress, and it wasn’t until She-Ra stood before them that he sobered up. Together, she and Entrapta told them the plan; they had to get Entrapta to the Central Spire so she could jam the frequency connected Prime to the chips, liberating all of Etheria from his control. It seemed so simple- just a brief walk and Mermista could be in his arms again.

“We need to lure Mermista and Scorpia out onto the battlefield- and there *will* be a battle,” She-Ra said. “If their chips are disabled while they’re on the Velvet Glove… it would be disastrous. They’ll be disoriented, weak, and unable to fight their way out. At best, they would be rechipped. At worst, killed.”

Sea Hawk’s jaw tightened. The idea of Mermista on that madman’s ship was already enough to turn his stomach.

“So not only are you going to be bringing Entrapta to the spire, you’ll all need to create a massive diversion. So I can bring the failsafe to the Heart, destroy it, and we can free our friends. Today, we stop Prime, and make sure he can never hurt anyone again. Today, we’re ending this. For good.”

They all leapt to their feet, cheering and rallying as adrenaline surged through them. In a matter of moments, they were splitting up, the BFS heading for the heart while the rest of them began the trek to the Spire.

“Alright we know the ‘what’.” Netossa spoke up first as they hiked through the woods, off the known paths. Perfuma’s magic made it slightly easier, but not by much. “Now we gotta figure out the ‘who’, the ‘where’, the ‘when exactly’, and most importantly, the ‘how’. So, no sweat.”

“Well…” Perfuma moved a thick vine aside. “We know that strong emotional reactions can disrupt the chip signal enough to create an opening. So, Sea Hawk should obviously try to provoke Mermista.”

“He’s good at that.” Frosta snorted, jostling him good-naturedly. “Except…what if he dies first?”

“Pardon?” Sea Hawk gulped.

“Frosta’s right.” Spinnerella nodded. “Mermista isn’t herself right now. Perfuma and Scorpia are one thing, assuming we’re also doing that-,” Perfuma blushed heavily, and said nothing, which said more than any words could. “The power matchup is comparable. But Sea Hawk…I don’t mean any offense by this, but you couldn’t safely hold your own against her right now.”

“I’ve been sparring Mermista for years, though,” he offered. “I know how she moves- shut up, Frosta- what attacks she prefers, how to read her.”

“No, you know how to read Mermista,” Perfuma sighed. “Not Prime. It’s…just her body.”

“Ah. Right.” He sighed, scrubbing a hand down his face. “I still think it’s the best chance we have.”

“Dude.” Netossa cast him a glance. “She could kill you.”

“If I don’t try, we’ll all be dead.”

Netossa held his gaze for a moment longer, before relenting. “Yeah. You’re right. Okay, Sea Hawk start thinking of ways to snap Mermista out of her funk. Shanties, boat fires, poetry, I don’t care how, just make it work.”

“Aye, aye.” His mind was already racing. All of those things provoked Mermista, sure, but only to annoyance. She was annoyed most of the time, and fairly immune to the feeling now. The most potent feeling he could elicit in Mermista was *easily* public embarrassment.

And the easiest way to do that was PDA.

Their fight from years ago came back to him now. How upset he’d been that she called him embarrassing, the implication that she hated being seen with him in public. And yes, fair, he had been…a lot in his younger years. Hell, he was still a lot. But this war had changed them both. Hopefully, he had just enough of that showboating firestarter left in him (of course he did, he was Sea Hawk) to pull off the plan that was beginning to take shape in his brain.

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Mermista woke, but just barely. It had been days since she’d felt another presence in her mind- either Sea Hawk or Prime- but now, her puppeteer seemed to be making up for lost time. She wasn’t sure if she was awake in reality, or just her mind. Either way, she was on the verge of a coma again. Prime was speaking to her, and she was vaguely aware that she was in his throne room.

They’re moving, little sisters. It’s time for you to be reunited with your precious loved ones.

Mermista felt Scorpia in her brain, just a small ways away. She was thrashing, still fighting Prime's control with her whole being. Mermista respected the hell out of her for it; she herself had to conserve every little bit of energy she could, and even that was rapidly depleting. It was harder when Prime spoke to her directly, like he was doing now.

Tell me, child. Do you miss him? Your dear, pathetic husband?

No, Lord Prime. I feel nothing but gratitude to bask in your light.

Yes, yes, a thousand times, yes. I won't let you hurt him, you fucking worm.

Good, my beloved. I can see how he plagues you still, in your heart. But worry not; I will allow you to rid yourself of this nuisance, this…embarrassment. Soon, you will be pure, cleansed in My Light. Unhindered by all that once wounded you so deeply, you will flourish.

Thank you, Lord Prime. I do not deserve your blessing.

If you make me hurt him, I will make the rest of our time bound together a living nightmare!

Your fealty is appreciated. Go now, with your sister, and send forth my mercy.

Yes, Lord Prime.

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The battle was raging on, and Sea Hawk’s blood was singing with the chaos of it all. It had been too long, too much hiding and running, not enough brutal attack, for his tastes. He slammed his blade through the chest of another bot, smiling grimly when it seized and collapsed. Entrapta should already be in the spire, but they hadn’t seen or heard or felt the missing Princesses.

“Perforation!” he yelled as he pierced yet another bot. So many bots, so few clones…and people. Hm.

Perfuma backed into him, her own row of bots sparking at her feet. “We have to keep their attention on us until Entrapta can finish!”

He raised his blade, nodding. Not even five minutes later, everything began to collapse. Netossa and Spinnerella sent a veritable battalion of bots to their doom in crumpled pieces, only to have them be replaced by row upon row of living, breathing clones.

They materialized in front of them, behind them, up along the rim of the caldera they were fighting in. Each was armed with a laser cannon, smaller versions of the model that had taken down Salineas, but no less deadly, Sea Hawk was sure.

He, Perfuma, and Frosta came together. Their youngest warrior was the first to voice the obvious. “Why aren’t they shooting?”

He shifted, boots sloshing through the water as he pivoted to guard their six- wait…water?

Perfuma shakily voiced his only thought. “Oh no...”

Sea Hawk screamed in agony as Scorpia’s lightning ripped through him, every nerve in his body catching fire. It lasted only a second before he collapsed into the water, just enough ability left in his body to turn his face out of the water. His breathing was labored, his vision was blurry, and there was a sharp ringing in the ear out of the water. The smell of burnt hair and skin- his own, most likely, he was terribly flammable- met his nose, and he fought down a gag. When his vision refocused, Sea Hawk swallowed down another scream of fear.

Mermista and Scorpia stood from their kneeled stances, faces void of all emotion. Sickly green rivulets of Prime’s essence snaked toward their eyes along their faces, spreading so quickly Sea Hawk could see the growth from here. Mermista’s brow furrowed as she locked sightless eyes on his prone form, and yet, neither Princess moved. In fact, they almost seemed…relaxed. Waiting. Behind him, from the direction of the spire, a whine built up before the entire basin was lit up with harsh, pale light.

Sea Hawk turned enough in the water to see a projection of Prime flickering to life over the spire, arms spread in false welcome. He groaned in equal parts annoyance and pain as he struggled to get to his feet. Just as he got one foot under him, Perfuma cried out.

"Entrapta!"

Sure enough, when Sea Hawk looked up, Prime's projection was joined by Entrapta's, held hostage by her hair. Tears filled the tech Princess' eyes, dripping gently down her face as she whispered brokenly. "I'm sorry…"

No… *no!* Without Entrapta, the chips couldn't be removed. Without her…he would lose Mermista forever.

"-All that's left for your world is a *terrible* , and *eternal* night." With one final smirk, Prime wrapped his gloating, and the projection fell apart, leaving them in darkness and silence.

Sea Hawk grit his teeth, finally staggering to his feet. There were a few moments of tense, horrid silence; clones and Princesses sizing them up while they did the same, waiting and watching.

Until the clearing exploded in chaos.

Scorpia hurled a ball of rolling lightning at them with a mighty yell, and it was all they could do to throw themselves headlong out of the way. Frosta and Castaspella landed alongside him, and quickly they staggered to their feet to keep moving.

“Keep them separated and distracted!” Netossa shouted from a few meters away. “We can’t let them flood and shock us like that again; I don’t think we’ll be getting up next time!”

Sea Hawk nodded, and whistled for Swiftwind. The horse came cantering at him, bending slightly to let him climb aboard his back. Together, they took off for a throng of bots and clones. Sea Hawk’s bareback riding skills weren’t the best- he had been built for ships, not horses- but he did alright. Swiftwind would charge at the enemies, sharp hooves lashing out as he galloped and kicked, occasionally using his wings to disorient them. The ones he couldn’t take down right away Sea Hawk swung at with his blade, but never to kill, not even now. Entrapta had told them that the clones were no more than puppets, sycophants who were little better than parrots. They weren’t innocent, but they weren’t to blame either.

Still, for every one they disarmed and disabled, two more beamed down to replace them, be it bot or clone. All too soon, they were being herded into the center of the basin, surrounded on all sides. Sea Hawk leapt off Swiftwind’s back, sprinting to take out a clone about to shoot Frosta in the back. Not a second later, the horse was taken down by a harsh wave, whinnying and yelling in pain.

“There’s too many!” Perfuma yelled. She sounded winded. “We have to retreat!”

“Retreat where?” Netossa panted. “We’re totally surrounded!”

And she was correct. Sea Hawk’s heart sank as he took stock of their situation; a sea of clones on one side, two deadly Princesses and a wall on the other. They were well and truly fucked, if he was being honest with himself. The first set of clones raised their arms, cannons whirring to life as they charged up an attack. Sea Hawk’s back was to them, his eyes on Mermista. Even if she was chipped, brainwashed, all but dead inside her own mind…he wanted her to be the last thing he ever saw if this was how it all ended.

Just as the cannons were reaching an ear splitting whine, indicating their imminent detonation, another sound reached their ears; the wind-chime murmur of magic, followed by a ferocious yell and a shockwave.

“Glimmer!”

Sea Hawk spun to face the Queen of Bright Moon in gratitude- and awe, when he saw the dozens of clones lying prone on the ground, covered in magical residue. Frosta ran to hug her best friend, cheering and whooping. Their reunion was cut short, though, by a rumbling roar Sea Hawk knew all too well.

“Behind you!”

He spun to face the tsunami he had expected to be bearing down on them, listening to the Alliance's strangled gasps of horrified awe. The tang of brine reached his nose, and Sea Hawk gaped; Mermista had pulled this water from the *ocean* , at least ten miles away. She stood there, biceps flexing as she manipulated the water to crest over them instead of at them. Prime was going to drop a metric ton of seawater on them; at least it would be faster than drowning.

Glimmer rushed forward, sorcery runes forming around her, and Sea Hawk sighed in relief. She shielded them from the onslaught, water rushing past them to take out the clones behind and around them, leaving the Alliance none the worse for wear-

Or so he thought, until Castaspella joined her niece, and together they wrested control of the water from Mermista. Sea Hawk felt his heart drop as they bubbled it, and sent the whole thing flying back at Mermista and the few clones guarding her. He and Perfuma gasped, and Sea Hawk shouted in fear when he saw his wife collide with the wall of the basin, *hard* . She had clearly managed to stop some of the force, otherwise she would likely be dead, but not all of it.

"Sea Hawk!" Netossa shook him from his stupor. "Whatever you're going to do, *do it now!* "

Right. He smiled, not at all feeling the confidence he was forcing himself to exude, and jogged as close as he dared to Mermista's prone form. He swallowed down the anger and fear and sorrow at just how bruised and scratched she was. As she got to her feet, he came within speaking distance.

"Mermista!" he crowed, letting himself slip into the most self-aggrandizing display of egomania he had, the exact attitude that he *knew* pissed her off more than anything. Strong emotion, eh? The only emotion that held a candle to Mermista's perpetual, simmering annoyance for his showboating persona was the love she had for his whole being. He planned on utilizing both. "Horde Prime thinks he controls you! But *I* …know you," He smirked, challenging her, baiting her into their little game. "And I am going to prove it to you! With the *power of shanting! OOOOH-!* "

Just as he had suspected, the very promise of his sea shanties was enough to provoke her ire. A tendril of water snaked around his ankle, and not a second later he was airborne, being forcibly whipped down the hard rock of the earth.

"Downward!" Sea Hawk cried, a warning to anyone who might have been beneath him as he came crashing down. He grunted on impact, but recovered immediately despite his protesting bones and muscles.

With a yell, Mermista sent more jets of water at him, razor sharp and heavier than sacks of bricks. He dodged and ducked behind rocks until he ran out of places to hide, at which point his dearest *sliced through the bedrock* shielding him. Sea Hawk couldn't help but be in awe of her power, if not also terrified, or the way his jaw dropped in shock. By the stars, she was a *goddess* -

Focus!

He leaned on the freshly hewn rock, propping his chin in his hand, affecting the most casual air he could. In his peripheral, he could see Netossa and Perfuma staring at him in abject confusion and terror. They just needed to trust him, he could do this-

“You know, this is actually kind of nice!” He smiled vapidly. “Doesn’t it remind you of the first time we met? You also tried to kill me then.”

One of his most favorite tall-tales to tell, and one of Mermista’s absolute least favorite lies of his. She had never tried to kill him, of course; the fib stemmed from the fact that their first night together- dancing with her and talking with her and later, tangling in sheets with her until sun up- had ‘taken his breath away’ as she ‘stole his heart’. He had written to her, once, out at sea as a Lieutenant, that he wasn’t sure she hadn’t tried to kill him, the way she danced with him on the floor and in bed. She had called him a melodramatic loser with too much time on his hands if he could make such flowery poetry about a ‘basic-ass hook up’.

And here they stood, all these years later.

In some ways, it did remind Sea Hawk of the first time they met. His heart was pounding the same, the feeling that this moment was the single most important one of his life, staring at this beautiful woman who seemed to embody the ocean herself. When they first met, Sea Hawk had been chasing adventure, and had seen in her the thrill of a lifetime- the chance to be a part of the greatest story ever. Now, he knew; her story was written on his pages just as his was hers, and their life together had been nothing but adventure.

It was time to keep writing.

Mermista, per usual, had a slightly differing opinion. With a mighty grunt, she sent torrents of water at him, aiming to kill. He yelped, sprinting and dodging and dancing away from each and every one until they stopped.

"Ha ha!" he crowed, only to once again miss the tendril of water snaking his ankle. She yanked his foot out from under him, dragging him along the rough, chewed up ground. He grunted, debonair charm slipping a moment as he rubbed his head. He knew a concussion when he felt one.

A shadow fell over him, and he slipped back into his persona, smirking roguishly and infuriatingly up at his wife as he crossed his legs and propped up his head. "Couldn't wait to sweep me off my feet?"

"Uuuuggghhh!" Mermista groaned, and his heart *soared* when he realized that the robotic tinge of Prime's control was absent. Her frustration was well and truly her own. This was it! " *Why are you like this?"*

He stood and dusted himself off, considering her question for all of two seconds. Why was he like this? A question she had been hurling at him since the very day they met. Why was he what? Why was he obnoxious, loud, and egomaniacal? Why did he put on airs and strut around singing about adventures that had never happened, or had happened differently? Why did there seem to be two of him at times, and why was one of those personas hellbent on annoying her to death?

Those were all excellent questions. But that wasn't what she was asking him.

Why was he so stubborn? Why was he ready to sit there and take hit after hit, ready to sacrifice himself if it meant saving her? Why was he so determined to save her- be it from Prime or herself? Why was he *here* , when by all logical accounts, they should never have worked out? Why, when everyone else in her life had left, was he still here, putting his own life on the line for someone as abrasive, rude, and emotionally damaged as her?

Well, it was really quite simple.

" *Because I love you, dearest.* "

Those words, those five simple words, said loud and proud for all to hear, slammed into her like one of her own waves, and Sea Hawk saw its impact. She gaped, and the green in her eyes faded abruptly, just like it had on the beach. It came back just as fast, but the connection had been interrupted substantially. As he stroked his mustache, her pupil-less eyes followed him; she was still a puppet, yes, but her strings had been cut.

“And also!” He smiled and tossed his hair, the signal Perfuma had been waiting for. “It’s a good distraction!”

A vine shot out, whipping against the chip exposed by her hair, and shattered the device’s housing. The green flickered spastically, before dying all together. Mermista’s eyes, *her* eyes, beautiful copper and amber, rolled back in her head as she collapsed, and he caught her readily. He lowered her to the ground gently, cradling her against his chest, careful of her many, many wounds as he brushed some loose tendrils of hair behind her ear, tears already clogging his vision.

“Please forgive me for that when you’re back to normal.” All traces of showmanship and confidence were gone from him now, having well served their purpose. Like a dam breaking, it hit him at once- she was back in his arms. Mermista, his love, his life, his wife and best friend and partner, was back with him. He fought down the sobs that were threatening to choke up, focusing instead on Frosta’s voice.

“Uh, guys? Did anyone see where Scorpia went?”

Sea Hawk slid an arm under Mermista’s knees, preparing to stand and move her somewhere less open. He frowned, pausing. Frosta was right- Scorpia was absolutely nowhere to be found. As he opened his mouth to respond, he saw the black ooze of dark magic creeping along the ground toward them.

He yelped in fear, shifting his grip on Mermista to keep her down and her head protected. Perfuma moved to do something, guard them or move them, but soon she was frozen in place, mouth open in horror. Sea Hawk tried to move, tried to speak- and failed. He realized belatedly that he, too, had been petrified by what could only be Micah’s magic.

As his head grew fuzzy, and his thoughts floated away, his last thoughts were of Mermista and whether he’d ever get to see her beautiful eyes again.

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It was quiet, for the first time in months. Mermista wasn’t anywhere anymore; no more barrier, no more Prime, no more darkness or shattered memories. Already the feeling of being There was fading, as if it had never been anything more than a nightmare. Now she was just…asleep. Sort of. She kept trying to wake up, but her eyes wouldn’t listen. Her limbs wouldn’t move, and if she didn’t focus, she’d sorta stop breathing. All super great things, totally.

There were arms around her, a hand on her face, calloused fingers brushing her hair away. A low, rumbling voice against her ear, asking her for forgiveness. Her head flopped toward the voice, and the warm, broad chest it was coming from. Whoever was holding her hitched her higher, in a move that was familiar and comforting.

Sea Hawk .

She begged her body to cooperate, to move and wake up so she could see her husband, hold him back and kiss him and talk to him. But it didn’t listen, and moments later, the darkness grew deeper, and she slipped further under.

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Sea Hawk gasped as he came to, instinctively tightening his arms around the precious cargo he held. He whipped around frantically, finding Perfuma, Frosta, all their dear friends. Everyone seemed relatively unharmed, if not incredibly disoriented and frightened.

Micah had fallen to a knee, Glimmer crouching beside him. The poxes and scars that had been carved into his skin from using dark magic were fading, and he was blinking in confusion at his daughter. He didn’t seem to know where he was, and the green in his eyes wasn’t totally faded. Sea Hawk clutched Mermista tighter; his legs weren’t strong enough to stand yet, so he cradled her head against his chest and simply…waited. He was sure this wasn’t over.

As if summoned by the thought, white, translucent energy began floating out of the spire. It was warm but sterilizing, in a way, and it brought with it the change Sea Hawk had been waiting for for months. Mermista groaned in his arms, and he watched in tentative glee as the sickly green lines of infection receded from her face. With a small sound, the chip detached itself and fell harmlessly to the ground. Sea Hawk couldn’t stop the sob of relief that punched out of his chest, and he gathered his wife closer to him, all but picking her up and pressing teary, frantic kisses to her temple, her cheek, her neck, the corners of her lips. She would kill him for it if she could, but he didn't care. She was returning to him!

"Hey everyone. I'm Bow."

Sea Hawk lifted his head from the crook of Mermista's neck, tears pausing as he saw the massive projection of one of his best friends standing over them all- a beacon of hope, just as Bow had always been. Next to him, a bit away, Glimmer's breath hitched in fear, uncertain of what was happening.

"Prime is probably trying to get his channel back right now, so I have to make this quick." Bow spoke calmly, clearly, like they weren't all toeing the cliff's edge of extinction. Brave lad. "Prime's controlled the universe for a long time. Right now, we're the *only thing* standing in the way of him controlling it forever."

Sea Hawk gathered Mermista impossibly tighter.

"You might be feeling hopeless. You might be thinking we don't stand a chance. A-and maybe…we don't. Prime's too strong-"

Around the rim of the basin, clones began materializing, armed with laser cannons, and orders to do whatever it took to bring them all down.

"-too powerful, but that's *not* gonna stop us! We need to show Prime we are not afraid of him, because we have each other."

Sea Hawk watched as their friends- their family- began closing ranks around him and Mermista, and Castaspella and Micah. She was still unconscious, and he wasn't going to leave her unprotected.They all knew that, and they supported him.

"We have love."

He straightened up. He may not be able to fight, but he wouldn't cower. Mermista wouldn't want him to. Years ago, she'd shown him firsthand that running, and self preservation, weren't nearly as noble as staying. No matter the cost. And if it was the last thing he did, he'd make her proud.

Something pushed along the bond, some small trickle of reassurance. *I'm always proud of you, Sebastian* .

"And if we go down, we go down together!" Bow continued. "We need you. We need *all* of you. It's time to take back our world! It's time to fight! For She-Ra! For *our homes! And for each other!* "

He blinked out not a moment later, but the job was done. The Princesses had rallied, their magic swirling around the battlefield like a banner. In his arms, Mermista flickered faintly, her magic begging to be unleashed, but she only groaned, head twitching against his chest. Sea Hawk brushed his lips against her bloodied hairline.

“Rest, my love,” he murmured. “You may not want to be awake for what comes next. I’ve got you.”

She settled, sighing as her face relaxed. Good. Mermista deserved whatever peace she could get.

The battle raged around them for what felt like hours, but really could have only been a handful of minutes. Sea Hawk kept his body around Mermista’s, shielding her. Castaspella threw up wards for the worst blasts that came their way, but she was exhausting herself keeping Micah alive, it seemed. At any rate, he lost count of how many laser blasts glanced across his back, scorching his beloved jacket to what he knew was beyond repair.

Rather his jacket than him or his wife, eh?

A few glancing blows caught her armor, pinging off her pauldrons or skating along her reinforced, enchanted clothing, but no marks were left. Sea Hawk was more than alright with taking the brunt of this damage. He was well used to being singed, and whatever kept Mermista safe was worth any pain.

Still, despite the overwhelming magical ability of the Alliance, they were being pushed in. When Netossa threw up a massive netted barrier, sweat pouring down her brow, Sea Hawk knew they were nearing the end. He took a breath, making the last of his peace with the fact. His thoughts were interrupted by the explosive entrance of Scorpia and Bow.

Scorpia sent a massive blast of lightning across the field, though it wasn't as strong as she usually made them. The arachnid woman was panting, littered in the same bruises and scars that Mermista was. As Bow raced for Glimmer, Scorpia's eyes found his, and the prone form of Mermista. Her eyes widened, and Sea Hawk offered her a small smile. She returned it sadly, before turning and grabbed Perfuma and Frosta in a bone-crushing hug. From here, Sea Hawk could see Perfuma's shoulders shaking, and the tears tracking down Frosta's face.

The moment, the glimpse of joy, was derailed by the sight of a massive, looming ship melting out of the inky night. The Velvet Glove, just as the Glimmer, Adora, and Bow had described it. Prime was here.

A single clone, dressed no differently than the others, but with a slightly more…hunched bearing, materialized on the ledge in front of them. In his hands, he had Entrapta's hair gripped painfully tight, keeping her feet off the ground. The Tech Princess thrashed and kicked, but it was no use.

"Rejoice, Etheria!" Prime's voice carried clearly across the battlefield, nauseatingly crazed. "For your end has *finally come!* "

Castaspella staggered to her feet, exhausted but determined. Sea Hawk slipped a hand under Mermista's legs, cradling her as close as he could. Fear, hot and cold all at once, was racing through him, his instincts telling him to grab Mermista and run, run, *run!* But there was nowhere to go, and he would rather be here with his loved ones if he was going to die, which was looking incredibly likely.

For a man who had stared death down almost his entire life, one would think he'd be better equipped for this. But, most of those times had been before he had so much to lose.

Glimmer and Bow clasped hands, Scorpia wrapped her arms around Perfuma and Frosta, Spinnerella and Netossa stood their ground, ready to fight to the end like they'd been fighting all their lives.

"You have chosen darkness!" Prime continued, manic. "And so into darkness you shall be plunged!"

Around them, the earth began shaking and splitting apart, sickly green light emanating from the depths below. Prime had reached the Heart, and corrupted it. His heart clenched- Adora…that meant she hadn't…

"The world shall end in fire!"

Columns of green flames shot out of the torn crust, and the Alliance staggered back with shouts of fear. One by one, as the heat quickly grew overwhelming, their friends dropped to the ground, grabbing one another and bracing. Scorpia, Frosta, and Perfuma huddled together, the arachnid woman doing her best to shield them with her exoskeleton. Spinnerella and Netossa clasped hands, tucked together and speaking words only meant for their ears. Swiftwind folded his legs, closed his eyes, and seemed content with just waiting. His horn sparked spasmodically, as he probably tried to reach Adora one last time. Next to him, Kadroh was crouched and trembling, but defiant still. Castaspella, with tears in her eyes, was holding her brother and staring at her niece. Glimmer and Bow remained standing, staring through the firestorm.

"Adora!" Glimmer yelled, attempting to summon their lost friend from the throes of the apocalypse.

Sea Hawk kept one arm around Mermista's shoulders, and one arm around her legs. Their faces he tucked together, his tears falling onto her cheek. He didn't cry for himself, he cried for her, for Salineas, for their people, for the future they would never have. The wedding they'd never plan, Mermista rolling her eyes over trivialities like flower arrangements and tablecloths. The adventures they'd never get to go on now. The dances they'd never dance, the love they'd never make again. They'd never meet their children, Mermista would never see her father again, never get the closure she deserved. Maevik and Eliza and Dhang, all far from them now. He hoped Maevik had found his husband and kept Eliza safe. He hoped Dhang had survived the chipping. And he hoped that, whatever came next, they'd all see each other again.

"AND WHEN THE ASHES SCATTER, AT LAST, THERE WILL BE ***PEACE*** *!"*

“Mermista,” he murmured, breath hitching. “‘I love you’ doesn’t begin to cover it. You are my world, dearest. You’re my best friend, my Queen, my north star. You saved me from myself, gave me a home, a-and a purpose, and I’ll never be able to repay you for that now. I was going to spend our whole lives showing you how grateful I am.” He sniffed. “I was going to be a good King, someone you could depend on. I-I was going to stop setting my ships on fire, and start staying by your side, which is where I’ve always belonged, even when I was too stupid to know that.

“I was going to watch you become the Queen you were never given the chance to be. We were going to rebuild, and make anew. I was going to dance with you in our rooms, and on terraces, and serenade you even when you pretended to hate it,” he chuckled. His lips were against her forehead, speaking his truth as the heat around them grew oppressive. “I was going to spend my life showing you how wonderful and beautiful you are, because I can’t think of anything I’d want to do more with the time given to me.”

She groaned, and the Bond flickered. He shook his head, brushing his mustache against her. “No, my love, stay asleep. Rest. You don’t want to be awake for this. *I* don’t want you awake for this. Dream, dearest. Dream of the future taken from us…and when you wake up, we’ll be there.”

Sea Hawk had no more words, so he accessed the Bond and sent his love, as deep and all encompassing as he could manifest from the very depths of his soul, into her consciousness. Her face wasn’t relaxed, but it wasn’t in pain. If anything, it reflected his own grief.

The fire was coming closer, eating up the earth they laid on. Sea Hawk closed his eyes, pressing his forehead to Mermista's.

This was it.

"Cry Etheria!" Prime's voice continued. "Cry for Prime's mercy! There will be no comfort for you! All the universe will be consumed in undying flame!"

Sea Hawk kissed Mermista one last time, wishing against his desire for her to stay asleep that she could kiss him back. "Goodbye, dearest. I'll see you soon. Always remember, I love you."

The fire was less than a foot from Glimmer and Bow, who wrapped themselves around one another, still standing in defiance of Prime. Closer, closer, the flames licked at them all, disintegrating rock and sand, eating up the distance between them hungrily-

Until it all stopped.

Like a switch being flipped, the flames simply died away, leaving behind the torn, scorched earth. Behind them, the sun began rising, painting the basin in rose gold. Sea Hawk opened his eyes fully, jaw falling open. No, it wasn't the sun. It was…fireflies?

Motes of light? Magic? Floating up out of the earth where the columns had once roared.

From a split in the wall of the basin behind them, a radiant star emerged, bringing with it the dawn of a new day. She-Ra. Adora.

She had done it.

Preceding her was a wave of magic so strong it turned the desert to meadow, coaxing life and growth out of nothing but ashen sand. She lifted her head to the Velvet Glove, hovering above them, and with a yell, raised her sword. Light erupted, pure magic at its finest, and covered the ship in its essence. When it faded, the ship was wreathed in magical foliage, wrapping around it, in it- a tree of life where once a beacon of death had floated.

She-Ra flipped the sword around, slamming it into the earth, transforming the entirety of the rock around them into new growth. The Princesses began glowing, each of them a rainbow of magical energy. In his arms, Mermista stirred. He looked down as she gasped, her eyes shooting open. The same glow came over her own body, turning her beauty ethereal. She was still disoriented, but she was awake.

Mermista was *back!*

Adora left to handle Prime, and cheers erupted around them, but Sea Hawk only had eyes for Mermista, growing more aware by the second. The glow seemed to be healing the lesser scrapes and bruises, and he watched them fade away. Her eyes found his, scant inches away, and she blinked.

“I know you.”

“Princess.” He grinned, tears filling his eyes as barely kept down a sob. “I’ve dreamed of you night and day.”

She blinked again, before the most beautiful, heart-stopping smile came over her face, crinkling her eyes. With shaking hands, she grabbed the lapels of his jacket, and crushed their lips together.

Sea Hawk sobbed into the kiss, holding her far, far too tightly, but he didn’t care. He didn’t care about any of it. His hand came up to cradle her jaw, her face, as his lips moved with hers. She had to be beyond concussed- Mermista would normally rather die than kiss him in public. But here she was, gasping and crying into his lips, her tears mingling with his.

Sea Hawk pulled back for air, but continued to cover her face, her jaw, her neck in kisses. “I love you, I love you, by the *gods* do I love you-”

“I love you, too, Sebastian,” she whispered, choking with emotion. He drew back to stare into her eyes, her beautiful copper eyes that he thought he’d never seen again. “I knew you could do it.”

“Do what?” He pressed kisses to each of her shaking fingers.

“Save me. I told you, didn’t I?”

He grinned, hugging her close. “As always, dearest, you were right.”

“Duh.” She chuckled hoarsely.

Around them, people were celebrating. Netossa dipped Spinnerella into a passionate kiss, both grinning and crying. Glimmer launched herself into Micah’s arms, both of their shoulders shaking with sobs. Swiftwind and Melog stomped and ran around the clearing, playing jovially with one another. Emily went racing away to find her master, while Scorpia hoisted Frosta onto her shoulders.

He watched the scorpion woman falter as Perfuma touched her pincer. “P-Perfuma, hi, wow! You look…you look great!”

The trio faltered as Catra came over, looking terrified but determined. Words were barely exchanged before Scorpia placed Frosta down and all but tackled Catra in an embrace. Perfuma and Frosta piled in, all of them laughing as they fell over.

Sea Hawk helped Mermista to her feet, then, one of her arms around his shoulder, one of his around her waist. He couldn't stop staring at her, enchanted by her beauty, overwhelmed by her presence. She was alive, she was in his arms, breathing, and for now…she was alright.

Adora, Entrapta, and…Prime? Came stumbling down the slope. Entrapta had her arm around the clone, and he was grinning down at her with unabashed joy, more emotion than any of the others had shown, save for Kadroh.

Oh! It was Hordak, then. Sea Hawk grinned for Entrapta, reunited with her lab partner. He turned to Mermista, her arm around his shoulders for support, and watched as her smile faded to skepticism. "So, are we all just like…okay with this?"

He grasped her hand, and tugged her lips back to his. "Later, my love. For now, we are all entitled to revel in the love we've won back."

She rolled her eyes at his prose, and he had to laugh.

"Never stop rolling your eyes at me, dearest."

"Oh, don't even worry about it, sailor," she snorted, but she was smiling. It didn't seem she could stop. "C'mere, before my concussion catches up to me."

He didn’t know how long they stood there, Mermista letting him hold her and kiss her for all their friends to see. It felt private still, though, in a way he couldn’t explain. The moment was interrupted by Perfuma’s voice.

“Mermista?” The other Princess gasped. They pulled apart, but Sea Hawk kept an arm around her. Perfuma’s eyes widened, filling with tears. “You’re awake?”

“Uh…obviously?”

Perfuma scrambled off the ground, out of the pile that was her, Scorpia, and Frosta, and tore across the grass. Mermista just turned and opened her arms, letting Perfuma practically tackle her. She grunted harshly, but returned the hug just as tightly. Sea Hawk let go gradually, when he was sure Perfuma had her. Both Princesses were crying, whispering to one another.

Frosta wandered over, hovering for only a second before the older two separated and dragged her into the hug. As the three near-sisters cried and laughed, Sea Hawk turned and saw Bow heading right for him. He grinned and opened his arms, laughing when the younger man crashed into him. “We did it!”

Hugs and tears and shouts of joy abounded for a while, people coming together and embracing in exhilarated relief. Sea Hawk never strayed more than five feet from Mermista, and that was only if she was hugging someone else. Normally, she would be pushing him off her and scoffing. Now, she held him just as tightly. As the battle adrenaline faded, along with the glow of She-Ra’s magic, he started to notice something wrong.

“Dearest, you’re…limping? Sort of?”

Mermista scowled and shifted her shoulders, then her hips. “I’m fine. Just really tight, I guess. Back hurts.”

“Let me see?”

“Later,” she grunted, adjusting her arm around him again. “It’s really not that bad, just uncomfortable.”

“...alright,” he relented. “But I will be checking.”

“Yeah, yeah.”

It was when they were all heading up the hill, out of the basin, that it came to a head. Scorpia stumbled, first, her right leg giving out suddenly with a foreboding crack. Perfuma and Frosta cried out, but it was Catra and Melog who went tearing down the hill after her. Mermista turned to him, quite suddenly, and he saw the sallowness of her skin, the sweat on her brow.

“Dearest, what’s wrong?” He frowned, reaching out for her. She had waved off his arm up the hill, saying it would just trip them both.

Mermista’s jaw worked, even as her eyes grew foggy. “I-I…it…Sebastian-”

She crumpled, eyes rolling back and shut as she hit the grass. He dove for her, and suddenly Bow and Adora were there, helping him roll her over. Blood was trickling out of her nose, and her head lolled oddly.

No…not like this. He had her back, she was supposed to be fine-

“We’ve got a pulse!” Bow called. Another thud drew their attention, and they turned to see Micah hit the ground at the top of the hill. Glimmer and Castaspella raced to him.

“Same here!” Catra shouted.

“They need to get to Mystacor!” Castaspella stood, drawing a rune on the ground. “Glimmer, take Scorpia and Mermista, I’ll take Micah.”

Sea Hawk scooped Mermista into his arms, supporting her head on his shoulder. Glimmer grabbed him, and a second later, they were standing in the atrium of the healing rooms at Mystacor. He blinked, and Scorpia and Perfuma and Frosta were there as well. Castaspella was speaking with a woman in healing robes, looking tired but unharmed. Mystacor itself looked fairly intact, no major damage to be seen.

A cervitaurian man approached, carting with him a hovering gurney. “Name?”

“Um. Sea Hawk?”

He jotted it down. “Her’s?”

“Mermista?”

The man blinked, looked at the paper, and then them, and blushed a bit. “Er. Right. Of course. Would you mind placing Her Majesty on the gurney? We’ve got to get her to a soul forge right away.”

“May I-”

“I’m sorry sir, family only.”

“I’m her husband.”

The man blinked, and quickly laid his hands along Mermista's brow. He frowned sadly, looking genuinely sorry and confused. "I apologize, I truly do, but a Confluence doesn't typically qualify in Mystacor."

Sea Hawk remembered, then, the difference between universal marriage and the Confluence. "Right. I-I understand. Salinean legality only."

"I'll ask my superior as soon as I can, but in the meantime, please let us get her examined?"

"Of course."

Sea Hawk laid Mermista down gently, pressing a kiss to her forehead. As they carted her and Scorpia away, he, Perfuma, and Frosta came together, fear all over their faces.

Nearly an hour later, their friends began appearing, bags in hand. Adora and Glimmer took off for the healing chambers, while Catra and Bow came to sit.

"Netossa and Spinnerella are going to start tackling refugee rehoming efforts," Bow sighed, scrubbing a hand down his face. "Entrapta and Hordak are already dismantling Horde scrap, seeing what they can do to make it useful for recovery. There's a lot of advanced tech in there, I think Entrapta is going to see what medical and energy uses it could be put to.”

Sea Hawk cleared his throat. “I need to get a message to someone- well, a few someones- but I’m not sure how to find them.”

“Melog can.” Catra perked up, ears unflattening. “It can track just about anything. Magic or some shit. Just think of who you’re looking for and it’ll find them.”

“Alright.”

Sea Hawk pressed a hand to Melog’s head, and did his best to project mental images of Maevik, Eliza, and Dhang into it. The cat meowed robotically, sneezed, and vanished.

“Now what?” Frosta sighed. Bow wrapped an arm around her.

“Now…we wait.”

Chapter End Notes

> We’re not done yet folks! A few bits of epilogue to set up the next fic featuring catra, a coronation, and a WEDDING! Like, a for real one.

Let me know what you thought, as always, and thank you <3

i'll swim and sail on savage seas

Chapter Summary

> Healing comes in many forms, some unexpected, others par for the course. It's time for Mermista and Sea Hawk to begin again.

Chapter Notes

> SORRY for this delay. i got caught up writing a million other things, including nanowrimo. But the epilogues are coming in hot, so please enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mermista had never liked doctors. They poked and prodded, and if they weren't the healers hired specifically for her family, they took far too much interest in her nonhuman attributes. So, when she woke up in a strange bed, in what could only be one of Mystacor's healing chambers, she groaned. The last time she'd been here, she was thirteen and had depleted her magic so severely she had passed out, and been unable to reconnect with the Pearl. That had been a hell of a tantrum.

She shifted to sit up, and her back and head *throbbed* . Nausea swept through her with the feeling, and she shut her eyes against the wave. When it abated, she sat up much more slowly. She was alone, which struck her as odd. Where was…

"Oh thank the gods," a healer, who had been carrying a tray of assorted magical items into the room, froze when they saw her. "You're awake. I'll fetch that handsome husband of yours, sweetie, just hold tight."

Mermista blinked, barely nodding before the healer was gone. A second later, Sea Hawk was there in the curtained doorway, staring at her in relief and wonder. "Dearest…"

She swallowed the lump in her throat. "Hey, babe."

He crossed the room in two strides, perching carefully on the edge of the bed and grabbing her hand. "How are you feeling?"

"Not great," she sighed, leaning back into the pillows. "What happened?"

"You collapsed on our way out of the basin," he reached and pushed some hair behind her ear. "They examined you in the glowy molecule thing-"

"The soul forge."

"Sure, yes," Sea Hawk flapped a hand, and she smiled a bit. "You have a bad concussion, and a bruised spine. It's also out of alignment, and pinching a nerve, which is what's causing the pain when you walk."

"Ah," Mermista blinked. "So…what now?"

“They need to operate.”

Mermista balked. “Uh, no, no. No thank you. I’ll just do yoga or something-”

“Dearest,” Sea Hawk fixed her with a very firm stare. “You need this. Your body needs you to do this.”

“Yeah, well, my body hasn’t really been in alignment with my brain lately, so, hmmm, no thanks,” she glared, hating how her voice trembled. She looked away as tears filled her eyes.

The bed shifted, and then Sea Hawk was laying next to her, tugging her down gently, so gently, to face him. “Mermista, dearheart,” he took her hand. “You’ve been through hell itself and back. And I hate asking you to do anything that you don’t want to do, especially now. But if you don’t do this…you may never be able to walk properly again. Not for longer than a few minutes, and probably not unaided. And you won’t be able to swim, or transform, or…”

Mermista shut her eyes. Part of her, the part of her that just wanted some fucking *control* , was screaming at her to refuse. But the larger, smarter part of her knew that she had to do this. For Sea Hawk, for her kingdom, and yes, for herself. So she set her jaw, and nodded. “Fine.”

“Thank you, dearest,” he brushed a kiss to the corner of her mouth. “Truly.”

She didn’t respond, just turned her head a bit to capture his lips again. They laid there for long minutes, trading lazy, slowly heating kisses. Mermista sighed, running her tongue along Sea Hawk’s bottom lip. He opened for her with a soft moan, and she licked into his mouth languidly. Footsteps outside pulled them apart, but only somewhat. She was too tired, too worn to hide anything about her emotions right now. At least not in front of the one person who would never judge her.

Sea Hawk sat up reluctantly. “I’m going to let them know you’ve given your permission, or whatever. I’m sure there’s paperwork, so I’ll bring that back. In the meantime, you have some guests who’d love to see you.”

She blinked. “Who?”

“Maevik, Eliza, and Dhang are all here.”

Mermista had to fight to not bolt upright. “Send them in. Please.”

Sea Hawk departed with one more kiss, and a moment later, Maevik was pushing through the curtain. She sat up slowly, and stared at him. Her guard’s throat worked as his eyes grew wet. “Your Majesty.”

“Royal Fork Bearer.”

He laughed, and very gracefully crossed the room to skirt a hasty bow, and wrap his arms around her gently, but firmly. Mermista buried her face in his shoulder, letting some tears fall. They said nothing. They had never been a verbose pair, not when actions suited just fine.

Maevik drew back, dabbed at his eyes. “I can’t tell you how thrilled I am to see you whole.”

“Same here,” she sniffed. “How is…everything?”

“Hard to say. But we’ve sent out missives through the remaining generals that the war is over, the Horde is defeated, and it’s time to rebuild our home. The people will come.”

“I sure hope you’re right,” she sighed. “How’s Eliza?”

“Shaken, but fine,” Maevik smiled. “She’s just outside, and I can’t tell you how touched she is that the King summoned her by name.”

“Of course he did. She’s going to be head guard one day, hm?”

"Quite right."

They sat in silence for a few more moments, just breathing and taking in the fact that it was all over. The mental images, the horrors, the things she'd seen and done, were clawing at her mind, but Mermista pushed them all away. Later. She could handle it later.

" *Beta?* " Dhang's voice floated through the curtain. "May we come in?"

"Please," she called.

Dhang looked older than ever, but his eyes were bright with victory, and the promise of peace. Eliza, trailing next to him, looked years older than she'd been when Mermista left her, and was littered in bruises and scrapes. Mermista reached out for them both, embracing Eliza first, hauling her up to sit on the bed, and then Dhang. He probed her connection, her magic, with his own, and she let him.

He pulled back with a frown. "You will need to sit with the Pearl for a long while, *beta* . She is unhappy."

"I know the feeling."

Sea Hawk did return with the paperwork, and some nutritional shake junk that Mermista curled her lip at. She wanted, like, sushi. Or rice. Or naan. Something with flavor. Her husband left as quickly as he came in, though, looking agitated. She glanced at Maevik, who frowned.

“He’s waiting for someone to arrive. Someone I couldn’t stop from getting here, despite my best efforts.”

“Who?” Mermista frowned, sipping her gross shake.

“Your father.”

Mermista just barely avoided choking. “That bastard’s still alive?”

Maevik frowned even harder, if that was possible. “You don’t remember? Sea Hawk said you met him while you were…”

“To be honest, I’m trying very hard, like, not to remember right now,” she averted her eyes. “How’s Scorpia?”

“The Lost Princess recovers well,” Dhang said. “She will need surgery as well for her hipbone.”

“That’s good-”

"Mermista."

Sea Hawk's voice interrupted them, and they all turned. He looked…nervous, and irritated, but tentatively hopeful. Maevik stood abruptly, as did the others. Eliza gave her one more hug before sliding off the bed.

"Former King Mercia is here."

Mermista's heart stopped, before starting again in double time, none of it showing on her face. She dismissed the three in the room on autopilot, eyes glued to Sea Hawk's like a lifeline. "Hawk…?"

"He sent word that he'd be coming a little after the other three arrived. Maevik attempted to stop him, but…your father is a stubborn man."

"Tell me about it."

Sea Hawk smiled softly. "Would you like me to stay?"

"I think…I gotta gut this fish alone," she grimaced. "But thank you. And I'll call you if I need you."

He tapped his head, and ducked out. Mermista took a deep breath, and then the moment she'd been waiting almost four long years for was here.

Her father stood in the doorway, staring at her impassively. Once upon a time, Mermista would have crossed her arms, fidgeted, looked away from his imperious gaze. But she was a different woman now. She was a Queen, a Princess of Power, a politician, and a warrior. And that was the short list.

"Mermista."

"Mercia."

He blinked at the use of his name, but gave no other reaction. He stepped into the room, and let the curtain fall shut behind him. It would soundproof the room, which might end up being best if this went the way it typically did.

"How are you feeling?"

Mermista paused, shock briefly shorting her brain out. The last time he'd asked her that, she was eight and they had just buried her mother.

"Fine," she answered on reflex. She was most certainly not fine, but he was the last person who needed to know that. He nodded, and she hated him for believing her. "Yourself?"

Mercia's eyes roamed the room. "That is unimportant."

"Sure."

She kept herself upright for as long as she could, but the pain in her spine was getting overwhelming, so she reclined back a bit in the pillows. Her father's eyes tracked the movement, narrowing when she couldn't contain a wince. "You are not fine."

"Clearly."

"Why be dishonest with me?" He seemed genuinely confused, and she sneered.

"Because I don't trust you, obviously?"

Mercia's eyes widened a fraction, but he just nodded. "Understood."

"Why are you here?" Pain was making her short-tempered, and the exhaustion was making her not care.

He looked away, running the nail of his thumb along the lines of his palm. It was the only nervous or thoughtful habit he'd ever betrayed. "I was…concerned. For you. After we met on the beach weeks ago, I've had much to think about."

"And plenty of time to do it, too," she scoffed.

Mercia frowned. "Your tone-"

"You do *not* get to lecture me about my tone!" She raised her voice slightly, daring him to disagree. He held her glare, but backed down.

"Fine. Yes. You're right."

She quirked a brow, skeptical. "Alright, I'll bite. What the fuck is up with you? You never agree with me."

"As I said, I've had much to think about."

"Well, I'm a captive and mildly interested audience," she snarked. "So feel free to enlighten me."

Mercia turned sharply, his glare much harsher now, and she fought against every urge to shrink away. “You have always been a fresh, combative child, haven’t you?”

“Born and bred, thanks for noticing.”

“Nevertheless,” her father pressed on. “I came here to…speak with you.”

“Well, it’s going, like, super great.”

“Will you let me-”

“Can you just get to the point?” She groaned.

“I am trying to apologize!” Her father snapped, and it shocked them both into silence. Mermista floundered, trying to maintain her mask.

“W-who said I want your apology?”

“Prime did. On the beach.”

Mermista was too stunned to speak, so Mercia pushed on.

“When we fought, on the beach…when that madman had you- he said things. Things I wouldn’t have believed if your…husband hadn’t confirmed them himself. And despite his many, *many* shortcomings-”

The water in the glass on her bedside table was racing toward him before she could think to stop it. “ *You will not speak about him like that* ,” she hissed. Mercia glanced apathetically at the water, hovering as a whip in front of his face. Mercia glared, but nodded, and she recalled the water.

“You’ve grown stronger.”

“You have no idea.”

Mercia sighed. “No, I don’t. And that is becoming my greatest regret in life. May I?” He gestured to the edge of the bed, and after a long pause, Mermista nodded.

“So. What did Prime tell you?”

“That I hurt you,” Mercia wouldn’t quite meet her eyes. “Not just by leaving, but…my presence in your life. That you reviled me, almost hated me. That you…feared me.”

Mermista played with her hands. “Yes. I did.”

“And he told me that you loved me, but that you never felt I returned it adequately, if at all. That the hole your mother’s passing left, I only ever made worse. He told me that you didn’t know I loved you.”

She just nodded, jaw clenched tight. She would *not* cry. Not in front of him.

“I thought,” Mercia’s voice was hoarse, tight. “I thought you knew why I pushed you. I thought you knew that I was trying to prepare you for the throne, trying to train you so you wouldn’t meet the same end Nerida did.”

“I understood that that’s what you thought you were doing,” Mermista muttered. “But what I *knew* was that you yelled at me, constantly. What I knew was that if I wasn’t perfect, I didn’t get to eat with you, or see my friends, or enjoy my life. If I dared to be anything less than what you wanted to see, I was punished, and deprived. That’s what I knew.”

“I never meant-”

“It doesn’t matter,” she seethed. “It doesn’t matter what you meant. What matters is that you stopped being able to even fucking *look at me* after Amma died!”

He froze, and she finally looked up. He looked impossibly sad at the tears in her eyes and it only fueled her rage.

“I didn’t need a fucking drill sergeant, or a tutor, or a mentor after she died. *I needed my father* ,” She wiped furious at her eyes. “And you were *never there* . You left me that day, too, and I have been totally and utterly alone, in a way that can’t even be described, ever since.”

“Mermista-”

“I don’t understand!” She cried, desperation taking hold of her. “I don’t understand what I did! Or didn’t do, whatever. Why couldn’t you be nice to me, o-or say ‘good job, *beta* ’? Why wasn’t I enough? *Why couldn’t you just stay?* ”

She couldn’t stop the sobs now, and drew her knees up- despite the pain- to bury her head in. His hand touched her arm, and she jerked away on instinct. Crying in front of her father was already a no, and she knew what came next- the grabbing, shaking her roughly and ordering her to stop. She flinched from it, warning him off with a noise.

“Alright, I’m sorry. I won’t touch you, *beta* .”

“Don’t call me that,” she sobbed. “You don’t get to walk in here and call me that.”

“Okay, Mermista. Okay.”

She lifted her head slightly, and saw Mercia staring at her with naked fear, and guilt. Good, she thought. She hoped he sat with it the rest of his life. “Tell me why.”

“Why what?”

“Why all of it.”

He hung his head. “It’s…complicated.”

“Figure it out.”

Her father sat in silence for a while, and Mermista accessed her Bond. Sea Hawk was thrumming with anxiety, and she tried to reassure him. He must have noticed her own grief, because he sent an overwhelming wave of love back. It dried her tears, and helped her hold her head a bit higher.

She may be the traumatized daughter of this douche, but she was also a Queen.

“Well?”

Mercia spread his hands, looking at her. “Have you heard of sea longing?”

Mermista frowned, sifting through her memories. “Yyyes? Maybe? Wasn’t it what killed the Prince in that old fairytale you used to read me? I think Dhang mentioned it once, too, in passing…”

“Yes, very good,” he praised her robotically, like he used to when she was very small, eyes far away. “It is an affliction that affects our people, us Land-Mer. It can be brought on by grief, or deep sorrow, but it can happen randomly as well. It is the need to return to the sea, to submerge yourself and surrender, and once it takes root, it cannot be cured. It is a curse.”

Mermista’s eyes widened. “And you…?”

“Yes,” he shut his eyes. “And I am ashamed. Ashamed I couldn’t be stronger, ashamed for what this sickness has done to me…to us. For what it made me do to you.”

“When did this start?”

“Shortly after your mother died, although I ignored it for many years. Which, in turn, only worsened it. It became difficult to feel anything more than my grief, and after years of fighting it, and it getting worse every day, I gave in. In the end, I couldn’t face you, and tell you the truth. I fled in the night like the coward I am.”

Mermista didn’t dissuade him of the notion. “I made the grief worse, didn’t I? That’s why you never looked at me.”

Mercia said nothing, only hung his head.

“That’s…that’s so unfair to me, you know that right?” She blinked away more tears. “I was a child. It wasn’t my fault that I looked like her, so why the fuck did I get punished?”

“I never said it was fair or right, Mermista,” he sighed. “In fact, I’ll be the first to admit it was so very wrong. I know that now. But it was, and is. I cannot escape this grief, this feeling. Even now, the sea calls to me, louder and louder.”

“So why now?” She sniffed. “Why show up now and make it better?”

“Because I was confronted with the consequences of my own cowardice on that beach. I wasn’t strong enough to stop you, anymore. My magic has faded in my exile. The rage and anger you felt for me was so potent that it nearly killed us all. I could no longer lie to myself that I had done my best all these years.”

Mermista just watched him. When he looked at her, well and truly, he was no longer just looking through her.

“You have grown into an incredible woman, Mermista, despite everything. Before Salineas fell, you brought it to prosper, and thrive, like your mother had always dreamed of doing, and never got to. I couldn’t be prouder to call you my daughter, even though I gave up that right years ago. And I want you to know, from me, that your mother loved you more than life itself. Whatever seas she swims now, she’s proud of you.”

Mermista bowed her head to hide her tears, but her father reached out again, making sure she could see his hand, and lifted her chin. She swallowed a sob, her voice treacherously fragile. “Baba?”

“I am truly sorry, for all the pain I’ve caused you,” to her utter shock, Mercia was crying, too. “I don’t know how to make it better, or if I can. I’m still tethered to the sea, and I will be for the rest of my days. But I needed you to know that whatever Prime told you was wrong. I’ve loved you from the moment I knew you were coming, to this very second, even if all I’ve done is hurt you. I love you, Mermista, *meri chand ke tukra* .”

Against her instincts, honed through years of her father’s coldness, she fell into him. This time, though, he caught her, and held her tight. He let her cry, and didn’t scold her, or try to stop her. He just held her, stroking her hair, and Mermista felt six years old again. They had a long way to go, and Mermista didn’t even know if it was a path she wanted to travel. But right now, she was finally at some form of peace with her father, and she didn't feel inclined to ask for more.

They pulled apart after a few long minutes, both dabbing their eyes and averting contact. Mermista almost had to laugh for, in the end, how similar they were. "I think," she breathed shakily. "We need to do this slowly. I have to rebuild all of Salineas, and that comes first. I trust you can understand that?"

"Yes, of course."

"So for now, let's just…be here?" Mermista gnawed her lip. "You have virtually no idea who I am, and, like, same. So, baby steps."

"Alright, be- Mermista," he nodded. "Slowly. Can I…is there any way to help with rebuilding from my position?"

"Call off your guard dogs in my court?" She rolled her eyes. "They make my life hell. And if you could work with some others on the underwater passageways between the islands, that would be great."

"The catacombs?" Mercia frowned. "I don't think-"

"Connectivity is key," she affirmed. "In an island chain kingdom. Otherwise, I'm going to end up with more Peekablues and a knife in my back, like, literally. People have to be able to move, and understand that even though we’re many islands, and many cultures and states, we’re one kingdom.”

Mercia was still frowning, but he was looking at her with renewed consideration. “As my Queen wishes.”

“Thank you, Baba.”

It was the closest he had come to smiling, the way his eyes crinkled at the name. It faded when there was a knock on the door, and they turned to see Sea Hawk. For his part, he didn’t balk at the twin stares of neutrality, though he did blink.

“My, that’s terrifying,” he mused, before he cleared his throat. “Dearest, they want to prep you for surgery.”

Mercia frowned. “Surgery? What for?”

“My back is fucked up,” Mermista explained. She turned to Sea Hawk. “How did it happen, by the way? I don’t remember this pain from before.”

“That…might be me?” A new voice crept from behind Sea Hawk, who shifted to reveal, well, most of the Alliance. Glimmer was at the front, looking guilt ridden and sheepish, as well as exhausted beyond reason. “When I redirected the tidal wave, I got…zealous.

I'm sorry! You were just, like, *really* gunning for us, and I had to make sure you went down, and-"

"Glimmer, please, chill," Mermista waved her off. "It kept me down long enough for the plan, if that's what you're calling it, to work."

Sea Hawk had the good grace to look a little sheepish as well. Mercia glanced between them, shaking his head and rolling his eyes. Perfuma pushed to the front, and Mermista almost winced for her asshole of a dad.

"Mercia," she began with a brittle smile. "How unexpected."

Her father inclined his head respectfully. "Chief Perfuma. How did Plumeria fare through the war?"

"Better than most," Perfuma's eyes were steel.

"Wait- Mercia?" Adora frowned in confusion. She looked awful, in Mermista's silent opinion. Bags under her eyes, pale skin, limp hair, bruises and cuts abounding- she was a walking zombie. "Mermista's dad? I thought he left."

"He did," Mercia responded dryly, and Adora reddened. "But that's between my daughter and I. Your Grace."

Sea Hawk opened his mouth to say something, but Bow bumped his back and the air was knocked out of his lungs in a pained groan. Bow winced, hands fluttering. “Sorry, Sea Hawk! Are you alright?”

“What happened to you?” Mermista’s voice was apathetic as ever, but she knew Hawk could feel her concern. He straightened, rubbing his shoulder, and she realized belatedly that his signature blue jacket was gone. “Where’s your jacket?”

He smiled sadly. “Afraid that particular piece of my wardrobe will have to be retired.”

“Damaged?”

Sea Hawk nodded, dodging Mercia’s calculating stare. “It’s nothing- but a scratch, really-”

“Your husband lies,” Mercia drawled, glancing at her. Mermista rolled her eyes.

“Yeah, obviously.”

“He was hurt at the end,” Frosta blurted, pushing into the quickly crowding room. “When we were being barraged, before Netossa’s net went up. His back got grazed a whole bunch with laser cannon fire!”

Mermista stared at him incredulously. “You didn’t think to move?”

“Couldn’t,” Sea Hawk blushed.

Glimmer smirked a bit, glancing between them. “You were unconscious, and we couldn’t get you out of the line of fire- nowhere to go. He shielded you the whole time.”

Mermista stared at her husband, refusing to cry anymore than she had, but needing him to understand how much she loved him. He stared back, smiling softly. Mercia was glancing between them with mild interest, and, if Mermista could read him right (she could), begrudging respect and gratitude for Sea Hawk. “Well, then. Thanks, Hawk.”

Sea Hawk just winked. “Any time.”

“Ugh, get a room,” Frosta groaned.

Mermista scowled at her, gesturing around her. “I, like, had one until you busted all in here.”

Perfuma clapped her hands softly. “Well, I think we had best get moving. It’s time for your operation.”

With that, Mercia stood and bowed formally to the room of nobility. He turned to Mermista, and squeezed her hand briefly. "You'll be in touch, I assume? Kiiiinda hard to reach you in the middle of, y'know, the fucking ocean."

Mercia exhaled a bit more through his nose, the equivalent of a laugh. "Ever have you had a way with words, *rani* ."

Mermista scowled and rolled her eyes at the term he had used when she was being a particularly stubborn or bratty toddler. "Whatever."

"I'll be in touch," he hesitated a moment. They were both aware of the borderline hostile audience, and neither were particularly fond of public displays of affection. But it spoke to the effort he was making when he leaned down, and, when she didn't recoil, pressed a kiss to the crown of her head. "Be well, my daughter. Heal swiftly."

"Bye, Baba."

He paused in front of Sea Hawk, something passing between them, before Mercia bowed once again and departed. All eyes turned to Mermista, and Sea Hawk and Perfuma hurried to her bedside.

“Are you alright?”

“How did it go, dearest?”

“Relax, guys,” she chuckled, then winced. Her back was seriously killing her. “It was fine. It’s…he apologized actually. It’s why he came. And to check on me.”

Perfuma’s jaw was on the floor as everyone came closer. “He did?!”

“Yep,” Mermista sighed. “It’s…we yelled, too. I yelled. It’s not good yet. But maybe one day it could be? And even if it’s not, like, anything more than this, that’s, like, fine.”

“I’m happy for you, my love,” Sea Hawk murmured, squeezing her hand.

“Yeah, whatever,” she muttered, all too aware of all the eyes on her. “What’s happening with everyone else?”

“Scorpia’s being taken to surgery now,” Glimmer came and sat on her other side, grabbing her open hand. “They’re gonna try to do both of you at once. Are you sure you’re not…mad?”

“I’m not,” Mermista shook her head. “I wasn’t me, Glim. You did what you had to.”

“I could’ve pulled more,” the younger Queen whispered morosely.

“Well, let me get a few good shots in next time we spar and we can call it even, eh?” Mermista snorted. Adora came up behind Glimmer.

“It’s really good to have you back, Mermista,” the blonde *beamed* at her. “We have so much to tell you-!”

“Let’s maybe wait on that, Adora,” Bow butted in quickly. “Mermista has to focus on healing. And then we can catch her up.”

There was something they weren’t telling her, and it was painfully obvious from the way the BFS was glaring at one another, Perfuma wouldn’t make eye contact, and Frosta looked almost furious. Sea Hawk met her eyes, and he made The Face. The face that said ‘you’re not gonna like it, but it’ll work out’. She glanced at Frosta. “Spill, kid.”

“Adora and Catra are dating.”

Mermista’s jaw *dropped* , as Glimmer whirled on Frosta. “Dude! What did we just say!”

An argument was beginning to break out, and her head was starting to pound for it. Sea Hawk, bless him, noticed, and pantomimed the whistle he was about to let loose. She plugged her ears with the water from the glass, and distantly heard the shrill call to shut up.

“Friends! Could we perhaps have this argument where Mermista isn’t about to be prepped for surgery?”

Everyone looked sheepish and nodded. Adora coughed. “Sorry, Merms.”

“Whatever, dude,” she shook her head. “I…yeah. Whatever.”

“Can we talk?” Adora’s eyes were wide, pleading. “Later?”

Mermista shrugged, gnawing on her lip. “When I’m awake.”

“O-okay.”

She didn’t want to push Adora away, but her walls were coming up fast and hard. Catra? The woman who had helped wage war against them for three years? Who had tried to kill Adora countless times? Who had *destroyed Salineas* , alongside Hordak? *Catra* ?

Yeah, Mermista needed time.

“The healers are here,” Glimmer murmured. She leaned in to hug her, and Mermista hugged her back. “See you on the other side.”

Adora hugged her tightly, clearly scared, and Mermista held her back. She wasn’t…mad. You didn’t choose who you loved. But…yeah. “Feel better, Mista.”

“Get some sleep, Savior.”

Frosta held her very tightly, and neither acknowledged it. Bow, too, but that was normal for him. He was a very emotive man. Perfuma was last, and she smoothed Mermista’s hair away from her face. “You’re gonna be fine. It’s very routine.”

“How’s Scorpia, really?”

“Struggling,” Perfuma sighed. “But I think we all will be for a while. I’ll be in her room, but call me, please. For anything. Even just some tea.”

“Yeah, got it.”

They hugged again, and then it was just her and her husband. The healers came over, and began running lines into her arm. Most places used needles, but this was more direct, and it wasn’t like she was intolerant of magic. Sea Hawk held her hand, even when someone tried to remove him.

“I’m sorry, sir, but with the Confluence only binding in Salineas-”

“And what about my word?” Mermista asked dryly. The healer blinked.

“Uh, well, Mystacor- it’s not-”

“For gods’ sakes, Ferdie,” the other healer sighed. “Just let the man stay. What’s he gonna do? Light the room ablaze?”

Mermista and Sea Hawk locked eyes, and promptly dissolved into only slightly-hysterical giggles. Some things would never change.

The healer pushed a sleep tonic through the lines, and Mermista felt herself starting to fall under very quickly. Sea Hawk kissed her knuckles, whispered his love, and then all was darkness.

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Sea Hawk was bone tired, but he couldn’t sleep. There was too much to do, too much to think about. A Confluence may keep him out of his wife’s healing chambers half the time, but it certainly didn’t keep him out of meetings. Maevik, Dhang, and he had set up a makeshift base of operations in an unused classroom in the school portion of the magical keep. From there, they’d been on calls with all sorts of generals, community leaders, governors, mayors, representatives. Eliza was standing guard outside the room, and while at first Sea Hawk had chuckled, he’d now watched her effectively scare off or keep away about eight different interruptions. The girl certainly had a future as a guard.

“You’re both going to need advisors sooner than later,” Maevik groaned after the umpteenth call with Governor Kelmis. “This is too much for one man to cope with, my Liege.”

“I agree wholeheartedly,” Sea Hawk shut his eyes, resting against the desk. “What’s next?”

A knock interrupted them, and Eliza’s head poked around. “There’s a healer dude here.”

Maevik’s eye twitched at her vernacular, while Dhang smothered a snort. Sea Hawk waved her in, and the healer followed. “Queen Mermista is awake, and asking for her husband.”

“Am I allowed in this time?”

“Erm, yes,” the healer coughed. “Head Sorceress Castaspella has instructed us to no longer bar you. Apologies for the red tape.”

Sea Hawk was already on his feet, waving the man off. “At ease, my good man. I’m required elsewhere.”

He strode through the halls with purpose, no one daring to stop him until he reached the room the healer had directed him to. It was for longer term staying, more like a hotel or guest room than a hospital. There was a balcony overlooking the Cloudy Sea, curtains blowing breezily. The bed was larger, not as large as their bed at home, but big enough for two. Mermista was resting when he entered, but opened her eyes when the bed dipped with his weight as he sat to remove his boots. He turned to her once they were off, and laid down when she encouraged him to.

They said nothing for a while, just staring at one another in the dark silence of the room. She didn’t have anymore lines connected to her veins, just a brace around her lumbar that he ran careful fingers over. He was realizing he was still in shock as he traced her body with his calloused fingertips- he didn’t fully believe she was here.

Mermista was doing the same, her hands ghosting his body. Down his arms, squeezing his muscles and tendons none too gently, and then up his torso, his chest, until she reached her jaw. She scratched it with her torn up nails, and he leaned into the touch he’d been craving for months. He didn’t realize he was crying until she wiped his tears away, and stroked his mustache softly. He kissed her fingertips reverently.

She broke slowly, first with tears dripping out of her blinking eyes, and then with small sniffles, until she was sobbing in earnest. He gathered her close, and not even the pain that lanced through him when she clutched at his back could make him let her go. “Mermista…”

“I thought I was going to die,” she cried into his chest. “You know, when we first woke up, and I saw you holding me and everything was beautiful,” she pulled her face back, and he stroked her hair as her eyes searched his. “I thought we were both dead, and that was that. I didn’t even realize we weren’t until we stood up. I- I thought-”

“Shhh,” he pulled her back in, his own tears falling into her hair. “We’re alive. We’re fine.”

“We are, like, definitely *not* fine, Sea Hawk.”

He chuckled. “Quite fair. But we can work on it together.”

“I hurt so many people,” she wept, and his amusement died a swift, painful death. “He made me do it, but it was my magic. They begged me to stop, and he wouldn’t let me.”

“It wasn’t you, my love. Everyone knows it, hell, most of the planet was chipped just the same.”

But Mermista couldn’t hear him. She was working through the last few months out loud, on autopilot. “At the Grotto, I tried to fight them, but they- they grabbed me- not everyone there could breathe underwater, Sebastian, and-and no one would ever be looking for them. And then it’s a blur, but there’s screaming, there’s so much screaming,” she clamped her hands over her ears, clawing at her hair. “A-and then, on the ship, it hurt, it hurt so bad-”

He saw her start to hyperventilate and cough before she realized it herself, and he was vaulting out of the bed to snatch up the wastebin by the foot of it in seconds. She leaned over the bed, heaving into the bin he held with one hand while he held her hair back with the other. What came up was the shake from earlier, certainly, and also neon green liquid that made Sea Hawk’s own stomach turn. Mermista coughed, sobbing for air, and he knew she was done. He made short work of tying off the bag, throwing it down the trash chute in the wall, and grabbing her a glass of water before helping her up and into the ensuite so she could rinse her mouth out.

He sat on the lid of the toilet, watching her. She was already moving better physically, but it was like there was a weight dragging her down. “Do you want to talk about the ship? Spinnerella…she told us some of it. But her memories weren’t all there.”

Mermista slumped to the ground, closing her eyes and leaning her head back against the cool tiled wall. “He experimented on us. He took my scales, my teeth, my hair, skin, whatever. I don’t know what he did with it, but I think he wanted to clone us.”

He balked. “C-Clone you?!”

“Mhm,” her eyes were faraway, dull. “Didn’t pan out, obviously, but I remember being terrified.”

“I certainly would be,” he muttered, shivering. Mermista smiled a bit.

“Hey, let me see your back,” she changed subjects abruptly, and he blinked. His brain was lagging incredibly behind, but he yanked his shirt up once he registered what she said. She stood with his help, and he turned to let her see the harsh scar across his back. It wasn’t terribly wide, about halfway down his back. It looked like he’d been gouged with fire, which, well, he sort of had been. It was a deep scar with singed edges and burned skin. The healers had said it wouldn’t look nearly as bad once he was fully recovered, but Sea Hawk was skeptical. Mermista’s fingers on it prickled, and his muscles twitched.

“It’s not too bad,” she whispered. “But it’s not great. Can I kiss it?”

He nodded, and closed his eyes as her lips pressed against the swath. His chest rattled as he inhaled, and he blinked away tears. How he had any left was anyone’s guess. They went back to bed quietly, laying down to face one another again. He reached out to stroke her arm. “Can I see your back?”

She bit her lip, but nodded, slipping off the loose shirt the healers had given her. Sea Hawk frowned at the state of her body- she had lost a considerable amount of weight, and he wasn't used to her diminished curves. She looked away, self conscious, but he pressed his lips first to hers, and then to her collarbone, her breasts, her stomach and waist- not to arouse, but to assure. To show her he loved her, and her body, no matter what shape.

He rolled her over gently, and traced the bruising down her back. It was a watercolor canvas of yellows, purples, and blues, and like she had, he asked permission before brushing his lips over every inch. She settled in his arms after, both beyond caring about any healers who might come in. Her skin-always cooler than his- was a balm against his as they laid chest to chest, breathing in sync as their hearts tapped out a rhythm that seemed to chant *'we're alive, we're here, I've got you'*.

"How long are you here for?"

"Two weeks," she murmured. "Maybe less if physical therapy goes well. But after that, I should be, like, totally healed and cleared for physical labor."

"And then what?"

She smiled against his chest, a small, tentatively hopeful little thing.

"And then we rebuild."

—----------

Mermista was out of Mystacor in two weeks, just as promised, with limited physical therapy to bring home and a vastly increased range of mobility. She couldn't lift more than fifty pounds for the first month of her recovery, but she didn't think she'd need to with Sea Hawk and Maevik hovering like they were.

She couldn't help but feel like she was leaving too many ends loose as she left though; Adora had never come to talk to her, called away for She-Ra business, Scorpia was still healing, and she hadn't seen another Princess in the two days leading up to her discharge. Glimmer had sent along a missive with the date and time of the first post-war Alliance meeting, though, so Mermista was certain things wouldn't be left open for long. For now, her primary focus had to be truly assessing the damage to Salineas, and creating a plan to rebuild.

Mermista's heart was in her throat as Sea Hawk sailed the Dragon's Daughter V, somehow miraculously still intact, into Salinean waters. As they approached the gate, her breath hitched, and Maevik's hand found her shoulder while Eliza's slipped into hers. The young girl had little care for decorum or status, and Mermista found it refreshing.

Debris and worse littered the water in varying states of decay. It had been a year and a half, maybe a bit more, since her kingdom fell. Above their heads, tied to rock pillars, the tridents and crowns of the Sea Gate's Guardians, and the spires of towers beyond that, Horde banners and flags waved jauntily. With a wave of her hand, Mermista sent tendrils of water out of the sea to grab the offending fabric and tear it down. She tossed her cargo onto the deck of the ship, far from them.

"I'll have Sea Hawk burn them later."

"I think we'll be burning more than that," Maevik sighed, eyeing the water. "Funeral pyres and ships will need to be arranged as soon as we're able."

"We feed and shelter the living first," she affirmed, eyes fixated on the torn, hole-ridden magic of the gate. "We can't help the dead anymore, and they wouldn't want us to put them first."

Maevik nodded, eyes heavy. Eliza tried to crane her neck over the side of the ship, and Mermista laid a hand on her head. When the girl looked up at her, she shook her head, a warning and an apology.

"You don't want to see, Eliza. Believe me."

"I-is my mom…?"

"I'll find her for you, if I can. If you'd like me to."

Eliza gnawed her lip. “I’ll think about it.”

They were approaching the gate. She raised one hand out, shaking though it was, and coaxed the veil to lift. It did, slowly, inch by inch, and she felt it groaning in protest deep in her own self.

‘I know, girl, ’ she murmured to it, trying to soothe the tetchy magic her ancestors had weaved. *‘ I’m in the same shape. Let’s just get through this, alright?’*

The veil lifted, and they sailed through. The wreckage was less here, and there were even a few Horde ships beached, or run aground. They didn’t know the treacherous, moody waters of Salineas, or understand how to navigate the natural defenses of her island chain. The very land of her people had fought back, and Mermista felt her chest swell with pride.

“What’s the refugee situation?” she asked Maevik.

“Much the same as Lua Pele, just in the capitol. We have tents and makeshift shelters set up, and we’re using what little buildings were left intact, or have at least proven structurally sound.”

Sea Hawk had the ship docked in minutes, the only standing boat in the entire, destroyed harbor. He descended the steps, tossing the mooring lines down and following them over. Once secured, Eliza threw down the gangplank, and for the first time in over a year, Mermista set foot in Salineas.

Sea Hawk's hand found her shoulder, squeezing tightly. Her own came up to cover his, and she took a deep, centering breath, thinking of Perfuma. Every building and structure in sight was crumbled, little more than rubble. The harbor's office building, as old as Salineas itself, practically, was gone, and she felt Sea Hawk's shaky inhale. The headwalls were piles of rock, as were most of the piers and docks, and the rough surf lapped at the land, reaching into the marketplace. The stalls were disintegrated, their goods strewn about and crushed, like they'd been trampled. More Horde flags abounded, and she tore them down viciously with her magic.

Beyond it all, the castle stood tall and proud still. She turned to Maevik. "The castle?"

"Castle Salineas remains almost completely intact," he smiled wanly. "Swami Dhang thinks the Pearl threw up barriers as far as it could during the siege, protecting itself while we sealed the doors. As I told you at your Confluence, it has certainly been looted up to the second floor, but it is relatively structurally sound."

"Relatively?" She quirked a brow.

“The windows have been blown in, so there’s a good bit of glass strewn about the halls. Most of the doors have been broken or torn off their hinges, which will be…trying to fix,” Maevik grimaced, massaging the bridge of his nose. “Those doors are *very* heavy, and *very* old.”

Mermista nodded. “Alright. I want a few people tackling the public halls of the castle as soon as possible, so we can get the sick, elderly, and young indoors and in beds and rooms if we can.”

Maevik’s eyebrows shot up. “In the castle?”

“Yes, in the castle,” she rolled her eyes. “The castle belongs to the people, whom we also happen to work for. Put them in my room if you have to, just shelter them.”

Maevik nodded at once, as did Eliza. “Yes, Your Majesty.”

They jogged off, and Mermista turned toward the castle. Sea Hawk’s hand nudged her, and after a moment, she took it.

“What’s the plan dearest?”

She laughed, dry and humorless. “Gods, Sebastian, if I only knew. Top of the list, check on the Pearl. Then…the Gate should be next, but I doubt I’ll be able to repair it without Adora, so we’ll see.

Realistically, I call in as many representatives and advisors as I can reach, and we come up with a plan for reconstruction."

Sea Hawk whistled. "How long do you think it'll take?"

Mermista stopped, looking around at the carnage. She knew she was in shock, the panic and grief in her so strong she couldn't possibly react beyond freezing. "Years. Five, if we're lucky with weather and finances. In totality, probably closer to ten."

"Well," he wrapped an arm around her shoulder. "Let's get started, then."

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The castle was almost entirely in working order, by some miracle. The roofs of the uppermost spires- astronomy towers that would finally have use again other than theoretical sorcery, rooftop gardens, specialized training arenas, and storage- were in the worst repair, and had been sealed off for safety. The lower levels were indeed covered in glass, and stank of rotting, dead fish from the aquatic walls that had burst when the Pearl went on the defense mid-siege. Mermista bubbled and cleaned the fish and other oceanic carcasses as they walked, and by the time they reached the throne room, the smell had faded from instant-gag to merely toe-curling.

Sea Hawk brushed aside glass and rock and coral with his shoes, walking a bit ahead of her, but gave up at the throne room. It was just as it had been during their Confluence- windows shattered, wall fountains broken and spitting water in every direction, the two-headed eel carpet in muddy tatters. That made her heart ache- that carpet had been her mother's favorite, and she remembered running up and down it as a toddler, giggling wildly.

"We'll see if it can be mended," Sea Hawk murmured, wrapping an arm around her waist. She just shrugged, listless and numb.

The throne itself, the seat, was cracked through and chipped, but the living coral behind it was unharmed. The Pearl shone on above it, at peace for the moment.

"Let's move on. The only things that need attention here are the carpet and the walls, which I don't think we're going to be repairing tonight."

Sea Hawk nodded, and followed her out. They wandered the halls, completely alone for the first time in…well, a good long while. Over a year, certainly. Mermista sighed at the empty walls and shattered pottery and glass and rock along the ground. Her favorite mosaic, of a mermaid swimming with a gray whale, was missing pieces and cracked. The pottery from the Fifth Age, pieces of her people's history, was either gone or destroyed. Her great-great-grandmother's watercolor paintings were missing, too, as was the art commissioned by some of the greatest artists in Salineas' history.

The courtyards were utterly ravaged, both the public front areas and the private gardens and paths in the back that wound down toward the private beaches, and her hidden grotto. Her mother's white hibiscus plants were almost entirely destroyed, trampled and torn. She knelt by them, Sea Hawk at her side, and caressed the crushed petals of one of the fallen flowers.

Tears welled in her eyes, and she bit down on a sob. "All I had left of her… it's all gone."

"Not all of it, dearest," Sea Hawk wrapped her in his arms, and she turned into his collar, letting the tears fall onto his shirt. "Maevik said your rooms were untouched-"

"All that the kingdom had left of her is gone!" She wept. "Her flowers, her favorite art, her touches… they'll forget her now. She'll be lost."

"Mermista," he gripped her shoulders gently. "For as long as you live, Nerida will never be forgotten. Her influence, and her love for Salineas, live on in you, and guide all you do. You'll tell her story, and make sure her sacrifice is remembered for ages to come. And nothing- no one- can ever take that from you. Or your people."

She leaned into him heavily, eyes shutting. "I'm so tired, Sebastian. I'm tired of everything being hard."

“I know, my love,” his lips brushed her forehead. “And I’m sorry I can’t make it easier for you.”

“Not your fault.” Mermista sat back up, brushing her eyes and getting to her feet. She turned and offered him a hand. “No one can. Except me, I guess.”

“Onward?”

“Nowhere else to go.”

The entrance to the private wing of the castle was hidden behind an endless waterfall, enchanted to not stop flowing for anyone but Mermista when the castle was in lockdown. With shaky hands, she parted the stream, and the door revealed itself. They took their time up the stairs, both of them still sore from surgery and battle.

Mermista couldn’t help but snort when they paused again to catch their breath, halfway up the second set of steps. “We look sooooo old right now.”

“I am old,” he chuckled. “Twenty six, can you believe it? They might as well put me out to pasture.”

“Guess that means I turned twenty five at some point,” Mermista smiled softly. “Feels weird, missing so much time.”

“We can catch each other up,” he yawned. “Once we’re settled.”

“C’mon, grandpa,” she teased, offering her hand. “We’re almost there.”

Save for a fine layer of dust, their rooms were the same as they’d been when they left. Mermista walked the halls like a ghost, trailing her fingers over marble, coral, stone, abalone, and wood surfaces. She reread the spines of the same books that had sat on these shelves since her father left, glanced over the same pictures in the same frames. Sea Hawk was opening windows and balcony doors, letting in fresh air and light. The cove and shore that these windows faced were protected by sandbars, and no Horde ships had been able to sail this way, which left the windows and balconies and terraces intact.

Mermista wandered into her kitchen, far more unused than she preferred. Though now, she was sure they’d be getting plenty of mileage out of it. Her cooks were deployed to the community centers to help feed the masses; royal or not, she was just one woman, and she could feed herself just fine.

Tonight, though, she had no intention of cooking. A quick rummage through the cabinets produced not much, they’d been running low on snacks when Salineas fell, but she did find a pack of dried, flavored seaweed snacks- her personal favorites. She hoisted herself onto the counter carefully, mindful of her spine, and went to open the snacks but found she…couldn’t. She just stared at them, in her hands, an innocuous pack of her once-beloved treats now mocking her, taunting her, chastising her.

"Dearest?"

Mermista lifted her head, sluggish, and saw Sea Hawk leaning against the arched frame of the kitchen entrance. "Huh?"

"You alright?"

"Uh…yeah. I guess. Fine as can be."

He nodded, pushing off the wall to stand in front of her. "You should eat those."

"Not hungry."

In betrayal, her stomach growled, and she huffed. Sea Hawk just wrapped her hands in his larger ones. "Dearest…"

"I don't feel like I should eat," she blurted. "It doesn't feel right, o-or like something I deserve. Not something this enjoyable, anyway."

Sea Hawk swallowed audibly, looking at her with naked concern. "Mermista, everyone deserves to eat."

“I’ll just eat a protein bar-”

“Mermista,” he rooted her to the spot with his Serious Voice. “You haven’t had a real meal, or any enjoyable food, in over a year. Please, eat what you want.”

She shook her head. “I can’t, Sebastian. Not while everyone out there has to eat provisions- I shouldn’t even be *here* , in the castle-”

“Darling,” he held her in place but was careful not to cage her in. “This is your home. You’ve already given orders to open the castle to all who need it as soon as humanly possible. The community centers still standing are taking people in as we speak, and we start rebuilding the rest *tomorrow* . Please, eat something enjoyable, take a shower, and sleep in your bed.”

Her bed. Not theirs. She swallowed, tears springing to her eyes. She ducked her head so he couldn’t see. “W-where, uh, will you sleep?”

He froze, too. “I, um, had assumed…with you. But I- I don’t want to crowd you, you’re right- it’s too soon after-”

His hands started to leave her, and she shot out and grabbed his sleeve in a vice grip. “ *No!* Please…I didn’t mean- I thought you-when you said *my* bed, I- I thought…”

“Oh, dearest, no,” Sea Hawk sighed, and she lifted her chin a bit. “It was a slip of the tongue, that’s all. I swear.”

She nodded, relieved. “Can we go? To bed? I don’t feel like eating.”

“Well,” he sighed. “I do. So can I have those if you won’t eat them?”

Mermista quirked an eyebrow. “You hate these.”

“I’m willing to give all your weird food a second chance,” he chuckled, plucking the package out of her hands. “If it doesn’t taste like protein slaw, hardtack, or herbal tea, it’s my new favorite food.”

She snorted, and wrapped her legs around his waist to draw him closer as he shoved a sheet of dried seaweed in his mouth. He grimaced, then paused, considering the taste. He smacked his lips, stared at the package, and shrugged. “I like it more than tree bark.”

Mermista laughed, small but genuine. “It’s a start.”

He ate a few more slices with growing enjoyment, Mermista watching on in vague jealousy. Eventually, it became too much, and she reached out tentatively. Sea Hawk didn't react other than tilting the container closer, knowing not to make a big deal out of it. He'd gotten really good at reading her cues, she pondered as she took a tiny bite of the seaweed. Flavor burst over her tongue, and she took a larger bite. The first piece vanished, and she reached for another. And then another.

They stood there in silence, in their kitchen, sharing the container of seaweed snacks until it was empty. Sea Hawk went to grab them glasses of water, but paused when the tap ran a murky tan. "Hm. Could be problematic."

Mermista groaned, sliding down to her feet. "The lines to the town are fine, we must have a damaged pipe in the castle somewhere. I'll discuss it with Maevik and the engineers tomorrow. We're the only ones in here tonight. For now…"

With a push and a pull, frowning in concentration, she separated the water from the sediment and taint, filling their glasses with fresh water and leaving the rest in the sink.

Sea Hawk grinned at her. "I'll never get tired of your magic."

"Not even after it almost killed you?" Mermista averted her eyes. Try as she might, she couldn't stop replaying their final confrontation, the hits he'd taken, the concussion she'd given him, the bones she'd nearly shattered. She didn't realize her hands were shaking until Sea Hawk took her glass, placed it on the counter, and then wrapped her hands in his.

“Not even then,” he murmured. “Look at me, love. I’m fine! I’m more than fine. I have you back and that’s all that matters.”

“For now,” she muttered. “Until the nightmares start, and the flashbacks, and you wake up next to me and don’t remember…”

“We’ll burn those bridges when we get to them.”

“...don’t you mean cross?”

“Pah! Details,” he grinned at her, and she couldn’t help smiling back. “Now, c’mon. We need to sleep.”

Mermista let him lead her upstairs to their master suite, as dusty and untouched as ever. On the floor was her shredded suit from the night of the grotto, and she froze.

Hands on her shoulders, tentacles, a prick on her neck- *green* , nothing but *green.* Scorpia, saving her from drowning, then nothing… then *here* . Prime undressing her- nausea, hot and angry and dizzying-

Mermista sprinted for the bathroom, just making it to the toilet in time. The green in the bowl wasn't just from the seaweed snacks, the glowing green remnants of the amniotic pods that Prime had forced into her body- not all that digestible evidently- mocking her. She doubled over again, and a hand grabbed her hair away from her body. The proximity of touch so near her neck was terrifying, and by the time she had nothing left in her body, she was shaking from exhaustion and anxiety.

Sea Hawk peered into the bowl, grimacing at the amniotic leftovers before he flushed the toilet. "Well, at least that's in working order. Mermista, can I…?"

She didn't know what he was asking, but the answer was no. She shook her head and curled up, knees to her chest, hands clasped over her hair. She wasn't fine, nothing was fine, her home was destroyed, *she* was in ruin herself, everything was hopeless and stupid and she'd never be happy again-

Humming reached her, a low tenor that dipped into a baritone here and there, soothing and familiar. It morphed into singing after a while, and Mermista followed the words, clinging to them like a lifeline.

"I'll swim and sail on savage seas

With ne'er a fear of drowning

And gladly ride the waves of life

If you will marry me…"

Mermista lifted her head, tears trailing down her cheeks. Sea Hawk was sitting against the far wall, turning something over in his hand. It sparkled and shone, catching the lowlight of the bathroom. He was lost in thought, in song, the familiar tune tugging harshly at Mermista's memories.

"No scorching sun, nor freezing cold

Will stop me on my journey

If you will promise me your heart…

And love-"

His voice broke, and faded into silence. Mermista watched a tear slide down his cheek. With a sigh, he got to his feet, and wandered back into the bedroom. She heard the balcony doors open, and his steps recede. She sat there a while, racking her mushed-up brain, trying desperately to remember why that song was so familiar-

It was the night they'd reunited after eight self-imposed months apart. His ring on her finger. They hadn't been able to sleep, too giddy (Sea Hawk) and keyed up (Mermista) to just lay around and wait for sleep. They were walking her private beach in their nightclothes, sleep pants for Sea Hawk, his scars and ink on display for all (her) to see, while the ocean spray kissed her skin, bare in her ratty old tank top and shorts. They'd looked the furthest thing from royalty and royalty-to-be at that moment, and it was perfect.

"I could compose a love song right now!" Sea Hawk had laughed, twirling her around in his endless exuberance. "The greatest love song of all time! Of passion, endless devotion, undying love!"

"Careful," she'd teased. "You're using up all your vocabulary before you even start- HEY! Put me down!"

He did, after kissing her breathless. Then, he cleared his throat, pulled her closer, and started whistling. It was a beautiful, haunting thing, forlorn but hopeful, tried and true… Mermista had been utterly transfixed, despite her usual eyerollings and sighs. And when he'd made it through the first verse, something had overtaken her, and she'd joined in.

Sea Hawk had called it the 'spirit of shanty'. She had called it love, privately.

Mermista staggered to her feet, and shook her head gently. She pulled water from the tap to rinse her mouth, splash her face, and wake herself out of the green-reverie gnawing at her peripheral. It faded, and she followed Sea Hawk out to the balcony. He was leaning on the banister, and the sea breeze ruffled his hair gently, just like she loved to.

Against her every instinct of self-preservation, Mermista took a deep breath, opened her mouth, and met him halfway.

"-and love me for eternity"

Sea Hawk spun around, startled, but hope quickly replaced the shock in his eyes. He seemed to hold his breath, not even daring to breathe if it would scare her off.

It wouldn’t, she knew. Now, she just had to show him that.

“My dearest one, my darling dear

Your mighty words astound me… ”

He smiled, elated, and more tears sprung to his eyes. Mermista took a further step onto the balcony, the lines she’d composed alongside him flooding her mind, drowning out the demons.

“But I’ve no need for mighty deeds

When I feel your arms around me-”

Sea Hawk laughed, loud and bright, and reached out for her. She reached back, and let him pull her across the terrace and into his arms where they had room to sway. He took over again, teasing and boastful, looking handfuls of years younger for it.

“But I would bring you rings of gold!

I’d even sing you poetry-”

“Is that what we’re calling this?” She rolled her eyes and he laughed, scooping her off her feet and placing her on the railing of the balcony. His warm hands on her hips steadied her as he sang on.

“And I would keep you from all harm,

If you would stay beside me!”

Mermista carded her hands through his thick hair, pushing it this way and that, before she leaned her head against his, gazing lovingly into his eyes. She pushed all she was feeling, everything she could never say, along their Bond, and watched more tears flood his eyes. She picked up the next part, barely more than a whisper.

“I have no use for rings of gold,

I care not for your… ‘poetry”

They both laughed, and he grabbed one of her palms to kiss it.

“I only want your hand to hold-”

He swooped in, emotion clogging his throat as he stared up at her like she had hung the stars in the sky.

"I only want you near me- "

The gravity of that one little line, their months apart, the grief that had plagued him in his solitude, wasn't lost on her, and she slid off the railing, into his arms, to hold him close. He held her tightly, and she wrapped her legs tighter around his middle as he lifted her clear off the stone to sway with her in his arms. He put her down eventually, but kept her close, still swaying but this time with a bit more rhythm. They finished together, in harmony as always.

"To love and kiss, to sweetly hold,

For the dancing and the dreaming,

Through all life's sorrows and delights,

I'll keep your love beside me"

Their foreheads came together again, and his lilting falsetto flew high over her low alto, unexpected but perfect together. As always.

"I'll swim and sail on savage seas

With ne'er a fear of drowning

And gladly ride the waves of life

If you will marry me…"

She gazed up into his eyes, and he took her hand, sliding onto her finger the object he'd been staring at before. Her wedding rings.

"If you will marry me… "

He leaned down, one finger under her chin, and hesitated, giving her a chance to pull away if she wasn't ready. But ready or not, she needed this, and gently grabbed the back of his head, tilting his lips down to meet hers. It was like the first time and the last time all over again. Every good morning kiss, every good night kiss, every time their lips found one another's when they made love. Their wedding kiss, their reunion kiss. All of it, all of them, right here.

Mermista was crying when they pulled back. "I love you."

"I love you, too," Sea Hawk hadn't stopped crying for a while, but that was par for the course with him. "I'll love you all my days, and every day after that."

She had no reply, not verbally, so she tugged him down for another kiss, letting her lips and their Bond say everything she struggled to. Sea Hawk heard her loud and clear.

He always did.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you!! Next time, we meet back up with a few beloved friends. Would love to hear everyone's thoughts and feelings!

begin again

Chapter Summary

> Aid comes for the Sea Gate, the first Alliance meeting post-war establishes where to go from here, and growing continues to be joyous misery

Chapter Notes

> setting up the foundation for the sequel and the topics I'd like to tackle! this chapter was fun, ngl, i got to play with characters i normally don't
>
> Enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Magical aid arrived a week after they did. Just as Mermista had thought, she could only bring the Sea Gate so far alone; it was First Ones' Tech after all, so it made sense that Entrapta and Adora were first on the scene. What made less sense were the two people who arrived with them.

She was knee-deep in clearing non-salvageable rubble off the foundation of what had once been a school when gasps and shouts and cries went up from the surrounding area. Mermista's head shot up, more sensitive than ever to her people's distress. An engineer and a foreman swept in, taking over her corner of the massive rock chunk while she clambered out of the muddy hole. She blinked when a hand entered her vision, palm up.

“Hey, Merms,” she stared up into sky blue eyes, wide and energetic as ever. Adora. “Need a hand?”

She smiled, only somewhat hollow, and let Adora haul her out of the pit. “You’re here to fix…the…Gate…?”

Her attention was immediately seized by the site of Catra, sitting atop Melog, and Hordak, no longer in his white robes but rather the deep purples and indigos of Dryl. His exoskeleton was on, and it looked decidedly not peaceful. Next to him, Entrapta waved with her hair. “Hello, Mermista!”

“Hi,” she greeted shortly, rounding on Adora. “Are you insane?”

“W-what?” The blonde blinked, looking wounded. “I thought you needed help, and no one knows more about Tech than Entrapta-”

“Entrapta isn’t the issue-”

“Your Majesty!” Maevik tore through the crowd, Sea Hawk at his side. “Hostile forces have been- oh.”

“Yes, oh,” she sighed. There was a crowd gathering, shifting uneasily and muttering. “Maevik, take Entrapta and…the other two…to the Sea Gate. Adora and I will meet you there,” her guard nodded while Entrapta squealed. “Hey, Geek Princess.”

“Hey, Rude Princess!”

A gasp rippled through the crowd, but Mermista just smirked. She was glad Entrapta and she were finally starting to oscillate the same wavelength. “You can look, and analyze, but do *not* touch my gate without me there, please.”

“You got it!” Entrapta fired off a vague salute and yanked her mask down. She turned to follow Maevik, Hordak falling in step, but Catra didn’t move.

“I’m not leaving Adora,” she frowned.

Mermista just looked at Adora. “She either goes now, or I have you all thrown out of here, and you can return alone at your earliest convenience.”

“Mista, please,” Adora stepped closer. “Why?”

“Look around,” she hissed. Adora did, glancing at the gathering crowd. “My people are scared of her, or they hate her, and I can’t control what everyone does. It’s for her safety as much as theirs. Maevik will keep her safe, I swear it, but if she stays at your side…”

Adora sighed. “Okay. I get it. Hang on.”

She went to Catra while Sea Hawk sidled up to her. “So, we have company, I see!”

“Mhmmmm,” Mermista pressed her lips together. “This has sooooo much messy potential.”

“Want me nearby?”

She snorted, but patted his chest softly. PDA was getting easier, if only because she needed to remind herself that he was there, alive, with her, pretty much constantly. “I mean no strong offense, but you feed off of other’s anxiety so destructively that I think you’ll either light yourself or the Gate on fire.”

“Very fair!” He nodded, brushing his hand down her arm. “I shall continue clearing the harbor debris,” She spared him a smile and started to walk away, when he seized her elbow. “Oh, and dearest?”

“Yeah?”

“Don’t think I didn’t see you trying to lift that section of rubble alone.”

She scowled, and blushed, sheepish but unwilling to show it. “Yeah, yeah, I know. My bad.”

“Just,” his eyes softened. “Take care of yourself. If not for you, then for me.”

Mermista sighed, nodding. “I’m…trying. I promise.”

“Alright, love,” he smiled. “I’m off, call if you need me.”

He tapped the side of his head, the Bond flickering as he did, and they parted ways. Adora was waiting for her, Melog at her side, while Catra stalked after Maevik and the other two, tail lashing. Mermista frowned heavily as people leapt clear of her with yelps and gasps of fear.

“So she’s got an anger issue, huh?”

Adora sighed. “We’re working on it. We’re…working on a lot of things.”

Mermista just hummed, and they began walking slowly. Adora was fidgeting next to her, but every time the woman tried to speak, they were interrupted by someone or another asking Mermista for advice, or wanting to thank She-Ra. It wasn’t until they reached the sand that Adora could finally turn to her.

“Mermista, are we friends?”

She blinked. “Uh, I had…assumed so?”

“Okay, good,” Adora sighed. “I just…of course we were allies, and sisters-in-arms, but that doesn’t always… I’m new to this stuff. The not-war stuff.”

“Girl, I think we all are,” she sighed. “But, yes, Adora. We’re friends. If I didn’t have a kingdom to rebuild, I’d invite you for brunch.”

Adora smiled. “Thanks! I’m, uh, super relieved to hear that. And glad!”

“Same here, sword lady.”

“So, uh…Catra.”

“Yes,” Mermista’s mood soured instantly. “Catra. Adora,” she sighed. “I’m not… *trying* to judge you. Your business is your own, and even though I am, like, morbidly, freakishly curious, I’m not going to force an answer out of you. But…why? Why her? From where I’m standing, it makes literally no sense.”

“I know,” Adora grimaced. “I know it doesn’t. But will you hear me out?”

Her eyes were so wide and pleading, Mermista’s heart couldn’t totally ice her out. She groaned. “Of course, I will.”

“Catra is…she’s my…it’s so hard to explain. When we were little, we were all we had. Growing up in the Horde is lonely, and looking back, *terrifying* . Catra kept me safe, and I…tried to keep her safe. I failed. A lot. And so did she, sometimes. She’d miss training on purpose, and let me get my ass beat. I’d run from Shadow Weaver, or clam up, even when it meant it was worse for Catra. We weren’t perfect, but we knew we’d always be there. The bond…I can’t even explain it.”

Mermista’s own Bond sat heavily in her mind. “I…understand.”

“When I left, I…destroyed her. No, I didn’t make her the way she was. But, I could have tried harder, I guess? I abandoned her.”

“Hold up,” Mermista stopped walking. “Didn’t you ask her, like, at least twice before the Battle of Bright Moon to come with you and help? And didn’t she admit to understanding that the Horde wasn’t, like, right? That’s what Glimmer said.”

Adora scowled. “That’s not- it’s not quite like that! It’s… complicated.”

Mermista shrugged, hands up. “Like I said, not really judging. Just curious.”

“Anyway,” she continued, kicking up some sand with her boots. “Throughout the whole war, it was like we were fighting each other. Yes, I was fighting the Horde, and her the Princesses, but it never quite felt like that.”

“Noticed that, trust me,” Mermista smirked.

Adora blushed. “Right. So, when Prime took her, I just…I remembered being a kid. And making that promise with her. That no matter what, I would always keep her safe. She was the one who got Glimmer out, who saved her. And when I went back, she was-”

Flashes of green, green, angry, furious *green* . A voice like shadows and nightmares dripping down her spine. *Little Sister* .

“-ista!” Adora’s hands were on her shoulder. “Mermista! Are you okay? Let me get Sea Hawk-”

“No!” She gasped, clamping a hand down on Adora’s arm. When had she fallen to her knees? “He’ll just panic, and there’s nothing he can do, anyway."

Adora sighed, but nodded. "Are they…often?"

"Lessening," she bit out, getting to her feet. "But yeah. More often than not. I never know when they're gonna hit, which is the worst part."

"Catra's in the same boat."

Mermista scowled, unwilling to feel sympathy for the war-monger who destroyed her home. "Yeah, well. Happens, I guess."

Adora sighed. "Yeah…"

"So she was chipped on Prime's ship?" Mermista prompted.

"Yes, and…he killed her," Adora's hands tightened into fists. "He threw her off of his dais, and she- she didn't get up. I brought her back once we got onboard Darla. And even though we had, uh, a few bumps, she's been at my side since."

"Except for when she abandoned you before the final stand," Mermista muttered. Adora shut her eyes. "It's just…Adora she has been trying to *kill you* since you left the Horde. How can you just move past that?”

“Because I love her, and I always have. Without her I don’t feel right. I don’t feel like Adora. She reminds me that I’m more than She-Ra,” the savior of Etheria shook her head. “And I’m not past it but I’m trying, for her.”

“And is she doing the same?”

“O-of course she is!” Adora whirled on her. “You don’t know her, Mermista!”

“You’re right, I don’t,” she shrugged, even as her voice turned acerbic. “All I know is that all of this,” she waved a hand, indicating the destroyed Gate, the ocean debris, and the leveled capital of her home. “Is because of her. So, forgive my hesitance to trust the woman and the alien overlord who destroyed my home!”

They were in a stand off, chests heaving with emotion- grief, anger, confusion- and unwilling to back down. Behind Adora, the ocean thrashed.

Shocking them both, Mermista looked away first. “I want you to be happy, Adora. You deserve it literally more than any of us. But…is this your happy ending?”

“It is,” she nodded, firm. “She is. I know you won’t forgive her-”

“I *can’t* ,” she hissed. “My people…”

“I know. But, please, for me, can you just give her the smallest chance to atone for everything that happened? She deserves the chance to move forward too, and help fix what she broke.”

“I will consider it when I hear those words from her mouth,” Mermista sighed. “Not yours.”

Adora sighed, but nodded. “I think the first Alliance meeting will be about, y’know, punishment.”

“My council is advising me to request they both stand trial for the Siege.”

“Does Salineas…?”

“Believe in the death penalty?” Mermista glanced at her. “Yes.”

“Mermista-”

She held up her hand. “But *I* don’t. As angry as I am…” she stared out at the waves, thinking of the bodies below. “There’s been enough death. Killing fixes nothing. Catra has a fantastic analytical, strategic mind. Hordak is the only being we know of who knows the stars, and advanced Tech. Losing either of them would do more damage than good to Etheria’s future. Double Trouble… well, we’ll see about that one.”

“So what will you do?”

“I’m lobbying for community service,” she turned and started walking again. “My advisors would rather see them banished or imprisoned indefinitely, and the people…will probably want the same. But I still have final say as Queen. They’ll most likely get a three month trial run. After that, we review…and it’s less in my hands.”

“But you’re still Queen,” Adora frowned.

“And I serve my people,” she sighed. “If they want Catra imprisoned, by overwhelming majority…”

“I’ll take her and run,” Adora vowed, jaw set. “I won’t-”

“I know you would,” Mermista snorted. “Why do you think I’m warning you now?”

Adora blinked at her, shocked, before her eyes grew soft. “Thank you, Mermista.”

“Yeah, whatever. It’s for you, not Kitty.”

The silence that sat with them as they reached the Sea Gate was still tense, but it wasn’t unfriendly. Mermista lifted them both up on a column of seawater, and they joined the others on a large rock in front of the Sea Gate. Entrapta had a datapad in hand, as well as a larger tech rig set up. Maevik was eyeing it with open disdain, and Mermista smothered a smile. Her head guard was an old-fashioned guy.

“-the readings are faaascinating!” Entrapta was gesturing to Hordak and Catra frantically. “It’s a shield, yes, but it’s also a *weapon* of some sort, with an energy regulating function built in!”

Hordak was nodding along. “But why? What energy does it deflect?”

“Storms,” Mermista cut in, crossing her arms. “It keeps the worst riptides, tsunamis, hurricanes, and cyclones away from the main islands, and makes the water around the chain easy to navigate. Its Salinean name translates to Goddess’ Blessing or Oceana’s Will, depending on dialect.”

Entrapta was jotting down all she said with great speed. “This technology is incredibly complex, especially for its age, and it’s interwoven so seamlessly with the Pearl’s magic and other sorcery that it’s-”

“An organism,” Hordak finished. “Like the runestones, it seems to possess a will of its own.”

She suppressed a shudder at the man’s voice. He couldn’t help what- *who* - he sounded like. “The old legends and fairytales say that each Rune Stone had an extension like this at one point, but that many fell over time, or failed after Mara’s Rebellion. They reflect the will of their Rune Stone, or whatever.”

“Where do the Princesses fit in?” Adora cocked her head. “Do they reflect the Stones’ will, or vice versa.”

“It’s symbiotic, or so I was told,” Mermista shrugged. “Most conduits, avatars, Princesses, whatever, exhibit similar behaviors to their predecessor.”

“So your line has always been grumpy?” Catra was clearly aiming for levity, but Mermista wasn’t feeling magnanimous.

“Wouldn’t know,” she said in a casual air. “Horde sorta, y’know, killed my mom before I had a chance to really know her soooo…”

There wasn't enough time for an awkward silence to settle, as Adora sighed and summoned the Sword immediately. With She-Ra there, everyone felt a bit less inclined to argue; something about the Savior's aura was inherently calming when she wanted it to be. Without further ado, Adora leveled her blade at the Gate, and began repairing it.

It was just as boring as it had been last time.

Mermista sighed silently, mentally running through the checklist of all she had to do by the end of next week, when they'd have to leave for the first Alliance meeting in peace. Get the capital's rubble fully cleared, meet with the contractors and engineers from Dryl and other Salinean islands to go over the plan for the first wave of rebuilds, hammer out the finer details of Catra's proposed community service sentence, and start shoring up for hurricane season. Even with the Gate, they wouldn't be as prepared as normal. Not to mention the next set of funerals, appointing replacements for the elected state officials they'd lost, dodge the vultures and wolves in her court… so fun being Queen.

Entrapta's hair tapped her shoulder and she flinched, hard. "What?" she snapped, far harder than she meant to. The Tech Princess' face wavered, hair reaching for her mask. Mermista collected herself, not wanting to hurt the very shaky foundation she and Entrapta were working on. "My bad. Sorry. I was just… spaced. And some things are still…"

"Hard?" The older woman supplied. "I understand. Though a common diagnosis, PTSD presents in many varied, complex ways. It's logical that you dislike being startled, especially with physical touch, due to the nature of your chipping."

Mermista grimaced, but it wasn't altogether harsh. "Thanks. I think."

"No problem!" Entrapta chirped.

"How has Dryl taken your return?" She probed, feigning interest in her fingernails.

"It's a mixed reception!" Her mask did come down now, despite her cavalier attitude. "But then again, I was never a- what's the phrase? Crowd favorite?"

"Believe me, I get the feeling."

Silent until now, Hordak's ears perked up. "Forgive my intrusion, but your people seem to admire and respect you, Your Majesty."

Mermista swallowed her bile at the sound of his voice. It wasn't him, *it wasn't him* . "Many do. But there are plenty who don't. Plenty in my court wish I was older, wiser, and less, y'know, irreverent. But I'm who they get, so…"

"Do you ever fear…a coup?" Entrapta kept her eyes on her screen, face forward, mask down.

“I used to, like, all the time,” she sighed. “Things settled after I got off my ass and actually started, like, running my kingdom, instead of waiting around for it to run itself. Why? Are there rumors?”

“Attempts had been made before,” the Princess shrugged, jerky. “That’s why I prefer tiny food, and fizzy drinks. Carbonation neutralizes most liquid poisons’ effects, and with tiny, individual servings, nothing would be concentrated enough to kill me! It’s highly efficient, and comforting as well.”

Mermista blinked. “That’s immensely fucked up. You know that, right?”

“I have made my peace with it!” Entrapta sounded like she was smiling. “But now…”

“I’d just do what your people want and need right now,” she sighed. “And go from there.”

“How will I know?”

“I dunno. Hold court, ask advisors, the usual?”

“...those seem like highly inefficient methods.”

“Then figure out something efficient,” she snorted. “No one can make shit work like you do, Trapt. You’re wholly unique, so I’m sure whatever solution you come up with will be, too.”

She lifted her mask, smiling gently. “...Thanks, Mermista. I am glad we’re friends.”

Mermista scowled, but only gently. Today had been waaaaay too touchy-feely for her comfort, and it wasn’t even lunch yet. “Don’t spread it around, Geek Princess.”

Next to her, Hordak stiffened. “What did you call her?”

Before Mermista could open her mouth, Entrapta was up and soothing the alien. “No, no! She doesn’t mean it as an insult- well, not anymore. She used to! But my research has shown Mermista’s brand of affection is similar to Catra’s. Terms of endearment in the form of ‘playful insults’, good-natured jabs known as ‘ribbing’, and plenty of complaining. ‘Geek Princess’ has become her ‘nickname’ for me, as I am, in her eyes, a tech fanatic! Mermista, in comparison, would be a noir literature Geek!”

Mermista blushed, hard. “Alright, that’s enough of that-”

“I’m still workshopping names for her of a similar caliber, one that strikes the middle of biting and observant. Rude Princess is a good placeholder for now, as Mermista is often perceived to be rude- as am I- despite the large amount of data that proves the contrary.”

She scowled. “No, I’m rude. I’m very rude-”

“Current contenders are Fish Legs, Fish Princess, Fish Geek or Geek Fish- there’s a theme here, see?- Detective Scales-”

“Great name for a cat,” Mermista deadpanned.

“-Fishstick, although I think that’s Frosta’s- Tuna Breath, Sea Hawk’s Legal Wife-”

“There it is.”

“And Fork Lady.”

“Keep at it,” Mermista snorted, a smile tugging at her lips. “You’re on the verge of greatness, I feel it.”

Hordak still looked displeased, not that Mermista cared. But she did care that Entrapta knew how she felt, because she was, like, making an effort or whatever.

“Hey, Trapt. You really know I don’t mean it as an insult, right?” she quirked a brow. “I hold your intellect in, like, the highest esteem since it literally saved my scales, and I’m never trying to, like, judge you for having special interests and shit.”

Entrapta blinked, then grinned. “I do know! But it’s still nice to hear it.”

She patted Mermista’s head with her hair, and they shared a smile. Now frantic to have Hordak and Catra’s eyes off of her- that was so much more than she usually felt comfortable saying in front of people, what was Sea Hawk *doing* to her?- she turned to Adora. “How’s it going, Biceps?”

“Good,” Adora grunted. “It’s just going to take me a bit longer this time around.”

“Can you take a break?”

“Not willing to risk it and find out.”

“Fair enough,” she nodded. “Just know that you can take all the time you need for the next, like, two weeks if you gotta.”

“Thanks!”

Satisfied with their progress and attitude, and certain Entrapta wasn’t going to mess with her Gate, Mermista nodded to the assembled before diving off the rock hovering dozens of feet in the air. She flipped and transformed, and in minutes was back on the beach of the island she was working on today. To her surprise, Sea Hawk was waiting for her just beyond the dunes.

“How did it go?” He offered her his arm, and she took it.

“Fine, I guess. We have…a lot to talk about regarding Catra.”

“I figured we would, so I sent the crew to lunch. Join me for a meal?”

Mermista smiled softly. She wasn’t really hungry- her appetite had yet to fully return- but she would nibble on something to make him happy and keep her energy up. “Sure, Legal Husband.”

It was really a low blow. Good for Entrapta.

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The first Alliance meeting after the war was…tense, to say the least. Sea Hawk’s eyes bounced around the room anxiously while his leg jiggled under the table. He had his own seat now, he’d noticed. Two high-backed chairs carved with gold plated scales, topped with a Pearl crafted from quartz and opal. Mermista sat next to him in the larger chair, drumming her nails impatiently on the tabletop. Seated so far were Perfuma, Scorpia, Micah, Spinnerella, Netossa, and Bow. Entrapta, Hordak, Adora, Catra, and Glimmer were notably absent.

Mermista turned to him suddenly. “What should we do about the boundary dispute between the Fischers and the Lovels?”

He blinked, caught off guard. “Erm, I myself am partial to letting the Board decide, as I don’t quite think it’s the sort of thing we need to be caught up in at the moment.”

“They’ll accuse me of delegating, and seeing it as lesser.”

“Well, dearest,” he stroked his mustache. “I don’t mean any offense to them, but with funerals to plan, bodies to uncover, schools and homes and entire communities to rebuild, and a trade system to reestablish- I do, in fact, think it’s lesser.”

Mermista huffed, but he saw her thinking it over. “Yeah, you’re not wrong.”

“We need to-”

The doors to the room flew open with a bang, at the same time Glimmer appeared next to her father in a shower of sparkles.

Adora, Entrapta, and their yet-to-be-convicted partners filed in, already looking quite defensive.

Sea Hawk gulped.

“Scorpia, Perfuma, bring us up to speed on your progress with dismantling the Fright Zone.”

The honeymooning couple launched into a lengthy tale, complete with interruptions, giggles, pet names, and all other things that were about to make Mermista vomit on the table, he had to assume.

‘Dearest, let them be young and in love,’ he whispered over the Bond. It was getting easier to speak in close range like this.

‘This is fucking painful, I want to gouge my ears out.’

‘Oh, please don’t, I love kissing them. Besides, this was us once!’

‘We were never like this,’ she snorted telepathically, her lips only twitching slightly in a smirk. *‘I would have sold my scales on the black market before I let this happen.’*

‘Too true, my love.’

“Thanks, guys,” Bow chuckled as they wrapped up. He sobered very quickly, though, looking right at them. “Mermista, Sea Hawk, how’s Salineas?”

“Uh, in pieces?” His wife raised an imperious eyebrow.

“Where are we with rebuilding?” Glimmer asked, and Sea Hawk practically *felt* Mermista’s hackles rise. He cut in before she could open her mouth.

“Slow, but progress is being made. We have the last set of funerals this week, at least…for now. I’m, ah, not sure there won’t be more as we progress, but, ahem, anyway. The harbor has been cleared of rubble, as has its marketplace. The bazaar, capital city, and suburbs of the main island are still in progress.”

“When do you think trade will reopen to the other kingdoms?” Glimmer glanced at her paperwork.

Mermista’s jaw was tight. “When we stop pulling bodies out of former neighborhoods, I imagine.”

Micah sighed, placing a hand on Glimmer’s shoulder. “We apologize, both of you. That was a *bit* insensitive, and hasty, considering the unfathomable loss you continue to cope with day in and day out. Can Bright Moon aid in rebuilding in any way?”

Sea Hawk blinked, impressed with Micah's swift diplomacy. He did spare a moment of slight sympathy for Glimmer, now blushing to her roots and looking quite guilty. He knew she was overwhelmed, and it had merely been a momentary slip. But…he'd be lying if he said it hadn't hurt nonetheless.

"I'm sure as we progress to more constructive efforts, we'll be calling in help from all across Etheria," Sea Hawk nodded. "For now, we don't think bringing in outsiders would be the best for the people's comfort or morale."

"Understood," Micah nodded, and sat back down.

'Thank you,' Mermista whispered in his mind. *'You have a good head for diplomacy.'*

'Must have been all that peacocking in my younger years.'

'Younger?'

He smothered a chuckle behind his hand, reaching under the table to gently pinch her leg. She swatted at him, pressing her lips together.

'Focus, Sebastian!'

'How can I? With you in that fantastic skirt…'

Mermista shifted casually, crossing her legs elegantly. She said nothing more, but reached out to caress the Bond. She'd gotten remarkably good at it, making it feel like her fingers were raking softly through his hair.

Topics circled from clone displacement, what to do about the overgrowth that seemed here to stay thanks to Adora's Powerful Gay Laser Beam at the end there, finding Double Trouble, what to do about the deserter Princesses, and lastly…reparations.

"Alright," Glimmer sighed. "We sent missives out to the representatives of your kingdoms as well as you, their heads. The representatives state the desires of the people of Etheria, as always, as verified by six witnesses each and here signed with truth sigils. Catra, Entrapta, Hordak, please stand as I read out the decisions. Monarchs, keep in mind that you have veto power and final say, but that trials and hearings will be held by courts of the people regardless. Per the Ancient Accords, are we understood and aligned?"

Frosta stood first. "The Empirical Kingdom of Snows understands, and agrees."

"The collective City-States of Bright Moon understand, and agree."

“Mystacor understands, and agrees.”

“The Kingdom of Salineas understands, and agrees.”

“The Unified Tribes of Plumeria understand, and agree.”

“The Kingdom of Dryl understands…and agrees.”

“The, uh, Former and hopefully Future Kingdom of Scorpioni understands, and agrees.”

All eyes turned to Adora, whose jaw was clenched tight. It was a tense moment until she sighed, shoulders dropping slightly. “I, Adora, Champion of Etheria, and She-Ra, Princess of Protection, understand…and I agree.”

“Thank you, all,” Glimmer sighed. “Let’s begin. Frosta, Empress of the Kingdom of Snows, your people have voted-” she broke off with a choking noise, and cleared her throat. “And they would see Catra imprisoned for life in the Blizzard’s Waste, Hordak put to death, and Entrapta sentenced to a life of community service.”

The room was silent. Everyone was aghast, even Frosta, who shook her head. “N-no! No. Veto on all accounts!”

“They will still have to stand trial,” Glimmer nodded, placing aside the missive. “If found guilty, the Alliance will help you discuss a mediated middle ground in the interest of compromise, or collaboration.”

“A-alright,” Frosta nodded, still looking rattled. “Okay.”

Glimmer sighed. “Bright Moon has voted for community service on all three accounts, the location of which has been left to the monarchy.”

Micah, Spinerella, Netossa, and Glimmer looked at one another, something passing between them. Micah cleared his throat.

“We will hold our decision until the end of the debate.”

Did he look at Mermista when he said that? Sea Hawk felt her tense next to him.

“Plumeria,” Glimmer grabbed the next note. “Shocking no one, your tribe has voted for part-time community service for Hordak and Catra, and pardon for Entrapta. Glad this is an easy one-”

“Veto.”

Once again, the room froze, every head snapping toward Perfuma. Her hands were clasped tightly, raised as if in prayer with her elbows on the table, while her head was bowed.

“W-what?” Catra stammered, tail lashing. Even Scorpia looked horrified.

“I cannot abide by these sentences, in good conscience,” the Chief of Plumeria murmured. “I sheltered my people from the worst of the war, and we made it through relatively unscathed. But so many others didn’t,” she wiped a tear away. “I propose full term community service, in Salineas and Dryl, as well as five years of mandatory therapy for each of them.”

Glimmer blinked, utterly shocked. “O-okay. Noted.”

“Perfuma-” Scorpia started, but then stopped. Some things were best saved for private conversation.

“Dryl is next,” Micah took over as Glimmer was still making the amended notes to Plumeria. “The people have voted to- oh, dear.”

Entrapta sighed. “As I suspected.”

“They have voted to see you removed from power, and stripped of your title, legacy, Guild Status, birthright, and…exiled. The other two, they have agreed to a lifetime of service in the mines.”

The Tech Princesses was silent for a long time, mask down. The severity of the verdict was not lost on anyone. To be stripped of an entire legacy, to be the end of your royal line… Mermista had once said it was her greatest fear, to be the last Monarch in Salineas, and it would mean she had failed her duty, and performed the ultimate disservice to her people.

“When is the retrial?” Entrapta’s mask snapped up, determined.

“One year from today.”

“Then with the power still left to me, I veto,” she nodded, much to everyone’s shock. “And I request permission to serve out my sentence in Dryl. I want to be the leader my people need, the leader you all have been, at one time or another. I used to be quite good at it, you know,” she smiled wistfully. “Until my mother passed, anyway. I would really like the chance to make all of this up to them, to her…and to all of you. Let me work in Dryl, and I promise I’ll churn out more tech, metal, gadgets, and bots to help with rebuilding than you could even *fathom!* ”

Sea Hawk had to smile at her enthusiasm, and he nudged Mermista with his elbow. She rolled her eyes and elbowed him back, but he knew she was already on board.

“All in favor?” Micah glanced around.

“One year, Entrapta,” Bow leveled her with his most serious look. “After that…it gets harder to help.”

“I can do this, Bow,” she grinned. “I *know* I can.”

They all voted in favor, and after that, it was finally time for Salineas’ verdict. Sea Hawk folded his hands together, leaning to prop his elbows on the table.

Glimmer cleared her throat. “The votes are…extremely scattered. For Catra and Hordak…the death penalty was the most popular choice, but only by seventy votes. Just behind it is a decade of service to the Kingdom, as seen fit by Her Majesty. Behind that…uh, Mermista can you translate this?”

She peered at the paper Glimmer passed over. “Eaten by sharks, loosely.”

“Loosely?” Hordak muttered.

Mermista glared. “The literal verbiage is a bit more descriptive.”

“Noted.”

“For Entrapta, community service was the popular vote. So, um,” Glimmer swallowed nervously. “What’s your vote?”

Mermista sighed, and he looked at her. “My people have voted to end your lives, just as you ended the lives of so many of their children, mothers, fathers, siblings… you get the picture. As Queen, it’s my job to listen to my people, and make their desires possible.”

A gasp rippled around the room, and Sea Hawk kept his face neutral. He knew what she was going to vote, but he allowed her this bit of theater anyway. And she claimed *he* was a peacock.

“...within reason,” she finished, reclining back into her throne-away-from-home. “I veto the death penalty, and move for a decade of full time community service. Hordak can split his time between Dryl and Salineas, so long as he’s working primarily toward rebuilding my kingdom until it no longer needs his constant attention. Catra remains in Salineas at all times, save for special exemption.”

Adora’s eyes bored into his, but Sea Hawk wouldn’t waver. They’d stayed up til the wee hours discussing this, and this was what was best for the people. Not them individually (the last place Mermista wanted Catra was Salineas), or Adora as their friend, but for the justice owed to their people.

“In that case,” Micah stood. “Bright Moon agrees with the conditions set by Queen Mermista for the community service of Catra, Hordak, and Entrapta. All in agreement?”

The vote was unanimous. Even Adora reluctantly stood and agreed, although it looked like she was pulling teeth to do so. Guilt and sorrow thrashed across the Bond, and Sea Hawk knew it was killing Mermista to hurt her friend. But the people came first.

“When do you want them to report?”

Sea Hawk deferred to Mermista, who was gnawing her lip. “Can we discuss that privately?”

She was technically supposed to be asking Glimmer, but she directed the question to Catra and Adora. Adora blinked, surprised, and looked at her girlfriend. “I- I have questions.”

“Would you rather ask them here, or in private?”

“Oh, um,” Catra blinked. “Later, I guess. A-and yeah, uh, take your time.”

“And you?”

Hordak shook himself out of a reverie. “I can report to Salineas whenever you’d like. I would like to begin my work in Dryl immediately, though.”

“What you do for the time being is between you and you, dude,” Mermista shrugged apathetically. “We done here? Kind of a long-ass boat ride back.”

“Right, yes, we’re good,” Glimmer clapped her hands. “Dismissed, everyone, and thank you all.”

Sea Hawk paused, clearing his throat. “Um, dearest, we’re forgetting something…?”

“Wha-? Oh, shit, right. Hang on, guys.”

She reached into the messenger bag he’d brought, left at their feet, and produced several laminated envelopes. Each person’s name was scrawled in gold, and they were sealed with Mermista’s sigil. She tossed them haphazardly, like frisbees, and Sea Hawk chuckled.

“What’s this?” Perfuma tilted her head.

“Wedding invitations!” Sea Hawk beamed, slinging an arm around his wife, who promptly pushed it off. Such was their age-old dance.

“I thought you were already married?” Catra tilted her head.

“Only in Salineas, legally,” he grinned.

“Yeah, for Bird Brain here to, like, actually get coronated and be King and all that other jazz-”

“And apparently let into your hospital room.”

“-yeah, that, whatever,” she rolled her eyes. “We need a universal marriage. And apparently eloping once is already cutting it, like, reaaaaally close to illegal for royalty, so, yeah. Big ass royal wedding in a few months’ time before my council kills me.”

Bow was vibrating, scanning the invitations. “Island of… dress code… reception… *dancing!* ”

“It’s usually a three-night thing, but I’m trying to talk them down to two,” Mermista groaned. “So, be ready for that. We can discuss details as we get closer.”

“A royal wedding!” Scorpia was beaming. “Gosh, is it gonna be like Princess Prom?”

Netossa laughed a bit. "Oh, no, honey, Princess Prom was the practice run. This is the real deal," she winked at Mermista. "I told y'all- Salineas parties go hard. This is gonna be amazing! Oh, and congrats, you two."

Congratulations rippled around the table, and Mermista blushed. "Ughhh, whatever, yeah thanks."

"Many thanks, friends! It will be a night to remember-"

"No."

"But-!"

"No boats. No fires. No shanties."

Sea Hawk pouted. "I'm filing for divorce."

"Oh, good luck with that," Mermista smirked. "Getting out is twice as complicated as getting in- the shark tooth trap."

"You know, there's a joke in there, somewhere-"

“I am *literally* fourteen!” Frosta groaned, glaring and readying a snowball to huck at them. Sea Hawk cleared his throat, blushing, while Mermista just chuckled.

“Catra, you had questions?”

And just like that, the meeting was over. Mermista slipped her arm into his, squeezing gently while everyone was distracted. “No boats on fire at the wedding because the guards get tetchy. But… if we sneak out after and sail out far enough…”

“Marry me?” He ducked down to press a kiss to her cheek.

“Already did, loser.”

“Do it again.”

“Hm, you know, I just might…”

He laughed, thrilled to see her in such high spirits. Lately, they’d get back to the castle after rebuilding, eat a fast dinner with Maevik and some advisors, working through logistics and plans even then, and then collapse into bed. They’d had little time to themselves, to relax or enjoy one another’s company.

Sea Hawk shook the thoughts from his head as Adora and Catra approached. The magicat's posture was defensive, and hunched. To his shock, Mermista kept her arm in his.

'They need to respect you as someone in charge, too, difficult as that may be.'

'Oh, how she wounds me!'

'Shut it.'

"Melog has to come with me," Catra demanded off the bat. "It's… it's part of me. I need it."

Mermista shrugged. "As long as it's not that damn horse."

"Hey," Adora pouted. "Swifty's a good boy."

"Swifty puts terrible ideas in Sea Hawk's overactive head."

Adora conceded that point with a shrug. "Fair."

“What else, Catra?” Sea Hawk prompted, smiling. She looked very off put by this.

“Uh, where am I going to stay? It’s a long trip from Bright Moon to Salineas, and Melog’s fast but it’s not that fast.”

“You’ll have a guest residency in the castle, under close supervision by my guards,” Mermista said. “Breakfast, and dinner will be provided. Lunch isn’t terribly common in Salineas, but we take tea around the same time. You’ll see, they’re similar.”

“What will I be doing?” Catra’s tail was lashing nervously, eyes bobbing between them.

“Whatever needs to be done,” Sea Hawk twirled his mustache in thought. “Rubble should be clear in a month, so you might be working with contractors, painters, fishermen, so on and so forth.”

Catra nodded, and then reddened. “How, uh…how near water will I be?”

Mermista raised an eyebrow. “Uh. It’s an island?”

“I know that!” Catra snarled, and then froze. “Um, I mean- yes, I know that, Your, uh, Grace?”

"Please just call me Mermista, for both of our sakes."

"A-alright."

"How often do I get to visit?" Adora butted in harshly.

"I…don't care?" Mermista shrugged. "As long as she's working, it doesn't matter to me. Stay the whole time if you feel so inclined."

"Wait, really?"

"Uh, yeah, dude," she rolled her eyes, fiddling with the fabric of his jacket. "I'm not doing this to punish you. And I'm not even here to punish *you* , honestly," she jerked her chin at Catra. "I'm here to figure out the best way to help my people, and what they want is to see their home rebuilt."

"And me dead," Catra muttered.

Sea Hawk shrugged. "You'll get past that, and learn not to take it so personally. Plenty of folks want me dead! For a myriad of reasons! So long as I know where I'm meant to be, what those others think and want is irrelevant. The only opinions that matter are your own, and the ones of those you've deemed worthy of your time."

The three women blinked at him, fairly shocked.

“Uh,” Catra said. “Alright. I’ll try to…remember that?”

“See that you do,” Mermista backed him up. “Is that all?”

“For now, yeah,” Adora nodded, looking at Catra.

They nodded and turned to go, but Catra’s voice stopped them.

“Hey, uh, Mermista,” they looked back to see her shuffling, one hand deep in Melog’s mane. “For what it’s worth…I am sorry. Sorry for everything.”

Mermista stared at her, cool and emotionless, but to her credit Catra didn’t look away. “It’s not worth much… yet. But you have the power to make it worth a whole lot more.”

And with that, they were gone.

—-

Four months to rebuild the beauty marks of the capital, set up temporary but stable housing for said capital's displaced civilian populace, re-establish preliminary trade routes without a harbor or market, and also plan a *royal fucking wedding* . To say Mermista had been on edge was…a broad, insulting understatement.

Plus, keeping Catra and Hordak alive long enough to actually help the people who seemed hellbent on killing them and avoiding an international incident was exhausting in and of itself.

At least, for once, Sea Hawk was minding himself. After a flammable incident on a fishing boat that landed his ass on the couch for three consecutive nights, he'd wised up that now was, like, definitely not the time to trifle with her patience. In between fine tuning the Gate for typhoon season, sitting in on meeting after meeting with architects, engineers, and surveyors, and boning up on international maritime trade laws, it had been nothing but wedding drivel.

What flowers would she like? No opinion, call Perfuma. What color scheme? Uh, the same color scheme her House had been using for literal centuries, duh. What food at the reception? Standard Salinean party fare, the same as any ball, with accommodations for intolerances. Of course. Who would be presiding? Swami Dhang. Would her father be attending?

Who fucking knew? Certainly not her.

Was Adora allowed to bring Catra, and Entrapta, Hordak? Seemed rude otherwise, so fine. As long as she got to enjoy her wedding.

Did the King have any family attending? Ask him!

Mermista collapsed into bed one month before the wedding with a long, loud, groan that she indulged in until her lungs had no more air to give. And then she wallowed in suffocating misery for another few seconds, just because she could. Feeling satisfied with her theatrics, she sat up and started removing her shoes. Across the room by the fireplace, Sea Hawk was laughing into his paperwork.

"A little less of *that* , thanks," she glared over her shoulder, half-hearted. Sea Hawk held up a hand in surrender, eyes never leaving the folder in his hand. "Whatcha got there?"

"The fifteenth set of plans for the new harbor system. Not that they'll be the last…"

She got up and crossed the room, shimmying out of her leggings as she did. They were caked in mud, and would need some serious laundering. Sea Hawk made room for her between his legs, and she leaned her back to his front on the couch. "Explain it to me."

"Yes, Your Majesty," he chuckled, and she blushed. It was hard, okay, to turn off the Queen Voice right away once they were alone. With the red pen he held loosely between his fingers, he pointed to various parts of the sketch. "So, there would be a sentry post waaaaay out here. Hard to see on the plans, but this is about five miles off shore. They'd check cargo going in and out, inspect the ships, all that jazz. There's a strip of bedrock here that’ll do nicely as foundation, and that’s about all we’ve agreed on. I want the incoming traffic directed to the right, and departures to the left.”

“Why?”

“Red, Right, Returning,” he recited. “It’s a boating rule of thumb. Red markers are kept on your right when returning homeward, and your left when exiting into open water. Logically, I figure the harbor should follow the same rule. Otherwise, we’ll have lanes crossing which is a disaster waiting to happen.”

“Makes sense to me. Why won’t they approve it?”

“I’m not an engineer so I can’t possibly know what I’m talking about,” he rolled his eyes, and Mermista patted his arm in sympathy.

“They’ll come around. Or I’ll step in.”

“I can handle it,” he smiled tightly, and she let it drop, rolling her eyes where he couldn’t see lest she start a fight. Sea Hawk finding his own path in the courts of Salineas remained a touchy subject. He didn’t want Mermista fighting his battles for him, but she hated the insults and whispers he had to endure while it took everyone else ages to catch up with what she’d already learned. Sea Hawk was brilliant in his own right, it just took…certain angles for that to shine through.

For now, she pressed closer to him, and kissed his jaw. “What else?”

“Here,” he gestured with the pen. “I want to establish a drop zone, for ships that are just dropping and moving onto the next port, so they don’t have to wait for a spot, unload, etcetera. It’ll keep the clog to a minimum. And over here, I’d like to set up the new port markets, further from the castle than before-”

“What? Why?” Mermista frowned. She liked the bustling ports so near.

“Security,” Sea Hawk shrugged, keeping his tone light. “I just… don’t want so many strangers near the castle. There’s only so many guards.”

“That sends, like, a terrible message, though,” she frowned. “Trade and those markets are the lifeblood of our kingdom, Sea Hawk, and they’ve always had a place near the castle. It’s as symbolic as it is functional.”

“I’m just not comfortable with it.”

“Well,” she blinked at him, incredulous. “Get comfortable with it.”

He narrowed his eyes. “You left the harbor system to me-”

“We’re still a team!” She glared. “We still run things by each other, and work together, and I’m sorry but this is a part of Salinean culture and life that I’m not budging on or changing.”

“So your say is absolute but mine isn’t?” His jaw set, and he moved his arms up and away from her. “That doesn’t seem like a team to me.”

“Look, I’m all for the harbor itself getting an update, I’ll be the first to admit I’m not super, like, well-read on sailing in that sense. But on land, that becomes my domain, too-”

“Fine.” He returned his gaze to his maps, scratching with his pen dejectedly.

She sighed. “Sea Hawk-”

“I said *fine* , Mermista!” He snapped, loudly, and she recoiled. With a scoff, she pushed off the couch and stormed into their closet. She snatched a bathing suit off a hook, and a sarong wrap, changed quickly and walked out.

Sea Hawk was watching her warily. “Sending me to the couch again?”

“Fuck off,” she snarled at him, walking past him to the balcony. There were stairs there that would take her to the beach.

“Mermista-”

“Leave me *alone!* ”

He got to his feet, trying to cut her off. “Dearest, wait-”

“Don’t you fucking ‘dearest’ me,” she whirled on him, glaring venemously. He stopped a few feet away, paling. Her skin was prickling, and her transformative control was slipping in her exhaustion and anger. She could feel her teeth sharpening, and scales rippling across her body, and she just *didn’t fucking care* . “Go ahead and snap and lecture me all you want, just like everyone else has been doing lately. How many wedding questions did you get interrupted with today? Huh? How many times were your projects sidelined because someone needed your opinion on *flowers* ? How many men did you have to shout down in meetings because they were twice your age with half your experience in politics? How many times were you stopped and publicly *interrogated and badgered* about providing the kingdom with an *heir* ? HUH?”

Sea Hawk held up his hands. “Mermista, I-”

" *ANSWER ME!"*

"None!" He swallowed. "None."

"Exactly!" She snarled. "So, go do whatever the fuck you want with the harbor, and the fucking market, for the home *I've* lived in and loved my entire stars-damned life. I don't *fucking* care anymore!"

She screamed the last bit at him before wrenching the door to the balcony open and storming out, slamming it shut behind her. It opened again when she was halfway down the stairs, but she paid his chase no mind, tearing onto the sand and not slowing when she hit the stone jetty that would carry her past the breakers. She tore off her sarong, letting it flutter to the sand. She would find it later. She dove headlong into the ocean, and only let her tears fall when she sank low enough that the moonlight was just a speck.

Beneath the waves, she raced away from the coast, heading deeper and deeper out to sea. Her tail worked in overtime to propel her faster- *faster-* until her thoughts couldn't keep up with her body and fell away entirely. Her lungs burned and her back twinged and, yeah, Mermista knew she wasn't healed enough for exercise like this but she was losing her damn mind. Nonstop talking, nonstop pleasantries and politeness all day, being who they all wanted to see, not the woman she really was because *that* Mermista was…wrong, somehow. They all made her feel wrong, and stupid, and off-color, all of them except Sea Hawk.

Usually.

She pushed the thought away and let the waves wash the tears off her cheeks. She refocused on the world around her, and her own body- the things she could control. Mermista's tail was getting longer, she'd noticed, and sprouting some new fins and fans. Maevik had shrugged when she'd asked him about it, and told her that it wasn't uncommon for merfolk to have one last growth spurt as they reached true adulthood. She was certainly grateful for it now, as she tore through the dark sea like a torpedo.

She hated fighting with Sea Hawk. When they really got into it, it wasn't bad because they were both yelling and both angry and ugly. But when it was this- this vicious, petty sniping until one of them exploded… she groaned, slowing at last as her lungs finally started to cramp. She turned over her shoulder lazily, floating through moonbeams, and swam a bit further out, letting her mind wander. She hated yelling at him, even when she was, like, totally right. He got the worst kicked-puppy look, all droopy and sad.

Love sucked sometimes.

Fish darted around her, some pygmy sea serpents and eels ribboning closer as she approached a long stretch of reef. The coral was bright and beautiful, and she swam along it, letting it soothe her. She imagined this was how Perfuma felt when she took calming nature hikes among blossoming trees. Mermista hated pollen, and sweat, but this she understood and adored.

Off in the distance, a pod of whales was singing and snuggling, getting ready for bed, and she stopped to watch. The calves were resting near the surface, squeaking and snorting while their parents sang haunting, deep-chested melodies to soothe them to sleep. Mermista found a shallow sand flat to lay on nearer to the pod, and the songs of the ocean lull her into a doze. It was hard for her to truly sleep in the ocean outside of her grotto, but naps were always nice. A voice in her head told her she was avoiding the issue, per usual, but she pushed it away.

When she woke, the moon was all but set, the whales were asleep, and she was *freezing* . With a shake, she pushed off the sandbar and went up to the surface. A quick glance oriented her, told her there were no ships hanging around, and that it had been about forty five minutes since she dozed off, about an hour since she left shore. With a sigh, she decided to head back to the grotto. If Sea Hawk had followed her to the shoreline, maybe he'd grabbed her sarong. If not, she'd get it tomorrow.

When she emerged into her hidden oasis, she was shocked to find feet dangling in the water, one ankle bearing a faded tattoo of a sigil in Icsarin that translated roughly to 'Captain'. She swam closer, tail flicking in agitation, peeking out of the water. Sea Hawk was sitting with his pants rolled up to the knee, smoothing out the sarong folded in his lap. He looked up when she broke the surface further, just her eyes and the top of her head peeking out.

"H-hi," he swallowed, glancing at her nervously. "How was your swim?"

"...okay, I guess." Her magic made it easy to understand her, even with her mouth underwater.

“Good,” he looked back down. “I was about to get my boat out and look for you. You were gone for a while.” He unfolded and refolded her sarong, swallowing harshly. “I don’t like when I can’t see you.”

Mermista closed her eyes. In her anger, she’d forgotten about his PTSD, his growing, neurotic need to have her close when they left the castle. It could be more than a bit annoying, but she knew that for now, he needed it, and he was working to need it less. She swam closer, placing a wet hand on his leg. “I’m right here.”

Sea Hawk reached out and gripped her hand tightly. She pushed herself out of the water more, folding her arms on his lap. He bent forward, wrapping his arms around her shoulders.

“I’m sorry, Mermista,” he sniffed. “I shouldn’t have gotten so short with you, and tried to cut you off or chase you. Or snipped at you.”

“It was kind of shitty, yeah,” she grimaced, but lifted her own arms to wrap around his neck. He straightened up, pulling her further out of the water- no easy feat with her tail of pure muscle doubling her weight. “I’m just so stressed, dude. The last thing I need is you fighting me, too. All day, no one… *hears* me. Or understands me, I guess. They all get this version of me that’s, like, so exhausting to put on, and if it slips…they look at me like you did tonight. Like I don’t understand. Or care. And it *hurts.* ”

“I’m sorry” he whispered into her shoulder. “I’m so sorry. I just… fight everyone all day, people who think I’m a moron, that it’s hard to turn off the defensiveness. But that’s no excuse. I can’t expect you to just take all of my hideous stress and frustration and then not offer you the same.”

He pulled her into his lap, the fin of her tail trailing through the water, and wrapped his arms around her waist and where her upper thigh would be, normally. She settled hers on his shoulders, gazing neutrally into his warm onyx eyes. She was still hurt, but she was trying not to let it control her.

“I’m sorry I haven’t been checking in,” he shut his eyes. “I didn’t know you were going through so much.”

“I didn’t want to worry you,” she shrugged, looking away. “It’s fine, really, I was just being dramatic. It’s nothing I haven’t been handling all my life, and I’m…it’s fine. I’m handling it.”

“Mermista,” he sighed. “You’re not alone anymore. You shouldn’t have to just ‘handle’ things like this. I’m… I complained about not being a team, but I’m the one who left you alone with all the bullshit.”

“Yeah, well, you’re new to ruling…”

“Doesn’t matter,” Sea Hawk frowned. “I’m your partner. I *want* to help you, Mermista!”

“Well, then…help, I guess.”

“Can you tell me how?”

She groaned, throwing her head back. “I dunno! No one’s gonna ask *you* about babies or flowers because the world sucks sometimes, so… I dunno.”

“Can I take other things off your plate?”

Mermista scowled. “Depends. Are you going to steamroll over my preferences for those, too? Or not even bother to ask my opinion on them and do whatever the fuck you want?”

Sea Hawk hung his head. “I…deserve that. I’m sorry, Mermista.”

“Whatever,” she shrugged, crossing her arms and dropping her eyes to her lap. “I’m over it.”

“You’re not,” he leveled a look of Knowing at her, and it made her want to drown him as much as kiss him. “Please don’t shut me out and lie to me.”

Mermista shut her eyes, and forced herself to relax. This was just Sebastian. He wasn’t going to judge her for needing help, or turn her away and make her face it alone. He would take her hand, do what she needed, and be happy he could help her in any way. "I'm…sorry. I'm having a bad day."

"I know," he pressed a careful kiss to her shoulder. "It's okay. I'm here for whatever you need. For real this time."

"I think," she sighed. "I need to raid the kitchen for a snack, and go the fuck to bed."

"Can we talk more in the morning?"

"Yes," she sighed, rolling her eyes. "We can talk, or whatever."

"Thank you, love."

She swapped her tail for her legs, and let Sea Hawk steady her on her feet before she took her sarong back. Her back was twinging, but she ignored it as they made their way back to their wing of the castle, thoughtful silence prevailing. In their kitchen, Mermista perched on the island counter while Sea Hawk set about rummaging through cabinets. They usually swapped off the meals they cooked, and she'd done breakfast that morning. Their cooks were only conscripted for tea and dinner, and the rest of the time, until rebuilding was complete, they helped feed the displaced and recovering citizens.

He threw together one of simpler traditional Snows' dishes she liked, a rice porridge with egg, some cured meat, and bits of fish. Hearty and simple, and very comforting. Just like him. She accepted the bowl and a piece of old naan with a small smile and he kissed her cheek, joining her on the counter.

Mermista sighed, nudging her food around. "So much for our carefree happy ending."

"Oh, I don't know," Sea Hawk hummed, already sounding much more like his usual self as he munched on his own piece of naan. "A year ago, we were living in a tent, eating protein slaw and dehydrated vegetables and simple broths. Now, we're in our warm, dry kitchen, planning our wedding, rebuilding our kingdom, and eating some very delicious- thank you, Sea Hawk- congee."

She snorted in actual amusement and nudged him with her elbow. "Thank you, babe."

"Always, dearest," he chuckled.

"And…you're right."

Sea Hawk choked slightly on his food. "Come again?" he coughed.

Mermista blushed and rolled her eyes. "This is a happy ending. *I'm* happy. I'm just also tired, y'know? I want to get back into politics and policy or even just manual labor. I don't want to keep being interrupted with this stupid wedding," she sighed, then straightened. "Not that marrying you is stupid- I didn't-"

"Relax, Mermista," he kissed her cheek. "I understand. I was fine with just the one wedding. It was dramatic! Dangerous! Rebellious! So many of my favorite things- and with my favorite person!"

She blushed even more, groaning. "Ugh, such a dork."

"But, like it or not, the people want this. Or, rather, they *need* it. We've been working so hard for so long, no break from the stress in years. Especially Salineas. When's the last time everyone came together for a festival? Or Holiday?"

Mermista frowned, thinking. "Probably the last Diwali, and that was…three years ago."

"See? We're well due for a true blue Salinean rager."

"It's not a bad point," she conceded, gnawing her lip as she turned over options in her head. "So… maybe we should pull focus off the capital buildings for now, and focus on the courtyards and town squares. It shouldn't be hard, just cobblestone repair. The Artists' Guild may want to build some new murals…"

The gears in her head were turning, and her fingers were itching for a pen. Mermista hopped off the counter, put her empty bowl in the sink, and took off for her private office. “Come!”

“Yes, ma’am!” Sea Hawk’s footsteps caught up quickly, and followed her down the hall. She grabbed a pen and one of her not yet filled journals off the desk, flipping to a clean page as she sat down. Sea Hawk came around the desk and perched on its surface facing her, resting his foot on the edge of her chair. She rested her chin on his knee when she glanced up at him.

“In all the cities you’ve visited, what are the most beautiful, communal parts of a courtyard?”

“Hmmm,” he pondered, still nibbling his dinner. She didn’t normally allow eating in here, but she loved him, or whatever, so… “Fountains! Everyone loves a fountain. Musicians are always nice, minstrels, bards, so on. People love to dance, or join in. Some courtyards have games built into the ground- horseshoe, hopscotch, dice or marble circles. Restaurants with outdoor seating. Benches for sitting and people-watching.”

She scribbled furiously, sketching vague outlines in the margins when Sea Hawk paused to think. Fountains had ever been a part of Salinean architecture, but usually they were functional.

“What about a splash area for like, tiny kids?” Sea Hawk tilted his head, thinking aloud. “Or for anyone who doesn't want to head to the beach during high tourism seasons?”

“Cute,” she smiled softly. “We used to have one of those on one of the terraces. Peekablue, the Star Sisters and I would play in it while our parents worked.”

Sea Hawk made a soft noise in the back of her throat. “Are there any baby pictures of you? I’ve never seen…”

“Uh, yeah, quite a few, actually,” she blushed, trying to deflect. “I’ll dig them up sometime.”

She glanced up to see him clearly trying not to vibrate out of his skin. She groaned. “Focus, and then I’ll see. *Maybe* .”

“Yes, dear,” he grinned. “You’ll want soft lights for the evening, too. Fire lamps, or maybe the Sorcerer’s Guild will enchant some of those firefly floaters. Something warm and homey.”

“We usually do string lights and tiki torches on the beaches because they’re easier to take down in a storm…” she gnawed her lip. “Nah, something permanent and sturdy for the squares. And then we just make sure they can’t be ripped up.”

“Fantastic!” he crowed, finishing his congee. “Drink?”

“Whatever you’re having is fine.”

She kept scratching out notes, vague approximations of layouts for larger town squares. They’d been smaller than was really comfortable for a long time, as they were ancient, built in the eras before tourism had really been a thing in Salineas. The main island was the oldest founded settlement by the merfolk, and had been entirely wilderness when they walked out of the sea. Hence why it hurt so much to see so many buildings and structures reduced to rubble and ash- so much of their history as a people, gone in an instant.

Sea Hawk nudged a glass into her hands, and she murmured her thanks.

“Should we hammer through some of the other nonsense while we’re here and awake?”

Mermista groaned, but nodded. “Fine. Flowers?”

“Neither of us particularly care. So, what would the people like?”

She snorted. “Hibiscus is the national flower of Salineas. White, blue, purple, burnt orange all grow around here. The white is rare, though…”

"Your mother grew them, right?" He asked softly. She nodded. "I think it'd be nice to have them there for her."

Mermista swallowed thickly. "Yeah. She'd like that."

"And you?"

"...yeah. Me, too." She tilted her head back, willing down the lump in her throat. "I wish she was here more than ever. I just want to *talk* to her. Did she hate all this, too? Did Dad help? What dress did she wear? Did the coronation go smoothly? How did she handle all of this stress?"

Sea Hawk nodded, and wrapped his hand around hers, still clicking her pen in agitation. She dropped it to squeeze back. "I wish you had her, too, my love."

"Yeah, well," she sighed heavily. "Not the first thing like this I'll do alone. Won't be last."

"You're not alone, dearest."

She glanced up into Sea Hawk's warm eyes. Loyal, reliable, *there* . "You're right. I'm not."

Chapter End Notes

Two more chapters and then we kiss them goodbye (for now...)
If you like what I write, check out my other SPOP stuff! I've got a few active projects in the air, all of which have seamista but in varying degrees. The rest are actually ensemble fics.
As always, I love to hear from y'all! Drop a comment or come find me on tumblr under the same handle!

fun to be friends with friends

Chapter Summary

> Rude inquisitions, and visits from friends!

Chapter Notes

> SORRY
> i've had a hell of a month or so. this fic is DONE its just gotta be editted twice more. please enjoy this goofy silly chapter. two more little wrap ups left!
>
> warnings for talking about sex and drinking and being young adults

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Another month ticked by, and Mermista found herself standing for yet another dress fitting when she could be sitting in a meeting with the courtyard engineers. The decision to shift focus to the public areas had been a hit, and it felt like everyone was finally taking that deep breath. With all the energy being poured into areas for recreation, for the upcoming wedding, excitement was building *very* quickly. And Mermista, against all logic, was getting extremely anxious.

She laid awake at night, tossing and turning, thinking about everything that could go wrong, or she could screw up. What if she clammed up and forgot to be happy? What if her friends hated the food and dancing? What if she insulted Sea Hawk- well, more than the joking amount of their baseline? What if she tripped, or he started being *too much* ? What if- what if- what if-

“Ow!”

“Sorry, Your Majesty!” The tailor winced, bowing their head. Mermista sighed.

“No, like, it’s fine. I’m sorry for fidgeting.”

The young person frantically shook their head. “It’s really fine-”

“Don’t let her scare you,” Sea Hawk called from where he was having fabric and pins jabbed into him as well. “She’s all bark, no b- *ow!* ”

“Oh, who did that?” Mermista let the water whip recede, relaxing her arm. “Weird weather lately.”

“You two are insufferable,” Maevik snorted from the door.

“Kill us yourself or stop complaining.” She tossed her hair, letting the tailor, now suppressing laughter, pin something to her shoulder. “Where are we with the community center?”

“The new foundation has been laid as of two hours ago,” Maevik smiled slightly. “This afternoon, they’ll begin laying the frame.”

“Excellent,” she nodded. “And the semi-permanent housing?”

“It’s been tied up in…” her guard/informal advisor shuffling some papers. “Hm. Commerce has flagged some pages.”

“Have someone set up a meeting for this afternoon, please. And get me some more files on a personal assistant.”

“Gladly.”

They were released from hell the fitting shortly, and immediately accosted by Mermista’s current least favorite person- Lady Humbis. She was her head lady in waiting until Lady Ofeni was released from the Healing Rooms, having contracted pneumonia shortly after being unchipped.

“Your Majesty,” the nosy old biddy inclined her head just enough to avoid disrespect. “Captain.”

Mermista bristled at her dismissal of Sea Hawk, but her husband just smiled. “Ma’am.”

“Your Grace, you’re due at the healing chambers. If you’d follow me…”

She frowned. "Uh, what? I'm not ill, and I don't recall scheduling an appointment for anything else." A glance at Sea Hawk produced only a shrug, and Maevik looked similarly confused.

"Oh, um, apologies, my Queen, I had assumed we were on the same page after our last discussion."

An uncomfortable, hot, angry feeling was creeping up Mermista's spine. She drew herself up higher, allowing the small bit of open kindness on her face to drop. "I assure you, we were not. Elaborate."

"Hmph, well," the older woman shook herself a bit. "Seeing as you have yet to…meet some of the expectations of the throne, I figured a bit of professional assistance wouldn't be amiss."

Behind her, Maevik inhaled sharply. Sea Hawk was still looking politely lost, bless his heart. Mermista smiled, and it was a sharp, dangerous thing.

"And which expectation would that be? I fail to see how the healers could help with rebuilding the people's homes, or working through community service sentences for Catra and Hordak, or, say, planning my wedding in a month's time, or even, oh, I don't know, pulling bodies out of rubble?"

Lady Humbis' face was paling rapidly. "W-well, no, not *those* expectations-"

“Then which?” She raised a single eyebrow, challenging her.

“The, um, the matter of providing the kingdom an heir-”

Sea Hawk barked an incredulous laugh, though there was no mirth in it. Mermista held up a hand, silencing everyone assembled. “Your concerns are not only unnecessary, but they are unwelcome and insulting, Lady Humbis. I will provide *the kingdom* with an heir when I see fit to, and no sooner. Until then, I assure you, we need no assistance whatsoever, professional or otherwise, in our bedroom.”

“I-I didn’t mean to imply-”

“You did more than imply,” she sneered. “You’re dismissed. Both from my presence and your position. Maevik, appoint the next in order until Ofeni is back. Good day.”

She turned on heel, gesturing sharply for Sea Hawk to follow, and left Maevik to handle the now-spluttering, red-faced noble she had just ended the career of. Maybe she’d feel worse about that in a bit, but right now, there were more important things to focus on.

“Dearest-”

“Please, don’t speak right now.”

He nodded in her peripheral, and wordlessly they headed to their next set of meetings. Before they split ways, he grabbed her hand and leaned in, pressing a fast kiss to her temple. She couldn’t muster a smile, but she squeezed his hand before dropping it.

Mermista took a centering breath, and nodded to the doormen to let her into the meeting.

“Alright, people, where are we with the aqueducts?”

— - – - - - – — –

Two weeks before the wedding, Mermista was actually relaxing on her terrace for once. It was Saturday morning, and everyone was taking the day to rest. When she’d attempted working anyway, Maevik had broken down her office door and politely but firmly escorted her to a lovely, private breakfast for her and Sea Hawk. Now, they were lounging on a couch, watching the waves. Despite the wreckage still covering the public beaches, there were people playing in the water, surfing, wakeboarding, and whatever else pleased them. The shrieks and laughs of children and the unsober roaring laughs of young adults reached them, and Mermista leaned back into Sea Hawk’s bare, sun-warmed chest with a smile.

They had the whole day to themselves, and she was more than ready to take a nap right here, let Sea Hawk carry her back to bed, and then…well, definitely *not* nap-

“Excuse me, Your Graces-”

Mermista opened her eyes with a sigh, turning to Maevik, Eliza just behind him. “Yes?”

“You have some unexpected guests.” Her guard looked quietly amused, while Eliza was practically vibrating with excitement.

She glanced at Sea Hawk, who shrugged. “Should we get, like, more dressed?”

“I don’t think that will be necessary,” Maevik chuckled. “Eliza, why don’t you let them in?”

The young girl nodded and vanished, and a second later, Glimmer materialized in a spray of sparkles, grinning from ear to ear. “Mermista! Sea Hawk!”

“Glimmer!” They both jumped off the couch. Sea Hawk reached the other queen first, and wrapped her in a tight hug. Mermista was waylaid by Bow charging onto the balcony and scooping her up into a bear hug. She shouted a laugh, letting him swing her around.

“Mermista! It’s *so* good to see you!”

“Move!” Another voice shouted. “My turn!”

Bow set her down just in time for Frosta to leap at her. Mermista caught the girl under the arms, and with a determined grunt, lifted her off her feet into an embrace. Frosta shrieked and she laughed. “What’s hanging, Tiny?”

“Fishstick!”

She set the young girl- teenager, now, gods- back on her feet just in time for Glimmer to collide with her. “Hey, Glim-”

“Mermista! How are you? How’s your back? How’s Salineas?”

“Glimmer,” Bow laughed, though it was choked from the iron grip Sea Hawk had on him. “Give her time to answer!”

Mermista laughed and tried to reply, but another person at the door stopped her train of thought short. “Perfuma!”

“Mermista!”

Her oldest friend practically tackled her, and Mermista hugged her back just as tightly. When they pulled back, both gently dabbed their eyes, laughing slightly. Last through the door were Scorpia and Adora, both looking somewhat nervous. Mermista put a stop to that when she crossed the balcony and wrapped her arms around Adora first- probably for the first time, like, ever by the shocked, happy look on the blonde's face. She pulled back, and offered Scorpia the same, yelping slightly when the tall woman lifted her clear off her feet.

"It's wonderful to see you both," she gasped once she could breathe again, back on her feet. "What are you all doing here?"

"Wellllll," Glimmer rocked on her heels, a mischievous smirk on her lips. "You're wedding is in *two weeks* -"

"Even though you're literally already married," Frosta snorted. Glimmer shushed her.

Perfuma wrapped an arm around Sea Hawk's shoulders, squeezing. "We thought we could steal you away for a little impromptu Girl's Night, while Sea Hawk, Bow, Scorpia, and Frosta, by her own request-"

"I don't wanna sit around and get burnt while you all gossip," Frosta rolled her eyes.

"- Do a Boy- well, I guess not a Boy's Night Out…?"

"Oh, I say we keep the name!" Scorpia grinned, and Frosta nodded. "It's authentic."

"Is Swifty coming?" Sea Hawk was *beaming* , and it was making Mermista's heart flip stupidly.

"He is! He's waiting outside though," Adora side-eyed Mermista. "Apparently horses aren't allowed within fifteen feet of the castle without a cargo load."

"Hm, weird." Mermista smirked and examined her chewed up nails. Adora rolled her eyes and nudged her. "So, what's the plan?"

"We," Perfuma motioned to the girls. "Were thinking a beach day? And then dinner in Bright Moon and a sleepover?"

Mermista smiled. It was lowkey, relaxing, intimate- everything she'd want. Everyone assembled knew she loathed a grand gesture (usually, ahem, Sea Hawk), or being the center of attention without ample time to prepare.

"And we were thinking a boat adventure!" Bow grinned, slinging an arm around Sea Hawk. "And then a bar! And then, uh…"

“Whatever happens next!” Scorpia joined the hug, pumping a pincer in excitement.

Mermista and Sea Hawk shared a glance, shrugging and smiling. “Yeah, sure, sounds…fun, actually.”

“Sounds like an *adventure!”* Her husband whooped. “Though, we do need to get dressed for such merriment.”

“Yeah, do you guys have bathing suits?”

“We have bags back at Bright Moon!” Glimmer squealed, hopping on her feet. “We didn’t know what you’d be tangled up in here, so we prepared for every scenario. Hang on!”

She poofed away, and Mermista smiled at the young Queen’s boundless enthusiasm. She was glad to see Glimmer getting back to some of her old self, her real self- eager, passionate, friendly- now that the stress of near-death was dying down.

“Hey, Mermista, could I grab you a sec?” Adora was shifting from foot to foot. Mermista nodded, a bit confused, and gestured for her to follow her into the residence.

“What’s up, dude?” She started heading for her bedroom to grab a bathing suit.

“Catra wanted to know if she could stop over at some point before her service starts and go over expectations, schedules, where she’ll be staying… she’s kind of terrified.”

Mermista grimaced internally at the thought of Catra being anywhere near her, but she knew she had to get over it. Long-term community service had been a hit with the delegates and representatives, even Peekablue, so like or not the furball was here to stay for a bit.

“Why not today?” she opened her bedroom door, making sure that, while messy, there was nothing…unseemly left out for anyone to see. There wasn’t, and their room was actually cleaner than not, for once. “Maevik has a clear schedule, and if I don’t give him something to do he’ll insist on tailing me around, and I’d rather he get to relax a bit.”

“R-really?” Adora leaned against the closer door while Mermista rummaged through her bathing suits. She hadn’t worn one in public since…well, years, now. One, she wasn’t sure which still fit just the way she wanted to. Two, her scarring was giving her a bit of pause. The angry, clawed webbing left behind by the chip was fading, but still visible along her shoulders, her neck, down her back a bit. And while her spinal surgery scar was small, and the stitching was gone, it was still *there* . Not to mention the other scars she’d accumulated over the years, and finally had ample time to linger over…

“-ista?”

She shook herself, and realized that she’d been holding her once favorite bathing suit for a few long seconds now, and staring off into space. Adora had pushed off the door, coming to stand near her peripheral- not behind her. Was she that obvious?

“Y-yeah, what? Sorry, I was…” She was what? Having a weird quasi-flashback in her massive walk in closet with her kind-of-mad-at-her-but-also-not friend clearly trying to talk to her?

“It’s okay,” Adora just smiled, understanding and sad. “I get them, too. Things that should be fine…they’re not. And it’s never when I expect, so I’m never ready…”

Mermista’s first instinct was to wall-off, shut down, and deflect quickly. But, against all her desires, she didn’t do that. Instead, she took a breath and nodded. “Yeah. It’s not as bad as I thought it would be. Or, maybe I’m still in shock, actually. Gods know Sebastian is…”

“Do you still want to go to the beach?” Adora tilted her head. “I’m the last person who’s gonna lecture you on relaxing.”

Mermista chuckled lightly. “Yeah, fair. I…wanna try.”

“Cool,” Adora grinned.

“Hey, ‘Dora… are we, like, okay?”

The blonde blinked and flushed. “We are! I swear-”

“Listen,” Mermista held up a hand. “It’s…okay if we’re not. I’d just rather you be honest with me instead of letting this, y’know, fester or whatever.”

“I…thank you,” Adora seemed to deflate, leaning against the doorframe. “I’m just- everything’s *hard* right now, even though it’s all supposed to be easy now? According to Glimmer and Bow? But it’s not so there must be something *wrong* , with me, or them, or- or everything…”

“Hey,” Mermista caught her eyes. “Life doesn’t *have to* be anything right now. We’re all…lost. War, conflict, stress- it’s all we’ve ever known. Just, I dunno, let yourself feel what you’re feeling, happy or ugly, I guess. This is all Perfuma’s thing, honestly-”

“No, no, that’s…it’s nice to know I’m not alone.” Adora mustered a smile. “And I guess right now, I’m not, uh, ‘okay’ with anyone- not even myself.”

Mermista frowned, and set about changing. She and Adora had shared plenty of medical tents and sleeping quarters during the war, and it wasn’t like Mermista was shy, per say. “What about Catra?”

“Oh- uh- yeah, psh, *obviously* -”

“Adora,” Mermista cast her a Look over her shoulder. “Don’t bullshit me. What am I gonna do? Judge you for relationship bumps? You saw what we went through.”

Adora laughed a bit. “Yeah, alright. That’s fair.”

“Listen. It’s okay to not be okay- *ugh* ! That’s such a lame line. Whatever. Just, if you wanna talk, well, you know where I live, duh. Or Sea Hawk, even. He’s, like, shockingly good at all this shit.”

“Emotions?”

“Yeah, whatever.”

Mermista smiled as Adora laughed again. “Thanks, Merms. I wanna be okay with everyone, and that’s…that’s gotta count for something, right?”

“Eh, probably a lot more than you think.”

She turned, and Adora nodded approvingly. "You look good!"

"Thanks," Mermista blushed- c'mon, emotionally damaged dork or not, Adora was still She-Ra. And, like, shredded. "You better go get dressed. Send my alleged better half up here when you see him- there are some rules to go over. And then I guess, uh, feel free to head down to the water. I'll meet you there soon."

Adora flashed her a thumbs up. "On it, Merms."

She vanished out of the bedroom, and Mermista took the chance to give herself a once over in the mirror. Her skin wasn't as loose and sallow as it had been a month ago, Sea Hawk had seen to that with protein-rich meals around the clock, and her ribs were no longer visible. Her curves weren't quite where they'd been, but hey- progress or whatever.

The bikini she'd picked was…minimalist was probably the politest word. It was just the Alliance on her private beach, she saw no need for anything modest. The whole thing was hand-crocheted from a small shop that had once frequented the bazaar, a soft muted blue like the sky on a soon-to-be-stormy day. The top was a simple triangle tie without a lower edge, covering the sides of her tits but not the bottoms. The bottom was basic, but the ties on the side were jeweled, not strings, that curved up over her hips. She turned this way and that, moved a bit, making sure everything stayed where it should. Satisfied, she turned, only to be pressed up against the wall by her husband.

Mermista moaned into the kiss he crushed to her lips, grabbing for his hair, his shoulders, anything she could get. His calloused hands skimmed her waist, her hips, and she sighed when he grabbed handfuls of her ass, lifting her up until she could hike her legs around his waist. His arousal, separated from her only by the thin fabric of his sleep pants, and the tiny swath of bikini between her legs, pressed against her, and she gasped softly. He took the chance to sweep his tongue past her lips, and it wasn't long before she was rolling her hips against him, looking for some sort of friction.

His hands left her ass to cup her tits, squeezing just enough to leave her groaning. "I haven't seen this one in ages," he murmured.

"I haven't worn it since before Dad left."

"It's twice as lovely now as it was then," he kissed his way down her jaw.

She grinned. "Just lovely? Lame."

"Gorgeous," he corrected, punctuating each word with a tiny nip to the sensitive skin around her gills. "Sexy. Maddening. *Stunning-*"

"S-shut up," she groaned, though the effect was dampened by her clear arousal. "You have to get dressed and we need to go."

He pressed closer to her, and his kisses became less fervent, and more caressing. “We haven’t been apart in months, Mermista…”

“We’ve spent days alone,” she soothed, running softer fingers through his hair. “It’ll be just like that.”

“But we’ve always shared a bed at the end of the night. And I’ve always known you were nearby if I- if you-”

“I know, babe,” she raised his head up with a gentle finger under his chin. “But we’ll be okay. We probably both need this.”

Sea Hawk just pouted, pressing more kisses to her fingers, her wrist, trying to distract her.

“You’re telling me you don’t want to go get drunk and light something on fire?” She smirked, mildly disbelieving.

“Not if I don’t get to come home and ride the adrenaline high with you,” he ducked and pressed a kiss to the swell of her breast. “The best parts of those nights are always the sex we have after.”

Mermista groaned. Damn, if he wasn’t right. Sea Hawk was a *beast* on an adrenaline high, and they hadn’t had fun like that since- well, since their first wedding night, honestly. He’d walk in the room like he owned it, smelling of woodsmoke and bad, probably illegal, choices, and pick her up off of the couch, her desk chair, whatever. The way he'd toss her on the bed, tear his shirt off and bandana off, and bind her hands. Usually he flipped her over, pressed her face into the mattress while he rode her until she was a shaking, screaming mess, making her come over and over again. With each orgasm, his confidence grew, knowing he could play her as well as his fiddle, move with her easier than the sea. He knew her body better than any ship or blade- she was his passion, he'd said once, and had proven it over and over.

Great. Now she was soaked, and would have nothing to show for it. Reluctantly, she unhooked her legs and dropped to her own feet. "We can't…"

He sighed, and pressed one last kiss to her lips. "I know, love."

"What are you gonna wear?" She tried to distract herself with helping him get ready, and eventually the throbbing between her legs died down enough to actually focus. His blue jacket was still in tatters (for now- she planned on having it mended as one of her wedding gifts), so he grabbed a beige cotton shirt with a deep, laced vee instead of a boob window, black leather pants, his usual thigh-high work boots with the matching belt and sword holster, and a long leather great coat in navy. The trimmings were gold, captaincy emblems, to match the light embroidery that traced it. He slipped on fingerless sailing gloves, and lashed his usual bandana around his head to push back his fringe- he'd need a trim before the wedding.

"Satisfactory?" He spun in a small circle, and she nodded approvingly.

“Very regal,” she smoothed the front of his coat and shirt. “My King.”

He blushed very prettily at that, ducking his head sheepishly, and she smirked. “Was aiming for pirate…”

“Pirate King,” she shrugged.

“I think there’s already one of those…” his eyes grew distant as he pondered that, and she rolled her own.

“ *My* Pirate King, then,” she sighed. He grinned, refocusing and very pleased.

“Have you settled on my titles yet?”

“Wouldn’t you like to know?” She stuck her tongue out, and he leaned down to kiss it. “Sea Hawk!”

“I can’t help it!” He laughed, wrapping her in a hug. “You’re too… *mmph!* ”

She grinned as he squeezed her tight, face buried in his clavicle. It was just a few (long) hours without him, she'd be fine…right? The idea of him not being within reach was making anxiety dance along her spine, hot and prickly. Sea Hawk's hug softened into something deeper, and she snaked her arms under his coat to wrap around his waist. "I'll, like, miss you."

"And I'll miss you, my Queen."

Her heart fluttered obnoxiously. "Dork."

He just hummed, swaying them gently. Mermista was always shocked at how utterly relaxed she was in Sea Hawk's presence- she was probably the only person on earth who could say that. All too soon, they pulled apart, sparing each other one more lingering kiss before leaving the bedroom and parting ways. Sea Hawk was headed right for the main halls, while she would use their private balcony steps to get to the beach. Before she left, she called for one of her handmaids, and a young naiad girl, nervous as hell, padded into the room a few moments later.

Mermista handed her the list she'd scrawled. "Would you mind running this down to the kitchens for me? Let them know I'll be out on the beach with the Alliance."

The girl's eyes widened. "The other Princesses are here?"

“Mhm,” Mermista smiled slightly. “Would you like to help the kitchens bring out the snacks and drinks?”

“Oh, yes, please, your Majesty!” The girl grinned.

“See you in a bit, then.”

She left, and Mermista grabbed a sarong from the basket of light, beachy linens that had become a permanent fixture by the balcony doors, tying it about her hips and grabbing her beach bag before heading down the steps.

On the beach, Spinnerella and Netossa had joined the others, and grinned widely when they saw her. “Girl! You look *great* !”

She accepted Spinnerella’s hug and Netossa’s side-jostle with a small laugh. “So do you! How are things?”

Everyone was laying on beach towels under umbrellas, and Mermista spread her own out between Perfuma and Adora, who’d left a space for her. They shot the shit for a long time, catching up on everything in ways they couldn’t during Alliance meetings with the oppressive weight of their Kingdoms on their shoulders.

“-and *then* ,” Mermista leaned in, grinning when the others copied her. “She corners me in front of Sea Hawk and Maevik-”

" *No* -"

" *Yes* ," she shook Perfuma's knee for emphasis. "And goes 'I made you an appointment with the healers since you obviously need professional help'-"

" *Shut. Up!"* Glimmer's jaw was practically in the sand, half-incredulous, half-horrified, entirely amused.

"So I told her that the last thing we needed was any sort of help in bed, aaaaaand then I fired her."

The others dissolved into laughter and shocked gasps. Adora's eyes were bulging out of her head. "You can just do that?!"

"She's the Queen," Netossa waved her off. "Merms can do what she wants!"

"I didn't feel, like, *good* about it," she rolled her eyes. "But everyone needs to get off my dick about getting knocked up."

She flopped back onto her towel, and Perfuma patted her knee sympathetically. "I hear you. I've had several inquiries of varying politeness made about my…fertility."

“Join the club,” Glimmer groaned. Adora patted her sympathetically on the shoulder.

“We don’t get asked anymore,” Spinnerella smirked. “Netossa scared the shit out of the courts years ago.”

“Tell me,” Mermista demanded. “For my own sanity.”

“Oh,” Netossa demurred slightly. “It wasn’t anything…too bad. Some nosy council member just kept pressing and pressing, asking me and Spinny all sorts of intrusive questions- who’s going to carry, how are you going to go about it, do you need a donor, on and on- and one day, he did it in front of the Alliance. Well, what remained of it at that point. And I don’t quite remember what I did or said-”

“Because you blacked out in rage.” Spinnerella smiled slightly.

Netossa nodded. “Right, yes. But when all was said and done, the dude immediately resigned his position, apologized, and left. And no one ever bothered us again.”

Mermista was grinning unabashedly. “Oh, I can’t wait to try that.”

Next to her, Perfuma tilted her head. “Could I ask you guys something…personal?”

“Is anything really TMI at this point?” Netossa raised a brow. “We’ve been through everything together.”

They all shared soft smiles and nods. It was true. They were more than an Alliance, they were family. Sisters in arms and peace. “Why…don’t you have a kid?”

Spinnerella shrugged. “It seemed irresponsible during the war, honestly. We were always running around, on mission- we barely saw each other for some stretches of time. How would we have time to, like, grow and raise a whole other person? And governesses help, sure, but we didn’t want them to not ever know us.”

“That makes sense,” Glimmer smiled. “I would feel bad leaving a baby with a sitter, like, all the time…”

“Well, you’ll have to get a bit used to it when the time comes,” Netossa smiled sadly. “Being Queens, rulers, whatever… your mom hated doing it, but she spent so much of her day running around that it wasn’t fair to you. Babies need, like, sleep. A lot of it. And regular feedings. Going from meeting to councils to whatever else makes all that hard.”

Mermista frowned. “There are always babies at meetings here. Or, there were during the last baby boom when I was, like, a teenager. And I remember getting passed around a bunch when I was little at all sorts of meetings.”

“Salineas has always been more like Plumeria in that,” Perfuma nodded. “Baby-wearing is big, breastfeeding is publicly normal, even cross-nursing is common in both nations.”

“Really!” Glimmer’s eyes were wide. “None of those things are, like, a thing in Bright Moon.”

“Be a trend setter,” Perfuma smiled. “Baby wearing is so nice…”

“What are those things?” Adora tilted her head.

“Baby-wearing is, like, when you wrap the kid in a sling or carrier and walk around with them,” Mermista explained. “It’s comforting, or whatever. And I’m assuming you know what breastfeeding is…?”

“It feels self explanatory,” Netossa snorted.

“Uh, sure…” Adora blinked. “They definitely covered that in the Horde.”

Mermista blinked. “Ah. Right.”

“Those things on your chest?” Netossa pointed to Adora’s simple wrap bathing suit. The blonde blushed and placed a hand over her chest. “Yeah. If you get pregnant, they make milk, and a baby eats that milk, via your nips.”

“That sounds horrific,” Adora blinked. “Uh, no offense.”

“Hey, it’s not for everyone,” Perfuma smiled. “There are lots of options.”

“Hell, *babies* aren’t for everyone,” Mermista shrugged. “No shame in it.”

“I thought you wanted kids?” Spinnerella tilted her head.

“I do, now. I didn’t for a really long time.”

Adora nodded. “What changed?”

“Uh, lots of things, or whatever,” Mermista deflected. “Hey, here comes, like, drinks and food.”

The Princesses stood and made room for the food and drinks that Mermista's staff brought out, nodding and thanking everyone. The girl from earlier looked utterly starstruck by the time she was leaving, but had never been anything other than polite. Mermista would have to keep an eye on her, see if she'd like a promotion.

They settled back down, glasses of sangria in hand and plates of food on the sand in front of them.

"To Mermista," Netossa held her glass up. "Finally getting her shit together and marrying her pyromaniac hunk."

She rolled her eyes as everyone cheered and clinked glasses. A few sips in, Netossa was giving her a *loaded* look. "Oh gods, what?"

"So, tell us… what's that lunatic like in bed?"

Mermista *flushed* as the others exchanged interested glances. "You don't-"

"Oh we do," Glimmer smirked. "C'mon, you gotta admit- you two don't make a lot of sense on the outside. It's about time we got all the details!"

She groaned, and took a long, deep sip of her wine. "Sea Hawk… is a fucking animal."

The other women cheered, jostling one another. Even Adora was looking more than politely interested.

“Go oooooon,” Glimmer smirked.

“Well, what is it you wanna know?” Mermista sipped more sangria. “It’s a vague question.”

“Who’s in charge?” Netossa smirked.

“Depends,” she answered on reflex, and watched everyone’s jaw drop. “Uh, what?”

“I can’t see you…listening to Sea Hawk!” Glimmer chuckled. “Is he…I mean…”

“I’m still a brat,” Mermista snorted. “But he can be…convincing.”

The other women ‘oooooh!’ed in delight, and she rolled her eyes. Adora, fidgeting slightly with her towel, cleared her throat. “Uh, while we’re on the topic, what’s it…like? Your first time?”

It was a miracle they didn't all sprain their necks as they snapped to look at their savior. Spinnerella blinked politely. "Have you never…ever?"

"Fraternizing is strictly not permitted in the Horde barracks," Adora shrugged. "And when I left there was a whole war to worry about."

"I'm starting to understand some of your tension issues," Perfuma murmured.

"Plus, she's a Princess," Glimmer shrugged awkwardly. "Technically she's not supposed to…you know."

"Oh, fuck that," Mermista waved her off. "I've slept with, like, more than a few people since I came of age."

"Sea Hawk wasn't your first?" Glimmer gasped.

She snorted. "Fuck no. And I *definitely* wasn't his. My first was the daughter of one of our wealthiest merchants. She was nice, it was fun, and then we parted ways."

Adora was staring now, blushing much harder. "You…with a girl?"

“Uh, yeah? A few times, actually.”

“Does Sea Hawk know?” Netossa tilted her head.

Now it was Mermista’s turn to blush and look away. “Ohhhh yeah. He knows. And he’s been with plenty of guys, too, so…”

“What was that voice?” Perfuma smirked.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about-”

“Mermista,” Spinnerella smirked. “Has Sea Hawk…seen you with a girl?”

Adora and Glimmer gasped, scandalized. Mermista rolled her eyes internally. She always forgot how prudish Bright Moon could be. She could either deflect and move on or…have a little fun.

She swirled her wine around. “He’s seen me with a couple guys, too.”

“ *Spill!* ” Netossa was practically gagging for more info, leaning over her wife’s shoulder.

“Back before I had to take the throne, when we were first fooling around- courting- whatever- we used to go clubbing, like, *a lot* . And a couple of the clubs were… well, they weren’t just for dancing. Sea Hawk had been to parties like that before, and been with multiple partners at once, so one night we just, y’know, didn’t turn down the offer. No one recognized me back then because my dad kept me, like, locked away in the castle to train and study for years, so no one really looked twice.”

“W-what did you, like, do?” Glimmer’s face was bright red, but she was clearly desperate to know more. Mermista shrugged.

“Everything, honestly. He’d fuck me while others watched, we’d fuck other people together, or vice versa. The best night was, um,” she glanced around the beach and leaned in. “Some tyrosaur was railing Hawk while he fucked me, and I had some girl riding my face- one of the best orgasms of my life, honestly.”

Netossa and Spinnerella looked ready to throw her a party, while Perfuma cleared her throat. “Mermista, my gods-”

“What?” She scowled. “We always used protection with others. Don’t be a prude. Besides, you have no room to judge with your- what are they called? Spring Bloom Festivals? Fertility Fairs?”

“That’s different!” Perfuma spluttered.

“Bitch, that’s an orgy.”

“What’s that?” Adora’s eyes were pingponging between the two of them.

“It’s a sex party.” Netossa polished off her sangria while Adora choked on hers. “You can swap partners, take multiple, watch, help others… it can be fun if that’s what you’re into. Spinny and I have been to a few in our day.”

“Those years are well behind us,” Spinnerella snorted, and Netossa nodded wholeheartedly.

“Yeah, I don’t know if we’d ever get back there either,” Mermista stretched. “I don’t like sharing much anymore.”

“Awwwww,” Perfuma and Glimmer sighed.

“Ugh, whatever,” she rolled her eyes. “Glimmer, have you and Bow fucked yet?”

The younger queen had been taking a sip of wine, and it ended up sprayed across the sand as she choked. Adora thumped her on the back, hard, until she could catch her breath.

“We, uh…we’re getting there,” Glimmer blushed. “It’s…I dunno. We’ve been friends our whole lives! It’s hard to take that next step."

"Same here," Adora whispered, hugging herself.

The rest of them shared a sympathetic glance. Netossa spoke up first. "It is hard, you're right. Just go at the pace you feel best with. And, honestly, don't be afraid to laugh."

"Huh?" Glimmer tilted her head.

"She's right," Perfuma shrugged. "Sex is silly, honestly. It's fun, and exhilarating, but bodies are funny."

"They're gonna make weird noises, and do weird things, and look nothing like you've imagined," Mermista chuckled. "And it's a scary situation for everyone when it's a mutual first time. So, don't be afraid to just, like, acknowledge that."

"The first time Spinnerella went down on me-"

"Oh gods," the Wind Princess buried her face in her hands. "Not this!"

"Hush, it's hilarious," her wife wrapped her arms around her. "The first time she was, y'know, down there, she um…stretched me a bit too wide and I uh…well, my body made a *very* unsexy noise, very loudly. And I laughed so hard we had to stop and it totally killed the mood."

Mermista and Perfuma laughed themselves sore at that, while Glimmer and Adora seemed to relax a bit at the ridiculous anecdote.

"One of my earliest times," Perfuma wiped away a tear. "I, um, came so hard that all the trees around us exploded in this spray of pollen and blossoms that could be seen for *miles* . So everyone knew when we got back to the village sneezing and coughing and runny-eyes. And that was *humiliating* at the time."

"There was one night, a couple of years ago, before the Siege," Mermista cleared her throat. "We were on the edge of the bed, and I was in Sea Hawk's lap, like, riding him. We were getting really into it, getting loud, talking dirty, and…" she paused to collect herself. "He started smacking my ass, hard, and I guess at one point, he, like, totally missed-"

Netossa barked a laugh while Perfuma covered her mouth with her hands. "Oh, no…"

"Uh-huh," she snorted. "He slapped himself full force in the balls, *so hard* that he doubled over and fell off the bed. And to this day I have never let him forget it."

Glimmer was howling with laughter now, and even Adora was wiping tears away. "So, it's like…going to be kind of stupid?"

"Oh, yeah," Netossa nodded. "Making those memories with your partner is more than half the fun sometimes."

"Sex, like, isn't just about the orgasm," Mermista shrugged. "It's about being close with your partner, and sharing moments and parts of yourself with them that you wouldn't with anyone else."

"Even if you don't finish your first time," Perfuma smiled gently. "It will be special and amazing because it'll be with someone you care about deeply. The rest will come as you go."

"Literally," Netossa smirked.

"Thanks, guys," Adora smiled shyly.

"Alright now that we've all bonded or whatever, can we swim?" Mermista stretched. "I'm baking alive."

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Swimming was wonderful, dinner on Bright Moon's bay was amazing and refreshing and delicious, and Mermista was feeling very relaxed as they wrapped up around sunset.

“What should we do now?” Glimmer glanced around at them. “We’ve got hours before we have to head back to the castle.”

“We could hit up a bar?” Netossa shrugged. Mermista nodded enthusiastically. She hadn’t been to a good bar in, like, pitifully long. “Suggestions?”

“Fish Eye Diamond in Crow’s Point is a good starter bar,” she shrugged, turning to Adora, Glimmer, and Perfuma. “I’m operating under the assumption that none of y’all have been to a bar.”

“We fished Sea Hawk out of one the first time we met you,” Glimmer smiled.

“That tracks.”

“The Grotto was really my only experience like that,” Perfuma looked a bit apprehensive. “But I’m game for anything.”

“This place is chill, I promise,” Mermista soothed her. “Dancing and drinks. No fights or brawls or pirates or thieves. The most scandalous thing that happens there is bathroom hookups, and that’s, like, bar standard.”

“Alright,” Perfuma smiled a bit. “I trust you.”

“Adora, you good to keep drinking?” Spinnerella eyed their token lightweight.

“Yeah!” She grinned, well past tipsy but not quite drunk yet. “This stuff is great. I want more of whatever that was.”

Mermsita glanced at what remained of her drink. “Ask the bartender for a Bay Breeze. Trust me, you’ll love it.”

“Alright!”

Glimmer teleported them all to the nicer end of Sea Worthy’s peninsula, nicknamed Crow’s Point by the locals. It was where the elite and their children tended to take their yachts and boats for dinner on the water when traveling between Salineas and the mainland. Shockingly, the area was booming, bustling with shoppers and families and revelers and diners all over the place.

Mermista led them to the bar, a massive structure with several levels, each slammed with people. The lowest level, below them, was also where people parked boats before heading up to get a drink, and she did a double take at the familiar sails sitting in the harbor. She deliberated only a moment before smirking, keeping her mouth shut.

They walked up to the main bair on the ground level, the biggest area in the building. It sprawled out onto decks and balconies with beautiful ocean views, not that Mermista could see them from here through the throng of people. She grabbed the bartender's attention, who all but sprinted over when she realized that the entirety of the Alliance was waiting at the bar.

“Good evening, your Majesties,” she bowed politely, grinning. “What can I get started for you tonight?”

“Put it under my usual tab-”

“Hell no, bitch! This is *your* bachelorette party!” Spinnerella cut her off firmly. “Put this under *our* tab, and don’t accept any of her money.”

“Hey!” Mermista laughed, touched. “Thank you, seriously.”

“Don’t even think on it, girl!” Netossa smirked. “Our treat.”

“In that case, let me get a glass of the house sangria, and shots for all of us?”

The bartender nodded and grinned, grabbed everyone else's orders, and had the drinks out in record time. They saluted, tapped their shot glasses, and downed them quickly. Perfuma grimaced at the burn, while Adora looked downright revolted. Glimmer just licked her lips. "I liked that! What was it?"

"Vodka, straight," Mermista grinned. "I like you, Sparkles, you're fun."

Glimmer blushed happily at that. "Awww, Mista! You're sweet when you're drunk."

"Oh, girl, I'm barely even tipsy," she grinned. "You'll *know* I'm drunk when I start hugging."

They all laughed, and chatted for a while before Glimmer and Spinnerella decided to hit the dancefloor, while Netossa tried to teach Perfuma and Adora how to properly take a shot (with water, thank gods). Mermista polished off her sangria, and went to go peruse the whiskey options when she finally spotted her prey.

She sidled up to the bar, keeping her RBF forward and impassive as she squeezed in next to him. Sea Hawk was facing forward, tapping an empty whiskey glass on the bar in a jaunty rhythm. He smelled of woodsmoke, sea salt, and sweat, and she licked her lips hungrily. The bartender slid a new whiskey to him and turned to her. "What'll it be?"

"Honey bourbon on the rocks, please." Next to her, her husband stiffened, her voice giving her away almost instantly. Instead of turning to her, though, he stayed facing forward. Mermista eyed him curiously as the bartender left.

“Evening,” he drawled, still not looking at her. “What brings you to Crow’s Point?”

Mermista smirked slightly. “Um, none of your business?”

“Oh-ho-ho,” Sea Hawk chuckled. “Pardon me for making conversation with a beautiful woman.”

“You’re sweet, but,” she flicked her hair over her shoulder. “I’m married.”

“Oh, come now,” he smirked. “That only means as much as you want it to, gorgeous.”

The bartender brought her drink over, and she nodded her thanks before taking a long, slow pull. It burned her throat, but soothed it too, and Mermista felt the liquid fire start to warm her cheeks. “And what do you want it to mean?”

She angled to face him now, and he did the same. His eyes flashed as he took her in, and Mermista crowed internally; she’d raided his closet and snatched a couple of things for her outfit, and it was certainly paying off. She wore a sleeveless, shoulderless, black leather corset top that did wonderful things for her chest, tight black slacks, and heeled boots. Dark eye make up, hoops, black lipstick, and a low, artfully messy bun tied back by his signature red bandana completed her femme fatale look.

Sea Hawk most definitely wanted to eat her alive.

“So,” she demurred. “What’s a guy like you doing around here? You look more like a pirate than a tourist.”

“I could say the same about you, ma’am,” he stepped closer, invading her personal space, but kept his hands to himself. “Walking around in all that leather.”

“Bold of you to comment what I walk around in,” she sneered, rolling her eyes. If he wanted to play, she wasn’t going to half-ass it.

He just laughed. “My apologies, my lady-”

“Not your lady.”

“No? But we’ve met before, danced before, talked and loved before!” He cajoled, spreading his arms. Was he giving up that easily?

“Uhhhhh…we have?”

“Certainly,” he winked, stepping closer. She took a small half step back. “In your dreams, of course.”

She groaned and rolled her eyes, but took a fast sip to hide her tiny smile. “You call that game?”

“It’s always worked for me before.” Sea Hawk grinned and took another step. Her back met the bar, and he crowded closer, leaning down to whisper in her ear. “Of course, if the lady abhors my presence, I am fully capable of taking my leave from her.”

Her hand reached out and snagged the fabric of his shirt. “Well, she wouldn’t exactly say *abhor* …”

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Glimmer was working up a sweat with Spinny on the dancefloor when she collided with a very chiseled, very familiar, and very… burnt? chest.

“Bow!”

“Glimmer!”

Her boyfriend wrapped her in a hug that lifted her off her feet and she laughed delightedly. “What are you doing here?”

“We’ve been here for like an hour! Scorpia and Frosta are on the top floor where there’s mocktails for her to drink and a few less people, and Sea Hawk and I have been hanging out down here! What are you doing here?”

“Netossa mentioned a bar and Mermista suggested this place!” She pecked his lips as he set her back down on her feet. “How was your day of adventures?”

“It was *so cool!* ” Bow grinned. “We raced some other pirates and we *won* , and then blew up an old Horde tanker that beached off some islands, and Sea Hawk let us all try steering the ship and sailing!”

“You blew up a ship?” Glimmer smirked and raised an eyebrow. “Did you fulfill all your pirate fantasies?”

“It was awesome,” Bow’s eyes were sparkling. “The fire was so *big!* And it felt so freeing!”

“Damn,” she laughed. “Guess I’ll have to steal Sea Hawk next time, I could always stand to blow off some steam.”

“Bow!” Adora found them, now thoroughly drunk as she stumbled into the archer’s hug. “You found us!”

“I did! And totally by accident,” he laughed. “Hey- where is Mermista? And Sea Hawk? I lost him like ten minutes ago.”

Glimmer frowned and scanned the crowd for blue hair, or a mustache, and came up empty- wait!

“Is that them?”

Bow followed her pointed finger and gasped, a choked, scandalized sound, confirming her question. That most certainly was Mermista and Sea Hawk pressed up against the bar, flirting *hard* with one another. Their faces weren’t even an inch apart, and when they spoke their lips seemed to brush. Sea Hawk had one hand on Mermista’s hip, the other wrapped around a glass of whiskey. Mermista’s own hands and glass were resting on the pirate’s chest, playing with the collar of his jacket.

“I’ve never seen her so…”

“Happy?” Bow tilted his head.

“Not quite,” Glimmer tapped her lip. “She was happy after we unchipped her. This is something else.”

“Content,” Adora said with surprising clarity. “She’s comfortable, for once.”

And that was it, wasn’t it? Mermista seemed to have fully let her guard down, and it was almost like looking at a totally different person.

“Sea Hawk, too,” Bow mused. “He’s…steady. Not calm, for sure. But…”

“Yeah,” Glimmer nodded. “He’s relaxed.”

Their usually explosive, hairpin-trigger, dramatic pirate was, well, still. His fingers didn’t twitch, his legs weren’t shaking, he wasn’t vibrating out of his skin or running around. He looked utterly at peace in Mermista’s presence, confident and grinning. He leaned in, murmuring something in her ear, and they watched, gobsmacked, as their normally cranky friend threw her head back and laughed, full-bodied and bright.

“Awwww!” Bow sighed. “They’re so *cute* !”

“I don’t think I could ever call Mermista cute again after today,” Adora’s eye twitched. “You think Sea Hawk is wild? Mermista’s insane.”

Glimmer made an agreeing noise in the back of her throat, but her eyes were still focused on the couple across the room. They touched one other with natural ease, like the other person was an extension of themselves. There was no pauses, or blushing, or stumbles or apologies. Sea Hawk snagged one of the belt loops of Mermista's pants and tugged her closer, starting to lead her to the dancefloor, and she just rolled her eyes and let him.

She wanted that ease. She wanted to touch Bow like that, casually and sensually, like it was nothing and everything all at once.

Maybe she'd cancel the sleepover tonight.

Mermista and Sea Hawk were behaving oddly, though. He wasn't smiling quite as naturally as he usually did, and she seemed almost…demure. Flirtatious but cautious. Which was maybe a bit of a ridiculous claim as they joined the crowded masses of people dancing to the bass-heavy, electronic sounding music from Dryl, and began dancing *very* sexually. But it was true. Even when Mermista wound her arms behind her, and dragged Sea Hawk down into a filthy, obscene kiss that had her, Bow, and Adora blushing, there was a wall there.

"Is it just me," Bow coughed. "Or are they being…different?"

"Thank god, I thought I was going crazy." Glimmer exhaled in relief.

“It’s like they’re pretending to be strangers,” Adora observed, sipping her drink. “When Mermista first walked up to Sea Hawk, they didn’t hug or anything. It was…tense.”

“Wait,” Glimmer snorted. “That’s kind of hilarious. Think this is part of the game?”

Bow swallowed audibly as Sea Hawk grabbed Mermista’s hips hard, muttering in her ear, and rolled their bodies together. Mermista bit her lip, spinning around and fisting her hand in the fabric of a now smirking Sea Hawk’s shirt. They watched her pull him off the dance floor and in the direction of…somewhere.

“I have no idea,” he coughed. “And I’m definitely not going to ask.”

They returned ten minutes later, looking no different or less put together when they rejoined the dancing. They had new drinks, and that easy, comfortable air about them remained, so Glimmer assumed they'd gone up to the other, less crowded bar for some alone time. Still, she was nervous when she tugged Mermista aside to whisper in her ear. As gracefully and normally as she could, she asked Mermista if she wouldn’t mind skipping the sleepover. Glimmer knew she was blushing, and glancing very obviously at Bow. Mermista grinned wolfishly.

“Girl,” she placed both hands on Glimmer’s shoulders. “I give you my every blessing to go have the night of your *life* .”

Glimmer laughed, loud and bright, and a grin spread across her friend's dark-stained lips. They hugged tightly, and it wasn’t long before the rest of the Alliance joined in, jostling and yelling and just being… *happy* .

Fairytale ending, indeed.

Chapter End Notes

> hope you enjoyed! next chapter coming much sooner i promise

dressed like a fucking queen

Chapter Summary

Sea Hawk's coronation

Chapter Notes

second to last chapter y'all! lots of lore, lots of love, lots of Hawk. hope you enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was four days until the wedding, and Sea Hawk was *freaking* . But quietly! If Mermista figured out that he was having a long-form panic attack, it would more than likely send her over the edge as well. For everyone’s sake, that was best avoided. Though, really, who could blame him? He’d be setting off for his coronation trial this very evening, and the kingdom itself seemed to be holding its breath.

“Your Majesty, you really *must* hold still.”

“S-sorry!” He yelped, forcing his hands to still. The henna artist smiled in sympathy.

“Nervous?”

“How could you tell?” He chuckled self-deprecatingly.

“You know,” the young girl, maybe sixteen, but the best at her craft in the capital and hand-picked by Mermista, leaned in conspiratorially. “We all think it’s sweet, how nervous you and the Queen are considering that you’re…well.”

“Already wed?”

“Yes, that.”

Sea Hawk laughed a bit more at that, watching the deep brown ink flow across his skin. “It’s more nerves about doing all the everything else properly, I think. I’m not nervous to marry Mermista, she’s… well, she’s the most incredible person I’ve ever met, y’know? I’m nervous I’ll do something wrong and have it fall on her- make *her* look bad. Mermista’s worked so hard to earned everyone’s respect, and I cannot be the person who ruins that.”

“I assure you, my King, you won’t be,” the girl shook her head. “I don’t think there’s a force on earth that could sway the people’s opinion of the Queen. Those who still dislike her now always will, and there’s no sense wasting your energy concerning yourself with bigots and losers.”

“Well said!” He laughed. “You’re quite smart. What’s your name again?”

“Li’in,” she smiled. “Thank you for asking. How are preparations of the island going?”

“The island we’ll be wed on- Vi’ahan- is all set. It was untouched by the war, being almost completely hidden by mangroves and half-sunken, so there was minimal preparation save for decor.”

“We’re all so excited,” Li’in beamed. “A festival is just what we all need to regroup, I think. Erm,” she blushed. “If I may give my two cents.”

“Please do!” He nodded. “The peoples’ opinion is always the most important to us.”

Li’in smiled shyly, and went back to her work. Mermista was having her henna done tomorrow, as they weren’t technically permitted to see one another’s designs until the ceremony. With the coronation that evening, though, some rules were going to be bent and worked around. He’d wear sleeves to hide most of it, and she would wait until after her public appearance to be marked.

As she worked, Li’in pointed out to him where she’d hidden Mermista’s name, or rather, her ancient Salinean sigil, his own name in Icsarin runes, their official anniversary date, and other important imagery- the Pearl, scales, lines that waved like flames in between the symmetrical, intricate patterns, bird wings. It was hours before she was done, but Sea Hawk was so enthralled watching the artistry that the time flew by.

“Try not to move for the next half-hour, and then take care not to rest your arms or hands on anything,” Li’in instructed as she packed up. “The henna will itch as it flakes off, but try to let it fall away naturally. If some parts stick, you can dust them off gently. Queen Mermista will be able to help you out.”

“Thank you, Li’in,” he bowed respectfully. “Enjoy the festival.”

“Congratulations, my King.”

She left, and Sea Hawk sat still for all of twenty minutes before he stood and stretched gently. He decided to walk the halls, and see what befell him- he doubted he’d get further than the main level before being accosted. However, to his eternal delight, it seemed everyone was too busy running around with last minute ceremony and party preparations to stop him.

He had nothing left to prepare that night, so, he let his feet carry him where they pleased as his mind wandered. His ship was ready with everything he might possibly need within reason. His sword was sharpened. He was ready for sundown. Tonight was the full moon, and at high tide, if all went properly, he’d be crowned for all to see right here- the throne room.

He’d truthfully been avoiding this room like the plague. It was empty for now, and he let the heavy doors fall shut behind him. The two headed eel carpet had been temporarily replaced by one showing the phases of the moon, bordered by depictions of the tide. The bottomless pools that lined the room, and stretched deep, deeper than even the catacombs, were still, even as water fell into them from high above. The coral around the throne had made a full, blooming recovery, and lofted over it all shone the Pearl.

Sea Hawk couldn't honestly say why, but he found himself kneeling, and bowing his head. He'd never been one for prayer, and he had no idea what he was doing, but the anxiety inside of him was mounting, and he was hurting for options to alleviate it.

"Um, hello," he murmured, closing his eyes. "I'm Sea Hawk- er, Sebastian- but you knew that. We've, ah, spoken before…? At my first wedding, which I'm sure you also…recall. Right. Um. My coronation trial is tonight, and I have no idea what I'm doing, and I feel a bit silly but, truthfully, I would love *something* to go off of here. Some sign that I'm not going to totally fuck this up…?"

At first, there was nothing but silence, and he sighed. Just as he was resolving to get to his feet, a sudden warmth washed over him- a summer wave reaching shore. He opened his eyes, and found himself on a white-sand island, nothing but still ocean visible for miles. Above him, stars covered the night sky, and in the distance, an aurora danced like a ribbon.

"Hello?"

No answer. The sand, however, shifted, and revealed a buried chest. Sea Hawk frowned, kneeling to open it. Inside sat mountains of gold, and jewels, but they felt…wrong. Gingerly, he pawed them aside, and unearthed a book sitting inside. He pulled it out and let the chest fall shut. The words inside the journal were written in a language he couldn’t decipher, and the more he tried to read them, the foggier they became. At the very back of the book, though, were legible words in common Etherian.

Polaris. Serpent. Tidepool. Flame.

Leave the gift. Take the wrapping.

Sea Hawk frowned, confused, and then he blinked and he was back in the throne room. The sun had begun to set, sending warm light spilling through the newly repaired stained glass windows of the throne room. He shook his head, groggy, and lifted his eyes to see the throne itself was now occupied.

“Mermista!” He yelped, shoving his hands behind his back, only to realize a cloak had been thrown over him that covered his now dry and flaking arms. “Uh…huh?”

“I received word that the King had vanished a few hours before his coronation trial,” Mermista rose from her seat languidly, regally. “And so I checked the Bond to find it weirdly occupied. Lo and behold, when I came to check the Pearl, I found you here.”

She knelt in front of him, wearing a loose, long sleeved top. “How long was I gone?”

“About two hours. It’s time to get ready.”

Sea Hawk swallowed, shaking. “Alright.”

Mermista led him up to their rooms via the backhalls from the throne room so they wouldn’t be accosted. Once tucked away, she turned as he changed his top. Apparently, they were doing this the traditional way after all. Sea Hawk brushed off some of the flakes that were ready to fall, and slipped into a fine silk sailing shirt- finer than anything he’d ever sailed in. She turned when he was done, and handed him new leather sailing pants, and wrapped a turquoise and gold sash around his waist, knotting it expertly. He slipped into new boots, and stood in the mirror, nodding approvingly.

“I think I’m ready.”

“Not quite yet,” Mermista tugged him away, and in the dimming light of their room, slipped two familiar shoulder braces and neck plate onto his body. He swallowed as she cinched them with ease, and then smoothed her hands down his chest. “The trial is different for everyone. It changes like the tide. This armor kept me safe all through the war, and now, I hope it’ll do the same for you.”

He laid his hands over hers, holding them to his chest. “I’m scared, Mermista.” Whispering it into the dark made it so real, and his heart stuttered.

“Don’t be,” her eyes seemed to glow in the lowlight. “No matter what happens out there, everything will be alright.”

“This feels backwards,” he chuckled.

“Right?” She smirked. “You’re going to be fine, babe. And then tonight, you’ll be crowned…”

“What?” He nudged her, and she shook her head.

“Nothing, nothing,” she sighed. “It’s just…wild. When we met, I thought you were just some fun, rebellious moment in time. A blip, or whatever. And now, I’m going to crown you King.”

Sea Hawk reached up and caressed her cheek with the back of his hand. “You’re the best thing that ever happened to me, Mermista.”

She rolled her eyes, but smiled. “Yeah, well. Ditto.”

“C’mere,” he whispered, tugging her into a gentle kiss. “I love you, dearest.”

“I love you, too,” she whispered back. “Now, let’s go show ‘em what you’re made of.”

Sea Hawk swallowed his fear. “Here goes nothing.”

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Mermista took a deep breath from her spot waiting on the shore. He had launched from the pier ten minutes ago with a wave and a flourish, gripping tightly the trial map he'd been gifted by a rather pinch-faced vizier. Already, his ship was a speck in the distance, the winds at his back, sails glittering in the twilight.

"So," Maevik pressed a warm…something into her hands. Cider, maybe. She had no stomach for it. "Any idea what he's up against?"

"Nope," she sighed. "It's different for everyone, every time."

"He'll be fine," her guard nodded, reassuring them both. "More than fine."

Mermista said nothing, just kept her eyes on the horizon. The Bond was teeming with anxious, but invigorated energy. He was still nervous, but at the helm of his ship, with something to occupy his mind, Sea Hawk was back in control.

C'mon, goober…you can do this.

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Sea Hawk grinned as the sea wind tore at his hair and clothes, making his eyes water and his heart soar. He'd *missed this* - the open ocean, his wheel under his hands, the feeling of his ship underfoot, an extension of his body and will. All his stress and fear fell away, and he finally felt like his old self- confident, ready for what came next, and eager to take whatever it was by the horns.

He'd be even more ready and confident if the map he'd been given wasn't actively disappearing before his eyes. Alas, such was life. With a shrug, he crumpled the paper and shoved it into his pocket. No use in lamenting now- he didn't have time to workshop a solution going this fast in the dark.

Like he'd been taught so many eons ago by his mother and her parents, by Bill and N'Davi, he glanced at the moons, their alignment, and then, as he'd come to learn on his own in a handful of months, located the legendary north star- Polaris- in the sky. Doing the calculations as quickly as he could, the memory of his vision came back.

Polaris, serpent, tidepool, flame.

Step one, done. He'd found Polaris, and had used it to boot. Next…serpent? He mulled it over. There were no sea serpents of note in Salineas' waters, and this trial wasn't to extend beyond the kingdom's borders. There was however…Sea Snake Pass. The most treacherous route one could take in these waters in daylight. Attempting it now would be a fool's suicide.

Sea Hawk grinned, and punched in the approximate coordinates.

In a matter of minutes, the massive, jagged stone monoliths that marked the entrance to the Pass lay before him, and the only sound was that of roaring water. He grit his teeth, rechecked his sail's lines, and steered Dragon's Daughter VI into the breach.

Immediately, Sea Hawk was fighting for his life. With a grunt, he barely kept the wheel in place as it begged to send him flying into the rocks. The sonar on his cruiser told him that the maximum depth below him was four hundred feet, but the maximum depth just twenty feet to either side was maybe forty-five, and would only get shallower. He pressed on. In the dark, his only visuals were his equipment screens and readings, and the rest was up to his ears.

As soon as the wheel slackened, the sensors *screamed* , and he pulled with all his might in the other direction, sending the ship into a vague drift. He missed the rock that had been in his path by less than ten feet, and a shiver laced up his spine. Sea Hawk lost track of the minutes that ticked by as he slalomed from side to side, yanking and holding the wheel as needed while keeping his senses tuned for whatever would come leaping out of the darkness next.

He whooped loudly when he saw the end of the miles long pass, but didn't dare gun it straight- according to the sonar, there was a rocky shelf just ahead of him, and almost no time to dodge it. With a yell, he flipped on the anti-grav fin, and held his breath as the Dragon's Daughter lifted out of the water, up, *up* -

And cleared the rock by a foot.

“YES!” He roared, pumping his fist, adrenaline racing through his veins hot as fire. His fingers twitched with the need for celebratory destruction, but he reined it in. He wasn’t done yet.

The second he left the Pass’ waters, the ocean turned oddly still, like glass. In the same moment, his sonar *screeched* , and he dove for the anti-grav controls, gently lowering his ship back into the water. The sails came down next, and he drifted to an almost unnatural stop. According to his sensors, all around him were sandbars. Shallow stretches of sea floor only *feet* below his ship. With a grimace, he engaged the anti-grav again to give the ship- and himself- a few more inches of wiggle room.

Polaris, still in sight. Check. Serpent, passed. Check. Next, tidepool. The rest of the words- leave the gift, take the wrapping- came back to him.

Well and truly stumped for the moment, Sea Hawk wracked his brain and smoothed his mustache. As he thought, he played with the sensors. The sonar was telling him that the sandbars stopped a few meters away, and then started again. He frowned, zooming out.

The sandbars were forming…pools. Underwater pools. Tidepools.

With a grin and jaunty whistle, Sea Hawk dropped a ladder over the side of his ship and slid down to the watery ground below. The sea only reached mid-calf where he landed, but if he wanted to get to the center of the tidepool, he'd have to dive down below his ship. In the dark. With no visual cues.

Not ideal.

Ah, well. Nothing to it but to do it, as Sea Hawk always said! He sloshed through the water to a stretch of shallow sand, and began walking the winding path it made. The moon climbed higher and higher, and he began to sweat. There was nothing here, and technically the only 'tide'pool was the one his ship was in. The rest were just pools.

Ahhhh- *ha* ! …Fuck.

With a groan, Sea Hawk turned and hiked back to his ship. The odds were, the treasure was directly underneath his ship in the pitch black. Between the lack of light and the fact that the anti-grav fin was on a safety timer, and could drop into the pool and trap him at any moment…he was at a loss. How on Etheria could he remove his ship and light the way at the same time?

Polaris. Serpent. Tidepool… Flame.

There was no way it was that simple. Right?

Sea Hawk's heart began to race, the familiar itch and adrenaline starting to pump through him. It would be easy. The ship was empty of personal effects. He had whiskey and fuel aplenty. The fin's emergency locks would keep the burning wreck above the water. The fire would burn long enough. It wasn't a terrible swim back to shore-only a couple of miles. And in a pinch, he could reach Mermista through the bond.

Righty then! Time to set the thing ablaze.

He clambered back up the ladder, jumping below deck and checking his cabin before grabbing the bottles of whiskey, leaving the fuel supply. It burned slower and brighter, better serving his purpose, and he poured it over the deck generously. Briefly, he mourned its loss, but shrugged in the end.

He slid down the ladder, yanked his headband off, and tied one end of it around a loose stone buried in the sand. He lit the other end with the lighter he kept in his waterproof pouch, and when it caught, lobbed the stone up to the deck, whistling a shanty as he waited for it to light up. Once it did, he waded into the deeper water. By the time he was holding his breath, the ship was ablaze, smoke billowing toward the night sky and providing more than enough light to see into the pool.

Sea Hawk nearly lost his breath in a gasp once he could see what he was working with.

The entire floor of the pool, about twenty feet below him, was covered in pearls. They ranged in size from roughly his fist to his pinky nail, each shining with an internal, ethereal glow. Magic. He shook himself, focusing. Polaris, Serpent, Tidepool, and Flame. Checkity-check across the board.

Leave the gift, take the wrapping.

Obviously, the gift was a pearl. Touching any of these could render the trial over, and failed. Sea Hawk tucked his limbs closer. What was the wrapping? The sand? Seemed a bit of a stretch. Traditionally, the wrapping of a pearl was a clam. So where was the clam producing these pearls?

He swam back up, taking a breath, and tread water as he mulled it over. These pearls were ancient. The clam that had produced them was likely long dead. So maybe there was some other wrapping? Or there was one pearl in specific whose wrapping he had to take?

Sea Hawk groaned, and then smiled. He was starting to sound an awful lot like his wife.

He took another breath, and dove down further this time, scanning as closely as he could. He saw now the ocean debris littering the floor in the crevices between each pearl. Up and down he dove in the light of his burning ship, taking lungfuls of air and then scanning for anything resembling a clam while taking care not to touch the jewels of the sea.

After ten long minutes of this, he saw, tucked between two pearls, a small, shimmering stretch of ridges. Not even daring to hope, he swam closer, and in the last dying embers of his ship, saw that yes, it was a tiny, golden clam, glittering like a dancing flame. Carefully, he chipped it out, and snagged it in his hands. It seemed so fragile, sitting against his fingerless sailing gloves. Sea Hawk cupped it, and swam to the surface with his prize cupped like a fledgling seagull in his hands.

On the sand, he flopped onto his back and drank in lungfuls of air. His ship was all but gone, chunks of smoldering debris falling into the tidepool. Oddly enough, when they hit the water they disintegrated and left behind no ash or smoke. What an odd place this was.

Sea Hawk looked down at the tiny shell in his hands. It felt… warm. Increasingly warm. Even through his gloves, the heat was unmistakable, yet it was oddly comforting. The longer he held it, the more aware he became of a growing presence in his mind. It wasn't Mermista, or the Bond, which had remained silent this entire time. It was something less abstract, sharper, beckoning him. It was the shell. Against all common sense, he placed it on his knee, and removed his gloves. It was calling to him, and he was curious enough to answer.

In his bare palm, it began to glow- just a twinkle at first, but soon it was like holding a tiny golden star. The feeling in his brain sharpened further taking shape and sound.

Sebastian…

"Yes?" He answered aloud. It felt proper.

You have successfully completed your trial, and found my long-lost totem.

He grinned. "Fantastic! …what's a totem? And who are you?"

The voice chuckled, deep and amused, and the shell flashed bright enough to temporarily blind him. Sea Hawk yelped, and rubbed his eyes in a vain attempt to lessen the afterimage. When his vision cleared, he saw he was no longer alone.

At first, he thought the woman next to him was Mermista, but the longer he stared the more different she looked. Her hair was more teal than his wife's turquoise, and her skin wasn't as deeply tanned. Mermista's nose wasn't as curved, and this woman's eyes were yellow, not amber. Her ears were impressive fans, and she was more than dotted with scales- they burst in pockets and sprays of blues and greens and golds, catching the moonlight.

"Who are you?"

Her smile was kind, and soft- almost motherly. "I am Oceana."

Sea Hawk’s jaw dropped. “T-the first Queen of Salineas? Am I dead? If I’m dead my wife will kill me.”

Oceana laughed, high and melodious like birdsong. “No, son of the sea, you live yet.”

He exhaled in relief. “Good, good. So…um, hello! I’m Sea Hawk.”

“I know,” she nodded, smiling still. “The beloved of my youngest.”

“Youngest?”

“Well, I suppose I could call her my great, great, great, great- you get the idea- granddaughter. But then we’d be here all night.”

“Ah,” he nodded. “Logical.”

“Quite,” Oceana grinned. “So. You’re the new King.”

“I-” Sea Hawk blinked. “Huh. I suppose I am.”

“Many congratulations to you, Sea Hawk,” a ghostly hand smoothed over his head, a sea breeze ruffling his locks. “Very few have been as deserving of this position as you are, tried though my daughters did to bring honor to my beloved Kingdom. I see many wonderful things for your future, many blessings and adventures…" The Goddess' eyes grew distant with thought. "I see great prosperity in Salineas' future, but also the potential for much unrest…"

Sea Hawk swallowed. "What can we do? We want Salineas to flourish."

"I see this in you," Oceana nodded. "You and Mermista must hold tightly to one another, and draw strength from the love you've built. Love, joy…these things are the gifts of life, yes, but they also take work, dedication, patience and grace. I will share with you, Sea Hawk, that the path Mermista walks has many challenges ahead. She will need you more than ever, despite what she may say."

He nodded, drinking in her words. "Anything. I'd do anything for her."

Oceana smiled again, beatific. "As she would you. Never doubt that, Sea Hawk."

Sea Hawk knew, of course, that Mermista loved him, and was as devoted to him as he was to her in her own, quiet way. But to hear it from the lips of one widely considered to be a Goddess… it warmed him deeply. "I won't, your Greatness."

"We are family now, dear one," Oceana stood, statuesque, and offered him a translucent hand. He watched scales ripple across it, and took it gratefully. Once he was on his feet, the former Queen leaned down and kissed his brow. "Lead Salineas with the passion and open heart that is your birthright."

She began to walk away and a thought occurred to him. "Wait! Uh…how do I get back?"

Her laughter reached him again. "My totem is a blessing upon the House of Salineas. That includes you now, *beta* ."

And with that, she was gone. He looked around, dazed. The moon was nearly at its zenith, his ship had burned into nothing, and all he had was this little magic shell.

He'd done more with less!

With nothing else to do, he began walking along the sandy sunken paths between the pools. As he walked, he saw that each was filled with a different sort of gem, each a gift of the ocean. Sea Hawk had the distinct feeling that this place was as real as Oceana had been, and that once he left, he wouldn't be able to return. Nonetheless, he didn't dare stop.

Gradually, he became aware of a faint tingling in his feet, pins and needles like he'd been sitting on them too long. Maybe his boots were too tight? Odd, the tailor had never messed up before. Ah, well, these were stressful times. The sand dipped lower, and he was wading in knee-high water. The tingling followed, growing in intensity. The thought occurred to him that perhaps the sea itself was magic, and irritating him. As a mortal, his physiological tolerance for magical exposure was naturally much lower.

When the tingling reached his waist, the sensation in his legs had become a dull burning, like he'd been sprinting and his calves were sore. In his bare palm, the shell was becoming a super nova, glowing brightly and burning.

A blessing upon the House of Salineas …

Feeling remarkably silly, Sea Hawk sprinted the last bit of the sandy path, plunging himself in water up to his chest. The burn spread to his neck, his waist, and he shut his eyes, not even daring to hope that what he thought might be happening could *actually* happen. The feeling was reaching a crescendo as the ground fell away from him, and he was treading open water. In the distance, the Sea Gate was glittering and waving, and he focused on it as the burn went supernova. Something inside of him was rippling, knitting together, and it was getting harder to keep his head above water because his legs weren't listening to him, instead dragging him down lower and lower. With a yelp, he sank, and in the lowlight provided by the stars, saw his pants fluttering away into the depths along with his boots, both torn. What…?

He kicked his legs, the pressure in his lungs growing unbearable, and they jerked heavily. He glanced down-

And *screamed* .

His legs were- were *gone!* In their place was a long, scaled tail that tapered into a flared, translucent fin. It was a fiery red, some orange and yellow-gold patches of scale all running together to give the appearance of a dancing flame. The tailfin was similarly colored, and the colors seemed to fade and merge as he twisted and turned. He took a deep breath- and then panicked because he was *underwater* , and that would be bad-

Only it didn't hurt like he was drowning. In fact, when he exhaled again in panic, bubbles flew out of his mouth. He inhaled again, and felt air fill his lungs. His hand flew to his neck, and ran over raised, fluttered slits of skin. Gills. He had gills.

A gift …

The shell, still clasped in his hand, shone and sparkled, and where once there had been nothing, now there was a chain. He looped it over his neck without a thought and went back to staring at his tail.

He had a way home. Now, he just needed to get the hang of this.

He thought back to all the times he'd watched Mermista in the water, how her hips and abdomen worked together, rolling and pivoting to move her. He flipped over, clenched his abs, and unclenched them as he pushed down. He moved forward a bit.

"Ha ha!"

As the moon climbed higher, Sea Hawk kept on, the clenches turning into jerky but efficient rolls of his hips, and before long he was in familiar waters again. He swam up, peeking above the waves, and saw the lit torches and lights and the gathering crowd on the main docks, waiting for his return. At the end of the stone pier was Mermista, still as a statue with her trident in hand. He ducked below the waves, thinking. The moment was his to take, but how…

He took off the necklace, holding it by the chain, and watched as his tail faded away into loose, shimmering pants. He replaced the totem, and his tail came back. With a bit of maneuvering and a lot of energy, he could gain enough speed to breach the waves. Sea Hawk grinned, and began gunning for shore. As he approached, he practiced leaping out of the waves, higher and higher with each pass.

At the headwall, he put all he could into it, and crested out of the water. Shouts and gasps rippled through the crowd, and he yanked the necklace off before he could eat shit on the stone. His legs materialized, and he landed on them roughly, stumbling a few steps-

Right into Mermista's arms. She took his weight easily, and helped steady him on his feet before pulling away slightly.

“Um. Hi. What the fuck?”

“I know, right!” He laughed, adrenaline still coursing through him.

Advisors and sorcerers- Dhang among them- were rushing toward them. They parted for the Swami, who approached them as neutrally as ever. He gestured for Sea Hawk to come forward, and he placed his hands on his forehead.

“Sea Hawk had passed his trial. He has earned the right to be crowned King of Salineas!”

The crowd erupted into cheers and shouts, and Sea Hawk straightened nervously, but happily. Dhang nodded, a clear sign of approval, patting his cheek before pulling away. The same pinch face advisor who had given him the useless map pushed his way to the front.

“And just where is your ship, Captain?” He sneered. “And what is that in your hand?”

The crowd pushed closer, and Mermista stepped up to his side, ready to open her mouth. He beat her to it, though.

“My ship is…gone,” he coughed. “And this is a totem of Oceana’s. I found it in the tidepool beyond Sea Snake’s Pass.”

“Would you like the wreck recovered, my King?” A young guard asked, despite Maevik’s warning glare.

“There…is no wreck to recover.”

Mermista now whirled on him. “You didn’t.”

“It was part of the trial!”

“Sebastian!”

“There was no other way!” He swore, and watched Maevik cough into his hand in his peripheral vision. “The tidepool was dark, and the ship was grounded anyway. I certainly wasn’t sailing it out. Plus, one of the phases of the trial was ‘flame’. It was simple math, and besides, IV took a real beating during the war. She was out to pasture anyway.”

Mermista still looked more than a bit annoyed, but rolled her eyes and let it go. “You’re not getting another ship for a year at least.”

“That’s fair.”

Pinch Face cleared his throat. “Excuse me, but all totems and gifts are to be relinquished to the people-”

“Not those claimed in personal trial,” Dhang stroked his facial hair, considering. “The King may keep this totem if he wishes, as it was a direct gift from Oceana to the House of Salineas.”

“And how would that be possible?” The man sneered.

“That totem only reveals itself to those blessed by the Goddess herself,” Dhang shrugged. “If Sea Hawk has it, then his rule has already been approved. Now, I do believe it is just about time to crown. The rest of the Alliance has arrived with Queen Glimmer, and it would be rude to keep them waiting, hm?”

The crowd dispersed, heading up the lit paths toward the open castle. Mermista held his hand, keeping him in place until it was just them on the beach, and Maevik waiting at the end of the pier. He turned to her, ready to apologize again, when he saw a small smile on her face blooming on her face.

“I’m, like, so proud of you,” she shook her head. “You… you did great. There’s not a person in this kingdom who will ever doubt your authority to rule, now, you know? They might doubt you, or me, but a totem from Oceana…”

“I couldn’t have done it without you,” he murmured, pressing his forehead to hers. “Your great-to-the-thousandth-power grandma says hi, by the way.”

“You saw her? Oceana?” Mermista blinked in shock.

He nodded. “Yeah. It was…really quite overwhelming to be honest.”

“I can imagine, yeah,” she nodded vaguely. “Okay, wow. Yeah, so… ready?”

“Nope!” He grinned. “I’m terrified.”

“This part is easy. All you have to do is kneel there and then stand. No speeches. And then…well, everything stays the same.”

“But totally different.”

“Now you’re getting it.”

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Sea Hawk was pulled aside by handmaids and courtiers, redressed in a fine silk sherwani and slacks befitting a king, with a scarf draped over his shoulders. His hair was slicked back, his mustache quickly trimmed and waxed before he was hit with sweet smelling oils. His henna flowed between his fingers, dried and darkening, catching his eyes and several others'.

Maevik and Eliza stood outside the shut doors of the throne room, each holding a handle.

"Ready, Mustache King?" Eliza asked, eyes shining with mirth. Maevik rolled his fondly.

Sea Hawk smiled gently and nodded. "Ready."

They pulled the doors open, and the volume inside quieted. Either side of the main carpeted aisle was filled with people kneeling on silken pillows, who stood as he entered. Civilians, guards, military personnel, council members, state heads (Peekablue and Sweet Bee among them), advisors, cabinet members… and of course, the Alliance, seated at the front in positions of honor. To the right were Bow, Glimmer, Adora, and Spinnerella and Netossa. To the left were Perfuma, Frosta, Scorpia, Entrapta, and Kadroh. Hordak and Catra had been barred from the event, as the entire council was unanimous in feeling it was too soon, and would send a mixed message about priorities. It hadn't been a fight worth having.

Sitting on her throne in full, gorgeous regalia was Mermista, looking every inch the Queen. Her own crown, a refurbished heirloom actually to her liking, sat on her head, her nath in her nose, and gold armbands ringing her biceps. She wore a lehenga choli with a light, silk floor length skirt, turquoise, navy, teal, and gold rippling like water as she stood. Her trident was handed to

Maevik, who must have come around the side, before she gestured for him to come forward. All eyes turned to Sea Hawk as he stepped into the room, but he refused to let it unnerve him. He loved being the center of attention, even now, and walked proudly to the throne. He grinned at the Alliance as he reached the front, winking surreptitiously.

“Kneel, Captain Sea Hawk of the Kingdom of Snows,” Mermista’s voice rang out through the room, dry but gentle all at once. He kneeled, bowing his head. “You seek Kingship to Salineas.”

“I do.”

“Are you prepared to swear your fealty for all to hear?”

“I am.”

“Then do you, Sea Hawk, swear to put first the people of Salineas in every circumstance? In times of war and peace? At risk to your own life, should it mean saving even one civilian?”

“I do.”

“In times of prosperity…and in hours of hardship, do you swear to stay?”

The ghost of Mercia lingered in the room, and it felt like the promise of a lifetime to affirm. “I do.”

“Do you swear to uphold the values of our culture, our society, and our justice system in all you do?”

“I do.”

“And do you swear above all else,” her voice softened just slightly. “To love this Kingdom as I do, and as all my forebears have, until the end of your days?”

He looked up at her now, and met her eyes so she could see for herself how deeply he meant it. “With all that I am, I do solemnly swear.”

“Then by the power vested in me by my mother, the Pearl, and my people-” Mermista turned and gestured. A young courtesan approached her, climbing the dais and offering her a box on a pillow. Mermista lifted the lid and withdrew a gorgeous, simple gold crown, alike to hers but distinctly its own as well.

It was gold, of course, studded with pearls and oceanic jewels and gems. It was a circlet of gold, but instead of a plain band, it was carved and etched. If one looked at it a certain way, it gave the illusion of feathers. And if the head was tilted, the feathers became flames. Mermista’s own circlet was waves of gold, with small scale designs worked into it. At the apex of each sat a pearl that came to rest at the center of his forehead when she placed the crown on his head.

"-I crown you Sea Hawk, King of Storms, Son of Bird Song, He with Soul of Burning Flame, Tireless Seeker of New Horizons. Rise, now, and take your place at my side."

The crowd erupted into raucous cheers, whoops and hollers, and he rose easily to his feet. Mermista smiled at him softly, proudly, and gestured for him to turn before applauding herself. Sea Hawk grinned as he turned, bowing slightly and waving.

"Yeah!" Frosta cheered. "Go Hawk!"

Bow whistled sharply, laughing as he clapped. Scorpia was crying as she rattled her tail and knocked her pincers together. Perfuma's grin was prouder than almost any others, as her eyes ping ponged between him and Mermista. Once the applause died down, and everyone began filing to the lower levels for a small afterparty, Mermista joined him.

He held his arm out to her on instinct, and a small 'awww' rippled through the crowd still assembled. Mermista blushed and rolled her eyes, but took it anyway. "You look good in a crown."

"As do you," he murmured. "Are these newly made?"

“No,” she snorted. “I wouldn’t divert money that needs to go to rebuilding to something as trivial as the metal on our heads. I went digging through the catacombs- retired weaponry and crowns and all that- and found these from the seventh period. They were last worn by Queen Vellam and King Neeru.”

“They’re beautiful, and shockingly fitting.” He ghosted a hand over the feathers. “Hey, what happens to my necklace?”

“Whatever you want, I guess.” Mermista shrugged. “Do you want to keep it?”

Sea Hawk blushed, rubbing his neck sheepishly. “It could prove very helpful on adventures- you’d certainly have to rescue me less. But…it also means something else I get to share with you, if you’ll teach me.”

Mermista blushed as well, looking elsewhere. “Yeah, sure. Sounds like fun, or whatever.”

They were ambushed by their friends as soon as they cleared the room, much to Maevik’s immense anxiety. People tackle-hugging his wards, even if those people were other monarchs, set his teeth on edge.

“That was so *cool!* ” Frosta cheered, arms around Mermista’s waist.

“And blessedly short,” Netossa slung an arm around Sea Hawk’s shoulders, and he leaned into the side hug. “Love the new crowns!”

“Thanks,” Mermista smiled. “Borrowed ‘em from some dead relatives.”

Bow hugged them both next. “This was so interesting! Each kingdom’s traditions are so different! I have a few questions-”

“Sea Hawk!” Adora leaned around and cut off Bow. “How’d your trial go?”

“Excellent!” He grinned. “It was quite the adventure!”

“How many ships you set on fire?” Glimmer snorted.

“Just the one!”

Netossa barked a laugh as Mermista groaned, dropping her face into her hand. The BFS blinked, equal parts alarmed (Adora), excited (Glimmer), and enchanted (Bow). “Really?”

“Yep! Only because there were no other options-”

“Allegedly.” Mermista muttered.”

“-and the trial called for it.”

“Also allegedly.”

Frosta pouted. “Aw man! We miss all the cool stuff.”

“Don’t worry! I shall regale you with the fantastic details!” He crowed, and Mermista groaned as they all began heading for the stairs. “There I was, at the prow, a map in my hands and the wind at my sails…”

Chapter End Notes

> just one more to go! it'll be out before the year ends. WOW what a journey. let me know what you thought! as always, i read each comment, and I'm working on getting back to each one.

i feel warm with your hand in mine, when we walk along the shoreline

Chapter Summary

A Wedding

Chapter Notes

Well y'all, here we are. At the end of the saga, at last. I really can't say what this fic has meant to me, writing it and having so many others read it. I found and made lifelong friends through this fic, an incredible creative community, and the confidence to start writing my own stuff.

Every single comment, kudo, like, and hit, has been a complete and utter blessing. When I felt that what I was writing was shit, someone had something incredible and kind to say that made me keep going.

A special, loving shout out to dudeabuck, who I'm almost certain never missed a chapter. Thank you so much!

I can't think of anything else to say, so. Tadaaaaa!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Alliance gasped as their ship cut through sparkling- *actually sparkling!-* waters, gently displacing fish, lily pads, and small birds. Behind them rolled the ocean they'd just come from, gentle now that they were past the Salinean breakers, and ahead of them lay a wide, still inlet carving through a sprawling, but flat island. From what Bow could see, the ground of the island was dark gray stone, smooth and shot through with lighter rocks, but as they made it further under the hanging foliage, glassy black rock began cropping up as well.

Next to him, in a fine lilac suit and her mask, Entrapta was muttering into a recorder as her head swiveled around. "Igneous and metamorphic bedrock with strong volcanic intrusions- this island was once over an active volcanic hotspot! The samples I collect here could be key in understanding Salinean architecture and engineering-"

"Please do not collect from this island," their guard- Maevik, actually, Mermista's most trusted guard (and strongest)- intoned from the yolk of their cruiser. It wasn't unlike a skiff. "This land is sacred to our people, and has remained untouched despite the war. We wish to keep it that way. I would be more than happy to have a tour of Salinean geology arranged for you, Your Majesty."

Entrapta blinked, but then nodded firmly. "I would appreciate that! Hear that Hordak? No samples from here."

Hordak, dressed in a gorgeous indigo and violet dress with two slits clean up his hips and plenty of lace detailing, nodded as well. "Understood and happily obeyed."

He and Catra, who clung to Adora with all she had while they were on the water (and looked very embarrassed about it), had been on edge all day. Despite Mermista's assurances via Sea Hawk via their groupchat on the Padds, which she hadn't texted in since being unchipped, the people attending the wedding and reception understood they were coming, and why, and weren't going to cause any problems.

“These plants are old,” Perfuma murmured, reaching up to brush some of the hanging willow branches tenderly. “Almost ancient. The stories they could tell…”

“Do plants often tell stories?” Scorpia tilted her head. Perfuma just giggled, and a sappy grin overcame the arachnid woman’s face. She wore a layered black and ruby dress that Glimmer had discovered a picture of in the catacomb murals and had had made for her. It worked with her chiton and tail, and complimented her muscular build perfectly. Perfuma wore a floaty pink, green and white two-piece gown in the Salinean style, sent to her by Mermista. Glimmer’s own had been called a lehenga choli, and the sash was a dupatta. Bow had been gifted a sherwani suit from Sea Hawk.

Glimmer’s dress was a beautiful, finely detailed watercolor of lavenders, pinks, grays, and gold embroidery, giving the illusion of a sunset high in the clouds. Her father and Castaspella’s matched, though they were vintage- from Mercia and Nerida’s wedding almost three decades ago. Netossa and Spinnerella had been sent new ones, as they’d been young at the last Salinean wedding. Adora had been gifted a saree, one shouldered and wrapped complexly (Mermista had sent folding instructions) in shades of white and gold with maroon detailing. Frosta wore a lehenga choli as well, navy and ice blue with diamond and silver piping and embroidery. Those who hadn’t been gifted personal finery weren’t offended, and had been sent an appropriate color guide.

“We’re here.”

The boat bumped the dock, and Catra’s tail poofed. Her claws had been sliding in and out in rhythm, either an attempt to self-soothe or preparing for being thrown overboard. She wore a new suit in white and gold, and her rough shorn hair had been tamed and coiffed and trimmed nicely. Her ears swiveled constantly when they weren't lying flat. Over a video call, he and Sea Hawk had expressed their mutual shock at her and Hordak's acceptance of the invitation. The King of Salineas thought it was a lovely gesture for peace and resilience and their determination to set things right. Bow hoped his wife agreed.

He helped his girlfriend off the boat, and together they helped Catra and Adora off and made sure everyone disembarked without incident. It was late noon, and they were among the first guests to arrive to avoid clamor and unfriendly eyes. Maevik led them up a stone and pearl-laid walkway toward a sprawling temple. They crossed over immaculate lawns where brightly feathered, long-tailed iridescent birds strutted to and fro, unbothered by them. Catra stumbled, staring in rapt attention at them.

Glimmer chuckled. "Never seen a peacock?"

"They're…weird. Good weird."

Maevik had paused to regard the magicat with slight amusement. "We call them Beaujays. They're the national bird of Salineas, though in all the upheaval, there's been a push for it to be replaced by the osprey."

Frosta blinked. "Everything to discuss and *that's* on the table?"

“You understand her Majesty’s shrinking patience.”

“Bureaucracy never fails to amaze me,” Hordak muttered. Maevik’s fanned ears, though, were twitching. Bow had always suspected merfolk heard more than they let on.

“You and I both,” the guard smirked, and it was very threatening. Hordak cleared his throat and fell silent, and they were led onward. The white cobblestone sparkled in the morning light, and the fluted, open archways of the temple yawned in welcome. They were led into a half-outdoor atrium, and then a half-outdoor hall. The entire temple was half indoor, half exposed. The architecture was swept and curled from natural erosion, and Bow was stopping every few feet to gape at something. He really ought to bring his dads here.

The space was decorated to the nines, truly befitting a royal wedding. Gauzy drapes that looked to be made of water and seafoam incarnate billowed into the halls, carrying the sea breeze with them. Floating lights in gold, teal, navy and red flickered throughout the building, guiding them on. Busts and paintings of queens and kings past lined the walls, along with huge sea glass and sea gem murals of mermaids. The halls were open and airy, and it was almost impossible to tell whether one was inside or out.

“Bow,” Glimmer whispered, and he broke his reverie to see them all paused before a lichen-covered doorway. As they nudged it, the foliage pulled itself apart. Perfuma gasped, delighted at the enchantments, while the rest of them gasped at the space beyond.

It was a massive space, with a high, domed ceiling far above. The walls were more stained glass than stone, and the windows gave way to wide open arches that led right to a black-sand beach. The floor was cool stone, as were the benches, though they were laid with silks and pillows for comfort. The seats were tucked into tall fronds of seagrass, and the aisle Mermista would walk down was lined like a dune with thick, short copses of greenery and flowers. The altar upfront was decorated with caged lanterns that flickered with golden flame, rich tapestries and silks, and mountains of artful, still living white orchids. Micah, who had come in with them, froze at the sight, and grabbed Castaspella's wrist.

"Dad?" Glimmer turned. They all frowned as Micah's eyes filled with tears, though he was smiling.

"The orchids…" he laughed wetly, sadly. "They're Nerida's. They were her favorites."

Castaspella's mouth pinched, and she hugged her brother's arm tightly as she fought off her own tears. "She's here with us today. I feel it."

Bow swallowed the sudden lump in his throat. It was going to be a beautiful ceremony.

"Is Mercia going to be here?" Micah brushed his eyes. "It's been… a long time."

“No one except Her Majesty knows,” Maevik murmured, brushing his own eyes. “The other guests will be arriving imminently, so you may want to take your seats.”

No sooner had they done so than did the other guests begin streaming in. Scorpia and Perfuma tensed at the entrance of Peekablue, Princess Sweet Bee on his arm. The two men spared them all a cursory, condescending glance before taking their seats- toward the back, Bow noted. The Star Sisters- Delphini, Andromeda, and Cassiopeia- arrived in triplet, as always, taking their seats further front than Peekablue, but behind the Alliance.

“Where Mermista puts people sends a huge political message,” Glimmer had told him one night, curled up in bed. *“With her marriage, she technically ascends to full political power in Salineas, just like Mom was for the Woods, the city-states, and Bright Moon. Where she puts them tells them the place they’ll have in her Age. ”*

Peekablue looked coolly displeased by his seat, but smart enough to realize he was lucky not to be in jail for treason to the capital. The Star Sisters looked grateful, if a bit saddened. He overheard Perfuma whispering in Scorpia’s ear.

“The Sisters used to be very close to Mermista,” she whispered. “Andromeda and she were even courting for a time. But they let Peekablue sway their allegiance, and Mermista has never fully forgiven them.”

“Damn,” Bow muttered. “I had no idea Salineas was so…volatile. Tetchy.”

“It’s the epicenter of global trade,” Catra muttered from Glimmer’s other side. “They stand to hold the most power going into the new age if they can repair in time, and everyone knows it.”

Glimmer and he shared a look, and shrugged. They’d discuss it later, he knew. Minutes ticked by, and the room filled up, as did the arches, the balconies above and behind them. A steady volume of noise was swirling about the room, but it cut itself in half with hushed whispers and gasps. Bow spun around from where he was chatting with a sorcerer noble from the island of Hanali.

Sea Hawk had emerged from the side of the room, and waved gently, jovially, to the assembled. He wore a layered, patterned sherwani, his Sun Blade at his side in a decorative sheath. The primary fabric was a gold tan patterned with small waves and feather-like symbols in deeper tan. Underneath that he wore a gauzy teal shift of silk, the exact shade that Mermista always wore. His pants were the same shade of teal with the same patterns, while his slippers were gold. The sash around his waist was teal, as was the first dupatta over his shoulder. The second one was a deeper shade of blue-green, and made of a thicker fabric. It sat over one shoulder, and draped over his forearm artfully. The necklaces that sat on his chest were a mix of wood beads, gold, gems, and, of course, pearls. He didn’t wear the pagdi on his head that all the grooms in the paintings had. Instead, the same tastefully simple crown from his coronation sat there. His mustache was waxed and groomed to perfection, his hair slicked back but still playfully tousled.

He caught Bow’s eye, and looked over to the man he’d come in with- Swami Dhang, if he wasn’t mistaken. When he nodded, he trotted down the two steps to hug them all and offer hand shakes, even to Catra and Hordak, who looked as stunned as the assembled.

“Thank you all for being here!” He beamed.

“We wouldn’t miss this for the world!” Glimmer squeezed his shoulder. “Nervous?”

“Is it so obvious?” Sea Hawk chuckled wryly. “I’m alright. She’s already my wife. Now, it’s just a performance.”

“Something you both excel at,” Perfuma winked.

He laughed, clapping her on the shoulder gently. Bow watched the split sleeve fall away to reveal his henna, now properly dark and beautifully detailed.

“Ooohh, can we see?” He pointed, and Sea Hawk held his hands out. They scanned and traced it until the small string orchestra and singer- a young girl, maybe sixteen- began tuning softly. The color drained from Sea Hawk’s face, but his eyes lit up.

"We'll see you all at the reception!" He whispered, giddy, and turned away to climb the short steps up to the altar. Dhang clasped his shoulder briefly, fatherly, and though the sorcerer didn't smile, his eyes crinkled happily. Sea Hawk clasped his hands in front of him, taking his place. The murmuring grew and fell in waves, people unsure whether to quiet down lest they all sit in awkward silence.

The plucking strings of a simple guitar, accompanied by soft violin swells, answered their question for them. The setting sun burned through the stained glass, coloring the room in rich amber and blue and purple. They all rose, and Perfuma, at the end of the bench nearest the aisle, picked up the enchanted lily left on her seat. In its cup sat a glowing mote of magical essence, and when all the flowers bent together toward the aisle, they shone together in two waving rows, beacons to lead the bride.

The singer opened her mouth, and an almost-sirenic voice, melodic and enchanting, filled the room.

"Wise men say

Only fools rush in…"

The first down the aisle were a gaggle of Salinean children, dressed to the nines and smiling at all the attention. They toddled down the aisle to much adoration, scattering blue and gold and white petals as they went. After them came an older child they all recognized as Eliza, Maevik's apprentice and Mermista's…ward? Also apprentice? Bow wasn't sure, but he knew they were close. She held a box carved from mother of pearl, and walked with practiced grace to stand beside Swami Dhang. The tokens Sea Hawk and Mermista would exchange.

"But I can't help

Falling in love with you… "

Bow knew this song. It was old, believed to be a relic of the First One's, and beloved by all who hadn't forgotten it. He'd caught his own dads humming it to one another when they swayed in the kitchen, waiting for tea to brew for a late-night translating stint. His eyes were growing wet, and the lump in his throat was undeniable. He slipped his hand into Glimmer's, squeezing tightly.

There was a pause, and everyone was holding their breath together. Then, the music swelled gently, now competing with the sound of…water? Trickling water. Gasps of awe were floating out of the crowd, and Bow craned his neck to see why. Crystal clear water was flowing down the aisle, pushed by a yet-unseen force.

"Like a river flows surely to the sea…

At the top of the aisle, the lichen and fronds were parting bit by bit, slowly revealing-

Respectfully, Bow's jaw dropped. Behind him, Adora inhaled sharply, and he swore he heard Netossa swear happily. Glimmer gasped delightedly, covering her mouth with her hand.

"Darling so it goes…"

Mermista was a *vision* . Her colors matched Sea Hawk's perfectly, but where he wore primarily gold with blue accents, she wore the inverse. Her saree was light teal, embroidered with gold, and hugged her curves gently. The full skirt moved like water itself, silks over silks in a multitude of layers light enough to flow, but heavy enough that they laid flat. Her dupatta was rich navy, bordered with the same gold- the twin to Sea Hawk's- and matched the gauzy veil-cape that streamed from the base of her beautiful updo to glide behind her. Gold clasps and pearl beads were woven into her elaborate hairstyle, catching the burning light. Her arms were covered in henna up to the elbow, partially covered by jewel encrusted bangles around her wrists. Her ears were technically void of jewelry, but her nose bore a large hoop- a nath, Bow was pretty sure- that was connected to her ear by a loose gold chain that brushed her jaw. And, of course, her makeup was artfully done. Her lips were stained a dark purple-mauve, her eyes done in smoky blues with gold eyeliner. A matha patti laid over her hair and forehead, a simple gold piece dotted with pearls.

Bow turned to look at Sea Hawk. His jaw had fallen softly open, and his eyes were wide, and in that split second of silence, Bow knew he was looking at pure adoration. Sea Hawk's hand came up to cover his mouth, but it couldn't stop the tears that were already trailing down his face. His shoulders quivered, and he blinked quickly, clearly trying to stop the tears to no avail. Bow blinked, and his own tears began falling. He glanced to see Glimmer in the same state, smiling helplessly.

“Some things are meant to be…”

Next to Mermista stood her father, Mercia. Bow watched in muted surprise as Mercia reached out and took her hands carefully. He murmured something to her, and she smiled, soft and small, at him. She let him lean in and kiss her cheek, and accepted his help over the foliage to step carefully into the water.

Mermista’s posture was perfectly regal as she glided through the inch of water step by step. Bow watched her face change, though, as she approached the dais, her cool mask giving way to overwhelming emotion. She only had eyes for Sea Hawk as she walked, and by the time she passed Bow, tears were tracking gently down her own cheeks. He noted that none of them disturbed her makeup, nor did the water around her feet cling to her dress.

As she ascended the steps, Sea Hawk held his hand out for her, and she slid hers into his grip.

“So take my hand

Take my whole life, too,

For I can’t help

Falling in love with you…”

They were both crying now, but smiling broadly, too, as they laughed at their own emotions while indulging in the other’s.

Bow’s chest hurt from keeping his tears as silent as humanly possible. Perfuma looked to be having the same issue, and was covering her mouth with her hand to muffle her sobs. They shared an understanding, self-deprecating smile. Love was funny in all its forms.

Swami Dhang stepped forward, raising his arms. “Loved and respected ones, we are gathered here today to celebrate and finalize the union of our Queen to her Chosen, our King. Yes, we are all aware of how very out of order these two did everything.”

Gentle laughter rippled through the crowd, and Mermista rolled her eyes fondly.

“Per Salinean tradition, the re-newlyweds will read their own vows to one another, spoken from their hearts to be witnessed by their families and allies, and Oceana herself.”

He gestured for Mermista to speak, and she dabbed her eyes gently. “Truly a crime you never did stand up,” the crowd heard her mutter to the swami as whatever magic Dhang was using to project his voice reached her. She cleared her throat delicately.

“We both know I’m not very good at fluff, or words in general,” Mermista smiled wryly, taking both of Sea Hawk’s hands in hers. “But for you, I’m going to try. While I was trying to find the words to express what you mean to me, I found a poem that I felt hit the nail on the head, so, allow me to take a page out of your book and read you some of it.”

Sea Hawk wiped his eyes gently with their still-joined hands, and Glimmer slipped her hand back into Bow’s to squeeze.

Mermista took a deep breath, staring into Sea Hawk’s eyes. “I will love you all my days. I will love you until the stars burn down, and until the world wears out. I will love you until the planets collide, and the suns fade away into cold night. Until the moons go out, and the seas and rivers dry up, I will love you. When I am old, and my memories slip away from me like sand, I will love you. When my tongue can no longer speak your name, it won’t matter because it will be written on my heart. And when my heart beats for the last time, it will be for you and all we have ever loved as one.”

Sea Hawk’s head was bent, and Bow glanced around the room- not one eye seemed dry in the entire room. Maevik was weeping into a handkerchief, shoulders shuddering with sobs as he clasped the hand of a shorter, kind-faced man who was also crying. Mercia, sitting directly behind them with Micah and Casta, had tears falling one by one from his eyes. Glimmer, now wrapped in his arms, was sniffling and smiling, and he saw the rest of the Alliance in the same state.

“Sea Hawk…Sebastian,” Mermista wiped her own eyes. “What you mean to me can’t be put into words. You’re my rock, and my reason. When I want to stop, you keep me going, and when I find myself in the dark- well, we all know you’ve probably got a lighter on you somewhere.”

The assembled laughed, and even Sea Hawk tossed his head back with a chuckle.

“We’ve done and seen so much together. We’ve fought side by side and had each other’s backs since the day we met, and I can’t think of a better way to go through life than with my best friend at my side. ” She reached up to wipe her eyes, and when Sea Hawk gently wiped a few away, a hushed ‘aww’ rippled through the crowd. Mermista blushed. “You’re there when no one else is. You believe in me when I can’t possibly do that myself. I’ve always known you’d be by my side, whether I wanted you there or not, because you knew what I needed better than I did. You refused to give up on me, even when there was literally no reason to stay. And there aren’t enough ways to say how much I love you for that.

“I’m about out of words, but I think you said it best a while ago. You are everything I have ever wanted, Sea Hawk. You are, without a doubt, the greatest adventure of my life, and I love you more every day for it.”

Sea Hawk raised their joined hands to his chest, clasping them lovingly. “I don’t know how you expect me to follow that up, dearest.”

Mermista smirked and shrugged a bit self-importantly. “Do your best, I guess.”

He laughed again, and cleared his throat. “It’s hard to say in one go how much you mean to me, Mermista, and how much I love you. Which is why I intend to spend our entire lives telling you every day.

As you know, I was born into very little, and what little I had the Horde took. For years, I wandered through life just seeking the next great thrill, the next story to tell, with very few designs for my future."

Behind Bow, he swore he heard Mercia make a vague noise of some sort.

"That all ended the night I met you. Mermista, you were born with a drive and a fire and a direction I'd never seen before, and from day one, I couldn't ever see myself being anywhere that wasn't at your side ever again. You inspire me to be so much more than I ever thought I could be just by being *you* ."

Bow had never heard Sea Hawk so…serious. Sincere. His natural timber was much deeper than he'd realized, and he held the audience captive with his innate, performative way of speaking. Even Mermista's were riveted to his, no trace of annoyance or sarcasm curling her lip or brow. She looked…in love. It struck Bow like- well, like an arrow- just how devoted they both were to one another. He'd only seen Mermista emote this strongly when she was pushed to a brink, usually grief. And Sea Hawk had never seemed so self-assured, so calm and certain, as he did right now. Watching them stand there together, no one could possibly deny they were two souls forged from the same star. His heart panged with happiness for them, but also with want and longing, and he held Glimmer tighter. *Soon* , he told himself.

Sea Hawk brushed one of her tears away again before continuing. "A long, long time ago, when I was just a boy in Snows, I asked my mother what love was. And she told me it was when you found a part of your soul in the body of another, and realized you'd been carrying a piece of theirs, too. She called that person a soulmate.

"A soulmate, she told me, is the one you are always carrying with you in some way, even when you can't see them, forever. They're your best friend, but they're so much more all at once. It's the person who knows you better than anyone else, even yourself at times, and believed in you before anyone else, or when no one else would. No matter what happens, you will always love your soulmate. My mother also told me that your soulmates makes you a better person, but I think it's more than that. Mermista, you make me want to be the best possible self I can be. Every day, you inspire me to do better than I ever thought I could, just by being yourself.

"I told you ages ago that you are my North Star, and that's never been more true. You've guided me through the darkest nights, staying by my side until I could see the sun again. You show me the way when I'm lost, even when I don't even realize how turned around I am."

Mermista bent her head, trying in vain to hide how overcome she was by his words. Bow had long since given up trying to muffle his tears, and glanced quickly at the others. Scorpia and Perfuma were both sobbing into their handkerchiefs, each with a hand on Frosta's shoulders. The young Princess was crying, too, but smiling happily and freely. Adora was crying silently, while Catra's eyes looked wide and wanting, riveted to the scene. Entrapta's mask was down, while Hordak clasped her hands in his.

Spinnerella and Netossa were clasping hands, leaning into one another and looking on fondly. Glimmer had wrapped herself around his arm, and he leaned his head against hers, pressing a soft kiss to her sparkling hair.

“You are my everything, Mermista,” Sea Hawk lifted her eyes back to his with a gentle finger under her chin. “You’re my rock and my reason, too. I would climb every single mountain, and sail to the end of each ocean on this planet, and every other, if you asked me. I will follow you anywhere you need, into battle or meetings, into balls, out of taverns, and clear to the ends of the earth. You are my moon and all of my stars. I love you, dearest, and I vow to show you and tell you that every day for the rest of our lives, and beyond.”

He squeezed her hands, raising them up to kiss her knuckles briefly. Bow had never seen such emotion on Mermista’s face, and his heart soared for it. He watched her mouth ‘I love you’ through her tears, and saw Sea Hawk squeeze her hands tighter in response.

Swami Dhang stepped forward, dabbing his own eyes. He gestured, and Mermista and Sea Hawk knelt as one. “At your Confluence, you took the magical vows that bound you to one another for eternity. Now, all that’s left is the legal end. Do you both vow to take the other as your beloved family- sacred above all else in Salineas?”

“We do.”

The sorcerer raised his hands, and the matching shawls around them began to glow, knitting together into one length of fabric that encircled them.

“Do you vow to treat one another with kindness, respect, and love in all moments?”

“We do.”

“Do you vow to stand by one another in sickness and in health, in prosperity and struggle, never straying from the path you walk as one?”

“We do.”

Dhang gestured, and Eliza and another young girl stepped forward. The other girl held a bowl of red powder that she offered them both. Mermista dipped her thumb in, and pressed the powder to the space between and just above Sea Hawk’s eyebrows. Somewhere above them, a bell chimed. Sea Hawk dipped his thumb in as well, pressing a red mark onto Mermista in the same spot, before he scooped a small pinch out between his fingers and thumb. He sprinkled and rubbed it into the part in Mermista’s hair, and the bell rang out again.

“You have marked one another as spouses in the Salinean tradition,” Dhang bowed to them both. “Now, do so in the Etherian way.”

Eliza stepped forward, holding out the box carefully. Mermista smiled at her, and withdrew her two small items Bow couldn’t quite see. She reached up to Sea Hawk’s ears, and he saw then that she was slipping in the cuffs she wore in her ear all through the war. “You gave me these years ago, when we didn’t think we had a star’s chance at happiness. So, now I’m giving them back- a promise fulfilled, and forever renewed.”

Sea Hawk reached up to caress them, and smiled so lovingly at her that Bow felt he could disintegrate into tears. He reached in and withdrew his own earrings. “Great minds think alike, I see. I stole these off of a man in Sea Worthy after I knocked him out for disrespecting the new Queen of Salineas, so I think it’s only fair you have them after all these years.”

Mermista was laughing into her hands, shaking her head, while most of the assembled joined in. Mercia was not laughing behind him, but when Bow snuck a glance, he did look fairly bemused. On the altar, Sea Hawk carefully slid the earrings into Mermista’s lobes, even as she sighed.

“Why are you like this?”

“Because you wouldn’t have me any other way, love.” Sea Hawk winked, and Mermista rolled her eyes. She had yet to stop smiling, thought, so the effect was severely lessened.

Dhang gestured broadly. “By the power vested in me by the crown and the Pearl, it is my great joy to pronounce you King and Queen in Resplendency, owners of your full titles and powers, and of course, most importantly… husband and wife. Rise, Queen Mermista and King Sea Hawk of Salineas, and celebrate your love with us.”

They did, the shawl around them vanishing in a spray of light, and turned to one another, grinning. His hands found her waist, while hers rested against his chest, and they fell into one another with gentle, natural ease. Their lips met softly, and the crowd erupted into cheers and applause that had them both clearly fighting grins. Mermista’s hands wound up around Sea Hawk’s neck and a second later, he dipped her expertly, one arm supporting her shoulder. The kiss deepened briefly, before they were both upright again, laughing and crying all at once. Perhaps more shocking than their characteristically dramatic kiss was the hug they swept one another into, holding one another close with the care only given to something precious.

The musicians started up again, and they turned as one to wave at everyone. Mermista grinned at the Alliance, winking and blowing kisses, while Sea Hawk only had eyes for her.

They walked down the dais and back down the aisle together, while everyone threw the rice that had magically materialized seconds ago. As she passed him, Mercia’s fingers twitched, and matching white orchids materialized on the newlyweds’ shoulders. Mermista’s eyes found his, and he nodded at her and Sea Hawk. She tugged her hand out of Sea Hawk’s to step into her father’s arms, and Bow watched them hug tightly, briefly.

“She would be so happy, *beta* ,” Mercia murmured. “She would approve.”

“And you?”

“For better or worse, I have a son now.”

Mermista squeezed her eyes shut, and hugged him a bit tighter before stepping away again. She smiled at her father, and reached up to tap the flower before rejoining her husband and walking away.

Micah clapped Mercia’s shoulders. “Good man.”

“He does love her fiercely.” Mercia still looked vaguely distressed at the thought, but more comfortable with it now.

“Get to know him,” Micah’s eyes flicked toward Bow, and he blushed to his roots. “Your son might surprise you yet.”

The crowd began dispersing, and Glimmer jostled him out of his pensive reverie. “C’mon! It’s time for the party!”

– — — –

The party was well underway by the time Mermista and Sea Hawk actually reappeared. Apparently, there was a ton of legal stuff to square away, like, immediately, and then they'd had to sit and chat with a portrait painter and some other stuff Bow had overheard being mentioned. The Alliance was in peak form, dancing, charming, drinking (with Adora under strict, heterochromatic supervision). The other nobility there were pleased to talk to them, while the citizens and dignitaries asked for war stories. They gave redacted versions, no one too eager to let melancholy dampen such a lovely day.

When the bride and groom appeared in a doorway at the top of a short staircase, the room erupted into applause that had Sea Hawk grinning and waving, and Mermista smiling politely. Bow didn't miss how her hands tightened around his arm, or how he tugged her a bit closer to his side. They were all scarred invisibly more than physically, he thought as Glimmer tensed next to him.

Mermista had changed into a simpler lehenga choli, patterned teal a few shades lighter than her hair and accented with gold. Her dupatta was a silky navy, darker than Sea Hawk's finely cut sherwani suit. He sported an embroidered wave on one shoulder, and a gold and amber necklace that complimented Mermista's jewelry perfectly. She wore a new matha patti, a large collar necklace, and had swapped her nath for a simple stud- all in gold. Her lipstick was different, cooler in tone but just as dark as before. Their tokens were gone, probably being kept somewhere safe, though he had put drop earrings back in and she had new cuffs. Bow smiled. Some things never changed. The dupatta on Sea Hawk's shoulder, over the wave, looked familiar, and he realized with a start that it was the magically woven scarf from the wedding, now separated again. It moved like living water that had captured falling stars in its waves, embroidered with rivers of gold.

They descended the steps with grace, and Mermista gestured for the band to keep playing. They did, and shortly after the attention was fixated back on the dancefloor enough for them to make their way to the assembled Alliance.

He and Glimmer were the first to crash into them, hugging tightly, far tighter than Mermista usually allowed.

She laughed and returned the embrace, even as she drawled, "Woooow, okay, like, calm down…"

Bow grinned. She'd said that when she'd first agreed to join the Alliance. And now, here they were. It felt like eons ago…

"You look *beautiful!* " Glimmer gushed. "Both of you!"

"Thank you, Shimmer!" Sea Hawk winked. "You as well! Your saree was ravishing, and this dress is *stunning* , truly!"

"Aw, Sea Hawk," she boxed his arm gently. "You're a charmer."

They'd been told to bring more casual clothes for the reception, and everyone had changed in their provided rooms at the temple during the intermission. Glimmer had offered to teleport everyone home, but this was easier. Plus, she could enjoy herself and relax if she didn't have to worry about zipping around the planet later.

"Mista!"

Perfuma practically crashed into Mermista, already crying. She pulled back to run a motherly hand over her coiffed hair and made-up cheek. "You look so beautiful, Mista, I'm *so* happy for you both!"

Mermista rolled her eyes, but it was all a show. "C'mon, dude, don't make me cry, this eyeliner is fresh."

"We all know it's waterproof," Perfuma soothed. Glimmer laughed, and Mermista flipped her off subtly, only making her laugh harder.

"Mermista! Hawk!" Scorpia was next, scooping them up in gentle bear hugs. "You are- this is- I'm just- congratulations!"

"Thank you, my friend," Sea Hawk boomed, slapping her back. Scorpia placed them down, and Mermista smiled softly.

"Thanks, Scorpia. I'm really glad you came."

“Wouldn’t miss it for the world!”

“Rude Princess!” Entrapta popped up from below their eye level, startling Sea Hawk and getting a genuine laugh out of Mermista. “Sea Hawk! Congratulations on your nuptials!”

“Thanks, Geek Princess,” the bride winked. “I’m glad you and your… partner? Is that the word you’re using?”

“It is, yes!” Entrapta grinned.

“I’m glad you were both able to attend today.” Mermista inclined her head politely in Hordak’s direction. He and Catra were off to the side, but it was Adora who stepped forward next.

“Thank you for inviting us today, Mermista,” she smiled, hugging them both. “All of us.”

Sea Hawk grinned. “Love takes many forms, and follows many rivers and roads. It is not for us to judge, only to celebrate while our hearts beat on!”

“What he said,” Mermista sighed, though she did lean into the arm he wrapped about her shoulders. “You’re all welcome in my kingdom at any time, for any reason. Or no reason.”

“You know we’ll be taking you up on that,” Netossa materialized in the circle, reaching to hug Mermista and then Sea Hawk, followed shortly by her wife. “Blessings and happiness and great sex to you both!”

“Hear, hear!” Sea Hawk laughed, slapping Netossa’s hand. Spinnerella and Mermista shared a long look of patient understanding.

“Unconditional, am I right?”

Mermista snorted. “Tell me about it.”

Frosta crashed into them next, wrapping her arms around Mermista’s waist. “You look gorgeous! I’m so happy you guys get to be gross together forever!”

Bow watched Mermista hug the young ruler back tightly. For all her aloof masking, it was undeniable how fond she was of Frosta, the way she was always encouraging her (often violent) ideas, listening to her stories with patience, indulging her complex table-top games. She, Perfuma, and Frosta had a sisterly bond just as strong as Glimmer and Adora’s, with that added layer of menacing only siblings can conjure. It was good for all three of them.

Sea Hawk hugged Frosta, too, saying something in a language Bow didn’t understand that made her laugh brightly. The last two to arrive and congratulate them were Micah and Castaspella, who wished them both well briefly before setting off to find Mercia again.

“I can’t believe he came,” Perfuma whistled. “How did that happen?”

Mermista shrugged. “Honestly, I sent an invite along with a pod of whales I knew crossed his path-”

“Wait, you can talk to whales?” Entrapta whipped out a datapadd. “Faaaaascinatinggg…”

“-and then he showed up today,” she finished. “I was doing what I wanted with or without him. I told him he can come and play nice or not show up to the day of his only child’s only wedding.”

“Sort of only,” Sea Hawk grinned.

“Well, yeah, duh.”

“I’m glad he came,” Glimmer smiled. “It’s… hard. Starting a relationship like that from scratch when you’re already an adult.”

“Preach, sister,” Mermista snorted, snagging two flutes of champagne from a passing server and handing one to Sea Hawk.

“Can I try?” Frosta pointed.

“No!” Most of the Alliance chorused, but Mermista shrugged.

“You won’t like it.”

“Mermista!” Perfuma gasped as Frosta grinned. “She’s fourteen!”

“Do *you* want to tell her about what *we* got up to at fourteen?”

Perfuma blushed, gathering more stares. Even Hordak and Catra, who had crept closer to their partners, looked vaguely interested. “W-well, that’s- that’s different!”

“It’s not,” Mermista rolled her eyes. “Besides, the more taboo she thinks it is, the worse it’ll be when she’s eighteen. Kid, it’s bitter and gross, and this is the good stuff. When you turn eighteen, I’ll teach you how to take a shot without puking, and order a drink that won’t give you a hangover. For now, you may take two sips of this because I am very generous and very powerful.”

Frosta rolled her eyes. “You’re annoying. Gimme.” The Alliance watched on in amusement as Frosta took a careful sip- and immediately recoiled. “Oh, ew! Gross! What is that- ew!”

Mermista leveled a look at Perfuma that said ‘ *see? Told you* ’ and took her glass back. “And now you know. It’s all like that for a while. You develop a palate.”

“Why would I want to?”

Hordak of all people answered while peering at Entrapta’s Padd. “According to all known logs and research, developing a sense for alcohol is a key part of developing an adult social life on Etheria, as it allows for relaxation and easier bonding between individuals both platonic and romantic.”

“Exactly!” Glimmer nodded. “What he said.”

“Which was?” Frosta blinked at her. “I don’t speak nerd.”

There was a brief, tense pause… before Hordak chuckled in genuine amusement. “The colloquial gist would be, ‘so you aren’t a loser’.”

Mermista clapped a hand over her mouth to muffle a laugh as Frosta’s jaw dropped open. “You- hey!”

“No one’s a loser,” Perfuma sighed.

“He is!”

“Stop.”

Catra was cackling into Adora’s shoulder, while Entrapta looked on, vaguely amused. Spinnerella’s head was in her hands, but Netossa seemed utterly thrilled.

“Alright, no fighting or causing a scene at my wedding,” Mermista gently pulled Frosta to her side. “Or I’ll throw you both out.”

“Understood,” Hordak sobered.

Mermista rolled her eyes. “That was joke. Mostly. We’ll work on it.”

Bow grinned, resting his head on Glimmer’s head and wrapping his arms around her shoulders. “So,” he lightly changed the subject. “Are you guys going to have a first dance?”

Sea Hawk and Mermista glanced at one another. “Any minute now.”

“What song?”

“Mermista won’t tell me,” Sea Hawk looked amused. “She said it’s part of my gifts.”

“I know what it is,” Perfuma sing-songed. Sea Hawk gaped at Mermista, who raised her hands.

“Hey, I needed some help with logistics, okay? You’re gonna know in-”

The lights suddenly dimmed a bit, dipping the room into deep, rich hues of amber, violet, magenta, and navy. Above them hung mirrors and gems on translucent, magical threads- mazes of suncatchers refracting rays of mid-noon light around the room. Mermista froze like a deer in a hunter’s sightline, but handed her empty glass to Perfuma before taking Sea Hawk’s arm and heading for the dance floor. It was a large glass floor, underneath which was the ocean. Fish and foliage and all sorts of wildlife moved to and fro, dancing and playing with the guests as they moved.

A set of violins, more than at the ceremony, began to hum a soaring note, something earthy and almost discordant, but rich enough to stay out of the realm of anything too dreary. Mermista and Sea Hawk faced one another, hands drifting naturally to find purchase on shoulder and waist alike. They moved as one, fluid and graceful, as the singer began.

When time is up and the sun near dies

'Til the rivers flood and the ocean dries

Hand in hand under the falling sky

I will love you"

Bow's breath caught in his chest, and he turned to Glimmer. "It's her vows," he whispered.

"What?" Glimmer tilted her head, eyes still fixed on the couple, now moving over and around one another like- well, like water.

"The lyrics," he smiled. "They're Mermista's vows."

Over Glimmer's head, he saw Perfuma nod and smile.

"You are the reason, I make it through the day

You gimme the reason to better all my ways…"

Bow could see the tears streaking down Sea Hawk’s face from here, and felt himself how moved the assembled was. Even Mercia, across the room and standing shoulder to shoulder with Micah, was looking particularly less frown-y than usual.

“And everything else fades away

You are my constant… ”

Sea Hawk pulled Mermista back, dipping her low and gentle. His forehead pressed to her bare clavicle, and her hand gripped the back of his neck lovingly but without fear. Glimmer’s hand tightened in his, and he knew she wanted this for them just as badly as he did.

“When we’ve walked the Earth every inch and mile,

Laughed so hard, until we’ve cried,

Through every triumph and every trial

I will love you…”

The music swelled, melodic, otherworldly humming filling the air. The setting sun bounced around the room hypnotically, gleaming in suncatchers and refracting off mirrors. Bow felt the song in his chest and head as much as in his ears. He turned and saw Adora's arms wrapped around Catra, unapologetic and almost defiant, as tears ran down both their faces. The magicat's own hands dug into her girlfriend's pale, freckled arms desperately, claws carefully retracted. Scorpia and Perfuma were swaying with one another, looking as at peace as Bow felt. Even Hordak's ears were up, relaxed, and he leaned against Entrapta carefully. Her hair was wrapped around his waist, but so was her arm. As the music played on, Bow felt, truly felt, for the first time, the freedom they'd fought so ardently for. This was only one of the first nights of forever, nights where they would celebrate one another and the love they'd created, cultivated, bled and cried for, fully realized at long last. Something bright and overwhelming was burgeoning in Bow's chest, and he choked on a sob as Glimmer wrapped her arms around him. He hugged her back, kissing her head.

On the floor, Mermista was *smiling* . Smiling like he'd never seen before, carefree and laughing but impossibly loving, and it was all for Sea Hawk. For the pirate she'd once been adamant was just her ride. It felt like only yesterday, sometimes, that she'd had him tossed from her throne room for overwhelming her with his flamboyant theatrics. And it had only been a handful of months ago that Sea Hawk had cradled her on the battlefield of their last stand, ready to perish with her. They'd made it through every impossibility to stand here in one another's arms, husband and wife for over a year, Queen and King of Salineas at last. Partners. Equals. Best friends.

"When time is up and the sun near dies

‘Til the rivers flood and the ocean dries

Hand in hand under the falling sky

I will love you.”

—- - —--- - —--- –

They managed to escape just after dinner. As people were standing up and starting to mill about and speak, Mermista had grabbed her husband’s hand and yanked him behind some of the massive, frondy plants, through a hidden doorway, down a short hall, and out onto the sand. From there, they’d made a break for it, running hand in hand down the shoreline away from the temple and hall. Adrenaline exhilarated their joy until they had laughed their breath away and slowed to an idle stroll. Sometimes they spoke, most of the time they didn’t. Every few feet, one of them would kick water at the other, and Mermista would pull it off their finery before it stained permanently.

“Hey,” Sea Hawk murmured in her ear. The sun was burning low in the sky, and it lit his hair aflame, turning finn and mauve to auburns and reds. Mermista carded her hand through it, disturbing the last of the gel slicking it back. She grinned as it settled back into its usual unruly coif.

“Hey, sailor,” she smiled. She’d been smiling all day, and her cheeks were seriously starting to hurt. For him, though, it was, like, worth it. Ew. Kind of. Not really.

“When do we have to be back?” His hand left hers to wrap around her waist while his lips brushed her ear. She shivered gently. “I haven’t had a moment with you all day. Which seems ironic.”

“Weddings are always for others, not the couple,” she snorted. “Hence our elopement. And, I dunno, before the final dance.”

“More dancing?” Hawk pulled back, grinning. “I like dancing with you.”

“So I’ve noticed.” She rolled her eyes, but it was gentle and loving. He pecked her cheek softly, still smiling. He hadn’t stopped smiling in hours either, but that wasn’t abnormal for him. As they rounded an outcrop of long-cooled lava, she caught sight of the Sea Gate, about a mile or so away to the West, and a thought occurred to her. “Hey, have you ever been up on the Gate?”

Sea Hawk blinked at her abrupt segue. “Uh- nope! I have not! Why?”

“C’mon,” she tugged him along, resuming a brisker pace. “The view is, like, insane.”

It was simplicity to ask the ocean to hold them up and let them walk to the Gate, though Sea Hawk laughed in delight at the novelty of strolling on the water. Mermista took his hand as they walked; in part because she liked the feeling of his hand in hers, but mostly because she didn't want him wandering out of her radius of control and taking a dunk in his finery. He tended to wander.

Although, in the end, one way or another, he always came back to her.

She boosted them up to one of the magically suspended rocks, the same one she'd stood on four years ago and watched as three strangers cared enough to help her in an hour of need. Adora, Glimmer, and Bow had waltzed into her throne room and turned her life on end. They'd shown her that caring wasn't weakness, that reaching out for help didn't make her a failure- that love, and passion, made her all the stronger. The man next to her had been laying the groundwork for that lesson already, but… it can take a village.

And now, thanks to them, thanks to *him* , here she stood. Alive. Queen. A wife. An entire future sprawling ahead of her, as bright and endless as the ocean below them, disappearing over the horizon and beckoning her to follow, to see the wonderful places she could end up.

Tell me darling, do you wish we'd fall in love?

All the time… all the time…

Music from the island reached them, spilling into the air and riding high on the breeze to serenade the sunset. Sea Hawk turned to her, and wrapped her in his arms to gently sway them to the music. Mermista brought her hands up to rest on his chest, and tucked her head against his neck. He was humming, so she closed her eyes to let the sound and vibrations wash over her. Was this peace at last?

Time together isn't ever quite enough.

They pulled apart a bit, just enough to look one another in the eyes, each drinking in the presence of the other. Slowly, her right hand trailed up his chest, while her left found his waist. She caressed his shoulder, his neck, caught in the translucent fabric of their enchanted dupatta, now a token of their House. She cradled the back of his head, stroking the fine, soft hairs there. His left arm wrapped around her, calloused fingers rubbing the bare skin of her lower back, while his right hand came up to cup her jaw. As one, they pulled each other in, a tide finally finding shore.

When you and I are alone,

"I love you, dearest," Sea Hawk murmured against her lips.

Mermista smiled into his kiss. "I love you, too."

There was nothing else to say. They knew it all. They knew the beginning of the story, and now, they knew the end- of this chapter at least. There were hundreds more to write together, and they had their whole lives to get the words just right. It had taken years of pain and joy, suffering and elation, blood and tears, but finally, *finally* … here they were.

I've never felt so at home.

Chapter End Notes

> This is not the last of canon seamista I will write. I have so many ideas planned for a sequel, I just gotta get em organized.
>
> Again, seriously, whoever is reading this, whenever, and for whyever, thank you. Let me know your thoughts, your feelings, etcetera, no matter how old this fic is when you get to this point future readers.
>
> For the Honor of Grey Whales :)

End Notes

I hope you’ve enjoyed! Next update will be soon!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!